

The Quest for a Universal Science:

**The Occult Philosophy of Ṣā'in al-Dīn Turka Iṣfahānī (1369-1432)
and Intellectual Millenarianism in Early Timurid Iran**

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This dissertation takes as its point of departure two key insights: first, that millenarian, universalist forms of thought were ubiquitous in late medieval and early modern intellectual history, whether in the Islamicate heartlands or Renaissance Europe; second, that the occult sciences (*al-ʿulūm al-gharība*) were far more integral to such universalist projects than has previously been acknowledged. I therefore focus my inquiry on Ṣā'in al-Dīn Turka Iṣfahānī (1369-1432), the foremost occult philosopher of early Timurid Iran, whose lettrist or kabbalistic thought (*ʿilm al-ḥurūf*) constitutes the centerpiece of his universalist project. Most notably, this type of occult philosophy—referring as it does to the neoplatonic-neopythagorean quest to comprehend the cosmos using all available means, whether rational or mystical, scientific or magical, in concert—precisely exemplifies the ‘will to synthesis’ that characterizes so much of later Islamicate intellectual history.

Ibn Turka was hardly exceptional in this regard; recent research suggests that he was the leader of a circle of thinkers based in Isfahan and Yazd, which included such heavyweights as Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī (d. 1454) and Qāzīzāda Rūmī (d. 1432). This Isfahan Circle, moreover, was

but the eastern branch of a vast extra-establishment network of intellectuals propagating from Cairo to Anatolia on the one hand and western Iran (and from thence Central Asia and India) on the other, and calling themselves, cryptically, the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'. The pivot of this network was Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (d. 1397), occultist and wonderworker at the Mamluk court in Cairo, who proclaimed a new era of human development through the retrieval and open promulgation of the occult sciences. Ṣā'in al-Dīn presents himself as simply the systematizer of Akhlāṭī's teachings, and was received as such in the later lettrist tradition.

Despite his importance, however, half of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's oeuvre remains in manuscript—including, predictably, his lettrist works, assumed to be the most marginal component of his thought. Ironically, it is precisely the fact that Ṣā'in al-Dīn has been acclaimed since the 19th century as an important synthesizer of peripatetic-illuminationist philosophy and mystical theory linking Ibn 'Arabī (d. 1240) with Mullā Ṣadrā (d. 1640) that led to his marginalization in the literature; by effectively obscuring the occultist tenor of his larger project, such acclaim abstracts it from its historical context and robs it of its animating virtue. The burden of the present study is therefore to remedy this neglect by presenting and contextualizing the central lettrist component of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's thought on the basis of his unpublished lettrist works, with particular attention to his magisterial *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* or *Book of Inquiries*, a *summa* of intellectual lettrism.

Following a presentation of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's biography and religio-historical context in Chapter 1 and an annotated list of his writings (some 45 Persian and Arabic works in total) in Chapter 2, the central chapters of Part 1 of this study investigate various aspects of his universalist lettrist project, with particular reference to peripatetic-illuminationist philosophy on the one hand and Sufism on the other. Chapter 7 consists largely of translated sections from the *Mafāḥiṣ*; Part 2 of this study is devoted to editions and/or translations of five of his minor lettrist treatises.

A running theme in Ṣā'in al-Dīn's works is invidious comparison of lettrism and philosophy: the faux-universal concepts of philosophical speculation notwithstanding, only the letter encompasses all that is and is not, all that can and cannot be; it alone is the *coincidentia oppositorum*; hence lettrism is the only truly universal science. I argue that Ṣā'in al-Dīn's unprecedented lionization of lettrism vis-à-vis philosophy represents a specifically intellectual form of the science distinct from its originary gnostic-messianic and Sufi strains. Indeed, it is typically—and erroneously—assumed that the Hurufi movement of Faḏl Allāh Astarābādī (d. 1394) defines later Islamicate lettrism; as an example of popular gnostic-messianic-Sufi lettrism, rather, that movement's vigor testifies to the religio-cultural valency of lettrism in Iran at all levels. I further argue that lettrist theory informs the ornate literary practice of the period, as may be seen in Ṣā'in al-Dīn's status as vaunted stylist of Persian prose.

Far from being fringe thinkers, Muslim lettrists of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's stripe saw themselves as both advancing human knowledge of the cosmos and demonstrating the miraculous inimitability of the Quran as the clearest transcript of divine Speech in history. Ibn Turka's significance within late medieval intellectual history centers precisely on his status as one of a panoply of late medieval and early modern thinkers to understand reality in textual terms, to be driven by the prospect of decoding and recoding the twin Books, the Quran and the cosmos.

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by

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Detail from Gāzurgāhī, *Majālis al-‘Ushshāq*, “Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī Receiving Gifts from Barqūq,” BL Or. 11837 f. 117 (Shiraz, ca. 1560). These figures appear to represent two of Akhlāṭī’s disciples—conceivably Ibn Turka and Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī—looking on as their master is received by the Mamluk sultan. Reprinted with the permission of the British Library.

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ABBREVIATIONS

AB	http://www.aghabozorg.ir
BÉO	<i>Bulletin d'Études Orientales</i>
BJMES	<i>British Journal of Middle Eastern Studies</i>
BSOAS	<i>Bulletin of the School of Oriental and African Studies</i>
DJI	<i>Dānishnāma-yi Jahān-i Islām</i> , http://www.encyclopaediaislamica.com
DMBI	<i>Dā'irat al-Ma'ārif-i Buzurg-i Islāmī</i> , http://www.cgie.org.ir
EI ²	<i>Encyclopaedia of Islam</i> , 2nd ed.
EI ³	<i>Encyclopaedia of Islam</i> , 3rd ed.
Elr	<i>Encyclopaedia Iranica</i>
EIs	<i>Encyclopaedia Islamica</i>
EQ	<i>Encyclopedia of the Qur'ān</i>
GAL	Carl Brockelmann, <i>Geschichte der arabischen Litteratur</i>
JAIS	<i>Journal of Arabic and Islamic Studies</i>
JBBRAS	<i>Journal of the Bombay Branch of the Royal Asiatic Society</i>
JMIAS	<i>Journal of the Muhyiddin Ibn 'Arabi Society</i>
JRAS	<i>Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society</i>
MKh	Ibn Turka, <i>Munāẓarāt-i Khams</i> , ed. Akram Jūdī-Nī'matī, Tehran, 1375 Sh./1996
Nashriyya	<i>Nashriyya-yi Nuskha-hā-yi Khaṭṭī-yi Kitābkhāna-yi Markazī-yi Dānishgāh-i Tihārān</i>
PL ¹	C. A. Storey, <i>Persian Literature: A Bio-bibliographical Survey</i>
PL ²	C. A. Storey and Y. E. Bregel, <i>Persidskaia Literatura</i>
Q	A. J. Arberry, <i>The Koran Interpreted</i> ¹
RSO	<i>Rivista degli Studi Orientali</i>
SEP	<i>Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy</i> , http://plato.stanford.edu
SI	<i>Studia Islamica</i>
SND	Ibn Turka, <i>Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr</i> , ed. Akram Jūdī-Nī'matī, Tehran, 1384 Sh./2005
TMN/D	<i>Munsha'āt-i Turka</i> , MS Dānishgāh 2576
TMN/M	<i>Munsha'āt-i Turka</i> , MS Majlis 10196

¹ I rely throughout on Arberry's Quran translation (*The Koran Interpreted*, New York, 1955), with occasional modifications.

TMN/MS	<i>Munsha'āt-i Turka</i> , MS Majlis-i Sinā 316
Yazmalar	http://yazmalar.gov.tr
YMN/C	<i>Munsha'āt-i Yazdī</i> , MS Cambridge H. 5
YMN/D	<i>Munsha'āt-i Yazdī</i> , MS Dānishgāh 2576
YMN/MS	<i>Munsha'āt-i Yazdī</i> , MS Majlis-i Sinā 316
YMN/V	<i>Munsha'āt-i Yazdī</i> , MS Vahid Paşa 621
ZDMG	<i>Zeitschrift der Deutschen Morgenländischen Gesellschaft</i>

1. Transliteration

I follow the *International Journal of Middle Eastern Studies* system for Arabic and Persian transliterations, with one exception: in Persian, the *tā' marbūṭa* is rendered *a*, not *ih*, for the sake of consistency with the Arabic. Arabic vowels are also used for Persian. In addition, the Persian *izāfa* is indicated as *-i* (*-yi* for words ending in vowels), but omitted in personal names (e.g., Aḥmad Samarqandī, not Aḥmad-i Samarqandī). The Arabic definite article is omitted from proper names after their first occurrence or in names of individuals from Persian-speaking regions. Conventional English spellings are used for countries, regions and major cities, as well as for some Arabic or Persian terms that have entered the English lexicon as established in the *Oxford English Dictionary* (e.g., *ulama*, *fatwa*, *qadi*, *Sharia/Shari'a*); I also naturalize other frequently used terms (e.g., *tafsir*, *Shi'i*, *Shafi'i*). Turkish is transliterated according to modern Turkish orthography.

2. Dates

Dates referring to the solar Islamic calendar today in use in Iran are indicated by 'Sh.,' i.e., *shamsī* or *hijrī-yi shamsī*. Lunar dates (*hijrī-yi qamarī*) are unmarked and always given with their Julian or Gregorian equivalent; to reduce clutter, I list only the Julian/Gregorian year in which the greater part of the *hijrī* year falls where more exact dates are lacking.

3. Table of Isopsephy (*Abjad*)

The eastern letter values used in the majority of texts examined in this study are as follows:

ا	ب	ج	د	ه	و	ز	ح	ط	ی	ک	ل	م	ن
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	20	30	40	50
س	ع	ف	ص	ق	ر	ش	ت	ث	خ	ذ	ض	ظ	غ
60	70	80	90	100	200	300	400	500	600	700	800	900	1000

PART ONE

Ibn Turka and his occult philosophy

INTRODUCTION

*a wise and letters play of all you can ceive*¹

—James Joyce

*The entire universe ... is perfused with signs, if it is not composed exclusively of signs.*²

—C. S. Peirce

*Decipher! Decipher! Then you will experience the vertigo of the human absolute.*³

—Salvador Dalí

I.1: Ibn Turka as occult philosopher

I have read in the records of the Arabians, reverend Fathers, that Abdala the Saracen, when questioned as to what on this stage of the world, as it were, could be seen most worthy of wonder, replied: “There is nothing to be seen more wonderful than man.” In agreement with this opinion is the saying of Hermes Trismegistus: “A great miracle, Asclepius, is man.”⁴

Thus Giovanni Pico della Mirandola (d. 1494) opens his famous *Oration on the Dignity of Man*, considered a foundational text of Italian Renaissance philosophy and manifesto of humanism. What is routinely forgotten, however, is the fact that his primary objective as stated in this text

¹ *Finnegans Wake*, New York, 1999, 237.

² *The Essential Peirce: Selected Philosophical Writings, Volume 2 (1893-1913)*, Bloomington, 1998, 394.

³ Salvador Dalí and André Parinaud, *Maniac Eyeball: The Unspeakable Confessions of Salvador Dalí*, London, 2004.

⁴ Pico della Mirandola, “Oration on the Dignity of Man,” trans. Forbes, 223.

is to put forward a *philosophia nova*, based in part on number, high magic and Hebrew kabbalistic speculation, as key to the deciphering of the cosmos, so marking the genesis of early modern Christian Kabbalah.⁵ In this Pico was far from atypical; indeed, as recent research has shown, a neoplatonic-kabbalistic-hermetic orientation characterizes much of 15th-17th century European natural and metaphysical philosophy and experimental science.⁶

⁵ George Makdisi, for example, imports the opening sentences of the *Oration* as epigram to his landmark study of Islamicate humanism (*The Rise of Humanism in Classical Islam and the Christian West*, 1990), yet nowhere indicates the importance of esotericism to humanistic thought. Pico composed the *Oration* in 1486 as a preface to his *900 Conclusions* wherein he sought to fully harmonize Aristotle and Plato for the first time (Copenhaver, “Giovanni Pico della Mirandola,” *SEP*). It should be noted that this work stands testimony to the Renaissance admiration for Muslim thinkers; Pico explicitly holds the ‘Arabs’ in higher regard than the Latins, capable of understanding celestial matters beyond the ken of the latter (Farmer, *Syncretism in the West*, 204; Derlipanska, “Perceptions and Reception,” ch. 4). This admiration extended to the political front: Temür himself was adopted as a humanist hero (Meserve, *Empires of Islam*, 203-23). On Pico’s *philosophia nova* see Still, “Pico’s Quest for All Knowledge”; on his kabbalistic thought see Wirszubski, *Pico della Mirandola’s Encounter with Jewish Mysticism*. On Christian kabbalism more generally see Zinguer et al., eds., *Hebraic Aspects of the Renaissance*. Philip Beichtman identifies three distinct but interrelated currents of Renaissance kabbalistic thought (*Alchemy of the Word*, x-xi): “First of all the Jewish stream, which rises in Northern Spain and Southern France in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, then expands over Europe in the sixteenth century, while being ‘radicalized’ through the ‘holy community’ in Safed, in the Middle East ... Secondly, a Christian Cabala, though one existed earlier in Spain, contemporaneous and competitive with the Jewish one, first becomes a factor in European culture with Pico della Mirandola’s discovery of The Zohar, brought over to Italy by Jewish refugees from Spain. Pico said, before every sacred council that would hear him, that he thought that nothing so well proves the divinity of Christ and the truth of the New Testament as Cabala. This conjecture of Pico’s, although early on condemned as heretical because of its Neoplatonic demotion of Reason (Acquinian-Aristotelian theology), nevertheless nourished a Christian Cabala for centuries. Thirdly, a demiurgic Neopagan Cabala, one that is God-Angel-and-Demon conjuring and connects with a more-or-less ancient Hermeticism, is spawned in Italy just about the same time as Pico’s Christian one ... Some of the martyrs of this Neopagan Cabala were Giordano Bruno (burned, 1600, for refusing to retract his theory of infinite worlds) and Lucilio Vanini (burned, 1619, for flat atheism).” Other prominent Christian kabbalists include Johannes Reuchlin (d. 1522; *De Verbo Mirifico, De Arte Cabalistica*), Cardinal Egidio da Viterbo (d. 1532; *Scetchina*, “On the Hebrew Letters”), Francesco Giorgio (d. 1541; *De Harmonia Mundi, Problemata*), and Guillaume Postel (d. 1581), who translated the *Zohar* and *Sefer Yetzirah* into Latin (the latter under the title *Abrahami Patriarchae Liber Jezirah Sive Formationis Mundi*, 1552).

⁶ See e.g. Håkansson, *Seeing the Word*; Hanegraaff, ed., *Dictionary of Gnosis and Western Esotericism*; Killeen and Forshaw, eds., *The Word and the World*; Osler, ed., *Rethinking the Scientific Revolution*; von Stuckrad, *Locations of Knowledge*. As Stephen McKnight advises (“The Wisdom of the Ancients,” 91-92), we must abandon “the long-standing positivist paradigm that groups Bacon and other major seventeenth-century figures into either the modern camp of science and technology or the ancient camp of religion and philosophy. Recent work in Renaissance cultural history and the history of science is making it increasingly clear that this Comtean construction is responsible for creating polarities and juxtapositions that did not actually exist. Bacon, Newton, and many leading figures of the age often blended ‘science,’ religion, and esoteric knowledge in the search for a holistic, organic understanding of human nature, the natural order, and God.” This is not to say that this strain does not continue in post-17th century European and American thought, only that, with the rise of positivistic Enlightenment thinking, it did so in less ‘scientific’ and more widely syncretistic guises. On the vitality and persistence of esotericism and

Roughly 80 years earlier in Timurid Iran, Šā'in al-Dīn 'Alī Turka of Isfahan (770-835/1369-1432) began to formulate a strikingly similar brand of occult philosophy, one dedicated to the upward evolution of humanity and profoundly progressive and millenarian in outlook. His stated goal was to formulate a universal science that would encompass history and the cosmos and unify all of human knowledge under its aegis. Moreover, the central kabbalistic or lettrist (*ḥarfī*, *ḥurūfī*) component of this science would enable the adept to not only decipher the twin Books, the Quran and the cosmos, but to in fact *write* the future, *rewrite* reality—the Perfect, Prophetic Man as *magus* in his status as transcript (*nuskha*) of the macrocosm.⁷ As Šā'in al-Dīn saw it, this new phase of human evolution was heralded by a portentous celestial conjunction (likely that of Saturn-Jupiter in Scorpio in 767/1365);⁸ his generation, poised on the edge of history and encompassing all that went before, was therefore the best generation, the late 8th/14th century the beginning of a golden age in which the prophetic legacy transmitted by the Imams and the ancients would be actualized.

While Šā'in al-Dīn was less successful in promoting his vision in Iran than were his later cognates in Europe, his lettrist thought is nevertheless richer than and distinct from Renaissance kabbalism in that it draws on a long-since naturalized and living Islamic tradition fusing the Hellenic-gnostic patrimony of antiquity with metaphysical, magical and

millenarianism in American culture, for example, see Albanese, *A Republic of Mind and Spirit*; for the same in Latin American culture see Graziano, *The Millennial New World*.

⁷ This 'real Cabala' manipulates things, as well as language; it "rotates the 'letters' of nature and at the same time performs more traditional operations on letters in scripture" (Lehrich, "Finding One's Place," 260).

⁸ I am not entirely sure which conjunction Šā'in al-Dīn has in mind, but the Saturn-Jupiter conjunction in October 1365 appears to be the most significant astrological event of the century in the Islamic context; a similar Saturn-Jupiter conjunction in Scorpio in April 571 had long been associated with the advent of Muḥammad, so its reappearance in 1365 suggested the beginning of a period of great change in the Muslim world (see Abū Ma'shar, *On the Great Conjunctions* i, 127, 152-3; cf. de Callatāy, *Ikhwan al-Safa'*, 45-47). In particular, the year 1365 marked a change of element from air to water (the *trigonalis* or medium conjunction), i.e., it was the first year that Saturn-Jupiter conjunctions began recurring in the water signs, then from 1425 to 1583, and finally in 1643. Conjunctions in a water element were associated with periods of spiritual, cultural, economic or political flourishing; the period 1365-1643, for example, taken as a piece, bracketed the Renaissance in Europe.

eschatological speculation centered on the Quran. The science of letters (*‘ilm al-ḥurūf*) entered Islam at its inception in the messianic-gnostic syncretism of the early *ghulāt*⁹ and was associated in more sedate Shi‘i circles with the *K. al-Jafr wa-l-Jāmi‘a* of ‘Alī, an omniscient text recording past and future history and all knowledge of the cosmos, together with other texts specific to the House of the Prophet and passed down through the line of the Imams;¹⁰ continued in the mystical meditations of Sufis from the mid-3rd/9th century, the sophisticated occult syncretism of the Jābir b. Ḥayyān corpus in the same century and the neoplatonizing and hermetic encyclopedism of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’ in the 4th/10th; and further matured in the radical theory of Ibn ‘Arabī (d. 638/1240) and Sa‘d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī (d. 649/1252) and the radical praxis of Abū l-‘Abbās al-Būnī (d. 622/1225?) and Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (d. 799/1397), Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s own teacher and latter-day master of *jafr*.¹¹ The 8th-10th/14th-16th centuries witnessed a burgeoning of messianic Shi‘i-Sufi groups in Iran, some of whom retrieved the gnostic-messianic elements of letter symbolism; this phenomenon is typified by the Ḥurūfiyya, whose founder, Faḏl Allāh Astarābādī (d. 796/1394), proclaimed a new, ‘post-Islamic’ dispensation centering on himself as messiah and on Persian as the new language of revelation.¹² Kabbalistic thought in its Islamicate context thus represents a broad cultural current hosting messiahs and mystics, Imams and intellectuals, and comprehends in its various iterations everything from

⁹ Al-Mughīra b. Sa‘īd (d. 119/737), eponym of the Mughīriyya, was the first to explicitly use letter symbolism for the purpose of ‘cosmic semiotics’ within a gnostic-syncretist framework, this being continued more systematically by the Khaṭṭābiyya; see Wasserstrom, “The Moving Finger Writes”; Daftary, “The Earliest Ismā‘īlīs,” 217-18; Tucker, *Mahdis and Millenarians*, 52-70. Recent research suggests that the foundational text of the Jewish Kabbalah, the *Sefer Yetzira* or *Book of Formation*, likewise derives from this 2nd-3rd/8th-9th century gnostic-syncretic Near Eastern milieu, a product of the creative symbiosis of Jewish and early Islamicate occult sciences, and is thus coeval with e.g. Isma‘ili and Sufi speculations on the subject (Wasserstrom, “Sefer Yeṣira and Early Islam”).

¹⁰ Modarressi, *Tradition and Survival*, 1/4-12, 17-20.

¹¹ See Chapter 4 for a survey of the development of the various strands of Islamic lettrist thought from the 2nd-11th/8th-17th centuries.

¹² As will be discussed in Chapter 8, lettrists like Ibn Turka dismissed such gnostic-messianic movements as perverting the science for non-intellectual and non-Islamic ends.

metaphysics, cosmogony and physics to numerology, astrology and magic. Where Pico was forced to import and recover, then, Šā'in al-Dīn synthesized and extended.

As Ibn Turka's thought in general has yet to be analyzed in depth, and his occult philosophy is almost wholly untouched, in this study I propose to examine and contextualize the central lettrist component of his larger intellectual project. While great strides have recently been made in Iran in the direction of publishing his works, the image presented remains skewed and incomplete in that most of his specifically lettrist works have yet to be edited, much less analyzed, precisely because they are assumed to be the most obscure and marginal component of his oeuvre.¹³ As a result, what little scholarship there is on Ibn Turka tends to present him as a mystical-scholastic thinker lodged unobtrusively somewhere between Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī (d. 672/1274) and Mullā Ṣadrā (d. 1050/1640), although Henry Corbin's brief but warm embrace of him as a standard-issue Shi'i esotericist has helped to complicate this featureless picture somewhat.¹⁴ In Iran his modern reputation rests almost exclusively on his *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, a synthesis of Ibn Sīnā, Suhrawardī and Ibn 'Arabī/Qūnavī on the topic of absolute being (*al-wujūd al-muṭlaq*), which has long featured as a staple teaching text in Imami seminary curricula in Iran.¹⁵ Representing this consensus, 'Allāma Ṭabāṭabā'ī (d. 1402/1981) celebrates Šā'in al-Dīn in his *al-Mīzān* as a preeminent synthesizer of peripatetic philosophy and

¹³ Specifically, over half of his oeuvre (some 46 known Persian and Arabic works) remains in manuscript.

¹⁴ Corbin, *En Islam iranien*, 3/233-74.

¹⁵ See the important studies of his *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id* by Sayyid Jalāl al-Dīn Āshtiyānī (intro., *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, Tehran 1396/1976) and Ayatollah 'Abd Allāh Javādī Āmulī (*Tahrīr-i Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, Tehran 1372 Sh./1993), which limit themselves to a close discussion of this text as a definitive mystico-philosophical treatment of the concept of absolute being. These studies reflect the *Tamhīd*'s relatively recent adoption as a staple teaching text in Imami seminary curricula in Iran, probably in the late Qajar period, and perpetuate a distorted image of Šā'in al-Dīn as a Sufi-philosopher in the scholastic mode—in short, a mere precursor to the philosophical school of Isfahan. The *Tamhīd* addresses the “doubts of the peripatetics” and illuminationists, relying primarily on the Ibn 'Arabī school tradition as formulated by Qūnavī and Jandī; it is bare of any reference to the author's more central lettrist concerns.

theoretical mysticism, ranking him in this regard with Fārābī and Suhrawardī.¹⁶ (Muḥammad Taqī Dānishpazhūh's characterization of Ibn Turka as the 'Spinoza of Iran' represents an interesting variation on this theme.¹⁷) The few Western scholars to mention Ibn Turka for the most part faithfully reiterate this judgment. Hossein Ziai characterizes Ṣā'in al-Dīn as a Shi'i thinker primarily concerned with harmonizing religion and philosophy, in the context of which he sought to promote the political authority of divinely-inspired 'ulamā';¹⁸ this statement is incorrect and anachronistic, and merely reflects the *Tamhīd*'s popularity in modern-day Shi'i seminary circles. In his various discussions of later Islamic philosophy in Iran, S. H. Nasr refers to Ibn Turka as a peripatetic and illuminationist philosopher and Sufi of the school of Ibn 'Arabī, and a key Shi'i thinker linking Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī and Mullā Ṣadrā.¹⁹ John Cooper, similarly relying largely on the evidence of the *Tamhīd* but breaking ranks to acknowledge a

¹⁶ *Al-Mīzān fī Tafsīr al-Qur'ān*, 5/282-84; I am indebted to Hussein Abdulsater for alerting me to this reference. In this passage Ṭabāṭabā'ī identifies three discrete methods by which to seek knowledge of supernal truths (*al-ḥaqā'iq*): 1) adherence to the outward forms of religious practice; 2) rational inquiry; and 3) self-purification, i.e., Sufism. He describes them as being like the three angles of an equilateral triangle; when the partisans of any one approach assert its superiority at the expense of the other two, the triangle is bent into an exaggeratedly scalene shape. The esoteric and exoteric, the rational and mystical, are thus wholly interdependent. Among the thinkers to reconcile (*tawfīq*) exoteric religious practice with mystical theory are Ibn 'Arabī, 'Abd al-Razzāq Kāshānī, Ibn Fahd al-Ḥillī, Zayn al-Dīn al-'Āmilī and Fayḏ Kāshānī; those who reconciled peripatetic philosophy with mystical theory include Fārābī, Suhrawardī and Ṣā'in al-Dīn Turka; those who reconciled exoteric religious practice with peripatetic philosophy include al-Qādī Sa'īd al-Qummī; finally, those who reconciled all three approaches include Ibn Sīnā, Mullā Ṣadrā and more recent thinkers, who alone figured forth the balanced triangle of human perfection. The rather idiosyncratic nature of this categorization aside, it should here be noted that Ṭabāṭabā'ī's championing of the Sadrian *ḥikmat-i muta'āliya* makes him unusually receptive to Ṣā'in al-Dīn's synthetic treatment of philosophy and theoretical mysticism as in, for example, the *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, and at the same time dismissive of the more strictly occult dimension of the latter's thought. Cf. the use of Ṣā'in al-Dīn strictly as an authority on illuminationist philosophy in the important 11th/17th century Ādhar Kayvānī pseudo-Zoroastrian text *Dābistān-i Mazāhib* (Corbin, "Typologie," 261 n. 83).

¹⁷ "Majmū'a-yi Rasā'il-i Khujandī," 312; specifically, he asserts Ibn Turka to be the 'Spinoza of Iran' to rhetorically underscore the necessity of publishing and studying his works. In his study of Sufism in Iran, 'Abd al-Ḥusayn Zarrīnkūb (*Dunbāla-yi Justujū dar Taṣavvuf-i Īrān*, 142) takes issue with this title as being misrepresentative of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's more mystical and lettrist concerns. The irony of this characterization will become apparent in the course of this study; for the present it may be briefly noted that Spinoza, as a Bible critic, undercut precisely the basis on which lettrism rests.

¹⁸ "Recent Trends," 413-15.

¹⁹ See e.g. *Islamic Philosophy*, 209-10.

larger project, describes Ibn Turka as “one of the first to seek to unify the Peripatetic, *ishrāqī* and Akbarian strands in the perspective of Shī‘ī esotericism” and “learned in the science of numerical symbolism, which he incorporated into his writings.”²⁰ All such characterizations err, on the one hand, in focusing on the *Tamhīd al-Qawā‘id*, by far the best known of Ṣā’ib al-Dīn’s works in the modern period but strictly of secondary importance in the estimation of the author and his contemporaries, as will be seen; and on the other, in taking over Corbin’s assumption that Ṣā’ib al-Dīn is a standard-issue Shī‘ī esotericist. In his recent and welcome article on Ibn Turka’s apologies, Leonard Lewisohn takes the opposite tack, unfortunately misrepresenting him as an orthodox Sunni Sufi thinker while calling for more research to be done;²¹ needless to say, the image Ṣā’ib al-Dīn presents of himself in the apologies, produced under great duress, is hardly reflective of his primary concerns.²² The *de facto* scholarly consensus, then, such as it is, presents Ibn Turka as a mystical philosopher—effectively obscuring his explicitly *occultist* project. Furthermore, *pace* both Corbin and Lewisohn, Ṣā’ib al-Dīn’s ambiguous confessional position is best described as Shī‘ī-Sunnism or imamophilism, a defining feature of 9th/15th century Islamic religiosity, particularly in Iran and particularly in esotericist circles.²³

As will become clear in the course of this study, even a casual survey of Ṣā’ib al-Dīn’s writings suggests that he is best understood not as a mystical philosopher or scholastic mystic but as an occult philosopher, i.e., a thinker whose system embraces “the entirety of the ‘occult sciences,’” including kabbalah, numerology, astrology and natural magic, “provided that these are understood not only as practical disciplines but as integral parts of a comprehensive

²⁰ “From al-Ṭūsī,” 591.

²¹ “The Confessions,” 65–78.

²² Cf. Rosemarie Quiring-Zoche’s similarly problematic description of Ṣā’ib al-Dīn as “a Sufi poet, philosopher, and jurist” (“Afzal-al-Din Torka,” *Elr*).

²³ See §1.4 below for more on this point.

religious philosophy and cosmology on neoplatonic, hermetic and kabbalistic foundations.”²⁴

Occult philosophy as such thus refers to the quest to comprehend the cosmos using all available means, whether rational or mystical, scientific or magical, in concert. This larger project naturally includes such mystical-philosophical syntheses as Ṣā’īn al-Dīn achieves in the *Tamhīd*, but cannot be limited to them without crippling the whole. It is here necessary to underscore the central role of kabbalistic/lettrist methodologies in most varieties of occult philosophy, whether in Timurid Iran or, as we saw with Pico, quattrocento Italy. Apart from numerous works dedicated to lettrism or with substantial lettrist content, Ibn Turka’s magisterial *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* or *Book of Inquiries*, an Arabic *summa* of his neoplatonic-kabbalistic-hermetic philosophy, constitutes the centerpiece of his oeuvre and was the basis of his fame throughout the Timurid and Safavid periods.²⁵ Completed in 823/1420, it is an extended investigation into the roots of all manifestation in the One and the mechanics of multiplicity’s derivation therefrom, and treats of the letters in their three primary aspects, numerological (*iḥṣā’ī*), symbological (*kitābī*) and phonological (*kalāmī*), with a fourth section dealing more generally with the letters as such (*fī anfusi-hā*) in the context of language and literature.²⁶ In the introduction to this work Ṣā’īn al-Dīn explicitly rejects the concept of absolute being, the focus of the *Tamhīd*, as an adequate object of inquiry; the faux-universal concepts of philosophical speculation notwithstanding, only the letter (*ḥarf*) encompasses all that is and is not, all that can and cannot be, and is hence

²⁴ Hanegraaff, *Dictionary of Gnosis and Western Esotericism*, 886-87, s.v. “Occult/Occultism.” This sense of the term was established in the Western context by Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa in 1510 with his first draft of *De Occulta Philosophia Libri Tres*.

²⁵ See Mīrzā ‘Abd Allāh Afandī (d. 1130/1717), *Riyāḍ al-‘Ulamā’ wa-Ḥiyāḍ al-Fuḍalā’*, 4/240, who assumes Ṣā’īn al-Dīn to be a mystical philosopher of Shī’i stock and of his works mentions only the *Mafāḥiṣ*. He describes it as a work on divine wisdom and comprising the mystical sciences in an occult mode (*al-ḥikma al-ilāhiyya al-muḥtawīya ‘alā ‘ulūm al-taṣawwuf ‘alā naḥjⁱⁿ gharīb*), and reports on an early copy of the *Mafāḥiṣ*, executed only two years after the work’s completion, that he examined in the town of Bārfarūsh (Bābul) in Māzandarān. Khwāndamīr’s (d. 942/1535) very brief notice on Ṣā’īn al-Dīn mentions three of his works: *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*, *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, and *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr* (*Ḥabīb al-Siyar*, 2.2/356).

²⁶ In the introduction to this work (*K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 53a) he cites Ibn ‘Arabī, Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī and the oral teachings of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlātī, more on whom below, as his primary sources.

the proper object of a universal science. By extension: lettrism is the only form of metaphysics worth the name.²⁷

The general misprision of late medieval occult philosophy aside, that thinkers of the stature of Ibn Turka remain shrouded in richly undeserved obscurity is one of the many pernicious effects of the scholarly narrative, nearly universal until recently, that long dismissed late medieval and early modern Islamicate culture as ‘post-classical’ and therefore stagnant and hidebound, drunk on artifice and insensible to meaning, glaze-eyed and splay-footed at the Whiggish march of history.²⁸ To the contrary, the late medieval period in the Islamicate lands²⁹ is now being increasingly recognized as host to a wide range of grand intellectual and cultural syntheses and creative energies spanning various fields of human endeavor, from philosophy to literature, from astronomy to global trade. This broad recuperation of later Islamicate history still lacks an important component, however, in that it has yet to give due place to occult philosophy as such, preferring to disappear it into Sufism or mystical philosophy on the one hand and extremist messianic movements such as the

²⁷ See e.g. MS Majlis 10196 f. 55a, MS Esad Efendi 1731 ff. 8b-9a; this introduction is translated in §7.3.1 below. The universality and transcendence of the letter has much to do with the fact that it alone constitutes the *coincidentia oppositorum*; that is to say, it alone of all existents is not offset by an opposite (MS Majlis 10196 f. 58a).

²⁸ For recent problematizations of the category ‘post-classical’ and its invariable association with decline see Bauer, “In Search of ‘Post-Classical’ Literature”; Losensky, *Welcoming Fighānī*, a study of the poet Bābā Fighānī Shīrāzī (d. 925/1519); Stearns, “Writing the History of the Natural Sciences in the Pre-modern Muslim World” (my thanks to Prof. Stearns for a preprint version of this article). The association between the occult sciences and decadence in the Islamicate world is exemplified in Abel, “La place des sciences occultes dans la décadence.” On orientalist biases with regard to philosophy see Gutas, “The Study of Arabic Philosophy in the Twentieth Century”; Eichner, “The Post-Avicennian Philosophical Tradition and Islamic Orthodoxy.” This is not to say that the trope of decline and decadence is not often encountered in medieval Islamic literature itself; we have only to refer to Ghazālī’s *Iḥyā’ ‘Ulūm al-Dīn* or Ibn Taymiyya’s works for assertions that the community has jumped its tracks and true religion is guttering. Indeed, the Sunni creeds present the course of history as a flatline of unswerving fidelity to a past ideal embodied by the generation of the Companions and (to a lesser extent) that of their Successors—a flatline punctuated, it is true, by periodic renewals of the original paradigm, but with the golden age firmly in the past. This theme does not obtain in the Shi’i and especially Imami context, which does not postulate a golden period subsequently become decadent but rather a golden opportunity that was spectacularly missed; by the same token, however, the golden period is inevitable through the reirruption of the Imam into history.

²⁹ I.e., Marshall Hodgson’s Later Middle Period.

Ḥurūfiyya on the other, or dismissing it as mere magic, i.e., failed science or debased religion. (As we shall see, the occult philosopher here under consideration, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn Turka, has some very sharp words to say about this.)

That such a blind spot persists is only to be expected, however, given that the remarkable prevalence of occult philosophy in early modern thought is only beginning to be recognized in its European context, where scholarship is otherwise far more advanced. Over the last decades, the thought of the leading minds of the Renaissance and the ‘Scientific Revolution’ (by now a highly problematized term), from Ficino to Newton and from Bruno to Bacon, has been retrieved and discovered to be profoundly esoteric in orientation, this strain having been buried under the detrius of positivist Enlightenment attitudes or successfully shunted aside as an embarrassing fit of medieval lunacy that fuddled these otherwise towering intellects, the Achilles’ heel of the heroes responsible for the ineluctable rise of the West.³⁰ This scholarly effort to deconstruct the presentist and exclusivist narrative of European intellectual progress by taking early modern thinkers on their own terms has led in Europe to a flourishing academic treatment of Western esotericism.³¹ The same space needs to be granted to occult philosophy in later Islamicate intellectual history.³² The present study, dealing as it does with a thinker triply marginalized in the literature for his post-classicism, for his esotericism and for his oriental stemming, constitutes a tentative step in this direction.

³⁰ Cf. the contention of Horkheimer and Adorno (*Dialectic of Enlightenment*, 4 et passim), and Foucault after them (*Madness and Civilization*), that Enlightenment rationality was and is exclusionary and repressive in nature, and ultimately totalitarian.

³¹ See e.g. Hanegraaff and Pijnenburg, eds., *Hermes in the Academy*. Such treatments often focus on the entangled and interpenetrating nature of religious, esotericist and ‘scientific’ pursuits in the early modern period; recent studies along such lines include Collins, *The Petrine Instauration*.

³² For efforts to recuperate late medieval and early modern Islamicate science, for example, see Stearns, “Writing the History of the Natural Sciences; Saliba, *Islamic Science*; Sabra and Hogendijk, eds., *The Enterprise of Science*; Brentjes, “Orthodoxy,” *Ancient Sciences*; and Morrison, *Islam and Science*, a study of the synthesis of Sufism and science in the work of Nizām al-Dīn Nīsābūrī (d. 729/1329).

I.2: Late medieval millenarianism and universalism

The 9th/15th century was, above all, an age of expansiveness driven by the millenarian ideal of universalism in various arenas of human endeavor. In the Islamic world this energy may be seen as building both toward the completion of the lunar millennium or 960 solar years since the advent of the Prophet and toward the fulfillment of the allotted 7,000 years of prophetic history.³³ Progress toward this end was measured by the succession of great, middle or small Saturn-Jupiter conjunctions (*qirān*, whence the messianic title *ṣāhib-qirān*, the Lord of Conjunction, applied to Temür³⁴), the great conjunction in particular having been held since Sasanid times to signify momentous religious and political changes.³⁵ A presentist and eurocentric reading of history, of course, terms this period the European Age of Discovery—this at a time when various European powers were struggling to nip at the flanks of Eurasian civilization and Renaissance thinkers embraced their dependency on the Greek, Persian and Egyptian ancients and the Arabic philosophers.³⁶ The explorations of this century may be characterized as being carried out within five broad domains:

³³ A Prophetic hadith, cited by the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā', links these two concepts: "The life of the world is seven millennia; I have been sent in the last of these millennia" (Marquet, "Les cycles de la souveraineté," 51).

³⁴ See Moin, "Islam and the Millennium," 36–60. A later Ottoman bureaucrat identified Temür as the third of three Lords of Conjunction, after Alexander the Great and Chinggis Khān (Fleischer, *Bureaucrat and Intellectual*, 281).

³⁵ The standard work on this subject is Abū Ma'shar's (Albumasar) (d. 272/886) *K. al-Milal wa-l-Duwal* (aka *K. al-Qirānāt*), edited and translated by Yamamoto and Burnett in *Abū Ma'shar on Historical Astrology*; political astrology of this type, rendered into Latin, was to become extremely popular during the Renaissance (Pingree, "Qirān," *El*²). For a discussion of the title *ṣāhib-qirān* in the Ottoman context see Flemming, "Ṣāhib-Qirān und Mahdī." Ibn Khaldūn critically surveys past predictions of the duration of Islam based on the various Saturn-Jupiter conjunctions, first defining the significance of the great (960 years), medium (240 years) and small (20 years) conjunctions as follows: "The great conjunction indicates great events, such as a change in royal authority or dynasties, or a transfer of royal authority from one people to another. The medium conjunction (indicates) the appearance of persons in search of superiority and royal authority. The small conjunction (indicates) the appearance of rebels or propagandists, and the ruin of towns or of their civilization" (*The Muqaddimah*, 2/213).

³⁶ See e.g. Ben-Zaken, *Cross-Cultural Scientific Exchanges*; Bisaha, *Creating East and West*; Brentjes, *Travellers from Europe*; Bulliet, *The Case for Islamo-Christian Civilization*; Derlipanska, "Perceptions and Reception," esp.

- 1) the *religious*, involving a quest to unify or purge all the sects of one religion, unify all religions or unify the world under one religion or new dispensation;³⁷
- 2) the *political*, manifesting in the desire to establish a world state and preside over the end of history (nurtured by the Ottomans in particular);³⁸
- 3) the *economic*, involving the attempt to access, expand and monopolize the established China-Indian Ocean-eastern Mediterranean trade network;³⁹
- 4) the *creative*, manifesting in the simultaneous drive in literature, the arts and architecture toward grandiose consolidation and synthesis on the one hand and extreme formal refinement on the other;⁴⁰ and

ch. 4; Goody, *The Theft of History*; Hodgson, *Rethinking World History*; MacLean, ed., *Re-Orienting the Renaissance*.

³⁷ Martin Luther's (1483-1546) birth was commonly associated, for example, with the 1484 Saturn-Jupiter-Mars conjunction, thought to mark the advent of a new prophet (Coulano, *Eros and Magic*, 184-91; North, *Stars, Minds and Fate*, 80). Bruno's universalist project sought to produce a fusion of Christianity and Judaism, on occult bases, to heal the multiplying rifts that had grown up in the interim; cf. Faḏl Allāh Astarābādī's vision of a new religious dispensation to heal the rifts in Islamdom. Related phenomena include the emergence of messianic, reformist and post-confessional Sufi orders (e.g., the Nūrbakhshīyya); extremist, gnostic-syncretist and 'post-Islamic' movements (e.g., the Ḥurūfiyya); the phenomenon of Shi'i-Sunnism or imamophilism (for a definition of which see below); and, again in Europe, the notion of the Catholic pope as world emperor (see e.g. Tommaso Campanella's *Reminiscentur et Convertentur ad Dominum Universi Fines Terrae*, discussed in Ernst, *Tommaso Campanella*, 152-58; the fourth section of this treatise is a polemic against Islam's claim to universalism, addressed to "the great Turk, the Shi'a of Persia, the Arabs, the Sheriff of Fez and Morocco, the Tartars and the Great Mongol").

³⁸ See Flemming, "Şāḥib-Ḳirān und Mahdī"; Turan, "The Sultan's Favorite." Corollaries of this theme include the self-presentation of the rulers of this period as simultaneously *insān kāmil*, *khalīfa* and *mujaddid*, i.e., locus of all political, religious and spritual power (see Moin, "Islam and the Millennium"), as well as the increasing militarization and politicization of the Sufi orders (e.g., the Ṣafaviyya), driven by the expectation of the Mahdī's imminent advent at the head of a Sufi army.

³⁹ See e.g. Casale, *The Ottoman Age of Exploration*; Abu-Lughod, *Before European Hegemony*; Frank, *ReORIENT*; Matar, *Turks, Moors, and Englishmen*; Subrahmanyam, "Connected Histories." Examples here include Ottoman-Portuguese competition in the Indian Ocean; the sea voyages of Magellan and Columbus; and the land voyages of Ibn Baṭṭūṭa and Marco Polo. On the millenarian impulse driving these voyages see e.g. Watts, "Prophecy and Discovery."

⁴⁰ In Iran this phenomenon is particularly associated with Timurid miniature painting of the Herat school (Lentz and Lowry, *Timur and the Princely Vision*); the 'fresh style' (*tarz-i tāza*) or 'Indian style' (*sabk-i hindi*) in Persian poetry, together with the conservative comprehensiveness of a poet like Jāmī (d. 898/1492) (see Losensky, *Welcoming Fighānī*); ornate prose and new synthetic genres; and monumental Timurid architecture of an unprecedentedly synthetic nature (on the great madrasa-khanaqah complexes, e.g., see Böwering and Melvin-Koushki, "Ḳānaqāh," *Elr*).

- 5) the *intellectual*, involving attempts, often esotericist in approach, to construct a new universal philosophy or science to supersede the philosophical-scientific systems of the peripatetic philosophers and dialectical theologians, and more generally to retrieve, organize and synthesize all earlier knowledge.⁴¹

We may locate Ibn Turka's project neatly within the last of these; or rather, its primary mode is intellectual, while also participating in the creative (literary), religious and political domains. For reasons of space and theme this study privileges the central lettrist aspect of its intellectual mode, and can only briefly touch on the latter aspects of his project.⁴² It must be emphasized, however, that the wide-ranging, synthetic and designedly multivalent nature of Ibn Turka's works reflects the universalist ambition that drives his larger project.

Yet universalist impulses tend toward mutual exclusivity. Most portentous for Šā'in al-Dīn's fate as an intellectual, the socioreligious tension generated by the great millenarian stirrings of this period was released in Iran in a variety of messianic Sufi and extremist movements, some increasingly militarized and politically aggressive (e.g. the Šāfiyya), some reformist and post-confessional (e.g. the Nūrbakhshīyya), and others gnostic-syncretic and 'post-Islamic' (e.g. the Ḥurūfiyya). In particular, the emergence of the Ḥurūfiyya, seen as politically and religiously threatening by the Timurid state and persecuted as such, was to seriously compromise Šā'in al-Dīn's efforts to promote lettrism as the universal science for a

⁴¹ In a recent paper İhsan Fazlıoğlu ("Forcing the Boundaries," 1) discusses three of these domains in the Ottoman context. On late medieval Arabic encyclopedism see e.g. Muhanna, "Oceans of Knowledge." This is not to discount earlier universalist tendencies, e.g. the encyclopedism of the Ikhwān al-Šafā' or Ghazālī's comprehensive reformulation of the religious sciences and fusion between theology and philosophy within the context of Sufi practice (see Griffel, *Al-Ghazālī's Philosophical Theology*). The noticeable uptick in apocalypticism and writings of the *malāḥim* genre begins in the 7th/13th century eastern Mediterranean region (see Masad, "The Medieval Islamic Apocalyptic Tradition"); it must be emphasized that such apocalypticism was often synergetic with, rather than antithetical to, scientific pursuits (see DeVun, "John of Rupescissa and the States of Nature").

⁴² I do however devote an Excursus to the important question of form and content in Ibn Turka's writings, and Chapter 5 surveys the political uses of lettrism.

new age. His religious unimpeachability as a Shafi'i qadi in Isfahan and Yazd notwithstanding, and despite the fact that he presented his system to the Timurid elite precisely as corrective to both the stultifying conservatism of the scholarly establishment and the antinomian decadence of groups such as the Ḥurūfiyya, Ṣā'in al-Dīn was unable to escape the taint of hurufism pinned to him by his establishment opponents. Thrice summoned to Shāhrukh's (r. 811-50/1409-47) imperial seat in Herat to stand trial for suspected heterodox views, he was able to successfully defend himself on the first two occasions, in ca. 825/1422 and 829/1426; however, in the wake of an attempt made on Shāhrukh's life in 830/1427 by a Hurufi assassin—possibly staged by the Timurid ruler himself—,⁴³ Ṣā'in al-Dīn was recalled to the capital and on the basis of his claimed Hurufi sympathies summarily stripped of his position and property, imprisoned, tortured and exiled. (The apologies he wrote during his trial of 829/1426 and after the events of 830/1427 are remarkable documents that provide a firsthand account of the fraughtness of early Timurid intellectual and religious life.⁴⁴) A number of other suspect, high-profile individuals, among them the charismatic and influential Sufi master Qāsim-i Anvār⁴⁵ and the calligrapher Ma'rūf Khaṭṭāt Baghdādī, were also expelled from Herat. This purge is best understood in the context of Shāhrukh's aggressive attempts to consolidate eastern and

⁴³ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 9, 114-19.

⁴⁴ *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* I and *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* II, together with the creedal tracts *R. l'tiqādāt* and *R. l'tiqādiyya*. There exist two brief studies of the apologies to date: Lewisohn, "Sufism and Theology in the Confessions of Ṣā'in al-Dīn Turka Iṣfahānī (d. 830/1437) [sic]," and Morio, "Ta'ammulī dar Difā'iyāt-i Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī Turka-yi Iṣfahānī." Lewisohn's well-taken insistence on taking the apologies at face value (Sufism and Theology 66, 77) aside, however, it bears repeating that they must be treated with caution as sources for Ṣā'in al-Dīn's own views, given the duress under which they were composed and the author's need to distance himself to the extent possible from Sufism in general and hurufism in particular. Thus Ṣā'in al-Dīn's comparison of himself to Ghazālī and Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī (*al-imāmayn*) and self-presentation as a standard-issue Ash'arī thinker (see e.g. *R. l'tiqādiyya* 268) and appeals to the (pointedly non-messianic) orthodoxy of Khwāja Pārsā ("*Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* I," 172, 187-8, 193), for example, are to be taken with several grains of salt—they tally too easily with Shāhrukh's Sunnizing program and give the lie to much of the author's oeuvre.

⁴⁵ It should be noted that Qāsim-i Anvār (d. 837/1434), apart from being Ni'mat Allāh Valī's *khalīfa* and a *dā'ī* for the Ṣafaviyya, was one of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's companions in Cairo (Mufīd Mustawfī, *Jāmi'-i Mufīdī*, 3/16-17; Aubin, *Majmū'a*, 156-57).

western Iran under his direct control, in the course of which he targeted both messianic movements such as the Ḥurūfiyya and Nūrbakhshiyya and extra-establishment intellectuals such as Ibn Turka and his circle as ungovernable threats to his tenuously centralized state; it also reflects Shāhrukh's efforts to control the religious scene in Iran under the rubric of his Sunnizing project.⁴⁶

For his part, Ṣā'īn al-Dīn ended his life a broken man in exile, casualty to the contest between establishment normativity and messianic heterodoxy in early 9th/15th century Iran. Precisely for this reason, his lettrist works provide the best contemporary contrast to the gnostic-messianic hurufism of Faḡl Allāh Astarābādī and his followers on the one hand and the more specifically Sufi approach to the science of letters of Shāh Ni'mat Allāh Valī (d. 834/1431)⁴⁷ on the other, to take two prominent examples; more importantly, they are an index of the great seriousness with which occult philosophy was regarded both in elite intellectual circles in western Iran and among certain members the Timurid ruling class.

I.3: The Isfahan Circle and the Neo-Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'

The Isfahan Circle, Ṣā'īn al-Dīn's network of disciples based in western Iran, has been described by Evrim Binbaş as constituting a Timurid 'Invisible College,' an extra-establishment 'republic of letters' dedicated to naturalizing esotericism in Iran.⁴⁸ This intellectual network is virtually unstudied, apart from Binbaş's 2009 monograph on Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī (d. 858/1454), Ibn Turka's chief disciple, as Timurid historian and esotericist and as important member of the

⁴⁶ Binbaş, *Sharaf al-Dīn* 9, 114-19. On Shāhrukh's attempt to control doctrine as upholder of the Shari'a see Manz, *Power, Politics and Religion*, 238-43.

⁴⁷ His *Maktūbāt* (ed. Muḥammad Rasā), for example, contains eight treatises on lettrism (768-810). For a discussion of their contents see §4.3.2 below, and Farzām, *Taḥqīq dar Ahvāl*, 256, 405-7, 478-80, 485-6, 502-3.

⁴⁸ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 79-82; idem, *The Timurid Invisible College*; cf. Fleischer, "Ancient Wisdom," 235.

circle.⁴⁹ The lack of scholarly attention notwithstanding, the members of this Isfahan Circle were far from marginal; to the contrary, they were still remembered as having been the leading intellectual figures of their day into the early Safavid period. Dawlatshāh Samarqandī (d. 900/1494 or 913/1507), for example, explicitly identifies Ibn Turka and Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī as the two most prominent intellectuals of Shahrūkhid Iran, with the two Sufi masters of comparable status being the Kh^wājagānī shaykh Muḥammad Pārsā (d. 822/1419) and the Kubrawī shaykh Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī (d. ca. 839/1436).⁵⁰

More broadly, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn and the members of his Isfahan Circle may be seen as the eastern arm of a larger network of intellectuals stretching to Anatolia via Cairo and calling themselves, cryptically, the Ikhwān al-Ṣafāʾ.⁵¹ The Ottoman arm of this network is being studied by Cornell Fleischer and İhsan Fazlıoğlu, among others, who posit them as a non-hierarchical intellectual confraternity operating in Anatolia and the Balkans independently of the madrasa-khanqah system. Fleischer describes this group as pursuing a grand project synthesizing natural, philosophical, scriptural, historical and mystical knowledge within a larger lettrist and prophetic framework, having as its goal the creation of a just order, a golden age.⁵² ʿAbd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī (d. 858/1454) of Antioch, the influential scholar, lettrist and apocalypticist thinker whose doctrine directly informed the messianism of early Ottoman imperial identity, may be identified as the linchpin of this group of scholars in the Ottoman

⁴⁹ “Sharaf al-Dīn ʿAlī Yazdī (ca. 770s-858/ca. 1370s-1454): Prophecy, Politics, and Historiography in Late Medieval Islamic History.”

⁵⁰ *Tazkirat al-Shuʿarā*, 340. He also lists among the outstanding Shahrūkhid-era poets Kātibī, whom he identifies as Ibn Turka’s disciple in “*ilm-i taṣavvuf*” (340, 384). This Mawlānā Kamāl al-Dīn Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī should not be confused with the later and more famous Kubrawī shaykh Kamāl al-Dīn Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī, Makhdūm-i Aʿẓam (d. 958/1551) (DeWeese, “The *Kashf al-Hudā*,” 63).

⁵¹ Note that Ṣāʿin al-Dīn states that he personally has disciples as far afield as India and Anatolia, as well as the length and breadth of Iran, and his books are everywhere in high demand (“Nafsat al-Maṣḍūr II,” 209-10).

⁵² Fleischer, “Ancient Wisdom,” 235.

context.⁵³ Other members include Mullā Fanārī,⁵⁴ the first Ottoman *shaykh al-islām*, and Shaykh Bedreddīn, the famous judge-cum-millennarian activist and rebel.⁵⁵ For his part, Ṣā'in al-Dīn may be considered the cognate of Bisṭāmī in Iran given the primary focus of both thinkers on lettrism as a scientific methodology for analyzing the inner workings of history and the cosmos. While it is unclear whether they met during their respective long residences in Mamluk Cairo, they were both the intellectual heirs of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (d. 799/1397), the famed Kurdish occultist and resident wonderworker at Sultan Barqūq's (r. 784-801/1382-99) court, who must be considered their most important influence and whose teachings are frequently referenced in their works.⁵⁶

Given the high degree of intellectual confluence between Timurid Iran and Ottoman Anatolia via Cairo, then, the Neo-Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' may tentatively be conceived of as having an eastern and western branch.⁵⁷ (It seems, moreover, that the scope of this network must be further expanded; in his second apology Ṣā'in al-Dīn remarks on the popularity of his writings in all the surrounding regions, from Anatolia in the west to Transoxania and India in the east.⁵⁸) While the precise degree of communication between these two branches remains to be determined, it is immediately productive to analyze the respective outputs of such thinkers as

⁵³ On Bisṭāmī and the Neo-Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' network see Fazlıoğlu, "İlk Dönem Osmanlı İlim"; Fleischer, "Ancient Wisdom"; Gril, "Ésotérisme contre hérésie."

⁵⁴ Cf. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's admiring reference to him ("Nafsat al-Maṣdūr," 173). For more on Fanārī see Shiraz Sheikh's forthcoming dissertation; its working title: "Molla Fenari and the Akbarian Tradition in the Early Ottoman State."

⁵⁵ See §1.2 below.

⁵⁶ See §1.2 for more on this important but wholly unstudied figure.

⁵⁷ On contemporary 'Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' references in Iran see Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 101-16.

⁵⁸ "... [T]his seeker of knowledge, whose writings are borne abroad by the north and east winds and are well received in all regions and on all shores, with travelers from India (*Hindūstān*) and Anatolia being dispatched in search of copies of his treatises and books, and whose students come to him from all lands, including Shiraz, Samarkand, Anatolia and India (*Hind*)" ("Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 209-10).

Ibn Turka and Bisṭāmī as constituting a single, coherent and much larger project. As defined by Fleischer for the Ottoman context, the features of this project include

preoccupation with apocalyptic and messianic themes and images; Abrahamic prophets and pre-Islamic history as authoritative sources of guidance, particularly through appropriate application of either mystical, lettrist, or astrological techniques; reverence for the figure of Ali and his descendants as possessors of comprehensive gnostic knowledge of past and future history transmitted, though increasingly restricted in its possession and circulation, from Adam and the time of Creation; and particular reverence for Jesus and for Christian, as well as Jewish, wisdom traditions. To this admittedly summary list, of course, should be added the affective and revelatory power of letters ... The point of lettrism, as perhaps of Sufism after Ibn Arabi, is its comprehensiveness. These sciences—for such they were to Bistami and his contemporaries—preserved access to the cosmic order underlying successive and interrelated revelations. Properly deciphered, the beginnings of history, and its cycles of prophets, point to its ends.⁵⁹

I.4: Literature review, sources and methodology

As noted above, very little has been done on Ibn Turka to date, and the little that has been done is primarily in Persian. The only sustained treatments of Ṣāʾin al-Dīn in a western language are Henry Corbin's study of his *R. Shaqq-i Qamar u Bayān-i Sāʾat*⁶⁰ and Leonard Lewisohn's short study of his apologies;⁶¹ S. H. Nasr and Hossein Ziai mention him briefly in several places and urge his study.⁶² Brockelmann knows only his commentary on the *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*,⁶³ while Browne

⁵⁹ Fleischer, "Ancient Wisdom," 235. Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī often speaks of the *ahl-i taḥqīq*, a group that may be seen as coextensive with the *ikhwān*, whom he defines as those who believe in the unity of opposites, the influence of celestial bodies, and the status of the quranic *muqattaʿāt* or mysterious isolated letters as the keys to existence (see e.g. his *Nikāt-i Kalimāt al-Tawḥīd fī l-Qurʾān*, Süleymaniye MS Ayasofya 1801; Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 95). Cf. Ṣāʾin al-Dīn's treatment in the *Mafāḥiṣ* of the concept of the unity of opposites (*taʾānuq al-aṭrāf*, *taʾānuq ḍiddayn*) in the context of language (MS Majlis 10196 f. 58b).

⁶⁰ "Typologie des spirituels selon Sâʾinoddīn ʿAlī Torkeh Ispahānī (ob. 830/1427) [sic]," Ch. 3 of his *En Islam iranien*, 3/233-74.

⁶¹ "Sufism and Theology in the Confessions of Ṣāʾin al-Dīn Turka Iṣfahānī (d. 830/1437) [sic]."

⁶² E.g., Nasr, "The School of Isfahan Revisited," 209-10, 324 n. 3 and his preface to the Āshtiyānī edition of the *Tamhīd* (i-iv); and Ziai, "Recent Trends in Arabic and Persian Philosophy," 405-25 ("Ṣāʾin al-Dīn and the Harmony of Religion and Philosophy," 413-15).

⁶³ GALS 1/793^{12y} (^{12z} = ʿAlī Turkī): Raḡib 688, 698 (830/1427).

mentions incidentally that a “Şā’inu’d-Dīn Tarika” was responsible for the poet Kātibī’s (d. 838/1435) conversion to Sufism.⁶⁴ Storey recognizes him a Sufi author and exponent of ornate prose, but lists only his *R. Munāẓarāt-i Khams* by way of example.⁶⁵ Finally, Ibn Turka lacks even a basic entry in the *EI*², a surprising lacuna given his late medieval and modern importance, however misconstrued.⁶⁶

In contrast to the almost total lack of attention to Ibn Turka in western scholarship, the 1970s in Iran saw his rediscovery and the beginnings of a push to edit and publish his works, resulting first in the publication of a collection of fourteen of his shorter treatises⁶⁷ and followed by an annotated edition of his *Tamhīd al-Qawā’id*.⁶⁸ The events of the Revolution slowed this activity for a number of years, but the last decade has now seen the publication, in excellent editions, of several further works; the editors’ learned introductions to these volumes constitute the extent of scholarship on Şā’in al-Dīn to date.⁶⁹ Twenty-two of his works have now been published, out of a total of 46 known works,⁷⁰ meaning that roughly half of his output

⁶⁴ *LHP*, 3/489.

⁶⁵ *PL*, 3/2, 251.

⁶⁶ It does, however, have a brief entry for “Afḍal al-Dīn Turka,” the name of three different members of the family; this entry is much expanded in the *EI*³. The *EI*, still only half complete, to date contains entries on “Afzal-al-Dīn Torka” (i.e. the three individuals with that name) and “Abū Ḥāmed Torka.” Dr. Yarshater has kindly invited me to write the entry on Ibn Turka, s.v. “Şā’en-al-Dīn Torka Eşfahānī.”

⁶⁷ *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Şā’in al-Dīn ‘Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Işfahānī*, ed. S. ‘A. M. Bihbahānī and S. I. Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972.

⁶⁸ Incorporating the commentaries of Muḥammad Riżā Qumshā’ī and Mīrzā Maḥmūd Qummī, it was first printed in Tehran in 1396/1976 and reprinted in Tehran in 1360 Sh./1981 and in Qom in 1381 Sh./2002; see §2.1.2.43 below.

⁶⁹ Based on this scholarship, entries in the *Dānishnāma-yi Jahān-i Islām* and the *Dā’irat al-Ma’ārif-i Buzurg-i Islāmī* on the Turka-yi Işfahānī family (respectively, Sayyid ‘Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Muḥammad Zārī, “Turka-yi Işfahānī”; and Muḥammad ‘Alī Mawlavī, “Āl-i Turka”) contain useful overviews and partial bibliographies of Ibn Turka as the most eminent member of the line. Dihkhudā’s *Lughatnāma* has a separate entry for him under “Şā’in-i Işfahānī.”

⁷⁰ I leave aside here Ibn Turka’s *divān* and collection of correspondence, including 58 letters, letter fragments and notes; see §2.1.3 below.

still remains in manuscript; nevertheless, this spate of publishing has now made it possible to begin to analyze Ibn Turka as a thinker and writer.

Credit for initiating this push must go to Sayyid ‘Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī, who in a 1971 article observed that, due to the unconscionable scholarly neglect of Ibn Turka, it has fallen to him to personally spearhead the study and publication of his works.⁷¹ In the same article Bihbahānī also drew attention to the prominent lettrist component of Ṣā’ in al-Dīn’s oeuvre. In so doing he reiterated Muḥammad Taqī Dānishpazhūh’s call in 1966 to study the works of Ibn Turka, in his view the ‘Spinoza of Iran’; he too recognized in passing the importance of lettrism to Ṣā’ in al-Dīn’s thought.⁷² A few short articles in Persian have been published in the interim, including a (rather unsatisfactory) examination by Fujii Morio of the apologies,⁷³ Luqman Baymatoff’s brief overview of Ibn Turka’s life (with emphasis on his Khujandī origins),⁷⁴ and Najīb Māyil Haravī’s introduction to his edition of the *R. Madārij Afhām al-Afwāj*. From within the school of Tehran, Jalāl al-Dīn Āshtiyānī’s (d. 1425/2005) long introduction (173 pp.) to his 1976 edition of the *Tamhīd* is particularly useful for locating Ibn Turka within modern Imami thought,⁷⁵ as is Ayatollah Javādī-Āmulī’s (b. 1352/1933) *Taḥrīr-i Tamhīd al-Qawā’id*, consisting of his lecture notes on the text.⁷⁶ However, the best overview to date of Ṣā’ in al-Dīn’s life and works is given by Akram Jūdī-Nī‘matī in the introduction to her recent edition of Ṣā’ in al-Dīn’s *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*, an ornate and influential commentary on Ibn al-Fāriḍ’s (d. 632/1235)

⁷¹ “Aḥvāl u Āsār-i Ṣā’ in al-Dīn Turka-yi Iṣfahānī,” 110. This article also contains an edition of Ṣā’ in al-Dīn’s *R. al-Inzālīyya*.

⁷² “Majmū’a-yi Rasāyil-i Khujandī,” a brief description of MS Majlis 10196 (for which see §2.1.1 below).

⁷³ “Ta’ammulī dar Difā’iyyāt-i Ṣā’ in al-Dīn ‘Alī Turka-yi Iṣfahānī.”

⁷⁴ “Darbāra-yi Aḥvāl u Āsār-i Ṣā’ in al-Dīn Khujandī.”

⁷⁵ See also the article on the *Tamhīd* in the *Dānishnāma-yi Jahān-i Islām* by M. Zārī‘ and M. B. Karīmīyān.

⁷⁶ Tehran, 1372 Sh./1993. Ayatollah ‘Abd Allāh Javādī-Āmulī is the prayer leader of Qom and a prominent exponent of the modern Sadrian school in Iran (Sajjad Rizvi, “Mulla Sadra,” *SEP*).

al-Tā'iyya al-Kubrā.⁷⁷ Uniquely among scholars to treat of Ibn Turka, Jūdī-Ni'matī attempts a preliminary evaluation of his thought on the basis of his oeuvre as a whole, which can only produce an image of the man very different from the caricature that has heretofore been offered.⁷⁸ I have depended primarily on her account, together with the apologies, in constructing Ṣā'in al-Dīn's biography in Chapter 1.

The general sociopolitical and religious context of the Timurid period has also seen a recent rise as an object of scholarly interest; here I am thinking especially of Beatrice Manz's *Power, Politics and Religion in Timurid Iran* (2007), a study of Iran under Shāhrukh and as such vital to the present study; Maria Subtelny's *Timurids in Transition* (2006) and earlier work on the political aspects of literary practice at the late Timurid court in Herat;⁷⁹ and Kathryn Babayan's *Mystics, Monarchs, and Messiahs* (2003), a synthesis of the interpenetrating religious and political currents of the period. Shahzad Bashir's work on the Ḥurūfiyya and similar mystical-messianic movements such as the Nūrbakhshiyya flesh out the fraught context in which Ṣā'in al-Dīn developed his lettrist program,⁸⁰ as does the close analyses by Orkhan Mir-Kasimov of the foundational Hurufi texts.⁸¹ Abbas Amanat's (1996) approach to the later derivative Hurufi group, the Nuṣṭaviyya, as a secular messianic social resistance movement is also instructive.⁸²

With respect to late medieval Islamic occult philosophy, Mohammad Masad's 2008 dissertation on Islamic occultism and apocalypticism in the 7th/13th century provides a

⁷⁷ Tehran, 1384 Sh./2005.

⁷⁸ She has also edited Ṣā'in al-Dīn's very popular *Munāẓarāt-i Khams*, an ornate mystico-philosophical romance (Tehran, 1375 Sh./1997).

⁷⁹ "The Poetic Circle at the Court of the Timurid, Sultan Ḥusayn Baiqara, and Its Political Significance."

⁸⁰ See e.g. his *Fazlallah Astarabadi and the Hurufis, Messianic Hopes and Mystical Visions*, "Enshrining Divinity," and "Deciphering the Cosmos from Creation to Apocalypse."

⁸¹ See e.g. his "Étude de textes hurūfī anciens: l'oeuvre fondatrice de Fadlallāh Astarābādī"; "Notes sur deux textes *hurūfī*"; and "The Ḥurūfī Moses."

⁸² "The Nuṣṭawī Movement of Maḥmūd Pisīkhānī and His Persian Cycle of Mystical-Materialism."

general backdrop to my investigation of early 9th/15th century occult philosophy. Pierre Lory's work on the Islamic occult sciences generally (1993)⁸³ and the science of letters specifically (2004)⁸⁴ provides a more immediate context, and together with Denis Gril's survey of the same science in his study of the long second chapter of Ibn 'Arabī's *al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya* (2004)⁸⁵ forms the foundation of the first part of my survey of the history of Islamicate lettrism in Chapter 4. Toufic Fahd's extensive work on magic and the occult sciences in Islam is likewise fundamental to this survey, particularly his *La divination arabe* (1966), as is Manfred Ullmann's classic *Die Natur- und Geheimwissenschaften im Islam* (1972). Gerhard Böwering's work on early Sufi lettrism (2011)⁸⁶ is also useful here.

Most importantly, my understanding of late medieval Islamic occult philosophy as developed in these pages is dependent on the ongoing research of Cornell Fleischer⁸⁷ and his Chicago Circle into the cognate—and more successful—universalist projects developed by contemporary thinkers in the Ottoman context, particularly 'Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī and the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' network of intellectuals. Both logistically and conceptually, this network, posited by İhsan Fazlıoğlu in a 1996 article,⁸⁸ may be seen as largely coterminous with that represented by the Isfahan Circle; hence research on either branch has vital bearing on the whole intellectual complex. (Fleischer's current project, titled *A Mediterranean Apocalypse*, will provide definitive corroboration of the transregional and transcultural nature of

⁸³ Lory and Regourd, eds., *Sciences occultes et Islam*.

⁸⁴ *La science des lettres en Islam*.

⁸⁵ "The Science of Letters."

⁸⁶ "Sulamī's Treatise on the Science of the Letters (*ilm al-ḥurūf*)."

⁸⁷ E.g., "Ancient Wisdom and New Sciences: Prophecies at the Ottoman Court in the Fifteenth and Early Sixteenth Centuries" and "Shadow of Shadows: Prophecy in Politics in 1530s İstanbul."

⁸⁸ "İlk Dönem Osmanlı İlim ve Kültür Hayatında İhvanu's-Safâ ve Abdurrahman Bisṭâmî"; see also his "Forcing the Boundaries in Religion, Politics and Philosophy: Science in the Fifteenth Century."

millenarianism and occultism through the 10th/16th century.) The single most useful piece of scholarship for my purposes, however, is Evrim Binbaş's recent monograph on Ibn Turka's close associate and disciple, the eminent historian, occultist and mathematician Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī (d. 858/1454) (2009).⁸⁹

Despite these heartening advances, scholarship on Islamic occult philosophy still lags far behind that on the occult philosophy of the European Renaissance; I have accordingly found current developments in Renaissance studies highly relevant to my purposes here. The pioneering studies of Frances Yates on early modern European esotericism (as undertaken, e.g., in *The Rosicrucian Enlightenment*, 1972) were the first to retrieve the occult as a legitimate field of research; her insistence on the importance of analyzing the occult thought of the standard heroes of the 'Scientific Revolution' such as Giordano Bruno (d. 1600) (*Giordano Bruno and the Hermetic Tradition*, 1964) has in the last decades been taken to heart and prompted numerous studies along similar lines.⁹⁰ The current study of Western esotericism as a field in its own right is motivated by the central insight that "esotericism [should not be] seen as a selection of historical 'currents' ... but as a structural element of Western culture."⁹¹ Håkan Håkansson's masterful study of the occult philosophy of John Dee (d. 1608) (*Seeing the Word: John Dee and Renaissance Occultism*, 2001), whose project bears striking resemblances to that of Ibn Turka, has proved to be particularly useful, as has Nicholas Clulee's seminal post-Yatesian reading of Dee from a history of science perspective integrating the occult and non-occult aspects of his

⁸⁹ "Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī (ca. 770s-858/ca. 1370s-1454): Prophecy, Politics, and Historiography in Late Medieval Islamic History."

⁹⁰ Many of these recent studies challenge some of Yates's basic theses, in particular her promulgation of the 'myth of the magus'; see Hanegraaff, "Beyond the Yate's Paradigm"; Vickers, "Frances Yates and the Writing of History"; and Leirich, "Finding One's Place: Magic, Science, Religion, and Interdisciplinarity." While Yates' tendency to overstate her case often impairs her arguments, however, it is precisely this habit that allowed her to so successfully raise awareness of the ubiquity of esotericist concerns in early modern European thought.

⁹¹ Von Stuckrad, "Western Esotericism: Towards an Integrative Model of Interpretation," 80.

thought (*John Dee's Natural Philosophy: Between Science and Religion*, 1988).⁹² More generally, I take a page from recent research such as is collected in Kevin Killeen and Peter J. Forshaw's edited volume *The Word and the World: Biblical Exegesis and Early Modern Science* (2007) in characterizing Šā'in al-Dīn's occult philosophy as a quest to decipher the twin Books, the Quran and the cosmos.

Yet it must be kept in mind that because such reconsiderations of the role of occult philosophy in the emergence of modern scientific rationality have only recently gained traction in the context of European intellectual history, they remain for the most part artificially if necessarily eurocentric.⁹³ (That the discussion in the field of history of Islamicate science has largely been focused on the 'legitimate' disciplines of astronomy, mathematics, optics, etc., and possible routes of transmission to the West, hardly helps to combat the prevailing presentist and eurocentric bias.⁹⁴) However, the existence of a massive literature on occult philosophy and the occult sciences preserved in manuscript form in libraries from Asia to Europe and North Africa stands eloquent testimony to the centrality of occult modes of thinking in the late medieval and early modern periods, 'East and West,' and suggests a vast web of circulation till now unmapped. Nor was this circulation simply transregional or transcultural, but also trans-epistemological; to late medieval and early modern thinkers, 'esoteric' and 'exoteric' are but complementary, interpenetrating categories on the continuum of human knowledge—'science' in the global, nonparticularistic understanding of the term.⁹⁵

⁹² In particular, cf. Dee's 'archemastrie,' conceived of as a comprehensive superscience based on number, a wholly "experimental" methodology which "can discover knowledge in the spheres of other sciences that they themselves cannot discover ... because of its potentially unlimited interdisciplarity" (Lehrich, "Finding One's Place," 261).

⁹³ Cf. the focus of some recent studies on Renaissance orientalism, e.g. Stolzenberg, "Egyptian Oedipus: Antiquarianism, Oriental Studies and Occult Philosophy in the Work of Athanasius Kircher."

⁹⁴ See e.g. Stearns, "Writing the History of the Natural Sciences."

⁹⁵ Cf. DeVun, "John of Rupescissa and the States of Nature: Science, Apocalypse, and Society in the Late Middle Ages," 3: "But it is important to consider what Rupescissa meant when he wrote the word 'science' in his texts. For him, science was *scientia*—knowledge or truth, especially that which touched

Given the sheer mass of unexamined material here in view, as a methodological necessity I concentrate on Ibn Turka as an outstanding but also representative intellectual of the late medieval period. It is not an accident that Šā'in al-Dīn's thought resonates in such large measure with that of later Renaissance figures such as Pico, Dee or Bruno; indeed, Bruno's description of his project as "a cabala of theological philosophy, a philosophy of cabalistic theology, a theology of philosophical cabala"⁹⁶ expresses precisely Ibn Turka's own project. Guided by the 'connected histories' principle,⁹⁷ then, this study represents a preliminary attempt to understand the occult philosophy of Ibn Turka and the role of his circle in western Iran as an important node of this vast intellectual network.

I remarked above that roughly half of Šā'in al-Dīn's oeuvre remains in manuscript, including most of his lettrist works; the latter are, of course, the focus of the present study, but I draw on other writings, particularly the famous apologies, where these furnish relevant context. In addition, the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* and *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* are veritable goldmines for the reconstruction of the intellectual and sociopolitical networks in which Šā'in al-Dīn and his circle operated; the first collection, comprising some 50 letters or notes from or to Ibn Turka, has yet to be edited, although the second, including a further seven (or eight) letters relating to Šā'in al-Dīn and his family, was recently edited and published in two volumes by the

upon scripture, nature, and the meaning of human history. The 'science' that Rupescissa hoped to discover was the technical knowledge to produce alchemical and medical materials, the exegetical knowledge to predict the reign of the antichrist, and the spiritual knowledge to reform Christian society—certainly a much broader scope of inquiry than that suggested by our modern term. For this reason, 'science' in my title denotes the full range of *scientiae* that Rupescissa pursued and expressed in his writings. This definition is perhaps idiosyncratic, but it stems from the difficulty of adapting medieval concepts to modern vocabulary. I ask the reader, then, to dismiss any preconceptions about 'science' as it is usually used in order to appreciate the complex meanings of the medieval topics discussed in this study."

⁹⁶ Yates, *Giordano Bruno*, 262, from Bruno, *La cabala del cavallo pegaseo*, Palermo, 1992, 837: "Eccovi cabala, teologia e filosofia: dico una cabala di teologica filosofia, una filosofia di teologia cabalistica, una teologia di cabala filosofica" See de León-Jones, *Giordano Bruno and the Kabbalah*, 24.

⁹⁷ See e.g. Subrahmanyam, "Connected Histories: Notes towards a Reconfiguration of Early Modern Eurasia"; Werner and Zimmerman, "Beyond Comparison: *Histoire Croisée* and the Challenge of Reflexivity."

indefatigable and lamented Īraj Afshār.⁹⁸ In Chapters 4 and 5 I draw on a broad range of lettrist sources from the medieval and late medieval periods; like Ṣā'in al-Dīn's lettrist works, most of the vast corpus of Islamic lettrist thought remains in manuscript. My primary task in this study will therefore be to present Ibn Turka's lettrist project through the analysis and contextualization of his relevant works. To this end I provide extensive translated sections throughout Part 1 of this study, and devote Part 2 to a full translation and/or edition of several of his most important minor lettrist treatises. For reasons of space, in Chapter 7 I provide only a few translated excerpts from the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* judged to be representative of the author's methods and goals in this, the centerpiece of his oeuvre. In what follows I refer occasionally to the works of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī, Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī and 'Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī for corroboration on certain points of doctrine, but unfortunately the sheer mass of unedited material these represent, much of it preserved in manuscripts currently inaccessible to me, makes it impossible to begin to summarize their writings here. It must be emphasized that this study, the first to address the question of Ibn Turka's lettrist thought, is necessarily provisional, and seeks only to establish a useful standard of comparison for future research into the universalist thought of the Isfahan Circle specifically and late medieval Islamic intellectual history generally.

⁹⁸ *Manẓūmāt*, ed. Īraj Afshār, Tehran, 1386 Sh./2007; and *Munsha'āt*, ed. Īraj Afshār and Muḥammad Rizā Abū'ī Mahrīzī, Tehran, 1388 Sh./2009; see §2.1.3 below for a detailed description of these collections. As Binbaş remarks, "[O]ne cannot emphasize enough the importance of the Timurid *Munsha'āt* (collections of letters and treatises) as a source for Timurid intellectual and political history. One of the distinguishing characteristics of the Timurid intellectual history is the existence of numerous *Munsha'āt* collected under the name of a certain intellectual. Unfortunately, during most of the twentieth century, these *munsha'āt* were relegated to the field of social and economic history, and their potential for the intellectual and cultural history were hardly appreciated. However, with the gradual appearance in print of those *munsha'āt* belonging to various intellectuals we are reminded that the *munsha'āt* are invaluable sources for intellectual history as well ... One final aspect of the *munsha'āt*, especially of those descriptive in format, that needs to be emphasized is that one of the most productive sources of the study of intellectual networks in the Timurid period is the contents of the *munsha'āt*. For most *munsha'āt* include the letters and treatises of several individuals, who are part of the same intellectual network" ("Sharaf al-Dīn," 12-13).

I.5: Definition of terms

Given the marginalized nature of the topic here under consideration, there exists as yet no scholarly consensus as to acceptable terminology for the primary concepts and categories that will be mentioned in these pages. The terms I propose below are for analytical convenience, and may be replaced with others in the face of new evidence; for the time being they must remain slippery.

As a case in point, the term *lettrism*: denoting as it does that methodology centered on but in no way limited to letters, it implies a host of other sciences with which the letters are invariably seen to interface at all levels of reality, including numerology, judicial astrology, astronomy, alchemy, magic, divination, and so forth. Where does one term stop and another begin? The same volatility applies to the categories of (peripatetic or illuminationist) philosophy and (theoretical) mysticism, particularly in their synthesis as the mystico-philosophical systems that define so much of later Islamic intellectual history. My choice of ‘occult philosophy’ to denote the broader, universalist project of Ṣā’id al-Dīn and his circle simply takes a page from an ongoing debate in Western esotericism studies; as defined by Wouter Hanegraaff in the *Dictionary of Gnosis and Western Esotericism*, it does reasonable justice to that project while being more usefully descriptive than the catchall term ‘esotericism.’ Finally, my rendering of the fundamental and highly polysemous term pair *wilāya/walāya* as ‘sanctified power’ is simply a translation of convenience; there is no English equivalent. I accordingly use these terms as follows:

⦿ *Lettrism*: Any type of methodology (e.g., *jafr*, *‘ilm al-ḥurūf*) centered on letters as keys to deciphering (and manipulating) all levels of physical and spiritual reality; to this end the letters are held to be matrices of numerological, astrological, alchemical, magical and other correspondences. Lettrist theory presupposes a perfect, eternal, revealed

Book upon which to focus its operations, the Quran in the case of Islamic lettrism and the Torah in the case of Jewish or Christian kabbalah. Although the term kabbalah/cabala might be naturalizable to the Islamicate context—Steven Wasserstrom, for example, posits a common 2nd-3rd/8th-9th century gnostic-syncretic Near Eastern milieu for the first expressions of Hebrew and Arabic letter speculation⁹⁹—, for the time being it seems prudent to use the more neutral term lettrism in this study in recognition of the fact that letter theories appear to have been far more mainstream, widespread and varied in the Islamicate context than in the Jewish or post-14th century Christian; and as a revealed Book the Quran, of course, differs fundamentally from the Torah in fabric and content and hence generates different speculative and operative possibilities.¹⁰⁰ The multifariousness and multivalency of Islamic lettrism aside, in what follows I posit for analytical convenience three overarching but frequently interpenetrating strands: gnostic-messianic, Sufi, and intellectual.¹⁰¹

⁹⁹ More specifically, he sees the foundational text of Hebrew kabbalah, the *Sefer Yetzirah*, as the product of the creative symbiosis of Jewish and early Islamicate occult sciences, and thus coeval with e.g. Ismaʿili and Sufi speculations on the subject (Wasserstrom, “Sefer Yeşira and Early Islam”).

¹⁰⁰ The most distinctive quranic feature in this regard are the isolated sura-initial letters (*al-ḥurūf al-muqattaʿa*), the focus of much of Islamic lettrist theory. It is, however, intriguing to note that the high point of Sufi lettrism in Andalusia and the Maghrib during the 6th-7th/12th-13th centuries, represented by Ibn ʿArabī and al-Būnī in particular, coincided with the emergence of a mature Jewish kabbalism in the same region; see e.g. Moshe Idel, “Kabbalah and Elites in Thirteenth-Century Spain,” *Mediterranean Historical Review*, 9 (1994), 5-19.

¹⁰¹ Cf. Moshe Idel’s three categories of Jewish kabbalah, all well represented in late medieval and Renaissance Italy in particular: the ecstatic-mystical (e.g. Abraham Abulafia), the theurgical-theosophical (e.g. Menahem Recanati), and the astromagical-hermetic (e.g. Yohanan Alemmano) (*Kabbalah in Italy*, 3, 29). With respect to the category of intellectual lettrism I posit in this study, cf. the term “intellectual gnosticism” proposed by Jeffrey Kripal in his *The Serpent’s Gift* to describe an epistemological approach that in privileging knowledge over belief synthesizes rational and religious or mystical modes of knowing, thereby transcending both (*The Serpent’s Gift*, 11-12 et passim; but see Wouter Hanegraaff’s critique in “Leaving the Garden (In Search of Religion): Jeffrey J. Kripal’s Vision of a Gnostic Study of Religion,” *Religion*, 38 (2008), 259-76). In Idel’s terms, intellectual lettrism is perhaps best described as privileging both theosophical-theurgical and astromagical-hermetic strains of the science, depending on the predilections of the individual lettrist, while Sufi lettrism, particularly in its earlier phase, tends to privilege the ecstatic-mystical strain without being limited thereto. More broadly, Sufi lettrism is typically associated with a formal Sufi affiliation on the part of the practitioner, unlike intellectual lettrism. Gnostic-messianic lettrism, for its part, is primarily defined not by its content but by its religious and sociopolitical motives.

⦿ *Occult philosophy*: An umbrella term denoting the universalist, neoplatonic-lettrist-hermetic projects developed by late medieval and early modern thinkers with the goal of decoding (and recoding) the cosmos. As defined by Hanegraaff, such projects typically encompass “the entirety of the ‘occult sciences,’” including lettrism, numerology, astrology, alchemy and natural magic, “provided that these are understood not only as practical disciplines but as integral parts of a comprehensive religious philosophy and cosmology on neoplatonic, hermetic and kabbalistic foundations.” A characteristic feature of such projects is the belief in the ancient lineage of the sciences on which they depend.¹⁰²

⦿ *Theoretical mysticism, mystical theory*: The type of speculative mysticism or theosophy associated with Ibn ‘Arabī as philosophized and systematized by his disciple Qūnavī and the later members of the Ibn ‘Arabī school, including Ibn Turka.¹⁰³

⦿ *Sanctified power*: My preferred, necessarily inadequate translation of the term pair *wilāya/walāya*, sometimes rendered ‘sanctity,’ ‘sainthood,’ ‘rulership’ or ‘friendship [with God],’ which refers in the Ibn ‘Arabian tradition to the station of the Perfect Man

¹⁰² Hanegraaff, “Occult/Occultism,” *Dictionary of Gnosis and Western Esotericism*, 886–87. As Daniel Stolzenberg remarks in his study of the Jesuit scholar Athanasius Kircher’s (d. 1680) esotericist and orientalizing thought: “Like other, related terms, such as ‘Hermeticism’ and ‘esotericism,’ the expression ‘occult philosophy’ may carry undesired connotations and invite misunderstanding ... By ‘occult philosophy’ I mean to refer to an intellectual tradition that Kircher received from Renaissance authors such as Marsilio Ficino and Cornelius Agrippa, who espoused influential theories about what may best be called ‘Neoplatonic magic,’ and who associated these theories with the notion of an esoteric tradition by which such teachings supposedly had been propagated from remote antiquity. The term ‘occult philosophy’ comes from the title of Cornelius Agrippa’s *De occulta philosophia*, first published in its entirety in 1533. I have chosen to use Agrippa’s expression because it comes from the vocabulary of the historical actors and implies simultaneously the Neoplatonic interpretation of occult sciences and the belief in their ancient, esoteric lineage” (“Egyptian Oedipus: Antiquarianism, Oriental Studies and Occult Philosophy in the Work of Athanasius Kircher,” 16–17).

¹⁰³ Meister Eckhart (d. 1327), Jakob Boehme (d. 1624), and Emanuel Swedenborg (d. 1772) may be cited as European cognates.

(*al-insān al-kāmil*) as vicegerent (*khalīfa*) over creation and transcript (*nuskha*) of the macrocosm.¹⁰⁴ It represents the actualization of that revealed through prophethood (*nubuwwa*). Like many lettrists, Ibn Turka consistently associates *wilāya/walāya* with the Imams and the ancients as repositories of all occult knowledge, and the science of letters most particularly; he further associates this station of human perfection with the written and mental forms of the letter, the spoken form being peculiar to prophethood.¹⁰⁵

I.6: Objective of this study

The present study seeks to answer, begin to answer, or modify the questions about Ibn Turka and his project first posed by Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī in 1977.¹⁰⁶ After surveying the long and complicated route whereby the intellectual synthesis (*talfīq*) between philosophy, mysticism and the occult sciences was achieved in Muslim intellectual circles, Dībājī observes that such syntheses were accomplished by Renaissance men—polymaths such as Ibn Turka, whose many-sided output demonstrates his learning in philosophy, mysticism, theology, jurisprudence, hadith, tafsir, literature, the occult sciences (numerology, *jafr*, talismans), mathematics, and astrology-astronomy. He finds Šā'in al-Dīn's career to raise ten questions in particular:

1. Philosophy: his *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id* represents a sophisticated synthesis of philosophy and mystical theory, and seeks to elevate the peripatetic discourse on the concept of

¹⁰⁴ For debates on the meanings of this term pair see e.g. Landolt, "Walāya," *Encyclopedia of Religion*, New York, 1987, 14/216-22.

¹⁰⁵ See §7.2 below.

¹⁰⁶ "Risāla-yi Anjām az Šā'in al-Dīn 'Alī Turka Khujandī Iṣfahānī," 154-58.

being (*wujūd*) through incorporation of intuitive and mystical data. How does this answer, for example, the final *namaṭ* of Ibn Sīnā's *Ishārāt*?

2. Theoretical mysticism: his commentaries on the *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam* of Ibn 'Arabī and the *Tā'iyya* of Ibn al-Fāriḍ are among the most important works on synthetic mystical philosophy. [What is their place in the respective commentary traditions on these two seminal texts?]
3. Lettrism: his heavy emphasis on the science of letters as formulated especially in the *Mafāḥiṣ*. [What is the nature of his lettrist thought?]
4. What is his relationship to the various lettrist trends of his day, including the Hurufis, Isma'ilis, bāṭinīs, Nuqtavis, Pasikhanis, or that advanced by Ibn 'Arabī? Or is he rather responsible for an independent movement?
5. What is the identity of the individual to whom Ṣā'in al-Dīn refers so frequently and with such respect as "our Sayyid" (*sayyid-i mā*)? Is it Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī or someone else?
6. What is his confessional orientation, Sunni and Shafi'i (as he avers in the *Tuḥfa-yi 'Alā'iyya*) or, as it appears from other works, Shi'i?
7. Did Ṣā'in al-Dīn and the abovementioned sayyid consider themselves as having a particular mission, and, if so, what was it?
8. What was his relationship with the Timurid and Ottoman states?
9. What was his influence on both the sciences and the literature and literary style of his day?
10. What gave rise to the troubles he encountered, these culminating in his exile, as expressed at various places in his works and in his apologies?

Despite its routine privileging of philosophy and mystical theory and slight de-emphasis of lettrism, Dībājī's list offers an excellent, if tentative, map of the main landmarks in the socio-

intellectual landscape into which this study ventures. But perhaps more to the point: I remarked above that Evrim Binbaş's recent monograph on Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī provides the immediate context for the present study as the first to shed light on many of the above points, particularly with respect to the preeminent importance of lettrism within the larger intellectual project of the Isfahan Circle. More specifically, then, my purpose in what follows is to unpack the thesis advanced by Binbaş:

Although deeply influenced by the philosophical theology of Ibn al-ʿArabī, Yazdī and other intellectuals in his circle [including, in the first place, Ibn Turka as its leader] seem to have developed their own language. The basic premise of this language can be summarized as follows: the secrets of the natural world and the divine world can be *understood* through proper adoption and application of literary, scientific, mystical, and historiographical methodologies. The most prominent of these methodologies was the science of letters (*ʿilm-i ḥurūf*). Geographically, these intellectuals seem to have been centered around Iṣfahān, Shīrāz, and Yazd in the Timurid Empire.¹⁰⁷

What, precisely, was this new intellectual language developed by Ibn Turka and his circle in western Iran? What this lettrism and its efficacy as a methodology for deciphering the twin Books, the Quran and the cosmos?

¹⁰⁷ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 9. Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī often speaks of the *ahl-i taḥqīq*, for example, as a distinct intellectual group that may be seen as coextensive with the Neo-Ikhwān al-Ṣafā', whom he defines as those who believe in the unity of opposites, the influence of celestial bodies, and the status of the quranic *muqatta'āt* or mysterious isolated letters as the keys to existence (idem, 92-95). Cf. K. al-Mafāḥiṣ, MS Majlis 10196 f. 58b, where Ṣā'in al-Dīn discusses the unity of opposites (*ta'ānuq al-aṭrāf*, *ta'ānuq diddayn*) in the context of language. It may be noted in passing that Giordano Bruno likewise places great emphasis on the principle of *coincidentia oppositorum* (de León-Jones, *Giordano Bruno and the Kabbalah*, 24).

A.1: Timeline¹

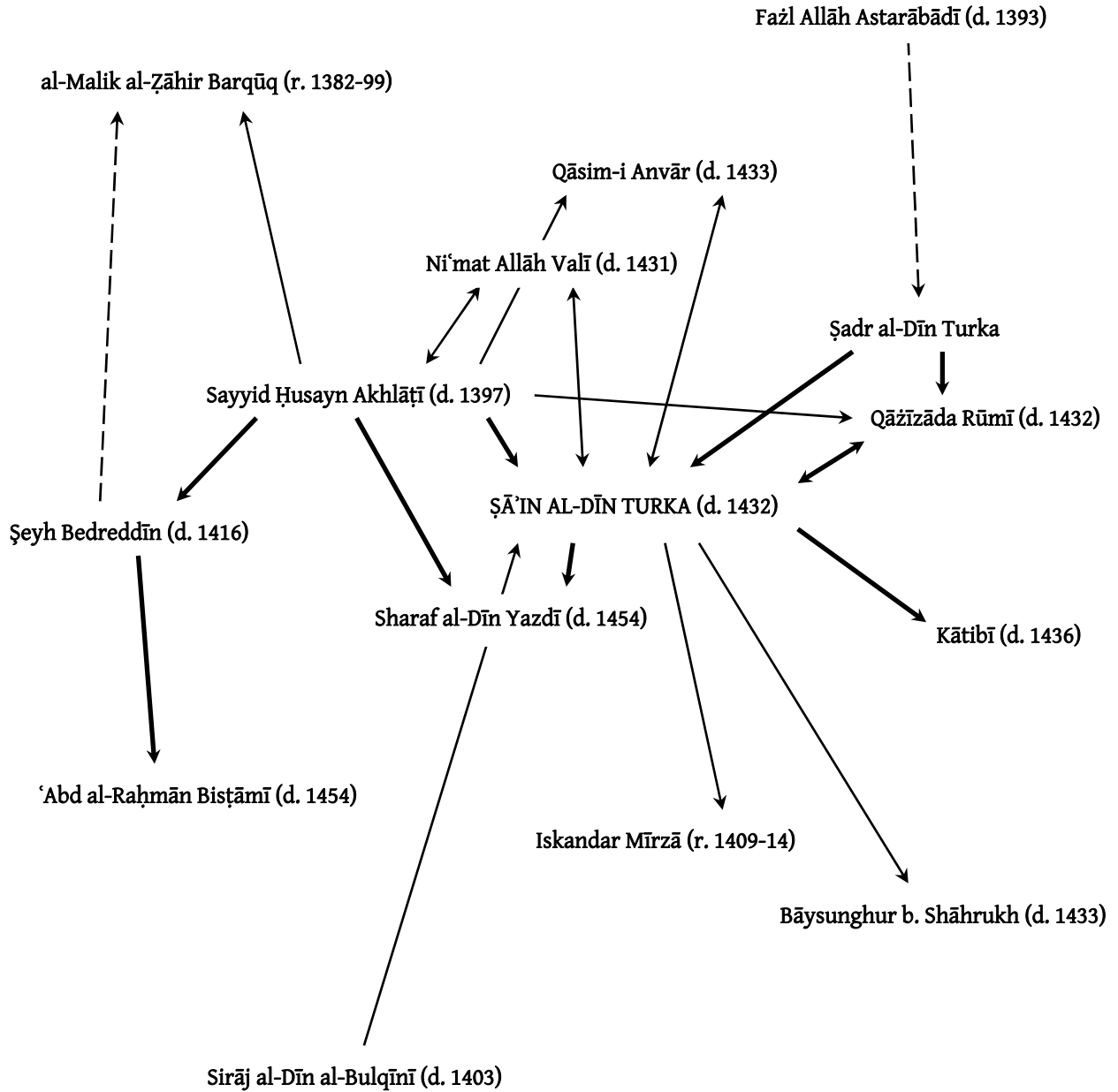
- 770/1369** Ibn Turka born in Isfahan
- 770/1369** *Temür takes Samarkand; it becomes his capital*
- after 787/1385** *Ḥaydar Āmulī dies in Najaf*
- 789/1387** *Temür takes Isfahan, massacres most of its inhabitants*
- 789/1387** The Turka family spared, sent to Temür's court at Samarkand; Šā'in al-Dīn's elder brother Šadr al-Dīn appointed qadi there
- c. 792/1390** *Ḥāfiẓ dies in Shiraz*
- c. 795/1393** Ibn Turka leaves Samarkand for Mecca, Cairo; Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī accompanies him
- c. 795-810/1393-1408** Studies under Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī, Sirāj al-Dīn al-Bulqīnī *et al.* in Cairo; remains abroad 15 years
- 796/1394** *Faẓl Allāh Astarābādī executed at fortress of Alinjaq by Mīrānshāh b. Temür*
- 799/1397** *Akhlāṭī dies in Cairo*
- 799/1397** *Shāhrukh b. Temür appointed governor of Khurasan*
- 806/1404** Completes *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*
- 807/1405** *Temür dies in Utrar*
- 808/1405** Writes *R. Munāẓarāt-i Khams*
- 808/1406** *Ibn Khaldūn dies in Cairo*
- c. 810/1408** Returns to Isfahan, takes up teaching
- c. 810-12/1408-9** Member of Pīr-Muḥammad b. 'Umar-Shaykh's court in Shiraz
- 812/1409** *Pīr-Muḥammad murdered; his brother Iskandar's rise to power in Fars*
- 812-15/1409-12** Member of Iskandar's court in Isfahan, appointed qadi and teacher (?)

¹ Events in Ibn Turka's life are unitalicized; other events are given in italics. The titles of the lettrist works referenced in this study are bolded. Given the sparseness of information on Ibn Turka's life, some dates and events here are conjectured or approximate; most are based on the colophons of MS Majlis 10196, the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* and the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī*. Select political events are taken from Manz, *Power, Politics and Religion*, xiii-xvii.

- 813/1410 *Shāhrukh completes madrasa-khanaqah complex in Herat, appoints teachers*
- 813/1411 *Shāhrukh declares the abrogation of Yasa law, enforces Shari‘a; taverns closed*
- 813/1411 *Rajab al-Bursī dies in Hilla*
- 813/1411 *Travels to Hijaz (for pilgrimage?), invites Sharaf al-Dīn; completes **Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam***
- by 815/1412 *Shāhrukh’s control established over Khurasan, Transoxania and Khwarazm*
- 815-17/1412-14 *Iskandar takes Isfahan, establishes brilliant court there*
- 815-17/1412-14 *Attached to Iskandar’s court in Isfahan; moves back to Shiraz due to harassment by envious individuals, puts forward his protégé Sharaf al-Dīn Ya‘qūb to replace him as qadi*
- 817/1414 *Shāhrukh marches against Iskandar in Iraq, who flees but is captured, blinded and later executed; replaces him with son Ibrāhīm Sulṭān*
- c. 817-25/1414-22 *Attempts to retire from public life*
- 817/1414 *Writes **R. Ḥurūf** in Shiraz for Iskandar (?)*
- 817/1415 *Completes a corrected version of **Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam***
- 818/1415 *Disturbances in Fars; Shāhrukh campaigns to impose control; Bāysunghur appointed governor of Mazandaran and western Khurasan*
- c. 823/1420 *Chaqmāq appointed governor of Yazd*
- 823/1420 *Completes **K. al-Mafāḥiṣ** (in Isfahan or Yazd?)*
- c. 825/1422 *His opponents go to Shāhrukh’s court at Herat, accuse him of Sufi bias; travels to Herat to clear his name, gains Shāhrukh’s favor, given judgeship in Yazd*
- 825/1422 *Writes **R. Asrār al-Ṣalāt** in Herat*
- 827-28/1423-24 *Family of Amīr Fīrūzshāh given governorship of Isfahan*
- 828/1425 *Writes (or has copied) **R. al-Inzālīyya**, **R. Anjām**, **R. Bā’iyya**, **R. Nuqṭa** and **R. Muḥammadiyya** (in Yazd?); revises and expands **K. al-Mafāḥiṣ** in company of Yazdī and other associates*
- 829/1426 *Writes **R. Shaqq-i Qamar**; writes **R. Su’l al-Mulūk** at request of Bāysunghur b. Shāhrukh; writes **Sharḥ al-Basmala**, sends copies to Ulugh Beg and Qāẓizāda Rūmī*
- 829/1426 *His enemies in Yazd send delegation to Herat accusing him of heresy and Shi‘i proclivities; summoned to Herat, writes **Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I** and **R. I’tiqādāt** for Shāhrukh in his defense, again gains Shāhrukh’s favor*
- 829/1426 *Writes **R. Bazm u Razm** in Herat*
- 830/1427 *Completes the **Tamhīd al-Qawā’id** in Shiraz*

- 830/1427** *Aḥmad-i Lur's assassination attempt against Shāhrukh; the arrest and exile of those with suspected Hurufi sympathies*
- 830/1427** Recalled to Herat, stripped of position and property, tortured, imprisoned; writes letter seeking redress to Amīr Fīrūzshāh
- c. 830-33/1427-30** Exile in Mazandaran, Gilan, Hamadan, Azarbayjan, Natanz; writes letters to Mar'ashī and Kārkiyā sayyids seeking patronage
- 831/1428** Writes R. *Tuḥfa-yi 'Alā'ī* for 'Alā' al-Dīn b. Bāysunghur
- 831/1428** *Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī completes his Zafarnāma*
- 832/1428** Writes R. *Mabda' u Ma'ād* for Shāh Raḡī l-Dīn in Mazandaran
- 833/1429** *Muḥammad al-Jazarī, his powerful opponent, dies in Herat; Shāhrukh's second Azarbayjan campaign against Qara Quyunlu*
- c. 833/1429** Fruitless attempt to obtain a hearing with Shāhrukh in Simnan
- 833/1430** Winters in Natanz, sends for family; while there writes K. *al-Manāḥij* for son Muḥammad
- c. 834/1430** Obtains a hearing at Shāhrukh's camp at Ṣā'in Qal'a near Sultaniyya, receives a promise of reinstatement
- 834/1430** *Shāhrukh arrives back in Herat from Azarbayjan campaign*
- c. 834/1431** Travels to Herat
- 834-35/1431-32** For nine months is in weekly attendance at court waiting for the review of his case; writes *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* II and R. *I'tiqādiyya* for Bāysunghur
- 835/1432** *Hurufi uprisings in Isfahan and Tabriz*
- 835/1432** Dies in Herat

A.2: Ibn Turka's intellectual network¹



¹ This diagram updates that given by Binbaş ("Sharaf al-Dīn," 366). Arrows indicate direction of influence, and line thickness indicates relative closeness of connection, whether primary or secondary. Note that the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* provides a fuller picture of Ibn Turka's socio-intellectual circle than can be presented here, but such further connections can be considered tertiary with respect to the present diagram.

CHAPTER 1

The life and times of Ibn Turka

1.1: The Turka family of Isfahan

Şā'in al-Dīn 'Alī Turka Işfahānī Khujandī, often known simply as Kh^wāja Turka Işfahānī or Şā'in-i Turka,¹ was born in 770/1369 almost certainly in Isfahan.² The Turka family had been noted for its scholars since Ilkhanid times; indeed, Şā'in al-Dīn himself notes the family's distinguished seven-century history.³ (In referring to Şā'in al-Dīn the short form Ibn Turka is often preferred to distinguish him as the most eminent member of this venerable line.) The name Turka, or 'little Turk' (Littleturk), is in reference to the family's Turkic origins; an ancestor is said to have emigrated from Khujand in the Farghana valley to Isfahan in the Khwarazmshahid/Seljuq period.⁴ In his *Tuhfa-yi 'Alā'ī* Şā'in al-Dīn reports that his family has always belonged to the Shafī'i rite.⁵

¹ His name in full: Şā'in al-Dīn Abū Muḥammad 'Alī b. Afzal al-Dīn Muḥammad b. Şadr al-Dīn Abī Ḥamid Muḥammad Turka Işfahānī Khujandī. Şā'in al-Dīn uses the *takhalluṣ* 'Alī in the small collection of his surviving poetry, and usually signs his letters as Şāyin-i Turka; in a reading note (*Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 330a) he identifies himself as 'Alī b. Muḥammad b. Muḥammad Turka. He is occasionally also called Şā'in al-Dīn Khujandī or Şā'in al-Dīn Işfahānī. The honorific Şā'in al-Dīn is sometimes mistakenly given as Żiyā' al-Dīn in the sources.

² While his date of birth is nowhere given in the sources, Şā'in al-Dīn states in his *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* I, completed on 8 Rajab 829/16 May 1426, that he is 59 (lunar) years of age at the time of writing (170), thus putting his birth sometime in 770/1369.

³ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 215. Information on the family's history before the 8th/14th century is unfortunately lost. For the most prominent members of the Turka family see Mūsavī-Bihbahānī and Zāri', "Turka-yi Işfahānī," *DJI*; Mawlavī, "Āl-i Turka," *DMBI*.

⁴ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 203; Ibn Turka, *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr* (SND), ed. Akram Jūdī-Ni'matī, xxxvi.

⁵ "Tuhfa-yi 'Alā'ī," 147.

The first member of the Turka family of note for whom we have information is Šā'in al-Dīn's grandfather, the philosopher Šadr al-Dīn Abū Ḥāmid Muḥammad b. Ḥabīb Allāh. Šadr al-Dīn appears to have had a close relationship with the Ilkhanid vizier and polymath Rashīd al-Dīn Ṭabīb (d. ca. 718/1318), and is presented in Timurid-era sources as one of the executors of the latter's estate upon his death.⁶ Šadr al-Dīn's philosophical works include *al-I'timād al-Kabīr*, *al-Ḥikma al-Manī'a*,⁷ *al-Irḥāṣ*, *Kunūz al-Afrāḥ fī Ma'rifat al-Ashbāḥ wa-l-Arwāḥ*, *al-Ḥikma al-Rashīdiyya* (this and the previous work being dedicated to Rashīd al-Dīn),⁸ and *Qawā'id al-Tawḥīd*.⁹ This last work, treating of the concept of absolute existence (*wujūd muṭlaq*), was written in an effort to synthesize peripatetic and illuminationist philosophy and Ibn 'Arabian mystical theory;¹⁰ Šā'in al-Dīn was to expand and refine his grandfather's work in his commentary thereon, *al-Tamhīd fī Sharḥ Qawā'id al-Tawḥīd* or simply *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, which, as noted above, was to become a staple teaching text for philosophical mysticism and the primary basis for Ibn Turka's modern reputation. Although there exist no separate studies on the philosopher, his importance to early 8th/14th century thought was not inconsiderable. Henry Corbin notes, for example, that

⁶ See Rahman, "Abū Ḥāmed Torka," *Elr*; Rashīd al-Dīn Ṭabīb (attrib.), "Maktūb-i Khwāja Rashīd al-Dīn Faẓl Allāh bi Šadr al-Dīn Muḥammad Turka"; Nakhjavānī, "Vaṣīyyat-nāma-yi Khwāja Rashīd al-Dīn Faẓl Allāh-i Vazīr ki bi Šadr al-Dīn Muḥammad Turka Nivishta." As Āqā Buzurg notes (*al-Dharī'a*, 25/108, no. 595), the *Vaṣīyyat-nāma-yi Rashīdī*, addressed to Šadr al-Dīn Turka, states that in Rashīd al-Dīn's library are 2,000 Qurans (with details as to the copyists) and 60,000 other volumes he collected from Iran, Turan, Egypt, Syria and Aden, all to be endowed to the Rab'ī Rashīdī. It should be noted, however, that Rashīd al-Dīn's correspondence is probably inauthentic, being rather datable to the Timurid period (Morton, "The Letters of Rashīd al-Dīn: Ilkhānid Fact or Timurid Fiction?"; an unpersuasive defense of their authenticity is offered in Soudavar, "In Defense of Rašīd-od-dīn and His Letters"). This raises the question: why was it important to the political and intellectual context of 9th/15th century Iran to posit a close relationship between Rashīd al-Dīn and Šadr al-Dīn Turka?

⁷ This work is alternatively titled *al-Ḥikma al-Mutqina*, *al-Ḥikma al-Mutbi'a* (*SND*, xxxvii).

⁸ *SND*, xxxviii.

⁹ Most of these works are today lost. The *Qawā'id al-Tawḥīd* is preserved in Šā'in al-Dīn's *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, and was also published separately by Majīd Hādizāda in his *Nuṣūṣ wa Rasā'il min Turāth Isfahān al-'Ilmī al-Khālīd* on the basis of the earliest copy of the *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, checked by the author himself (MS Majlis 10196 ff. 189-222; see §2.1.1.1). See Zārī and Karīmīyān, "Tamhīd al-Qawā'id (1)," *DJI*.

¹⁰ Its express purpose is to refute the 'doubts of the peripatetics,' and is heavily dependent on Šadr al-Dīn Qūnavī (d. 673/1274) and the *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam* commentary of Mu'ayyad al-Dīn Jandī (d. 690/1291).

Ḥaydar Āmulī (d. after 787/1385) acknowledged Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka as one of his main sources, second only to Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī (d. 672/1274) and his student ‘Allāma Ḥillī (d. 726/1326), the latter being Āmulī’s own teacher;¹¹ Āmulī says of Ṣadr al-Dīn: “The preeminent scholar and gnostic sage Ṣadr al-Ḥaqq wa-l-Milla wa-l-Dīn al-Iṣfahānī, known as Turka, ... wrote a number of books and treatises in this vein, among them the treatise he wrote on absolute existence, for which he adduced numerous proofs.”¹²

Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka’s *Qawā’id al-Tawḥīd*, the treatise to which Āmulī here refers, represents a prime Ilkhanid-era instance of the ‘will to synthesis,’ particularly between philosophy and mystical theory, that defines so much of later Islamicate intellectual history.¹³ As current research shows, the Mongol conquest of western Asia, far from destroying the bases of all scholarly creativity, opened up new intellectual possibilities in the eastern Islamicate world. The intellectual productions of the 7th-10th/13th-16th centuries do not simply preserve and imitate received traditions, as has long been assumed, but rather subvert them, on the one hand, by challenging or undercutting established doctrines or systems of thought, and transform them, on the other hand, by synthesizing multiple intellectual currents into larger wholes. This will to synthesis constitutes a drive to encompass and order all human knowledge while subverting such knowledge to creative, universalist ends.¹⁴ It is precisely this millenarian

¹¹ Corbin, “Aḥvāl, Shakhṣiyyat u Āsār-i Sayyid Ḥaydar Āmulī,” trans. Sayyid Javād Ṭabāṭabā’ī, in idem, *Maqālāt*, 147.

¹² *Jāmi‘ al-Asrār*, 497.

¹³ In his *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, for example, Ṣā’id al-Dīn speaks of such mystical-philosophical syntheses as being the standard intellectual approach of his day (MS Majlis 10196 f. 35a; see §7.3.1, prefatory section): “While the methodologies current among the nations are many and correspond to their different levels of attainment and purpose, the most straightforward and persuasive of these approaches relative to what people are familiar with is the rational-theoretical approach that depends on logical thought (*al-naẓar al-‘aqlī wa-l-fikr al-ālī*) while at the same time swerving not from the highway of intuitive all-comprehensiveness (*jam‘iyyatu-hu al-dhawqiyya*) into the thickets of thorny theoretical doubts on either side.”

¹⁴ See §1.2 above for more on the millenarian universalist spirit, of which this will to synthesis is a central expression, that animates so much of the intellectual, creative, religious, political and economic activity of the late medieval and early modern periods.

ethos that is embodied in both Ṣadr al-Dīn's project and that of his grandson Ṣā'in al-Dīn after him.

Little is known about Ṣā'in al-Dīn's father, Afzal al-Dīn b. Abī Ḥāmid, beyond the fact that he seems to have been in contact with Faḏl Allāh Astarābādī (d. ca. 796/1394), founder of the Ḥurūfiyya.¹⁵ Hurufi sources record that both Afzal al-Dīn and his son Ṣadr al-Dīn sought out Faḏl Allāh during his residence in Isfahan to have their dreams interpreted.¹⁶ (Needless to say, this contact does not imply Hurufi inclinations on the part of the two Turkas; the hagiographical point is to underscore Faḏl Allāh's fame as a Sufi before his messianic transformation, such that respected scholars of the religious sciences sought his counsel.) Ṣā'in al-Dīn's elder brother Ṣadr al-Dīn was an eminent scholar in the fields of hadith, tafsir, jurisprudence and *uṣūl al-dīn*; Ṣā'in al-Dīn, who studied under him for the first 25 years of his life (along with Qāẓizāda Rūmī),¹⁷ states that his brother taught nothing beyond the outward

¹⁵ Eichner, "Afḏal al-Dīn Turka," *El*³, on the basis of Ritter, "Studien zur Geschichte der islamischen Frömmigkeit," and Quiring-Zoche, *Isfahan*, 222–24.

¹⁶ Faḏl Allāh arrived in Isfahan around 766/1365 and quickly gained fame as a dream interpreter. Naṣr Allāh Nāfajī's *Kh'ābnāma* relates that one Kh'āja Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka attended an afternoon majlis of Faḏl Allāh's and there presented a dream to the latter. In this dream he saw the Prophet sitting, and went up to kiss his hand; he then noticed that he had inadvertently left some saliva on the back of his hand and felt ashamed at committing such an impropriety. Faḏl Allāh interpreted this to mean that Ṣadr al-Dīn was planning to write a book harmonizing religion and philosophy, but that he should abandon this plan so as not to risk shame before the Prophet. Later the same day, Kh'āja Afzal al-Dīn Turka (described as pious, learned, reclusive, wise and *mu'allah/muwallah*, and a member of Ṣadr al-Dīn's house) joined the majlis and related a dream in which God appeared to him and said that He would build him a dome, swearing, "If I cannot finish it you need no longer pray to Me." Faḏl Allāh interpreted this second dream to mean that Afzal al-Dīn had recently wanted to ask him for a cap (*kulāh*) made by Faḏl Allāh himself, but could not bring himself to do so. Thereupon Afzal al-Dīn confessed that this was the case, and Faḏl Allāh gave him the cap in question (Vatican MS Persian 17 ff. 32a–33a, quoted in Ritter, "Die Anfänge der Ḥurūfisekte," 15, and Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 168; cf. the more detailed account in the *Kh'ābnāma* of Kh'āja Sayyid Ishāq, Millet MS Ali Emiri Farsça 1042 f. 23a; and see Bashir, *Fazlallah Astarabadi*, 15–18, which mentions the first episode in a description of Faḏl Allāh's early career as a dream interpreter—my thanks to Professor Bashir for graciously providing me with copies of the relevant MS pages). The irony of Faḏl Allāh's interpretation of Ṣadr al-Dīn's dream, given the important mystico-philosophical syntheses achieved by both Ṣadr al-Dīn Abū Ḥāmid Turka and his grandson Ṣā'in al-Dīn, as well as the encompassing lettrist project of the latter, will become evident in the course of this study. On Faḏl Allāh's later career as messianic founder of the Ḥurūfiyya see §4.3.3 below.

¹⁷ Qāẓizāda Rūmī (d. 835/1432), noted astronomer and mathematician and the second director of Ulugh Beg's observatory at Samarkand, was also among Ṣadr al-Dīn's students (Eichner, "Afḏal al-Dīn Turka," *El*³; Ragep, "Qāḏī-zāda Rūmī," *El*²).

meaning of the Shari'a, deeming it too dangerous to delve into esoteric matters in public.¹⁸

Although Şā'in al-Dīn states that he had 10 children,¹⁹ including three sons and seven daughters,²⁰ we have only the names of his sons Jamāl al-Dīn Muḥammad, for whom he wrote his manual of logic, *K. al-Manāḥij*,²¹ and Najīb al-Dīn Ḥabīb Allāh, who appears to have written a brief lettrist treatise entitled *Qavā'id-i Jafr-i Jāmi'*.²² Nothing further is known about Najīb al-Dīn, but Jamāl al-Dīn may have been a key player in the Timurid-Turkmen power struggle in Fars in the later 9th/15th century:

In 872/1467-68, when the Qara Qoyunlu Jahānshāh (d. 872/1467) was defeated and killed by Uzun Ḥasan Aq Qoyunlu, [Jamāl al-Dīn] was among the pro-Turkmen notables of Iṣfahān. According to the *Kitāb-i Diyārbakriyya*, while Timurid Sulṭān-Abū Sa'īd b. Sulṭān-Muḥammad b. Mīrānshāh (d. 873/1469) and the Qara Qoyunlu Abū al-Qāsim b. Jahānshāh (d. 872/1467) were competing over Iṣfahān, Jamāl al-Dīn Turka took the pro-Timurid Khvāja Jalāl al-Islām Şā'idī hostage. Perhaps he was not that successful in his task, for Jalāl al-Islām Şā'idī was able to leave the town in order to meet with the envoy of Abū Sa'īd. After Abū al-Qāsim was killed by his brother Ḥasan-'Alī b. Jahānshāh (d. 873/1469), Jamāl al-Dīn Turka supported his rule. We hear no more about him in the contemporary chronicles; nor have we any information about his writings.²³

In addition, the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* preserves two letters from Jamāl al-Dīn Muḥammad to officials in Isfahan that suggest that he had some difficulty in completing his education in Fars

¹⁸ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I," 170.

¹⁹ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 206.

²⁰ See §2.1.3.1, no. 7.

²¹ See Quiring-Zoche, *Isfahan*, 224-25; Rāzī, *Haft Iqlīm*, 2/360; Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 169-70.

²² See MS Bodleian 1298/48 ff. 284a-85b (Sachau and Ethé, *Catalogue*, 1/col. 804); the Dānishgāh microfilm 1142/48 (Dānishpazhūh, *Mikrūfīlīm-hā*, 1/569) is presumably of the same MS. The *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* preserves a business letter from Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī to Afzal al-Dīn Muḥammad Turka, Şā'in al-Dīn's nephew, in which the former reports that Najīb al-Dīn Ḥabīb Allāh had left for Herat after a dispute with his brother over money matters; Sharaf al-Dīn thereupon intervened to resolve the dispute, lodging Ḥabīb Allāh at his own house and reallocating the money in question (see §2.1.3.1, no. 7). Şādiq Kitābdār gives a very brief biography of one Khvāja Ḥabīb Allāh Turka (*Majma' al-Khavāṣṣ*, 44-45), but it is not clear if this is the same individual; see Āzar, *Ātashkada*, 3/939; and Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 169.

²³ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 170.

due to the press of obligations in Herat.²⁴

Ṣadr al-Dīn's son (and Ṣā'in al-Dīn's nephew) Afzal al-Dīn Abū l-Faṭḥ Muḥammad is primarily known for his Persian translation of and commentary on Shahrastānī's (d. 548/1153) *K. al-Milal wa-l-Niḥal*, entitled *Tanqīḥ al-Adilla wa-l-'Ilal* and dedicated to Shāhrukh; most notably, he appends to Shahrastānī's text refutations of the arguments of the unbelievers as reported by the latter.²⁵ In his introduction Afzal al-Dīn seems to allude to the tribulations experienced by his uncle Ṣā'in al-Dīn as a result of his views.²⁶ He also wrote a Persian commentary on the *Burda* of al-Būṣīrī (d. 694/1295), though this achieved far less currency than Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's commentary on the same qasida.²⁷ Afzal al-Dīn was to have his own share of difficulties with the Timurid state, moreover: he was implicated in Sulṭān-Muḥammad's failed rebellion of 850/1446 and summarily executed by Shāhrukh.²⁸

Ḥabīb Allāh Turka, possibly the great-great-grandson of Ṣā'in al-Dīn, was a poet and chief qadi in Isfahan, and died while still young.²⁹ His son Afzal al-Dīn (d. 991/1583) traveled widely

²⁴ The first is addressed to Amīr Muḥammad Shāh, the governor (*dārūgha*, *ḥākīm*) of Isfahan (see §2.1.3.1, no. 3). In this letter Jamāl al-Dīn notes that he was sent from Herat to Shiraz to pursue his education there, and expresses his fear that were he to return to Herat he would never again have the opportunity to complete his studies because of his connections and duties in the capital. Jamāl al-Dīn sent a second letter on the same theme to the bureaucrat Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad Ṭāhir (§2.1.3.1, no. 4). See Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 170-71.

²⁵ See Quiring-Zoche, *Isfahan*, 224; Zarrinkoob, "Afzal al-Dīn Turka," *El*². Afzal al-Dīn completed his translation-commentary on 13 Rajab 843/20 December 1439.

²⁶ See *Tanqīḥ al-Adilla*, 35; Quiring-Zoche, "Afzal-al-Dīn Torka," *Elr*; Eichner, "Afzal al-Dīn Turka," *El*³.

²⁷ See e.g. MS Mar'ashī 3466 (172 ff.), an undated copy by Sulaymān b. Mubārak b. Ibrāhīm Tafrīshī (Ḥā'irī, *Fihrist*, 9/266). Sections of this work are transcribed in Mudarris Ṭabāṭabā'ī, "Āshnā'ī bā Asarī az Khwāja Afzal al-Dīn Muḥammad Turka-yi Isfahānī," 528-29.

²⁸ Dawlatshāh, *Tazkirat al-Shu'arā*, 606; Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 168. Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī was also among the group of notables and officials implicated in this rebellion, but was saved through the mediation of Mīrzā 'Abd al-Laṭīf b. Ulugh Beg. Sharaf al-Dīn was clearly close to Afzal al-Dīn as the nephew of his late mentor Ṣā'in al-Dīn; the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* contains a business letter to Afzal al-Dīn on the collection of taxes (see §2.1.3.1, no. 7).

²⁹ See Quiring-Zoche, *Isfahan*, 225-27; *SND*, xl. Āqā Buzurg mentions the existence of a collection of his poetry, *Dīvān-i Ḥabīb-i Isfahānī* (*al-Dharī'a*, 9.1/230, no. 1395).

in pursuit of learning in philosophy and the religious sciences; after completing his education he was appointed *qāẓī-yi ‘askar* under Shāh Ṭahmāsp I (r. 930-83/1524-76).³⁰ Upon the shah’s death he returned to Isfahan in the office of qadī, but came into conflict with the local Turkmen powers and relinquished his position. Afzal al-Dīn then decamped to Mashhad, where he worked until his death as *mudarris* and inspector of endowments (*nāẓir-i sarkār*) at the shrine of Imam al-Riḍā.³¹ Afzal al-Dīn’s influence with Shāh Ismā‘īl II (r. 984-85/1576-77), known for his Sunnizing tendencies, may be seen in the former’s successful bid to have ‘Ā’isha exempted from the customary Safavid practice of *tabarrā’ī*, the execration of the first three caliphs and (normally) ‘Ā’isha.³² Among his students were Abū l-Qāsim b. Abī Ḥāmid b. Naṣr al-Bayān b. Nūr al-Bayān Anṣārī Kāzirūnī, author of the *Sullam al-Samāwāt*, a biographical dictionary of philosophers and poets;³³ Qāẓī Nūr al-Dīn Iṣfahānī; and ‘Allāmī Chalabī.³⁴ We know of four works by Afzal al-Dīn: 1) *al-Masā’il al-Khamsa*, on various issues in theology, logic, jurisprudence, etc., written while a student of al-Muqaddas al-Ardabīlī;³⁵ 2) *Unmūdhaj al-‘Ulūm* or *R. fī Ḥall Maṭālib ‘Awīṣa min Funūn Mutanawwi’a*, treating of seven problems from seven disciplines— theology, logic, philosophy, geometry, Arabic, jurisprudence and legal theory—, with a preface

³⁰ An office he apparently shared with one Sayyid ‘Alā’ al-Mulk Ḥusaynī Mar‘ashī (Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī’a*, 21/266, no. 4976).

³¹ Eichner, “Afzal al-Dīn Turka,” *EI3*; Quiring-Zoche, “Afzal-al-Dīn Torka,” *EIr*. Aloys Sprenger describes his career as follows (*Catalogue*, 27-28, no. 306): “Khwājah Afdhal aldyn Mohammad Turkah, the Qādhiy, a son of Habyb Allah Turkah, and a descendent of Khwājah Čāyin aldyn Turkah, who had been a great Čūfy under Shāhrokh and had written a commentary on the Fočūč and on a qāčydaḥ of Ibn Fāridh. Afdhal aldyn after having completed his studies at Ispahān repaired to the ‘irāq and Syria to perfect himself in the traditions and other sciences and then made the pilgrimage to Makkah. In 967 he returned home from his travels and went to Qazwyn to Shāh Ṭāhmāsb and eventually the high office of Court Qādhiy was conferred upon him; after some time however he was obliged to resign it. He was very learned, and pupils flocked to him from all parts of Persia.”

³² Quiring-Zoche, “Afzal-al-Dīn Torka,” *EIr*; Mazzaoui, “Religious Policy of Safavid Shah Isma‘il II,” 50; Bāymatuf, “Afzal al-Dīn Turka va Shāh Ismā‘īl-i Duvvum-i Ṣafavī.”

³³ Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī’a*, 12/221, no. 1460. This work contains a biography of Afzal al-Dīn.

³⁴ Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī’a*, 9.1/84, no. 501.

³⁵ Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī’a*, 20/346, no. 3334. It is here reported to form part of a collection in the possession of Shaykh Ṣāliḥ al-Jazā’irī; its incipit: *ammā ba’dā fathī l-kalāmi bi-ḥamdi l-maliki al-‘allāmi*.

mentioning the author's sojourn in India;³⁶ 3) *Burhān al-Tawhīd*, a very brief discussion of the concept of the Necessary Existent (*wājib al-wujūd*);³⁷ and 4) *R. fī l-Ma'qūlāt al-Thāniya*.³⁸ A collection of his poetry also exists.³⁹

Later members of the family also worked as poets and scholars for the Safavid government. After Mullā Muẓaffar, poet and *munshī* under Shāh 'Abbās II (r. 1052-77/1642-66) in Isfahan,⁴⁰ however, all mention of the Turka family appears to cease.⁴¹ Almost to a man, then, the Turkas of Isfahan were qadis, poets, philosophers and religious scholars, and often given to the esoteric sciences.

1.2: Biography and intellectual network

Temür's policy of sparing and collecting the eminent scholars and artists of the cities he conquered exempted the Turka family from the bloody aftermath of his taking of Isfahan in 789/1387. Şadr al-Dīn, his son Afzal al-Dīn and his teenaged brother Şā'in al-Dīn were sent to Temür's court at Samarkand, where Temür appointed Şadr al-Dīn qadi. This office was to pass down through the family, the heritability of such appointments being a common trend in Iran

³⁶ Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 2/404, no. 1621, this according to his biography in the *Takmilat al-Amal*; see e.g. MS Majlis 10005/8 ff. 69a-76b.

³⁷ See e.g. the copy in UCLA's Caro Minasian collection, box 5, *majmū'a* 30/3 pp. 145-48; this collection also contains several works by Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī on similar topics, e.g. *R. fī l-thbāt Wājib al-Wujūd*. Cf. Afzal al-Dīn's comments to the same effect in MS Majlis 9500 f. 41b, '*min mufādāt Kh'āja Afḍal Turka raḥīma-hu Llāh.*'

³⁸ Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 21/266, no. 4976.

³⁹ This is titled either *Dīvān-i Afzal-i Iṣfahānī* (Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 9.1/85, no. 499) or *Dīvān-i Afzal-i Turka* (Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 9.1/85, no. 501).

⁴⁰ Muẓaffar Turka is known, for example, to have praised in a poem the beauty of Ā'ina-khāna palace in Isfahan (Babaie, "Isfahan, x. Monuments (2): Palaces," *EIr*).

⁴¹ Intervening members of the family of whom little is known include Şā'in al-Dīn's sons Jamāl al-Dīn Muḥammad and Najīb al-Dīn Ḥabīb Allāh, Jalāl al-Dīn Muḥammad (scholar under Shāh 'Abbās I (r. 995-1038/1587-1629)), 'Ināyat, and Qāsim 'Alī. For more details on the Turka-yi Iṣfahānī line see *SND*, xxxvi-xxlv; Mūsavī-Bihbahānī and Zārī, "Turka-yi Iṣfahānī," *DJI*; Mawlavī, "Āl-i Turka," *DMBI*.

during the 8th/14th to 10th/16th centuries; thus the Turkas were to frequently serve as qadis under both the Timurids and Safavids.⁴² The same period saw a shift in the Turka family identity from Shafi'i under the Ilkhanids and Timurids to Shi'i under the Safavids, although given both the pervasive imamophilism of the 9th/15th century on the one hand and an established Shi'i-Shafi'i legal tradition on the other this shift was hardly a dramatic one.⁴³ In Samarkand Ṣā'in al-Dīn, as noted, continued his studies under the direction of his elder brother; his broad erudition in the religious sciences, and especially the Sunni schools of *fiqh*, dates from this period. In his late twenties and at the insistence of his brother, Ṣā'in al-Dīn embarked upon a 15-year period of travel in search of learning abroad, i.e., roughly between 795-810/1393-1408, the circumstances in Iran being too strait to properly carry on the family's legacy with respect to philosophy and mystical theory.⁴⁴

While Ṣā'in al-Dīn is reported to have spent time in his travels in Mecca and Baghdad,⁴⁵ it was his extended residence in Cairo that was to leave the deepest imprint on his thought. He there became the student of Sirāj al-Dīn al-Bulqīnī (d. 805/1403) in hadith, considered by some the *mujaddid* of the century,⁴⁶ who was sympathetic to Sufism.⁴⁷ Ṣā'in al-Dīn also implies that he

⁴² "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I," 170; Eichner, "Afḍal al-Dīn Turka," *EI*³.

⁴³ On the phenomenon of Shi'i-Sunnism or imamophilism see §1.4 below; on Shi'i-Shafi'ism see Stewart, *Islamic Legal Orthodoxy*; idem, "Ḥusayn b. 'Abd al-Ṣamad al-ʿĀmilī's Treatise for Sultan Suleiman and the Shīʿī Shāfiʿī Legal Tradition."

⁴⁴ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I," 170; "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 203.

⁴⁵ Ṣā'in al-Dīn mentions in several places his having spent time in Mecca, e.g. "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 203; the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* also preserves a letter from Ṣā'in al-Dīn to Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī stating the author's plans to depart Isfahan for the Hijaz and inviting Sharaf al-Dīn to accompany him (see §2.1.3.1.1, no. 1). The early 11th/17th century account of Ṣā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn's sojourn in Baghdad in search of a Sufi master to disciple themselves to (Abū l-Qāṣīm Anṣārī Kāzirūnī, *Sullam al-Samāwāt*; see Mufīd Mustawfī, *Jāmiʿ-i Mufīdī*, 3/302) should, of course, be taken with several grains of salt; but it will be noted that Kāzirūnī's source was likely Afḍal al-Dīn b. Ḥabīb Allāh Turka (d. 991/1583), his teacher.

⁴⁶ Gibb, "al-Bulqīnī," *EI*².

⁴⁷ Without being wholly a partisan, however; when certain verses of Ibn al-Fāriḍ's *Tā'iyya* were presented to him, he declared them beyond the pale of belief (*SND*, lii). For the controversy surrounding the *Tā'iyya* in Egypt, see Homerin, *From Arab Poet to Muslim Saint*, 55-75.

was a regular participant in scholarly majlises at the Mamluk court—in his second apology, for instance, he relates an episode in which Sultan Barqūq (r. 784-801/1382-99) pressed him for his opinion of another scholar⁴⁸—, suggesting that he was broadly acquainted with the Cairene intellectual elite of the period.⁴⁹ Ṣāʿin al-Dīn’s use of new hybrid genres cultivated in the contemporary Mamluk literary scene, particularly the anthology-as-commentary genre as exemplified by his *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*, also reflects his embrace of Cairene high culture of the turn of the 9th/15th century.⁵⁰

More importantly, however, in Cairo Ṣāʿin al-Dīn was to meet and apprentice himself to Sayyid Kamāl al-Dīn Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī Afṭasī Ḥusaynī (d. 799/1397), the famed Kurdish occultist and rumored mahdi—by far the most momentous event in Ṣāʿin al-Dīn’s intellectual life. A physician by trade, Sayyid Ḥusayn was resident alchemist and wonderworker at Sultan Barqūq’s court.⁵¹ Ṣāʿin al-Dīn’s period of discipleship under Akhlāṭī transformed him from a competent scholar of the religious sciences to an ambitious universalist thinker and thoroughgoing occult philosopher. As will become clear in the course of this study, the type of occultist, millenarian universalism promulgated by Sayyid Ḥusayn is defined by its pointed transcendence of epistemological—and confessional—boundaries.⁵² (The Mamluk historian Ibn Ḥajar al-ʿAsqalānī (d. 852/1449) relates, for instance, that upon Akhlāṭī’s death his house was found to contain “a golden cup, flagons of wine, clothes of priests, a copy of the Bible, books on

⁴⁸ “Nafṣat al-Maṣdūr II,” 211-12. The scholar in question was Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad al-Jazarī (d. 833/1429), originally of Damascus, whose enmity towards Ṣāʿin al-Dīn was later to cause the latter much grief; see §1.3 below.

⁴⁹ His residence in Cairo would have overlapped e.g. that of Ibn Khaldūn, who died there in 808/1406.

⁵⁰ See §E.2 below.

⁵¹ He was known in particular for his mastery of *jafr*, *raml*, *hurūf* and *taksīr*, all techniques of applied letterism (SND, li). A deluxe copy of Gāzurgāhī’s *Majālis al-ʿUshshāq*, MS BL Or. 11837, produced in Shiraz in ca. 1560, includes a painting of Sayyid Ḥusayn receiving gifts from Sultan Barqūq (f. 117); a detail from this painting is reproduced at the beginning of the present study.

⁵² Cf. the equally millenarian efforts of Sayyid Muḥammad Nūrbakhsh and Faṣl Allāh Astarābādī to establish a new, post-confessional, pan-Islamic dispensation; see e.g. §4.3.3. below.

philosophy (*al-ḥikma*), astrology (*al-nujūm*), geomancy, and a chest full of precious stones.”⁵³ Akhlāṭī’s refusal to attend Friday prayers, moreover, laid him open to charges of Shi‘ism.⁵⁴ Such was Sayyid Ḥusayn’s mark on the younger man that Ṣā’in al-Dīn invariably presents himself in his lettrist writings as but the systematizer of Akhlāṭī’s teachings; as a result, the later lettrist tradition in Iran remembers Ṣā’in al-Dīn as simply Akhlāṭī’s greatest disciple.⁵⁵ That Ṣā’in al-Dīn never refers to Sayyid Ḥusayn in his writings by name but only as ‘our Sayyid’ (*sayyid-i mā*),⁵⁶ ‘the Sayyidic Presence’ (*ḥaẓrat-i sayyidī, al-ḥaḍra al-sayyidiyya*)⁵⁷ or ‘the sublime Sayyidic Threshold’ (*al-sudda al-saniyya al-sayyidiyya*)⁵⁸ may be taken as an index of his unparalleled regard for his teacher.⁵⁹

Nor was Ṣā’in al-Dīn the only scholar to be so transformed through contact with Akhlāṭī. The infamous Shaykh Bedreddīn Simāwī (d. btw. 819-23/1416-20), before meeting Sayyid Ḥusayn, was a judge and prominent intellectual with a predilection for mystical theory—one whose scholarly and social profile, in fact, precisely matched that of Ibn Turka; subsequent to his discipleship under Akhlāṭī, however, he became the messianic leader of a mystic-millenarian rebellion that rattled the Ottoman state in 819/1416. This rebellion and its instigator, thoroughly described in contemporary Ottoman sources, have attracted

⁵³ *Inbā’ al-Ghumr bi-Abnā’ al-‘Umr*, 3/336-38; trans. in Binbaş, “Sharaf al-Dīn,” 140.

⁵⁴ Ibn Ḥajar, *Inbā’ al-Ghumr*, 3/336-37. On the necessarily ambiguous and imamophilic nature of occultist thought from the 7th/13th century onwards see §1.4 below.

⁵⁵ See e.g. ‘Alī Ṣafī Kāshifī, *Ḥirz al-Amān*, section 1.1.5, summarized in §4.4.4 below; and Ḥājjī Khalīfa, *Kashf al-Zunūn*, 2/1263.

⁵⁶ “R. Shaqq-i Qamar,” 116.

⁵⁷ R. Ḥurūf, MS Majlis 10196 f. 156b; R. *Arba’īniyya*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 120b.

⁵⁸ K. *al-Mafāḥiṣ*, preface, MS Majlis 10196 f. 52b.

⁵⁹ Cf. Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s reference in his *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* I to Khwāja Muḥammad Pārsā simply as ‘*khwāja-yi mā*’ (193).

considerable scholarly interest.⁶⁰ Ṣā'in al-Dīn's fate was less spectacular, hence the paucity of scholarly interest in our thinker to date. Yet Ṣā'in al-Dīn, as Akhlāṭī's chief disciple in the east,⁶¹ was animated by precisely the same millenarian ethos, though he expressed it in universalist and intellectual, rather than messianic and sociopolitical, terms. In this sense, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's writings therefore represent the most convenient point of access to an understanding of the doctrines and motives of both Akhlāṭī and Bedreddīn. Ṣā'in al-Dīn was responsible for synthesizing the abstruse and scattered strands of his master's teachings, which are otherwise preserved in a highly piecemeal fashion,⁶² into a coherent system; that is to say, Sayyid Ḥusayn was more prophetic hero, a doer, and Ṣā'in al-Dīn, his apostle, a thinker. The present study, then, although focused more or less exclusively on Ṣā'in al-Dīn's letterist writings, represents an attempt to gain further purchase on the doctrines and intellectual ambience of this network as a whole, propagating from Cairo to western Iran (and from thence to Central Asia and India) on the one hand and Anatolia on the other. Needless to say, a detailed study of Akhlāṭī and his writings remains a major desideratum.⁶³

Ṣā'in al-Dīn's closeness to Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī (d. 858/1454), the famed litterateur, historian and mathematician, dates from at least this period; later Timurid sources report that Ṣā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn lived and performed spiritual exercises together in rooms under

⁶⁰ See e.g. Balivet, *Islam mystique et révolution armée dans les Balkans Ottomans*.

⁶¹ This is implied, for example, in a letter Akhlāṭī sent to Ṣā'in al-Dīn wherein he addresses the latter as *khalīlī* ('my bosom companion') and describes him as *al-amīr al-khaṭīr wa-l-badr al-munīr wa-l-baḥr al-ghazīr*, the leading luminary among his circle of brethren (*wāsiṭat 'aqd ikhwāni-hi*) (see §2.1.3.1.2, no. 1; the letter is transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.2 below). Cf. the 9th/15th century *manāqib* work on Shaykh Bedreddīn by Ḥāfiẓ Ḥalīl, *Simavna Kadısıoğlu Şeyh Bedreddin Manākıbı*, which portrays Akhlāṭī as designating Bedreddīn as his successor in Cairo (69-70; see also Kissling, "Das Manākıbnāme Scheich Bedr ed-dīns," 156-57). For a discussion of the relationship between Akhlāṭī and Bedreddīn see Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 139-49.

⁶² Akhlāṭī's known works include *R. Jafr-i Jāmi'a*, *R. Jāmi'iyya* and *R. Ḥuṣūl al-Maqāsid* (Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 152-55). Two of his works (or rather two collections of amalgamated sections, *fuṣūl*) on various topics in applied letterism have been printed to date: *Sifr-i Jafr* (Tehran, 1386 Sh./2007) and *R. fī Qawā'id al-Jafr wa-'Ilm al-Falak wa-Zayārij wa-'Ilm al-Ḥurūf* (Beirut, 2002).

⁶³ The best discussion of Akhlāṭī to date is found in Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 139-62.

Sayyid Ḥusayn's apartment on the banks of the Nile.⁶⁴ Not surprisingly, the lettrist theory and millenarian universalism espoused by Ṣā'in al-Dīn likewise permeates Sharaf al-Dīn's oeuvre. (Evrin Binbaş's recent study of Sharaf al-Dīn is here my point of departure.) It must be emphasized that what has long been supposed to be an unaccountable—and therefore irrelevant—occultist tinge to many of Sharaf al-Dīn's works was considered by the author himself to be central to his larger intellectual project; he moreover identifies Ṣā'in al-Dīn as his teacher in this regard.⁶⁵ It further bears emphasizing that Ṣā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn were considered by the late Timurid period to have been the two most prominent intellectuals of Shahrukhid Iran, suggesting that their profoundly occultist project had a far wider currency than has heretofore been supposed.⁶⁶ As I proposed in the Introduction (§1.3), the two men and their circle in western Iran constitute the eastern arm of the Neo-Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' extra-establishment intellectual network, currently being studied by Cornell Fleischer and İhsan Fazlıoğlu and their students, which appears to have been centered in Cairo in the person of Akhlāṭī and extended into Ottoman lands with such figures as Shaykh Bedreddīn, 'Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī and Mullā Fanārī. Qāzīzāda Rūmī, the eminent astronomer, must also be accounted a member of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's circle in Iran; he studied the exoteric sciences with Ṣā'in

⁶⁴ See Gāzurgāhī, *Majālis al-'Ushshāq*, majlis 34, 189; and §4.3.3.2 below. Both the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* and the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* testify to the closeness of their relationship: the first collection includes a letter from Ṣā'in al-Dīn to Sharaf al-Dīn stating the author's plans to depart Isfahan for the Hijaz and inviting Sharaf al-Dīn to accompany him, and if this is not possible, to at least keep in touch through correspondence (see §2.1.3.1.1, no. 1, transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.1 below); and the second collection comprises two letters from Sharaf al-Dīn to Ṣā'in al-Dīn, a transcription of a few admonitory lines addressed by Ṣā'in al-Dīn to a majlis, and several items relating to Ṣā'in al-Dīn's children (see §2.1.3.2). In addition, part of the theoretical introduction to Sharaf al-Dīn's *Ḥulal-i Muṭarraz* is interjected into Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *R. Tuḥfa-y 'Alā'ī* in the earliest collection of the latter's works, MS Majlis 10196 ff. 374b-75b. Further manuscript evidence likewise suggests that Sharaf al-Dīn was intimately involved in promoting Ṣā'in al-Dīn's works; the two earliest manuscript copies of the latter's *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, for example, contain a colophon stating that Sharaf al-Dīn checked the copy and was present in teaching sessions on the work (cf. MS Majlis 10196 f. 119a; Beinecke MS Landberg 146 f. 179b).

⁶⁵ See e.g. Bākharzī, *Maqāmāt-i Jāmī*, 106-7, trans. in §8.2.2 below.

⁶⁶ Dawlatshāh, *Tazkirat al-Shu'arā*, 340, trans. in §4.4.3.1 below.

al-Dīn in Samarkand under the tutelage of the latter's elder brother Ṣadr al-Dīn,⁶⁷ and is similarly reported to have been disciple to Akhlāṭī in Cairo.⁶⁸ His continuing occultist sympathies may be seen in his letter to Ṣā'in al-Dīn of ca. 829/1426 thanking him for sending a copy of his lettrist *Sharḥ al-Basmala*.⁶⁹

Other members of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's larger intellectual network in Iran are also reported as having made a point of visiting Akhlāṭī in Cairo. Ni'matullāhi hagiographical sources record that Shāh Ni'mat Allāh Valī (d. 834/1431) and Shaykh Qāsim-i Anvār (d. 837/1433) accompanied Ṣā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn on a visit to their master.⁷⁰ The same sources further portray Ni'mat Allāh with having instructed Ṣā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn to seek out Akhlāṭī in the first place, thereby awarding Ni'mat Allāh credit in some measure for their brilliant careers.⁷¹ That there indeed existed warm relations between Ṣā'in al-Dīn on the one hand and Ni'mat Allāh and Qāsim-i Anvār on the other is confirmed in the *Munsha'āt-i Turka*.⁷² Nor is this surprising, given both Sayyid Ḥusayn's and Ṣā'in al-Dīn's consistent lionization of Ibn 'Arabian thought: Ni'mat Allāh, while purely a popularizer of Akbarian mystical theory rather than a thinker in his own right, was one of the most prominent Sufi lettrists of his day, and Qāsim-i Anvār was similarly a great promoter of Ibn 'Arabī in his poetry and his preaching. While not a professional Sufi himself, then, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's intellectual program gave him common cause with

⁶⁷ Eichner, "Afḍal al-Dīn Turka," *El*³; Ragep, "Ḳāḍī-zāda Rūmī," *El*².

⁶⁸ See Gāzurgāhī, *Majālis al-'Ushshāq*, 189; he is here called Ibn al-Qāzī Rūmī. Kh'āndamīr calls him Mawlānā Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn Mūsā (*Habibu's-siyar*, Tome 3, Pt. 3, 369).

⁶⁹ See §2.1.3.1.2, no. 2, transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.2, no. 2.

⁷⁰ See §4.3.2 below.

⁷¹ See §4.3.2 below.

⁷² The collection preserves a letter from Ṣā'in al-Dīn to Shāhrukh in response to the latter's summons to attend his court, to be communicated to the newly-ascendant ruler by Ni'mat Allāh (see §2.1.3.1.1, no. 16). The relation between Ni'mat Allāh and the younger Ṣā'in al-Dīn is discussed in §4.3.2 below.

these influential Sufi masters.⁷³

Şā'in al-Dīn learned of Temür's death (807/1405) while still abroad and returned to Isfahan perhaps two or three years later. There he took up teaching and and purposed to lead a quiet life of contemplation (*gūsha-nishīnī*). However, he soon attracted the attention of Pīr-Muḥammad b. 'Umar-Shaykh, Temür's grandson, who had inherited the governorship of Fars; he was accordingly summoned to Shiraz and made a member of his court. After Pīr-Muḥammad's murder in 812/1409, his brother Iskandar Mīrzā took his place in Shiraz, soon afterward establishing a brilliant court in Isfahan;⁷⁴ he too made Şā'in al-Dīn a member of his court and bestowed similar honors on him, these presumably including a teaching post and judgeship.⁷⁵ At Iskandar's court Şā'in al-Dīn would have come into contact with luminaries in various fields, including the astronomers Giyās al-Dīn Kāshī and Maḥmūd Kāshī, the poets Bushāq Aṭ'ima and Mīr Ḥaydar, and the historian Mu'īn al-Dīn Naṭanzī.⁷⁶ It is not unlikely that this association contributed to Şā'in al-Dīn's later problems in the region. Iskandar rebelled against Shāhrukh in 817/1414 and was violently quashed, and Fars and Arab Iraq added to Shāhrukh's domains; any previous attachment to Iskandar's court may have been seen as a liability. Indeed, that Şā'in al-Dīn's enemies were later able to plague him so successfully had little to do with demonstrable doctrinal irregularities on his part, but rather the political instability and factiousness of western Iran on the one hand and Shāhrukh's distrust of ambitious, independent-minded intellectuals, especially those with mystical and millenarian inclinations, on the other.⁷⁷ At this juncture Şā'in al-Dīn again attempted to retire from public

⁷³ See §8.2 below for more on Şā'in al-Dīn's view of Sufism and relations with contemporary Sufi masters.

⁷⁴ It should be noted that Iskandar appears to have been an overt Shī'i, or in any event a devoted imamophile, with a pronounced interest in lettrism (Aubin, "Le mécénat timouride à Chiraz," 82, 85-86).

⁷⁵ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 212.

⁷⁶ Soucek, "Eskandar Solṭān," *EIr*.

⁷⁷ See Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 9, 114-17.

life, but certain individuals in Isfahan, connivers jealous of his growing fame, went to Shāhrukh's court in Herat and accused him of deviation from the Sunna through a bias toward Sufism (*ṣūfīgarī*). Šā'in al-Dīn, despite advanced age and frail health, was forced to travel to Herat in an attempt to clear his name. He gained Shāhrukh's favor and temporarily silenced his enemies; Shāhrukh offered to restore him as qadi in Isfahan, but Šā'in al-Dīn opted for Yazd instead in an effort to escape those who would intrigue against him.⁷⁸

Šā'in al-Dīn's period of residence in Yazd, from ca. 825-29/1422-26, spanned relatively uneventful and hence productive years. Most notably, it was during this period that he produced many of his lettrist works, including *R. Anjām*, *R. Su'l al-Mulūk*, *R. Shaqq-i Qamar u Bayān-i Sā'at*, *R. Nuqṭa*, *R. al-Inzāliyya*, *R. Muḥammadiyya* and *Sharḥ al-Basmala*, as well as the revision and expansion of his lettrist *summa*, the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, in the company of Sharaf al-Dīn and other associates.⁷⁹ It was also during this period that he acquired a number of students, who, he states, flocked to him from Shiraz, Samarkand, Anatolia and India.⁸⁰ Among them was Kātibī Turshīzī (d. 839/1436), accounted in the later Timurid and early Safavid periods the leading poet of Shahrukhid Iran; he is said to have been converted to the Sufi path at Šā'in al-Dīn's hand.⁸¹ The beginning of Kātibī's *divan* accordingly includes four poems in eulogy of his

⁷⁸ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I," 171-72. Of the three main cities of Fars, Isfahan, Shiraz and Yazd, the last was known to be the most stable and politically quiescent—hence Šā'in al-Dīn's choice. Beatrice Manz characterizes the respective political character of these three cities as follows (*Power, Politics and Religion*, 164-65): "Among the cities we can also see consistent differences; the notables of Yazd avoided trouble wherever possible, while the Isfahanis repeatedly initiated action, not waiting for the princes to propose it. They seem to have gone out to choose their ruler from among those available and remained loyal for as long as they found it feasible. Shiraz pursued a middle course; sometimes acting on its own when the outcome of the power struggle seemed predictable. There may well have been disagreements within the city about how bold or conservative a course to take, and the Shirazi ward headmen seem to have been the most aggressive, following an established tradition of political activism."

⁷⁹ This fact is noted in audition certificates at the end of the two earliest copies of the work, MS Majlis 10196 f. 119a and Beinecke MS Landberg 146 f. 179b.

⁸⁰ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 209-10.

⁸¹ Dawlatshāh, *Tazkirat al-Shu'arā*, 384; see also Browne, *A Literary History of Persia*, 3/489 (Browne here renders Šā'in al-Dīn's name "Šā'īnu'd-Dīn Tarika"). As Khwāndamīr describes him in his *Ḥabīb al-Siyar* (wr. 921-35/1515-29) (trans. Thackston, 360-61): "Mawlana Katibi Nishapuri's name was Muhammad ibn

teacher, referring primarily to Ṣā'in al-Dīn's unparalleled learning and his scrupulous application of the law as qadi.⁸² Most significantly, however, Kātibī thrice pointedly associates Ṣā'in al-Dīn with the term *ṣafā*—almost certainly a reference to the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' network discussed above. These instances may therefore be seen as adding to the evidence cited by Binbaṣ as to the probability that this network, heretofore studied primarily in its Ottoman context, also extended to western Iran in the persons of Ṣā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn and their Isfahan Circle.⁸³ In the first ghazal, Ṣā'in al-Dīn is addressed as simply 'Kh^wāja 'Alī' and identified with *ṣafā* in the poem's *maṭla'*.⁸⁴ The relevant line in the second ghazal is as follows:

That shoot of purity (*nihāl-i ṣafā*), Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī—he from whose
fragrance the blossom itself is perfumed⁸⁵

Finally, in a third ghazal Kātibī explicitly refers to Ṣā'in al-Dīn as leader of a group he calls the *ahl-i ṣafā*; the poem in full:

When dawn scatters forth daisies upon the beflowered mead
and the fields of wheat lie dappled,
The forces of the east shake their bonds and the king of western gloom
retreats with unheard-of haste;
When the raven of the west falls pheasantlike prey to the falcon of dawn,

Abdullah. For subtle poetic nature and sharpness of intellect he was the most outstanding of all the poets of Shahrukh's time. He composed rare gems in all styles of poetry, especially in qasida. His divan of ghazals is well known. In most of his qasidas he praised and eulogized Mirza Baysunghur. Among this poet's masnavis are essays on puns and poems containing dual meter and rhyme, *Husn u Ishq* (*Beauty and Love*), *Nazir u Manzur* (*Beholder and Beheld*), *Bahram and Gul-andam*, and *Muhibb u Mahbub* (*Lover and Beloved*). The verses and stories of these are extremely subtle and well arranged. Mawlana Katibi was afflicted by an epidemic in Astarabad in 839 [1435-36] and took to his sick bed. During delirium he composed this line: *By the wrathful fire of the plague was stricken Astarabad, whose dust was more fragrant than musk. No one, young or old, remained, for when when fire strikes a forest nothing at all remains.*"

⁸² A line on this last theme: 'So lauded is the judgment of Ṣā'in al-Dunyā wa-l-Dīn 'Alī/ that even the judge of the heavens (*qāzī-yi falak*) adheres to his rulings' (Ankara MS Milli A.6869/3 ff. 195b-96a, Ankara MS Milli A.1899 ff. 23b-24a).

⁸³ Binbaṣ, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 99-106.

⁸⁴ *Chūn bayraq-i barrāq-i ṣafā gasht ṣaf-ārā* (Ankara MS Milli A.6869/3 ff. 200b-201a).

⁸⁵ Ankara MS Milli A.6869/3 f. 184a-b, Ankara MS Milli A.1899 f. 19a-b.

transfixing the garden of morn, and the cock turns nightingale,
The king of the west, having held dread sway for a time, is castrated at the hand
of his enemy the monarch of morning, his line extinguished;
When the seed of the night is sown in the field of the west
the east pours torrential showers on those broad expanses:
Wonder not that the sun's tears should flow, for its eye
is ringed about with kohl—and the kohl of darkness refreshes.
Fresh from its own subjugation, the sun casts the world
and its azure, musky-locked firmament into the fire ...
The world exchanges the dark of night for the light of morning
like ignorance is transformed to knowledge at the breath of my lord (*kh^wāja*),
Kh^wāja Ṣā'in al-Duwal wa-l-Dīn, succorer of the Folk of Sincerity (*mu'īn-i ahl-i ṣafā*),
the point of whose pen is the pivot on which the cosmos turns.⁸⁶

Other members of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's network during the Yazd phase of his career include Qivām al-Dīn Muḥammad (d. 830/1427), Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's brother, who appears to have adopted the *takhalluṣ* 'Ṣā'inī' out of veneration for his teacher.⁸⁷

Ṣā'in al-Dīn's unswerving and impartial application of the Shari'a in Yazd, however, earned him enemies among the entrenched elite (*mutaḡhallibān*) of that city,⁸⁸ who sent a delegation to Shāhrukh seeking his dismissal. When this failed, they compiled a case against him on the basis of certain statements in works written in his youth, claiming to have found, for example, a verse praising 'Alī and condemning 'Umar and 'Uthmān:⁸⁹

The closed eyes of those two are a byword for blindness
but your eye, O 'Alī, is alive with insight!

⁸⁶ Ankara MS Milli A.6869/3 f. 223b, Ankara MS Milli A.1899 ff. 24b-25a, MS Majlis 7776 f. 10b.

⁸⁷ See §2.1.3.2 below; and Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 13, 25-28. Qivām al-Dīn described Ṣā'in al-Dīn as being among the leading 'ulamā', *muḥaddisān* and *fuqahā'* of the age (Richard, "Un témoignage inexploité," 56, 68). In addition, a note on MS Majlis 10196 f. 122a indicates that Ṣā'in al-Dīn wrote a brief commentary, *R. dar Ḥadīṣ-i Nabavī*, for a *majmū'a* of Mawlānā Rukn al-Dīn Ṣā'id Kirmānī, suggesting this individual as another member of his circle.

⁸⁸ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I," 172.

⁸⁹ *SND*, liv; the verse is given in Ma'sūm 'Alī Shāh, *Tarā'iq al-Ḥaqā'iq*, 3/30. This pretext is not explicitly mentioned in the first apology, which is primarily concerned to answer the charge of *sūfiqarī*; secondarily, however, its sweeping dismissal of all but the Sunni confessional position and heavy emphasis on Sufism as a purely Sunni phenomenon clearly imply that Ṣā'in al-Dīn's Sunni credentials had also been brought into question.

In so doing, they succeeded in stirring up the opinion of the scholars of Herat against him, such that Shāhrukh summoned him to the imperial capital to be tried again. On this second trip he wrote the first of his remarkable apologies, the *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* I, together with a creedal tract, *R. I'tiqādāt*, both dated 829/1426 and addressed to Shāhrukh. With these masterly defenses he again earned Shāhrukh's favor and returned to Fars. However, in 830/1427 the Hurufi Aḥmad-i Lur made an attempt on Shāhrukh's life as he was exiting the congregational mosque in Herat; Aḥmad was killed on the spot, and Shāhrukh proceeded to arrest prominent figures with suspected ties to the Ḥurūfiyya—Qāsim-i Anvār,⁹⁰ Ma'rūf-i Khaṭṭāt, Ṣā'in al-Dīn and others. Ṣā'in al-Dīn, having just left Herat, was summoned back and imprisoned, stripped of his position and property, tortured, then exiled.

For much of the next five years, up until his death in Herat in 835/1432, he wandered from place to place in northern and northwestern Iran in search of livelihood, teaching hadith and tafsir at local mosques and writing treatises for various governors and amirs;⁹¹ his surviving letters from this period are largely either pleas to these same individuals to grant clemency and allow him to support his wives and children against hunger and frost, or letters to various Sufi shaykhs and bureaucrats requesting their material or tactical assistance.⁹² He appears to have spent some time in Hamadan and Tabriz, and sought patronage at the Mar'ashi court in Mazandaran and the Karkiya court in Gilan in particular.⁹³

In 833/1430 Ṣā'in al-Dīn made an unsuccessful bid to obtain a hearing at Shāhrukh's camp

⁹⁰ It should be noted that Qāsim-i Anvār, before becoming Shāh Ni'mat Allāh Valī's *khalīfa*, had an earlier connection to the Ṣafaviyya in his status as disciple to Ṣadr al-Dīn Ṣafavī (d. 794/1391). However, *pace* Roger M. Savory's characterization of Shaykh Qāsim as an active Ṣafavī propagandist, there is no evidence to suggest that he maintained his connection to the Ardabil shrine after the death of his master (Binbaş, "The Anatomy of an Attempted Regicide," [23] (my thanks to Dr. Binbaş for a preprint version of this article); Savory, "A 15th Century Ṣafavid Propagandist at Harāt").

⁹¹ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 206-7.

⁹² For letters of this type see e.g. §2.1.3.1, letter 26. In treatises written in exile he complains of his tribulations, e.g. "R. Tuḥfa-yi 'Alā'i," 122.

⁹³ See §2.1.3.1, letters 28-34.

in Simnan,⁹⁴ upon which he went to Natanz and summoned his family there. The next year Shāhrukh was campaigning against the Qara Quyunlu in Azarbayjan; Šā'in al-Dīn finally obtained a hearing at the sultan's camp at Šā'in Qal'a near Sultaniyya and received a promise of reinstatement. He followed Shāhrukh back to Herat, and spent the last year or so of his life in weekly attendance at Shāhrukh's court in Herat, anticipating the review of his case. Our main source for this period of exile is Šā'in al-Dīn's second apology, addressed to Shāhrukh's son Bāysunghur, which details the enormity of his tribulations in exile and seeks Bāysunghur's intercession with the sultan—to little real effect, as it turned out.⁹⁵ Šā'in al-Dīn died in Herat on Monday, 14 Dhū l-Ḥijja 835/12 August 1432 at the age of 63, frustrated, impoverished and in a state of limbo.⁹⁶

⁹⁴ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 207.

⁹⁵ The *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* II is likewise accompanied by a very brief formal statement of creed, the *R. I'tiqādiyya*.

⁹⁶ *SND*, xlvii. Malik al-Shu'arā' Bahār reports that the printed version of Khwāndamīr's *Ḥabīb al-Siyar* gives the year 830 for his death, but a MS copy of the work in his possession gives the more correct date of 836 (*Sabk-shināsī*, 3/229); because Šā'in al-Dīn's death occurred a mere two weeks from the end of 835, news thereof would probably not have reached Fars until the beginning of the following year. The year 830 is certainly wrong, since Ibn Turka composed a number of works after this date (e.g., *R. Tuḥfa-yi 'Alā'ī*, *R. Mabda' u Ma'ād*). For brief accounts of Šā'in al-Dīn's life see Faṣīḥ Khwāfī, *Mujmal-i Faṣīḥī*, 3/229; Kāzīrūnī, *Sullam al-Samāwāt*, 19-20, 144-49; Shūshtarī, *Majālis al-Mu'minīn*, majlis 6; Ma'sūm 'Alī Shāh, *Tarā'iq al-Ḥaqā'iq*, 3/30; Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 9/570. Aḥmad 'Alī Khān Hāshimī's *Makhzan al-Gharā'ib*, completed 1218/1803 at Delhi, also contains an entry for Šā'in al-Dīn 'Alī of Isfahan; see MS 395/1348, Bodleian Library, Oxford, undated (Sachau and Ethé, *Catalogue*, 1/col. 345).

1.3: Ibn Turka's apologies

*The shaykh is consumed with his endless judgments of
bad and good
continually moaning that this is more and that less
Even stranger are the shortsighted people
who paint one person a rebel and another a man of God!*⁹⁷

—Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī

*So it may please your sacred Maiestie ... to cause your
Highnesse sayd Seruant, to by tried and cleared of that horrible
and damnable, and to him, most grievous and dammageable
Sclaunder ...*⁹⁸

—John Dee

Şā'in al-Dīn's apologies are, in the first place, the primary source of information about his life; beyond their autobiographical value, however, they provide us with a uniquely candid look at the religio-political machinations that made intellectual life in early Timurid Iran so fraught.

His first *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr*, or 'Tubercular Expectoration,' was written for Shāhrukh in 829/1426 in response to the accusations leveled against Şā'in al-Dīn by his enemies in Herat.⁹⁹ It comprises an introduction with autobiographical details and a discussion of the superficial character and base motivations of his accusers, followed by two sections (*vaṣl*): 1) a

⁹⁷ Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī, from a ghazal beginning *ṣūfī mabāsh munkir-i rindān-i may-parast* as quoted in Sulṭān Muḥammad Fakhrī Harātī's 928/1522 Persian translation (pp. 25-26) of 'Alī Shīr Navā'ī's *Majālis al-Nafā'is* (see p. 32, which preserves only the first two lines of this ghazal). The ghazal is also preserved in Gāzurgāhī, *Majālis al-'Ushshāq*, 234.

⁹⁸ "To the Kings most excellent Maiestie," 1604, Bodleian Library, University of Oxford.

⁹⁹ There may have been a formal inquisitorial body that handled such charges of heterodoxy as were brought against Şā'in al-Dīn. Muḥammad Tūsī refers in his *R. Majma' al-Tahānī u Maḥzar al-Amānī*, written for Bāysunghur, to a *majlis-i tafahḥuṣ u dīvān-i tajassus* that was responsible for interrogating Hurufis brought to trial ("R. Majma' al-Tahānī," 30). This was presumably the same institution that conducted Şā'in al-Dīn's three trials.

commentary on nine hadith in censure of reprehensible innovation (*bid'a*) in matters of religion; 2) a commentary on the sayings of Sufi masters and leading religious authorities in support of the orthodoxy of Sufism; Sufis are identified as striving to know and imitate Muḥammad perfectly. This focus on Sufism stems from the fact that Ṣā'in al-Dīn was charged by his detractors with exhibiting Sufi bias (*ṣūfiḡarī*)—hardly problematic on the face of it, seemingly, but here no doubt meant to cast the accused as sympathizing with the views of the more extremist, subversive and utopian Sufi movements of the period, particularly the Ḥurūfiyya.

The introduction mounts a strong defense against the accusations of those who, Ṣā'in al-Dīn says, are no more than mafiosos and backbiters such as plague scholars these days—people of little learning but many designs (*aghrāz*).¹⁰⁰ Ṣā'in al-Dīn excoriates his accusers for both their lack of learning and their blatant hypocrisy: they attempt to damn their betters by associating them with a fringe Sufi element, yet are wholly silent about astronomy and astrology, which sciences are often ostensibly at odds with quranic dictums yet enjoy universal vogue at royal courts. Of similar vogue is Zamakhsharī's (d. 538/1144) *Kashshāf*, an overtly Mu'tazili work defending the createdness of the Quran—yet every scholar touts it and prides himself on mastering it.¹⁰¹ Ṣā'in al-Dīn proceeds to draw an equivalency between Mu'tazilism and Shi'ism in terms of basic theoretical principles (*uṣūl*), with both agreeing in the main with the philosophers; all three groups are enemies of the Sunna.¹⁰² (In a companion tract, the *R*.

¹⁰⁰ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I," 187.

¹⁰¹ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I," 186-77. See Andrew Lane's *A Traditional Mu'tazilite Qur'ān Commentary* for an evaluation of this as a common view on the *Kashshāf*.

¹⁰² "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I," 175. Cf. the dismissal of kabbalism by Elijah del Medigo (d. 1493), an Averroist and sometime member of Pico della Mirandola's circle, as being more or less equivalent to neoplatonism: "Most of [the kabbalists' views] agree with the statements of the early philosophers, the negligibility of whose opinions is well understood by learned people. Whoever has seen the statements of the Platonists and these [kabbalistic] statements will know that such is the truth" (*Sefer Behinat ha-Dat*, 99, trans. in Idel, *Kabbalah in Italy*, 161; see Bland, "Elijah del Medigos's Averroistic Response").

I'tiqādiyya, the author is primarily concerned to show himself as a standard-issue Ash'ari thinker.) To deflect his accusers, the author is particularly concerned to show that even if he did at some point have Sufi inclinations—to which he is not admitting—, Sufis cannot by any measure be considered as deviating from the Sunna, but rather as epitomizing it. He enumerates many examples of the orthodoxy of prominent Sufi masters,¹⁰³ dwelling frequently on Kh^wāja Muḥammad Pārsā (d. 822/1419), the Kh^wājagānī master and favorite of Shāhrukh. Such Sufis are carefully distinguished from those charlatans who use their charisma and cunning to amass disciples and gain control over rulers, or who use Sufism as an excuse for laziness, chanting 'Everything is God!' without bothering to pass beyond their basic animal natures.¹⁰⁴

Ṣā'in al-Dīn's second apology, the *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* II, was written for Bāysunghur b. Shāhrukh some five years after the disastrous events of 830/1427, which saw the author's arrest, torture, imprisonment and exile in the wake of the Hurufi attempt on Shāhrukh's life.¹⁰⁵ It is even more autobiographical and takes a different tack than the first; it is also much angrier in tone. Ṣā'in al-Dīn details his wanderings and tribulations in exile, stating that he has 10 children and a few wives (*dah ṭifl u 'awratī chand*) he was rendered unable to care for.¹⁰⁶ In contrast to his first apology, here it is not the author's interest in mystical theory but his scholarly fame as such that is at issue. As Ṣā'in al-Dīn says, his writings are sought out and used from Anatolia to Central Asia to India, and his students as widely dispersed; he is simply being

¹⁰³ E.g., 'Abd Allāh Anṣārī (d. 481/1089), al-Ḥakīm al-Tirmidhī (d. btw. 318-20/936-38), Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī (d. 649/1252) ("Nafsat al-Maṣdūr," 173).

¹⁰⁴ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I," 176-77.

¹⁰⁵ Ṣā'in al-Dīn states that it has been five years since he was sent into exile, and nine months since he had been promised to have his case reviewed at the imperial seat in Herat; in the meantime he has appeared at court once or twice a week, to no avail ("Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 199, 207). This puts the date of composition sometime between ca. 832-35/1429-32.

¹⁰⁶ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 206. This number included three sons and seven daughters (see §2.1.3.1, no. 7).

attacked by those who consider knowledge a means to social standing, who have not developed beyond such base passions as greed and envy. No true scholar can be safe from their attacks.¹⁰⁷

Anyone in any village or city of any profession who attains to prominence in his art is liable to be attacked by his peers out of envy, who attempt to discredit him in the eyes of [local] rulers; how much more so a scholar whose writings are known and used far and wide? My writings have reached the various countries of the world; envoys have come from India and Anatolia seeking copies of my treatises and books; my students are widely dispersed in places like Shiraz, Samarkand, Anatolia and India—in short, I am a noted scholar. I am simply being attacked by those who consider knowledge a means to a comfortable life, who have not developed beyond such animal passions as greed, petulance, envy. No prominent person is safe from such attacks.¹⁰⁸

In a passage particularly intriguing for the light it sheds on the intellectual scene in Herat, Šā'in al-Dīn notes that his enemies in attacking him hide behind the reputation of Shaykh Muḥammad al-Jazarī (d. 833/1429), whom he dismisses as knowing nothing beyond the science of Quran reading (*qirā'at*) and some hadith.

This, the foremost teacher of hadith and Quran in the Timurid realm, was able to secure a prominent position for himself in Fars purely on the basis of his native Arabic, [hailing as he does from Damascus,] and since he had the favor of rulers he became influential and in majlises constantly caused problems for my students and complained. [All this is because] once when I was in Egypt the Mamluk sultan asked me about him and I sketched his character and qualifications, this causing Jazarī to fall in that ruler's estimation. He became my enemy from that point onwards, but he couldn't very well say the reason for this back in Fars so as not to endanger his position at court. Instead he used his connections to cause trouble for me, although I showed him only respect.¹⁰⁹

Finally, Šā'in al-Dīn develops the theme of imposter Sufis who do not observe the Shari'a but rather use their tricks to amass disciples and gain influence over rulers. He mentions receiving the *khirqā-yi tabarruk* from a prominent Sufi master before traveling abroad, only to find upon

¹⁰⁷ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 210.

¹⁰⁸ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 209-10 (paraphrased). Dawlatshāh Samarqandī identifies Šā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī as the two most prominent intellectuals of Shahrukhid Iran, and states that Šā'in al-Dīn's writings are famous throughout the world (*Tazkirat al-Shu'arā*, 379; *SND*, lviii); see §4.4.3 below.

¹⁰⁹ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 211-12 (paraphrased). Khwāja Pārsā's enemies likewise tried to use Jazarī's authority to discredit Pārsā's hadith credentials (Manz, *Power*, 76-77).

his return that the disciples of this master had dispensed with the Shari‘a; Šā’in al-Dīn’s attempt to confront him on this point did not end well. His similar exhortations to another prominent Herati shaykh, almost certainly Qāsim-i Anvār, were better received. These episodes are recounted, of course, primarily in order to portray Šā’in al-Dīn as staunch admonisher of wayward Sufi masters and vigorous upholder of the Shari‘a—and hence the Sunnizing Shahrukhid state. Most significantly for the purposes of the present study, Šā’in al-Dīn ends by dismissing the Hurufi movement of Fażl Allāh Astarābādī in harsh and bitterly resentful terms.¹¹⁰

Finally, in the brief *R. I’tiqādiyya*, among the last of his writings, Šā’in al-Dīn does in fact admit to having explored suspect sciences in his youth, justifying this on the strength of the hadith, *Learn even sorcery (ta‘allamū ḥattā l-siḥr)*; here he compares himself to Ghazālī and Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī (*al-imāmayn*) in their willingness, sprung of intellectual integrity, to delve experimentally into all branches of knowledge.¹¹¹

The very condensed account of these treatises I give here is nevertheless suggestive of their usefulness for an analysis of the intellectual and religious currents of the period, both in Iran and the Islamic heartlands. Šā’in al-Dīn’s apologies are fascinating documents that more than merit close analysis in their own right, although such is beyond the scope of the present study. For the purposes of this section, however, I provide below a more detailed paraphrase of the *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* I to show the texture of the author’s defensive strategy, and in Chapter 8 (§8.3) translate the final section of the *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* II for the light it sheds on Šā’in al-Dīn’s attitude toward organized Sufism on the one hand and Hurufism on the other.

¹¹⁰ “*Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* II,” 212-15.

¹¹¹ “*R. I’tiqādiyya*,” 268.

Given that a group of defamers (*badgūyān*) has denounced me to you¹¹² and summoned me to Herat to stand trial, it has become necessary to write this account in my defense. I am currently 59 [lunar] years of age, having spent 25 years studying the religious sciences under my eminent elder brother; my family has been engaged in furthering the religious sciences for the past two centuries, and the writings of my forebears on such subjects still circulate. The subjects I studied with my brother were hadith, tafsir, jurisprudence and *uṣūl al-dīn*. I was then sent by my brother and other teachers in Samarkand to pursue wider learning abroad, and for 15 years I studied intensively and with rigorous discipline under great religious scholars, and then returned home to my brethren at the direction of my teachers there. In brief, I spent these 15 years studying nothing save tafsir, hadith, *uṣūl al-dīn* and jurisprudence according to my family tradition, neglecting the outward dictates of the Shari'a not a whit.¹¹³

The office of judge was bestowed upon my brother by Temür himself after our family's removal to Samarkand, which office then passed to me. The Shari'a stipulates that it is incumbent upon all those who are placed in this office to strive for justice and mend any breach therein—a high and noble calling in service to Muḥammad—, defending the wronged from their oppressors. It remains a noble office for all that certain bad eggs have abused it:

If a pearl falls into muck
its value is nowise impaired.

As Imam Abū Ḥanīfa states in his *Hidāya*: Judgeship is the noblest of all acts of worship (*qazā afḡal-i 'ibādāt ast*). In the time of former kings the Shari'a was woefully neglected, but under Shāhrukh's rule it has gained such a brilliance as was never before achieved in centuries past. When someone has a case to be settled in court it is now done wholly according to the Shari'a, for the king has entirely abolished the *dīvān-i yarghū* which had darkened the minds of kings and polluted the land of Islam for a long period. Under the aegis of such a religion-nurturing sovereign, then, it is the duty of all those he has appointed to fulfill this office of ruling according to Muḥammad's law to not fear the powerful (*mutaghallibān*) or be a respecter of persons. Any judge that neglects this charge in favor of making his life easier and enjoying the pleasures of this world should be consumed with shame.

God knows that I have twice made the long journey from Persian Iraq to Khurasan despite my age and ill health to pay my respects to the royal person, during which audiences I communicated much the same sentiments to you out of precisely this sense of duty. On the second visit I submitted two statements (*ṣūrat*) to the royal consideration. The first was a statement of creed declaring my adherence to the Sunna and Jamā'a, which was delivered in the presence of the leading religious scholars at court and testified to by them; this should leave no opening for my opponents to cast doubts on my orthodoxy. The second was delivered to Shāhrukh at his residence in the Bāgh-i Mukhtār [in Herat], and communicated my avid support for the king's efforts to restore the Shari'a; Shāhrukh responded most graciously and instructed me to return to Persian Iraq, appointing me qadi of Yazd.

¹¹² Addressing Shāhrukh.

¹¹³ Ṣā'in al-Dīn's blatant omission here of any reference to his formative discipleship to Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī in Cairo is the first indication of many that his apologies, as per the nature of the genre, are not meant to reflect his own intellectual project but rather the predilections and anxieties of Shāhrukh.

In the interim I have kept to myself and striven to carry out my duties to the best of my ability. I did not allow the powerful to oppress any poor person, but because the assertive are many and each one takes refuge in the protection (*himāyat*) of someone, they are accustomed to bending the qadi to the will of their powerful backers, and hence became my enemies. They plotted and schemed and sought to intimidate me, but they largely failed in this endeavor given the king's support for the rule of Shari'a. Another group devised a strategem whereby they approached the governor of the city and attempted to denounce me, but thank God that they could only do so by saying I had written something wherein I quoted the words of certain Sufi masters (*mashāyikh*)—some twenty years ago!

[Such a charge is inadmissible on several grounds.] First, according to the Shari'a charges cannot be leveled against someone on the basis of their having written something. For example, if someone writes a note agreeing to give someone something, it is not binding according to the Shari'a, although it is the right of the designated recipient to receive that promised; my own case, then, pertains to the right of God, but the Shari'a in a cognate case pertaining to human rights refuses to judge. Second, according to the Shari'a one cannot be charged with transgression for simply quoting the words of another; all blame if blame there be rests solely with the original author.

Second, it is clear to the perspicacious that were quoting such things a blameworthy matter with respect to religion, the leading lights of Islam, whom everyone everywhere holds to be pious Muslims, would have refrained from writing—for it is these I have quoted. I refer here to Kh^wāja Muḥammad Pārsā, Kh^wāja 'Abd Allāh Anṣārī, Kh^wāja Muḥammad 'Alī Ḥakīm Tirmidhī, Shaykh Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī and their like. The example of Shams al-Dīn Fanārī, chief qadi (*qāzī l-quḏāt*) in Anatolia, may further be cited: he is an extremely prominent scholar who nevertheless constantly and openly teaches mystical theory, and indeed discourses of nothing else—and yet he is held in the highest regard throughout the Ottoman domains! Ghazālī may also be mentioned in this connection. First, all such works are in accordance with the Shari'a; second, the Quran forbids all such machinations against fellow Muslims and the making of empty accusations and backbiting.

Indeed, according to such evil-minded people, a science like astronomy (*'ilm-i hay'a*) should amount to unbelief (*kufr*) given that it is based on physical principles that are sometimes ostensibly at odds with various quranic passages. Astrology (*nujūm*) must likewise entail unbelief since it is based on the same principles, yet astrology is a central topic of discussion in royal majlises, especially nowadays when the science has seen a tremendous revival as a result of new astronomical observations.¹¹⁴ Furthermore, Zamakhsharī's *Kashshāf*, which every teacher and scholar these days promotes and takes great pride in mastering, pushes blatant Mu'tazili content in its defense of the createdness of the Quran—a position deemed *kufr* by all leading Hanafis and Shafi'is. The *Kashshāf* is in point of fact explicitly anti-Sunna. If my accusers do not have some ulterior motive in branding me an unbeliever, then why are they so mysteriously silent about astrology or the *Kashshāf*, blithely ignoring the incorrect doctrines of the Mu'tazilis and philosophers? But no, they demonize Sufis and respected jurists instead. As Hafez sings,

The tulip's in its cups, the narcissus is soaked—
yet I'm the one accused of debauch?

¹¹⁴ This due not least to the efforts of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's associate Qāzīzāda Rūmī, the second director of Ulugh Beg's observatory in Samarkand.

I have many judges, O Lord:
whom shall I make mine?¹¹⁵

It will be beneficial for the cause of religion to show why the situation is thus. Although there were and still are many *madhabs* other than the Sunni, broadly speaking they may be boiled down to three: the Mu'tazila, the Shi'a, and the philosophers. Now the Mu'tazila attained ascendancy during the early 'Abbasid period and destroyed many Sunni leaders; they tortured Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal and forced Shāfi'ī to flee to Egypt. This type of fanatical intersectarian hostility between Sunnis and other groups is therefore of long standing. Given this situation, many people over the years claimed to be Sunni and of Sunni stemming, despite actually being Shi'i or Mu'tazili or of philosophical bent. Now the Shi'a and Mu'tazila rely on entirely the same theoretical principles (*uṣūl*), and both agree in the main with the philosophers; all three are enemies of the Sunna. The Sufis shaykhs, however, are all partisans of the Sunna and Jamā'a, and do not accept disciples unless they too profess the Sunna. The problem (*fitna*) lies not with them but with those who falsely claim to be followers of the Sunna. These latter spend their energies deflecting attention away from themselves with accusations of the doctrinal perversion of others, doing so in order to continue holding their own perverted doctrines—they are projecting, in other words, a necessary technique for survival under such a righteous and Sunni sultan as Shāhrukh. They cause trouble for sincere and orthodox scholars and then meet to mock them in private.

Mention must be made of another issue: [what it means to be a Sufi]. Sufis are simply the Sunni elite, and the name only indicates that one has reached a certain level of perfection in his knowledge and practice. However, Sufis are frequently accused of two pernicious faults of expression and behavior.

The first fault is that in a state of ecstasy they often say things that seem to constitute unbelief. Now certain lazy good-for-nothings who have not passed beyond their basic animal natures latch onto such statements and reduce them to the simplistic "Everything is God"—God forbid!—thereby becoming heretics (*mulḥid*, *zindīq*). They suppose that the poetry of such luminaries as Shaykh Aḥmad-i Jām, Mawlānā Rūmī, 'Irāqī, and others supports their lazy view and put them forward as their representatives. This has led various princes and rulers to think that all Sufis are of their type, worthy of condemnation by the jurists; and indeed, because such movements are subversive and anarchic (*ḥarakat-hā-yi bad*), rulers naturally give credence to those scholars who are anti-Sufi and call all their states and actions evil. However, it is obvious that in order to understand the words of these Sufi masters one must spend years disciplining oneself intellectually and practically on the Muḥammadan path; only then will one's shaykh allow one to begin exploring those more rarefied stations of the way. And even after spending years in service to a master, one still may not be able to understand the meaning of the words of such enlightened Sufis. So how can those who have never progressed beyond their basest desires and motivations—envy, petulance, malice, etc.—ever have the faintest idea of what they mean?

The second fault is that [all too often] imposters are able to pass themselves off as great Sufi masters, sitting in corners and gathering around them a group of sly, world-worshiping cheats. These disciples of theirs are then dispatched to the rulers and members of the government to woo them with impressive claims to the effect that their master performed feats of asceticism or a number of miracles. This induces important personages to want to hear and see their master for themselves, and he is accordingly

¹¹⁵ Ḥāfiz, ghazal: *man na ān rind-am ki tark-i shāhid u sāghar kunam*.

invited to royal majlises where he slowly corrupts rulers with his tricks, inducing them to swear allegiance to him as disciples. As time passes these imposters gain complete control over the ruler and influence him toward evil policies, and much unrest (*fitna*) results therefrom. This scenario is painfully familiar.

It is no small part of the glory of the Timurid state that it has done away with such perversions. However, it is worth reminding the king of the age of such things so he can continue to forstall their occurrence; and he must remember that these two types of people—lazy anarchists and cunning imposters—are far from being true Sufis and give the great Sufi masters a bad name.

The reason behind all such corruption is that the words of the Prophet are not heeded, for he states in many hadith that we should keep ourselves from all kinds of reprehensible innovation (*bid'at*)—*Every kind of innovation is error (kullu bid'atⁱⁿ ḍalāla)*. He emphasized this point more than any other because it is the source of much corruption. Therefore in the next section I will adduce the relevant hadith and translate them so their meaning will be clear to the padishah, and so he may act accordingly in the realm and expunge from it all types of innovation.

This section will be divided into two subsections: 1) a Persian translation of a number of hadith so the padishah can understand their meaning precisely, and 2) examples from the shaykhs and scholars of the Sunna from the time of the Prophet till the present.

1) Nine standard Sunni hadith [i.e., drawn from the collections of Bukhārī, Muslim, Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal, Abu Dā'ūd, Bayhaqī, etc.] as nine is a propitious number for rulers. The first four hadith treat of innovation.¹¹⁶ The fifth hadith is used to criticize the contemporary profusion of recluses who accomplish feats of asceticism solely to impress the masses and to gain fame for holiness—such destroys Islam. The sixth hadith shows that people's motives are not to be judged, only their actions. The seventh is on just rulership. The eighth is on good and bad viziers as the expression of God's will toward a ruler. The ninth is on the far greater excellence of the scholar (*ālim*) as compared to the worshiper/ascetic (*ābid*); it is supported by the hadith *Scholars are the heirs of the prophets*. This last leads into the next section where the author is concerned to show that the type of knowledge bequeathed by the prophets is not the exoteric kind taught in the madrasas by scholars who seek to gain fame thereby, but rather that inner prophetic knowledge as taught by the great luminaries of Islam, including Sufi shaykhs.

2) The first hadith is on the seven *ahruf* of the Quran, comprising the *ẓāhir*, *bāṭin*, *ḥadd*, and *maṭla'* of each verse. The second is on the Prophet's bequeathing to his followers two kinds of knowledge, one being far more precious than the other and therefore hidden. The third, quoted by Ghazālī, is on the fact of Abū Bakr's being chosen as caliph due not to his piety but rather due to a secret knowledge he possessed; this is supported by a hadith of 'Alī: "Had I wished, I could have filled seventy camel loads' worth in commenting on the the Fātiḥa alone"—whereas a scholar of the exoteric sciences could barely fill one book on the same sura. The fourth is a statement by the Companion Ibn Mas'ūd to the effect that all knowledge must be rooted in the Quran. The fifth is the eminent commentator Ibn 'Abbās's exposition of the verse *Who is given wisdom is given great good* (Q 2:269) in which he says that all wisdom is contained within the Quran; this is supported by a *khavar* of Ḥusayn b. 'Alī in which he answers a question as to the meaning of *KHY'Ṣ* (Q 19:1): "Were I to tell you the meaning of these letters you would be able to walk on water." Now these are all the words of the Companions, and all are to the effect that true knowledge is hidden from the understanding of most people.

¹¹⁶ The second is through 'Ā'isha al-Ṣiddīqa. Note that with the third hadith Ṣā'in al-Dīn translates *al-khulafā' al-rāshidūn* as simultaneously 'rightly-guiding, rightly-guided' (*rāh-numā-yi rāh-yāfta*).

Yet the famous Sufi masters have written books to precisely the same effect, masters such as Ḥakīm Tirmizī, Imam Ghazālī, Shaykh ‘Abd Allāh Anṣārī, and Shaykh Sa‘d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī. Ḥakīm Tirmizī, for example, posed a series of [157] questions that only the elite of the Muḥammadan saints would be able to answer. Two individuals answered them: Shaykh Sa‘d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī in Khurasan, and Muḥyī l-Dīn [Ibn ‘Arabī] Ṭāṭī Andalusī in the Maghrib. Thus it is apparent that the Sufis strive to realize the status of Muḥammad and plumb the knowledge he bequeathed, and the Quran above all—they have no other aim.

These are the words of the great men of former times; the leading Sufi masters of our own day are similarly exercised and write books to the same end. A prime example is Kh^wāja Muḥammad Pārsā who has composed treatises on such topics, and taught the qasida of Ibn al-Fāriḍ to his son and wrote a treatise on the subject, displaying his great esteem for Ibn al-Fāriḍ therein. Sayyid Sharīf [Jurjānī] also has a very famous treatise on Sufism.¹¹⁷ Mawlānā Shams al-Dīn Fanārī, the greatest living scholar in Anatolia and chief qadi there, teaches this science and no other. When I was in Cairo Shaykh Sirāj al-Dīn Bū l-Qīnī [Bulqīnī] was still alive and I attended his lectures; he would frequently refer to this science [of Sufism], and whenever jurists would attempt to defame Sufis he would criticize them harshly. More, he himself composed mystical poetry that he would read in his majlises.

In contrast to my experience in Egypt, my elder brother [Ṣadr al-Dīn] refused to speak openly of this science and forbade his associates to do so as well, not because he thought it evil but because he thought it necessary to protect oneself against those people who have little learning but many designs—for such are unfortunately numerous in these parts.

Mention may again be made of the example of Kh^wāja Muḥammad Pārsā, sometime speaker at the royal majlis,¹¹⁸ who argues for the vast interior dimension of religious knowledge. In his *Mirṣād al-‘Ibād* Najm al-Dīn Rāzī divides scholars into three groups: exoteric scholars, esoteric scholars, and those who combine both exoteric and esoteric—these last unite east and west and are the poles of their age, upholders of the world. Tirmizī’s *Nawādir al-Uṣūl* is another example of the inner interpretation of religious knowledge. Kh^wāja Abū Ya‘qūb Yūsuf Hamadānī¹¹⁹ said that the sciences of the gnostics have penetrated to the very core of the Sunni schools, whereas the schools of innovators, whether Qadiris or Jabris, anthropomorphists or Mu‘aṭṭila, philosophers, libertines or sophists, are without foundation. Other texts and authorities upholding such views include: Abū Bakr Muḥammad Kalābādhī’s *al-Ta‘arruf li-Madhhab [Ahl] al-Taṣawwuf*, the *R. al-Qushayriyya*, Shaykh Abū Sa‘īd b. Abī l-Khayr, Faṭḥ Mawṣilī, the *Fuṣūl ‘Imādiyya* and *Khulāṣat al-Fatāwā*, Imam Ghazālī, and ‘Aṭṭār. As Tirmizī says, the sayings of the Sufi masters, like the Quran itself, contain certain ambiguities that cannot be parsed by the intellect. One should not even dislike God’s saints, much less pronounce them unbelievers; they are the true rulers. Junayd: The divine threat is directed against those who deny the right of this group, and the divine blessing toward those who honor them. And the divine jealousy—He is like a lion in protecting His own. The basic Sufi position may be summed up by citing the famous *dūbayt* often repeated by Kh^wāja Pārsā (*kh^wāja-yi mā*):

¹¹⁷ I.e., the *Ta‘rīfāt*.

¹¹⁸ As an orthodox Kh^wājagānī shaykh and preeminent hadith authority, Pārsā’s wide influence served as a natural prop to Shāhrukh’s Sunnizing program; more concretely, Pārsā helped Shāhrukh stage his comeback in Bukhara (Manz, *Power*, 76).

¹¹⁹ Kh^wāja Yūsuf Hamadānī (d. 534/1140) was accounted the forebear of the Naqshbandiyya, also called the *ṭarīqa-yi kh^wājagān* after his precedent of taking the title *kh^wāja*.

Only that will acquaint you with Reality
that frees you from the manacles of self.
You cannot attain it by knowing;
you can only know by unknowing.

Thus far has been a faithful intimation of Kh^wāja Pārsā’s discourse and a summary of some of his statements—I accordingly close herewith, given that most people in the realm believe in his sanctity and accept his teachings.¹²⁰

Now Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s tone in the preceding is rather shrill in pushing the author’s Sunnism, and facile in its dismissal of the Shi’a, Mu’tazila and *falāsifa*. In this the apologies may be taken as a mirror of Shāhrukh’s strident Sunnizing program; needless to say, such a position certainly does not reflect that of Ṣā’in al-Dīn, whose veneration for the Imams and skill in philosophy is everywhere evident in his works.¹²¹ (Granted, Ṣā’in al-Dīn is consistent in his disapproval of Mu’tazili theology; the doctrine of the created Quran in particular is antithetical to his lettrist project.¹²²) His first apology, moreover, champions a type of orthodox Sufism much esteemed but by no means personally embraced by the author, who pointedly declined to identify as Sufi while maintaining friendly—and in some cases hostile—relations with various prominent Sufi masters. I investigate the question of Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s ambiguous confessional orientation in the following section (§1.4) and his equally ambiguous relationship to organized Sufism in Chapter 8.

¹²⁰ “Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I,” 169-93.

¹²¹ Pace Lewisohn’s recent argument for taking the apologies at face value (“Sufism and Theology in the Confessions of Ṣā’in al-Dīn Turka Iṣfahānī (d. 830/1437) [sic],” 66, 79 n. 23); even a cursory survey of Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s oeuvre suggests that the situation is more complicated than it would seem.

¹²² See e.g. his censure of Zamakhsharī in the opening section of part four of the *Mafāḥiṣ* (MS Majlis 10196 f. 90a), summarized in §7.2 below.

1.4: Late medieval Shi'i-Sunnism or imamophilism

*You must forever revel in your devotion to Murtaẓā
envelop your heart in the skirt of the Folk of the Mantle
Engrave love for that Family upon the surface of your soul
seal, as I've done, your heart with ardor for Ḥaydar
Abominate the company of those estranged from 'Alī
but keep ever close to his friends.*¹²³

*Take my path, the path of the Sunna
else you'll wander lost and confused
From God I've received my universal rite
this guidance mine from all eternity.*¹²⁴

—Ni'mat Allāh Valī

Given his heavy emphasis on the Imams as preeminent sources of occult knowledge in the Islamic dispensation, that Ṣā'in al-Dīn is reflexively assumed in the literature to be Shi'i (or crypto-Shi'i) is hardly surprising. And indeed, absent the context of the present study, Corbin's assertion that he is an openly Shi'i thinker in terms of confessional allegiance is perfectly reasonable.¹²⁵ However, it wholly ignores his historical context, which was characterized by rampant confessional ambiguity between Sunni and Shi'i that increasingly defined Islamic

¹²³ *Dīvān-i Shāh Ni'mat Allāh Valī*, 27.

¹²⁴ *Dīvān-i Shāh Ni'mat Allāh Valī*, 581, ghazal 1525. By 'universal rite' (*mazhab-i jāmi'*) Ni'mat Allāh is referring to the phenomenon of Shi'i-Sunnism and antisectarianism treated here. For a discussion of this theme in Ni'mat Allāh Valī's works see Āzmāyish, "Vus'at-i Mashrab u I'tidāl-i Mazhab-i Shāh Sayyid Ni'mat Allāh-i Valī."

¹²⁵ See e.g. his study of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *R. Shaqq-i Qamar*, "Typologie des spirituels selon Sā'inoddīn 'Alī Ispahānī (ob. 830/1427) [sic]." By contrast, Jean Aubin, who assumed Ṣā'in al-Dīn's Shi'i identity in his 1957 article "Le mécénat timouride à Chiraz," later modified his opinion as expressed in "De Kūhbanān à Bidar" (1991) (my thanks to Dr. Binbaş for bringing my attention to this fact).

religiosity, particularly in Iran, up to the beginning of the 10th/16th century.¹²⁶

The confessional ambiguity, even promiscuity, of the period has become axiomatic in recent scholarship.¹²⁷ Marshall Hodgson, one of the first historians to note this phenomenon, attributed it to the dramatic spread of what he terms ‘Alid loyalism.¹²⁸ However, the scholarly focus to date has been trained largely on the extremist, messianic and syncretist elements coming out of this mix, here exemplified by the Ḥurūfiyya and Nūrbakhshiyya; yet such fringe movements, in placing a heavy premium on healing and transcending sectarian fragmentation, were expressing precisely a unificationist, synthesizing ethos that pervaded society at large. This ethos manifested in a wide variety of forms, from religious to political,¹²⁹ from artistic to intellectual.¹³⁰ Most significantly for the purposes of the present discussion, the relationship of confessional ambiguity to an interest in the occult sciences has been demonstrated by Mohammad Masad in his recent monograph on the 7th/13th century Islamic apocalyptic tradition, wherein the Imams represent the repositories of hidden knowledge for Sunni and Shi‘i alike, to the extent that Sunni practitioners of, e.g., divination (*jafr*) are confessionally

¹²⁶ The imposition of Twelver Shi‘ism on Iran in the 10th/16th century by the originally heterodox and messianic Sufi Safavids did much to restore the old Sunni-Shi‘i polarity in the early modern Islamicate world. On the ahistorical tendencies of Corbin’s rereading of Islamic philosophy in prophetic terms see Rizvi, “Philosophy as a Way of Life,” 35-36.

¹²⁷ See e.g. Woods, *The Aqquyunlu*, 3-4; Masad, “The Medieval Islamic Apocalyptic Tradition,” 142-66; Molé, “Les Kubrawiyya entre sunnisme et shiisme”; Subtelny and Khalidov, “The Curriculum,” 210; Jacobs, “Sunnî and Shî‘î Perceptions.”

¹²⁸ Hodgson, *The Venture of Islam*, 2/446.

¹²⁹ Thus Gawharshād, wife of Shāhrukh, despite her dedicated Sunnism, endowed the shrine of Imam ‘Alī al-Riḍā in Mashhad with a magnificent mosque complex; thus Sulṭān-Ḥusayn Bāyqarā (r. 873-911/1469-1506), whose court at Herat was perhaps the most brilliant of the Timurid century, attempted upon his accession to have the *khuṭba* given in the name of the twelve Imams (he was only prevented from doing so by his advisor ‘Alī Shīr Navā‘ī (d. 906/1501), a Naqshbandi); and thus coins were struck by Sulṭān-Ḥusayn, Sulṭān-Abū Sa‘īd (r. 855-73/1451-69) and Jahānshāh Qara Qyunlu (r. 841-72/1438-67) bearing the phrase ‘*Alī walī Allāh*’ on the face and the names of the first three caliphs on the obverse (Halm, *Shi‘ism*, 68; Ja‘fariyān, *Tārīkh-i Tashayyu‘*, 844).

¹³⁰ For examples see §1.2 above.

indistinguishable from their Shi‘i counterparts.¹³¹ Nor is occultism proper a limiting factor. Sufism played a significant role from the 7th/13th century onward as an interface communicating Shi‘i content to Sunnism and vice versa; the nearly universal filiation of the emergent Sufi orders to ‘Alī is symptomatic of this.¹³² The main point of shared doctrine is the concept of *wilāya/walāya*, sanctity or sanctified power, now colored to a degree by Shi‘i imamology; Sufi shaykhs began to see themselves as partaking of Imam-like powers vis-à-vis their disciples.¹³³ (In a slight overstatement of this trend, Ḥaydar Āmulī (d. after 787/1385) calls Sufism Shi‘ism and Shi‘ism Sufism.¹³⁴) Indeed, even the staunch Sunni Naqshbandiyya, who deliberately traced their filiation to Abū Bakr rather than ‘Alī in an attempt to prevent further Shi‘i encroachment,¹³⁵ were at pains to distinguish between Shi‘ism and Rāfiḍism—the former consisting of the praiseworthy veneration of ‘Alī and the line of the Imams (*tawallu’*), the latter consisting of the hateful condemnation of the first three caliphs and ‘Ā’isha (*tabarru’*).¹³⁶ The very reactionariness of such a distinction serves to highlight the prevalence of *tashayyu’ ḥasan*, a moderate inclination toward Shi‘ism, in 9th/15th century Iran. That a certain unease accompanied this confessional ambiguity is perhaps best seen in the example of Ḥusayn Vā‘iz

¹³¹ Masad, “The Medieval Islamic Apocalyptic Tradition,” 142-66.

¹³² Such shaykhs include Rifā‘ī (d. 578/1182), Badawī (d. 675/1276), Dasūqī (d. 676/1277) et al.

¹³³ That is to say, the combined rise of messianism and interpenetration of Sufism and Shi‘ism during this period led in Iran to a new type of Sufi shaykh, who “[w]ith his religious prestige and political pretensions ... resembled more and more the Šī‘ī Imām in his universalistic spiritual claims” (Bashir, “The *Risālat al-Hudā*,” 2).

¹³⁴ Zarrīnkūb, *Dunbāla-yi Justujū*, 140. Seen as reflecting new sociopolitical realities on the ground, however, Āmulī’s statement seems not unreasonable.

¹³⁵ There exists, however, a second Naqshbandi initiatic chain, the so-called *silsilat al-dhahab*, leading from Ja‘far al-Šādiq through the Imami line of descent to ‘Alī (Algar, “Some Observations,” 289).

¹³⁶ Cf. Khwāja Muḥammad Pārsā’s *Faṣl al-Khiṭāb*, which despite a strongly pro-Sunni and anti-Rāfiḍī position still gives a biography of the twelve Imams. This regard remained a feature of Naqshbandi thought for the duration of the 9th/15th century; several decades later, for example, the Naqshbandi ‘Abd al-Vāsi’ Niẓāmī Bākhārī (d. 904/1499) overtly defends the twelve Imams in his *Maqāmāt-i Jāmī* in a refutation of a certain Shi‘i scholar.

Kāshifī (d. 910/1505), who in his home town of Sabzevar was accused of being a Sunni, and in Herat was accused of being a Shi'i.¹³⁷

This interpenetration of Sufism and Shi'ism was to strike particularly deep root in Shi'i scholarly circles.¹³⁸ The rationalist school of Bahrain of the 7th/13th century, centered around Kamāl al-Dīn Ibn Sa'āda al-Baḥrānī (d. ca. 640/1242), Jamāl al-Dīn 'Alī b. Sulaymān al-Baḥrānī (d. ca. 669/1271) and Kamāl al-Dīn Maytham b. Maytham al-Baḥrānī (d. 699/1300), was the first to achieve a synthesis of Imami theology with Ibn 'Arabian mystico-philosophical thought;¹³⁹ coming roughly a century later, Āmulī's work canonized this trend, simply adjusting Ibn 'Arabī's concept of *walāya* to fit Shi'i doctrine. Such syntheses became increasingly sophisticated, as may be seen from the example of Ibn Abī Jumhūr al-Aḥsā'ī (d. after 906/1501). Initially a Mu'tazili-style theologian, in his later work, the *K. al-Mujlī li-Mir'āt al-Munjī* (in the form of a commentary on his own *al-Nūr al-Munjī min al-Ẓalām*, itself a gloss on his *K. Masālik al-Afhām fī 'ilm al-Kalām*), he extends the efforts of earlier Imami thinkers to produce a thoroughgoing synthesis of the four main intellectual currents of his time within a rationalist theological framework. The *K. al-Mujlī* thus brings together theology, peripatetic and illuminationist philosophy, and Ibn 'Arabian mystical theory, all cast in the mold of Shi'i imamology.¹⁴⁰ This trend was to culminate in the supremely synthetic philosophical systems of the 11th/17th century school of Isfahan, and that of Mullā Ṣadrā (d. 1050/1640) in particular.

¹³⁷ Ja'fariyān, *Tārīkh-i Tashayyū'*, 843-45; the two cities are less than 300 miles apart. Kāshifī's definitive *Rawzat al-Shuhadā'* documents the prominent place of the custom of mourning Imam Ḥusayn in Sunni-Shi'i Iran before the advent of the Safavids; its importance is such that in Iran the recitation of the tragedy of Karbalā' is still today termed *rawza-khānī* in reference to Kāshifī's work (Subtelny, "Kāṣefī, Kamāl-al-Dīn Ḥosayn Wā'ez," *Elr*; Amanat, "Meadow of the Martyrs," 250-54). See §4.4.2 below for a discussion of Kāshifī as a preeminent occult philosopher of the late Timurid period.

¹³⁸ Ja'fariyān, *Naqsh-i Khāndān-i Karakī*, 57; Momen, *Shi'i Islam*, 96. Sufi influence became particularly pronounced in Nizari Isma'ilism.

¹³⁹ See Al-Oraibi, "Shī'i Renaissance."

¹⁴⁰ Schmidtke, *Theologie, Philosophie und Mystik*, 12-13. It was criticized by some later Imami thinkers as being excessively Sufi in tone (Madelung, "Ibn Abī Djumhūr al-Aḥsā'ī," *El'*).

Indeed, in the final analysis, Shi'ism had the greater effect on Sufism, in that while Sufism participated in Shi'ism's efflorescence Shi'ism did not participate in Sufism's later decline in Safavid Iran.¹⁴¹

In his recent history of Shi'ism in Iran, Rasūl Ja'fariyān proposes the term 'Twelver Sunnism' (*tasannun-i isnā-'asharī*) to describe the confessional ambiguity of the late medieval period.¹⁴² While all twelve Imams (i.e., those of the Twelver tradition)—or the fourteen Infallibles (*chahārdah ma'sūm*)¹⁴³—enjoyed universal respect during this period, Shi'ism in Iran was itself becoming increasingly subject to intraconfessional ambiguity between the Twelver, Isma'ili, Zaydi and *ghulāt* traditions,¹⁴⁴ and in any event primary emphasis had been laid on 'Alī and Ja'far al-Ṣādiq in the wisdom tradition from much earlier; I accordingly prefer the more generic terms Shi'i-Sunnism or imamophilism in order to account for a range of orientations along this axis. With respect to Timurid Iran in particular, endemic Shi'i-Sunnism may be seen as a normalization of both the pluralism of the Ilkhanid period and the accompanying Sunni-Shi'i intellectual rapprochement, as well as a symptom—or cause—of politically messianic Sufism.

How then to locate Ṣā' in al-Dīn in the complex, shifting and ambiguous religious terrain of the early 9th/15th century? On the one hand, his Shafi'i credentials are impeccable, although Devin Stewart's work on the Shi'i Shafi'i legal tradition of the period, it must be noted,

¹⁴¹ Ja'fariyān, *Naqsh-i Khāndān-i Karakī*, 56. This process eventually resulted in the transformation of several Sunni Sufi orders into Shi'i orders, e.g. the Ṣafaviyya, the Kubrawiyya (especially its suborders the Nūrbakhshiyya and Dhahabiyya) and the Nīmatullāhiyya.

¹⁴² Ja'fariyān, *Tārīkh-i Tashayyū'*, 843.

¹⁴³ Even from his vantage point in the early 10th/16th century, Faḡl Allāh b. Rūzbihān Khunjī-Iṣfahānī (d. 927/ 1521), despite his well-known opposition to Shi'ism and hatred of the Safavid dynasty, wrote his tract *Wasīlat al-Khādīm ilā l-Makhdūm* in defense of the *chahārdah ma'sūm*, and penned a number of poems eulogizing certain Imams (see e.g. *Mihmān-nāma-yi Bukhārā*, 336-38).

¹⁴⁴ As Shahzad Bashir observes ("The *Risālat al-Hudā*," 2-3), "[I]n the Iranian world, the lines of demarcation between Twelver, Ismā'īlī, Zaydī and Ghulāt sub-sects of Ṣī'ism were becoming blurred, allowing for the generation of a new Ṣī'ism which retained its connection to the claims of the family of 'Alī but strained against particular sectarian doctrines such as the occultation of the Twelfth Imam."

problematizes Shafi'ism as a reliable marker of Sunnism.¹⁴⁵ Perhaps more significantly, Ṣā'in al-Dīn belongs to the specifically Sunni tradition of writing *manāqib* works on 'Alī and the Imams, well-established by the 7th/13th century.¹⁴⁶ He penned what Āqā Buzurg Ṭihirānī calls, somewhat misleadingly, a *Sharḥ al-Nahj*;¹⁴⁷ precedents include Shīrawayh Daylamī (d. 509/1115), Muḥammad b. Ṭalḥa al-'Adawī (d. 652/1257) and Sibṭ Ibn al-Jawzī (d. 654/1256). This *Sharḥ al-Nahj* or *Tarjuma-yi Ahādīs az Ḥaẓrat-i Amīr*, identified by the author as deriving from the *Firdaws al-Akhbār* of Shīrawayh Daylamī and the *Musnad* of Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal, belongs to a common tradition of pairing hadiths on 'Alī's exceptionality found in the non-standard Sunni collections with select aphorisms from the *Nahj al-Balāgha* and other sources.¹⁴⁸ Interestingly, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's treatment is repeated almost verbatim in the 13th/19th century by the Hanafi Naqshbandi shaykh Sulaymān al-Qundūzī (d. 1294/1877) in his *Yanābī' al-Mawadda*.

Nor does Ṣā'in al-Dīn shrink from mentioning the Companions and Successors even in his most esoteric works, which lionize the Imams by necessity. In the final section of the *K. al-*

¹⁴⁵ See e.g. Stewart, *Islamic Legal Orthodoxy*; idem, "Ḥusayn b. 'Abd al-Ṣamad al-'Āmilī's Treatise."

¹⁴⁶ Already in the 3rd/9th century, with the decline of the influence of the traditionist Hanbalis and their strong antagonism to Shi'ism, Ash'aris had begun to compose independent works on the *ahl al-bayt*, some proceeding to write biographies of and *manāqib* works on the twelve Imams. By the 7th/13th century regard for the twelve Imams had become standard in Sunni circles, as seen from Ibn Khallikān's inclusion of their biographies in his *Wafayāt*, and the *muḥaddith* Kamāl al-Dīn Muḥammad b. Ṭalḥa al-Ḥalabī al-Shāfi'ī's (d. 652/1254) *Maṭālib al-Su'ul fī Manāqib Āl al-Rasūl*. The 8th-10th/14th-16th centuries saw a considerable uptick in Sunni production of *manāqib* works and eulogies on the Imams. Two examples enshrining this trend are Ibn al-Ṣabbāgh al-Mālikī's (d. 855/1451) *al-Fuṣūl al-Muḥimma fī Ma'rifat Aḥwāl al-A'imma*, and Ibn Ṭūlūn's (d. 953/1546) *al-Shadharāt al-Dhahabiyya fī Tarājim al-A'imma al-Ithnā 'Ashariyya 'ind al-Imāmiyya* (Ja'fariyān, *Tārīkh*, 841-2). During the same period, a certain respect for the *khulafā' al-rāshidūn* emerges in Shi'i circles; the historian Ḥamd Allāh Mustawfī (d. ca. 750/1349), for example, opens his famous *Tārīkh-i Guzīda* with a 25-page discussion of the first three caliphs, expressing his devotion to them; he then proceeds to a discussion of 'Alī's exploits and virtues, following this with a section on the other Imams with explicit reference to their infallibility as God's *ḥujaj* on earth, and concluding with a section on the hidden Mahdi (Ja'fariyān, *Tārīkh-i Tashayyu'*, 842).

¹⁴⁷ *al-Dharī'a*, 14/140.

¹⁴⁸ See e.g. MS Majlis 10196 f. 330a. Cf. 'Alā' al-Dawla Simnānī's (d. 736/1336) *Manāẓir al-Maḥādīr li-l-Munāẓir al-Ḥādīr*, described by Jamal Elias (*The Throne Carrier*, 182-83) as follows: "The treatise is based in large part on quotations from the *Nahj al-balāgha*. It is similar in style and attitude to Simnānī's other works, combining reverence for the *ahl al-bayt* with condemnation of those who curse 'Ā'isha and the first three caliphs."

Mafāḥiṣ, for example, his *summa* of lettrism, he speaks of the ontological supremacy of the letter as testified to by quranic verses and hadiths traced to the Prophet, as well as to the *ṣaḥāba* and the *tābiʿūn*, to which category ʿAlī and Ḥusayn are assigned.¹⁴⁹ Ṣāʿin al-Dīn follows this passage with a catalogue of statements in support of the same point made by various of the righteous *salaf*, including most notably Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal (d. 241/855) and al-Shāfiʿī (d. 204/820), who in upholding the doctrine of the uncreated nature of the Quran defend the eternality of its every letter; in this context, Zamakhsharī's (d. 538/1144) failure to appreciate the supreme virtue inherent in the quranic letters is singled out for censure. The author ends this interlude by exhorting the less intelligent and more fractious of his readers (*al-ghabī wa-l-muʿānid*) to adhere in this matter to 'the way of the pious forebears and the path of the folk of the Sunna' (*ṭarīqat al-salaf wa-sanān ahl al-sunna*).¹⁵⁰

On the other hand, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn's oeuvre is peppered with features of a more characteristically Shiʿi type. In his commentary on Ibn al-Fāriḍ's *Tāʿiyya al-Kubrā*, the *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*, for example, he significantly alters the second hemistich of line 619 in what would seem to be specifically Shiʿi fashion as follows:

From: *bi-ʿitrati-hi staghnat ʿani l-rusuli l-warā / wa-aṣḥābi-hi wa-l-tābiʿīna l-aʿimmatī*
 I.e.: 'Mankind no longer needs the Messenger, having the Messenger's family and his Companions and Followers, leaders of the faith'

To: *... / wa-awlādi-hi wa-l-ṭāhirīna l-aʿimmatī*
 I.e.: 'Mankind no longer needs the Messenger, having the Messenger's family, his children and the holy Imams'¹⁵¹

In his commentary on this line Ṣāʿin al-Dīn invokes the *ḥadīth al-thaqalayn*, explicitly equating

¹⁴⁹ MS Majlis 10196 f. 89b.

¹⁵⁰ MS Majlis 10196 ff. 89b-90a. It is telling that Ṣāʿin al-Dīn here considers the need to list the righteous *salaf* who supported the doctrine of the uncreated Quran to be a concession to the unintelligent, whereas the intellectual and spiritual elite, he implies, consider devotion to the Imams as guardians of the uncreated, all-creative letters a given.

¹⁵¹ *SND*, 269; cf. *Dīwān Ibn al-Fāriḍ* 128 l. 614/620.

the second ‘weighty thing’ with the Prophetic family (*‘itra*), rather than with the Sunna.¹⁵²

In the epilogue to his *R. Anjām*, furthermore, he cites a tradition that simultaneously supports the quintessential Islamicness of lettrism and expresses a pro-Shi‘i disapproval of the course of early Islamic history:

An instance is cited by al-Tha‘ālibī who reports that when the holy verse *ḤM ‘SQ* (Q 42:1-2) was revealed the Prophet appeared to be overcome by exhaustion. A group of Companions who were with him at the time asked ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib, governor of the realm of sanctified power (*valāyat/vilāyat*) and intimate in the harem of mysteries, what untoward event had caused this exhaustion in the Prophet’s blessed constitution. After looking into the matter ‘Alī informed them that it was on account of the verse which had just been revealed, “for it indicates that the Prophet’s noble community will after the expiration of the period of guidance treat his exalted family most improperly (*bī-adabī*).”¹⁵³

What then was Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s confessional position? We need look no further than his millenarian brand of esotericism in the context of its early 9th/15th century Iranian milieu to conclude that in confessional terms he was, simply put, a Shi‘i-Sunni, being far more interested in unification and synthesis driven by the upward cycling of prophetic history than in atomizing sectarian divisiveness and polemic—both-and, not either-or.¹⁵⁴ Even in his stridently Sunni apologies, he alerts the careful reader to his disgust with confessionalist posturing by drawing a facile equivalency between Shi‘ism, Mu‘tazilism and *falsafa*, all hopelessly opposed to the Sunna,¹⁵⁵ and presenting himself as a standard-issue Ash‘ari scholar. As will become

¹⁵² *SND*, 269. However, Ṣā’in al-Dīn does not hesitate to acknowledge the important roles of Abū Bakr, ‘Umar and ‘Uthmān in early Islam as described in three verses almost immediately following (ll. 621-3), while reserving his highest praise for ‘Alī as the repository of all knowledge (l. 624) (*SND*, 270).

¹⁵³ *R. Anjām*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 159a. See Part 2, §T.3 for an edition and translation of this treatise.

¹⁵⁴ Cf. his nephew Afzal al-Dīn’s translation of Shahrastānī’s *K. al-Milal wa-l-Niḥal*, entitled *Tanqīḥ al-Adilla wa-l-‘Ilal*, which expands on the original with detailed arguments disproving the doctrines of all non-Sunni groups. On the replacement of Chinggis Khān by ‘Alī as legitimizing political symbol in early Timurid Iran see Moin, “Islam and the Millennium,” 56-76.

¹⁵⁵ “*Nafsāt al-Maṣdūr I*,” 174-5. He extends this to say, moreover, that all Sufis are Sunnis by necessity. However, it should be noted that Ṣā’in al-Dīn, as a lettrist, necessarily holds the Quran to be uncreated, and was thus very much at odds with the Mu‘tazila on this point.

patently clear in the course of this study, this is a self-misrepresentation so exaggerated as to be cartoonish.¹⁵⁶

¹⁵⁶ Indeed, among the very few marginal notes on a copy of this apology (MS Majlis 10004 pp. 230-1) are several expressing amazement at this stock dismissal, one of which exclaims: *‘ajab ast īn qawl az misl-i īn ṣāhib-i kamāl!*—how could such a scholar known for his enlightened Shi‘i and mystical views perpetrate such a *reductio ad absurdum* here? Cf. Āqā Buzurg Ṭīhrānī’s conclusion that Ṣā’īn al-Dīn, an obvious Shi‘i, is simply exercising *taqiyya* in his apologies (*al-Dharī‘a*, 9.2/571). Akram Jūdī-Ni‘matī weighs all the evidence in Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s writings and concludes that he was effectively a crypto-Shi‘i in personal outlook, though not necessarily in the sectarian sense of the term (*SND*, lx-lxiii).

2.1: Annotated list of works

Ibn Turka's oeuvre as it is known to date comprises 25 Persian and 19 (or 20) Arabic works (44 or 45 in total), a small Persian/Arabic *dīvān*, one *ijāza*, and a body of correspondence (including 58 letters, letter fragments and notes). Twenty-two of these works have been edited or printed in some form, for which see section one of the bibliography. The list below is based on that given by Akram Jūdī-Ni'matī in the introduction to her edition of the *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*,¹ supplemented from other sources and with corrections where necessary; each work is briefly summarized and all known MS copies are listed.

Where possible, in determining the date of composition for each work I relied on the colophons preserved in the earliest, most complete and most reliable collection of Ibn Turka's works, MS Majlis 10196, which was copied over the last eight years of the author's life and three years past his death; in this MS the incipit and explicit of the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, f. 52a and f. 118b, are written in the author's own hand, suggesting that the copyist was in close contact with the author at various points. I have accordingly analyzed the colophons in this collection in a preliminary attempt to establish a chronology for his writings. In many instances, however, it is impossible to tell whether the date given is the date of composition or the date of transcription; fully half of the MS, representing almost two-thirds of the preserved works, was copied between the years 827-29/1425-27, i.e., the period bracketing Ibn Turka's first trip to

¹ *SND*, lxxxviii-xcix.

Shāhrukh's court at Herat to defend himself against accusations of heresy. That in this half the texts are given in almost perfect chronological order suggests that their dates do not necessarily refer to their date of composition but only their date of transcription; given the circumstances in the author's life during these two and a half years or so, perhaps some of these works were copied as part of the evidence in defense of his orthodoxy. In any event, where a date seems to be the date of transcription rather than of composition, I flag it with an asterisk. The second half of the MS is less problematic, as the works are not in chronological order and cover the years 829-38/1427-35, with perhaps no more than two copied after Ibn Turka's death. I thus assume dates given in this half of the MS are more likely to be or approximate the date of composition, and that places, when specified, refer to the place of composition or a nearby location.²

The range of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's writings reflects the relative importance he assigns to various epistemological modes as laid out in his intellectual hierarchy, discussed in particular in *R. Shaqq-i Qamar* and *R. Madārij Afhām al-Afwāj* (on which see Chapter 6). That is to say, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's lettrist works dominate his oeuvre, followed closely by works synthesizing Ibn 'Arabī's brand of theoretical mysticism with both illuminationist and peripatetic philosophy. Theology and hadith are by no means absent, but are soon sublimated into higher modes (in his view) of thought. Ibn Turka takes particular satisfaction, it appears, in demonstrating the meaning of a quranic verse or a hadith at every epistemological level simultaneously; indeed, this methodical, hierarchical approach to knowing pervades his thought. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's major works show this range: *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, his magnum opus, a *summa* of lettrist theory; *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*, a lettrist commentary on Ibn 'Arabī's most famous work; *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*, an ornate commentary on Ibn al-Fāriḍ's *Tā'iyya al-Kubrā* in the new anthology-as-commentary genre; *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, a synthesis of Ibn 'Arabian mystical theory and peripatetic and

² This reconstructed chronology of writings is incorporated into the chronology of events, §A.1 above; it is of course subject to revision if new data come to light.

illuminationist philosophy on the topic of absolute being; *K. al-Manāhij*, a manual of logic in the Avicennan mode; *Munāẓarāt-i Khams*, a philosophical romance in ornate prose. Of these all but the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* has been recently published in Iran in excellent editions. Ibn Turka's literary concerns must also be noted; several of the works just listed are written in an ornate prosimetrical style embracing the whole of the Persian and Arabic literary traditions.

Six sections follow below: 1) Collections of Ibn Turka's works; 2) known major and minor works; 3) correspondence (*munsha'āt*); 4) *ijāzas*; 5) untitled works; and 6) (mis)attributed or mistitled works. The MSS cited for each entry are arranged according to their date of completion, if known. The MS lists in section one after each extant work are by no means exhaustive, but hint at the relative impact of each, primarily in Iran and Anatolia.³

2.1.1: Collections of Ibn Turka's works

1. MS 10196, 425 ff., Majlis Library, Tehran, copied between 828-41/1425-37.⁴ The earliest, most complete and most reliable collection of Ibn Turka's works, containing 35 of his major and minor works, together with selections from his poetry; 15 items of correspondence with various individuals, an *ijāza* and other incidental material are preserved in the margins. According to marginal notes, one work in the collection, *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, features an incipit and explicit in the author's own hand, which is easily distinguishable from the rest of the text, and the *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam* likewise features an autograph note at the end; in any event, the copyist⁵ seems to have accompanied the author during the period of his exile after the trial of 830/1427. Many of the works in this collection bear colophons that occasionally give both the date of composition and the date of copying, but more usually only the date of copying, providing a *terminus ad quem* for the composition of the works in question. Folios 374b-75b contain an interjected fragment from the preface to Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's *Ḥulal-i Muṭarrāz*, and a note on f. 52a indicates that marginal comments followed by *F* are by Sharaf al-Dīn. This important *majmū'a* was previously owned by Mullā 'Alī Nūrī (d. 1246/1831) and Muḥammad Taqī Bahār (d. 1370/1951), and features a number of marginal comments

³ Many of the MSS in Iran as listed here are taken from the union catalog of Muṣṭafā Dirāyatī (*Fihristvāra-yi Dastnvisht-hā-yi Īrān*, 2010). Note that microfilm entries from the Tehran University Central Library do not usually indicate from which MS they are taken.

⁴ Previously MSS Majlis 8503-5 and 8387 (Bihbahānī, "Aḥvāl," 110).

⁵ Dānishpazhūh conjectures that the copyist is the Khwāja Zāhīr al-Dīn Muḥammad of the *Munsha'āt-i Turka*, §2.1.3.1, letter 46 ("Majmū'a," 311; cf. MS Majlis 10196 f. 330).

- by the former. It is briefly described in Muḥammad Taqī Dānishpazhūh, “Majmū‘a-yi Rasā’il-i Khujandī,” *Farhang -i Īrān-zamīn*, 14 (1345-46 Sh./1966-67), 307-12.
2. MS 1294, Mishkāṭ Collection, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied in 839/1435 (AB; Munzavī, *Dānishgāh*, 7/2740).
 3. MS 5423 (= TIEM 2054), Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439. It contains 20 of Ibn Turka’s works, together with a selection of his poetry (Ritter and Reinert, “Die persischen,” 192).
 4. MS 1825, Veliyuddin Collection, Beyazıt Library, Istanbul, copied in Abarquh on 16 Jumādā II 851/29 August 1447; the *majmū‘a* also contains works by Ḥusayn Kh‘ārazmī, ‘Azīz Nasafī, etc. (Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1027). A microfilm copy (442) is held at the Tehran University Central Library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mikrūfilm-hā*, 1/476).
 5. MS Arabic BIJ 1238/3, British Library, London, a copy from the royal library of the Bijapur Sultanate made between 869-71/1465-67; it is heavily repaired, many folios are mixed and the margins are cut. Among other works, it includes the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, *Tamhīd al-Qawā‘id*, *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*, and *R. Nuqṭa*.
 6. Unnumbered *majmū‘a*, Bāqir Riqqat Collection, Tehran, copied by ‘Abd al-Qādir b. Muḥammad b. Afzal Khurāsānī and completed on 16 Jumādā II 901/2 March 1496. It contains ten of Ibn Turka’s shorter treatises, together with a selection of his *ghazals* and *rubā‘īs* (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 5/624).
 7. MS 10003, 216 pp., and MS 10004, 272 pp., Majlis Library, Tehran, copied at the Mas‘ūdiyya madrasa in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98. This two-volume collection includes two longer works (vol. 1) and 17 minor treatises (vol. 2) (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/16).
 8. MS 4029, 54 ff., Malik Library, Tehran, copied in Edirne on 28 Jumādā I 921/10 July 1515. It contains five of the author’s shorter works and two relevant letters (Afshār, *Malik*, 7/153).
 9. Microfilm 2814, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied by Murtaẓā b. Muḥammad Ḥusaynī in 1048/1638; it is a copy of an unspecified MS containing five of the author’s shorter works (Dānishpazhūh, *Mikrūfilm-hā*, 1/734).
 10. MS 3035, 247 ff., Mar‘ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī and completed on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673. It contains 19 of the author’s shorter works (Ḥusaynī, *Mar‘ashī*, 8/227).
 11. MS 326, 501 ff., Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677 and containing 15 treatises and two *masnavīs*, the first 10 by Ibn Turka. A colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishkada*, 3/51). The opening folios contain a note of Sunni bent: *īn rasā’il-i mutabarraka az taṣānīf-i afzal al-muḥaqqiqīn u akmal al-mudaqqiqīn-i zū l-taṣānīf al-‘adīda mawlānā Ṣā’īn al-Dīn Turka qaddasa sirra-hu wa-razzaqa-nā birra-hu bi ṭarīqa-yi ahl-i sunnat* (AB).
 12. MS 810d, Faculty of Theology Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied in 1087/1676 (AB; Ḥujjatī, *Dānishkada*, 399).
 13. MS 2002, 62 ff., New Series, Princeton University Library, copied by ‘Alam al-Hudā Ibn Muḥammad al-Muḥsin in 1093/1682 (?); it contains the *Munāẓarāt-i Khams* and four shorter works (Mach and Ormsby, *Princeton*, 257, no. 1123).
 14. MS Add. 16839, British Library, London, copied at the end of the 11th/17th century; it contains nine of the author’s treatises as part of a larger a collection of various writings on mystical, occult, philosophical and Shī‘i themes (Rieu, *Supplement*, 2/833).
 15. MS 10319, Majlis Library, Tehran, undated; it contains three of Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s lettrist works, including *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, *R. Ḥurūf*, and *R. al-Inzāliyya* (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/319-21). Note that this collection also contains Ibn Sīnā’s *R. al-Nayrūziyya fī Ma‘ānī l-Ḥurūf al-*

Hijā'īyya (no. 5, pp. 603-5).

16. MS 2930, 501 ff., Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, an undated collection of three major and 10 minor works (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 3/48).
17. MS 124, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran (Bihbahānī, “Aḥvāl,” 111).
18. MS 5858 (= MS 360), Sa'īd Nafīsī Collection, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied by Murtaẓā b. Muḥammad Ḥusaynī in Jumādā I 1048/September 1638 (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 16/109). A microfilm copy (2814) is held at the same library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfīlm-hā*, 1/734).
19. MS 32-Bahār, Majlis Library, Tehran, an undated collection (*Nashriyya*, 5/670).

Other possible collections of Ibn Turka's works include three at the Central Library of Tehran University, MS 431, MS 3231 and MS 5244 (Bihbahānī, “Aḥvāl,” 111).

2.1.2: Ibn Turka's major and minor works

1. *Anjām* or *Taṣavvuf u Ḥurūf* (Persian), ‘Conclusion,’ ‘Sufism and Lettrism’

Variant titles: *Rah-Anjām*, *R. dar Tamyīz-i 'Ilm-i Ḥurūf az Taṣavvuf*, *Maqṣūd az 'Ilm-i Taṣavvuf u Ḥurūf*⁶

1. MS 10196, ff. 158a-60a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 17 Dhū l-Qa'da 828/30 September 1425 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/239).
2. MS 5423, ff. 178b-83a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 10004, pp. 153-62, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/14).⁷
4. MS 1825, Veliyuddin Collection, Beyazit Library, Istanbul, copied in Abarquh on 16 Jumādā II 851/29 August 1447; the *majmū'a* also contains works by Ḥusayn Kh'ārazmī, 'Azīz Nasafī, etc. (Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1027). A microfilm copy (442) is held at the Tehran University Central Library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfīlm-hā*, 1/476).
5. MS 9263/6, ff. 182b-92b, Mar'arshī Library, Qom, copied in Jumādā II 1061/June 1651 (AB).
6. MS 3035/14, ff. 125b-31b, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/233).
7. MS 326/6, Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677; a colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishkada*, 3/51).⁸

⁶ Munzavī notes the existence of a copy entitled *Rah Anjām u Jāmi'-i Aṭvār-i 'Ilm-i Ḥurūf* (*Fihrist*, 2/1027).

⁷ This copy is mentioned by Āqā Buzurg Ṭihrānī (*al-Dharī'a*, 22/112, no. 6315).

⁸ This copy is mentioned by Āqā Buzurg Ṭihrānī (*al-Dharī'a*, 22/112, no. 6315).

8. MS 7136/5, ff. 50a-57a, Millī Library, Tehran, copied by Muḥammad Taqī b. Abī l-Ḥasan in 1093/1682 (*Anvār, Millī*, 4/439).⁹
9. MS Add. 16839, btw. ff. 32-62, British Library, London, copied at the end of the 11th/17th century; this text occurs with eight others by the author in a collection of various writings on mystical, occult, philosophical and Shi'i themes (Rieu, *Supplement*, 2/833).

A comparison of Sufism with the science of letters. It consists of an introduction on the importance of knowledge and two sections (*vaṣl*): 1) the science of Sufism and its objectives; 2) the science of letters and its objectives. An epilogue gives three accounts in support of the latter, two from the Imams and another on the nature of the sura-initial *muqatta'āt* as containing predictive knowledge, especially of political events. In section two the author refers the reader to the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* for more detail. It was completed on 17 Dhū l-Qa'da 828/30 September 1425.¹⁰

Published: Ibrāhīm Dībājī, ed., “*Risāla-yi Anjām az Ṣāyīn al-Dīn ‘Alī Turka Khujandī Iṣfahānī*,” *Nashriyya-yi Dānishkada-yi Adabiyyāt u ‘Ulūm-i Insānī-yi Dānishgāh-i Tih-rān*, 97-98 (Spring-Summer 1356 Sh.), 154-81. I have re-edited this treatise on the basis of earlier MSS and translated it in Part 2 of this dissertation (§T.3).

2. *R. al-Arba‘īniyya* (Arabic), ‘On the Number Forty’

Variant title: *Khaṣā’iṣ ‘Adad al-Arba‘īn*

1. MS 10196, ff. 120b-21a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 13 Jumādā II 828/2 May 1425.
2. MS 312/10, Imām Ṣādiq Madrasa, Qazvin, copied in Rabīʿ II 1272/February 1856 (Marāghī, *Imām Ṣādiq*, 1/314).
3. MS 2930, ff. 115b-118a, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, undated (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 4/371).

⁹ Possibly identical to MS 1962 in the same library.

¹⁰ Cf. Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharīʿa*, 22/112, no. 6315, who calls the treatise *Maqṣūd az ‘Ilm-i Taṣavvuf*; cf. also cf. the *Rah-Anjām-nāma* of Bābā Afzal Kāshānī, MS Majlis 4868/8 and MS Majlis 10304/13.

A brief commentary on the hadith *man ḥaḍiṭa arbaʿīna ḥadīth^{an}*. It was written at the instance of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (*al-ḥaḍra al-sayyidiyya ṣāhib walāyat al-wilāya wa-mālik mamālik al-irshād wa-l-hidāya*) for the latter's son Nūr al-Dīn; the author opens with a prayer of thanks that he was led to Akhlāṭī's circle. It was completed before 13 Jumādā II 828/2 May 1425.

Unpublished.

3. *Asrār al-Ṣalāt* (Persian), 'The Mysteries of Ritual Prayer'

1. MS 10196, ff. 129b-39a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd on 26 Ramaḍān 828/11 August 1425.¹¹
2. MS 5423, ff. 215b-36a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 1825, Veliyuddin Collection, Beyazıt Library, Istanbul, copied in Abarquh on 16 Jumādā II 851/29 August 1447; the *majmūʿa* also contains works by Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī, ʿAzīz Nasaḥī, etc. (Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1027). A microfilm copy (442) is held at the Tehran University Central Library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/476).
4. Unnumbered *majmūʿa* (no. 3), Bāqir Riqqat Collection, Tehran, copied by ʿAbd al-Qādir b. Muḥammad b. Afzal Khurāsānī on 16 Jumādā II 901/2 March 1496 (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 5/624).
5. MS 1117, ff. 196b-218b, New Series, Princeton University Library, a collection of Sufi texts copied from 903/1498 onwards.
6. MS 4029/7, 54 ff., Malik Library, Tehran, copied in Edirne on 28 Jumādā I 921/10 July 1515 (Afshār, *Malik*, 7/153).
7. MS 5858 (= MS 360), ff. 89-150, Saʿīd Nafīsī Collection, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied by Murtaẓā b. Muḥammad Ḥusaynī in Jumādā I 1048/September 1638 (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 16/109). A microfilm copy (2814) is held at the same library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/734).
8. MS 3939/6, pp. 94-97, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in the 10th/16th or 11th/17th century; the MS exhibits water damage throughout (AB).
9. MS 9263/2, ff. 65a-115a, Marʿashī Library, Qom, copied in Jumādā II 1061/June 1651 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Marʿashī*, 24/56).
10. MS 3035/16, ff. 139b-68a, Marʿashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Marʿashī*, 8/234).
11. MS 326/1, Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677; a colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishkada*, 3/48, 51).
12. MS 312/11, 30 ff., Imām Ṣādiq Madrasa, Qazvin, undated (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/315).

¹¹ This copy is mistakenly said by Āqā Buzurg Ṭihrānī (*al-Dharīʿa*, 22/112, no. 6315) to have been made on 17 Dhū l-Qaʿda 828, which applies rather to the *R. Anjām*.

13. MS 20/20, Āyatallāh Ḥujajī Library, Najafabad, undated, copied by Muḥammad Qāsim b. Tāj al-Dīn Maḥmūd Ḥusaynī (Ḥāfiẓiyyān, *Ḥujajī*, 46).

On the symbolism and esoteric meaning of the prayer act, treated from mystical and lettrist points of view; attention is also given to the Shafī'i and Hanafi legal positions on the subject. It is referred to in the *R. Su'l al-Mulūk*. It was completed on 21 Jumādā II 820/5 August 1417 in Herat. Treatises with the same title are attributed to Ibn 'Arabī, Ibn Ṭāwūs (d. 664/1266), 'Abd al-Karīm Jīlānī (d. 832/1429), and Ni'mat Allāh Valī (d. 836/1433), though Ibn Turka's treatise is much better represented in Iran than any of these.¹²

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Ṣā' in al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed.

Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 41-100.

4. *Aṭvār-i Salāsa* (Persian), 'The Three Stages/Types [of Sufis]'

Variant titles: *R. dar Taṣavvuf*, *R. fī l-Marātib al-Thalātha min al-Taṣawwuf*

1. MS 10196, ff. 145b-48a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 7 Shawwāl 828/22 August 1425 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/238).
2. MS 1918/21, pp. 185-201, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied by Muḥammad b. Abī Bakr Qanāt Shīrīnī in 828/1425 (AB; Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1044; Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 9/613).
3. MS 5423, ff. 347b-55a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
4. MS 1825, ff. 325-36, Veliyuddin Collection, Beyazıt Library, Istanbul, copied in Abarquh on 16 Jumādā II 851/29 August 1447; the *majmū'a* also contains works by Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī, 'Azīz Nasafī, etc. (Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1027). A microfilm copy (442) is held at the Tehran University Central Library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mikrūfilm-hā*, 1/476).
5. MS Add. 23983, ff. 35-52, British Library, London, copied in Muḥarram 858/January 1454 (Rieu, *Supplement*, 1/42).
6. MS 5, ff. 82-98, *majāmī fārisiyya*, Dār al-Kutub, Cairo, copied by Muḥammad b. Ḥājī Ḥasan Salghurshāh in 864/1460 (*Makhtūṭāt*, 1/202; Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1044).
7. Unnumbered *majmū'a* (no. 8), Bāqir Riqqat Collection, Tehran, copied by 'Abd al-Qādir b. Muḥammad b. Afzal Khurāsānī on 16 Jumādā II 901/2 March 1496 (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 5/624).
8. MS 10004/4, pp. 115-26, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/13).

¹² See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 11/68, no. 423; cf. the *R. fī l-Ṣalāt* or *R. fī Asrār al-Ṣalāt* attributed to Ibn Sīnā in many MSS (Mahdavi, *Fihrist*, no. 85).

9. MS 4029/2, Malik Library, Tehran, copied in Edirne on 28 Jumādā I 921/10 July 1515 (Afshār, 7/153).
10. MS 9596/2, Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad, copied in the early 10th/16th century (AB; Fikrat, *Fihrist-i Alifbā'ī*, 57).
11. MS 1754/8, Amīr al-Mu'minīn Library, Najaf, copied by Sharaf-i Jahān 'Abd al-Rashīd b. 'Abd al-Fattāh Khuzā'ī Naẓarī in 1037/1628 (Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1044).
12. MS 3035/11, ff. 98b-197b, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Šāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/232).
13. MS 326/7, Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677; a colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishkada*, 3/11).
14. MS 1701/3, ff. 30b-46a, 'Allāma Ṭabāṭabā'ī Library, Shiraz, copied in the 11th/17th century (Ḥāfiẓiyyān, *Nuskha-pazhūhī*, 3/169).
15. MS Add. 16839, btw. ff. 32-62, British Library, London, copied at the end of the 11th/17th century; this text occurs with eight others by the author in a collection of various writings on mystical, occult, philosophical and Shi'i themes (Rieu, *Supplement*, 2/833).
16. MS 312/9, 10 ff., Imām Šādiq Madrasa, Qazvin, copied in Rab'ī II 1272/February 1856 (Dānishpazhūh, *Mikrūfilm-hā*, 1/314).
17. MS 1670/1-9/220, 10 ff., Gulpāyagānī Library, Qom, undated; partial copy from near the beginning of the first *aṣl* to the end of the treatise (Dānishpazhūh, 1/433).
18. MS 20/18, Āyatallāh Ḥujajī Library, Najafabad, copied by Muḥammad Qāsim b. Tāj al-Dīn Maḥmūd Ḥusaynī, undated (Ḥāfiẓiyyān, *Hujajī*, 45).
19. MS 930/72, Millī Library, Tehran (Anvār, *Millī*, 4/439).
20. MS D. 22/7, 15 ff., E. G. Browne Collection, Cambridge University Library, undated (Nicholson, *Browne*, 42).

A treatise explicating the three types of Sufi, i.e. the *muḥaqqiqān*, the *abrār*, and the *akhyār*.

It consists of an introduction on the three types, followed by three *aṣls*: 1) on the level of those who achieve *taḥqīq*; 2) on the exposition of realities (*ḥaqā'iq*) in the manner of Ibn 'Arabī; 3) on the formation of the human type (*uṣṣur-i insānī*). It was completed before 7 Shawwāl 828/22 August 1425. The number of surviving early MSS of this work suggests its popularity in the 9th/15th century. Note that Ni'mat Allāh Valī wrote a treatise entitled *Aṭvār-i Ḥikmat* (MS Malik 2571/30).¹³

Published: Ḥusayn Dāvūdī, ed., "Aṭvār-i Salāsa: Risāla'ī az Šā'in al-Dīn Turka," *Ma'ārif*, 9/2 (Murdād-Ābān 1371 Sh./Jul.-Oct. 1992), 45-77 [171-203].

¹³ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 9/53, no. 154; this entry includes a partial list of Šā'in al-Dīn's works, including those not given separate entries.

5. *R. al-Bā'iyya* (Arabic), 'On the B'

1. MS 10196/13, ff. 122b-24a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 14 Ramaḍān 828/30 July 1425 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/237).
2. MS 2930/1, ff. 1b-6a, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, copied on 4 Şafar 845/24 June 1441 (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 3/232).

A short treatise in the lettrist manner in answer to a postulant's question as to why the *bā'* is foremost in precedence among the letters. It was completed before 14 Ramaḍān 828/30 July 1425.

Unpublished; an edition is included in Part 2 of this study (§T.5).

6. *Dīvān* or *Manzūmāt* (Persian, Arabic), Collected Poetry

1. MS 10196, f. 121b., Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in early 828/1425; this page preserves nine Persian and three Arabic *ghazals*, four Persian *rubā'īs*, a Persian *qit'a* and two Persian *mu'ammās*.
2. MS 5423, ff. 147b-49a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439; it contains one *ghazal* and two *rubā'īs*.
3. Unnumbered *majmū'a* (no. 11), Bāqir Riqqat Collection, Tehran, comprising Ibn Turka's *ghazals* and *rubā'īs*, copied by 'Abd al-Qādir b. Muḥammad b. Afzal Khurāsānī on 16 Jumādā II 901/2 March 1496 (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 5/624).
4. MS 4029/4, Malik Library, Tehran, copied in Edirne on 28 Jumādā I 921/10 July 1515; this collection of the poetry of 'Hażrat-i Makhdūmiyya-yi Murshidiyya-yi Muḥibbiyya' includes one *ghazal* and three *rubā'īs* by Ibn Turka (Afshār, *Malik*, 7/153).

Ibn Turka's poetical output appears to have been very modest. His *takhalluṣ* is 'Alī, although some (e.g. Riżā Qulī Khān Hidāyat in his *Majma' al-Fuṣaḥā'* and *Tazkira-yi Riyāz al-Ārifīn*) have mistakenly ascribed to him the pen name Şābir. It is not clear whether a full *dīvān* has been preserved of his poetry, which is scattered throughout his works (e.g. in the *R. Munāẓara-yi Khams*, *R. Aṭvār-i Salāsa*, etc.). MS Majlis 10196 f. 121b preserves eight *ghazals*, eight *rubā'īs*, and

two Arabic fragments by the author.¹⁴

Unpublished, although Ibrāhīm Dībājī reproduces five *ghazals*, three *rubāʿīs* and some Arabic verses attributed to Ibn Turka in the introduction to his edition of the *K. al-Manāḥij* (see below), lx-lxiii; he does not cite his source, but these are clearly drawn from MS Majlis 10196 f. 121b. A selection of nine *rubāʿīs* and a three-line Persian fragment, all taken from Ibn Turka's *R. Munāẓarāt-i Khams* and *R. Aṭvār-i Salāsa*, is attributed to Ibn Turka in 'Abd al-Mannān Naṣr al-Dīn Khujandī's *Tazkira-yi Shu'arā-yi Khujand* (Tehran, 1384 Sh./2005), 116-17; all but four of these, however, are certainly by other poets (viz., Abū Sa'īd b. Abī l-Khayr, Awḥadī Marāgha'ī, Niẓāmī, 'Irāqī, and Ḥāfiẓ).

7. *Ḥurūf* (Persian), 'On the Letters'

Variant titles: *R. Ḥarfiyya*, *R. Ḥarf*, *R. Jāmi'-i Aṭvār-i 'Ilm-i Ḥurūf*

1. MS 10196, ff. 154b-57b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 14 Dhū l-Qa'da 828/27 September 1425 in Yazd (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/239).
2. MS 15/5, pp. 59-72, Adnan Ötügen Collection, National Library, Ankara, copied by 'Abd al-Malik b. Badr al-Balkhī in 833/1429.
3. MS 5423, ff. 138b-47a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
4. MS Add. 23983, ff. 2-20, British Library, London, copied in Muḥarram 858/January 1454 (Rieu, *Supplement*, 1/42).
5. MS 4650/32, ff. 228b-39b, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Aḥmad b. Maḥmūd Mutaṭabbib Tūlamī Gīlānī in 864-66/1460-62 (AB).
6. MS 17/9 *fīrūz*, pp. 155-81, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied by Sulṭān 'Alī in 886/1481 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 21/184).
7. MS 10004, pp. 137-51, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98.
8. Unnumbered *majmū'a* (no. 5 [or 9]), Bāqir Riqqat Collection, Tehran, copied by 'Abd al-Qādir b. Muḥammad b. Afzal Khurāsānī on 16 Jumādā II 901/2 March 1496 (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 5/624).
9. MS Add. 16839, btw. ff. 32-62, British Library, London, copied at the end of the 11th/17th century; this text occurs with eight others by the author in a collection of various writings on mystical, occult, philosophical and Shi'i themes (Rieu, *Supplement*, 2/833).
10. MS 12593/10, pp. 732-48, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied in the 10th/16th century; an

¹⁴ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 9.2/570, no. 3153; no separate diwan is mentioned, but a number of Ṣā'īn al-Dīn's works are listed and his poetry is said to be included in these.

owner's mark at the beginning assigns it to Muḥammad Mu'min b. Mullā Ishāq Harandī, dated Ramaḍān 1173/May 1760.

11. MS 1701/2, ff. 20-30, 'Allāma Ṭabāṭabā'ī Library, Shiraz, copied in the 11th/17th century (Ḥāfiẓiyyān, *Nuskha-pazhūhī*, 3/169).
12. MS 9263/8, ff. 232b-47a, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied in Jumādā II 1061/June 1651 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 24-57).
13. MS 3035/13, ff. 114b-24b, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/233).
14. MS 326/10, Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677; a colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishkada*, 3/54).
15. MS 10319/3, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in the 13th/19th century (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/319).
16. MS 20/16, Āyatallāh Ḥujajī Library, Najafabad, copied by Muḥammad Qāsim b. Tāj al-Dīn Maḥmūd Ḥusaynī, undated (Ḥāfiẓiyyān, *Hujajī*, 44).
17. MS 1298/47, ff. 279a-83b, Walker Collection, Bodleian Library, Oxford, undated; it is here titled *R. Ḥarf* (Beeston, *Catalogue*, 1/col. 804; Rieu, *Supplement*, 1/42). A microfilm of this MS (1142/47) is held at the Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishpazhūh, *Mikrūfilm-hā*, 1/569).
18. MS 8182-8183, Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad, undated (Fikrat, *Fihrist-i Alifbā'ī*, 221).

On the premises and principles of the science of letters, in summary and introductory form. It consists of an introduction on the meaning of the letter and its constituent parts and three sections (*aṣl*), each having four subsections (*vaṣl*): 1) on the written form of the letters; 2) on the spoken form of the letters; 3) on the mental-spiritual form of the letters. An epilogue touches on the meaning of the Doubled Seven (*al-sab' al-mathānī*). In introducing the subject the author distinguishes between two types of lettrist: the *ahl-i khavāṣṣ*, concerned with the practical application of the science, and the *ahl-i ḥaqāyiq*, concerned with larger theoretical issues; the treatise is devoted to the second approach. It was written at the request of a dignitary, perhaps Iskandar Mīrzā, and completed on 10 Ramaḍān 817/23 November 1414 in Shiraz (it mentions the *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*, completed Dhū l-Ḥijja 817/March 1415);¹⁵ a copy appears to have been sent to one Sayyid Niẓām al-Dīn Aḥmad in the same year with accompanying letter (see §2.1.3.1, letter 15). The earliest surviving copy (Majlis 10196) was

¹⁵ I.e., shortly after Iskandar's rebellion against Shāhrukh was violently quashed.

completed on 14 Dhū l-Qa‘da 828/27 September 1425 in Yazd.¹⁶

Unpublished; I provide an edition and translation in Part 2 of the present study (§T.2).

8. *R. al-Inzāliyya* (Arabic), ‘On the Sending Down of Revelation’

1. MS 10196, ff. 126b-28b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 17 Ramaḍān 828/2 August 1425 (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/237).
2. MS 10319/4, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in the 13th/19th century (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/321).

On the revelation of the heavenly Books as treated successively from exoteric (*ahl al-zāhir*), mystical (*ahl al-dhawq*), and finally lettrist (*ahl al-ḥarf*) perspectives. The movement of divine words from above to below is conceptualized into three components: 1) the source of the encompassing movement from above; 2) the human target of this movement, its point of concentration; 3) the medium of this movement between higher and lower. Ibn Turka proceeds to reject two standard views of *inzāl*: the view that revelation entails a spatial movement from heaven to earth as suggested by the term’s linguistic meaning, and the view that revelation entails the emergence of what was hidden; rather, it must be understood in the applied metaphysical sense held by the Sufis. It was completed before 17 Ramaḍān 828/2 August 1425.

Published: Sayyid ‘Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī, “Aḥvāl u Āsār-i Ṣā’ih al-Dīn Turka-yi Iṣfahānī, bi Inẓimām-i *Risāla-yi Inzāliyya-yi Ū*,” in *Collected Papers on Islamic Philosophy and Mysticism*, ed. M. Mohaghegh and H. Landolt, Tehran, 1349 Sh./1971, 97-145.

9. *Iṣbāḥ al-Anwār* (Arabic), ‘Lights’ Dawning’

Variant title: *Sharḥ Ḥadīth al-Īmān* (?)

¹⁶ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī‘a*, 15/321, no. 2058.

1. MS 10196, ff. 404b-16b, Majlis Library, Tehran, partial copy made in 841/1438 (?).

A lettrist treatment of the hadith on the tripartite division *iḥsān-īmān-islām*. This work is mentioned in the *R. Tuḥfa-yi 'Alā'ī* (written 1 Jumādā I 831/17 February 1428 and treating of the same subject) as being incomplete, although the reader is referred to it for more detail; the *R. Muhr al-Nubuwwa* and *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* do so as well. MS Majlis 10196, the only surviving copy, breaks off in the middle of an otherwise empty page at the end of the manuscript; presumably the work was never finished. The section that survives contains references to both the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* and the *R. al-Muḥammadiyya*. In particular, a marginal note in the earliest copy of the *Mafāḥiṣ*, MS 10196 f. 89a, which refers the reader to the *K. al-Iṣbāḥ* for a more detailed and accurate treatment of the question as to why the letter is all-encompassing suggests the author's ambitious plan for the work; it was perhaps conceived of as an even fuller treatment of lettrism than given in the *Mafāḥiṣ*, but left unfinished in the wake of the difficult events of 1427 and the author's subsequent exile.

Unpublished.

10. *Iṣṭilāḥāt al-Ṣūfiyya* or *Iṣṭilāḥāt-i Ṣūfiyān* (Arabic), 'Sufi Terminology'

1. MS 10196, ff. 184a-88b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 25 Rajab 829/2 June 1426.
2. MS 2697/1, pp. 12-29, Millī Library, Tehran, copied by Qurbān 'Alī Nīshābūrī in 1230/1815 (Anvār, *Millī*, 6/274).
3. MS 2930/8, ff. 124b-41a, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, undated (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 3/142).

A list of Sufi terms in *abjadī* (not *alifbā'ī*) order. It was completed before 25 Rajab 829/2 June 1426.

Unpublished.

11. *I'tiqādāt* (Persian), 'Statement of Creed'

Variant titles: *Mu'taqadāt*, *Mu'taqadiyya*, *al-Mu'taqada*, *'Aqīda*, *R. dar I'tiqād*, *Izhār-i I'tiqād*

1. MS 10196, ff. 165b-72a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Herat on 19 Jumādā I 829/29 March 1426 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/240).
2. MS 5423, ff. 241b-56a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 1825, Veliyuddin Collection, Beyazıt Library, Istanbul, copied in Abarquh on 16 Jumādā II 851/29 August 1447; the *majmū'a* also contains works by Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī, 'Azīz Nasaḫī, etc. (Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1027).¹⁷ A microfilm copy (442) is held at the Tehran University Central Library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/476).
4. MS Add. 23983, ff. 131-69, British Library, London, copied in Muḥarram 858/January 1454 (Rieu, *Supplement*, 1/42).
5. MS 10004, pp. 83-114, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/14).¹⁸
6. MS 3035/10, ff. 55b-97a, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/231).
7. MS 326/5, Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677; a colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishkada*, 3/11).
8. Microfilms 829 and 830, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh) (= microfilm 442?).

A lengthy treatise written during Ibn Turka's second trip to Herat to clear his name of accusations of deviation from the Sunna and pro-Sufi bias. It presents the author as a staunch Sunni-Ash'ari and opposed to Mu'tazilism, philosophy, Shi'ism and all forms of messianic Sufism, having as its theme Q 11:54: *I call God to witness as you too witness that I am innocent of that you associate*. It was completed before 19 Jumādā I 829/29 March 1426 (presumably in Herat) as a companion piece to the *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* I and addressed to Shāhrukh.¹⁹

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Ṣā'ib al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed.

Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 221-64.

¹⁷ This copy is mentioned by Āqā Buzurg Ṭihrānī (*al-Dharī'a*, 21/211, no. 4655).

¹⁸ This copy is mentioned by Āqā Buzurg Ṭihrānī (*al-Dharī'a*, 21/211, no. 4655).

¹⁹ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 21/211, no. 4655.

12. *R. I'tiqādiyya* (Persian), 'Statement of Creed'

1. MS 10196, f. 171b, Majlis Library, Tehran, undated copy (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/239).

A very brief statement of creed, in the form of a letter,²⁰ in which Ibn Turka justifies his wide learning in his youth, including forays into sciences at odds with the principles of Sunnism, on the basis of the hadith *ta'allamū ḥattā l-siḥr* ('Learn even sorcery'), in this comparing himself to Ghazālī and Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī. He further says that even if he has carried over anything of the formulations of the Sufi masters this does not impinge in any way on matters of creed. It was presumably written around the same time as the *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* II, written ca. 832-35/1429-32, since it mentions the *R. I'tiqādāt* (here called *R. 'Aqīda*) above; it apparently survives only in MS Majlis 10196.

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed. Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 267-68.

13. *al-Khaṣā'is* (Arabic)

Referred to in the *K. al-Manāhij* as a more comprehensive work on logic in which he engages with the discipline with a wider frame of reference beyond that of the peripatetics and deals with more problematic issues, unlike in the *Manāhij* which is meant as a primer of peripatetic logic; he often relies on Ibn Sīnā. The work does not seem to have ever been finished. Cf. *K. al-Manāhij*, lxxx, xci, 4. In his *R. Ḥurūf* (completed 817/1414) the author refers to another work in progress entitled *Khaṣā'is-i Kamālī*, seemingly lettrist in nature and therefore presumably a different work.

Unpublished; no MS copies are known to survive.

²⁰ Like several of the author's surviving letters, it is signed *kamtārīn-i fuqarā, Ṣā'in-i Turka*.

14. *Khavāṣṣ-i 'Ilm-i Sharf* (Persian), 'On the Special Properties of the Science of Morphology'

Variant titles: *R. dar Ma'nā-yi Khavāṣṣ-i 'Ilm-i Sharf*, *Sharf al-Qulūb*

1. MS 10196, f. 129a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied presumably in Ramaḍān 828/August 1425 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/237).
2. MS 5423, ff. 177b-78a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 10004, pp. 266-67, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/14-15).
4. MS 3035/5, ff. 41b-43a, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/229).
5. Microfilm 827, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh).

On various issues relating to the science of morphology dealt with in a lettrist manner; morphology, that is language itself, is defined as the process wherein singularity becomes multiplicity, and thus mirrors the deepest level of reality. All proceeds from the *maṣḍar*, which in its various iterations becomes first perfect tense verb (*fi'l-i māzī*), then imperfect tense verb (*fi'l-i muẓārī*), command (*amr*), negation (*nahy*), and so on. The pronoun *huwa* is implicit within all such forms, and is the source of all divine names such as First, Last, Manifest, Hidden. One must master multiplicity to attain to the singularity underlying. Cf. the *Naḥw al-Qulūb* of Qushayrī where connections are drawn between the rules of Arabic grammar and the spiritual journey of the mystic.²¹

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed. Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 279-82.

15. *Mabda' u Ma'ād* (Persian), 'Origin and Return'

Variant title: *'Ayn al-Ḥikma*

1. MS 10196, ff. 266b-71a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Ṣafar 832/November 1428 in Chalu, Mazandaran (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/242).

²¹ See Lory, *La science des lettres*, 53.

2. MS 5423, ff. 262b-84b, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. Unnumbered *majmū'a* (no. 6), Bāqir Riqqat Collection, Tehran, copied by 'Abd al-Qādir b. Muḥammad b. Afzal Khurāsānī in 16 Jumādā II 901/2 March 1496 (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 5/624).
4. MS 10004, pp. 47-82, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Hā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/12).
5. MS 9263/7, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied in Jumādī II 1061/June 1651 (Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 24/57).
6. MS 3035/19, ff. 224b-47a, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/236).
7. MS 7136/5, ff. 61b-87a, Millī Library, Tehran, copied by Muḥammad Taqī b. Abī l-Ḥasan in 1093/1682 (Anvār, *Millī*, 4/439).²²
8. MS 1701/5, ff. 54b-71, 'Allāma Ṭabāṭabā'ī Library, Shiraz, copied in the 11th/17th century (Ḥāfiẓiyyān, *Nuskha-pazhūhī*, 3/169).
9. MS 9596/12, pp. 198-218, Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad, copied in the 11th/17th century (Āstān-i Quds, 9/273).
10. MS Add. 16839, btw. ff. 32-62, British Library, London, copied at the end of the 11th/17th century; this text occurs with eight others by the author in a collection of various writings on mystical, occult, philosophical and Shi'i themes (Rieu, *Supplement*, 2/833).
11. MS 4045/8, Malik Library, Tehran, copied in Ṣafar 1275/September 1858 (Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 22/430, no. 7742).
12. MS 4126, pp. 1-136, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh),²³ copied in 1294/1877; it gives the title *'Ayn al-Ḥikma* (AB).
13. MS 177-*mīm*, *adab fārisī*, Dār al-Kutub, Cairo, an undated copy featuring gilding (Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 22/430, no. 7742).

In the introduction Ibn Turka states that it was written at the request of one Shāh Raẓī l-Dīn that he write something on this subject in the mystical manner that would give an overview of the contemporary terrain of the religious sciences. It consists of an introduction on the divisions of the human type, and two chapters (*bāb*): 1) origin and return as formulated by exoteric theoreticians; 2) the same subject as formulated by Sufis; an epilogue summarizes the conclusions that may be drawn from this. It was completed early Ṣafar 832/mid-November 1428 at Manzil-i Chālū (Mazandaran).²⁴

²² Possibly identical to MS 1962 at the same library.

²³ Or possibly the Majlis Library.

²⁴ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 19/51, no. 268; cf. 22/430, no. 7742.

Unpublished.

16. *Madārij Afhām al-Afvāj fi Tafsīr Āyat Samāniyat Azvāj* (Persian), ‘On the Levels of Understanding of Various Groups as to the Exegesis of the Verse *Eight Couples*’

1. MS 10196, ff. 352b-59b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 6 Dhū l-Qa‘da 831/17 August 1428 (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/242).
2. MS 5423, ff. 285b-310a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 10004, pp. 1-46, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/12).
4. MS 3035/18, ff. 194b-223b, Mar‘ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar‘ashī*, 8/236).

A relatively detailed commentary on Q 6:143-44: *Eight couples: two of sheep, two of goats ... two of camels, two of oxen*. It consists of two sections (*maqāla*): 1) treating of the passage in the manner of exoteric scholars and Quran commentators; 2) treating of the passage in the manner of esoteric scholars and Sufi masters. More broadly, the treatise comprises seven subsections corresponding to the levels of esoteric realization and arranged in ascending order, to wit, the passage’s interpretation according to 1) exoteric exegetes; 2) Sufis of outward practice; 3) philosophers; 4) the ‘verifiers’ (*muḥaqqiqān*) among the Sufis; 5) the Sufi elite (*ṣurafā’*); 6) those who can understand the language of the prophets and interpret the forms of the revelations they have brought; and finally 7) the members of the House of the Prophet and those who can riddle their cryptic utterances from among the saints of Islam, and the sages of antiquity, disciples of the prophets of God. It was completed on 6 Dhū l-Qa‘da 831/17 August 1428 in Mazandaran and written at the request of a local ruler.²⁵

Published: Najīb Māyil Haravī, ed., “*Madārij al-Afhām*,” *Kayhān-i Andīsha*, 17-18 (1367 Sh./1988), 48-73, 67-93.

²⁵ Perhaps Sayyid Murtaẓā Mar‘ashī; cf. §2.1.3.1, letter 28 below.

17. *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* (Arabic), 'Book of Inquiries'

Variant title: *al-Mafāḥiṣ min al-'Ulūm al-Ilāhiyya*

1. MS 10196/2, ff. 52-118, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in 823/1420; this copy contains autograph sections at the beginning and end of the work, with authorial interpolations and explanations in the margins throughout (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/236).
2. MS 146, ff. 1-179, Landberg Collection, Beinecke Library, Yale University, copied in 823/1420 (?) and collated with the authoritative copy; an audition note states that the author read the work and made additions in the presence of Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī and a group of companions and disciples in 828/1425.
3. MS 155, 195 ff., Šādiqiyya Library, Damghan, copied on 7 Rajab 825/27 June 1422 (handlist, 220).
4. MS 626, ff. 1b-136a, Kılıç Ali Paşa Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in 833/1430.
5. MS 6371, ff. 1-90, Malik Library, Tehran, copied by Sulaymān b. Muẓaffar Ḥusaynī on 2 Jumādā II 853/23 July 1449 (Afshār, *Malik*, 1/519).
6. MS Arabic BIJ 1238/3, British Library, London, a copy from the royal library of the Bijapur Sultanate made between 869-71/1465-67; it is heavily repaired, many folios are mixed and the margins are cut.
7. MS 121, 283 ff., Namāzī Madrasa, Khuy, copied in the 9th/15th century (Khū'ī, *Namāzī*, 70).
8. Microfilm 266, 283 pp., Markaz-i Iḥyā'-i Mīrās-i Islāmī, Qom, taken from a copy (MS 121) in the Namāzī madrasa, Khuy, made in the 9th/15th or 10th/16th century (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī* ('Aksī), 1/308).
9. MS 231, Selimiye Library, Edirne, copied in 985/1577 (*Yazmalar*).
10. Microfilm 100, 141 ff., Mar'ashī Library, Qom, taken from a copy in the Namāzī madrasa, Khuy, made in the 10th/16th (?) century; it includes marginal corrections, and was endowed by Ibrāhīm al-Sharīf al-Ḥusaynī in 1230/1815 (Ḥā'irī, *Mar'ashī*, 1/103).
11. MS 1536, ff. 1-157, Malik Library, copied in Muḥarram 1066/November 1655 (Afshār, *Malik*, 1/519).
12. MS 10105, ff. 1a-207b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in the 11th/17th century (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/130).
13. MS 430, 98 ff., Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied on 2 Sha'bān 1077/28 January 1667 (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 3/498).
14. MS 10025, 185 ff., Majlis Library, Tehran, copied by 'Uẓmā b. Mashhadī Fīrūzābādī on 10 Šafar 1078/1 August 1667 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 3/498).
15. MS 810d/5, ff. 51b-155b, Faculty of Theology Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an incomplete copy made in Jumādā I 1087/July 1676 (AB; Ḥujjatī, *Dānishkada*, 399).
16. MS 85 (385), Asiatic Society Library, Calcutta, copied in 1117/1705 and attributed to Raẓī l-Dīn Abū Naṣr al-Ḥasan b. al-Faẓl al-Ṭabrisī ('Alī, *Asiatic*, 298).
17. MS 4280, Ayasofya Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in 1124/1712 (*Yazmalar*).
18. MS 5781, Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad, copied in 1204/1790 (Fikrat, *Fihrist-i Alifbā'ī*, 552).²⁶

²⁶ To be identified with the copy mentioned by Āqā Buzurg Ṭihrānī in *al-Dharī'a*, 21/309, no. 5218, being part of the *waqf* of al-Ḥājj 'Imād.

19. MS 10319/2, ff. 429-599, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in the 13th/19th century (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/319).
20. MS 3543, 130 ff., Mar'ashī Library, Qom, undated (Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 9/337).
21. MS 432/5, Āl Jamāl al-Dīn Collection, Sūq al-Shuyūkh, Iraq, undated.²⁷
22. MS 1731, ff. 1b-208b, Esad Efendi Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, undated (*Yazmalar*).
23. MS 1102, Carullah Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, undated (*Yazmalar*).
24. MS 1411, Şehit Ali Paşa Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, undated (*Yazmalar*).
25. MS 3519, Beyazıt Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, undated (*Yazmalar*).

On numerology, the science of letters and language symbology, intended to show the roots of all manifestation in the One and the mechanics of multiplicity's derivation therefrom. It is a *summa* of lettrist doctrine, and treats of the letter in its three primary aspects—numerological, symbological and phonological—, as well as the letter as it is in itself and in the context of language and literature. Citing Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī as his main oral source and Ibn 'Arabī and Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī as his main textual sources, Ibn Turka opens the work with an exordium on the excellence of the divine sciences, identifying three ways in which they may be successfully pursued which nevertheless differ in specific levels or modes of attainment: 1) the way of those who deal with the realities behind the forms of the letters making up the names of things; 2) that of those who deal both with the form and meaning of letters; 3) that of those who attain to the inner essence of the realities by way of numerology (*'ilm-i a'dād*), this last method being peculiar to 'Alī who received it via the Prophetic legacy. Among its various diagrams, the book includes a master diagram, the Ṭahawī Circle, that functions as a cosmological key encompassing the cosmos in its *wujūdī* and *kawnī* aspects; its importance to Ṣā'in al-Dīn's thought is indicated by the fact that he refers to it separately in other works, e.g. the *Iṣbāḥ al-Anwār* (MS Majlis 10196 f. 407b) and the *R. Nuqṭa* (ed. 'Alī Farrukh, 184, 190).²⁸ The *Mafāḥiṣ* also contains master tables referred to as *jadāwil al-baḥr* (see e.g. MS Majlis 10196 ff. 71a-

²⁷ See "Shu'ūn al-Makhṭūṭāt: Makhṭūṭāt Khizānat Āl Jamāl al-Dīn (Qaryat al-Mu'minīn, Sūq al-Shuyūkh, al-'Irāq)," *al-Mawsim*, 1 (1409), 129-61: 142.

²⁸ Confusingly, the Arabic *Sharḥ al-Tā'iyya*, presumably written in Cairo, i.e., before 806/1404 (?), also refers to the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* (ed. Hadizada, 86).

b), intended by the author to be a key or exemplar (*unmūdhaj, dustūr*) for all of the issues treated the same work, from which the experienced student may extrapolate the wisdom realities (*ḥaqā'iq ḥikmiyya*) contained within the letters of revelation. The author reiterates this description of the tables in the *R. Nuqṭa*.

The earliest copy of this work, MS Majlis 10196, features autograph sections at the beginning, middle and end of the copy.²⁹ The same copy contains marginal notes referring to the reader to the author's *Sharḥ al-Basmala* (f. 84a) and his unfinished *K. al-Iṣbāḥ* (f. 89a) respectively for more detail on certain points; the author states his hope to expound more fully on the esoteric aspects of a verse in section 3.7 (f. 85a). The main text also refers the reader to the author's *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam* (f. 75a), *R. al-Muḥammadiyya* (f. 76a) and *R. Asrār al-Ṣalāt* (f. 77a). It was completed on 1 Sha'bān 823/11 August 1420 (MS Landberg 146) or 19 Dhū l-Ḥijja 823/25 December 1420 (MS Majlis 10196),³⁰ perhaps in Isfahan or Yazd, and revised and expanded in 828/1425;³¹ specifically, MS Landberg 146 contains an audition note at the end stating that the work was proofread and notes were added to it by the author in the company of Yazdī and a group of 'friends, students and children' (*fī jam' min al-khullān wa-ṭā'ifa min al-tullāb wa-l-wildān*) in 828/1425.³²

Unpublished; I am in the process of editing this work on the basis of four of its five earliest copies, all made during the author's lifetime.

²⁹ See appendix P.3 for these examples of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's handwriting from MS Majlis 10196.

³⁰ This date is supported by the entry on IT in 'Abd Allāh Afandī's *Riyāḍ al-'Ulamā'*, pt. 4, 240.

³¹ MS Majlis 10196 states in a marginal correction to Ṣā'in al-Dīn's autograph colophon that this date refers to its copying (*taswīd*) only.

³² See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 21/309, no. 5218; Isfahānī, *Riyāḍ al-'Ulamā'*, 4/240; Mudarris Tabrīzī, *Rayḥānat al-Adab*, 2/166. Cf. Āqā Buzurg's reference (*al-Dharī'a*, 2/44, no. 172) to a *R. Asrār al-Ḥurūf* by Mawlawī Aḥmad b. al-Qāḍī Naṣr Allāh al-Dabīlī al-Tatawī al-Mustabshir (d. 998/1590) as being written in the manner of the *Mafāḥiṣ*.

18. *K. al-Manāhij* (Arabic), 'Book of Methods'

1. MS 10196, ff. 382b-404a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Natanz on 20 Rajab 833/14 April 1430.
2. MS 2930/12, ff. 386b-460a, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, copied in Abarquh on 8 Jumādā I 845/14 September 1441 (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 5/656).
3. Microfilm 1049, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), undated (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/387).
4. Microfilm 1097, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), undated (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/387).
5. Microfilm 1111, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), undated (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/387).

A treatise on logic in the manner of the latter-day philosophers (*muta'akhkhirūn*); all issues are dealt with in minute detail. In places it references the relevant section of Ibn Sīnā's *Shifā'*. It consists of a general introduction to the science, followed by four methods (sg. *manhaj*). While Ibn Turka does follow the contemporary method in the main, e.g. in the four-term syllogism, far from rejecting the views of the ancient philosophers on this subject he at points prefers them to contemporary views.³³ He wrote the work for his son Muḥammad. It was completed on 20 Rajab 833/14 April 1430 in Natanz.³⁴

Published: *K. al-Manāhij fī l-Manṭiq*, ed. Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1376 Sh./1997.

19. *R. al-Muḥammadiyya* (Arabic), 'On the Name Muḥammad'

1. MS 10196, ff. 139b-45a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 5 Shawwāl 828/20 August 1425 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/240).
2. (?), Majlis Library, Tehran (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/238).
3. MS 2930/3, ff. 91b-111b, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, copied in Abarquh on 23 Šafar 845/13 July 1441 (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 5/523).

On the properties of the name Muḥammad dealt with in a lettrist manner. It deals in

³³ See El-Rouayheb, *Relational Syllogisms*, 145.

³⁴ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 22/339, no. 7349; here it is incorrectly identified as an Arabic work on 'irfān.

particular with the issue of how the rulings of the Muḥammadic law were derived without reference to any of the intellectual sciences. The *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* is referenced at the end of the preface. It was completed before 5 Shawwāl 828/20 August 1425.*

Unpublished.

20. *Muḥr al-Nubuwwa* (Arabic), ‘The Seal of Prophethood’

1. MS 10196, f. 189a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 4 Jumādā II 831/21 March 1428³⁵ (Ḥāʾirī, *Majlis*, 32/240).
2. MS 2930/4, ff. 112b-115a, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, undated (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 5/691).
3. MS 2002/4, ff. 57b-59b, New Series, Princeton University Library, copied by ʿAlam al-Hudā Ibn Muḥammad al-Muḥsin in 1094/1683 (Mach and Ormsby, *Princeton*, 257, no. 1123).

Consisting of a preface and two sections. At the end the author refers his readers to the *K. al-Iṣbāḥ*. Completed before 4 Jumādā II 831/21 March 1428 in Shiraz.*³⁶

Unpublished.

21. *Munāẓara-yi Bazm u Razm* (Persian), ‘The Debate of Fight and Feast’

1. MS 10196, ff. 162b-65a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 20 Rabīʿ II 829/1 March 1426³⁷ (Ḥāʾirī, *Majlis*, 32/239).
2. MS 5423, ff. 256b-62a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 1825, Veliyuddin Collection, Beyazıt Library, Istanbul, copied in Abarquh on 16 Jumādā II 851/29 August 1447; the *majmūʿa* also contains works by Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī, ʿAzīz Nasaḫī, etc. (Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1027).³⁸ A microfilm copy (442) is held at the Tehran University Central Library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mikrūfilm-hā*, 1/476).

³⁵ This date is given by Āqā Buzurg (*al-Dharīʿa*, 22/296, no. 9048).

³⁶ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharīʿa*, 22/296, no. 9048.

³⁷ This date is given by Āqā Buzurg (*al-Dharīʿa*, 22/293, no. 7152).

³⁸ This copy is mentioned by Āqā Buzurg (*al-Dharīʿa*, 22/293, no. 7152).

4. MS 10004, pp. 211-22, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/15).
5. MS 3035/1, ff. 1b-10a, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/227).
6. MS 326/9, Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677; a colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishkada*, 3/12).
7. MS 2002/2, ff. 47a-56a, New Series, Princeton University Library, copied by 'Alam al-Hudā Ibn Muḥammad al-Muḥsin in 1093/1682 (?).
8. MS 4354, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by one Mahdī in 1312/1895 (AB).

An ornate *munāẓara* between the sword and the pen, couched in mystical style, and similar in theme to the R. 'Aql u 'Ishq. The two parties are represented by the courtly elite at the banqueting (*bazm*) hall of Beauty vs. the dread and warlike (*razm*) rulers of the court of Majesty, who together constitute the dichotomy of feasting and fighting; each asserts its superiority on the basis of arguments drawn from reason and tradition. Finally Sultan 'Ishq summons both reason ('aql) and experiential intuition (*zawq*) and judges between them, with the verdict that all worldly and religious affairs are furthered by them both in equal measure, such that neither may claim precedence. Written for Bāysunghur,³⁹ it was completed before 25 Rabī' II 829/6 March 1426 in Herat.*⁴⁰

Unpublished.

22. *Munāẓarāt-i Khams* or 'Aql u 'Ishq (Persian), 'The Five Debates,' 'Love and Reason'

Variant titles: *Munāẓara-yi 'Aql u 'Ishq*, *Munāẓarāt-i Khams-i Ṣā'iniyya*

1. MS 55744, Millī Library, Tehran, copied in 808/1406 (Anvār, *Millī*, 4/439).
2. MS 5423, ff. 183b-215a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 1825/27, Veliyuddin Collection, Beyazıt Library, Istanbul, copied in Abarquh on 16 Jumādā II 851/29 August 1447; the *majmū'a* also contains works by Ḥusayn Kh'ārazmī,

³⁹ Ritter and Reinert, "Die persischen Dichterhandschriften," 191.

⁴⁰ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 22/293, no. 7152.

- ‘Azīz Nasafī, etc. (Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1027). A microfilm copy (442) is held at the Tehran University Central Library (Dānīshpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/476).⁴¹ This is the earliest and most reliable copy of the work used in the edition by Jūdī-Nī‘matī (*MKh*, 19).
4. MS Add. 23983, ff. 53-130, British Library, London, copied in Muḥarram 858/January 1454 (Rieu, *Supplement*, 1/42).
 5. MS (?), Dār al-Kutub, Cairo, copied in 863/1459 (*MKh*, 21).
 6. MS 2900/1, ff. 1-43, Manisa Public Library, copied in Istanbul by Muṣṭafā b. Aḥmad b. Khidr b. Ṣānī (?) in Ramaḍān 878/1473 (*Yazmalar*).
 7. MS 2042/3, Revan Köşkü Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied by ‘Alī b. Qivām b. Aḥmad, Mawlā Mīrak Ṭabīb, in Rabī I and II 888/May-June 1483; according to the colophon this copy was proofread on 11 Muḥarram 891/17 January 1486 (*MKh*, 19). A microfilm copy (227/3) is held at the Tehran University Central Library (Dānīshpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/436).
 8. MS 2667/7, ff. 344b-391a, Manisa Public Library, copied in 894/1488.
 9. Unnumbered *majmū‘a* (no. 2), Bāqir Rīqqat Collection, Tehran, copied by ‘Abd al-Qādir b. Muḥammad b. Afzal Khurāsānī on 16 Jumādā II 901/2 March 1496 (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 5/624).
 10. MS 10003/2, pp. 161-216, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd on 25 Dhū l-Qa‘da 903/15 July 1498 (Ḥā‘irī, *Majlis*, 32/12).
 11. MS 67/13, ff. 125b-63b, Markaz-i Dā‘irat al-Ma‘ārif-i Buzurg-i Islāmī Library, copied on 20 Shawwāl 1011/2 April 1603 (AB; Munzavī, *Dā‘irat al-Ma‘ārif*, 1/245).
 12. MS 20/21, Āyatallāh Hujajī Library, Najafabad, copied by Muḥammad Qāsim b. Tāj al-Dīn Maḥmūd Ḥusaynī on 24 Shawwāl 1039/6 June 1630 (Ḥāfiẓiyyān, *Hujajī*, 46).
 13. MS 5858/1 (= MS 360), pp. 1-87, Sa‘īd Nafīsī Collection, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānīshgāh), copied by Murtaẓā b. Muḥammad Ḥusaynī in 1048/1638 (Dānīshpazhūh, *Dānīshgāh*, 16/109). A microfilm copy (2814/1) is held at the same library (Dānīshpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/734).
 14. MS 9263/1, ff. 1b-64a, Mar‘ashī Library, Qom, copied in Jumādā II 1061/June 1651 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar‘ashī*, 24/56).
 15. Microfilm 1182/87, Mar‘ashī Library, Qom, copied on 28 Ṣafar 1063/28 January 1653 (Ḥā‘irī, *Mar‘ashī*, 3/432).
 16. MS 2120, 50 ff., Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in 1073/1663 (Ḥā‘irī, *Majlis*, 6/98).⁴² A microfilm (883) of this MS is held at the Markaz-i Iḥyā‘-i Mīrās-i Islāmī, Qom (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī* (‘Aksī), 3/76).
 17. MS 484, 25 ff., Central Library, Tehran University (Dānīshgāh), copied by ‘Azīz Allāh Ḥusaynī in Jumādā II 1086/1676 (AB).
 18. MS 326/8, Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānīshgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677; a colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānīshpazhūh, *Dānīshkada*, 3/51).⁴³
 19. MS 1962/1, ff. 1b-45a, Millī Library, Tehran, copied by Taqī l-Dīn Muḥammad b. Abī l-Ḥasan in 1093/1682 (*Anvār*, *Millī*, 4/439).⁴⁴

⁴¹ This copy and its microfilm is mentioned by Āqā Buzurg Ṭīhrānī (*al-Dharī‘a*, 22/282, no. 7107).

⁴² This copy is mentioned by Āqā Buzurg Ṭīhrānī (*al-Dharī‘a*, 18/222, no. 112).

⁴³ This copy is mentioned by Āqā Buzurg Ṭīhrānī (*al-Dharī‘a*, 22/282, no. 7107).

⁴⁴ Or MS 7136, pp. 1-82?

20. MS 2002/1, ff. 2b-46b, New Series, Princeton University Library, copied by ‘Alam al-Hudā Ibn Muḥammad al-Muḥsin in 1093/1682 (?).
21. MS 3514/3, ff. 23-27, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied by Muḥammad Muḥsin Burūjirdī in Isfahan in Muḥarram 1097/December 1685 (MKh, 20; AB; Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 12/2523).
22. MS Add. 16839, btw. ff. 32-62, British Library, London, copied at the end of the 11th/17th century; this text occurs with eight others by the author in a collection of various writings on mystical, occult, philosophical and Shi‘i themes (Rieu, *Supplement*, 2/833).
23. MS 935/3-6/25, 27 ff., Gulpāyagānī Library, Qom, copied by Mullā Maqṣūd b. Mashhadī Sayf al-Dīn Shaqqāqī (?) on 7 Rabī‘ I 1133/6 January 1721 (Ḥusaynī, *Gulpāyagānī*, 8/4568).
24. MS 2549/6, ff. 25b-64b, Malik Library, Tehran, copied by Sayyid Muṣṭafā Iṣfahānī on 22 Sha‘bān 1304/16 May 1887 (Afshār, *Malik*, 6/41).
25. MS 3829/2, ff. 12b-61b, Mar‘ashī Library, Qom, undated (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar‘ashī*, 10/208).
26. MS 835, 81 ff., Mishkāt Collection, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), undated; at the end of this copy the title *Gulshan* is given to this work (Munzavī, *Mishkāt*, 3/484).
27. MS 2618/11, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), perhaps copied in the 11th-12th/17th-18th centuries; the end of this copy is missing. The learned copyist provides many useful marginal clarifications (MKh, 20; Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 9/1484).
28. MS 11625, Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad, undated (Fikrat, *Fihrist-i Alifbā’ī*, 553).
29. MS 254, 61 ff., Russian National Library, St. Petersburg, undated (AB).

A popular *munāẓara* work consisting of five debates in an ornate narrative style, and clearly influenced by the allegorical tales of Ibn Sīnā and especially Suhrawardī. In this narrative the interior faculties debate each other, in the course of their debates solving many problems of philosophy and mystical theory, especially the issue of reason vs. love.⁴⁵ The five *munāẓaras* may be characterized as follows: 1) that between the partisans of ‘*aql* and the partisans of ‘*ishq*; 2) that between *vahm* and ‘*aql*; 3) that between *vahm* and *khayāl*; 4) that between hearing and sight; 5) that between lover and beloved. It was completed in Muḥarram 808/June-July 1405 (cf. MS Millī 55744, completed in 808/1406). In MS Mishkāt 835 the work is entitled *Gulshan*. It

⁴⁵ Cf. Najm al-Dīn Rāzī’s (d. 654/1256) similarly-themed ‘*Ishq u ‘Aql*.

mentions the author's *Tamhīdāt* (i.e., *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*) and at the end the qasida *Naẓm al-Durar*.⁴⁶

Published: 'Aql u 'Ishq yā Munāẓarāt-i Khams, ed. Akram Jūdī-Ni'matī, Tehran, 1375 Sh./1997.

A recent article discusses its narrative style: Šābir Imāmī, "Qışsa-pardāzī dar 'Aql u 'Ishq."

23. *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* I (Persian), 'Tubercular Expectoration (I)'

1. MS 10196, ff. 179b-83b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Herat on 8 Rajab 829/16 May 1426 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/240).
2. MS 5423, ff. 165b-75a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 10004/12, pp. 225-45, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98; this copy includes marginal comments critical of the author's statements (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/15).
4. MS 3035/2, ff. 11b-25a, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Šālih Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/227).
5. Microfilm 830, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh).

An apology written in response to the accusations of Ibn Turka's enemies in Yazd leveled against him at Shāhrukh's court in Herat. It comprises an introduction with autobiographical details and a discussion of the superficial character and base motivations of his accusers, followed by two sections (*vaṣl*): 1) a commentary on nine hadith in censure of *bid'a* in religion; 2) a commentary on the sayings of Sufi masters and leading religious figures in support of the orthodoxy of Sufism; Sufis are identified as striving to know and imitate Muḥammad perfectly. It was completed on 8 Rajab 829/16 May 1426 in Herat as a companion piece to the *R. I'tiqādāt* and similarly addressed to Shāhrukh.⁴⁷

⁴⁶ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 18/222, no. 112, here titled *Gulshan*; cf. *ibid.*, 22/282, no. 7107, where he notes a similar work attributed to Nasaḥī (author of the *Manāzil al-Sā'irīn*); Ḥājjī Khalīfa, *Kashf al-Zunūn*, 2/1834; see also Ivanow, *Curzon*, no. 427.

⁴⁷ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 24/244, no. 1267; despite the author's frank tone, here Šā'in al-Dīn is said to assert a Sunni identity out of *taqiyya*.

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Šā'in al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed. Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 169-94. Two recent articles discuss this and the following apology: Leonard Lewisohn, "Sufism and Theology in the Confessions of Šā'in al-Dīn Turka Iṣfahānī (d. 830/1437) [*sic*]"; Fujii Morio, "Ta'ammulī dar Difā'iyāt-i Šā'in al-Dīn 'Alī Turka-yi Iṣfahānī."

24. *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* II (Persian), 'Tubercular Expectoration (II)'

1. MS 10196, ff. 226b-30a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in 838/1435 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/241).
2. MS 5423, ff. 337b-47a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 10004, pp. 246-61, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/15).
4. MS 3035/3, ff. 26b-37a, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Šāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/228).
5. Microfilm 830, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh).

An apology written after Ibn Turka's arrest, imprisonment and exile as a result of the Hurufi attempt on Shāhrukh's life in 830/1427. Here the author gives more autobiographical details and describes the tribulations he and his family have experienced in exile. It dwells on the theme of imposter Sufis who do not observe the Shari'a but rather use their tricks to amass disciples and gain influence over rulers; Šā'in al-Dīn mentions receiving the *khirqā-yi tabarruk* from one Sufi before traveling abroad, only to find upon his return that the disciples of this master had dispensed with the Shari'a. The Hurufi movement of Faḍl Allāh Astarābādī is dismissed in harsh, resentful terms. The apology is addressed to Shāhrukh's son Bāysunghur and requests his mediation in arranging an audience with the sultan; it is not dated but context puts its composition sometime between ca. 832-35/1429-32.⁴⁸

⁴⁸ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 24/244, no. 1267.

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Šā'in al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed.
 Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 197-217.

25. *Nuqta* (Persian), 'On the Dot'

Variant title: *Sharḥ-i Ḥadīs-i Nuqta*

1. MS 10196, ff. 124b-26a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 16 Ramaḍān 828/1 August 1425 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/237).
2. MS 5423, ff. 237b-41a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS Arabic BIJ 1238/3, British Library, London, a copy from the royal library of the Bijapur Sultanate made between 869-71/1465-67; it is heavily repaired, many folios are mixed and the margins are cut.
4. Unnumbered *majmū'a* (no. 4), Bāqir Riqqat Collection, Tehran, copied by 'Abd al-Qādir b. Muḥammad b. Afzal Khurāsānī on 16 Jumādā II 901/2 March 1496 (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 5/624).
5. MS 10004, pp. 127-34, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/13).
6. MS 4029/5, Malik Library, Tehran, copied in Edirne on 28 Jumādā I 921/10 July 1515 (Afshār, *Malik*, 7/153).
7. MS 4196/21, ff. 218b-21b, Malik Library, Tehran, copied in 1017/1608 and described as being a *guftārī-yi 'irfānī-yi ḥurūfī bi naẓm u naṣr* (AB; Afshār, *Malik*, 7/261).
8. MS 5858/4 (= MS 360), pp. 189-200, Sa'īd Nafīsī Collection, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied by Murtaẓā b. Muḥammad Ḥusaynī in 1048/1638 (Afshār, *Malik*, 8/232). A microfilm (2814/4) of this MS is held at the same library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/734).
9. MS 3035/12, ff. 108b-13b, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB).
10. MS Add. 16839, btw. ff. 32-62, British Library, London, copied at the end of the 11th/17th century; this text occurs with eight others by the author in a collection of various writings on mystical, occult, philosophical and Shi'i themes (Rieu, *Supplement*, 2/833).
11. MS 326/4, Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677; a colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishkada*, 3/50).
12. MS 312/8, 8 ff., Imām Ṣādiq Madrasa, Qazvin, copied on 5 Rabī II 1272/February 1856 (Marāghī, *Imām Ṣādiq*, 1/313).
13. MS 20/17, Āyatallāh Ḥujajī Library, Najafabad, an undated copy by Muḥammad Qāsim b. Tāj al-Dīn Maḥmūd Ḥusaynī (Ḥāfiẓiyyān, *Hujajī*, 45).
14. MS 16913d, Majlis Library, Tehran, undated (Majlis registry).
15. MS 1021/14, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), undated; the catalog attributes the work to Davānī (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 6/2247).
16. MS Add. 16837, British Library, London (Rieu, *Supplement*).

A commentary on ‘Alī’s statement, *Anā l-nuqta allatī taḥta l-bā* (‘I am the dot beneath the B’), written in response to a friend. It was completed before 16 Ramaḍān 828/1 August 1425.* This treatise has also been (incorrectly) attributed to Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī, under which heading it was published by Ismā‘īl Vā‘iz Javādī.⁴⁹

Published: ‘Alī Farrūkh, ed., “Sharḥ-i Ḥadīs-i Nuqṭa,” *Mīrās-i Ḥadīs-i Shī‘a*, 1 (n.d.), 173-90; and online by the same editor at http://www.iec-md.org/maaref/hadith_noqteh.html. Ibrāhīm Dībājī, ed., “Risāla-yi Nuqṭa-yi Ibn-i Turka-yi Iṣfahānī: Sharḥ-i Ḥadīs-i ‘Anā l-nuqta allatī taḥt al-bā,’” in ‘A. A. M. Khānī and Ḥ. Sayyid ‘Arab, eds., *Khīrad-i Jāvidān: Jashn-nāma-yi Ustād Sayyid Jalāl al-Dīn Āshtiyānī*, Tehran, 1377 Sh./1998, 312-24.

26. *Qābiliyyat* (Persian), ‘On Receptivity’

Variant title: *A‘māl u Afāl*

1. MS 5423, ff. 175b-77a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
2. MS 1825, Veliyuddin Collection, Beyazıt Library, Istanbul, copied in Abarquh on 16 Jumādā II 851/29 August 1447; the *majmū‘a* also contains works by Ḥusayn Kh‘ārazmī, ‘Azīz Nasaḥī, etc. (Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1027). A microfilm copy (442) is held at the Tehran University Central Library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/476).
3. Unnumbered *majmū‘a* (no. 7), Bāqir Riqqat Collection, Tehran, 16 Jumādā II 901/2 March 1496 (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 5/624).
4. MS 10004, pp. 262-65, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā‘irī, *Majlis*, 32/15).
5. MS 5858/5 (= MS 360, Sa‘īd Nafīsī Collection), Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied by Murtaẓā b. Muḥammad Ḥusaynī in Jumādā I 1048/September 1638 (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 16/109). A microfilm copy (2814) is held at the same library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/734).
6. MS 9263/5, ff. 178b-82b, Mar‘ashī Library, Qom, copied in Jumādā II 1061/June 1651 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar‘ashī*, 24/57).
7. MS 314/5, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied in Rajab 1061/July 1651; the catalog suggests an attribution to Fayẓ Kāshānī (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 3/197).
8. MS 3035/4, ff. 38b-41a, Mar‘ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Šāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar‘ashī*, 8/228).

⁴⁹ In *Tahqīq dar Mabda’-i Āfarīnīsh*, 2/3 (1342 Sh./1963), 15-26; see Rizā Pūrjavādī, “Kitābshināsī-yi Aṣār-i Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī,” 89; see also Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī‘a*, 24/292-93, no. 1520.

9. MS 326/2, Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677; a colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishkada*, 3/49).
10. MS Add. 16839, btw. ff. 32-62, British Library, London, copied at the end of the 11th/17th century; this text occurs with eight others by the author in a collection of various writings on mystical, occult, philosophical and Shī'i themes (Rieu, *Supplement*, 2/833).
11. MS 20/19, Āyatallāh Ḥujajī Library, Najafabad, an undated copy by Muḥammad Qāsim b. Tāj al-Dīn Maḥmūd Ḥusaynī (Ḥāfiẓiyyān, *Hujajī*, 45).
12. Microfilm 8275, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh).

A brief, introductory treatment of Ibn 'Arabī's statement in the first chapter of the *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam* on the *fayẓ-i aqdas*, or 'most holy emanation,' with several quotations from Rūmī and other Sufi poets. The author focuses on the concept of receptivity in discussing the modes and types of emanation and the emergence of things from the First Intellect (*qābil-i fayyāz*). Whoever similarly arrives at his own originary principle (*mabda'*) in the sanctuary of unification (*ittihād*), such a knower may create what he speaks of through the language of receptivity or capacity (*qābiliyyat*). This point has to do with the issue of predestination vs. free will, since human actions conform to levels of knowledge, and knowledge of the real derives from a person's form of preparedness and intention to receive.

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed. Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 271-75.

27. *Shaqq-i Qamar u Bayān-i Sā'at* (Persian), 'On the Splitting of the Moon and the Last Hour'

Variant title: *Shaqq-i Qamar u Sā'at*

1. MS 10196, ff. 170b-72a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in 18 Rabī I 829/27 February 1426 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/239).
2. MS 5423, ff. 355b-61b, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 1825/20, ff. 315-24, Veliyuddin Collection, Beyazıt Library, Istanbul, copied in Abarquh on 16 Jumādā II 851/29 August 1447; the *majmū'a* also contains works by Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī, 'Azīz Nasafī, etc. (Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1027). A microfilm copy (442) is held at the Tehran University Central Library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mikrūfīlm-hā*, 1/476).

4. MS Add. 23983, ff. 21-34, British Library, London, copied in Muḥarram 858/January 1454 (Rieu, *Supplement*, 1/42).
5. MS 4650/18, ff. 179b-83a, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Aḥmad b. Maḥmūd Mutatabbib Tūlamī Gīlānī in 864-66/1460-62 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 12/228).
6. Unnumbered *majmū'a* (no. 10), Bāqir Riqqat Collection, Tehran, copied by 'Abd al-Qādir b. Muḥammad b. Afzal Khurāsānī on 16 Jumādā II 901/2 March 1496 (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 5/624).
7. MS 10004, pp. 163-72, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/14).
8. MS 8158, 7 ff., Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad, copied perhaps in the 10th/16th century (Āstān-i Quds, 11/150).
9. MS 4380/12, ff. 158-60, Markaz-i Iḥyā'-i Mīrās-i Islāmī, copied on 2 Dhū l-Ḥijja 981/25 March 1574 (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 2/936).
10. MS 5138/137, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in the 10th/16th or 11th/17th century (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 15/200).
11. MS 3035/15, ff. 132b-39a, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/234).
12. MS 326/2, Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677; a colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishkada*, 3/49).
13. MS 7355/8-37/145, 6 ff., Gulpāyagānī Library, Qom, copied in the 11th/17th century (Ḥusaynī, *Gulpāyagānī*, 5/2711).
14. MS 8185, 7 ff., Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad, copied in the 11th/17th century (Āstān-i Quds, 22/292).
15. MS 2401/32, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied by Rizā b. Mūsā Kashmīrī in the 11th/17th century (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 9/1018).
16. MS 1701/4, ff. 46b-56a, 'Allāma Ṭabāṭabā'ī Library, Shiraz, copied in the 11th/17th century (Ḥāfiẓiyyān, *Nuskha-pazhūhī*, 3/169).
17. MS Add. 16839, btw. ff. 32-62, British Library, London, copied at the end of the 11th/17th century; this text occurs with eight others by the author in a collection of various writings on mystical, occult, philosophical and Shī'i themes (Rieu, *Supplement*, 2/833).
18. MS 26333, 8 pp., Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad, copied in the 12th/18th century (Āstān-i Quds, 22/291).
19. MS 2697/4, pp. 93-106, Millī Library, Tehran, copied by Qurbān 'Alī Nīshābūrī in 1230/1815 (Anvār, *Millī*, 6/274).
20. MS 12158/15, ff. 195-98, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by 'Abd al-Raḥīm b. Muḥammad Taqī at the beginning of Sha'bān 1265/late June 1849 (Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 30/651).
21. MS 9541/23, ff. 231a-35b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in 1287/1870 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 30/210).
22. MS 1923/2, pp. 141-57, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in 1294/1877 (AB; Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 9/620).
23. MS 7532/4, ff. 481b-90, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, copied by Muḥammad 'Alī Kirmānshāh in 1298/1881 (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 5/142).
24. MS 6553/4, ff. 31-38b, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, undated (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 5/142).
25. MS 6525/15, ff. 114a-16b, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, an undated copy by Burhān al-Munajjimīn Muḥammad Tabrīzī (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 17/110).
26. MS 4778/1, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), undated (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 14/3822).

27. MS 16913d, Majlis Library, Tehran, undated.
28. MS 1298/45-46, ff. 275b-78b, Bodleian Library, Oxford, undated (Sachau and Ethé, *Catalogue*, 1/col. 803-4). A microfilm of this MS (1142/45-46) is held at the Faculty of Letters and Humanities Library, Tehran University (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfīlm-hā*, 1/569).
29. Microfilm 829, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh).⁵⁰
30. MS 427, Asiatic Society, Calcutta ('Alī, *Asiatic*, 298).

An explication of Q 54:1, *The Hour has drawn nigh: the moon is split*, according to seven different levels of interpretation arranged as an intellectual hierarchy. The first and lowest level of interpretation is that of the hadith scholars and jurists, the second dialectical theologians, third peripatetic philosophers, fourth illuminationist philosophers, fifth verifying Sufis, sixth lettrists, seventh and highest *men of might and vision*, i.e., the Imams and their heirs, masters of *jafr*. It was completed before 18 Rabī' I 829/28 January 1426.*⁵¹

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed. Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Biḥbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 103-17. I provide a translation of this treatise in Part 2, §T.1 below.

28. *Sharḥ al-Basmala* (Arabic), 'Commentary on the *Basmala*'

1. MS 10196, ff. 332b-51b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 28 Sha'bān 829/5 July 1426 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/242).
2. MS 2930/20, ff. 6b-9b, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, copied on 18 Ṣafar 845/8 July 1441 (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 3/48).

A commentary on the *basmala* in the lettrist manner. It was completed before 28 Sha'bān 829/5 July 1426* and a copy sent to Qāẓīzāda Rūmī (cf. his letter to Ibn Turka in the margin of MS Majlis 10196 f. 153a; see §2.1.3.1 below); the same manuscript contains a dedication to Ulugh Beg in the margin (f. 332b). Ṣā'in al-Dīn refers the reader to this treatise in a marginal note to

⁵⁰ Possibly identical to microfilm 442 at the same library.

⁵¹ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 14/209, no. 2226.

the K. *al-Mafāḥiṣ* (MS Majlis 10196 f. 84a).

Unpublished.

29. *Sharḥ-i Dah Bayt-i Muḥyī l-Dīn Ibn-i ‘Arabī* (Persian), ‘Commentary on Ten Verses by Ibn ‘Arabī’

Variant title: *Sharḥ-i Abyātī az Ibn-i ‘Arabī*

1. MS 10196, ff. 225a-26a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 18 Ramaḍān 838/17 April 1435 (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/241).
2. MS 5423, ff. 333b-37a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 10004, pp. 204-9, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/14).
4. MS 3035/9, ff. 70b-74b, Mar’ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar’ashī*, 8/231).
5. Microfilm 827, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh).

An exposition of select verses by Ibn ‘Arabī, especially treating of the difference between *wujūd* and *kawn*.⁵²

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Ṣā’ in al-Dīn ‘Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed.

Sayyid ‘Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 299-306.

30. *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam* (Arabic)

1. MS 10196, ff. 241b-330a, Majlis Library, Tehran, completed in Shiraz on 3 Rabī I 831/22 December 1427 (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/241); a note in the author’s hand at the bottom of the same page (signed ‘Alī b. Muḥammad b. Muḥammad Turka) testifies to the accuracy of this copy as read by the copyist in his presence, dating this note to 28 Ṣafar 832/4 December 1428 in Chālū in Tabaristan (Mazandaran). The colophon (f. 330a) further states that the work was finished on 20 Ṣafar 814/13 June 1411 and corrected on 19 Dhū l-Ḥijja 817/1 March 1415 in Fars, and was read by Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad al-Māzyār to Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī on 30 Rajab 820/12 September 1417 in Herat.
2. MS 10082, 511 ff., Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 14 Shawwāl 835/14 June 1432 (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/107).

⁵² See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī’a*, 8/282, no. 1209.

3. MS 1294, 262 ff., Mishkāt Collection, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied on 20 Jumādā I 839/11 December 1435 (AB; Munzavī, *Dānishgāh*, 7/2740).
4. MS 1233/2, ff. 71b-78b, Kastamonu Public Library, a partial copy (?) made by Mehmed Halis Tosyavî at Tosya in 1239/1822.

A long and subtle commentary on Ibn ‘Arabī’s masterpiece featuring frequent lettrist explanations and excursuses. As the colophon on MS Majlis 10196 f. 330a states, the work was completed on 20 Şafar 814/13 June 1411 and corrected on 19 Dhū l-Ḥijja 817/1 March 1415 in Fars. It is referenced in the author’s *R. Ḥurūf*, completed Ramaḍān 817/November 1414. Muḥsin Bīdārfar’s recent edition incorporates Mullā ‘Alī Nūrī’s (d. 1246/1830) extensive marginal comments on the work in the footnotes.⁵³

Published: *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*, in Ibn al-‘Arabī, *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*, ed. Muḥsin Bīdārfar, 2 vols., Qom, 1420/2000.

31. *Sharḥ-i Gulshan-i Rāz* (Persian), Commentary on Shabistarī’s *Garden of Secrets*

1. MS 3318, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), a defective copy made between the 10th-13th/16th-19th centuries and apparently appended to MS Majlis 10196, originally from the personal library of Muḥammad Taqī Bahār; it is the sole known copy of this work. A microfilm copy is held in the Francis Hoover Collection, Harvard University Library, and another microfilm (869 varen) at Leiden University Library (AB; Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 4/57).

Sometimes confused with the *R. ‘Aql u ‘Ishq*, which in MS Mishkāt 835 is titled *Gulshan*. While the attribution to Ibn Turka is by no means certain, given that there is only one late and defective copy of this work that survives which makes no mention of the author, context and content suggest Ṣā’ib al-Dīn as a likely candidate. Malik al-Shu‘arā’ Bahār seems to have appended it to MS Majlis 10196 for this reason. The work is dedicated to one Sulṭān

⁵³ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī’a*, 13/382, no. 1434; Ḥājji Khalīfa, *Kashf al-Zunūn*, 2/1263.

Muḥammad, perhaps Sulṭān Muḥammad b. Bāysunghur.⁵⁴

Published: *Sharḥ-i Gulshan-i Rāz: Az Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī Turka, Shāriḥ-i Shī'i-Mazhab-i Gulshan-i Rāz*, ed. Kāẓim Dizfūliyān, Tehran, 1375 Sh./1996.

32. *Sharḥ-i Ḥadīs-i 'Amā'* (Persian), 'Commentary on the Hadith of the Thin Cloud'

Variant title: *Sharḥ-i Ḥadīs-i Ghamām*

1. MS 10196/3, ff. 119b-20b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 3 Dhū l-Ḥijja 827/27 October 1424 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/236).
2. MS 10004, pp. 268-70, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/16).
3. MS 3035/6, ff. 43b-44b, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/229).
4. MS 2002/3, ff. 56b-57b, New Series, Princeton University Library, copied by 'Alam al-Hudā Ibn Muḥammad al-Muḥsin in 1093/1682 (?).

A brief lettrist commentary on the hadith given in answer to the question as to God's location before creation, the Prophet's answer being: *In a thin cloud ('amā')*, with air neither above nor below it. It was completed before 3 Dhū l-Ḥijja 827/27 October 1424.*

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed. Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 285-86.

33. *Sharḥ Ḥadīthayn* (Arabic)

Variant titles: *Sharḥ-i Dō Ḥadīs-i Nabavī*, *Javāb-i Chand Su'āl dar Harāt*

1. MS 10004/17, pp. 270-72, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/16).
2. MS 3035/7, ff. 45b-46b, Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar'ashī*, 8/229).
3. MS 2930, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, undated (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 3/48).

⁵⁴ Or perhaps the ruler of Gulbarga in India?

Written in reply to an unknown correspondent, a brief commentary, in philosophical, mystical and lettrist terms, on two hadiths: *Inna li-kulli shayⁱⁿ qalb^{an} wa-qalbu l-Qur'āni Yā-Sīn*, and *Unzila al-Qur'ānu 'alā sab'ati aḥruf*.

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Šā'in al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed. Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 289-91.

34. *Sharḥ Ḥadīth Nabawī* (Arabic)

1. MS 10196, f. 122a, Majlis Library, Tehran, undated.

A brief mystical commentary on the hadith *Khayru l-ḥadīth kitābu Allāhi wa-khayru l-hudā hudā Muḥammadⁱⁿ wa-sharru l-umūri muḥdathātu-hā wa-kullu bid'atⁱⁿ ḍalāla*. A marginal note in MS Majlis 10196 states that it was copied from the autograph included in a *majmū'a* of Mawlānā Rukn al-Dīn Šā'id Kirmānī.

Unpublished.

35. *Sharḥ Ḥadīth 'Ulwī* (Arabic)

1. MS 8184, Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad, undated (Fikrat, *Fihrist-i Alifbā'ī*, 333).

Although the above MS was not accessible to me at the time of writing, examination may reveal this commentary to be identical to one of the preceding three brief works.

Unpublished.

36. *R. fī Sharḥ Ḥaqīqat al-Waḥda al-Muṭlaqa al-Dhātiyya* (Arabic), ‘An Exposition of the the Reality of Absolute and Essential Oneness’

Variant title: *R. al-Khatmiyya*

1. MS 10196, f. 120a-20b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 3 Dhū l-Ḥijja 827/27 October 1424.

A brief mystical-philosophical treatment of the stated topic.

Unpublished.

37. *Sharḥ Khuṭbat al-Kashshāf* (Arabic), Commentary on the Prologue to the *Kashshāf*

Variant title: *Ḥāshiyat al-Kashshāf*

1. MS 10196, ff. 223b-24b, Majlis Library, Tehran, undated (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/241).
2. MS 2930/10, ff. 277b-81a, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, undated (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 3/480).

A brief commentary on the prologue to Zamakhsharī's (d. 538/1144) *Kashshāf*; the author states that it is to be used as a model or key to properly interpret the rest of the book. The lettrism of Ṣā'in al-Dīn and his circle presupposes an uncreated Quran; as a result, the author is here and elsewhere at pains to expose the pernicious aspects of Zamakhsharī's work. For example, in his first apology Ṣā'in al-Dīn cites as a foil the widespread contemporary popularity of this work despite its overt Mu'tazilī stance; and in the *Maḥāḥiṣ* he ends the opening section of part four by singling out Zamakhsharī's failure to recognize the intrinsic majesty of the quranic letters for special censure.

Unpublished.

38. *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr (al-Durar)* (Persian), Commentary on the *Tā'iyya al-Kubrā*

1. MS 10196, ff. -1b-51b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied 8 Ramaḍān 828/24 July 1425 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/235-36).
2. MS 5423, ff. 2b-124a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 10003, pp. 1-159, Majlis Library, Tehran, an incomplete copy, lacking the beginning to the commentary on l. 169, completed in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/9).
4. MS 2930/11, ff. 281b-386a, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, copied on 20 Rabī' II 845/7 September 1441 (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 3/48).⁵⁵
5. MS Arabic BIJ 1238/3, British Library, London, a copy from the royal library of the Bijapur Sultanate made between 869-71/1465-67; it is heavily repaired, many folios are mixed and the margins are cut.
6. MS 10, Jābirī Anṣārī Collection, Isfahan, copied in the 10th/16th century (*Nashriyya*, 6/594).
7. MS 760f, National Library, Tehran, an undated copy perhaps from the 11th/17th century; it lacks the final page (*SND*, xiv).
8. MS 5373/1-27/43 (2027), 166 ff., Gulpāyagānī Library, Qom, copied on 5 Jumādā II 1119/3 September 1707 (Ḥusaynī, *Gulpāyagānī*, 5/2634).
9. MS 6960, 57 ff., Mar'ashī Library, Qom, copied in the 12th/18th century (*AB*).
10. MS 2109, 323 pp., Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in 1266/1850; the date 1306/1889 is also mentioned, indicating that this copy belonged at one time to the library of Farhād Mīrzā (d. 1888), the son of Prince 'Abbās Mīrzā Qājār (d. 1833), and was bought by the former's son, Iḥtishām al-Dawla, upon his death (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 6/93; *SND*, xiv).
11. MS 522d, 216 ff., Faculty of Theology, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied in 1278/1862 (Ḥujjatī, *Dānishkada*, 87).
12. Microfilm 2584, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied in 1278/1862 (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/133).
13. MS 299, 33 ff., Dā'irat al-Ma'ārif-i Buzurg-i Islāmī Library, Tehran, a partial and unreliable copy by Zayn al-'Ābidīn Kulaynī Shīrāzī in 1380/1961 (*AB*; f 1/153).
14. MS 7777/6-52/117, 79 ff., Gulpāyagānī Library, Qom, an undated partial copy (Ḥusaynī, *Gulpāyagānī*, 5/2634).
15. MS 10207, 17 ff., Majlis Library, Tehran, an undated partial copy (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/254).
16. Microfilm 3109, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), a copy of a defective (i.e., lacking the end of the work from l. 728 onwards) and undated MS from the Millī Library in Tabriz (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 2/78).

A popular mystical-philosophical commentary on the *Tā'iyya al-Kubrā* of Ibn al-Fāriḍ (d. 632/1235) treating of each verse in an allusive and symbolic manner, with the frequent quotation of Arabic and Persian lines of verse. As Ṣā'in al-Dīn states, he wrote it at the request

⁵⁵ Bihbahānī reports that this copy preserves rather the Arabic version ("Aḥvāl," 124).

of friends, first in Arabic, then translating it into Persian for ease of comprehension.⁵⁶ The theoretical introduction comprises one main section (*aşl*) and fourteen subsections (*vaşl*). The commentary references both the *Mafāḥiṣ*⁵⁷ and the *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*. It was completed in Dhū l-Ḥijja 806/June 1404, presumably in Cairo.

Published: *Sharḥ-i Nazm al-Durr*, ed. Akram Jūdī-Ni‘matī, Tehran, 1384 Sh./2005 (Persian); *Sharḥ al-Tā’iyya al-Kubrā* (Arabic), ed. Majīd Hādīzāda, in *Nuṣūṣ wa-Rasā’il min Turāth Iṣfahān al-‘Ilmī al-Khālīd*, ed. Majīd Hādīzāda, Tehran, 1428/2007, 4/73-103 (partial Arabic).

39. *Sharḥ al-Tajallī al-Dhātī* (Arabic), ‘Commentary on the Essential [Divine] Self-disclosure’

Variant titles: *Sharḥ Risālat al-Tajallī al-Dhātī*, *Sharḥ Kalīmāt Ibn Hūd*, *Taṣṣīḥ Kalām Ibn Hūd al-Maghribī*

1. MS 2002/5, ff. 60a-62a, New Series, Princeton University Library, copied by ‘Alam al-Hudā Ibn Muḥammad al-Muḥsin in 1093/1682 (?) (Mach and Ormsby, *Princeton*, 344, no. 1523).
2. MS 868/6, Nūrbakhsh Library, Tehran, copied by Ḥaydar b. ‘Alī b. Ismā’īl Karakī in the 11th/17th century (*Nashriyya*, 13/243).
3. MS 2930/7, ff. 121b-24a, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, undated (= MS 465/3, Central Library, Tehran University?) (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 3/48).
4. MS 1033/5, ff. 8b-11b, Mishkāt Collection, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), undated (AB; Munzavī, *Mishkāt*, 3/465).

A 100-line versified commentary on Ibn Hūd al-Maghribī’s saying, “When God manifested for Himself through Himself from Himself in Himself to Himself, He became embodied. The first [existent] was a Throne, the second a Footstool, the third ... (*lammā tajallā Llāhu li-dhātī-hi*

⁵⁶ SND, 11. The original Arabic version, preserved only in the margins of the copy in MS Majlis 10196, is far more succinct than the Persian translation; in its ornate complexity the latter effectively constitutes a different work.

⁵⁷ This includes the Arabic version (ed. Hadizada, 86).

*bi-dhāti-hi min dhāti-hi fī dhāti-hi ‘alā dhāti-hi tajassada bi-l-jasadi fa-kāna l-awwalu ‘arsh^{an} wa-l-thānī kursiyy^{an} wa-l-thālithu ...).*⁵⁸

Unpublished.

40. *Su’l al-Mulūk* (Persian), ‘Request of Kings’

Variant titles: *Su’āl al-Mulūk*, *Maqbūl al-Mulūk*, *R. dar ‘ilm al-Ḥurūf*, *R. Khawāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf*

1. MS 10196, ff. 172b-79a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied 7 Rajab 829/15 May 1426 (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/240).
2. MS 5423, ff. 150b-65a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 4650/32, Mar’ashī Library, Qom, copied by Aḥmad b. Maḥmūd Mutaṭabbib Tūlamī Gīlānī in 864-66/1460-62 (Ḥusaynī, *Mar’ashī*, 12/234).
4. MS 10004, pp. 173-203, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Yazd in 903-4/1497-98 (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/16).
5. MS 12593/10, ff. 144b-171a, Mar’ashī Library, Qom, copied in the 10th/16th century (Ḥusaynī, *Mar’ashī*, 31/740).
6. MS 9263/8, Mar’ashī Library, Qom, copied in Jumādā II 1061/June 1651 (Ḥusaynī, *Mar’ashī*, 24/57).
7. MS 3035/8, 48b-70a, Mar’ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ Iṣfahānī on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar’ashī*, 8/230).

A treatise on the science of letters consisting of an introduction on the meaning of letters and their properties and essential realities, and two main sections, each with three subsections (*bāb, sukhan*): 1) on the properties (*khavāṣṣ*) of letters and the manner of accessing their noble essences; 2) on the theoretical aspect of the science of letters. An epilogue touches on the manner in which the realities of all things arise from the letters. It refers to the *R. Asrār al-Ṣalāt*. It was written at the request of Mu’izz al-Dawla Bāysunghur and completed before 7 Rajab 829/15 May 1426.⁵⁹

⁵⁸ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī’a*, 14/83, no. 1827 (*Sharḥ Maqālat Ibn Hūd*); cf. *ibid.*, 11/136, no. 847 (*R. Tajallī Dhātī*, Persian trans. by Ibn Turka).

⁵⁹ Cf. Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī’a*, 7/272, no. 1317, where it is called *Khavāṣṣ-i Ḥurūf*; a copy is there stated to be in the Sulṭān al-Qurrā’ī Collection.

Unpublished; see Part 2, §T.4 for an edition of this treatise.

41. *Sullam Dār al-Salām fī Bayān Hikam Ahkām Arkān al-Islām* (Persian), ‘The Ladder to the Abode of Peace: An Exposition of the Wisdom Behind the Ritual Obligations of the Pillars of Islam’

1. MS 10196, ff. 360b-66a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Abarquh on 26 Sha‘bān 832/31 May 1429 (Ḥā‘irī, *Majlis*, 32/242).
2. MS 5423, ff. 310b-33a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
3. MS 3035/17, ff. 168b-93a, Mar‘ashī Library, Qom, copied on 17 Jumādā II 1084/29 September 1673 (AB; Ḥusaynī, *Mar‘ashī*, 8/235).

A mystical exposition of the principles of doctrine and the wisdom behind various pillars of Islamic belief and practice, drawing on Quran, hadith and the sayings of Sufi masters. It consists of an introduction on the spiritual meaning of ritual worship (*‘ibādat*) and its various types and five short chapters (*bāb*): 1) on the dual *shahāda*; 2) on the wisdom governing the act of prayer and its conditions; 3) on the alms tax; 4) on the fast; 5) on the pilgrimage. It was completed before 26 Sha‘bān 832/31 May 1429 in Abarquh.*

Unpublished.

42. *Tamhīd al-Qawā‘id* or *al-Tamhīd fī Sharḥ Qawā‘id al-Tawḥīd* (Arabic), ‘Introduction to *The Principles of Divine Unity*’

Variant title: *al-Shahīd fī Sharḥ Risālat al-Tawḥīd*

1. MS 10196, ff. 189b-23a, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in Shiraz on 2 Dhū l-Qa‘da 830/25 August 1427.
2. MS 2930/9, ff. 141-277, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, copied on 29 Rabī‘ I 845/17 August 1441; the title is given as *al-Shahīd fī Sharḥ Risālat al-Tawḥīd* (Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 5/193).
3. MS Arabic BIJ 1238/3, British Library, London, a copy from the royal library of the Bijapur Sultanate made between 869-71/1465-67; it is heavily repaired, many folios are mixed and the margins are cut.
4. MS 41, Miftāḥ Collection, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied in the 9th/15th century; the end is missing in this otherwise good copy (*Nashriyya*, 7/124).
5. MS 2107, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied in 1048/1638 (AB).
6. MS 3650, 108 ff., Mar‘ashī Library, Qom, copied in the 11th/17th century; an owner’s mark gives the name Ḥasan b. ‘Abd al-Ghanī Iṣfahānī and the date 1066/1656 (AB).

7. MS 6400, 175 ff., Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, copied by Muḥammad ‘Alī Kirmānshāhī in Sipahsālār-i Kuhna on 12 Dhū l-Ḥijja 1301/1884 and compared with a copy dated 29 Rabī I 845 (i.e., MS Sipahsālār 2930 above) (AB).
8. MS 75, 110 ff., Āstān-i Ḥaẓrat-i Ma’sūma Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad b. ‘Abd al-‘Alī Darjazīnī on 4 Sha’bān 1305/1888 (AB).
9. MS 4571/1, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied by Muḥammad ‘Alī b. ‘Alī Naqī Gīlānī in 1305/1888; this MS is missing ff. 76-77 (AB).
10. MS 5798, 90 ff., Mar’ashī Library, Qom, copied by Muḥammad Darjazīnī on 10 Dhū l-Qa’da 1308/1891 (AB).
11. MS 284, Lughatnāma-yi Dihkhudā Institute Library, Tehran, copied in 1308/1891 (AB).
12. MS 124j/1, ff. 1b-5b, Faculty of Theology Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), comprising only the preface of the work, copied by Sayyid ‘Alī Akbar b. Sayyid ‘Abd al-Ḥusayn in ca. 1311/1894 (AB; Ḥujjatī, *Dānishkada*, 157).
13. MS 7825, 88 ff., Mar’ashī Library, Qom, copied in Muḥarram 1312/1895; the end of the MS exhibits water damage (AB).
14. MS 397/5, ff. 50b-114a, Dā’irat al-Ma’ārif-i Buzurg-i Islāmī Library, Tehran, copied by Yūsuf Mūsavī Ardakānī in 1313/1896 (AB).
15. MS 5248, 166 ff., Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied by Maḥmūd Ḥusaynī Sāvajī on 15 Dhū l-Qa’da 1314/1897 (AB).
16. Lithograph 413, 234 pp., Mishkāt Collection, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), constituting the printing by Aḥmad Shīrāzī of 1315/1898, edited and commented upon by Shādravān Mīrzā Yad Allāh Naẓar-i Pāk Kujūrī. The volume also includes the *Miftāḥ Mafātīḥ al-Fuṣūṣ al-Musammā bi-l-Nuṣūṣ* of Ṣadr al-Dīn Qūnavī, the *R. Vaḥdat-i Vujūd* of Āqā Mīrzā Muḥammad Qumsha’ī (written in reference to the first section of Qayṣarī’s commentary on the *Fuṣūṣ*), and a *R. Ithnā-‘ashariyya* attributed to Ibn ‘Arabī, and in the margin the *R. Ṭarīq al-Taṣawwuf* of Ibn ‘Arabī (written at the request of Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī) and the *Miftāḥ al-Ghayb* of Qūnavī (AB).
17. MS 4688/1, ff. 1b-153a, Mar’ashī Library, Qom, undated (AB).
18. MS 1527, 94 ff., Mar’ashī Library, Qom, undated (AB).
19. MS 2315, 121 ff., Millī Library, Tehran, undated (AB).
20. MS 37320m/85, Millī Library, Tehran (Anvār, *Millī*, 4/439).
21. MS 1599, 146 ff., Malik Library, Tehran, undated (AB).
22. MS 100, ff. 1b-6b, New Series, Princeton University Library, an undated copy comprising only the preface (Mach and Ormsby, *Princeton*, 337-38, no. 1496).

Ibn Turka’s commentary on his grandfather Ṣadr al-Dīn’s mystico-philosophical work on the concept of absolute existence (*wujūd muṭlaq*), *Qawā’id al-Tawḥīd*. Both texts have as their running theme the complementarity of philosophical and mystical modes of knowing. Ṣā’in al-Dīn here demonstrates his facility with peripatetic and illuminationist philosophy, often quoting Ibn Sīnā and Suhrawardī; in answering the ‘doubts of the philosophers,’ however, it relies primarily on Ibn ‘Arabian thought, especially as formulated by Qūnavī and Jandī. It refers

the reader to the *Mafāhiṣ*. It was completed before 2 Dhū l-Qa‘da 830/25 August 1427.*⁶⁰

The *Tamhīd al-Qawā‘id* is by far Ibn Turka’s best known and most influential work in the modern period, particularly in Imami circles. Unlike his other works, most of the surviving copies of the *Tamhīd* date to the late 19th century, reflecting a spike in interest in the work during the revival of Sadrian philosophy in Iran during the Qajar period. It has been used since then as a staple teaching text on mystico-philosophical thought in Shi‘i scholarly circles; in particular, it heads the *‘irfān* section in current seminary curricula in Qom.⁶¹ As I discuss elsewhere, the surge in popularity of the *Tamhīd* has served to obscure and distort Ibn Turka’s larger intellectual project, a situation the present study seeks to remedy in some small measure. Nevertheless, this work is indeed important in its own right as a prominent example of the will to synthesis so definitive of later Islamic intellectual history, particularly between peripatetic and illuminationist philosophy on the one hand and mystical theory on the other.

Recent scholarship, then, locates Ibn Turka—solely on the strength of the *Tamhīd*—at both the chronological and intellectual midpoint between Ibn ‘Arabī and Mullā Ṣadrā. Despite Ṣā‘in al-Dīn’s lack of Shi‘i credentials, he is presumed to operate within the trajectory of specifically Imami mystico-philosophical thought that culminates in the Sadrian transcendent philosophy (*al-ḥikma al-muta‘āliya*). For this reason it may be useful here to sketch the contours of this trajectory as a basis for comparison with Ibn Turka’s universalist project.

From the mid-7th/13th century onwards, Imami Shi‘i thought began to grapple simultaneously with aristotelian-neoplatonic metaphysics,⁶² as reformulated by Ibn Sīnā (d.

⁶⁰ Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī‘a*, 4/433, no. 1924; 17/181, no. 952.

⁶¹ Along with the *Taḥrīr-i Tamhīd al-Qawā‘id* of Ayatollah ‘Abd Allāh Javādī-Āmulī (b. 1933), consisting of his lecture notes on the text.

⁶² It should of course be noted that the aristotelianism of the Islamic philosophers largely derives from a paraphrase of Plotinus (i.e., the *Theology of Aristotle*), and thus is already substantially neoplatonic in its own right. On this question see Peter Adamson, *The Arabic Plotinus: A Philosophical Study of the “Theology of Aristotle”*, London, 2002.

428/1037) and then altered by Shihāb al-Dīn Suhrawardī (d. 587/1191),⁶³ and mystical theory (*irfān nazārī*) in the formulation of Ibn ʿArabī (d. 638/1240) and his followers. The beginnings of this trend lay in the turn of Imami theology to Muʿtazili rationalism in the second half of the 3rd/9th century,⁶⁴ leading to the express incorporation of philosophical content by, most prominently, Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī (d. 672/1274) and his student al-ʿAllāma al-Ḥillī (d. 726/1325). While due to a variety of factors, this veritable renaissance in Shiʿi intellectual activity may be seen as being driven by the ferment generated by the Mongol invasion of the 7th/13th century, this after the fertile Buyid period⁶⁵ had given way to a Sunni ascendancy with the Seljuq control of Iraq and Iran in the 5th-6th/11th-12th centuries. These four strands—Muʿtazili theology, peripatetic and illuminationist philosophy, and Ibn ʿArabian mystical theory—became increasingly interwoven over the next centuries, with Imami thinkers incorporating elements of each in formulating their own original, synthetic positions. Ṭūsī, conversant as he was with all four schools of thought, stands at the beginning of this period; it culminates in the 10th-11th/16th-17th centuries with the school of Isfahan and the grand synthesis achieved by Mullā Ṣadrā (d. 1050/1640).⁶⁶

Imami intellectual history from the mid-7th/13th to the mid-11th/17th centuries is,

⁶³ Here Suhrawardī should be regarded as a platonist primarily responding to Ibn Sīnā rather than to the ‘ancients,’ despite his claims to the contrary. See Dimitri Gutas’ review of John Walbridge’s *The Leaven of the Ancients* (“Essay-Review: Suhrawardī and Greek Philosophy”), where he contests the latter’s portrayal of Suhrawardī as a pythagoreanizing neoplatonist.

⁶⁴ This is not to discount its grappling, to a lesser extent, with Sunni-Ashʿari *kalām* as well (Rāzī, etc.). On the turn toward rationalism in Imami theology see Abdulsater, “al-Sharīf al-Murtaḍā and the Climax of Speculative Theology in Būyid Shīʿism.”

⁶⁵ The unprecedented freedom enjoyed by Shiʿi scholars during the Buyid period saw the production of the definitive compendiums of Shiʿi traditions and their associated legal works, hence the relative disinterest in philosophical theology until the advent of Abū l-Ḥusayn al-Baṣrī (d. 436/1044); see Kraemer, *Humanism in the Renaissance of Islam*.

⁶⁶ Schmidtke, *Theologie, Philosophie und Mystik*, 1-5.

consequently, enormously rich and diverse.⁶⁷ Perhaps most strikingly, it was through the efforts of Imami thinkers that the peripateticism of Ibn Sīnā, which had been covertly incorporated into an ‘orthodox’ Ash‘ari-Sufi synthesis by Ghazālī (d. 505/1111) and subsequently become embedded in Sunni theology,⁶⁸ experienced a second florescence and was definitively, and overtly, incorporated into Imami theology. Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī was the first to incorporate Ibn Sīnā using the ‘modern theological method’ (*ṭarīqat al-muta’akhhirīn*) in Imami *kalām*, integrating his theological discussions with philosophical concepts, methodology and terminology.⁶⁹ His correspondence with Ṣadr al-Dīn Qūnavī (d. 673/1274), Ibn ‘Arabī’s stepson and foremost disciple, is of particular interest in this context. In marked contrast to his master, Qūnavī was more methodical philosopher than inspired visionary; as chief interpreter of Ibn ‘Arabī’s thought, his systematization of the latter’s unruly insights in philosophical terms became the form in which they were to exert such a vast influence in the eastern Islamic world.⁷⁰ Qūnavī is, in short, responsible for initiating the movement to bring Ibn ‘Arabī into the mainstream of Islamic philosophy.⁷¹ (It may be noted that the illuminationist philosopher Quṭb al-Dīn Shīrāzī was simultaneously his student and Ṭūsī’s.) The Qūnavī-Ṭūsī correspondence, in which Ṭūsī addresses Qūnavī in terms of utmost respect, treats of various philosophical issues

⁶⁷ And inadequately explored; the intellectual activity in the middle of this period remains particularly obscure, with important thinkers of 8th-9th/14th-15th century Iran, some of whom will be touched on below, still lacking monographs.

⁶⁸ On Ghazālī’s introduction of Avicennism into Sunni theology, see Griffel, *Al-Ghazālī’s Philosophical Theology*, and Wisnovsky, “One Aspect of the Avicennian Turn in Sunnī Theology.” The older view that Ghazālī’s work represented a devastating assault on peripateticism, leading to the general decline of Islamic philosophy in the Sunni world from the 6th/12th century onward, has long ceased to be tenable.

⁶⁹ Schmidtke, *Theologie, Philosophie und Mystik*, 4.

⁷⁰ ‘Afīf al-Dīn al-Tilimsānī (d. 690/1291) is reported to have said that his first shaykh (i.e. Ibn ‘Arabī) was a philosophizing spiritual (*mutarawḥin mutafalsif*) whereas his second (i.e. Qūnavī) was a spiritualizing philosopher (*faylasūf mutarawḥin*) (Chittick, “The School of Ibn ‘Arabī,” 513). On Qūnavī’s neoplatonism and the visionary/philosopher tension more generally, see Chittick, “The Circle of Spiritual Ascent According to al-Qūnavī.”

⁷¹ Chittick, “The School of Ibn ‘Arabī,” 511.

such as *wujūd*, *māhiyya*, etc., with Ṭūsī requesting insights from Qūnavī on the one hand and Qūnavī demonstrating a thorough knowledge of Ibn Sīnā's writings on the other. In his letters Qūnavī is primarily concerned to show that the Sufi position (i.e. Ibn 'Arabī as interpreted by himself) agrees more or less with that of *falsafa*.⁷²

Pivotal as Ṭūsī is to this process, he acknowledges that both philosophy and mysticism had first begun to be systematically integrated into Shī'ī thought slightly earlier by the school of Bahrain. By the early 13th century, Bahrain was emerging as an important Imami outpost through its connection to Hilla, the capital of Imami learning at the time. Whereas intellectual activity in Hilla was focused on traditionalism and legal methodology, however, Bahrain saw the emergence of a rationalist movement centered on three thinkers: Kamāl al-Dīn Ibn Sa'āda al-Baḥrānī (d. ca. 640/1242), Jamāl al-Dīn 'Alī b. Sulaymān al-Baḥrānī (d. ca. 669/1271), and Kamāl al-Dīn Maytham b. Maytham al-Baḥrānī (d. 699/1300).⁷³ These thinkers likely had links with Ibn 'Arabī either directly or through one of his followers, e.g. Qūnavī, who is quoted by Ibn Maytham and 'Alī b. Sulaymān (unless it is Qūnavī who is quoting the latter's *Ishārāt* in his *Miftāḥ Ghayb al-Jam' wa-l-Wujūd*).⁷⁴ In any case, their engagement with both Ibn Sīnā's peripateticism and Ibn 'Arabian mystical theory is frequently apparent in their works. The school does not seem to have constructed a complete philosophical system of its own, but should be identified as responsible for integrating philosophy into Imami Shī'ism; Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī was to have even more of a decisive influence on this process.⁷⁵ Furthermore, an

⁷² Chittick, "The School of Ibn 'Arabī," 514; Zarrīnkūb, *Dunbāla-yi Justujū dar Taṣavvuf-i Īrān*, 119-23. 'Allāma Ḥillī, Ṭūsī's student, was probably familiar with the works of Ibn 'Arabī through the mystic Shams al-Dīn al-Kīshī (d. 695/1296), with whom he studied in Baghdad (Cooper, "From al-Ṭūsī to the School of Iṣfahān," 589).

⁷³ Al-Oraibi, "Rationalism in the School of Bahrain," 331-32.

⁷⁴ Al-Oraibi, "Rationalism in the School of Bahrain," 334. Jalāl al-Dīn Rūmī (d. 672/1273) is known to have sent a letter to Ibn Sa'āda asking him about certain issues, in particular the notions of *qabḍ* and *baṣṭ*.

⁷⁵ Al-Oraibi, "Rationalism in the School of Bahrain," 332. Ṭūsī commentated on Ibn Sa'āda, who apparently died while Ṭūsī was still at Alamut, and was a colleague to 'Alī b. Sulaymān; in a letter Ṭūsī refers to him as 'the king of philosophers and theologians' (ibid.).

attachment to the doctrines of Ibn ‘Arabī (especially *waḥdat al-wujūd*) is evident in the *Ishārāt* of ‘Alī b. Sulaymān and the *Sharḥ al-Ishārāt* of Ibn Maytham. They adapted these doctrines to Shi‘i imamology by identifying Ibn ‘Arabī’s seal of general sainthood (*khatm al-wilāya al-‘amma*) with Imam ‘Alī, and his seal of particular, Muḥammadan sainthood (*al-wilāya al-muqayyada al-muḥammadiyya*) with the Mahdi, so departing from Ibn ‘Arabī’s identification of the first with Jesus and the second with himself.⁷⁶ It is thus the school of Bahrain that was responsible for initiating a systematic Shi‘i mysticism, not Ḥaydar Āmulī (d. after 787/1385) as commonly believed. Their mystico-philosophical synthesis was to exert a great influence on the course of Shi‘i thought.⁷⁷

Ibn Abī Jumhūr al-Aḥsā‘ī (d. after 906/1501) occupies a prominent position among the Imami thinkers of the late 9th/15th century. Initially a Mu‘tazili-style theologian, in his later work, the *K. al-Mujlī* (in the form of a supercommentary on his own *K. Maslik al-Afhām fī ‘Ilm al-Kalām*), he emerges as the first Imami thinker to attempt a synthesis of the four main intellectual currents of his time within a rationalist theological framework. Like the works of earlier Imami synthesizers, the *K. al-Mujlī* brings together theology, peripatetic and illuminationist philosophy, and Ibn ‘Arabian *‘irfān*, all cast in the mold of Shi‘i imamology.⁷⁸

His contemporary Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī (d. 908/1502) was the foremost illuminationist thinker of the period and exponent of the school of Shiraz; certain accounts of him and passages in his writings suggestive of imamophilism are sometimes interpreted to mean that he was a crypto-Shi‘i or Shi‘i convert toward the end of his life, though this is hardly a necessary

⁷⁶ Ibn ‘Arabian concepts particularly influential in Imami thought include *waḥdat al-wujūd*, the imaginal realm (*‘ālam al-khayāl*), and the perfect man (*al-insān al-kāmil*) as the purest locus of the divine presence, as well as his views on sainthood (*wilāya*), prophethood (*nubuwwa*) and apostlehood (*risāla*).

⁷⁷ Al-Oraibi, “Rationalism in the School of Bahrain,” 333–34.

⁷⁸ Schmidtke, *Theologie*, 12–13. It was criticized by some later Imami thinkers as excessively Sufi in tone (Madelung, “Ibn Abī Djumhūr al-Aḥsā‘ī,” *Et*).²

conclusion.⁷⁹ Like Ibn Kammūna (d. 683/1284), Davānī played a pivotal role in blending peripatetic and illuminationist philosophy. His chief rivals were the founder of the school of Shiraz, Ṣadr al-Dīn Dashtakī (d. 903/1497), and his son Ghiyās al-Dīn Maṣṣūr Dashtakī (d. ca. 948/1541), who took Suhrawardī's insistence on the primacy of essence even further, espousing a radical essentialism in which existence does not possess even a mental reality. Davānī for his part tempers illuminationist essentialism, bringing it closer to an existentialist Avicennan model.⁸⁰ Ghiyās al-Dīn Dashtakī, eventually appointed *ṣadr* under Shāh Ṭahmāsp, was accounted a leading Imami scholar in both philosophy and law during the fraught period of transition in Iran from Timurid to Safavid state.⁸¹ Among the thinkers here, it is Ghiyās al-Dīn who furnishes the physical link with the school of Isfahan; his students (especially Kamāl al-Dīn Ardabīlī (d. 950/1543)) and their students in turn constitute the direct line to the generation of Mīr Dāmād.⁸²

Mīr Dāmād (d. 1040/1630), considered the founder of the school of Isfahan, was given the honorific title of 'Third Teacher,' i.e., after Aristotle and al-Fārābī, in recognition of his stature as a synthesizing philosopher. He is distinguished from some of the other thinkers touched on above by his vast learning in the traditional sciences (*ulūm naqliyya*) such as tafsir, hadith and *fiqh*. His synthesis of peripatetic and illuminationist philosophy, mystical theory and Imami theology picks up on Davānī's compromise between illuminationist essentialism and the Avicennan model. His student Ṣadr al-Dīn Shīrāzī (d. 1050/1640), known as Mullā Ṣadrā, famously rejected this compromise, in its place asserting a more radical version of the primacy

⁷⁹ See §1.6 above.

⁸⁰ Groff and Leaman, "al-Dawani," *Islamic Philosophy A-Z*, Edinburgh, 2007, 29. It should be noted that Ibn Sīnā can be read as supporting either an essentialism or an existentialism (i.e., with essence as an accident of existence).

⁸¹ Cf. Colin Turner, *Islam Without Allah? The Rise of Religious Externalism in Safavid Iran* (Richmond, Surrey, 2000), where it is argued that Dashtakī only posed as an Imami for professional convenience.

⁸² Cooper, "From al-Ṭūsī to the School of Iṣfahān," 593.

of existence and the fundamental dynamism of beings. He developed a new compromise of his own, however; although he posits in his ontology “metaphysical variance and plurality” vis-à-vis the monism of the school of Ibn ‘Arabī, he nevertheless observes a simultaneity between “the demands of philosophy and mysticism, between monorealism and metaphysical pluralism.”⁸³ The rationalizing mysticism of Ibn ‘Arabī becomes with Mullā Ṣadrā a heavily pregnant, mystically operative philosophy, *al-ḥikma al-muta‘āliya*, some four centuries later.⁸⁴ The integration of the four dominant intellectual currents surveyed here thus reaches its culmination in the work of Mullā Ṣadrā, and particularly his *K. al-Asfār al-Arba‘a*.⁸⁵ This is not to say that Imami mystico-philosophical thought in Iran subsequently declined—the example of such thinkers as Mullā ‘Alī Nūrī (d. 1246/1830)⁸⁶ and Mullā Hādī Sabzavārī (d. 1289/1872) says otherwise—but rather that Mullā Ṣadrā continues to exert a hegemonic influence up to the present day throughout Iran, Iraq and South Asia, with the modern school of Tehran as his direct inheritor.⁸⁷

Ṣā’ir al-Dīn’s *Tamhīd al-Qawā’id*, then, falls almost precisely at the midpoint between Ibn ‘Arabī and Mullā Ṣadrā, and represents a peculiar transitional point in the intellectual trajectory outlined above. From the perspective of modern-day Imami thought, Ṣā’ir al-Dīn is seen as combining peripatetic and illuminationist philosophy and Ibn ‘Arabian *‘irfān* within the context of Shī‘i esotericism, not unlike the more theologically-oriented syntheses of ‘Alī b.

⁸³ Rizvi, “Mysticism and Philosophy,” 227.

⁸⁴ Rizvi, “Mysticism and Philosophy,” 227.

⁸⁵ Cf. ‘Allāma Ṭabāṭabā’ī’s judgment in this regard (*al-Mīzān*, 5/282-84); see the Introduction above for Ṭabāṭabā’ī’s view of Ṣā’ir al-Dīn.

⁸⁶ Nūrī in particular was responsible for the resurgence of Ṣadrian philosophy during the Qajar period. A note in the beginning of the oldest and most reliable collection of Ṣā’ir al-Dīn’s works, MS Majlis 10196, indicates that it was in the possession of Nūrī, and the MS features some of his marginal comments (see §2.1.1.1 above).

⁸⁷ Nasr, *Islamic Philosophy from Its Origin to the Present*, 236-37. The main distinction of the school of Tehran from the school of Isfahan is the former’s status as the first to encounter Western philosophy.

Sulaymān in the 7th/13th century and Ibn Abī Jumhūr in the late 9th/15th. It is therefore generally assumed that Šā'in al-Dīn's work acted in some way as a precedent for the grand synthesis achieved by Mullā Šadrā. While I have not yet found evidence of any direct influence on the school of Isfahan,⁸⁸ it bears noting that Mullā Šadrā's doctrine of the radical primacy of existence, contra the essentialism of the illuminationists, is in line with Šā'in al-Dīn's position in the *Tamhīd*.⁸⁹

Published: *al-Tamhīd fī Sharḥ Qawā'id al-Tawḥīd*, ed. Ḥasan al-Ramaḍānī al-Khurasānī, Beirut, 2003;⁹⁰ *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, ed. and intro. Sayyid Jalāl al-Dīn Āshtiyānī, cmt. Muḥammad Riżā Qumsha'ī and Mīrzā Maḥmūd Qummī, Tehran, 1396/1976; repr. Tehran, 1360 Sh./1981; Qom, 1381 Sh./2002. A lithograph edition was first printed in Tehran in 1315/1897 by Shaykh Aḥmad Shīrāzī.⁹¹

Commentary: Āyatullāh 'Abd Allāh Javādī-Āmulī, *Taḥrīr-i Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, Tehran, 1372 Sh./1993.

43. *Taqdīm al-'Aql 'alā l-Nafs* (Arabic), 'On Intellect's Superiority to the Soul'

1. MS 319 (1187), ff. 69b-70b, New Series, Princeton University Library, copied in the 10th/16th (?) century (Mach and Ormsby, *Princeton*, 270, no. 1187).
2. MS 2930/6, ff. 118b-121a, Sipahsālār Library, Tehran, undated; presented to 'Dawlat-i Sayyidiyya-yi Imāmiyya-yi Rażaviyya' (AB; Munzavī, *Sipahsālār*, 3/486).

⁸⁸ It should be noted that members of the Turka family appear to have retained prominent positions in Isfahan until the early 11th/17th century; see §1.1 above.

⁸⁹ To wit, *wujūd muṭlaq* as the only real (*ḥaqīqī*), all multiplicity as facilitated by entifications or essences (*ta'ayyunāt, māhiyyāt*) is imaginal, or more properly, perspectival (*i'tibārī*). See also Mullā Šadrā, *Mafātīḥ al-Ghayb*, 493-95.

⁹⁰ This edition may be identical to that published in Qom in 1385 Sh./2006.

⁹¹ Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 17/181, col. 217; M. Zāri' and M. B. Karīmiyān, "Tamhīd al-Qawā'id (1)," *DJI*.

A brief lettrist work discussing the respective views of four groups as to the relation between intellect and soul: 1) the peripatetics, 2) the illuminationists, 3) the Sufis, and 4) the *muḥaqqiqīn*, i.e., the lettrists. One MS notes that it was presented to one ‘Dawlat-i Sayyidiyya-yi Imāmiyya-yi Raḡaviyya.’

Unpublished.

44. *Tarjuma-yi Aḥādīs-i Mamzūj bā Sukhanān-i ‘Alī u A’imma* (Persian), Translation of the Hadiths of ‘Alī and the Imams

Variant title: *Tarjuma-yi Aḥādīs az Amīr al-Mu’minīn, Sharḥ al-Nahj*

1. MS 10196, ff. 440b–41b, Majlis Library, Tehran, undated and incomplete.

An exposition of various hadiths of ‘Alī and the other Imams.⁹² In the only copy known to date, MS Majlis 10196, the title has seemingly been defaced, and the text is abruptly truncated.

Unpublished.

45. *Tuḥfa-yi ‘Alā’ī* (Persian), A Treatise Presented to ‘Alā’ al-Dīn b. Bāysunghur

1. MS 10196/47, ff. 371b–73b, 375b–82a, Majlis Library, Tehran, undated (Ḥā’irī, *Majlis*, 32/243).

A brief treatment of the hadith on the tripartite division *iḥsān-īmān-islām*. Each level is treated with respect to the five fundamentals of religious practice—ritual purity, prayer, alms tax, fasting, pilgrimage—and the wisdom expressed by their procedural requirements. Attention is given to the nature of their performance among the different Sunni groups, especially the Hanbalis and Shafi’is; Ibn Turka here states that his family has always belonged

⁹² See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī’a*, 14/140, no. 1980.

to the Shafi'i rite. At the end of the treatise the reader is referred to the *Iṣbāḥ al-Anwār* for more detail. The introduction complains of the harsh treatment he experienced in Herat (p. 122).

The treatise was written for 'Alā' al-Dīn b. Bāysunghur (a Hanbali) and completed on 1 Jumādā I 831/17 February 1428.

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed. Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 121-65.

46. *Żaw' al-Lama'āt* (Persian), Commentary on 'Irāqī's *Lama'āt*

Variant title: *Sharḥ-i Lama'āt*

1. MS 10196, ff. 148b-53b, Majlis Library, Tehran, copied on 8 Dhū l-Qa'da 828/21 September 1425/21 September 1425 (Ḥā'irī, *Majlis*, 32/238).
2. MS 15/4, pp. 59-72, Adnan Ötügen Collection, National Library, Ankara, copied by 'Abd al-Malik b. Badr al-Balkhī in 833/1429.
3. MS 5423, ff. 124b-38a, Fatih Collection, Süleymaniye Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied in Rajab-Ramaḍān 842/January-March 1439.
4. MS 1825, Veliyuddin Collection, Beyazıt Library, Istanbul, copied in Abarquh on 16 Jumādā II 851/29 August 1447; the *majmū'a* also contains works by Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī, 'Azīz Nasafī, etc. (Munzavī, *Fihrist*, 2/1027). A microfilm copy (442) is held at the Tehran University Central Library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mikrūfilm-hā*, 1/476).
5. MS 2142/3, ff. 44a-55a, National Library, Paris, copied in the late 9th/15th century; it contains only the preface of a commentary on the *Lama'āt*, most likely the present one by Ibn Turka. This collection also includes the *Mashārib al-Adhwāq* of 'Alī b. Shihāb Hamadānī, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *R. Ḥarfīyya* (i.e., *R. Hurūf*); it is here attributed to one Kh^wāja Zayn al-Dīn, and a second unattributed commentary on the *Lama'āt* entitled *Mashāriq al-Lama'āt*, dedicated to Sultan Ya'qūb Aq Quyunlu (Blochet, *Catalogue*, 4/96-98).
6. Unnumbered *majmū'a* (no. 1), Bāqir Riqqat Collection, Tehran, copied by 'Abd al-Qādir b. Muḥammad b. Afzal Khurāsānī on 16 Jumādā II 901/2 March 1496 (Ishkavarī, *Mīrās-i Islāmī*, 5/624).
7. MS 4029/1, Malik Library, Tehran, copied in Edirne at the beginning of 921/1515 (Afshār, *Malik*, 7/153).
8. MS 5858/3 (= MS 360, Sa'īd Nafīsī Collection), 34 pp., Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied by Murtaẓā b. Muḥammad Ḥusaynī in Jumādā I 1048/September 1638 (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 16/109). A microfilm copy (2814) is held at the same library (Dānishpazhūh, *Mikrūfilm-hā*, 1/734).
9. MS 326/3, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), an unreliable copy made in 1088/1677; a colophon at the end mentions the date 18 Dhū l-Ḥijja 996/8 November 1588, which must indicate the date of the MS from which this copy was made (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 3/50).
10. MS Add. 16839, btw. ff. 32-62, British Library, London, copied at the end of the 11th/17th century; this text occurs with eight others by the author in a collection of

various writings on mystical, occult, philosophical and Shi'i themes (Rieu, *Supplement*, 2/833).

11. MS Add. 16832, ff. 230-41, British Library, London, copied from 1165-74/1651-61. A collection of Sufi and Shi'i tracts in Arabic and Persian made by Sayyid 'Alī Naqī Khān b. Sayyid Abū Ṭālib al-Ḥusaynī al-Mashhadī; it includes such varied authors as Shabistarī, Davānī, Jāmī, Ni'mat Allāh Valī, Mullā Ṣadrā, Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī, Bābā Afzal Kāshānī, Abū Ḥāmid Ghazālī, etc. (Rieu, *Supplement*, 2/831).
12. MS 3424/2, 40 ff., Masjid-i A'zam Library, Qom, copied in 1202/1788 (Ustādī, *Masjid-i A'zam*, 3/1338).
13. MS 3821-19/151 (257), 21 ff., Gulpāyagānī Library, Qom, copied in Rajab 1287/1870 (Ḥusaynī, *Gulpāyagānī*, 5/2828).
14. MS 70, Topkapı Palace Museum, Istanbul, undated (*Yazmalar*).
15. MS 2912 (31?), British Library, London (Rieu, *Catalogue*, 2/831).
16. MS 427, Asiatic Society, Calcutta ('Alī, *Asiatic*, 298).

A commentary on Fakhr al-Dīn 'Irāqī's *Lama'āt* consisting of 28 'gleams' (*lam'a*). In its exposition it draws on Ibn 'Arabī, Qūnavī, Aḥmad Ghazālī and others, and treats of such topics such as love and its manifestations, the Breath of the Merciful (*nafas-i raḥmānī*), the Muḥammadan reality (*ḥaqīqat-i Muḥammadī*), receptivity/capacity (*qābiliyyat*), effusion (*fayḏ*), etc. It was written over the course of the year 815/1412, presumably in Isfahan. Note the existence of a contemporary copy in Turkey.⁹³

Published: *Chahārdah Risāla-yi Fārsī az Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī b. Muḥammad Turka-yi Iṣfahānī*, ed. Sayyid 'Alī Mūsavī Bihbahānī and Sayyid Ibrāhīm Dībājī, Tehran, 1351 Sh./1972, 3-38.

⁹³ See Ritter, "Philologica VII," *Der Islam*, 21 (1933), 97.

2.1.3: Correspondence (*munsha'āt*)

A selection of Ibn Turka's correspondence was preserved posthumously in what is usually termed *Munsha'āt-i Ṣā'in-i Turka*, comprising 46 letters, letter fragments or notes he sent to or (in a few cases) received from various Timurid notables and associates. The oldest surviving copy of his correspondence is preserved in the margins of MS Majlis 10196, the earliest and almost comprehensive collection of the author's works made largely during his lifetime; however, it has only 12 of these 46 letters, plus three more that appear to be unique to this MS. MS Malik 4029 preserves a further letter to Ṣā'in al-Dīn not found elsewhere. As it has come down to us, then, the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* includes 50 letters or notes in total.

A second source for correspondence relating to Ibn Turka or the members of his immediate family is the *Munsha'āt-i Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī*, comprising Yazdī's correspondence, poetry and incidental writings; it is often featured in hybrid collections containing other epistolary material from the early Timurid period. This includes, in particular, the *Tuḥfa-yi Nuṣratī* of Abū Bakr b. 'Alī Iskandarī (Ashkazarī), a manual of epistolography written for the Muẓaffarid Shāh Yaḥyā,⁹⁴ which comprises historical documents from the time of Temür and exemplifies chancery practice during this period.⁹⁵ The *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* (often attributed to Sharaf al-Dīn's brother Qivām al-Dīn (d. 830/1427)⁹⁶ given its inclusion of some material related to the latter) has seven items (and in MS Majlis-i Sina 316, eight) concerning Ṣā'in al-Dīn or the Turka family.

⁹⁴ Shāh Yaḥyā b. Shāh Muẓaffar b. Muḥammad Mubārīz al-Dīn was the founder of the Mubārīz dynasty, based in Yazd. Shāh Yaḥyā was known to be a deceptive, greedy and ambitious man; Ḥāfiẓ in particular fleers him for his stinginess. Shāh Yaḥyā ruled as Temür's vassal in Shiraz from 789/1387 to 793/1391, but when he rebelled Temür imprisoned and executed him in Rajab 795/May 1393 (Navā'ī, *Asnād*, 19; Bosworth, *The New Islamic Dynasties*, 264).

⁹⁵ Dānishpazhūh conjectures that this Abū Bakr Iskandarī is to be identified as the father of Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī (see Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 25).

⁹⁶ On Qivām al-Dīn Yazdī see Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 25-27.

Taken together, then, there survive some 58 letters, letter fragments or notes as an invaluable source for reconstructing Ibn Turka's biography and intellectual and socio-political networks.⁹⁷

2.1.3.1: *Munsha'āt-i Turka*

1. MS 10196, 425 ff., Majlis Library, Tehran, copied between 828-38/1425-35, i.e., largely during Ibn Turka's lifetime; it is the earliest, most nearly complete and most reliable collection of the author's works. A selection of 15 letters from Ibn Turka's correspondence, 12 of which also occur in the *Munsha'āt-i Šā'in-i Turka* as represented below and 3 of which appear to be unique to this MS, is preserved in the margins of the following folios: 51b (4), 122a (3), 139a (1), 148a (1), 153b (1), 160a (3), 172a (1), 188b (1).⁹⁸
2. Microfilm 227, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), from an unspecified MS copied by 'Abd al-Raḥmān b. 'Alī b. Mu'ayyad and Raḥī b. 'Alī Ḥusaynī in Rabī' I and II 888/April-May 1483. This collection contains two of Šā'in al-Dīn's letters (nos. 4 and 6) preserved elsewhere (Dānishpazhūh, *Mikrūfilm-hā*, 1/436).
3. MS 316, 274 pp., Majlis-i Sinā Library, Tehran, copied on 12 Rabī' I 905/17 October 1499 (*Nashriyya*, 6/529-31; AB).⁹⁹ A colophon (pp. 257-58) suggests that a substantial section of this copy was completed on 7 Sha'bān 878/28 December 1473; the same colophon names Qivām al-Dīn Muḥammad Yazdī Šā'inī as the compiler and states that the collection was copied in Ulang/Alang-i Abyaz, aka Awn/Ūn Ulang/Alang, in 5 Rabī' I 849/11 June 1445 (i.e., the date of copying of the present copy's source?). I was only able to access this MS in an incomplete and in places illegible microfilm copy (1278) held at the University of Chicago Library; this copy drops a long section, pp. 75-174, and breaks off at p. 260. The MS is a hybrid collection comprising the following elements: 1) *Munsha'āt-i Šā'in-i Turka* (pp. 1-34), containing 45 letters, letter openings or notes from Šā'in al-Dīn; 2) the *Tuḥfa-yi Nuṣratī* of Abū Bakr b. 'Alī Iskandarī (pp. 35-73);¹⁰⁰ after the lacuna comes a largely intact copy of 3) the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* (pp. 125-242), beginning with the last two pages of Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's *Dībācha* to his *Faṭḥnāma-yi Šāhib-qirānī*¹⁰¹ (pp. 125-26; I presume the MS has the entire preface), and continuing with the same author's preface to his brother Qivām al-Dīn's *dīvān* and the rest of the material typically included among Yazdī's correspondence, including his letters,

⁹⁷ I am indebted to Evrim Binbaş for his help on this section.

⁹⁸ Dānishpazhūh's short review of this collection ("Majmū'a") is not entirely reliable in its identification of the marginal letters.

⁹⁹ I assume this is identical to MS 4/1 in the Bayānī Collection, Tehran, copied in 905/1500 (*Nashriyya*, 2/45).

¹⁰⁰ See Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 25.

¹⁰¹ See Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 249-57.

prefaces, short treatises and inscriptions, as well as seven items relating to Ibn Turka or the members of his immediate family; and 4) a short section (from p. 243 onwards; in the microfilm it ends abruptly at p. 260) that includes the heading *Munsha'āt-i Šālih* (p. 258) as well as additional material relating to Yazdī, including one letter addressed to Šā'in al-Dīn, presumably from Sharaf al-Dīn (pp. 257-58). The *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* preserved in this MS is almost identical to that in MS Vahid Paşa 621. This important MS is thus the most extensive early source for Ibn Turka's correspondence and other letters concerning the Turka family, and includes 12 letters from Šā'in al-Dīn not preserved elsewhere.

4. MS 4029/6, 54 ff., Malik Library, Tehran, copied in Edirne on 28 Jumādā I 921/10 July 1515; this collection of six of Šā'in al-Dīn's minor treatises contains two relevant letters, one of which is unique to this MS (Afshār, *Malik*, 7/143).
5. MS 2576, 402 pp., Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied in the 12th/18th century (AB); a microfilm copy (1269) is held at the University of Chicago Library. There are grammatical errors and other defective readings throughout. Like MS Majlis-i Sinā 316, this MS is a hybrid collection containing the following elements: 1) a defective copy of the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* (pp. 1-168), missing a sizeable section after p. 84 (though pagination continues uninterruptedly) and stopping arbitrarily at approximately the two-thirds mark to continue seamlessly (mid-page) with letter no. 15 from 2) the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* (pp. 168-217), which here contains the remaining 32 (out of 46) letters of this collection as found in MS Majlis-i Sinā 316 pp. 10-34;¹⁰² this is followed by 3) the *Tuḥfa-yi Nuṣratī* of Abū Bakr b. 'Alī Iskandarī (Ashkazarī), a manual of epistolography written for the Muẓaffarid Shāh Yaḥyā (pp. 218-93); 4) an unattributed *R. dar Ādāb-i Mukātaba u Murāsala* (pp. 293-362); and 5) Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's *Dībācha* to his *Fathnāma-yi Šāhib-qirānī* (pp. 362-402). Given the defective nature of the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* in this collection, it preserves only two letters relating to the Turkas, both from Ibn Turka's son (*makhdūmzāda-yi ḥaqīqī*) Jamāl al-Dīn Muḥammad (pp. 163-66); but while its version of the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* is similarly defective, the fact that what remains corresponds very closely to the version in MS Majlis-i Sinā 316 suggests the existence of a standard collection of Ibn Turka's correspondence that may survive in other, at present unidentified MS copies.

The letters as presented in MS Majlis-i Sinā 316 and MS Dānishgāh 2576 appear to follow a rough chronological order beginning after Šā'in al-Dīn's return to Iran from Cairo in ca. 810/1408; i.e., it is doubtful that the first letter that speaks of the author's departure from Isfahan for the Hijaz represents the point at which Šā'in al-Dīn first commenced his studies abroad, but rather suggests a pilgrimage taken during the first period of his career in Shiraz and Isfahan (ca. 810-17/1408-14) under the patronage first of Pīr Muḥammad b. 'Umar Shaykh and then Iskandar b. 'Umar Shaykh. From this point the letters sequentially reflect the

¹⁰² This fact confused the later scholar who supplied a partial list of contents at the beginning of this MS; he supposes several of Ibn Turka's letters to have been written by Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī.

beginning of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's career in Shiraz and Isfahan under the patronage of Iskandar, Shāhrukh's takeover of western Iran, the installation of various amirs in Fars, the harassment of Ṣā'in al-Dīn by local scholars and *dīvān* authorities, his journeys to the royal court in Herat to defend himself against accusations of heresy, the debacle of 830/1427 in which he was stripped of his position and property and sent into exile, his period of exile in northern and northwestern Iran, and his final return to Herat to await the review of his case. In short, they appear to conform neatly to the chronology of events in Ṣā'in al-Dīn's life established in other sources. But this order should not be presumed to be rigorous; many letters could have been written at any point in Ṣā'in al-Dīn's later career, though the increase in otherwise uncontextualized simple letters of greeting toward the end of the collection (letters 35-47) suggests an attempt by the author to massage his larger network of acquaintances, both Sufis and administrative officials, in hopes of resolving his intolerable situation. Nor is this collection by any means a complete record of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's dealings with his contemporaries; one would expect, for example, a fair number of letters to Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī, his disciple and closest associate, but we have here only one written during the first stage of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's career in Fars—perhaps many of the rest were simply too informal to be considered worth preserving. The closeness of their relationship is more adequately sketched in the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī*, however, which as noted contains eight items relating to Ṣā'in al-Dīn or the members of his immediate family, and show Sharaf al-Dīn's attendance at his teacher's majlises, his accompanying Ṣā'in al-Dīn on journeys to Herat, and his concern for the latter's children (*makhdūm-zādagān*) after their father's death, among other things.

The letters are written in the type of highly stylized ornate prose typical in the epistolography of the period; the formulaic nature of these texts serves to encode contextual information (addressee, addressee's social or political office, spiritual status), crucial as most of

these letters lack identifying headers, as well as subtextual information.¹⁰³ In a few letters below this information is too scant to allow for more than conjecture as to the identity of the addressee.

A survey of the *Munsha'āt-i Ṣā'in-i Turka* shows the frequency of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's dealings with various Timurid amirs and his close relationship to Bāysunghur b. Shāhrukh in particular,¹⁰⁴ as well as his friendly relations with various prominent Sufis in Iran—Shāh Ni'mat Allāh Valī, Qāsim-i Anvār, Aḥmad Samarqandī, Ḥasan 'Aṭṭār, and Sayyid Muḥammad b. Shaykh Kajujī, among others. The latter feature of his letters both corroborates the information he gives, for example, in his apologies as to his dealings with prominent Sufi shaykhs (primarily in an admonitory role) and acts as a counterbalance to Ṣā'in al-Dīn's criticisms of organized Sufism expressed in various works; furthermore, the fact that the first three Sufis named were great promoters of Ibn 'Arabī in the face of often hostile reaction suggests this as a point of attraction for Ṣā'in al-Dīn. In addition, two letters, one in MS Majlis 10196 (f. 153b) from Qāẓizāda Rūmī, director of Ulugh Beg's observatory in Samarkand, and another (no. 31) sending greetings to the astronomer Badr al-Dīn in Gilan reveal open lines of communication between occult philosophers like Ṣā'in al-Dīn and practitioners of what are now considered the 'legitimate' sciences, and hence suggest the type of easy intellectual confluence between esoteric and exoteric so common in the late medieval and early modern era. Precisely given their author's difficult fate as a persecuted, high-profile thinker and qadi, then, Ibn Turka's letters provide an invaluable entrée into the complex regional and transregional networks—intellectual, social,

¹⁰³ On the encoding of information in ornate prose see Melvin-Koushki, "The Delicate Art of Aggression." The two most useful guides for Persian *inshā'* usage of the Timurid period are Maḥmūd Gāvān's (d. 886/1481) *Manāẓir al-Inshā'* (ed. Ma'sūma Ma'dankan, Tehran, 1381 Sh./2002) and Ḥusayn Vā'iz Kāshifī's (d. 910/1505) *Makhzan al-Inshā'* (see e.g. MS Manisa 2768).

¹⁰⁴ See e.g. letter 17 below; it is transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.1.

political—in which the intellectuals of early 9th/15th century Iran operated.¹⁰⁵

In the list below references to the three MSS consulted will be abbreviated as follows:

Majlis 10196 = *TMN/M*; Majlis-i Sinā 316 = *TMN/MS*; Dānishgāh 2576 = *TMN/D*. The order is that of *TMN/MS* and *TMN/D*; one note from *TMN/M* not preserved elsewhere is inserted into this list in its conjectured chronological position (no. 26), and indicated by square brackets. Only one letter, to Amīr Fīrūzshāh (no. 27), has been published.¹⁰⁶

1) *Letters from Ibn Turka*

1. To Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī (16 Jumādā I [814]/5 September [1411], Isfahan): the author expresses his great desire to rejoin the company of his brother and fellow *muḥaqqiq* Sharaf al-Dīn, and his delight at receiving his letter. Šā'in al-Dīn states that at the time of writing—Friday night (*laylat al-sabt*), 16 Jumādā I¹⁰⁷—he is on the verge of setting out, at a leisurely pace, from Isfahan for the Hijaz (presumably for the purpose of making pilgrimage). He asks that, in the event Sharaf al-Dīn cannot join him on this journey, he at least keep in touch by writing. A postscript is added sending greetings to all the author's associates and singling out one Ya'qūb in particular (to be identified with Sayyid Sharaf al-Dīn Ya'qūb, member of a powerful sayyid family, who appears to have been Šā'in al-Dīn's protégé and qadi of Yazd after his teacher's departure; see letters 4, 6 and 12 below) (*TMN/M* f. 160a, *TMN/MS* p. 1; see Part 2, §P.2.1 below).
2. To Amīrzāda Bāysunghur: the opening of a letter to Bāysunghur, here called Malik Mu'izz al-Dawla wa-l-Dīn (*TMN/MS* p. 1).¹⁰⁸
3. To Shaykh 'Alā' al-Dīn 'Alī [Chishtī]:¹⁰⁹ a letter of greeting proper to a notable Sufi, including references to khanaqah life and *dhikr*. The author ends with a note to communicate his greetings to one Mawlānā Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad, presumably

¹⁰⁵ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 13. Note that in addition to the MSS of the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* listed above there seems to be a further collection mentioned in the *Nashriyya-yi Dānishgāh-i Tihārān* (2/45) and the *Rāhnumā-yi Kitāb* (4.3/237).

¹⁰⁶ Given the intrinsic interest of this collection as a representative example of early Timurid *munsha'āt*, however, I hope to publish an edition in the near future. Letters referenced in this dissertation appear in appendix P.2.

¹⁰⁷ The two likeliest candidates for the year of composition are thus 814 (5 September 1411) or 822 (10 June 1419); assuming a rough chronological order to the letters as they appear in *TMN/MS* and *TMN/D*, the earlier date is preferable.

¹⁰⁸ Assuming a rough chronological order, this letter appears to be out of place.

¹⁰⁹ This Chishtī sayyid appears to have been the most prominent individual of this name in Shahrukhid Iran. Shāhrukh appointed 'Alā' al-Dīn 'Alī Chishtī as administrator of his madrasa-khannaqah complex in Herat, completed in 813/1410 (Manz, *Power*, 223).

Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad b. Sa'd al-Dīn Taftāzānī (d. 838/1434), a prominent member of the religious establishment in Herat as *shaykh al-islām*¹¹⁰ (TMN/MS pp. 1-2).

4. To Amīr Jalāl al-Dīn (ca. 816/1413, Isfahan?), almost certainly Amīr Jalāl al-Dīn Fīrūzshāh:¹¹¹ a letter notifying the amir that due to harrassment (*tashvīsh*) by certain envious individuals (*hussād*)¹¹² the author finds it necessary to leave the region (*jalā-yi vaṭan*) for a time (i.e., move to Shiraz; cf. letter 12 below), and recommending as his replacement¹¹³ the young but learned Mawlānā Sharaf al-Dīn Ya'qūb (see letter 1; letter 12 similarly recommends him to Iskandar's chief vizier)¹¹⁴ (TMN/MS pp. 2-3).
5. To Ghiyās al-Dīn Yūsuf, i.e., Amīr Yūsuf Kh^wāja:¹¹⁵ a brief letter of greeting to the amir; cf. letters 9 and 25 below (TMN/MS p. 3).
6. To Ghiyās Aḥmad Niẓām, i.e., presumably Sayyid Amīr Niẓām al-Dīn Aḥmad Ṣā'idī:¹¹⁶ the author requests that the amir look into Sharaf al-Dīn Ya'qūb Qāẓī's situation and a group of Sufis that was sent to him (TMN/MS pp. 3-4).
7. To Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad, i.e., Shaykh al-Islām Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad b. Sa'd al-Dīn Taftāzānī:¹¹⁷ a letter of greeting to this prominent member of the religious establishment in Herat (TMN/MS p. 4).
8. To Iskandar b. 'Umar Shaykh (?) (ca. 816/1413, Isfahan or Shiraz): the author addresses a royal personage, presumably Iskandar b. 'Umar Shaykh, his patron before Shāhrukh's first campaign in western Iran in 817/1414 (he uses the descriptive phrase *imāmat-ma'ābī-yi khilāfat-qibābī*, followed by the benediction *lā zāla riyāḍu l-saltanati l-kāmilati nāḍirat^{an} bi-hiyāḍi ḥikmatī-hi wa-'adālatī-hi*; the partially illegible opening line suggests

¹¹⁰ Manz, *Power*, 58, 215. Other possible candidates include Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad Awhād (d. 838/1434), *mudarris* at the Barāmān madrasa in Herat and later appointed as *khaṭīb* of the mosque of Gawharshād (Manz, *Power*, 218); the Sufi Shaykh Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad Kūsūyī (d. 863/1459), one of the shaykhs of Jām (Manz, *Power*, 71, 200, 226-27, 235); and (if another 'Alā' al-Dīn 'Alī is meant here) Sayyid 'Alī Jurjānī's (d. 816/1413) son Sayyid Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad (d. 838/1434), the *mutawallī* of the Fazāriyya madrasa in Shiraz (Manz, *Power*, 166, 215). It is unlikely to be Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad Jazarī (d. 833/1429), the foremost teacher of Quran and hadith in the Timurid realm, who would become one of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's most implacable enemies; after Temūr's death Jazarī spent much of the rest of his life in Shiraz (Manz, *Power*, 166).

¹¹¹ See also letters 10, 21-23 and 27 below; a full six out of a total of 47 letters preserved in the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* are thus addressed to Amīr Fīrūzshāh. Not coincidentally, Fīrūzshāh was the known as the greatest patron of the religious establishment, including Sufis, among Shāhrukh's amirs (Manz, *Power*, 221). Cf. another letter to this amir in the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī*, from Amīr Żiyā' al-Dīn: YMN/V ff. 121b-22b, YMN/MS pp. 202-3, YMN/D pp. 131-33.

¹¹² Cf. "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 210.

¹¹³ I.e., this took place before Ṣā'in al-Dīn assumed the qadiship of Yazd in ca. 825/1422 after his first trial in Herat.

¹¹⁴ Manz, *Power*, 151.

¹¹⁵ Amīr Yūsuf Kh^wāja b. Shaykh 'Alī Bahādūr (d. 846/1442), brother of Kh^wāja Yūsuf, governed the region from Sultaniyya to Qom, including Rayy (Manz, *Power*, 250).

¹¹⁶ This amir controlled Isfahan during Iskandar's rise to power in western Iran (Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 210).

¹¹⁷ Cf. letter 3 above.

the honorific Jamāl al-Dīn); he regrets his inability to visit in person and so writes instead to communicate his profound regard (TMN/MS pp. 4-5).

9. To Amīr Ghiyās al-Dīn Yūsuf Kh^wāja: the author expresses his gladness at the amir's arrival in Persian Iraq during Ramaḍān, this being due in part to the spiritual support of Sufis (*himmat-i darvīshān*), and regrets that circumstances prevent him from attending the amir in person (TMN/MS pp. 5-6).
10. To Amīr Fīrūzshāh (ca. 817/1414, Isfahan?): the author expresses his gladness at the arrival of the amir's troops (TMN/MS pp. 6-7).
11. To Amīr Sayyid Zayn al-ʿĀbidīn:¹¹⁸ a letter expressing the author's appreciation for the amir's protection of the weak and oppressed, for which reason he is universally loved by religious leaders and scholars (*ʿumūm-i arbāb-i ʿamāyim*) (TMN/MS p. 7).¹¹⁹
12. To one Ḥāfiẓ, i.e., Vazīr Ghiyās al-Dīn Ḥāfiẓ Rāzī¹²⁰ (ca. 816/1413, Isfahan?): the author expresses his appreciation for the particular regard the amir shows to religious leaders and scholars, and uses the descriptive epithet *mamālik-maʿābī-yi ḥaqāyiq-qibābī*, suggesting an interest in esoteric matters on the part of the amir. He proceeds to recommend the young but learned Mawlānā Sharaf al-Dīn Yaʿqūb to the amir's service as qadi (presumably in Isfahan), given that the author is moving his family to Shiraz; he requests the vizier's assistance in this regard (TMN/MS pp. 7-8).
13. To Darvīsh Aḥmad Samarqandī:¹²¹ the author's note of greeting accompanying a copy of his *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr* (here *Durar*), completed in 806/1404 (TMN/MS pp. 8-9; see Part 2, §P.2.1 below).
14. To a *dīvān* official (Fayẓ Allāh?):¹²² the author expresses his wish to visit the court soon, though he cannot do so immediately, and apologizes for not having been able to finish correcting several books in the single day allotted him. His addressee would seem to have had an interest in esoteric matters (*ʿulūm-i ḥaqīqī u maʿārif-i zawqī*) (TMN/MS pp. 9-10).
15. To Sayyid Nizām al-Dīn Aḥmad, i.e., presumably Sayyid Amīr Nizām al-Dīn Aḥmad Ṣāʿidī (ca. 817/1414, Shiraz):¹²³ a letter accompanying the author's introductory treatise on the science of letters, presumably (assuming a rough chronological order) the *R. Ḥurūf*,

¹¹⁸ Zayn al-ʿĀbidīn Junābādī (Gunābādī), sayyid and bureaucrat/vizier prominent in the *dīvān* in Temūr's reign and at the beginning of Shāhrukh's, known for his religious learning (Manz, *Power*, 66, 83, 85, 107).

¹¹⁹ Cf. two other letters to this amir in the *Munshaʾāt-i Yazdī*: 1) From Amīr Ziyāʾ al-Dīn, YMN/V ff. 122b-23a, YMN/MS p. 203, YMN/D p. 133; and 2) From Amīr Ḥāfiẓ al-Dīn ʿAlī, YMN/V ff. 127b-28b, YMN/MS pp. 207-8, YMN/D pp. 143-45.

¹²⁰ Ghiyās al-Dīn Ḥāfiẓ Rāzī (d. 825/1422), based in Yazd, was chief vizier of Iskandar and subsequently appointed by Shāhrukh to transport the Yazd-produced *kiswa* to the Hijaz. He was known as a learned man and a Sufi, a *ḥāfiẓ* who knew seven languages (Manz 124, 149, 280).

¹²¹ A gifted and aggressive preacher and chief disciple (*khalīfa*) of Zayn al-Dīn Kh^wāfi who lost favor with him ostensibly for preaching Ibn ʿArabī's views and quoting the poetry of Qāsim-i Anvār. Note Kh^wāfi's intense hatred of Ibn ʿArabī, and thus of the latter's promoters such as Qāsim-i Anvār and his previously foremost disciple Darvīsh Aḥmad (Manz, *Power*, 203, 231, 236-37; Bashir, *Sufi Bodies*, 99, 191).

¹²² The *laqab* is suggested by the phrase *fāyiḍa minhā aḥkām al-mulk wa-l-dīn*.

¹²³ Almost certainly the same addressee as letter 6 above. A less likely candidate is Sayyid Nizām al-Dīn Aḥmad, the *vāʾiz-i Shīrāz* (Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Din," 44 n. 32); cf. the same individual's letter to the ruler of Gulbarga in the *Munshaʾāt-i Yazdī* (YMN/V ff. 113b-16b, YMN/MS pp. 197-98, YMN/D pp. 117-20).

completed in 817/1414 in Shiraz, or possibly the *R. Anjām*, completed in 828/1425; neither treatise contains an explicit dedication.¹²⁴ The author further states that he will soon visit (*TMN/MS* pp. 10-11, *TMN/D* pp. 168-70).

16. In reply to Shāhrukh's summons to attend his court during his first campaign in western Iran of mid-817/1414; Šā'in al-Dīn sent the letter from Isfahan to Yazd to be communicated to Shāhrukh by Sayyid Ni'mat Allāh Valī (817/1414, Isfahan).¹²⁵ The royal summons coincided with Shāhrukh's capture of Iskandar, Šā'in al-Dīn's erstwhile patron, in the same year and installation of Ibrāhīm Sulṭān b. Shāhrukh as governor of Fars; as such Šā'in al-Dīn is concerned to convey his admiration and well-wishing to the newly ascendant Shāhrukh, and assures the ruler that he will attend his court (*TMN/M* f. 148a, *TMN/MS* pp. 11-12, *TMN/D* pp. 170-73; see Part 2, §P.2.1 below).
17. In reply to Amīrzāda Bāysunghur, referring to a treatise the author wrote that was objected to by a certain individual;¹²⁶ Šā'in al-Dīn dismisses his objections as empty and ignorant posturing, and invites Bāysunghur to have the scholars at his court examine it thoroughly, based as it is solely on traditional and rational sources (*dalāyil-i naqlī u 'aqlī*). He asserts that the work in fact constitutes a virginal bride from the invisible realm, but very few people are sufficiently mature as to marry (i.e., comprehend) it (*TMN/M* f. 172a, *TMN/MS* pp. 12-13, *TMN/D* pp. 173-75; see Part 2, §P.2.1 below).
18. To Amīrzāda Bāysunghur in Herat (825/1422?, Herat): the author complains that he has been in attendance at Bāysunghur's court for two days but has not been allowed to see the prince; he suggests that perhaps it would be easier if the latter should choose to grace a majlis with his presence, where it would be easier to talk together (*TMN/M* f. 139a, *TMN/MS* pp. 13-14, *TMN/D* pp. 175-76).
19. To Amīrzāda Bāysunghur (ca. 826/1423?, Yazd?): an unusually long and effusive letter to Bāysunghur in which the author describes how he was in attendance at the prince's court and conversing with its members (*mulāzimān*) when Bāysunghur himself rode in and in the subsequent audience showed Šā'in al-Dīn particular favor. (Šā'in al-Dīn here calls himself a *darvīsh* who has suffered injustice (*sitam-dīda*) and a broken stranger (*īn shikasta-yi gharīb*), no doubt referring to his harassment by the *dīvān* officials and other enemies in Fars.) The author then expresses his congratulations (*tahniyat*) for Shāhrukh's recent conquest—he here calls Shāhrukh 'emperor of the kingdoms of Iran and Turan' (*pādshāh-i mamālik-i Īrān u Tūrān*)—, stating that the notables, religious leaders and scholars are hastening to the royal court to convey their congratulations in person. He regrets that due to the wintry conditions (which even the sultan's troops found quite difficult) he is unable to undertake the month-long journey to court, and apologizes profusely for the delay in fulfilling his duty. He does however remind the prince that when he was in attendance at the royal court some two months prior he was not granted an audience with Shāhrukh, but was rather subjected to the attacks of fault-finders and defamers (*TMN/MS* pp. 14-17, *TMN/D* pp. 176-82).
20. To Amīrzāda Shāhrukh (ca. 829/1426, Yazd?): the author greets the sultan and states that his objective in serving the Shari'a is twofold: 1) to be blameless before the

¹²⁴ Šā'in al-Dīn's third introductory treatise on lettrism, *R. Su'l al-Mulūk*, was completed in 829/1426 at the request of Bāysunghur.

¹²⁵ Dānishpazhūh identifies three separate letters on *TMN/M* f. 148a: one sent to Ni'mat Allāh Valī as dictated by Iskandar, followed by two from Šā'in al-Dīn to Ni'mat Allāh Valī asking him to intercede with Shāhrukh on his behalf ("Majmū'a," 309).

¹²⁶ Perhaps Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad Jazarī.

Prophet, and 2) to further Shāhrukh's Shari'a-promoting mission. He has accordingly sent a *darvīsh* to the latter's court to discuss a number of considerations to this end. Secondly, Ṣā'in al-Dīn says that he is sending with this letter a treatise he wrote on the occult properties of things and various occult sciences (*dar bāb-i khavāṣṣ-i ashyā u 'ulūm ast gharīb chīzī chand*) that the ruler should find interesting; this is most probably the *R. Su'l al-Mulūk*, written in 829/1426 for Bāysunghur¹²⁷ (TMN/MS p. 17, TMN/D pp. 182-83; see Part 2, §P.2.1 below).

21. To Amīr Fīrūzshāh: the author greets the amir and hopes that his success will be furthered through the spiritual support of Sufis (*du'ā-yi darvīshān u himmat-i īshān*). Ṣā'in al-Dīn then petitions the amir (*zarā'at*) to instruct his *nuvvāb* to receive the bearer of this letter, Shaykh Burhān al-Dīn Amīr Shaykh b. Shaykh Taqī l-Dīn Dādā,¹²⁸ for whose character and learning he vouches, as the latter has a few requests to make (TMN/MS pp. 17-18, TMN/D pp. 183-84).
22. To Amīr Fīrūzshāh (ca. 827-28/1423-24?,¹²⁹ Yazd?): the author expresses his gladness at the arrival of the royal troops to Persian Iraq under the amir's command, counting it a great boon to all religious leaders and scholars (*'umūm-i arbāb-i 'amāyim*) who had been suffering with all the unrest in the region (with the exception of the *nukabā-yi ḥirmān*). Ṣā'in al-Dīn further expresses his wish to attend the amir's court immediately and regrets that circumstances prevent it at the moment (TMN/M f. 51b, TMN/MS p. 18, TMN/D pp. 184-86).
23. To Amīr Fīrūzshāh: this appears to be only the opening of a letter to the amir, with no indication as to the purpose for writing (TMN/MS pp. 18-19, TMN/D p. 186).
24. To Vazīr Amīr Sayyid Zayn al-'Ābidīn: a brief note of well-wishing and appreciation for the vizier's support religion and learning, and hopes that the spiritual power of Sufis will further his success. Like letter 23, this appears to be the opening of a longer letter (TMN/MS p. 19, TMN/D pp. 186-87).
25. To Amīr Yūsuf Kh^wāja (ca. 829/1426?, Yazd or Herat?): the author complains that despite his status as the most established man of letters in Fars according to custom since the time of Ghāzān Khān and his frequent and difficult trips to the royal court, he is being harrassed by *dīvān* officials (*muṣāyaqa*, *tashvīsh*) and requests the amir's intervention in this intolerable situation (TMN/MS p. 19, TMN/D pp. 187-88).
26. [A brief request (ca. 829/1426?, Herat?) from Ṣā'in al-Dīn to the *dīvān* bureaucrats that they issue his stipend (*dāranda*), given that it is winter and he has a large family to care for (TMN/M f. 160a).]
27. To Amīr Fīrūzshāh (ca. 830/1427, Herat?): the author complains of his torture and imprisonment at the hands of the debt- and tax-collectors of the royal *dīvān* and their confiscation of his property; he thanks the amir for his attention into the matter and for ordering the restoration of some of his property, which will allow him to care for his family.¹³⁰ He states that a group of his friends successfully freed him from

¹²⁷ It should be noted that this treatise also features a prognostication of the duration of the Timurid state—one century—based upon a lettrist analysis of Shāhrukh's name (MS Majlis 10196 f. 178b).

¹²⁸ Shaykh Taqī l-Dīn Dādā's mausoleum was located in the Sar-Ab-i Naw quarter east of Yazd (one of the two most important mausolea in the city), and his khanaqah in the nearby village of Bundarabad (Manz, *Power*, 172).

¹²⁹ The family of Fīrūzshāh was assigned the governorship of Isfahan in 827/1424 or 828/1425 (Manz, *Power*, xv).

¹³⁰ Or: he requests the amir to order this?

imprisonment, and that to his shame he is still dependent upon their protection for his survival; his family suffers mightily due to the deprivations they are enduring. Šā'in al-Dīn therefore petitions (*arza-dāsh*) the amir to pursue his case further and to restore his stipend (*dāranda*). He ends the letter by dwelling on a hadith (*kullu l-nāsi yaghdū fa-bā'i^{un} nafsa-hu fa-mu'tiqu-hā aw mūbiqu-hā*)¹³¹ and a quranic verse (Q 32:21: "And We shall surely let them taste the nearer chastisement before the greater; perhaps so they will return") in a pious meditation on the purpose of suffering in this life. (The note concerning one Rukn al-Dīn/ʿAzud al-Dīn that appears to be appended to this letter in *TMN/M* occurs in *TMN/MS* as a freestanding *hāshiya* before letter 2 above, suggesting that there is some confusion as to which letter it is meant to contextualize) (*TMN/M* f. 160a, *TMN/MS* pp. 19-21, *TMN/D* pp. 188-90; published in *Chahārdah Risāla*, 295-96).

28. To the ruler of Mazandaran in Sari, i.e., Sayyid Murtaẓā Mar'ashī¹³² (ca. 831-32/1428-29, Mazandaran): a pained exposition of the tribulations of the author and his family in exile and requesting the ruler's support in the form of a stipend (*dāranda*), for the work of scholars (*kār-i fuẓalā u dānishmandān*) is wholly dependent on royal patronage. The author first speaks of having passed through Gilan but, finding it uncongenial,¹³³ preferred to proceed forthwith to Mazandaran and the Mar'ashī court at Sari. He then touches on his troubles, saying that he, an innocent scholar (*īn dānishmand-i bī-gunāh*), was punished (*ta'zīb*, i.e., imprisoned?) for a full year despite the intercession of various amirs and other notables. (A break occurs here, with an interjected *huwa*, which seems to indicate that two letters have here been combined: the first requesting an audience at the Mar'ashī court, the second written after such audience was granted.) Šā'in al-Dīn proceeds to express his gratitude for being graciously welcomed to court, which served to ease the pains of exile (*ādash-i hijrān u hirmān*, *dard-i hijrān u bī-sāmānī-yi awẓā'i dawrān*); he describes being in attendance there for two days where he was shown every respect, and fears to impose further on the ruler's time, but will stay a further two days at the latter's insistence (*TMN/MS* pp. 21-23, *TMN/D* pp. 190-94).
29. To Sayyid Aḥmad, i.e., Amīr Sayyid Aḥmad Kārkiyā¹³⁴ (ca. 831-32/1428-29, Gilan): the author first praises the amir's patronage of scholars and Sufis, proceeding to congratulate (*tahniyat*) him on his conquest; Šā'in al-Dīn regrets that family duties, all the more pressing in exile, prevent him from expressing his congratulations in person,

¹³¹ Muslim, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *al-Ṭahāra*, bab 1, hadith 556; al-Tirmidhī, *Sunan*, K. *al-Da'awāt 'an al-Rasūl*, bab 91, hadith 3859; Ibn Māja, *Sunan*, K. *al-Ṭahāra*, bab 5, hadith 293; etc.

¹³² Sayyid Murtaẓā Mar'ashī b. 'Alī Sārī (d. 837/1433) ruled in Sari from 820-37/1417-33 (Calmard, "Mar'ashīs," *EF*²; Manz, *Power*, 141-42).

¹³³ Cf. the remarks of 'Abd al-Fattāḥ Fūmanī in his *Tārīkh-i Gīlān*, 5 (trans. in Melville, "The Caspian Provinces," 45): "If anyone blessed with perceptiveness, intelligence, wisdom and an understanding of the times, after reading and contemplating this book, ponders with the eye of reflection and experience the tyranny, heretical innovations and contempt for others that the men of Gilan have constantly displayed, he will know for sure what consequences will follow from ingratitude for benefits received and from violation of the dues owed to an ancient benefactor."

¹³⁴ The Kārkiyā were a Zaydī Shī'a family of sayyids with dynastic control of Gilan. Under Shāhrukh the region was first ruled by Sayyid Riẓā Kārkiyā (d. 829/1426), and subsequently by Sayyid Nāṣir Kārkiyā in Lahijan and Sayyid Aḥmad Kārkiyā in Ranikuh (Manz, *Power*, 136, 142, 253, 280). Sayyid Aḥmad is the most likely candidate here: the letter was written during Šā'in al-Dīn's period of exile in northern Iran, and the language used to address the sayyid (e.g., *ālī-ḥazrat-i khilāfat-panāhī-yi imāmat-ma'ābī lā zāla zimāmu niẓāmi l-mulki wa-l-dīni bi-yaday qudrati-hi wa-iqbālī-hi*) indicates his status as an autonomous ruler.

as do the weakness and ill health brought on by his recent tribulations. But he is confident that his letter will be sufficient, recalling a poetic exchange between the author and the amir on this theme (TMN/MS pp. 23-24, TMN/D pp. 194-96).

30. To Amīr Sayyid Nāṣir Kārkiyā¹³⁵ (ca. 831-32/1428-29, Gilan): a *tahniyat-nāma* on Sayyid Nāṣir's conquest as communicated to him by the members of his court near Rayy¹³⁶ and discussed in a recent majlis. The author proceeds to praise the amir's patronage of scholars and regret his inability to attend the amir's court due to physical infirmity (TMN/MS pp. 24-25, TMN/D pp. 196-99).
31. To Amīr Sayyid Nāṣir Kārkiyā (ca. 831-32/1428-29, Gilan): a letter of greeting and congratulations on a conquest, accomplished with the spiritual support of Sufis. The letter is followed by a postscript in which the author sends his greetings to the members of the Kārkiyā court, singling out the astronomer Badr al-Dīn (*Badr al-maṭālī' al-ḥikam al-ṭūsiyya wa-l-aḥkām al-Baṭalmūsiyya*, i.e., of the school of Ṭūsī and Ptolemy) for particular respect (TMN/M f. 51b, TMN/MS pp. 25-26, TMN/D pp. 199-201).
32. To Amīr Sayyid Kārkiyā, i.e., either Sayyid Nāṣir or Sayyid Aḥmad¹³⁷ (ca. 831-32/1428-29, Gilan): a brief *tahniyat-nāma* on a conquest, crediting it to the presence of Sufis in the amir's retinue (TMN/M f. 51b, TMN/MS p. 26, TMN/D pp. 201-2).
33. To Amīr 'Alā' al-Dīn¹³⁸ (ca. 831-32/1428-29, Gilan?): a *ta'ziyat-nāma* on the death of one of his sons of the Bahādur line, consoling the amir with the thought that since he is at the height of his powers he will soon produce another heir, which will serve to ease the Amīra's grief (TMN/M f. 122a, TMN/MS p. 26-27, TMN/D pp. 202-3).
34. To Amīr 'Alā' al-Dīn Gīlānī (ca. 831-32/1428-29, Gilan?): a letter of thanks sent after attending the amir's court and enjoying his solicitude, this after the events of 830/1427 (the author refers to himself as *sitam-dīda*, a victim of injustice) (TMN/M f. 122a, TMN/MS pp. 27-28, TMN/D pp. 203-5).
35. To Shaykh al-Islām Kh^wāja Sayyid Muḥammad b. Kh^wāja Shaykh Kajujī¹³⁹ (ca. 831-32/1428-29, Lahijan-Tabriz?): a letter of greeting to the *shaykh al-islām* and leading Sufi of Tabriz reporting on the author's travel via Lahijan during the first 10 days of Jumādā II and the assistance of one Ḥasan, who will inform Sayyid Muḥammad of the necessary details when he arrives; Ṣā'in al-Dīn closes the letter with an inquiry after the sayyid's health. A postscript sends greetings to the sayyid's disciples and residents of his khanaqah in Tabriz (*mulāzimān-i āstān-i 'irfān-āshyān, fuṣalā-yi kām-kār u 'urafā-yi 'ālī-iqtidār*) and expresses the author's longing to be among them (*yā layta-nī kuntu ma'a-hum*) (TMN/M f. 122a, TMN/MS pp. 28-29, TMN/D pp. 205-6).

¹³⁵ See preceding footnote.

¹³⁶ But this was controlled by Amir Yūsuf Kh^wāja, who governed the area from Sultaniyya to Qom (Manz, *Power*, 250).

¹³⁷ Their father, Sayyid Rizā Kārkiyā, died in 829/1426, and thus before Ṣā'in al-Dīn's sojourn in Gilan during his exile.

¹³⁸ There appear to be several candidates for the addressee of this and the following letter, presumably the same individual: 'Alā' al-Dīn (al-Dawla) b. Bāysunghur (d. 865/1460) (as he was born in 1417, however, this is perhaps less likely); 'Alā' al-Dīn 'Alīka Kükältash; or 'Alā' al-Dawla, son of the vizier 'Izz al-Dīn Ṭāhir Simnānī, who served the ruler of Mazandaran (Manz, *Power*, 101).

¹³⁹ The son of Kh^wāja Ghiyās al-Dīn Muḥammad, known as Shaykh Kajujī (Kujujī, Kajūjānī) Tabrīzī (d. 778/1376), among the leading mystics of Tabriz and master of the main khanaqah there; he was also *shaykh al-islām* of the city, a position his son inherited ('Abbās Fātiḥī Abarqūṭī, "Musāfir-i Bukhārā: Aḥvāl, Āsār u Zindagī-yi Nāṣir-i Bukhārāṭī," *Kayhān-i Farhangī*, 248 (Khurdād 1386 Sh.), pp. 58-63, p. 62).

36. To Kh^wāja Tāj al-Dīn Ḥasan ‘Aṭṭār:¹⁴⁰ a letter of greeting to the prominent Naqshbandi Sufi in eulogy of his spiritual stature and abilities as shaykh, with a postscript sending greetings to the shaykh’s disciples and residents of his khanaqah and expressing the author’s longing to visit (*yā layta-nī kuntu ma’a-hum*) (TMN/M f. 51b, TMN/MS p. 29, TMN/D pp. 206-7; see Part 2, §P.2.1 below).
37. To Sayyid Qāsim-i Anvār: a brief letter of eulogy and friendship;¹⁴¹ the author closes by asking after the shaykh’s health. A postscript sends greetings to the shaykh’s disciples (*mulāzimān-i āstān-i irshād-āshyān*), expressing his particular regard for the jurist (*taqvā-qibāb-i fatvā-āyāt*) ‘Azīz Jalāl Yūsuf, most probably Jalāl al-Dīn Yūsuf Awbahī, the loyal student of Sa’d al-Dīn Taftāzānī (d. 793/1390) and prominent among the Herati ulama¹⁴² (TMN/MS pp. 29-30, TMN/D pp. 207-9; see Part 2, §P.2.1 below).
38. To Sayyid Qāsim-i Anvār (830/1427 or 834/1431?, Herat?): a brief letter to the shaykh written after the author spent several days in his company; Ṣā’in al-Dīn describes Sayyid Qāsim with the notable eulogistic phrase *valāyat-panāhī-yi irshād-malāzī-yi siyādat-qibābī-yi haqāyiq-ma’ābī-yi ‘irfān-iyābī* (TMN/MS pp. 30-31, TMN/D pp. 209-10).
39. A brief note to Sayyid Bahā’ al-Dīn,¹⁴³ a Sufi shaykh (*janāb-i siyādat-qibāb-i ma’ālī-iyāb-i haqāyiq-ma’āb*) (TMN/MS p. 31, TMN/D p. 210; see Part 2, §P.2.1 below).
40. A brief note to Mīr Makhdūm, a shaykh (*janāb-i tawfīq-iyāb-i haqāyiq-ma’āb*), and his Sufi disciples (*muṭṭifān-i darvīshān*) (TMN/MS p. 31, TMN/D p. 210).
41. To Ṣadr Jalāl al-Dīn Luṭf Allāh:¹⁴⁴ a brief letter expressing the author’s regard for the chief *ṣadr*, whom he calls *sulṭān al-‘ulamā’* (TMN/MS p. 31, TMN/D p. 211).
42. To Ṣadr Jalāl al-Dīn Luṭf Allāh: a brief letter of well-wishing (TMN/MS p. 31, TMN/D pp. 211-12).
43. To Ghiyās al-Dīn Ḥāfiẓ, i.e., the same Ghiyās al-Dīn Ḥāfiẓ Rāzī of letter 12 above:¹⁴⁵ a brief letter of well-wishing to Iskandar’s former chief vizier, who is now primarily occupied with teaching (the author speaks of his mass of students (*wufūd al-ṭalaba*)) (TMN/MS pp. 31, TMN/D p. 212).
44. To Vazīr Faṣīḥ, i.e., Faṣīḥ Aḥmad Kh^wāfi:¹⁴⁶ a brief letter of well-wishing toward the vizier (TMN/MS pp. 32, TMN/D pp. 212-13).

¹⁴⁰ Presumably Kh^wāja Ḥasan ‘Aṭṭār, the son of ‘Alā’ al-Dīn ‘Aṭṭār (d. 802/1400), successor to Bahā’ al-Dīn Naqshband (d. 791/1389). His son Kh^wāja Muḥammad, based in Transoxania, was held in high esteem by Jāmī (d. 898/1492) (Gross and Urunbaev, *The Letters*, 85).

¹⁴¹ Among the descriptors Ṣā’in al-Dīn uses here is *niqābat-qibābī*, suggesting that Qāsim-i Anvār held the position of *naqīb* in Herat.

¹⁴² Jalāl al-Dīn Yūsuf Awbahī was among the prominent Herati ulama and one of four teachers appointed to Shāhrukh’s madrasa-khanaqah complex; he was the student of Sa’d al-Dīn Taftāzānī and staunchly defended his teacher’s positions (Manz, *Power*, 58). A second, less-likely candidate is Jalāl al-Dīn Yūsuf b. Qāsim Ḥallāj (d. 823/1420) (Manz, *Power*, 217).

¹⁴³ Possibly Bahā’ al-Dīn ‘Umar Jaghāra’ī (d. 857/1453), a prominent Herati shaykh (Manz, *Power*, 59).

¹⁴⁴ Jalāl al-Dīn Luṭf Allāh (d. 842/1439) was chief *ṣadr* under Shāhrukh (Manz, *Power*, 213).

¹⁴⁵ This identity is suggested by the similarity of the opening addresses in both letters: letter 12 uses the phrase *mamālik al-ḥaqā’iq* in reference to the amir (together with the epithet *mamālik-ma’ābī-yi haqāyiq-qibābī*), the present letter *jawāhir al-ḥaqā’iq*. The alteration in this phrase—*mamālik* to *jawāhir*—reflects the intervening termination of Ghiyās al-Dīn Ḥāfiẓ’s political career with the downfall of Iskandar.

¹⁴⁶ I.e., Faṣīḥ Kh^wāfi, Bāysunghur’s vizier (Kh^wāndamīr, *Ḥabīb al-Siyar*, Tome 3, Pt. 3, 352).

45. To two unnamed Sufis: a letter on Sufi and illuminationist themes, reporting on the proceedings of a majlis (TMN/MS pp. 32-33, TMN/D pp. 213-16).
46. To Kh^wāja Ṣāḥir al-Dīn Muḥammad:¹⁴⁷ a letter of friendship; the author opens by praying against the wiles of the envious and hostile and invoking the spiritual support of the Sufis. He regrets that their respective families have fallen out of touch, and is delighted that they have renewed the old bond; Ṣāḥir al-Dīn further expresses the wish to reestablish contact with other individuals possibly related to him, particularly one Kh^wāja Burhān al-Dīn Yaqīn, from whom he is currently estranged (TMN/M f. 188b, TMN/MS pp. 33-34, TMN/D pp. 216-17).
47. To one Zāfir al-Dīn, a Sufi:¹⁴⁸ a very brief and informal note expressing friendship and sincere regard (TMN/MS p. 34, TMN/D p. 217).

2) Letters to Ibn Turka in MS Majlis 10196

1. From Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (*ḥaẓrat-i Sayyidi*) to Ṣāḥir al-Dīn: a warm letter urging Ṣāḥir al-Dīn to write a work establishing the propositions (*muqaddamāt*) and associations or conjunctions (*iqtirānāt*) proper to the science of letters—perhaps the *Mafāḥiṣ*? Akhlāṭī addresses his accomplished disciple as *khalīlī* ('my bosom companion') and describes him as *al-amīr al-khaṭīr wa-l-badr al-munīr wa-l-baḥr al-ghazīr*, the leading luminary among his circle of brethren (*wāsiṭat 'aqd ikhwāni-hi*). The sayyid closes with a brief lettrist analysis of a Prophetic hadith (*ṭa'āmu l-wāḥidi yakfī l-ithnayni, wa-ṭa'āmu l-ithnayni yakfī l-arba'ata, wa-ṭa'āmu l-arba'ati yakfī l-thamāniyata*), seemingly in allusion to a recent stay by Ṣāḥir al-Dīn at his residence (TMN/M, front matter; see Part 2, §P.2.2 below).¹⁴⁹
2. From Qāẓizāda Rūmī to Ṣāḥir al-Dīn on receiving a copy of the latter's *Sharḥ al-Basmala*¹⁵⁰ (ca. 829/1426, Samarkand): the astronomer opens his letter with tones of great respect, including descriptive phrases emphasizing Ṣāḥir al-Dīn's mastery of the whole of the Islamic tradition (*ḥaẓrat-i sharī'at-shi'ārī-yi ṭarīqat-disārī-yi ḥaqīqat-āsārī*) and spiritual perfection (*valāyat-shi'ārī-yi virāsāt-disārī-yi khatmī-yi atammī*), and expresses his great desire to see him—the alchemical matrix of everlasting life and eternal collyrium (*kīmiyā-yi ḥayāt-i abadī u tūtiyā-yi bīnā'ī-yi sarmadī*)—in person. Qāẓizāda then mentions meeting Ṣāḥir al-Dīn in Herat¹⁵¹ and reminds him of his promise to visit him in Samarkand. The author proceeds to thank Ṣāḥir al-Dīn for sending him a copy of his *R.*

¹⁴⁷ Perhaps the copyist of MS Majlis 10196 (Dānishpazhūh, "Majmū'a," 311); cf. MS Majlis 10196 f. 330a, where a note in the author's hand refers to a Ṣāḥir al-Dīn as the copyist.

¹⁴⁸ As suggested by the opening phrase *lā zāla fī l-irtiqā' i ilā ma'ārijī l-kamālī Zāfir^{an} li-l-Ḥaqīqati wa-l-Ṭarīqati wa-l-Dīn*.

¹⁴⁹ See appendix P.2, no. 2.1 for a transcription of this letter. Cf. Gāzurgāhī (*Majālis al-'Ushshāq*, 189), who states that Akhlāṭī's disciples, including Ṣāḥir al-Dīn, Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī and Qāẓizāda Rūmī, would occupy themselves with spiritual exercises (*riyāẓāt u mujāḥadāt*) in a room under Akhlāṭī's house.

¹⁵⁰ The treatise was completed by 829/1426, suggesting that the present letter was written around the time of letters 24 and 25 above.

¹⁵¹ I.e., during the latter's second trial?

Basmala, and remarks on the refined and agreeable comportment of Ṣahīr al-Dīn,¹⁵² who brought the treatise to him and conveyed Ṣā'in al-Dīn's greetings (TMN/M f. 153b; see Part 2, §P.2.2 below).¹⁵³

3) Letters to or from Ibn Turka in other MSS

1. To Amīrzāda Bāysunghur (microfilm 227/4, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), from an unspecified MS copied by Raḏī b. 'Alī Ḥusaynī in Rabī' I and II 888/April-May 1483 (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/436)).
2. From Amīr Riḏā Kiyā to Ṣā'in al-Dīn (MS 4029/6, Malik Library, Tehran, copied in Edirne on 28 Jumādā I 921/10 July 1515 (Afshār, *Malik*, 7/143); MS 2024, Revan Köşkü Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul, copied by 'Alī b. Qivām b. Aḥmad, Mawlā Mīrak Ṭabīb, in Rabī' I and II 888/April-May 1483; according to the colophon this copy was proofread on 11 Muḥarram 891/17 January 1486 (Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 22/160, no. 6503; *MKh*, 19)).
3. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's reply to the foregoing letter from Amīr Riḏā Kiyā (MS 4029/6, Malik Library, Tehran, copied in Edirne on 28 Jumādā I 921/10 July 1515 (Afshār, *Malik*, 7/143); microfilm 227/6, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), from an unspecified MS copied by 'Abd al-Raḥmān b. 'Alī b. Mu'ayyad in Rabī' I and II 888/April-May 1483 (Dānishpazhūh, *Mīkrūfilm-hā*, 1/436)).

The above three letters are found in other sources not available to me at the time of writing, but two of them may be supposed to duplicate letters from the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* collection described above. Context suggests that the sender and recipient of letters 2 and 3 is incorrectly identified as Amīr Sayyid Riḏā Kārkiyā,¹⁵⁴ given that he had died (in 829/1426) before Ṣā'in al-Dīn's sojourn in Gilan during his period of exile, which rather coincided with the rule of Sayyid Nāṣir Kārkiyā from Lahijan and that of his brother Sayyid Aḥmad from Ranikuh. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's reply (no. 3) to the Kārkiyā sayyid may therefore be presumed to be identical to one of the three letters to Sayyid Nāṣir (nos. 30, 31, 32) or the letter to Sayyid Aḥmad (no. 29) above. Letter 2 in this list does however preserve this amir's initial letter to Ṣā'in al-Dīn, which is not otherwise preserved in TMN/M, TMN/MS or TMN/D. Letter 1, to Bāysunghur, may likewise

¹⁵² Presumably the same Ṣahīr al-Dīn of letter 45, who was possibly the copyist of MS Majlis 10196.

¹⁵³ See appendix P.2, no. 2.2 for a transcription of this letter.

¹⁵⁴ Sayyid Riḏā Kiyā was the chief ruler of Gilan (Manz, *Power*, 142).

be presumed to be identical to one of the four letters (2, 17, 18, 19) to Bāysunghur described above.

2.1.3.2: *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī*

1. MS 1019, Revan Collection, Topkapı Palace Museum, Istanbul, copied on 27 Sha'bān 867/17 May 1463; a microfilm copy (152) is held at the Millī Library, Tehran. This MS, which I was unable to examine, is very similar in content to MS Vahid Paşa 621.
2. MS 621, Kütahya Vahid Paşa Library, copied on 10 Dhū l-Qa'da 868/15 July 1464 and lacking a few folios at the beginning. It contains Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's *Dībācha* to his *Faṭḥnāma-yi Ṣāḥib-qirānī* (ff. 3a-10a),¹⁵⁵ his preface (dated 830/1427) for his brother Qivām al-Dīn's *dīvān* (ff. 10b-16a), his preface for the album (*muraqqa'*) of one Khwāja 'Abd al-Qādir (ff. 16a-39b), his preface for an anthology (*chung*) prepared by Khwāja Rukn al-Dīn Mas'ūd Ṣā'idī for prince Ismā'īl b. Ibrāhīm Sulṭān (ff. 40a-45a), several other prefaces (ff. 45a-59a), assorted correspondence with various Timurid notables, including seven letters or incidental material concerning Ibn Turka or the members of his family as specified below, and other incidental writings such as postscripts (*khātimas*) and brief forays into various topics (ff. 59a-176b), as well as inscriptions for several structures in Shiraz and environs (ff. 92b-96b). Its companion volume, MS 622, contains his collected poetry (*manẓūmāt*).
3. MS 316, 274 pp., Majlis-i Sinā Library, Tehran, copied on 12 Rabī I 905/17 October 1499 (*Nashriyya*, 6/529-31; AB). A colophon (pp. 257-58) suggests that a substantial section of this copy was completed on 7 Sha'bān 878/28 December 1473; the same colophon names Qivām al-Dīn Muḥammad Yazdī Ṣā'inī as the compiler and states that the collection was copied in Ulang/Alang-i Abyaẓ, aka Awn/Ūn Ulang/Alang, in 5 Rabī I 849/11 June 1445 (i.e., the date of copying of the present copy's source?). I was only able to access this MS in a poor and in places illegible microfilm copy (1278) held at the University of Chicago Library; this copy drops a long section, pp. 75-174, and breaks off at p. 260. The MS is a hybrid collection comprising the following elements: 1) *Munsha'āt-i Ṣā'in-i Turka* (pp. 1-34), containing some 40 letters from or to Ibn Turka; 2) the *Tuḥfa-yi Nuṣratī* of Abū Bakr b. 'Alī Iskandarī (pp. 35-73); after the lacuna comes a largely intact copy of 3) the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* (pp. 125-242), beginning with the last two pages of Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's *Dībācha* to his *Faṭḥnāma-yi Ṣāḥib-qirānī* (pp. 125-26; I presume the MS has the entire preface),¹⁵⁶ and continuing with the same author's preface to his brother Qivām al-Dīn's *dīvān* and the rest of the material typically included among Yazdī's correspondence, including his letters, prefaces, short treatises and inscriptions, as well as seven items relating to Ibn Turka or the members of his immediate family; and 4) a short section (from p. 243 onwards; in the microfilm it ends abruptly at p. 260) that includes the heading *Munsha'āt-i Ṣāliḥ* (p. 258) as well as additional material relating to Yazdī, including one letter addressed to Ḥaẓrat-i Ṣā'iniyya, presumably Ibn Turka (but possibly Qivām al-Dīn, aka Ṣā'inī) (pp. 257-58). The *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* preserved in this MS is almost identical to that in MS Vahid Paşa 621.

¹⁵⁵ See Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 249-57.

¹⁵⁶ See Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 249-57.

4. MS H. 5 (7), Cambridge University Library, copied in the 9th/15th century; similar in content to MSS Revan 1019 and Vahit Paşa 621, it includes Sharaf al-Dīn's *Dībācha* to his *Faṭḥnāma-yi Şāhibqirānī* (ff. 1a-10b), his preface to his brother Qivām al-Dīn's *dīvān* (ff. 10b-11a), and much, though not all, of the correspondence and incidental writings included in the two oldest collections, but none of the short treatises.¹⁵⁷ It includes five of the seven (or eight) letters relating to the Turka family.
5. MS Orient. 4° 142, Staatsbibliothek preussischer Kulturbesitz, Berlin, a full copy of the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī*.
6. MS 3685, Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad, undated (= MS Malik 3685). A microfilm copy (1262) is held at the University of Chicago Library. A shorter version of the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī*; it includes 19 letters not found in the above MSS, though none by Yazdī or Ibn Turka.
7. MS 2576, 402 pp., Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied in the 12th/18th century; a microfilm copy (1269) is held at the University of Chicago Library. There are grammatical errors and other defective readings throughout. Like MS Majlis-i Sinā 316, this MS is a hybrid collection containing the following elements: 1) a defective copy of the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* (pp. 1-168), missing a sizeable section after p. 84 (though pagination continues uninterrupted) and stopping arbitrarily approximately at the two-thirds mark to continue seamlessly (mid-page) with letter no. 14 from 2) the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* (pp. 168-217), which here contains the remaining 27 (out of 40) letters of this collection as found in MS Majlis-i Sinā 316 pp. 10-34; this is followed by 3) the *Tuḥfa-yi Nuṣratī* of Abū Bakr b. 'Alī Iskandarī (Ashkazurī) (pp. 218-93), a manual of epistolography written for the Muẓaffarid Shāh Yaḥyā; 4) an unattributed *R. dar Ādāb-i Mukātaba u Murāsala* (pp. 293-362); and 5) Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's *Dībācha* to his *Faṭḥnāma-yi Şāhib-qirānī* (pp. 362-402). Given the defective nature of the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* in this collection, it preserves only two letters relating to the Turkas, both from Ibn Turka's son (*makhdūmzāda-yi ḥaqīqī*) Jamāl al-Dīn Muḥammad (pp. 163-66); but while its version of the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* is similarly defective, the fact that what remains corresponds precisely to the version in MS Majlis-i Sinā 316 suggests the existence of a standard collection of Ibn Turka's correspondence that may survive in other MS copies.
8. MS Suppl. Pers. 727, Bibliothèque Nationale, Paris.¹⁵⁸ This collection is titled *Munsha'āt-i Qivām al-Dīn Muḥammad Şā'inī*, but is generally equivalent to the *Munsha'āt-i Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī* (Blochet, *Catalogue*, 3/248-49).

The *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* is a collection of letters, prefaces, postscripts, short treatises and inscriptions written largely by Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī or his brother Qivām al-Dīn (d. 830/1427); there seems to be some confusion between Sharaf al-Dīn and Qivām al-Dīn, however, as this collection is often attributed to the latter.¹⁵⁹ (Some copies are titled *Munsha'āt-i Şā'inī*, in reference to Qivām al-Dīn's *takhalluṣ*, Şā'inī; this was presumably chosen in honor of Şā'in al-

¹⁵⁷ For a list of contents see Nicholson, *Browne*, 107-9; see Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 249-57.

¹⁵⁸ See Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 15 n. 14.

¹⁵⁹ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 25-26.

Dīn.) The various pieces of correspondence from Ibrāhīm Sulṭān b. Shāhrukh preserved in this collection were written by Yazdī in his office as Ibrāhīm Sulṭān's *munshī*.¹⁶⁰ As noted above, the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* typically contains seven or eight items relating to Ṣā'in al-Dīn or the members of his immediate family. Binbaş observes: "The fact that Yazdī's letters, treatises, and prefaces are found intermingled with the *Munsha'āt-i Ṣā'in al-Dīn Turka* and the *Munsha'āt-i Qivām al-Dīn Yazdī* demonstrates their close personal and intellectual relationship."¹⁶¹ Given the author's official capacity, the *Munsha'āt-i Yazdī* exhibit a wider range of addresses than do the *Munsha'āt-i Turka*, including, for example, letters to the Mamluk sultan written for Ibrāhīm Sulṭān, to the sultan of Gulbarga for Sulṭān Sa'īd, for various amirs to Sulṭān Muḥammad b. Bāysunghur, from the latter to various amirs (e.g., Fīrūzshāh, Zayn al-'Ābidīn), and from various amirs to others.

There exists another MS in Paris (BnF 1644) copied in the early 10th/16th century that purports to contain the complete works of Qivām al-Dīn Muḥammad Ṣā'inī. A deluxe MS decorated in the Shirazi manner, it includes 1) a preface by Quṭb al-Dīn Shīrāzī (grandson of Ṣāhīr al-Dīn 'Abd al-Raḥmān Shīrāzī); 2) *qaṣīdas* in eulogy of Iskandar, Bāysunghur and Sayyid Rizā Kiyā; 3) *tarjī'-bands*; 4) *ghazals*; 5) Arabic *muqaṭṭa'āt*; 6) a five-line piece satirizing Sayyid Rizā Kiyā; 7) Persian *muqaṭṭa'āt*, including a eulogy; 8) a *masnavī*; 9) two prose pieces, one being in honor of Tāj al-Dīn 'Abd al-Raḥīm; 10) *mu'ammās*; and 11) prose letters (mistakenly titled as *masnavīs*). A note on f. 5a indicates that Qivām al-Dīn lived successively in Shirvan, Azarbayjan, Diyarbakr, Syria and Egypt, and died in 830 (1426-27).¹⁶²

References to the four MSS consulted here will be abbreviated as follows: Vahid Paşa 621 = YMN/V; Majlis-i Sinā 316 = YMN/MS; Dānishgāh 2576 = YMN/D; Cambridge H. 5 = YMN/C.

1. A request (*multamas*) from the son of Amīr Tarkhān for a collection of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's

¹⁶⁰ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 42.

¹⁶¹ "Sharaf al-Dīn," 15.

¹⁶² Blochet, *Catalogue*, 3/248-49.

works: this letter, sent by Muḥammad Šūfī b. Ghiyās al-Dīn Tarkhān¹⁶³ presumably to Sharaf al-Dīn, contains an effusive description of the virtues of Šā'in al-Dīn's works, and requests a volume of his works in Persian (*ibārāt-i ḥaqāyiq-ishārāt-i fārsī*). Significantly, here the author states that Šā'in al-Dīn's writings are directed in particular toward the *ūlū l-aydī wa-l-abṣār* (YMN/V ff. 59a-60a, YMN/MS pp. 160-61).¹⁶⁴

2. A transcription of a few admonitory lines (*fiqra-yi chand multamas-i vā'izī*) addressed by Šā'in al-Dīn to his listeners during one of his majlises (YMN/V ff. 87a-88a, YMN/MS pp. 179).¹⁶⁵
3. From Kh^wāja Jamāl al-Dīn Muḥammad Turka, son of Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's teacher Šā'in al-Dīn Turka (*makhdūmzāda-yi ḥaqīqī*),¹⁶⁶ to Amīr Muḥammad Shāh, governor (*dārūghā*) of Isfahan (before Sha'bān 867/May 1463):¹⁶⁷ this and the following letter from Jamāl al-Dīn indicate the difficulties he is encountering in attempting to complete his education. In the present letter he states that he was sent to Shiraz from Herat, perhaps in his adolescence, to pursue his education there, and expresses his fear that were he to return to Herat he would never have the opportunity to complete his studies because of his connections and duties (*'alāyiq u 'avāyiq*) in the capital¹⁶⁸ (YMN/V ff. 139a-40a, YMN/MS p. 216, YMN/D pp. 163-65, YMN/C f. 95b).
4. From Kh^wāja Jamāl al-Dīn Muḥammad Turka to the late Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad Ṭāhir (before Sha'bān 867/May 1463):¹⁶⁹ he is similarly concerned about furthering his education in this letter, here insisting that this is his best opportunity to study the religious sciences, and remarking that the original intent of his travels indicated in his original *sifārish-nāma* (letter of recommendation) was that he do so. He further requests the bureaucrat to order his connections (*'alāyiq*) not to interfere with his

¹⁶³ Here styling himself Sultān Muḥammad b. Tarkhān, Muḥammad Šūfī was *tovachi* and commander of a *tūmen* in Shāhrukh's army. He and his brothers, as sons of Temūr's follower Ghiyās al-Dīn Tarkhān (also the father of Shāhrukh's influential wife Gawharshād), were known as the Tarkhān amirs and featured prominently in Shāhrukh's army and administration during his consolidation of rule. Muḥammad Šūfī's brothers included 'Alī Tarkhān (d. 820/1417), appointed *amīr divān* by Shāhrukh; Ḥasan Šūfī Tarkhān (d. 827/1424), who assumed the office of *amīr divān* after his brother's death; Ḥamza Tarkhān (d. 819/1416); Ḥusayn Šūfī Tarkhān (d. ca. 819/1416?); and Sayyid Aḥmad Tarkhān (Manz, *Power*, 38-39).

¹⁶⁴ On the significance of this phrase in Šā'in al-Dīn's thought see §6.2 below.

¹⁶⁵ The short section that follows (YMN/V ff. 88a-88b, YMN/MS pp. 179-80), containing four statements and in YMN/V titled *fiqarāt-i mufarraḡ*, may or may not represent further lines by Šā'in al-Dīn.

¹⁶⁶ Jamāl al-Dīn may have instead been Afzal al-Dīn Turka's son, though the epithet here would seem to disallow this (see Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 169).

¹⁶⁷ Amīr Muḥammad Shāh was the brother of Amir Fīrūzshāh; his other brothers Amīr Kh^wānd Shāh (d. 838/1435) and Amīr Maḥmūd Shāh were also governors of Isfahan (Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 170, 171 n. 275).

¹⁶⁸ These two letters are discussed in Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 170-71.

¹⁶⁹ Kh^wāja Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad Ṭāhir is probably to be identified with the bureaucrat also known as Kh^wāja Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad Simnānī, appointed to the *divān* in Herat in 811/1408 with Temūr's agent Sayyid Fakhr al-Dīn Aḥmad and again, very briefly, in 821/1418; after he was dismissed the same year, he moved to Yazd in 828/1425 to work in the *divān* there. YMN/C refers to him as the *vazīr-i Isfahān*, while the Berlin MS designates him *mīr-i tūmān-i Isfahān* (Manz, *Power*, 85 n. 27, 148; Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 170, 171 n. 276).

- studies¹⁷⁰ (YMN/V ff. 140a-40b, YMN/MS pp. 216-17, YMN/D pp. 165-66, YMN/C f. 96a).
5. From Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī (?) to Šā'in al-Dīn Turka: a petition to the author's teacher, with reference to one of his sons (*makhdūm-zāda*) (YMN/V ff. 165b-66b, YMN/MS p. 235, YMN/C ff. 121b-26a).
 6. A letter of condolence (*ta'ziyat-nāma*) sent to Šā'in al-Dīn's children (*makhdūm-zādagān-i ḥaqīqī*) upon their father's death (YMN/V ff. 166b-67b, YMN/MS pp. 235-36, YMN/C ff. 126b-27a).
 7. To Kh^wāja Afzal al-Dīn Muḥammad Turka, Šā'in al-Dīn's nephew or cousin¹⁷¹ (ca. 835/1432?): a business letter on the collection of taxes, probably written soon after Šā'in al-Dīn's death. Sharaf al-Dīn states that Šā'in al-Dīn's son (*makhdūm-zāda-yi arjumand*) Kh^wāja Najīb al-Dīn Ḥabīb Allāh Turka departed for Herat after a dispute with his brothers over money matters; Sharaf al-Dīn intervened and resolved this unacceptable situation, lodging Ḥabīb Allāh at his own house and reallocating the money in question. It appears on the basis of this letter that Šā'in al-Dīn had three sons and seven daughters¹⁷² (YMN/V ff. 167b-68b, YMN/MS pp. 236-37, YMN/C f. 127b).
 8. In reply to Šā'in al-Dīn (ca. 817/1415, Shiraz or Yazd?): the author congratulates Šā'in al-Dīn (described here as *valāyat-panāh-i karāmat-shi'ār-i irshād-ma'āb-i takmīl-qibāb*, thus emphasizing his role as teacher) on completing his commentary on the *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*,¹⁷³ and states that he will accompany him on a trip to Khurasan, which will include a pilgrimage to the shrine of Imam 'Alī al-Riḍā (i.e., Mashhad) (YMN/MS pp. 257-58).¹⁷⁴

Published: Yazdī's correspondence and poetry have been edited and published separately:

Manẓūmāt, ed. Īraj Afshār, Tehran, 1386 Sh./2007; and *Munsha'āt*, ed. Īraj Afshār and Muḥammad

Riżā Abū'ī Mahrīzī, Tehran, 1388 Sh./2009.

¹⁷⁰ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 171.

¹⁷¹ Afzal al-Dīn Ṣadr or Afzal al-Dīn b. Ṣadr (d. 850/1446) is primarily known for his translation of Shahrastānī's *al-Milal wa-l-Niḥal*, dedicated to Shāhrukh (Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 168-69).

¹⁷² This letter is briefly discussed in Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 172. Cf. "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 206, where Šā'in al-Dīn states that he has 10 children and a few wives (*dah tiḡl u 'awratī chand*).

¹⁷³ Šā'in al-Dīn completed his *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam* in 814/1411, producing a corrected version in 817/1415 in Fars (presumably Shiraz).

¹⁷⁴ In YMN/MS, the only source where it appears, this letter is followed by a postscript or colophon, possibly to the entire collection, attributing it to Qivām al-Dīn Yazdī as author and compiler, and giving a date of completion of 5 Rabī' I 849/11 June 1445 (i.e., well beyond Qivām al-Dīn's death); this copy was made on 7 Sha'bān 878/28 December 1473.

2.1.4: *Ijāzas*

1. *K. al-Maṣābīḥ*

1. MS 10196, f. 126a, Majlis Library, Tehran.

A certificate for the *K. al-Maṣābīḥ* (Arabic), given by Ibn Turka to one of his prominent contemporaries.

2.1.5: Untitled works

1. *Kitāb Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī Turka*

1. MS Add. 7611, ff. 85b-123b, British Library, London, copied in 1137/1725. Part of a collection of Sufi extracts compiled by one Sulaymān (ca. 10th/16th c.), entitled *Maqālāt al-ʿĀrifīn wa-Mirʿāt al-Sālikīn*, including sections from the *Lubb al-Muḥaqqiqīn* of Allāhbakhsh b. Sayyid Ṣadr al-Dīn Bhakarī (?), *Miṣbāḥ al-Arwāḥ* of Shaykh ʿAlī Tūnī (contemporary of Bāyazīd Bisṭāmī), *Sharḥ-i Lamaʿāt* of Niʿmat Allāh Valī, *Tazkirat al-Awliyāʾ* of ʿAṭṭār, *K. Asrār* of ʿAbd Allāh Anṣārī, together with poetical extracts from ʿAṭṭār, Niʿmat Allāh Valī, Maghribī, Qāsim-i Anvār, Amīr Ḥusaynī, ʿIrāqī, Shabistarī, and Jāmī (Rieu, *Supplement*, 774b).

Given the theme of the compilation in which it occurs, examination of this work may reveal it to be either Ibn Turka's *R. Aṭvār-i Salāsa* or his *Żaw' al-Lamaʿāt*, two treatises popular among Sufi audiences.

2.1.6: (Mis)attributed or mistitled works

1. *Jafr* (Persian)

1. MS 2950/5, p. 30, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied in the 11th/17th or 12th/18th century (Dānishpazhūh, 10/1833).

A brief treatise on *jafr* attributed to Ibn Turka; it may be supposed to have been written well

after his death, as the above MS mentions the year 909/1504.

Unpublished.

2. *Makhzan al-Gharā'ib* (Arabic)

Āqā Buzurg (*al-Dharī'a*, 20/227, no. 2699) states that he has often seen a treatise by this name figure in collections of Ibn Turka's works, which strongly suggests him as author. On the strength of Āqā Buzurg's report a work with this title is attributed to Ṣā'in al-Dīn in the Bodleian MS catalog (Sachau and Ethé, *Catalogue*, 1/col. 804).

Unpublished.

3. *Sharḥ al-Hidāya*

Āqā Buzurg (*al-Dharī'a*, 14/174-75, no. 2054; cf. Ḥājjī Khalīfa, *Kashf al-Zunūn*, 2/646) notes that the attribution of this treatise to one Kh^wāja Ṣā'in al-Dīn suggests Ibn Turka as a possible candidate.

Unpublished.

4. *Taqrīr Mas'alat al-Tawḥīd* (Persian)

1. MS 6275/15, ff. 294-314, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), copied by Muḥammad Durr Jizīnī in 1309/1892 (Dānishpazhūh, 16/232).

Unpublished.

5. *al-Tawrāt* (Arabic)

1. MS 3514/2, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh), undated (Dānishpazhūh, *Dānishgāh*, 12/2523).

An Arabic translation of 21 chapters from the Torah. Immediately preceding it in the collection is Ibn Turka's *Munāẓarāt-i Khams*, so its attribution to Ibn Turka is probably a mistaken association on the part of the cataloger.

Unpublished.

6. *R. [fī] l-Wujūd* (Arabic)

1. MS 4196/22 (?), Malik Library, Tehran, copied in 1017/1608 (Afshār, *Malik*, 7/262).

A work with this title is attributed to Ibn Turka in MS Malik 4196, immediately following his *R. Nuqṭa*; as I do not currently have access to this MS, I can only conjecture that it represents a copy of either the *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id* or *R. fī Sharḥ Ḥaqīqat al-Wahda al-Muṭlaqa al-Dhātiyya*.

7. *Muhayyij al-Ashwāq*

An otherwise unknown work attributed to Ibn Turka by Aḥmad Munzavī (*Fihrist*, 2/1027).

8. *Ma'jūn-i Ilāhī*

An otherwise unknown work attributed to Ibn Turka by Aḥmad Munzavī (*Fihrist*, 2/1027).

2.2: Works grouped by theme

In what follows Ibn Turka's works are listed in order of length or importance, with date of composition if known. Note that titles are duplicated if they fall into more than one category. I give precedence to lettrist works, followed by works on mystical theory, philosophy and so on, in accordance with the author's epistemological hierarchy as laid out most clearly in his *R. Shaqq-i Qamar*;¹⁷⁵ Ibn Turka's intellectual concerns may likewise be seen in the disproportionate attention he gives to lettrist matters in the first place and mystical-philosophical matters in the second.

1. Lettrist works or works with lettrist content

al-Mafāḥiṣ (823/1420)
Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam (814/1411)
Ḥurūf (Shiraz, 817/1414)
Anjām (828/1425)
Su'l al-Mulūk (before 829/1426)
Shaqq-i Qamar va Bayān-i Sā'at (before 829/1426)
Sharḥ al-Basmala (before 829/1426)
R. al-Inzāliyya (before 828/1425)
R. al-Bā'iyya (before 828/1425)
R. al-Muḥammadiyya (before 828/1425)
Nuqṭa (before 828/1425)
R. dar Ma'nā-yi Khavāṣṣ-i 'Ilm-i Ṣarf
Taqdīm al-'Aql 'alā l-Nafs
Asrār al-Ṣalāt (Herat, 825/1422)
Sharḥ-i Ḥadīs-i 'Amā' (before 827/1424)
Sharḥ Ḥadīth al-Īmān

2. Works organized according to an epistemological hierarchy¹⁷⁶

Shaqq-i Qamar u Bayān-i Sā'at (before 829/1426)
Madārij Afhām al-Afwāj fī Tafsīr Āyat Thamāniyat Azwāj (Mazandaran, 831/1428)

¹⁷⁵ See §6.1 below.

¹⁷⁶ I.e., works which examine a topic from multiple epistemological standpoints associated with specific groups, such as traditionists, philosophers, Sufis and lettrists, in ascending order.

R. al-Inzāliyya (before 828/1425)
Aṭvār-i Salāsa (before 828/1425)
Mabda' u Ma'ād (832/1428)
Taqdīm al-'Aql 'alā l-Nafs

3. Works on Sufism or mystical theory

Aṭvār-i Salāsa (before 828/1425)
Iṣṭilāḥāt Ṣūfiyya (before 829/1426)
Mabda' u Ma'ād (Mazandaran, 832/1428)
Sullam Dār al-Salām fī Bayān Ḥikam Aḥkām Arkān al-Islām (Abarquh, 832/1429)
R. fī Sharḥ Ḥaqīqat al-Waḥda al-Muṭlaqa al-Dhātiyya (before 827/1424)

4. Commentaries on Sufi texts

Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr (Cairo?, 806/1404)
Zaw' al-Lama'āt (Isfahan?, 815/1412)
Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam (814/1411)
Sharḥ-i Dah Bayt-i Muḥyī l-Dīn Ibn-i 'Arabī
Sharḥ al-Tajallī al-Dhātī
*Sharḥ-i Gulshan-i Rāz**

5. Mystico-philosophical syntheses

Tamhīd al-Qawā'id (Shiraz, 830/1427?)
Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam (814/1411)
Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr (Cairo?, 806/1404)
Munāẓarāt-i Khams (808/1405)
Munāẓara-yi Bazm u Razm (before 829/1426)
Qābiliyyat
Sharḥ al-Tajallī al-Dhātī

6. Philosophical romances

Munāẓarāt-i Khams (808/1405)
Munāẓara-yi Bazm u Razm (before 829/1426)

7. Logic

al-Manāḥij (Natanz, 833/1430)

8. Quran commentaries

Shaqḡ-i Qamar va Bayān-i Sāʿat (before 829/1426)

Madārij Afhām al-Afwāj fī Tafsīr Āyat Thamāniyat Azwāj (Mazandaran, 831/1428)

Sharḥ al-Basmala (before 829/1426)

Sharḥ Khuṭbat al-Kashshāf

9. Hadith commentaries

R. al-Arbaʿīniyya (before 828/1425)

Tarjuma-yi Aḥādīs az Amīr al-Muʾminīn

Tuḥfa-yi ʿAlāʾī (831/1428)

Sharḥ-i Ḥadīs-i ʿAmāʾ (before 827/1424)

Sharḥ Ḥadīth al-Īmān

Sharḥ Ḥadīth ʿUlwī (?)

Sharḥ Ḥadīth Nabawī

10. Jurisprudence

Asrār al-Ṣalāt (Herat, 825/1422)

Iṣbāḥ al-Anwār (incomplete in 831/1428)

Tuḥfa-yi ʿAlāʾī (831/1428)

11. Apologies, creedal works

Nafsat al-Maṣdūr I (Herat, 829/1426)

Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II (ca. 832-35/1429-32)

Iʿtiqādāt (before 829/1426)

R. Iʿtiqādiyya (ca. 832-35/1429-32)

Muhr al-Nubuwwa (before 831/1428)

Mabdaʾ u Maʿād (832/1428)

Sullam Dār al-Salām fī Bayān Ḥikām Aḥkām Arkān al-Islām (Abarquh, 832/1429)

CHAPTER 3

Ibn Turka's universalist lettrist project

3.1: Ibn Turka's popularization of lettrism as universal science

Subsequent events notwithstanding, it appears that upon his return to Iran from Cairo in *ca.* 810/1408 Ṣā'in al-Dīn found a receptive audience for his occult philosophy at the courts of the Timurid princes of western Iran. He first joined the court of Pīr-Muḥammad b. 'Umar Shaykh in Shiraz; when Pīr-Muḥammad was murdered in 812/1409, his brother Mīrzā Iskandar (d. 818/1415) rose to power in Fars and established what was by every measure a brilliant though short-lived court in Isfahan.¹ Iskandar himself was known for his imamophilism and esotericist bent,² and may be imagined as taking warmly to Ṣā'in al-Dīn; significantly, it is possible that he personally commissioned the latter to write his first treatise on lettrism, the *R. Ḥurūf*. Iskandar was presumably also responsible for installing Ṣā'in al-Dīn in his hereditary office as qadi of Isfahan, established to the Turka family by Temūr himself upon his appointment of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's elder brother and teacher Ṣadr al-Dīn as qadi in Samarkand.³

¹ Iskandar is accounted the leading Timurid patron of culture in the early Shahrukhid period, showing a particular interest in alchemy and astrological and astronomical illustrated works; the efflorescence of Iskandar's court was especially represented in book painting (Richard, "Un témoignage inexploité," 60-65; Aubin, "Le mécénat timouride à Chiraz"; Gray, "The School of Shiraz"; Manz, *Power, Politics and Religion*, 30-1). See Evrim Binbaş's essay in the forthcoming volume "*Norm, Transgression and Identity in Islam: Diversity of Approaches and Interpretations*" (ed. Orkhan Mir-Kasimov) for a discussion of Iskandar's messianic self-understanding and attempt to synthesize mysticism and theology.

² Ando, "The Timurid Historiography," 13; Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 216 n. 112.

³ "Nafṣat al-Maṣdūr II," 203.

Meanwhile, Shāhrukh was consolidating his power in eastern Iran from his capital in Herat, styling himself *khalīfa* and adopting an aggressive Sunnizing policy in a bid to unify eastern and western Iran under his rule. By 815/1412 he had established his control over Khurasan, Transoxania and Khwarazm, whereupon he turned his sights westward. He marched against the rebellious Iskandar in 817/1414 and removed him from power, replacing him with his own son Ibrāhīm Sulṭān. In the face of these and other disturbances Ṣāʿin al-Dīn attempted to retire from public life and sought refuge in Shiraz and Yazd, where between 817-25/1414-22 he produced his lettrist *summa*, the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, as well as his lettrist commentary on the *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*. This period of contemplation and productivity came to an end with Ṣāʿin al-Dīn's first trial in Herat in 825/1422; he was able to gain Shāhrukh's favor, however, and was given a judgeship in Yazd at his own request. Most of his minor lettrist treatises appear to have been written between 828/1425 and 831/1428, a period in which he twice stood trial and was exiled, for despite royal antipathy toward hurufism it appears that there continued to be an interest in his brand of lettrism among certain members of the Timurid elite, in particular Shāhrukh's son Bāysunghur (d. 837/1433), famed for his skill in calligraphy and artistic patronage. Ṣāʿin al-Dīn was more than happy to reciprocate. At the end of his *R. Suʿl al-Mulūk*, for example, written in 829/1426 for Bāysunghur, the author offers a lettrist prognostication of the duration of the Timurid state; he calculates on the basis of Shāhrukh's name that its glory will persist for one century, i.e., the whole of the 9th Islamic century⁴—a fairly accurate prediction, as it happened.

For the purposes of the present chapter, I have selected the three minor lettrist treatises, all in Persian, that are explicitly focused on establishing the nature, scope and objectives of lettrism as such, thus excluding those of his lettrist works that are more theme-driven.⁵

⁴ *R. Suʿl al-Mulūk*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 178b; see §5.4 below.

⁵ Thematic lettrist treatises that are beyond the scope of the present discussion include *R. al-Inzālīyya*, on the revelation of the heavenly Books as treated successively from exoteric, mystical, and finally lettrist perspectives; *R. al-Bāʿīyya*, a short treatise in the lettrist manner in answer to a postulant's question as to why the *bāʿ* is foremost among the letters in terms of its invariably sura-initial occurrence in the Quran;

(Preliminary editions of all three and translations of two are included in Part 2 of this study.) I will first reiterate a summary of each as a basis for further discussion below:

1. **R. *Ḥurūf***, possibly commissioned by Iskandar and completed in 817/1414 in Shiraz,⁶ an introductory treatment of the premises and principles of lettrism. The introduction touches on the meaning of the letter as such, followed by three sections devoted to each of the three aspects of the letter respectively: written-textual (*raqamī kitābī*), associated with sight; spoken-oral (*lafẓī kalāmī*), associated with hearing; and spiritual-mental (*ma'navī lubābī*), i.e., numerical, associated with the heart. The treatise closes with an examination of the Doubled Seven (*sab' al-mathānī*) as a test case.⁷

2. **R. *Anjām***, aka *R. dar Tamyīz-i 'Ilm-i Ḥurūf az Taṣavvuf* or *Taṣavvuf va Ḥurūf*, written in or before 828/1425, a comparison of Sufism and lettrism. Sufism is first juxtaposed with philosophy, both involving the quest for wisdom (*ḥikmat*) and as such constituting noble sciences within their own ambit; but neither can compete with lettrism, which is presented as the supreme science of the age. The treatise is stated to be written in the most accessible manner possible in the interest of promoting the science more widely.⁸

3. **R. *Su'l al-Mulūk***, written in or before 829/1426 at the request of Bāysunghur b. Shāhrukh, an introductory work treating of both the practical (i.e., alchemical and talismanic) and the

R. al-Muḥammadiyya, on the properties of the name Muḥammad; *R. Asrār al-Ṣalāt*, on the symbolism and esoteric meaning of the prayer act; *R. Nuqṭa*, a commentary on 'Alī's statement, *Anā l-nuqṭa allatī taḥta l-bā*; *R. dar Ma'nā-yi Khawāṣṣ-i 'Ilm-i Ṣarf*, on various aspects of morphology dealt with in a lettrist manner; *Sharḥ al-Basmala*, a commentary on the *basmala* in a lettrist manner; and a number of other treatises featuring specifically lettrist components. Mention should also be made of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's magisterial commentary on the *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam* of Ibn 'Arabī, which, distinctively among the host of commentaries on this text, is thickly veined with lettrist excursions.

⁶ A copy appears to have been sent to one Sayyid Niẓām al-Dīn Aḥmad in the same year with accompanying letter (see §2.1.2, no. 7; and §2.1.3.1, letter 15).

⁷ See Part 2, §T.2 for an edition and translation of this treatise.

⁸ See Part 2, §T.3 for an edition and translation of this treatise.

theoretical aspects of lettrism. It is likewise written in a highly accessible manner, and offers a broader overview of the science than is given in the two preceding treatises, neither of which are concerned with practical-magical applications.⁹

Ṣā'in al-Dīn's most succinct statement as to the objective of lettrism occurs in the *R. Anjām*, where he presents the science as the key to the unification of all human knowledge of the cosmos. Where philosophy deals only with universals and the more concrete disciplines such as historiography, astronomy or alchemy are enmeshed in particulars, the objective of lettrism is “investigation into everything in the cosmos, both universals and particulars, and their categorization (*tarattub*) by means of this science.”¹⁰ Here, of course, Ṣā'in al-Dīn is most notably taking issue with the Avicennan concept of metaphysics as the ‘universal science’ (*al-ilm al-kullī*) dealing with all existents.¹¹ Based on inductive reasoning (*adilla-yi naẓarī*) alone, metaphysics is confined to the abstract and therefore cannot truly claim to be universal. As he states more fully in the same treatise:

It is clear to the inhabitants of the alley of attentiveness and perspicacity that any science which can clearly formulate knowledge of all things, both universals and particulars, and whose principles and questions clarify the nature of every level of divine and engendered existence, from that of engendered beings (*akvān*) up to that of the [fixed] entities (*a'yān*), such that the ornament of proof (*burhān*) shines forth brilliantly from the folds of its expositions (as may be demonstrated to those seekers (*ṭālibān*) whose degree of perception and purpose is but slightly less than that of the Heirs of the Prophetic legacy (*vārisān-i khatmī*) and who are acquainted with his devoted servants (*khāksārān-i kūy-i khidmat-ash*))—such a science surpasses all others in value.

⁹ See Part 2, §T.4 for an edition of this treatise. The *Munsha'āt-i Turka* preserves a letter the author wrote to Shāhrukh to accompany a treatise treating of ‘several topics relating to the occult properties of things and various occult sciences’ (*dar bāb-i khavāṣṣ-i ashyā u 'ulūm ast gharīb chīzī chand*), most probably the *R. Su'l al-Mulūk* (TMN/MS p. 17, TMN/D pp. 182–83; see §2.1.3.1, no. 20 above; the letter is transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.1 below).

¹⁰ MS Majlis 10196 f. 159a.

¹¹ The term *al-ilm al-kullī* properly refers to ontology in both Peripatetic and Illuminationist philosophy, which, together with *al-ilm al-rubūbī* or *al-ilm al-ilāhī*, i.e. theology, constitutes metaphysics. Heidrun Eichner discusses the various later philosophical uses of the term (“The Post-Avicennian Philosophical Tradition”; see e.g. the chart on p. 87).

My heart said, I long for mystical knowledge!
Teach me if you're able.
I replied, A. It said, Yes, and? I said, That's it:
if anyone's home a single letter will suffice.¹²

Ṣā'in al-Dīn thus counterpoints lettrism in its true universality with philosophy and Sufism.

While both must be considered inferior to lettrism, however, they are necessary and noble disciplines in their own right:

The science of Sufism may thus be seen as constituting a mode of wisdom that is formulated in terms of Muḥammad's Sunna and the prescriptions (*sharāyī*) of his revelation, and has its place among the permitted sciences and required practices. Mainstream philosophy constitutes a [complementary] science that is formulated in terms of inductive proofs and rational demonstrations (*adilla-yi naẓarī u barāhīn-i 'aqlī*), and likewise has its place among the permitted sciences and required practices. Consider the difference in their methods and compare the point of departure and end result of each.

The Chosen One is in this cosmos where one imagines Intellect to be,
a sun in that sphere where one strains to see Suhā.¹³

The objective of the science of Sufism is likewise clear to the perspicacious: its program of education and training aims to elevate a person beyond the level of mere animal physicality (*ḥayavāniyyat*) and accidental being (*ḥayāt-i 'ārizī*) by means of the proven methods and practices contained in the prophetic teachings so as to attain to the level of human perfection and eternal life, thereby escaping entrapment in the darkness of the flesh where one is cut off from the fount of the water of life.

That spring from which Khizr drank the water of life
is in your own home, but you've blocked it off!¹⁴

In his *R. Ḥurūf* Ṣā'in al-Dīn is concerned to further situate his brand of lettrism among the sciences by contrasting it with the far more common practical-magical approach exemplified

¹² *R. Anjām*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 158b. Cf. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's explanation in the introduction to his *Mafāḥiṣ* that whereas the concept of absolute being (*al-wujūd al-muṭlaq*), limited as it is to existent objects, is an insufficiently universal object of study, the letter encompasses all that is and is not, all that could be or cannot be, and is hence the proper object of a universal science (see e.g. MS Majlis 10196 f. 55a, MS Esad Efendi 1731 ff. 8b-9a; see also §7.3.1 below for a translation of this introduction).

¹³ I.e., the faint star Alcor in Ursa Major; finding it in the night sky was regarded by the Arabs as a test of sight. The verse is by Sanā'ī.

¹⁴ *R. Anjām*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 158a.

by Būnī. While he fully accepts the validity of lettrism as an occult praxis (his master, Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī, was renowned as a *magus*), Šā'in al-Dīn prefers to emphasize the neglected yet more important function of lettrism as the basis for a broader occult philosophy.¹⁵

Given that the science of letters is a universal science (*az 'ulūm-i kullīyya*) comprising numerous other sciences under its aegis, each of them important and worthy of purpose in its own right, the practitioners of this science naturally fall into various camps. Generally speaking, however, they may be divided into two overarching groups.

The first and best-known group consists of those who are concerned with the occult properties of the letters (*ahl-i khavāṣṣ*). These investigate into the occult properties of each letter according to each of its three forms, and hold that the utterance or contemplation of a letter in accordance with a specific description (*vaṣfī mu'ayyan*) and its associated conditions activates its particular property either with respect to the levels of the physical world (*marātib-i dunyavī*) or to spiritual interactions at various levels (*mu'āmalāt-i ukhravī va madārij-i ān*). The exponents of this first approach, including most prominently Abū l-'Abbās al-Būnī, have composed innumerable books and treatises on the subject, and make up the majority of those concerned with the science of letters.

The second group consists of those who are concerned with the letters' underlying realities (*ahl-i ḥaqāyiq*). These investigate into the meanings (*ma'ānī*) behind the letters and the universal sciences (*'ulūm-i kullī*) they contain, and understand all types of knowledge and modes of knowing, whether with respect to the divine presences (*ḥazarāt-i ilāhiyya*) or the contingent realms (*'avālim-i imkāniyya*) and all that comes to be in them, in terms of the heavenly Book (*kitāb-i āsmānī*) and the isolated quranic letters (*ḥurūf-i muqaṭṭa'a-yi qur'ānī*). They likewise apprehend the occult properties of everything that has ever manifested or will ever manifest in the universe, each communicating this according to the vigor and capacity of his understanding. My purpose in this treatise is to present a few of the guiding principles (*uṣūl*) of this latter group, this in order to familiarize seekers with this science and equip them to pursue it to perfection—God grant us all success to this end.¹⁶

Finally, in the *R. Su'l al-Mulūk* Šā'in al-Dīn capitalizes on the contemporary popularity of applied lettrism to draw attention to its theoretical component. He demonstrates, by way of

¹⁵ Cf. Hanegraaff's discussion of Agrippa's innovative interpretation of the nonmagical *Corpus Hermeticum*, which resulted "in a new perspective on how the attainment of a superior gnosis implies the acquisition of suprahuman powers. Moreover, the new perspective was not seen as magical either, but as something much 'better than magic'" ("Better than Magic: Cornelius Agrippa and Lazzarellian Hermeticism," 2-3).

¹⁶ *R. Hurūf*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 154b. Cf. 'Alī Šafī b. Ḥusayn Kāshifī's treatment in his *Ḥirz al-Amān min Fitān al-Zamān*, which reproduces this division precisely: *ahl-i ḥaqīqat* vs. *ahl-i khāṣṣiyyat*, the latter being far more numerous than the former; unlike Šā'in al-Dīn, however, he chooses to concentrate on the practical approach of the *ahl-i khāṣṣiyyat*, extensively quoting earlier writers to this end. For more on this work see §4.4.4 below.

example, the interdependency of both modes in medical terms:¹⁷

Now among the quranic prooftexts for this function of the letters according to both of the above divisions [i.e., the practical and the theoretical] is the following: *And We send down of the Quran that which is a healing and a mercy to the believers* (Q 17:82). According to the plain meaning of this verse, it is abundantly clear that what is revealed in the Quran contains within it two great benefits, both of which constitute props to the foundation of human perfection and without whose preparatory assistance (*tamhīd*) the meaning of perfection can never be realized.

The first of these two benefits is bodily healing (*shifā-yi badan*); that is to say, these quranic letters, issuing as they do from the pharmacy (*sharbatkhāna*) of divine subtleties, serve to restore the body's native power and natural balance in the event its constitution (*mizāj*)—which in its mature and healthy state figures as one's vehicle on this path—loses that balance, and its bodily or spiritual form ceases to function properly, becoming incapable of bearing any burdens or traveling the path.

My beloved is Jesus-breathed—kill me in her presence
and then behold what her breath does.¹⁸

Thus the special properties contained in every potion, medicine and electuary are in fact contained to a greater degree within these quranic letters, these uncreated heavenly substances. If anyone harbors a reservation on this point, he should know that it is on account of a deficiency in his belief in the Quran and failure to ascend the rungs of faith ...

The second of these two props of perfection as revealed through the quranic letters applies when the body requires no medical treatment, being in full possession of its natural balance and its external and internal faculties; at this point the effusion of divine mercy (*rahmat-i rahmānī*) fills the cups of one's bodily instruments (*asbāb u ālāt-i jismānī*) to the brim with its flow of virtues (*afzāl*), such that one is enabled to climb out of the chasms of satanically-inspired incapacity and failure on the ascending rungs of existence and thereby arrive at human perfection. This activates one's preparedness (*isti'dād*) to receive from the hand of the cupbearer of divine mercy the choicest wine of theoretical inquiry and divine knowledge in the receptacles of the eternal letters and the pots of the primordial molds (*awzā'*) and quaff therefrom. Through persistence in drinking from these cups one may arrest one's descent into alienation (*bu'd*) and the deserts of estrangement and ascend to nearness [with God] (*qurb*) and the sanctuary of union (*jam'iyyat*).¹⁹

¹⁷ Cf. Rashīd al-Dīn Ṭabīb's (d. 718/1318) *R. Ḥurūf*, which compares the letters to individual medicinal substances; in isolation each has a property (*ḥukm*) and particularity (*khāṣṣiyyat*) peculiar to it alone, but when combined with other medicinal substances it acquires new medical properties—so too with the quranic letters (*Bayān al-Ḥaqāyiq* 278; see §4.3.1 for more on this treatise).

¹⁸ Awḥadī, *ghazal*: *ṣabrī kunīm tā sitam-i ū chi mī-kunad*.

¹⁹ *R. Su'l al-Mulūk*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 172b.

As we have seen, then, Šā'in al-Dīn considers his lettrism, supreme among the universal sciences, to be superior to both philosophy and Sufism, and presents it as constituting simultaneously an occult praxis and an occult philosophy, placing emphasis on the latter aspect as corrective. While he does not consider himself the first to have arrived at such an understanding—he consistently defers to his teacher Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī and acknowledges Ibn 'Arabī and Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī as two of his main textual sources²⁰—, he is explicit that the approach to lettrism that he is promoting is unique to his generation and exemplifies the upward evolution of human knowledge.

But how would his contemporaries have received this classification? His assertions aside, how unique was Šā'in al-Dīn's approach to lettrism? To answer this question we must trace the emergence and development of Islamic lettrism from the 2th/8th century to Šā'in al-Dīn's day, with particular attention to the definitions of the science given in earlier and contemporary classifications of knowledge of the *taṣnīf al-ʿulūm* genre. Attention must also be given to how his project was received in Iran during the century after his death as a measure of the extent to which he succeeded or failed, or was perceived as having so done, in his promotion of lettrism as universal science.

²⁰ See e.g. *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, MS Majlis f. 53a.

CHAPTER 4

Ibn Turka and the Islamicate science of letters

Divinity, adieu!
These metaphysics of magicians,
And necromantic books are heavenly;
Lines, circles, scenes, letters, and characters;
Ay, these are those that Faustus most desires.
O, what a world of profit and delight,
Of power, of honour, of omnipotence,
Is promis'd to the studious artizan!¹

—Christopher Marlowe

The cords of all link back ... That is why mystic
monks. Will you be as gods? Gaze in your omphalos.
Hello ... Put me on to Edenville. Aleph, alpha:
nought, nought, one.²

—James Joyce

The present chapter, comprising five sections, surveys the broad contours of and diverse currents within the Islamic science of letters as the context in which the importance and originality of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's contribution must be evaluated. For reasons of space and theme, I here focus rather artificially on the history of the science of letters (*ʿilm al-ḥurūf*, *ʿilm al-jafr*) as a distinct discipline, conceived of as a continuum running from rarefied lettrist theory to popular forms of letter magic, and including all types of numerological speculation.³ It should, however, be borne in mind that this science was always closely associated with other such

¹ *The Tragical History of Doctor Faustus*, ed. I. Gollancz, London, 1905, 4.

² *Ulysses*, New York, 1961, 38.

³ The guiding principle here, as Ṣā'in al-Dīn and others frequently state, is that number is to letter as spirit is to body; i.e., numbers are simply letters at a higher register of being.

theoretical, divinatory and practical-magical disciplines as *‘ilm al-khawāṣṣ* (dealing with the properties of divine names, quranic words, alchemical substances, etc.), *‘ilm al-asmā’* (dealing with the divine names), *‘ilm aḥkām al-nujūm* or *al-tanjīm* (judicial astrology), *‘ilm al-kīmiyā* (alchemy), *‘ilm al-awfāq* (magic squares), *‘ilm al-ruqā* (quranic spell magic), *‘ilm al-ṭalāsīm* (talismans) and *‘ilm al-ta’āwīdh* or *al-tamā’im* (amulets), *‘ilm al-fa’l* (omen interpretation, bibliomancy), and *‘ilm al-ta’bīr* (dream interpretation and incubation), among others.⁴

In section one, I begin with Islamic lettrism’s murky inception in gnostic-extremist Shi’i circles of the 2nd/8th century and briefly trace the process of its progressive ‘philosophization’ within a neoplatonic-neopythagorean framework, particularly on display in the *Rasā’il* of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’. I then shift focus to the simultaneous ‘Suficization’ of lettrism, a process that begins in the late 3rd/9th century and comes to full flower in the work of three Sufi thinkers in particular: Abū l-‘Abbās al-Būnī, Ibn ‘Arabī, and Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī. Significantly, the maturation of Sufi lettrism involved its own progressive ‘neoplatonization’ and ‘neopythagoreanization,’ thereby following the trajectory of gnostic Shi’i lettrism;⁵ Ibn ‘Arabī, for instance, draws in his encompassing lettrist thought on Sufi authorities, such as Tustarī and Ḥallāj, and more broadly intellectual authorities, such as Ibn Masarra, Jābir b. Ḥayyān and the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’, in equal measure. I conclude this section with a brief look at the semi-independent strain of lettrist thought represented by Ibn Sīnā’s *R. al-Nayrūziyya*; neither Sufi

⁴ See e.g. Ullman, *Die Natur- und Geheimwissenschaften im Islam*; Fahd, *La divination arabe*; O’Connor, “Popular and Talismanic Uses of the Qur’ān,” *EQ*.

⁵ Thus lettrist thought may be considered one of the telltale signs of Sufism’s successorship to messianic-gnostic Shi’ism in general religious terms. Marshall Hodgson remarked on this successorship as follows: “So far as the *Ghulāt* raised problems of a more general nature regarding the spirituality of the soul and the possibility of its communion with God, they no doubt contributed to the emotional tone of later Twelver and Ismā’īlī Shī’ism. However, in this respect their evident successors were the Sufis. Though Sufism was no doubt not immediately connected with the *Ghuluww*, the mystical states of the soul, as well as the relative ranks of various mystics, have been endlessly discussed in Sufism ever since the closing of the classical period of the early *Ghulāt*; and it is among them that has been kept alive that oddly significant, so-called Christian idea, that what survives at death is the pure soul” (“How Did the Early Shī’a Become Sectarian?” 8, quoted in Tucker, *Mahdis*, 110-11).

nor gnostic, semi-philosophical and semi-hermetic, this approach may be loosely styled intellectual lettrism—a term of convenience that is applicable to Ṣāʿin al-Dīn’s project as well.

In section two, I chart the development of lettrism from the 4th/10th to the 9th/15th century as reflected in works of the *taṣnīf al-ʿulūm* (classification of the sciences) genre. In successive classification schemes the science of letters, or rather the complex of various occult sciences involving the manipulation of letters, becomes increasingly naturalized within the Islamicate context, to the point that by the 8th/14th century it is partially merged with Sufism, which had itself been increasingly recognized from the 6th/12th century as a distinct Islamic science on a par with hadith studies or theology. Ṣāʿin al-Dīn is shown to be responding to and contesting such classifications in his reconceptualization of lettrism as a universal science distinct from and superior to both Sufism and philosophy, and serving to weld the patrimonies of antiquity and the Islamic dispensation into a single, perennial, prophetic tradition.

Section three examines the three dominant strains of lettrist thought current in Iran in Ṣāʿin al-Dīn’s day by way of three case studies: 1) Rashīd al-Dīn Ṭabīb, representing intellectual lettrism; 2) Niʿmat Allāh Valī, representing Sufi lettrism; and 3) Faḏl Allāh Astarābādī, representing gnostic-messianic lettrism.⁶ These categories are of course artificial, yet approximate, it is argued, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn’s own understanding of the science; indeed, he consciously takes the first two strains as his point of departure while violently disapproving of the Hurufis. I close this section with a look at ʿAbd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī’s lettrist pedigrees, indicating as they do the teachers and texts that were advancing lettrism in Egypt and Syria in the early 9th/15th century; Ṣāʿin al-Dīn is far more reticent than his Ottoman counterpart about his years of study in the west, but may be presumed to have studied many of the texts ʿAbd al-Raḥmān lists. Similarly, while Ṣāʿin al-Dīn and ʿAbd al-Raḥmān are equally persuaded of the ancient pedigree of the sciences they champion, only the latter attempts a detailed

⁶ As will be noted, however, the gnostic-messianic character of hurufism emerged clearly only after the death of Faḏl Allāh, who drew primarily upon a Sufi context, however messianic; see §4.3.3 below.

taxonomy of pre-Islamic authorities. (The implications of their vaunting of the ancients will be explored in Chapter 6.)

In section four I trace the persistence of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's brand of intellectual lettrism in Iran in the later Timurid and early Safavid periods. Here I examine two thinkers in particular, the philosopher and theologian Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī and the polymath and occultist Ḥusayn Vā'iz Kāshifī, both of whom quote Ṣā'in al-Dīn on lettrist matters. I also examine the construction of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's image during this period as the greatest student of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī and systematizer of his teachings, as well as one of the two most prominent intellectuals of Shahrukhid Iran—his own disciple Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī being the other. It is further noted that by at least the early 10th/16th century there emerges a more deliberate emphasis in lettrist writings on the experimental, as opposed to the traditional, basis of applied lettrism.

While the lettrist thought of the Safavid and post-Safavid periods is beyond the scope of this study, I observe in a brief epilogue that Islamicate lettrism as such has persisted in a variety of forms up to the present, although mainly in practical-magical or gnostic-messianic guises, these proving more resilient than intellectual lettrism in the face of the Enlightenment objectification and denaturing of language. That Ṣā'in al-Dīn's reputation as the preeminent lettrist thinker of Shahrukhid Iran appears to have been seriously compromised by the Qajar period, when his lesser philosophical-mystical works, particularly the *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, came into vogue during the revival of Sadrian philosophy in the late 13th/19th century, stands testimony to the marginalization of intellectual lettrism in Iran.

An important component to any survey of the science of letters is the political uses to which the science was frequently put, particularly under the rubric of *jafr* strictly defined; Ṣā'in al-Dīn was certainly among those to recognize the political dimension of the science. Given its special importance for Islamicate historiography, I discuss this component separately in Chapter 5.

4.1: History of *‘ilm al-ḥurūf* from the 2nd-7th/8th-13th centuries

The science of letters, *‘ilm al-ḥurūf*, has often been put forward by its practitioners as the most universal of Islamic sciences, comprehending in its various iterations everything from metaphysics, cosmogony and physics to numerology, alchemy and magic. With roots deep in the gnostic and philosophical traditions of antiquity, the science as it developed in Islam was informed by two different but increasingly interpenetrating aspects: 1) cosmological, Hellenic and hermetic, and 2) metaphysical, spiritual and eschatological, above all quranic.⁷ Its early development is especially associated with the legendary *K. al-Jafr wa-l-Jāmi‘a* of ‘Alī and other texts such as the *Muṣḥaf Fāṭima*, the sole preserve of the House of the Prophet; originally said to be ‘Alī’s record of the Prophet’s statements on matters of lawfulness and unlawfulness and the laws of inheritance, these soon acquired the status of esoteric and omniscient texts of glorious dimensions containing all knowledge of the cosmos, past, present and future, and passed down through the line of Imams.⁸ Ja‘far al-Ṣādiq is especially said to have consulted them. The Shi‘i *ghulāt* of the 2nd/8th century were accordingly the first Islamic sect to make use of a putative letter symbolism in expressing their various gnostic cosmologies. This practice was continued by the early Isma‘ilis, and when at the beginning of the 4th/10th century Isma‘ili thought was recast in neoplatonic and neopythagorean form by the philosophers of the so-called Persian school and slightly later by the group of (semi-Shi‘i?) encyclopedists known as the *Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’* (Brethren of Sincerity), the science of letters became an accepted medium for philosophical and eschatological speculations. Esoteric Shi‘i thought may thus be considered the first to bridge the divide between the Hellenic-gnostic and metaphysical-quranic patrimonies of *‘ilm al-ḥurūf*. The resurgence of extremist messianic Shi‘i-Sufi groups in the 8th-

⁷ Gril, “The Science of Letters,” 146.

⁸ Modarressi, *Tradition and Survival*, 4-5, 18-19.

9th/14th-15th centuries, especially typified by the Ḥurūfiyya in Iran and Azarbayjan, led to a reemphasis of the gnostic-syncretic elements of letter symbolism.⁹

Following closely behind the first Shi'i *ghulāt*, Sufi thinkers began to exploit letter symbolism from the mid-3rd/9th century, such attempts reaching their mature, though unsystematic, form in the writings of Abū l-'Abbās al-Būnī (d. 622/1225?), Ibn 'Arabī (d. 635/1240) and Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī (d. 649/1252) and extending into the modern period with thinkers such as Shaykh Aḥmad al-Aḥsā'ī (d. 1214/1826). The focal point of all such speculations was the 78 isolated letters (*al-muqaṭṭa'āt*) standing at the head of 29 quranic suras, constituted of 14 distinct letters (i.e., precisely half of the Arabic alphabet); these were considered to be both the keys (*fawātiḥ*) to the revelation for the worthy as well as the seals (*khawātim*) upon its *mysterium* for the unworthy.¹⁰ The divine names (*asmā' Allāh al-ḥusnā*) and the *basmala* (in particular, the initial *bā'* and the point under the *bā'*)¹¹ also assumed special importance in letter mysticism early on. The theory of the letters' physical correspondences represents the science's oldest stratum, however—the practical application of letter symbolism in magic, astrology and alchemy, in which guise it came to be termed *sīmiyā'*. Indeed, Ibn Khaldūn (d. 808/1406), while acknowledging its close connection to Sufism, places his

⁹ Reviving the earliest Shi'i cosmologies, such symbolism especially entailed the identification of the letters of the Perso-Arabic alphabet with the human form.

¹⁰ In a recent article ("The Mysterious Letters") Devin Stewart shows that the *muqaṭṭa'āt* are meant to represent the (Aramaic or Hebrew?) alphabet as a symbol of the heavenly source of scripture, the *umm al-kitāb*, defining them as follows: "The mysterious letters are statements of mantic authority indicating that the messages that follow them are veracious revelations from a supernatural source. They do this by symbolizing sacred writing that derives from a heavenly book and by extension the divine knowledge that is contained in that book and is accessible only through revelation" (345). He further observes that the *muqaṭṭa'āt*, unlike the other distinctive features of the quranic text, appear to have no precedent in the pre-Islamic mantic tradition (339).

¹¹ The Quran, like the Torah, begins with *B*, hence the letter's significance in kabbalistic operations in both Jewish and Muslim traditions. The *Fātiḥa* is taken to be the key to the Quranic text as a whole, and the *Fātiḥa*'s initial *bismi Llāh* in turn the key to the sura, and the *bā'* the key to the *basmala*, and the *nuqṭa* under the *bā'* the key to the *bā'*—the primordial, fructifying seed giving rise to the universe. As the famous hadith attributed to 'Alī runs, "I am the point beneath the *bā'* (*anā l-nuqṭa allatī taḥta l-bā'*)."¹² (The Bāb, incidentally, claimed a similar status.)

discussion of the science of letters immediately following that on talismans and other practical occult arts and at a considerable remove from his discussions of Sufism and philosophy.¹²

Nevertheless, even Būnī (or Pseudo-Būnī), the preeminent exponent of practical letter magic whose manuals are still used widely today, seems to have seen this as the best way to preserve the esoteric, salvific truths of lettrism for later generations, a hardy shell to the moist kernel.

In its Islamicate context, then, the science of letters in a sense defies classification; but its running theme for over a millennium has been the deconstruction of reality through tracing God's words—whether the Quran or the cosmos itself—back to their source (*ta'wīl*). (And, in the case of magical or alchemical operations, the reconstruction of reality in accordance with the will of the adept.) Even Ibn Sīnā (d. 428/1037), that pinnacle of sober philosophy, is concerned to demonstrate in true hermetic style that the isolated quranic letters stand as code for the entire process of creation, from origin to return.¹³ This science's unique virtue, as Ṣā'ib al-Dīn emphasizes, is the universalism of its application:

[L]es penseurs de la *s̥mīyâ'* [i.e., the science of letters] vont lire l'ensemble des rythmes du monde en fonction des 28 lettres de l'alphabet arabe (plus, éventuellement, les 4 lettres propres au persan). À chaque entité sera affectée une ou plusieurs lettres: aux anges comme aux cieux visibles, aux planètes et aux constellations, à chaque signe zodiacal, à chaque jour de la semaine, à chaque heure du nyctémère, comme à chaque élément naturel suivant sa densité, aux médicaments, etc. À cette répartition viendront se greffer des polarités propres à l'alphabet arabe. Ainsi entre les 14 lettres «lumineuses» placées en exergue de certaines sourates du Coran, et les 14 autres dites «ténébreuses»; ou encore entre les 14 lettres «solaires» assimilées à l'article à la prononciation, et les 14 autres «lunaires», etc... Ainsi l'univers entier, depuis les atomes terrestres jusqu'au Trône de Dieu, sera-t-il lu comme un immense système de polarités entretenant des rapports incessants (des «mots») telle une immense galaxie de significations se renvoyant sans cesse les nouvelles données d'une pensée cosmique en mouvement. Deux remarques sont à retenir concernant cette vision de la *s̥mīyâ'*:

- d'une part, la *s̥mīyâ'* est une science universelle, visant à rendre compte de *tout* ce qui peut se manifester à tous les niveaux de l'être: de l'universel comme du particulier, du spirituel comme du subtil ou du dense. Elle veut rendre compte de la forme de chaque

¹² Gril, "The Science of Letters," 143. He also completely disassociates the science of letters from *jafṛ*.

¹³ Gril, "The Science of Letters," 134-35. This is especially evident in his *R. Nayrūziyya fī Ma'ānī al-Ḥurūf al-Hijā'iyya*, examined in §4.1.3 below.

entité—ses lettres—comme de l'énergie—le chiffre—qui l'anime, rassemblés en une formule unique. Et surtout, elle permet le passage d'un domaine à un autre grâce à un système de correspondance assez réduit, puisque 28 signes seulement sont mis en œuvre ...

- d'autre part, la *sîmiyâ'* est un langage en soi, elle se suffit à elle-même pour exprimer le monde. Bien plus, elle permet de faire l'économie du vocabulaire philosophique, appareil souvent lourd, peu maniable, décrivant mieux le fixe que le mutable. Elle exprime les phénomènes en tant que systèmes de relations: la lettre n'a de sens que située dans un mot—le mot n'acquiert d'utilité qu'au sein d'une phrase. Bien évidemment, chacune des 28 lettres participe à une multitude indéfinie de relations à tous les niveaux de l'être; elle sert de point de repérage, et sa réalité terrestre, dans la langue arabe, n'en est qu'une expression particulière limitée... Par ailleurs, la lettre exprime l'univers dans son dynamisme: tout est mouvement, il n'est pas de lecture immobile. Cette «syntaxe» des phénomènes est rendue utilisable par le jeu des permutations consonantiques, des passages au nombre, et les divers autres procédés de la Science des Lettres. Mais, rappelons-le, cette combinatoire ne vise pas seulement à établir des liens abstraits, à fonder une sorte de cybernétique avant la lettre: elle se propose comme une lecture initiatique, un dévoilement (*kashf*).¹⁴

4.1.1: The science of letters from gnosticism to philosophy

The first gnostic influences within Islam are discernible in the doctrines of the 2nd/8th century Kaysāniyya, supporters of the line of Hanafid 'Alids, including signature gnostic views on the redemption of the world and the transmigration of souls (*tanāsukh*).¹⁵ Such views were frequently combined with a revolutionary-messianic political agenda, with increasingly extreme postures of rejection of the non-'Alid caliphs (hence the polemical appellation *rawāfiḍ*). (Indeed, one scholar holds that the penetration of gnostic ideas into *ghulāt* movements was a development rather of the early 3rd/9th century, and that their initial beliefs were messianic in a purely political sense; our reliance on later heresiographers for information about early *ghulāt* doctrines makes for a rather distorted picture.¹⁶) It is with al-Mughīra b. Sa'īd (d.

¹⁴ Lory, *La science des lettres*, 43-44.

¹⁵ Madelung, "Kaysāniyya," *El*². *Tanāsukh* is a doctrine common to many fringe movements in Islam from its inception.

¹⁶ Bayhom-Daou, "The Second-Century Šī'ite *Ġulāt*," 15ff. Cf. Asatryan, "Heresy and Rationalism in Early Islam," who shows that some of the accusations in heresiographical material, while exaggerating or

119/737), eponym of the Mughīriyya, that we find the first explicit use of letter symbolism within a gnostic syncretist framework. A sorcerer in the Aramaic tradition, he introduced the use of letters to express his cosmogony: the figure of the creator as a man of light, with limbs in the shape of the letters of the Arabic alphabet.¹⁷ Coming slightly later, Abū l-Khaṭṭāb (d. ca. 138/755), the radical disciple of Jaʿfar al-Šādiq,¹⁸ may be considered the first Shiʿi to organize a fully-fledged *bāṭinī* movement; the Khaṭṭābiyya was to have a particularly decisive influence on the subsequent development of esoteric Shiʿism, and especially on the nascent Ismāʿīliyya. His doctrines include the concepts of spiritual ranking and adoption;¹⁹ the existence of two prophets in every era, the speaking or legislative prophet (*nāṭiq*) and the silent prophet

distorting, were far from baseless.

¹⁷ Wasserstrom, “The Moving Finger Writes,” 12, 16; Tucker, *Mahdis and Millenarians*, 61. Cf. the Valentinian Gnostic Marcos, who maintained that “the body of the Supreme Wisdom (*Aleutheria*) was made up of the letters of the Greek alphabet” (Tucker, *Mahdis and Millenarians*, 61). St. Irenaeus of Lyons characterizes Marcos’s doctrine as follows: “When first the inconceivable and nonmaterial Father ... willed to make utterable that of him which was ineffable and to give form to that which was invisible, he opened his mouth and sent forth a word which was similar to himself. This stood by and showed him who and what he was: a form, appearing from the invisible” (*Av. Haer.* I 14,1; trans. in Foerster, *Gnosis: A Selection of Gnostic Texts*, Vol. 1: *Patristic Evidence*, trans. R. M. Wilson, Oxford, 1972, 203; quoted in Merkur, *Gnosis*, 199). As Daniel Merkur summarizes (*Gnosis*, 199): “The first hypostasis was the Greek word *arche*, ‘beginning.’ It was simultaneously audible and visible; and because it consisted of four letters or elements, it was called the tetrad. The addition of further words, of four, ten, and twelve letters each, resulted in a ‘whole name’ of thirty elements or letters.” Irenaeus: “The whole name was the Truth. Marcos saw her in a vision. Behold her head on high: Alpha and Omega; her neck: Beta and Psi; her shoulders and hands: Gamma and Chi; her breast: Delta and Phi; her diaphragm: Epsilon and Upsilon; her back: Zeta and Tau; her stomach: Eta and Sigma; her thighs: Theta and Rho; her knees: Iota and Pi; her shins: Kappa and Omicron; her ankles: Lambda and Xi; her feet: Mu and Nu. This is the body of Truth. ... This is the form of the element, this the character of the letter. And this element he calls ‘Man’ and says it is the source of all speech, the beginning of every sound, the expression of all that is unspeakable” (*Adv. Haer.* I 14, 3; Foerster, *Gnosis*, 205; Merkur, *Gnosis*, 199-200). “Each one of the letters contains in itself other letters by means of which the name of the letter is expressed, and again other letters are in turn indicated by means of other letters, and the others by others still, so that the number of the letters extends to infinity” (Irenaeus, *Adv. Haer.* I 14, 2; Foerster, *Gnosis*, 204; Merkur, *Gnosis*, 200). “The further development of Marcos’s cosmology, in which the truth became mother to the demiurge, proceeded on numerological principles. It was no longer the letters and their meanings as words, but their numerical values and arithmetical computations that brought the many features of the cosmos into being” (Merkur, *Gnosis*, 200; Irenaeus, *Adv. Haer.* I 15, 118,4; Foerster, *Gnosis*, 208-16). This doctrine was continued in Aramaic Mandaism, “the only Gnostic sect that has continued as a living tradition down to the present day” (Merkur, *Gnosis*, 201).

¹⁸ Jaʿfar subsequently disavowed him publicly.

¹⁹ The latter being particularly revolutionary in that it simultaneously opened spiritual leadership to the *mawālī* and destroyed the basis for the Imamate as physical descent from the Prophet.

(*ṣāmit*);²⁰ the divinity of the Imams and their inheritance of the divine light (*nūr*); an emphasis on *ta'wīl bāṭinī*, in which the esoteric meaning of scripture supersedes its apparent meaning; and, most relevant for the purposes of this discussion, a cosmogony (like that of the Mughīriyya) based on letters, which are then replaced by their corresponding numerical values.²¹ Nor were the Mughīriyya and the Khaṭṭābiyya exceptional in this regard; indeed, the gnostic adaptations that were attempted in the 2nd/8th century were so rife and aggressive as to “constitute a virtual failed takeover of Islam.”²²

The Ismāʿīliyya, however, represent the first point of convergence in Islam between the gnostic and metaphysical traditions inherited from late antiquity. On the death of Abū l-Khaṭṭāb, the Khaṭṭābiyya split into several groups, one of which apparently transferred its allegiance to Ismāʿīl b. Jaʿfar, eponym of the Ismāʿīliyya.²³ The most distinctive characteristic of pre-Fatimid Ismaʿilism is its focus on *ta'wīl*, symbolical or allegorical interpretation, as the means of arriving at the *bāṭin* of revelation, thereby revealing its eternal truths (*ḥaqāʾiq*). A main component of this *ḥaqāʾiq* system was an overtly gnostic cosmology elaborated in the second half of the 3rd/9th century and current through the beginning of the Fatimid state (est. 297/909). A surviving treatise by Abū ʿĪsā al-Murshid, a Fatimid propagandist (*dāʿī*) and judge in Egypt during the reign of al-Muʿizz (r. 341-65/953-75), is the main source of information about this earlier phase of Ismaʿīli doctrine before its definitive neoplatonization in the 4th/10th

²⁰ The silent prophet, identified with ʿAlī in the most recent cycle of prophecy, is considered to be higher than the speaking prophet in that he is master of the esoteric truth contained in the exoteric message of his counterpart.

²¹ Daftary, “The Earliest Ismāʿīlīs,” 218; Tucker, *Mahdis and Millenarians*, 61. A similar replacement of letters with numbers occurred in Sufism (Fahd, “Djafr,” *Et*). Generally speaking, the shape of each letter corresponds to body and its associated numerical value corresponds to spirit.

²² Wasserstrom, “The Moving Finger Writes,” 15.

²³ Daftary, “The Earliest Ismāʿīlīs,” 217. Muḥammad b. Ismāʿīl b. Jaʿfar is the last Imam of the earliest Ismaʿīlīs. It should be noted that they never used such a term for themselves, but designated their movement simply as *dīn al-ḥaqq* or *ʿilm al-ḥaqq*, as well as *al-daʿwa*, the mission, or sometimes *al-daʿwa al-hādiya*, the rightly guiding mission (ibid., 218; Halm, *Shiʿism*, 160).

century at the hands of Nasafī (d. 332/943), Sijistānī (d. after 361/971), Kirmānī (d. 411/1021) and Nāṣir Khusraw (d. after 462/1070), as well as through the influence of the encyclopedic *Rasā'il* of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' (4th/10th c.). According to this earlier cosmology, God, alone in timeless nothingness, created a light (*nūr*) and addressed it with the quranic imperative *kun*, Be! The two original letters of *kun*, *KN*, through duplication became *kūnī*, *KUNY*, the feminine form of the imperative, the first creature and hypostasis-creatix. On God's command (*amr*), *Kūnī* created from herself the second creature, *qadar* (*QDR*), determination, as her assistant and male principle to her female. Thus emerged the first two principles of creation from whose union all other creatures issued. The letters *KUNY-QDR*, the *ḥurūf 'ulwiyya*, are identified with the first seven of the 28 letters, and represent the seven *nuṭaqā'*, or legislative prophets, while the last seven letters represent the Imams.²⁴

The association of letters with Isma'ili cosmogony and the doctrine of cycles did not cease, however, with the reformulation of Isma'ili teaching in neoplatonic or emanationist terms. This may be seen from the example of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā', whose *Epistles* are best described as an amalgamated esoteric-philosophical-scientific manual meant to provide the beginner with a comprehensive training program that will allow him to penetrate to the *ḥaqā'iq*. Despite their probable origin as a collaborative project bracketing the first half century of Fatimid power (ca. 287-254/900-65),²⁵ the *Epistles* exhibit (with one exception) a general stylistic cohesiveness. They have often been seen as a foundational Isma'ili text, or at least one with pronounced Shi'i loyalties, but the eclectic heterogeneity and combinative nature of their contents seems to

²⁴ Daftary, *The Ismā'īlīs*, 133-34.

²⁵ The identity of the authors remains an open question, although Abū Ḥayyān al-Tawḥīdī (d. 414/1023) explicitly mentions the names of four authors, to wit, the qadi Abū l-Ḥasan 'Alī b. Hārūn al-Zanjānī and his three companions, Abū Sulaymān Muḥammad b. Ma'shar [or: Mi'sar] al-Bustī al-Maqdisī, Abū Aḥmad al-Nahrajūrī and al-'Awfī, all of whom hailed from Basra and were connected to the chancellery scribe Zayd b. Rifā'a (Baffioni, "Ikhwan al-Safa'," *SEP*). In his review of the many different datings offered by scholars, Godefroid de Callataÿ suggests that, regardless of whether we believe the *Epistles* to have been composed by a single individual or through the collaboration of scholars over several generations, a general consensus holds them as having been completed by the 970s (*Ikhwan al-Safa'*, 10).

preclude any such neat ideological identification; in any event, the authors' Isma'īlism, if they so identified, was certainly not that advanced by the Fatimid state.²⁶ (Where the *Epistles* are consistent with the purpose of the contemporary Isma'īlī *da'wa*, however, is in their incitement to action as well as to knowledge, with a view to the soul's purification from matter and re-ascent upon death to the Universal Soul and then the Intellect—this through the agency of the Imam.) The 51 epistles (or technically 52) are rather artificially made to follow, in traditional philosophical form, a gradual progression from the concrete to the abstract—mathematics, logic, physics, metaphysics—and conclude with an epistle on astrological magic, necessary for the recognition of the legitimate Imam. The 50th epistle, called the 'comprehensive epistle' (*al-risāla al-jāmi'a*), functions as a condensed snapshot of the Epistles as a whole, dealing with the *ḥaqā'iq* while leaving aside the technical aspects of each science and supported by dialectical arguments of a neoplatonic type; it is complemented by an even more condensed version (*risāla jāmi'at al-jāmi'a*). The doctrine of the Epistles draws on Harranian syncretism and its synthesis of Babylonian religion, Mithraism and Greek religion and philosophy, catalyzed by hermetic influence; the Ikhwān in their turn considered all the sciences of the past to belong to Islam via their Imam, and thus achieved a new syncretism between this Harranian synthesis combined with a much more prominent neoplatonic element. Also present is an amalgam of Babylonian, Indian, Iranian and Greek astrology; stories from the Hebrew Bible and Rabbinic texts; and borrowings from the New Testament. The influence of Greek writings is, however, the

²⁶ The Isma'īlī thesis was asserted by Corbin and Marquet in particular, but as Stern and Diwald noted it may rather be a case of guilt by association through the subsequent embrace by Isma'īlī thinkers of the *Epistles* in the 6th/12th century (Baffioni, "Ikhwan al-Safa'," *SEP*). Fu'ād Ma'sūm (*Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'*, 275–303) makes a compelling case for the Ikhwān as an independent-minded philosophical-scientific-esotericist group of strong neopythagorean and neoplatonic leanings whose quest for a unitive view of knowledge and history placed them beyond confessional categories of Shi'i or Sunni; they accept both the Rāshidūn caliphs and Companions (as exemplary stalwarts of the early Muslim community) and the 'Alid Imams (as Prophetic heirs and sole guardians of hidden knowledge)—yet the true Imam, in all times and places, is the Intellect, or even the brotherhood as a body. The Ikhwān's idea of the perfect man is a Persian Muslim scholar-philosopher of the Hanafi rite, at least 50 years of age, who abjures religious extremism of any kind. Their confessional position, in short, appears to tally neatly with the Shi'i-Sunni esoteric outlook that would become ubiquitous in the 7th-9th/13th-15th centuries, as discussed in §1.6.

dominant one, especially magical and philosophical-hermetic writings, those of the pythagoreans, of Aristotle, of Plato, and of the neoplatonists. All is smoothly adapted to Islam, with changes where necessary.²⁷

As Pierre Lory observes in his article on the subject, the Brethren treat of lettrist themes through their discussions of language on the one hand and number on the other. They identify three levels of language: 1) the ordinary, utilitarian level, comprising grammar and literature; 2) that necessary for understanding religious texts, which, while equally utilitarian, allows one to achieve felicity in the hereafter; and 3) the philosophical approach, concerned with knowledge for its own sake and serving to deify man. It is the last level, of course, that occupies the Brethren's attention almost exclusively, which they pursue according to both the standard Aristotelian model and the more esoteric neoplatonic-neopythagorean model, without seeking to integrate the two. Under the aegis of the latter model, they describe the emanationist process whereby the heavenly language proper to the Universal Soul becomes differentiated into the languages of every order of being—angelic languages, the sublunary languages of nature, and the variety of human languages. In particular, the Adamic language is identified as *suryānī*—not to be confused with Syriac/Aramaic—consisting of autonomous letters pregnant with supernal meanings; the proliferation of human languages (and the misunderstandings this generated) came about through the arrangement of these *suryānī* letters into words. For its part, Arabic (i.e., the Arabic of the Quran) is not superior to other languages because it approximates the Adamic tongue, but because it is the most complete and most harmonious of *suryānī*-derived languages, and serves to focus the various qualities of all cosmic and human languages into a single matrix. From the Quran, then, a symbolic science of letters may be derived with which to demonstrate the universal harmony that suffuses every discrete discipline, from the numerical or geometrical harmonies of Arabic calligraphy, prosody or

²⁷ Marquet, "Ikhwān al-Ṣafāʾ," *El*².

music to the mysteries of the quranic *muqatta'āt*, with all admitting of astrological analysis in particular. Likewise, they apply neoplatonic-neopythagorean number theory in order to explicate the principle of divine unity (*tawhīd*), with God relating to the world as one relates to other numbers. Twenty-eight is considered the perfect number, equal to the sum of its parts, being the number of letters in the Arabic alphabet, of lunar mansions, of vertebrae in the backbone, and of the sum of the top row and right column of magic squares (*budūh*).²⁸ Indeed, number for the Brethren is the ultimate foundation of truth and key to the unification of all fields of knowledge, from arithmetics to grammar, from astrology to geography, from music to magic.²⁹

Continuing trends among the early *ghulāt*, then, Isma'ili doctrine was first expressed using gnostic-messianic elements, then progressively neoplatonized in Iran and Egypt, subsequently leading to the reform of Fatimid doctrine through the adoption in the 6th/12th century of the semi-Shi'i and thoroughgoingly philosophical outlook expressed in the *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'*.³⁰ More broadly, the canonization of the *Epistles* as an important watershed in Islamic intellectual history served to propagate their enthusiasm for neoplatonic-neopythagorean lettrism among many different religio-intellectual currents within Islam, particularly that constituted by the later Sufi thinkers examined below.

The vast corpus attributed to Jābir b. Ḥayyān, legendary pupil of Ja'far al-Ṣādiq³¹ and among the principal exponents of earlier Arabic alchemy, resembles the *Rasā'il* in its

²⁸ Varisco, "Numerology," *El*².

²⁹ Lory, *La science des lettres*, 65-74.

³⁰ There appears to have been a certain interest in letter symbolism in contemporary Nuṣayrī-'Alawī circles as well, as evidenced by Muḥammad b. 'Alī al-Jillī's (d. after 384/994) *R. al-Ḥurūf* (in Abū Mūsā and al-Shaykh Mūsā, eds., *Rasā'il al-Ḥikma al-'Alawiyya*, Vol. 2: 3. *al-Ḥusayn b. Ḥamdān al-Khaṣībī*, 4. *Muḥammad b. 'Alī al-Jillī*, Diyār 'Aql, Lebanon, 2006, 335-41). Al-Jillī was successor to al-Khaṣībī (d. Aleppo 356/957 or 358/969) (Halm, "Nuṣayriyya," *El*²). My thanks go to Dr. Mushegh Asatryan for alerting me to the existence of this work.

³¹ Ja'far here again standing in as proxy for Greek wisdom and occult sciences.

encyclopedic tapping of ancient literature via the pagan Harranian milieu. Jābir's Islamic gnosis is not the primitive gnosis of the Shi'i *ghulāt* of the 1st/7th and 2nd/8th centuries, but rather the gnostic syncretism in vogue at the end of the 3rd/9th century. It anticipates the advent of a new Imam who will replace the law of Islam with Greek science and philosophy, that is, a new, purely spiritual revelation as propounded by the 'Alid Imams (Ja'far al-Šādiq in particular). The fundamental principle in Jābir's science is that of *mīzān*, balance. It includes speculation on the letters of the Arabic alphabet, which he connects to the four elementary qualities (hot, cold, wet, dry), and applies to all things in the sublunary world as well as to things metaphysical. In this Jābir synthesizes neopythagoreanism and Shi'i speculations on the *K. al-Jafr*.³² As Jābir states in his *K. al-Aḥjār*,

The Balances are divided according to the diversity of natural objects. There are Balances of the Intelligence, of the Soul, of Nature, Form, and the Sphere of the stars; there are Balances of the four natures, animals, plants, and minerals—these are all useful Balances. But, finally, there is the Balance of Letters: and this is the most perfect of all!³³

He expands upon this thesis in the *K. al-Baḥth*:

A group of people says that the knowledge of matters relating to the four natures (*aḥwāl al-tabā'i*), as well as an understanding of the qualities (*kayfiyyāt*), may be attained by a more suitable method: that is, by means of the *names* (*asmā'*) of food, drugs, organs of animals, and parts of animals and plants. We have called this method the Balance of Letters. In it lies a meticulous science (*ilm daqīq*) through which one reaches an understanding of the real characteristics of natural objects (*ḥaqā'iq aḥwāl al-mawjūdāt*).³⁴

³² Kraus [Plessner], "Djābir b. Ḥayyān," *El*².

³³ *K. al-Khamsīn*, MS Shehit Ali Paşa 1277 f. 131a, quoted in Kraus, *Jābir ibn Ḥayyān*, 188 n. 3; trans. in Haq, *Names, Natures and Things*, 81.

³⁴ *K. al-Baḥth*, MS Carullah 1721 f. 110a, quoted in Kraus, *Jābir ibn Ḥayyān*, 223 n. 7; trans. in Haq, *Names, Natures and Things*, 81.

Denis Gril summarizes the Balance of Letters (*Mīzān al-Ḥurūf*), also called the Balance of Articulation (*Mīzān al-Hijā'*)³⁵ and the Balance of Utterance (*Mīzān Lafẓī*),³⁶ as follows:

To a greater extent than any other, this science [of balance as applied to letters] allows Islam to integrate the entire ancient esoteric heritage through the twenty-eight letters of the Arabic alphabet, with them, themselves, being considered as the product of the multiplication of the four “natures” via the different levels of the seven-tiered hierarchy ... It is thus clear that this balance aims not only at determining the properties of beings (*khawâss*), and their many magical, medical, astrological, alchemical, and other applications, but also at rediscovering, in the simple elements of language, the key to all knowledge.³⁷

It should be further noted that Jābir rejects the neopythagorean fixation on number as the basis of reality embraced by the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'; for Jābir, the structure of language, not number, corresponds to the structure of existing things.³⁸

These then are the broad contours of gnostic lettrist thought in the Shi'i context and the process of its philosophization up through the 4th/10th century. Such developments did not, of course, take place in a vacuum; the *Epistles* of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' and the Jābirean corpus in particular exerted considerable influence on the development of Sufi thought. Perhaps more importantly, the imamophilic impulse that pervades Sufi theory and practice has not a little to do with the occult supremacy accorded the Imams, particularly 'Alī and Ja'far al-Ṣādiq, as sole keepers of the *K. al-Jafr* and similarly omniscient texts. It is therefore to the development of Sufi lettrism that we now turn.

³⁵ *K. al-Tajmīr* (Book of Concentration), MS Leiden 1265 f. 167a-b, quoted in Kraus, *Jābir ibn Ḥayyān*, 244.

³⁶ *K. al-Sirr al-Maknūn*, MS Paris 5099 f. 55a; see Haq, *Names, Natures and Things*, 81.

³⁷ Gril, “The Science of Letters,” 129-30.

³⁸ Haq, *Names, Natures and Things*, 99 n. 11.

4.1.2: The emergence and maturation of Sufi lettrism

Sufi thinkers had already begun to tap into the burgeoning lettrist tradition outlined above by the late-3rd/9th century, that is, before its philosophization at the hands of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' and others. Abū Sa'īd Kharrāz (d. 285/899), for example, as quoted by Abū Naṣr Sarrāj (d. 377/988), was apparently among the first to use letter symbolism in his exposition of mystical doctrine. Other noted early Sufis to do the same include Aḥmad b. 'Aṭā' (d. 309/922), al-Ḥakīm al-Tirmidhī (d. ca. 324/936)³⁹ and Niffarī (d. ca. 365/976). It is Sahl Tustarī (d. 282/896), however, who came to be considered the first systematic expositor of the science of letters among the Sufis; the letters' cosmogonic role is particularly developed in treatises ascribed to him in subsequent generations.⁴⁰ Al-Ḥusayn b. Maṣṣūr al-Ḥallāj's (d. 309/922) use of the science of letters is of particular note, given Ibn 'Arabī's identification of him as one of its primary representatives. Ḥallāj's numerological and kabbalistic esotericism appears to be taken in the main from his master Sahl Tustarī, which suggests that there is some truth in the ascription of lettrist concerns to the latter.⁴¹ Ḥallāj's main work, the *Ṭawāsīn* (i.e., *ṬS*), frequently has recourse to line diagrams and lettrist symbols in an attempt to express the ineffable. His chapter glorifying Iblīs, by far the longest in the book, is infamous; the depiction of Satan as the most perfect lover of God became a popular theme among many Persian Sufi

³⁹ On Tirmidhī's "mystical linguistics" see Sviri, "Words of Power and the Power of Words."

⁴⁰ As well as in those of the early Andalusian mystic Ibn Masarra al-Jabalī (d. 318/931), who borrowed heavily from Tustarī (Gril, "The Science of Letters," 136-42). It should be noted, however, that the main lettrist work ascribed to Tustarī, *R. al-Ḥurūf*, cannot be considered authentic, but belongs to a broader "Andalusian Tustarī tradition" developed by subsequent generations of disciples; as such, Ibn Masarra's lettrist treatises predate this *R. al-Ḥurūf*, and are in any case more neoplatonic-neopythagorean in approach than the latter. Indeed, the similarities the *R. al-Ḥurūf* bears to the *Shams al-Ma'ārif* suggest that it was perhaps compiled by Būnī or one of Būnī's disciples, and therefore cannot be taken as representative of the earlier phase of Sufi lettrism (Böwering, *The Mystical Vision*, 17-18; Ebstein and Sviri, "The So-Called *Risālat al-Ḥurūf*," 215, 221, 224, 232-34).

⁴¹ But cf. the argument made recently by Michael Ebstein and Sara Sviri that lettrist concerns are entirely absent from those works that can be reliably attributed to Tustarī's oral teachings ("The So-Called *Risālat al-Ḥurūf*," 221).

writers, including Aḥmad Ghazālī (d. 520/1126), ‘Ayn al-Quzāt Hamadānī (d. 525/1131) and Rūzbihān Baqlī (d. 606/1209).⁴² Two meditations on letter symbolism stand out, one on the letters in the name Muḥammad and the second on the symbolism of the quranic ‘distance of two bows’ (*qāba qawsayn*) (Q 53:9) as well as references to the esoteric meaning of *mīm* and the *lām-alif* digraph. Generally speaking, in the *Ṭāwasīn* Ḥallāj regards letters in their quranic form as representing the path of knowledge par excellence.⁴³

Abū ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Sulamī’s (d. 412/1021) *Sharḥ Ma‘ānī al-Ḥurūf* is particularly valuable for the window it provides onto the mystical speculations of prominent Sufi masters of the 3rd/9th and 4th/10th centuries with regard to the Arabic letters, and the quranic *muqatta‘āt* in particular. The Sufi masters referenced in the first part of the treatise include al-Ḥārith b. Asad al-Muḥāsibī (d. 243/857), Abū Sa‘īd Aḥmad al-Kharrāz (d. 277/890), Abū l-‘Abbās Aḥmad b. Muḥammad al-Ādamī (Ibn ‘Aṭā’) (d. 309/921 or 311/923), al-Ḥusayn b. Maṣṣūr al-Ḥallāj, Abū Bakr Muḥammad al-Wāsiṭī (d. 320/932), Abū Bakr Dulaf b. Jahdar al-Shiblī (d. 334/946), Abū l-‘Abbās al-Qāsim al-Sayyārī (d. 342/953), and Ibn Shādhān (d. 376/986); those in the second part include Dhū l-Nūn al-Miṣrī (d. 245/860), Abū Bakr Muḥammad b. ‘Umar al-Warrāq al-Balkhī al-Tirmidhī al-Ḥakīm (d. 280/893), Abū Sa‘īd al-Kharrāz, al-Junayd (d. 298/910), Abū ‘Uthmān Sa‘īd b. Ismā‘īl al-Ḥīrī (d. 298/910), Abū Muḥammad Aḥmad b. Muḥammad al-Jurayrī (d. 312/924), Ibn ‘Aṭā’, Ḥallāj, Abū Bakr ‘Abdallāh b. Ṭāhir al-Abharī (d. ca. 330/942), Muḥammad b. ‘Isā al-Hāshimī, and Abū Muḥammad Ja‘far b. Muḥammad b. Nuṣayr al-Khuldī (d. 348/959); and many other early Sufi authorities are quoted anonymously throughout. Ḥallāj is without question the most frequently quoted authority.⁴⁴ As he states in the preface, Sulamī wrote this treatise as an

⁴² Mojaddedi, “Ḥallāj,” *Elr.*

⁴³ Gril, “Science,” 139.

⁴⁴ Böwering, “Sulamī’s Treatise on the Science of the Letters (*‘ilm al-ḥurūf*),” 347-5, 355-57.

addendum and conclusion to his major Quran commentary, the *Ḥaqā'iq al-Tafsīr*.⁴⁵ In his presentation of early Sufi lettrism, the author takes care to select only those quotations that reflect moderate views, using a primarily alliterative hermeneutic rather than an allegorical or esoteric one;⁴⁶ as such, shades of the bolder type of gnostic-syncretistic letter symbolism common among *ghulāt* movements of the 2nd-3rd/8th-9th centuries on the one hand or the contemporary neoplatonic-neopythagorean lettrism of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' on the other are wholly absent, as are any references to the lettrist theories of Sahl Tustarī, Ibn Masarra or even Ja'far al-Ṣādiq.⁴⁷ He likewise manifests very little concern for the numerological qualities of the letters. Furthermore, Sulamī only cites material on the first 22 letters of the Arabic alphabet (from *abjad* to *kalamān*), i.e., those corresponding to the Phoenician and Hebrew alphabets, wholly ignoring those six peculiar to Arabic (*thakhadh ḍaḥagh*).⁴⁸ Despite its omissions and general conservatism, however, the *Sharḥ Ma'ānī al-Ḥurūf* brings together a rich and unparalleled variety of early Sufi hermeneutical approaches to the Arabic letters.⁴⁹

Before we leave the 5th/11th century, mention must be made of Abū l-Qāsim al-Qushayrī (d. 465/1072), whose modest *Naḥw al-Qulūb*, as characterized by Lory,

contient-elle certains éléments d'une philosophie du langage, avec des réflexions, dans la ligne de l'ash'arisme, sur les rapports entre les mots du langage humain, et ceux que la sagesse divine prééternelle a adjoint de toute éternité aux choses. Mais son intérêt réside surtout dans sa tentative de tracer des correspondances entre les règles de la grammaire arabe, et le parcours spirituel du mystique. Il propose par exemple un parallèle entre le nominatif (*raf'*) et l'élévation de la volonté spirituelle, entre l'accusatif (*nasb*) et l'activité du corps dans l'obéissance à Dieu, et entre le datif (*khafd*) et l'abaissement de l'âme

⁴⁵ Böwering, "Sulamī's Treatise," 344.

⁴⁶ Böwering, "Sulamī's Treatise," 356, 365.

⁴⁷ Sulamī does however attribute to Ja'far al-Ṣādiq several letter interpretations in his *Ḥaqā'iq al-Tafsīr* (Böwering, "Sulamī's Treatise," 366-67).

⁴⁸ Böwering, "Sulamī's Treatise," 346-47. This omission is most likely meant to reflect the absence of these letters among the quranic *muqatta'āt* (Stewart, "The Mysterious Letters," 341).

⁴⁹ Böwering, "Sulamī's Treatise," 368-69.

charnelle dans l'humilité face au Créateur. Les déclinaisons, conjugaisons et différentes règles de syntaxe sont ainsi rapportées à des données de spiritualité et de dévotion. L'entreprise de Qushayrî garde des dimensions doctrinales modestes, car il ne s'agit pas d'un traité de théologie, mais plutôt d'un ouvrage destiné à aviver la curiosité et la compréhension intuitive des disciples soufis, sans choquer les musulmans littéralistes par un ésotérisme trop audacieux.⁵⁰

Mystical lettrism gained an unprecedented impetus in the flowering of Sufism in Andalusia and the Maghrib in the 6th/12th century. This florescence is associated with such figures as Ibn Qasī (d. 546/1151), Ibn al-'Arīf (d. 536/1141), Ibn Barrajān (d. 536/1141) and Abū Madyan (d. 594/1197), and may be seen as culminating in the mystical theory of Ibn 'Arabī (d. 635/1240), who emigrated to the east in 596/1200. The lettrist concerns of Ibn Barrajān, Abū Madyan and Ibn 'Arabī in particular are informed by the neoplatonic-hermetic approach of Ibn Masarra (d. 319/931), an early pioneer of the western lettrist tradition.⁵¹ Abū l-'Abbās al-Būnī (d. 622/1225?), typically regarded as the greatest exponent of letter magic in the Islamic tradition, must be included in this roster, for he understood himself to be, and was universally received as, a Sufi; in the later tradition he is made to cite such eminences as al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī, al-Junayd, Abū Madyan and Ibn 'Arabī as spiritual predecessors. Mention should also be made of Abū l-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī (d. 656/1258), whose well-known travel charm, the *ḥizb al-baḥr*, for example, invokes the properties and secrets of various letters.⁵² The Maghribi lettrist tradition seems to have also been continued by the relatively neglected Abū l-Ḥasan al-Ḥarrālī (d.

⁵⁰ Lory, *La science des lettres*, 53. For a study of this treatise see Longo, "Spiritual Grammar: A Comparative Theological Study of Jean Gerson's 'Donatus moralizatus' and 'Abd al-Karim al-Qushayri's 'Nahw al-qulub.'" Cf. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *R. dar Khawāṣṣ-i 'Ilm-i Sharf* (see §2.1.2, no. 14).

⁵¹ For Ibn Masarra's lettrist theory see his *R. al-I'tibār* (MS Chester Beatty 3168/4 ff. 88-95, copied 686/1287), ed. Clemente, "Edición crítica de la 'Risalat al-i'tibar' de Ibn Masarra de Córdoba"; trans. idem, "Traducción anotada de la 'Risalat al-I'tibār' de Ibn Masarra de Córdoba"; and K. *Khawāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf* (MS Chester Beatty 3168/2 ff. 65a-83), ed. Clemente, "Edición crítica del K. *Jawāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf* de Ibn Masarra"; Ibn Masarra, *al-Ḥurūf*. His *R. al-I'tibār* and *Khawāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf* were printed together as *Min al-Turāth al-Falsafī li-Ibn Masarra*, ed. Muḥammad Kamāl Ja'far, Cairo, 1402/1982. See also M. Asín Palacios, *The Mystical Philosophy of Ibn Masarra and His Followers* (Böwering, "Sulamī's Treatise," 366 n. 78).

⁵² The Maghebi master and founder of the Shādhiliyya figures prominently in 'Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī's *isnāds* for the science of letters (see §4.3.4 below).

647/1239), perhaps one of the historical Būnī's teachers. Ibn Barrajān is, of course, famous for his prediction of Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn al-Ayyūbī's (d. 589/1193) recapture of Jerusalem from the Crusaders in 583/1187 on the basis of numerological and astrological calculations applied to the first five verses of Sūrat al-Rūm (Q 30). This episode is cited by many later lettrists, including Ibn 'Arabī, Ibn Turka, 'Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī and 'Alī Ṣafī Kāshifī, as an outstanding example of the divinatory efficacy of the science of letters, and has continued to be celebrated in Ash'ari circles up to the present as a proof of the doctrine of *i'jāz al-Qur'ān*. Because of its special political importance in later Islamic historiography, including Turkmen and Ottoman chronicles of the late 9th/15th century, I offer a translation of Ibn Barrajān's tafsirs on Q 30:1-5 in Chapter 5 (§5.2.1.1), together with Ibn 'Arabī's critique of his lettrist methodology (§5.2.1.1.1).

Sufi lettrism thus attains its mature form in the writings of three mystics in particular: Abū l-'Abbās al-Būnī, preeminent authority on letter magic, primarily in its western form; Ibn 'Arabī, preeminent authority on Sufi letter theory and the main link between the western and eastern traditions; and Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī, preeminent exponent of the eastern Sufi lettrist tradition.

4.1.2.1: Abū l-'Abbās al-Būnī and letter magic

Abū l-'Abbās Aḥmad al-Būnī's (d. 622/1225?) *Shams al-Ma'ārif*, in short, middle and long recensions, stands as the most important grimoire in the Islamicate world,⁵³ and his other, more authentic works constitute basic source texts on letter magic.⁵⁴ Yet we know little about the life of this western master, and the two dates of death given by Ḥājjī Khalīfa (d. 1067/1657),

⁵³ Unlike the *Ghāyat al-Ḥakīm* of Majrīṭī (d. 395/1105), which became a standard source in Europe under the title *Picatrix*, the *Shams al-Ma'ārif* does not appear to have been translated into Latin. For more on the grimoire genre see Davies, *Grimoires: A History of Magic Books*.

⁵⁴ Brockelmann ascribes 40 titles to Būnī, a clearly symbolic number (Witkam, "Gazing at the Sun," 184).

622 and 630 AH, appear to be arbitrary.⁵⁵ Even the *Shams al-Ma'arif*, the basis for Būnī's fame, appears to bear a rather tenuous connection to the man himself.⁵⁶ His status as a Sufi is likewise much contested; Sufi biographers hold him up as a saint and mystic, while authorities like Ibn Khaldūn condemn him as a sorcerer.⁵⁷ As Būnī himself repeatedly argues, however, the magical operations that he (or Pseudo-Būnī) lays out in such exhaustive detail represent but forms of applied Sufism.

Scholarship on magic in the Islamic world is proceeding apace, and increasingly moving away from the triumphalist and positivist accounts typical of earlier studies with their unhelpful characterizations of magic and the occult sciences as irrational and unbalanced forms of religious mania.⁵⁸ In particular, we are fortunate to have a number of excellent studies on Būnī, although many tend to be marred by an overdependence on the pseudopigraphic *Shams al-Ma'arif*; this has the effect of reinforcing the inaccurate image of Būnī as more mage than Sufi shaykh.⁵⁹ Nevertheless, as I am here primarily concerned to determine Būnī's

⁵⁵ *Kashf al-Zunūn*, 1062, 1161; Hamès, "al-Būnī," *El*³; Lory, *La science des lettres*, 91. Neither date is particularly persuasive, since he is also said to have died in Cairo and been buried in the Qarāfa cemetery near the tomb of 'Abd al-Jalīl al-Ṭahāwī, who died in 649/1251 (Dietrich, "al-Būnī," *El*²). As Noah Gardiner shows in a forthcoming article based on extensive manuscript research of the Būnian corpus ("Forbidden Knowledge? Notes on the Production, Transmission, and Reception of the Major Works of Aḥmad al-Būnī," *JAIS*, [7-8]; my thanks to the author for sending me a draft of this important article), authorial colophons and audition certificates on early MSS of two of Būnī's works testify to the fact that he was still very much alive and active in Egypt in 622/1225.

⁵⁶ Gardiner argues that the *Shams al-Ma'arif al-Kubrā*, wholly distinct from the authentic *Shams al-Ma'arif wa-Laṭā'ī al-Awārif*, is in fact the work of anonymous compilers in the 11th/17th century ("Forbidden Knowledge?" 35-39).

⁵⁷ Francis, "Magic and Divination in the Medieval Islamic Middle East," 625. For Ibn Khaldūn's treatment of magic more generally see Asatrian, "Ibn Khaldūn on Magic and the Occult."

⁵⁸ Gardiner, "Forbidden Knowledge?" 39; Francis, "Magic and Divination," 626.

⁵⁹ Gardiner, "Forbidden Knowledge?" 2 n. 10. See e.g. Toufic Fahd, "Magie comme 'source de la sagesse' dans l'oeuvre d'al-Būnī"; Lory, "Science des Lettres et Magie: La magie des lettres dans le *Shams al-ma'arif*," in *La science des lettres en Islam*, 91-112; Lory, "Parole et magie en Islam"; Francis, "Islamic Symbols and Sufi Rituals for Protection and Healing"; El-Ġawhary, "Die Gottesnamen im magischen Gebrauch in den al-Buni zugeschriebenen Werken"; Cordero, "El Kitāb Šams al-ma'arif al-Kubrā (al-yuz' al-awwal) de Aḥmad b. 'Alī al-Būnī"; Pielow, *Die Quellen der Weisheit*; and Noah Gardiner's ongoing research on Būnī promises further insights. For lists of Būnī's works see Brockelmann, *GAL*, 1/497; Cordero, "El Kitāb Šams al-Ma'arif al-Kubrā," ix-xviii; Fahd, *La divination arabe*, 231-32, 237-38, 243; Ullman,

influence on early 9th/15th century lettrist thought, less attention need be paid to the question of this great grimoire's authenticity inasmuch as its various forms were unquestioningly attributed to Būnī in the later lettrist tradition;⁶⁰ and in any event, a lack of scholarly attention to Būnī's more authentic but lesser known works, all of which remain in manuscript, places them beyond the remit of the present study.⁶¹

Taken as an organic though problematic whole, then, the Būnī corpus constitutes a distinctly universalist project, one rooted deeply in the Quran, and as such is a key precedent for Ṣā'in al-Dīn's own universalist ambitions. In a recent article on Būnī's methods and goals Toufic Fahd offers a comprehensive summary of the great mage's project;⁶² the abstract is worth quoting in full:

Like his predecessor Mağriṭī and his successor H. C. Agrippa, al-Būnī builds a universe based on the neoplatonic monad. It is penetrated by divine rays, an all-encompassing web, both active and influential, that allows the magician, both wise and mystical, to discover the mystery and evaluate its effect on created, animate and inanimate beings. He has only to retrace his path along the taut lines of this web to find the One, Allah ..., and try to decipher the message to see what has been preordained.

In order to reach this highest level of knowledge, magic can be used to follow the paths to the source of wisdom. This knowledge may be transformed into philosophy and mysticism under the influence of a universal 'sympathy' whose signs spontaneously appear or are deciphered through the letters of the alphabet; numbers; symbols and their inversions; conversions; equivalence; compositions (into phonemes; words; circumlocutions; sentences and sound); and oppositions, as well as literal exegesis and

Die Natur- und Geheimwissenschaften, 390-91. On magic and divination in general see Savage-Smith, ed., *Magic and Divination in Early Islam*; Burnett, *Magic and Divination in the Middle Ages*; and Francis, "Magic and Divination in the Medieval Islamic Middle East."

⁶⁰ E.g., by 'Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī in his *Shams al-Āfāq*; see §4.3.4 below. Ibn Khaldūn's (d. 808/1406) critical remarks in his *Muqaddima* establish a *terminus ad quem* for the original core of the *Shams al-Ma'ārif* (Lory, *La science des lettres*, 92).

⁶¹ Gardiner ("Forbidden Knowledge?" 12-13) identifies five works as constituting the core of the historical Būnian corpus: *Shams al-Ma'ārif wa-Laṭā'if al-'Awārif* (distinct from the *Shams al-Ma'ārif al-Kubrā*), *Hidāyat al-Qāsidīn wa-Nihāyat al-Wāṣilīn*, *Mawāqif al-Ghāyāt fī Asrār al-Riyādāt*, *ʿIlm al-Hudā wa-Asrār al-Ihtidā fī Sharḥ Asmā' Allāh al-Ḥusnā*, and *Laṭā'if al-Ishārāt fī l-Ḥurūf al-'Ulwiyyāt*. There are a further three works that are likely authentic, and were certainly received as such by the 8th/14th century: *al-Lum'a al-Nūrāniyya fī Awrād al-Rabbāniyya* (particularly popular into the 12th/18th century), *Tartīb al-Da'awāt fī Takḥṣīṣ al-Awqāt 'alā Ikhtilāf al-Irādāt*, and *Qabs al-Iqtidā' ilā Wafq al-Sa'āda wa-Najm al-Ihtidā'*.

⁶² Fahd, "Magie comme 'source de la sagesse.'"

allegorical and fantasist interpretations. Physics; chemistry-alchemy; mathematics; astronomy/astrology and theology/philosophy are then also included. In short, all aspects of knowledge converge to decipher the secrets of Creation and the Creator.

Yet, the most pertinent method to access esoteric knowledge is through Qur'anic ... exegesis, a type of "voluntarist" hermeneutics. This is at the core of al-Būnī's works. For al-Būnī, everything stems from the Qur'an ... and in particular from the divine Names; the *basmallah* [sic], and the mysterious letters of the Qur'an that begin some surahs ... He also used many divining techniques including the *Ġafr*, the *Zā'irġa*, the *ḥāfiya ḥarfiyya* and the *kīmiyā'*.

Thus with al-Būnī's work the Qur'an ... becomes the object of theological, philosophical, mystic and alchemic speculations. The desired outcome is the good fortune of man here on earth, by way of a Qur'anic ... 'elixir.' The required conditions to achieve this state are those to which Sufis submit themselves: faith; ritual purity; meditation exercises (*riyāḍa*); isolation (*ḥalwa*); invocation (*dikr*), spirits [sic] evocations. Through consistently using the Qur'an ... as the cornerstone of his esoteric explorations, al-Būnī avoids censure for his work.⁶³

This universalist project aside, Būnī's primary methodology is that of letter magic. As Lory summarizes (problematically confining his remarks to the *Shams al-Ma'ārif*):

[L]e *Shams al-ma'ārif* est pour l'essentiel consacré au pouvoir magique des lettres. Il contient certes maints excursus abordant l'astrologie, l'alchimie ou la divination; mais la grande majorité des développements reviennent inlassablement à une préoccupation centrale: comment utiliser la force surnaturelle incluse dans les lettres et les noms pour infléchir le cours des événements? ... Celle-ci peut se résumer succinctment en trois points.

— Tout est nombre dans l'univers, depuis les premières impulsions de l'acte créateur jusqu'aux détails des phénomènes dans le monde sublunaire. Mais la nature des nombres s'accomplit dans les lettres (du verbe divin), qui tout en gardant une valeur numérique, créent des sens au fur et à mesure qu'elles constituent l'infrastructure du monde.

— Dès lors, la structure de l'univers n'est pas seulement *comparable* à un langage: elle est tout entière langage. L'alchimie ou la magie se posent alors comme des sciences de la «morphologie» et de la «syntaxe» des phénomènes du monde.

— Quant au langage humain—pensé, articulé et écrit—il est la condensé réel de ce langage universel. Non seulement il lui est homologue, mais il participe à son accomplissement. Quand l'homme profère un discours magique, sa parole lui donne prise sur la «parole de l'univers» qui constituent les phénomènes.⁶⁴

This letter magic is in turn the primary manifestation of the sanctified power—*walāya*—peculiar to perfected Sufis: "La sainteté, *walāya*, selon eux consiste avant tout en l'acquisition d'un

⁶³ Fahd, "Magie comme 'source de la sagesse,'" 61-62.

⁶⁴ Lory, *La science des lettres*, 95.

pouvoir, et la clé de ce pouvoir est l'accès aux sciences ésotériques et surtout à la principale d'entre elles, la science des lettres.”⁶⁵

As an investigation into the particularities of (Pseudo-)Būnī's lettrism is beyond the scope of the present study, I limit my focus here to the forged pedigrees given at the end of the *Shams al-Ma'ārif al-Kubrā* for the overview they provide of the broader lettrist tradition of the 7th-8th/13th-14th centuries, particularly as understood in western Sufi circles.⁶⁶ As mentioned, the *Shams al-Ma'ārif* is preserved in short (*ṣuḡhrā*), middle (*wuṣṭā*) and long (*kubrā*) recensions, although these are late, highly artificial and misleading categories; the massive and confused manuscript record suggests that the original core of the work, the *Shams al-Ma'ārif al-ṣuḡhrā*, is probably attributable to Būnī in some measure, but was hugely expanded upon by his disciples and later compilers over the course of two or more centuries, with what came to be known as the long recension only maturing by the 11th/17th.⁶⁷ (Jan Just Witkam has coined the term 'Corpus Būnianum' to indicate the uncertainty surrounding the origin of texts attributed to Būnī.⁶⁸) While Būnī's highly anachronistic pedigrees given in the epilogue to the printed editions of the *Shams al-Ma'ārif al-Kubrā* have only a slight presence in the manuscript record,⁶⁹ in their core they may derive from a *Fahrāsā* or education autobiography attributed to Būnī; they were, however, clearly subject to later editing and expansion in an effort to present Būnī as a conduit and synthesizer of the entire Islamic occult tradition, east and west, Sunni and Shi'i, with an emphasis on its Sufi and western form.⁷⁰ In particular, Noah Gardiner has shown

⁶⁵ Lory, *La science des lettres*, 104.

⁶⁶ Cf. the pedigrees given by 'Abd al-Raḥmān Biṣṭāmī, summarized in §4.3.4 below.

⁶⁷ Gardiner, "Forbidden Knowledge?" 17, 35.

⁶⁸ Witkam, "Gazing at the Sun," 183.

⁶⁹ See e.g. Süleymaniye MS Beşir Ağa 89, a copy of the *Shams al-Ma'ārif al-Kubrā* produced in 1057/1647 (Gardiner, "Forbidden Knowledge?" 36).

⁷⁰ Witkam, "Gazing at the Sun," 190.

that at least two of these *isnāds* were imported from the occultist writings of ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Biṣṭāmī (d. 858/1454), who set great store on Būnī’s works and named him prominently in his own pedigrees.⁷¹

For precisely this reason, it is worth reproducing Būnī’s purported pedigrees here not for the light they shed on Būnī’s own education, which is probably minimal, but rather for the fact that they represent an idealized and global picture of the 7th-8th/13th-14th century Sufi lettrist tradition from the perspective of the 9th/15th and later centuries. This range is suggested by the presence in these *isnāds* of such names as Muḥammad al-Kūmī al-Tūnisī (d. 810/1407), Musā‘id b. Sārī al-Hawārī (d. 819/1416), ‘Izz al-Dīn Muḥammad Ibn Jamā‘a al-Shāfi‘ī (d. 819/1416),⁷² Tāj al-Dīn ‘Aṭā’ al-Mālikī al-Shādhilī (d. 709/1309), Shihāb al-Dīn al-Maqdisī (d. 697/1298), and Ibn ‘Arabī (d. 635/1240). The Būnī pedigrees are thoroughgoingly Sufi, and feature many of the standard authorities, early and later, such as Ma‘rūf Karkhī (d. 200/816), Sarī Saqaṭī (d. 253/867), and Junayd (d. 297/910) on the one hand and Abū Najīb Suhrawardī (d. 563/1168) and Abū Madyan (d. 594/1197) on the other. Important names are missing, to be sure, such as Sa‘d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī or Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī, and many of the names given are otherwise unknown or too badly corrupted in the different copies and hence not of particular use. Nevertheless, the image these pedigrees present of (Pseudo-)Būnī as a nexus of Sufi occultist thought with an emphasis on the North African and Maghribi-Andalusi tradition and

⁷¹ Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 36-39; these *isnāds* are A (*kalimat al-shahāda*, to Muḥammad via ‘Alī) and C (*‘ilm al-ḥurūf*, to al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī) in the list below. Gardiner further remarks in the same section: “Even some of the language al-Biṣṭāmī uses to open the presentation of his *asānīd* is reproduced in *Shams al-ma‘ārif al-kubrā*, and the language used within the *isnād* regarding modes of transmission is also identical ... I would propose that al-Biṣṭāmī’s writings were likely the source of other parts of the text beyond these two chains. Even at a glance, the talismans in *Shams al-ma‘ārif al-kubrā* ... are far more similar to the talismans in al-Biṣṭāmī’s *Shams al-āfāq fī ‘ilm al-ḥurūf wa-al-awfāq* and other of his works than to any of those in the medieval Būnian corpus.”

⁷² ‘Abd al-Raḥmān Biṣṭāmī regarded ‘Izz al-Dīn Muḥammad as an authorized transmitter of Būnī’s works (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 29); see §4.3.4 below.

boasting a firm connection to Ibn ‘Arabī does not fundamentally misrepresent the man in his later reception as the most referenced occultist in the Islamic tradition.

Būnī’s *isnāds* are given for four categories of knowledge: *shahāda*, *‘ilm al-bāṭin*, *ḥurūf*, *awfāq*. Witkam, who devoted most of a recent article on the *Shams al-Ma‘ārif* to these pedigrees,⁷³ reconstructs them on the basis of the various printed editions; Gardiner supplements Witkam’s treatment with data from his broad survey of the manuscript tradition. With reference to these two studies, then, the *isnāds* may be given in standardized and abbreviated form as follows:⁷⁴

A. Pedigree for *kalimat al-shahāda*, to Muḥammad via ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib (from Biṣṭāmī)⁷⁵

1. Abū ‘Abd Allāh Muḥammad al-Kūmī [al-Fakūnī] al-Tūnisī al-Mālikī (d. 810/1407)
2. Shaykh Māḍī al-‘Azā’im⁷⁶
3. Abū ‘Abd Allāh Muḥammad b. Abī l-Ḥasan ‘Alī b. Hirzhum [Ḥarām]⁷⁷
4. Abū Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ b. ‘Aqbān al-Wākilī al-Mālikī⁷⁸
5. Abū Madyan Shu‘ayb b. Ḥasan al-Andalusī al-Ishbīlī (d. 594/1198)⁷⁹
6. Abū Shu‘ayb Ayyūb b. Sa‘īd al-Ṣunḥājī
7. Abū Ya‘zā [Ya‘izz] al-Ma‘arrī [al-Maghribī]⁸⁰

⁷³ Witkam, “Gazing at the Sun”; the *isnāds* are reconstructed on pp. 190-97. See also Francis, “Islamic Symbols,” 101-12.

⁷⁴ *Shams al-Ma‘ārif al-Kubrā*, 530-32. In the lists below I largely omit honorifics and reorder *isnāds* where necessary to show chronological regression to an original source. Dates of death are supplied where known. Following Gardiner I note the two *isnāds* taken from Biṣṭāmī.

⁷⁵ Gardiner identifies this pedigree as an expanded version of that given by Biṣṭāmī in his *Shams al-Āfāq* and other works (“Forbidden Knowledge?” 36-37); see §4.3.4.A.1 below.

⁷⁶ Cf. an abridged copy of Biṣṭāmī’s *Rashḥ Adhwāq al-Ḥikma*, MS Carullah 1543/1 ff. 5b-6a, which gives ‘Abū l-‘Azā’im Māḍī b. Sulṭān’ (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 37). MS Beşir Ağa 89 f. 213a-b and Biṣṭāmī’s *Shams al-Āfāq* adds here the names Abū l-‘Abbās al-Dahhān/Dahhānī and Abū l-‘Abbās al-Khārimī/al-Jārimī (see §4.3.4.A.1). MS Beşir Ağa 89 f. 213a-b appears to have the *nisba* ‘al-Khāfi’ for the latter, while MS Carullah 1543/1 ff. 5b-6a, representing an abridged copy of Biṣṭāmī’s *Rashḥ Adhwāq al-Ḥikma* featuring a briefer version of the same *isnād*, appears to have ‘al-Jāfi’ (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 37).

⁷⁷ MS Beşir Ağa 89 f. 213a-b has Abū ‘Abd Allāh Muḥammad b. Abī l-Ḥasan ‘Alī b. Khawārazm (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 37).

⁷⁸ MS Beşir Ağa 89 f. 213a-b has Abū Muḥammad Ṣāliḥ b. Bayḍā’ (?) b. ? al-Dakkānī al-Mālikī (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 37).

⁷⁹ See ‘Abd al-Wahhāb al-Sha‘rānī, *Lawāqih al-Anwār fī Ṭabaqāt al-Akhyār*, 1/154-56, no. 275.

⁸⁰ For nos. 6 and 7 MS Beşir Ağa 89 f. 213a-b has Abū Ya‘zā al-Hashkūrī (?) and Shu‘ayb Ayyūb b. Sa‘īd al-Ṣunḥājī, i.e., in reverse order (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 37). See Sha‘rānī, *Lawāqih*, 1/136-37, no. 257.

8. Abū Muḥammad b. Maṣṣūr⁸¹
9. Abū Muḥammad ‘Abd al-Jalīl b. Maḥlān
10. Abū l-Faḍl ‘Abd Allāh b. Abī Bishr, son of
11. Mūsā al-Kāẓim, son of
12. Ja‘far al-Ṣādiq, son of
13. Muḥammad al-Bāqir, son of
14. Zayn al-‘Ābidīn, son of
15. al-Ḥusayn, son of
16. ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib
17. Muḥammad

B. Pedigree for *‘ilm al-bāṭin*

1. Ja‘far al-Ṣādiq
2. Qāsim b. Muḥammad b. Abū Bakr al-Ṣiddīq
3. Muḥammad

C. Pedigree for *‘ilm al-ḥurūf*, to al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī (from Biṣṭāmī)⁸²

1. Abū ‘Abd Allāh Shams al-Dīn al-Iṣfahānī (616-88/1219-89),⁸³ Būnī’s teacher
2. Jalāl al-Dīn ‘Abd Allāh al-Biṣṭāmī (d. 452/1060)⁸⁴
3. [Qiwām al-Dīn Muḥammad al-Biṣṭāmī]⁸⁵
4. al-Shaykh al-Sīrjānī [al-Sīrḥā]
5. Qāsim al-Sarjānī [al-Sīrḥānī/al-Sīrjānī]⁸⁶
6. ‘Abd Allāh al-Balyānī (d. 683/1287)⁸⁷
7. Aṣīl al-Dīn al-Shīrāzī (d. 618/1221)
8. [Muḥammad al-Suhrawardī]⁸⁸

⁸¹ MS Beṣīr Aḡa 89 f. 213a-b has Ibn Muḥammad Tubūr (?) (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 37).

⁸² Gardiner identifies shows this pedigree to be almost identical to that given in a copy of Biṣṭāmī’s *al-Ujāla fī Ḥall al-Anmāt al-Mu‘arrafa bi-Jam‘ Abī al-‘Abbās Aḥmad*, Süleymaniye MS Baḡdatlı Vehbi 930 ff. 6b-7a (836/1433) (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 36-37).

⁸³ I.e., the prominent Isfahani judge in Egypt.

⁸⁴ Author of *al-Iḥsān fī Faḍīlat A‘lām Sha‘b al-Īmān*, *al-I‘lām fī Ru‘yat al-Nabī ‘alay-hi l-Salām fī l-Manām* (Kaḥḥāla, *Mu‘jam al-Mu‘allifīn*, 6/130). His name is given as “Alā’ al-Dīn al-Biṣṭāmī” in one of the earliest dated copies of the *Shams al-Ma‘ārif al-Kubrā*, MS Beṣīr Aḡa 89 f. 213b, and in Biṣṭāmī’s *al-Ujāla*, Süleymaniye MS Baḡdatlı Vehbi 930 ff. 6b-7a (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 37).

⁸⁵ This individual is added in both MS Beṣīr Aḡa f. 213b and Biṣṭāmī’s *al-Ujāla*, Süleymaniye MS Baḡdatlı Vehbi 930 ff. 6b-7a (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 37).

⁸⁶ Or ‘Qāsim al-Shīrāzī’ in Biṣṭāmī’s *al-Ujāla*, Süleymaniye MS Baḡdatlı Vehbi 930 ff. 6b-7a.

⁸⁷ Witkam gives ‘al-Bayānī.’

⁸⁸ Added on the basis of MS Beṣīr Aḡa f. 213b; the corresponding place in Biṣṭāmī’s *al-Ujāla*, Süleymaniye MS Baḡdatlı Vehbi 930 ff. 6b-7a, has two names in its stead: Rukn al-Dīn al-Sajāsī (?) and Quṭb al-Dīn al-

9. Abū al-Najīb al-Suhrawardī (d. 563/1168)
10. Abū l-Ḥasan Muḥammad al-Ghazālī, Būnī's teacher⁸⁹
11. Aḥmad al-Aswad (4th-5th/10th-11th c.)⁹⁰
12. Ḥammād al-Dīnawarī (d. 299/912)⁹¹
13. al-Junayd al-Baghdādī (d. 298/910)
14. Sarī al-Dīn al-Saqaṭī (d. 253/867)
15. Ma'rūf al-Karkhī (d. 200/816)
16. Dāwūd al-Jabalī [al-Jīlī]⁹²
17. Ḥabīb al-'Ajamī (d. ca. 140/757)
18. al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī (d. 110/728).⁹³

D. Pedigrees in 'ilm al-awfāq, to Ibn 'Arabī and Abū Madyan

1. Sirāj al-Dīn al-Ḥanafī
2. Shihāb al-Dīn al-Maqdisī (b. Nablus 628/1231, d. Damascus 697/1298),⁹⁴
3. Shams al-Dīn al-Fārisī
4. Shihāb al-Dīn al-Hamadānī
5. Quṭb al-Dīn al-Ḍiyā'ī
6. Muḥyī l-Dīn Ibn al-'Arabī (d. 638/1240)
7. Abū l-'Abbās Aḥmad b. al-Nawrīzī [al-Tūrīzī],⁹⁵
8. Abū 'Abd Allāh al-Qurashī (d. 599/1203)⁹⁶

Abḥārī (Gardiner, "Forbidden Knowledge?" 36).

⁸⁹ Both MS Beṣir Aḡa f. 213b and Bisṭāmī's *al-'Ujāla*, Süleymaniye MS Bağdatlı Vehbi 930 ff. 6b-7a, have Aḥmad al-Ghazālī here. It should be noted that Abū Ḥamid Muḥammad Ghazālī, and perhaps his brother Aḥmad by extension, was considered a leading authority on various occult sciences by at least the early 10th/16th century; see §§4.3.4 and 4.4.4 below.

⁹⁰ A disciple of 'Isā al-Qaṣṣār, said to have lived a full century; see Dhahabī, *Ta'rīkh al-Islām*, 30/198. This figure is not present in the pedigree in MS Beṣir Aḡa f. 213b, but is present in that given in Bisṭāmī's *al-'Ujāla*, Süleymaniye MS Bağdatlı Vehbi 930 ff. 6b-7a. The latter also adds here the name 'Akhī Faraj al-Zanjānī.'

⁹¹ I.e., Mimshādh al-Dīnawarī, a leading disciple of 'Isā al-Qaṣṣār (the correct form of his name is given in both MS Beṣir Aḡa f. 213b and Bisṭāmī's *al-'Ujāla*, Süleymaniye MS Bağdatlı Vehbi 930 ff. 6b-7a); see Dhahabī, *Ta'rīkh al-Islām*, 30/198.

⁹² The form 'Dāwūd al-Ṭā'ī' is given in both MS Beṣir Aḡa f. 213b and Bisṭāmī's *al-'Ujāla*, Süleymaniye MS Bağdatlı Vehbi 930 ff. 6b-7a.

⁹³ Bisṭāmī's *al-'Ujāla*, Süleymaniye MS Bağdatlı Vehbi 930 ff. 6b-7a, adds "Alī b. Abī Ṭālib" here. Cf. the lineage of Sufis Kāshifī gives in his *Futuvvat-nāma-yi Sulṭānī* (124): 'Alā' al-Dawla Simnānī, Najm al-Dīn Kubrā, Abū Najīb Suhrawardī, Muḥammad Aswad, Mimshādh Dīnawarī, Junayd, Ma'rūf Karkhī, 'Alī al-Riḍā, Mūsā al-Kāẓim, Ḥusayn, 'Alī, and Muḥammad.

⁹⁴ A famed dream interpreter; see Dhahabī, *Ta'rīkh al-Islām*, 52/316-17; Ṣafadī, *al-Wāfi bi-l-Wafayāt*, 7/32.

⁹⁵ Not the Abū l-'Abbās al-Faḍl b. Ḥātim al-Nayrīzī (fl. 299/912), a famous astronomer mentioned by Ibn Nadīm.

⁹⁶ See Sha'rānī, *Lawāqih*, 1/159-60, no. 281.

9. Abū Madyan al-Andalusī (d. 594/1197)

1. ‘Izz al-Dīn Muḥammad b. Jamā‘a al-Shāfi‘ī (d. 819/1416)
2. Muḥammad b. Sīrīn⁹⁷
3. Shihāb al-Dīn al-Hamadānī
4. Quṭb al-Dīn al-Ḍiyā‘ī
5. Muḥyī l-Dīn Ibn al-‘Arabī (d. 638/1240)

1. Abū ‘Abd Allāh Muḥammad b. ‘Alī

E. Pedigrees in *‘ilm al-ḥurūf wa-l-wafq*, to Muḥammad

1. Musā‘id b. Sārī b. Mas‘ūd b. ‘Abd Allāh b. Raḥma al-Hawārī al-Ḥimyarī al-Qurashī [al-Miṣrī al-Sakhāwī] (730-819/1330-1416)
2. Shihāb al-Dīn Aḥmad al-Shādhilī
3. Tāj al-Dīn ‘Aṭā’ al-Mālikī al-Shādhilī (d. 709/1309)
4. al-‘Abbās Aḥmad b. ‘Umar al-Anṣārī al-Mursī⁹⁸
1. Abū l-‘Abbās Aḥmad b. Maymūn al-Qaṣṭallānī
2. Abū ‘Abd Allāh Muḥammad b. Aḥmad al-Qurashī
3. Abū Madyan Shu‘ayb b. Ḥasan al-Anṣārī al-Andalusī
4. Dāwūd b. Maymūn al-Harmīrī [al-Harīrī/al-Hurayrī]
5. Abū Ayyūb b. Abī Sa‘īd al-Ṣunhājī al-Azammūrī [al-Armūzī]
6. Abū Muḥammad b. Nūr
7. Abū l-Faḍl ‘Abd Allāh b. Bishr, son of
8. Abū Bishr al-Ḥasan al-Jawjarī
9. Sarī al-Dīn al-Saqatī (d. 253/867)
10. Dāwūd al-Ṭā‘ī (d. 165/782)
11. Ḥabīb al-‘Ajamī
12. Abū Bakr Muḥammad b. Sīrīn (d. 110/728)
13. Anas b. Mālik (d. 91/709)
14. Muḥammad

F. Būnī’s shaykhs

1. Abū l-Ḥasan Muḥammad b. Muḥammad al-Ghazālī (cf. C8 above)⁹⁹
2. Abū l-Ḥasan ‘Alī b. Muḥammad b. Ibrāhīm al-Ḥarrālī [al-Ḥarrānī] (d. 637/1240)¹⁰⁰

⁹⁷ See Sha‘rānī, *Lawāqih*, 1/36, no. 49.

⁹⁸ See Sha‘rānī, *Lawāqih*, 2/12-20, no. 310.

⁹⁹ Būnī is here referred to in the third person as Aḥmad b. Yūsuf al-Qurashī.

¹⁰⁰ The text notes that this shaykh died in Hama in 538/1144 and wrote *K. al-Lum‘a*, *K. Shams Maṭālī‘ al-Qulūb* and other occultist works (532). I correct the text’s al-Ḥarrānī to al-Ḥarrālī, i.e., Abū l-Ḥasan al-Ḥarrālī, son of a Jewish convert to Islam and a great occultist; like Ibn ‘Arabī, he immigrated to Syria from the Maghreb in the face of Almohad persecution. The date of death given for him here is obviously corrupt.

3. Abū ‘Abd Allāh al-Qurashī¹⁰¹ (cf. E2² above)

G. A dream *isnād*, via Ibn Sīnā to Muḥammad

1. ‘Alī b. Sīnā (d. 428/1037)
2. Muḥammad al-Dawrakī [al-Dawūkī]
3. Muḥammad al-Jazarī [al-Jararī]
4. ‘Izz al-Dīn Muḥammad ‘Abd Allāh Muḥammad b. Mūsā b. Sulaymān al-Anṣārī
5. Abū l-Ḥasan ‘Alī b. Aḥmad b. ‘Abd al-Wāḥid al-Qudsī
6. Muḥammad b. ‘Abd Allāh b. Ibrāhīm b. Mūsā
7. Muslim b. Ibrāhīm b. ‘Abd Allāh al-Makkī
8. Ḥumayd al-Ṭawīl
9. Anas b. Mālīk (d. 91/709), Companion and scribe of
10. Muḥammad

4.1.2.2: Muḥyī l-Dīn Ibn ‘Arabī and letter theory

Complementing the applied lettrism of Būnī, theoretical lettrism in its Sufi form achieved its definitive formulation in the work of Ibn ‘Arabī (d. 635/1240), and most particularly in the long second chapter devoted to it in his *magnum opus*, *al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya*.¹⁰² In his study and translation of extracts from this chapter, Denis Gril concludes that it may in fact be considered the key to the *Futūḥāt* as a whole.¹⁰³ Ibn ‘Arabī’s unsystematic but wide-ranging treatment of the science is often similar to that of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’; apart from shared content, they both extend letter symbolism to cover such fields as physics, numerology and the revolution of celestial spheres and temporal cycles, and both advance it as a means of spiritual activation.¹⁰⁴

¹⁰¹ Here described as being *min a’yān mashāyikh al-gharb wa-l-Miṣr*.

¹⁰² Ibn ‘Arabī wrote a number of separate treatises on various aspects of the letters; the bulk of these may be assumed to have been incorporated into the *Futūḥāt*. See e.g. *al-Mabādī’ wa-l-Gḥāyāt fī Ma’ānī l-Ḥurūf wa-l-Āyāt* and *al-‘Iqd al-Manẓūm fī-mā Taḥtawī l-Ḥurūf min al-Khawāṣṣ wa-l-‘Ulūm*, ed. Sa’īd ‘Abd al-Fattāḥ, Beirut, 2006; and the brief list he gives in the R. *al-Mīm wa-l-Wāw wa-l-Nūn* (83-84). Sara Sviri notes that Chapter 198, “Concerning the Knowledge of Breath (*nafas*),” likewise constitutes “a comprehensive and systematic discussion on language and its creative power” (“*Kun*—the Existence-Bestowing Word,” 50).

¹⁰³ Gril, “Science,” 107. Given Gril’s excellent treatment of this difficult chapter, I will not venture here beyond a brief summary of its most salient features and sources.

¹⁰⁴ Gril, “Science,” 119.

Sahl Tustarī and Ibn Masarra are the authorities most frequently quoted by name in this chapter. In Ibn ‘Arabī’s formulation, “the meanings carried by letters encompass absolute Existence in its totality: God and the universe ... It is through the letter that both what is Written is drawn out, and the Law is fulfilled.”¹⁰⁵ The divisions and degrees of the 28 letters of the alphabet (equal to the number of lunar mansions) are, like the waystations of the mystic wayfarer (*sālik*), infinite, being as they are perpetually generated by the rotations of the concentric spheres. The science of letters is here indistinguishable from metaphysics and cosmology, and functions as initiator on the mystical path.¹⁰⁶ In particular, knowledge of the isolated sura-initial letters constitutes the fulfillment of faith and key to the divine names, the fount of all creation. Only 14 in number, they nevertheless begin a great many Names; in this sense they function like phonemes common to a multiplicity of languages. Gril summarizes: “The science of letters might thus be defined as a metalinguistics and a metaphysics announcing the principles of the production of both language and the physical world.”¹⁰⁷

In these discussions Ibn ‘Arabī is largely building on, synthesizing and expanding the work of his predecessors—Tustarī, Ḥallāj, Jābir b. Ḥayyān and the Ikhwān, among others. He further aggrandizes the science, however, in his extension of the quranic text to encompass everything composed of letters, every thing in fact. “The letters thus become the hermeneutical principle not only of the Qur’ān but of all reality”¹⁰⁸

Nevertheless, it must be noted that Ibn ‘Arabī is for the most part intentionally unsystematic in his discussions of lettrism, often scattering them in his works seemingly at

¹⁰⁵ Gril, “Science,” 108.

¹⁰⁶ Gril, “Science,” 112-13.

¹⁰⁷ Gril, “Science,” 125-26.

¹⁰⁸ Gril, “Science,” 146-47.

random in an attempt to put off the unworthy;¹⁰⁹ and even in the comprehensive second and one hundred ninety-eighth chapters of the *Futūḥāt* he eschews discussion of the more practical aspects of lettrism (while firmly establishing, of course, their theoretical basis). Unlike Būnī, who champions letter magic as a quintessentially Sufi science offering incontrovertible proof of mystical doctrine, Ibn ‘Arabī judges applied lettrism too potent a subject to risk speaking of openly.¹¹⁰ He explains the reasons for his circumspection in his *R. al-Mīm wa-l-Wāw wa-l-Nūn*:

I speak here, in the manner of Ibn Masarra al-Jabalī and his like, of the secrets (*asrār*) of the letters, rather than of their active properties (*khawāṣṣ*); for to speak of the active properties of things is usually to expose oneself to accusations and denunciations ... Denunciations are provoked in this wise: It is incumbent upon those who attempt such things [i.e., letter magic] that they have [exact] knowledge of the [desired] compound (*tarkīb*) together with its forms, times, scripts (*aqlām*), and so forth; if even the slightest aspect is off the whole operation will come to nothing, upon which the [incompetent] operator will blame the operation itself, saying: I tried what he said and nothing happened. For this reason it is preferable that those on our Path maintain total silence with respect to [such] applied sciences (*al-‘ulūm al-‘amaliyya*)—indeed, it is strictly forbidden (*ḥarām*) them to expatiate upon [these sciences] in a manner comprehensible to both the initiated and the uninitiated (*al-khāṣṣ wa-l-‘āmm*), for this would allow corrupt persons, despite their unworthiness, to use [such sciences] to their personal advantage. At most, therefore, I have but alluded to them in my books for the benefit of my companions, as I am confident that none but they will understand what I allude to, with all others uncomprehending; nor am I concerned that I may be denounced, for, praise God, my religion is sound.¹¹¹

In sum, it appears that from the late 7th/13th century onward Būnī and Ibn ‘Arabī, both firmly within the Sufi tradition, were taken as representing the two dominant approaches to the science of letters. Būnī came to stand for the primarily practical approach focused on harnessing and manipulating the properties (*khawāṣṣ*) of the letters for material and/or

¹⁰⁹ Sviri, “*Kun*—the Existence-Bestowing Word,” 49-50. This approach embodies the principle of *tabdīd al-‘ilm* or ‘the dispersion of knowledge,’ standard in esotericist writings, whereby “truth was never to be revealed completely at one place,” but rather scattered throughout a corpus “like so many pieces of a jigsaw puzzle” (Haq, *Names, Natures, and Things*, 6; see Gril, “The Science of Letters,” 143; Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 13).

¹¹⁰ Nor does Ibn ‘Arabī use *jafr* openly, except once at the end of his early Maghribine work ‘*Anqā’ Mughrib* for the purpose of prognosticating the arrival of the Mahdi (trans. in Elmore, *Islamic Sainthood*, 531-32).

¹¹¹ “*R. al-Mīm wa-l-Wāw wa-l-Nūn*,” 87.

spiritual ends, by far the more popular trend in the Islamicate world from the medieval to modern periods; Ibn ‘Arabī came to stand for the primarily theoretical approach focused on the letters’ *ḥaqā’iq*, or essential realities, as a means of analyzing all levels of existence. As we saw in Chapter 3, Ṣā’ib al-Dīn explicitly identifies himself with the more rarified approach of Ibn ‘Arabī, though he is thoroughly familiar with the active properties of the letters.¹¹² Indeed, his lettrist treatises take a Būnī/Ibn ‘Arabī dichotomy for granted.

4.1.2.3: Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī

Together with Ibn ‘Arabī, Ṣā’ib al-Dīn specifically identifies his second primary textual source for theoretical lettrism as being Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī (d. 649/1252), and his *K. al-Maḥbūb* in particular. Sa’d al-Dīn’s preoccupation with esoterica and lettrism (both theoretical and applied) is on full display in his Arabic works *K. al-Maḥbūb*¹¹³ and *K. Baḥr al-Ma’ānī*,¹¹⁴ as well as in a number of minor Persian and Arabic treatises on the science of letters: *R. dar Bayān-i Khavāṣṣ-i Sūra-yi Yā-Sīn*,¹¹⁵ *R. Ḥaqā’iq al-Ḥurūf*,¹¹⁶ *R. fī ‘Ilm al-Ḥurūf*,¹¹⁷ *R. fī Ma’nā Ḥurūf al-Hijā’*,¹¹⁸ *K. al-Nuḡṭa*,¹¹⁹

¹¹² In the *R. Su’l al-Mulūk*, for example, he treats both practical and theoretical aspects in equal measure; see Part 2, §T.4 below.

¹¹³ This important work survives in the following MSS: MS Topkapı A1418 ff. 3a-288a (Rajab 718/September 1318); MS Ayasofya 2058 ff. 1b-205b (Cairo, Muḥarram 736/August 1335); MS Fatih 2785, 213 ff. (Cairo, 701/February 1302; vol. 2 only); MS Ayasofya 2057 ff. 1a-209b; MS Nuruosmaniye 2577; MS Yeni Camii 726, 253 ff.; MS Şehit Ali Paşa 1342/1 ff. 1-139; MS Königlich Bibliothek 4084, Berlin (12 Dhū l-Ḥijja 643/30 April 1246); MS Carullah Efendi 1078; MS Carullah Efendi 1096; and MS Orhan Gazi 77, Bursa (Elias, “Sufi Lords,” 63). Other MSS include: Microfilm 1170, Markaz-i Iḥyā’-i Mīrās-i Islāmī, 618 pp. (7th/13th c.); MS Dānīshgāh 3253 (7th-8th/13th-14th c.); MS Majlis 3253 (34S), 698pp. (7th-8th/13th-14th c.); MS Manisa 1224 (727/1326); MS Orhan Camii 638, Bursa (753/1351); and MS Sāzmān-i Lughat-nāma-yi Dihkhudā 52 (9th-10th/15-16th c.).

¹¹⁴ This work survives in MS Fazıl Ahmed Paşa 706/1 ff. 1b-92a, Köprülü Library (733 (933)/1332-33 (1524-25)). Elias characterizes it as an esoteric treatise dealing with “visionary experiences which Sa’d al-Dīn underwent at age 40” (“Sufi Lords,” 61).

¹¹⁵ MS Esad Efendi 3790/13 ff. 41b-42a (999/1590-91); MS Majlis 9466/46 pp. 92-93; MS Majlis 14374 ff. 55b-57b (Elias, “Sufi Lords,” 61).

¹¹⁶ MS Pertev Paşa 606/2 ff. 12-17 (1064/1654) (Elias, “Sufi Lords,” 62).

R. Sajanj al-Arwāḥ wa-Nuqūsh al-Alwāḥ,¹²⁰ *Sharḥ-i Basmala-yi Sharīf*,¹²¹ as well as other untitled treatises. Even Sa'd al-Dīn's more general works on Sufism evince a strong interest in the science of letters, as for example his *K. al-Miṣbāḥ fī l-Taṣawwuf*,¹²² a number of whose sections, including the first three, are concerned to show the primacy of lettrist speculations with respect to Sufi doctrine.¹²³

An analysis of the dense *K. al-Maḥbūb*, which still languishes in manuscript form due not least to the widespread belief in the intellectual and cultural irrelevance of this science, is unfortunately beyond the scope of the present study. This book is, however, often referenced in Ṣā'in al-Dīn's own lettrist *summa*, the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*; some attention will accordingly be devoted in Chapter 7 to the question of Sa'd al-Dīn's role as one of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's primary sources. For the purposes of the present section, I translate Sa'd al-Dīn's very brief treatise on the properties of sura Yā-Sīn (Q 36)¹²⁴ to provide a taste of the author's lettrist concerns.¹²⁵ In particular, note Sa'd al-Dīn's assertion of the necessity of veiling such powerful knowledge as is contained in the science of letters in allusions and riddles lest the masses learn of it and occasion the breakdown of society through the indiscriminate and unbridled use of magic:

¹¹⁷ MS Şehit Ali Paşa 1342/18 ff. 263b-66b (10 Jumādā II 838/11 January 1435) (Elias, "Sufi Lords," 62).

¹¹⁸ MS Ayasofya 4795, 117 ff. (Elias, "Sufi Lords," 63).

¹¹⁹ MS Şehit Ali Paşa 1364/4 ff. 76b-77a (Elias, "Sufi Lords," 63).

¹²⁰ MS Fatih 2645 ff. 1b-86a (Jumādā I 656 (659)/May 1258 (April 1261)); MS Carullah Efendi 1541; MS Āstān-i Quds (?) (see *Āstān-i Quds*, 8/29) (Elias, "Sufi Lords," 64). An excerpt is preserved in MS Majlis 14374 ff. 4b-5b.

¹²¹ MS Çorlulu Ali Paşa 445/1 ff. 1-13 (Elias, "Sufi Lords," 64).

¹²² Ed. N. M. Haravī, Tehran, 1362 Sh./1983.

¹²³ Of Sa'd al-Dīn writings only the *K. al-Miṣbāḥ* has been published; for a preliminary list of his works that survive in manuscript, see Elias, "Sufi Lords," 61-66.

¹²⁴ Various entitled *Sharḥ-i Sūra-yi Karīma-yi Yā-Sīn*, *R. dar Bayān-i Khavāṣṣ-i Sūra-yi Yā-Sīn*, etc.

¹²⁵ These concerns, it may be observed, are distinctly more imamophilic than the western lettrist tradition.

In the name of God, the merciful, the compassionate. Praise be to God, Lord of the worlds, and blessings be upon His Messenger Muḥammad and all his house.

To proceed: In what follows are a few points relating to the recitation of the holy sura Yā-Sīn and certain of its properties, here written down, after asking leave of the spirits of the Imams, our guides (peace be upon them) who expounded the science of *jafr*,¹²⁶ by the humble servant Sa'd al-Dīn Muḥammad Ḥamuvayī in hopes that it will help travelers on the divine path to reach their goal—God is the Helper and Succorer.

Know that the sura Yā-Sīn has many special properties indeed. The holy Messenger (God bless and keep him and his house) called it the very heart (*qalb*) of the Quran,¹²⁷ and most scholars of *jafr* take the view that it contains the supreme name of God (*ism-i a'zam*). It is related that whoever recites this sura after the dawn prayer while observing all necessary conditions will have 70 years' worth of minor sins (*gunāh-i ṣaghīra*) forgiven him,¹²⁸ and he will not die on that day; if he does die, he failed to recite it properly. These are the conditions: one must face the *qibla* in a state of ritual purity, in a clean place and in clean clothes, and begin one's recitation in a state of total concentration.

Know that in this sura are three places in particular that bear highlighting; whoever when reciting brings to mind his purpose at these three places will achieve it. Scholars of this discipline have not written about these three places except allusively, for were they to publicize such secrets and people to learn of them, the latter would work astounding deeds (*kār-hā-yi 'aẓīm*). [I will therefore similarly allude to them as follows:]

1. The first may be alluded to as being located in the expression of two words the number of whose letters together equal the number of the gates of paradise [i.e., eight]. The first word has two letters, each of which is repeated after the other. The second word has four letters, none of which are repeated, although one of its letters is repeated in the first word, and its second letter is the second of the first letter of the first word in numerical value; its third letter is comparable (*bi-izā'*) to the first letter of the first word in the second register (*marātib-i sāniya*) of the numbers of gematria (*jummal*); and [the value of] its fourth letter is equivalent to the sum of the first and third letters. (But God knows best.)¹²⁹
2. The second may be alluded to as being located in three words the sum of whose letters equals the number of the gates of hell [i.e., seven]. The first and seventh letters are equivalent (*mutamāsil*), as are the second and sixth, as are the third and fifth. The fourth letter is the pivot (*markaz*) of the sum, and is a letter whose *bayyināt*¹³⁰ are equivalent (*muṭābiq*) to the letters of the Supreme Name, i.e., the

¹²⁶ A typical imamophilic expression; see §1.6.

¹²⁷ Tirmidhī, *Sunan*, *Kitāb Faḍā'il al-Qur'ān 'an Rasūl Allāh*, bab 7, no. 3129; Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal, *Musnad*, *musnad* 8, hadith 20, no. 20626.

¹²⁸ Cf. Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal, *Musnad*, *musnad* 8, hadith 20, no. 20626.

¹²⁹ A marginal comment in MS Majlis 14374 f. 56a identifies these two words as being from Q 36:12: *imām mubīn*.

¹³⁰ The *bayyināt* of a letter are what remains of the letter's name written out in full after the first letter has been subtracted; e.g., the *bayyināt* of the name Muḥammad (MḤMD): *mīm-ḥā'-mīm-dāl* → *īm-ā'-īm-āl* (YMA'YMAL) (Dihkhudā, *Lughatnāma*, s.v.).

name of the [divine] essence (*ism-i zāt*); it is [also] a letter which possesses the degree (*rutba*) of the Seal of Sainthood (*khātām-i valāyat*) and through which the circle of letters is completed, connecting the *bayyināt* of the last letters with the first [letter] (? *az bayyināt-i avākhir bi avval mīpayvandad*). This letter may also be indicated by stating that the operation (*amal*) it produces when combined with words is precisely the same whether [read normally or] inverted (*maqlūb*). (But God knows best.)¹³¹

3. The third may be alluded to as being located in five words the sum of all whose letters is equivalent to the sum of all the abovementioned gates [i.e., 15], with one remaining and unrepeated equivalent to the number of the letters in the Supreme Name mentioned above as well as the letters of the two words referred to in the first allusion according the order of the first and second words, but in these words occurring out of order. Furthermore, the number of dots in these words comprise all possible positions, half above and half below. It is clear that of the most beautiful names of God one appears at the beginning and two at the end, and in writing it out, all scholars agree, two names are contained therein—these being the Supreme Name; other names may be derived from them, such as *al-Mu'min* and *al-Ḥalīm*, and so forth according to this model.¹³²

[The practitioners] of this science have not disclosed nor permitted the disclosure of more than this. It is not possible to set out the above more clearly than I have here done, although it is still hardly explicit, and it was difficult for me to venture this far. My dear child, had your receptivity not been entire, I would not have written on the subject at all; you must therefore burnish your heart with the polish of sincerity until the nature of these secrets be reflected to you. (But God knows best.) Once you have identified the [three] places I've alluded to, you will attain the power to benefit or harm (within the bounds of the Shari'a) as you will, God willing.¹³³

This brief treatise is followed by further instructions on how to employ this and other suras in special prayers, including instructions on how to make an amulet (*ḥirz*) for protection against

¹³¹ The MS Majlis 14374 copy lacks a marginal comment identifying the relevant phrase here.

¹³² A marginal comment in MS Majlis 14374 f. 56b identifies these five words as being from Q 36:81: *balā wa-huwa l-khallāqu l-'alīm*.

¹³³ MS Majlis 14374 ff. 55b-57b. A defective copy of this treatise is preserved in MS Majlis 9466/46 pp. 92-93. Cf. Cornelius Agrippa's comments in his *De Occulta Philosophia* on the mechanics of the operations Ḥamuvayī describes: "Therefore sacred words have not their power in Magicall operations, from themselves, as they are words, but from the occult Divine powers working by them in the minds of those who by faith adhere to them; by which words the secret power of God as it were through Conduite pipes, is transmitted into them, who have ears purged by faith, and by most pure conversation and invocation of the divine names are made the habitation of God, and capable of these divine influences; whosoever therefore useth rightly these words or names of God with that purity of mind, in that manner and order, as they were delivered, shall both obtain and do many wonderfull things ..." (3/11, quoted in Miles, "Occult Retraction," 450).

ills and enemies called *Ḥirz Fātiḥat al-Kitāb fī taskhīr al-qulūb wa-taysīr al-maṭlūb*, which in this undated MS, Majlis 14374, is credited to Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī as transmitter.¹³⁴

Indeed, the general complex upon which Ṣā'in al-Dīn draws in formulating his lettrism is exemplified by the mix of lettrist treatises in this same collection, which includes the above treatise together with another partial treatise by Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī,¹³⁵ a multi-sectioned *R. dar Jafr* attributed to Akhlāṭī wherein Ibn 'Arabī figures as a primary authority,¹³⁶ and a short work attributed to Būnī consisting of ten sentences, each treating of a divine name and its properties.¹³⁷

4.1.3: Ibn Sīnā's philosophical lettrism

As noted in the foregoing, Sufi lettrism appears to have become the dominant form of the science in the 7th/13th century primarily through the efforts of Būnī, Ibn 'Arabī and Ḥamuvayī; it is important to note, however, that the gnostic-hermetic approach to lettrism as philosophized by the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' in particular persisted in non-Sufi, more generically intellectual forms. This fact is demonstrated by Ibn Sīnā's (d. 428/1037) brief but intriguing foray into lettrism as a natural support for cosmological speculation in his *R. al-Nayrūziyya fī Ma'ānī l-Ḥurūf al-Hijā'iyya*; given the philosopher's stature, the existence of this treatise indicates the degree to which the science of letters was emerging as a respectable scholarly discipline by the 5th/11th century.¹³⁸

¹³⁴ MS Majlis 14374 f. 57b-58b.

¹³⁵ The partial treatise represents an extract from Ḥamuvayī's *K. Sajanjāl al-Arvāḥ* (ff. 4b-5b).

¹³⁶ MS Majlis 14374 ff. 5b-20a. For other treatises on *jafr* by Akhlāṭī see e.g. MSS Majlis 12514, Majlis 12559, Majlis 12581, and Majlis 12597.

¹³⁷ MS Majlis 14374 ff. 60b-63b.

¹³⁸ Cf. Fārābī's *K. al-Ḥurūf*, which is purely grammatical in concern.

The treatise was written for one al-Shaykh al-Amīn Abū Bakr Muḥammad b. ‘Ubayd (or ‘Abd Allāh) and presented to him as a gift during Nawrūz, hence the name *al-Nayrūziyya*;¹³⁹ likewise the *R. al-Aḍḥawiyya*, which the philosopher also wrote for this individual and presented to him during ‘Īd al-Aḍḥā.¹⁴⁰ That the *R. al-Nayrūziyya* may be dismissed as apocryphal is suggested by Ibn Sīnā’s total lack of interest in matters letterist in the rest of his oeuvre. Nevertheless, the treatise is well-represented in the manuscript tradition from early on—Yaḥyā Mahdavi, for example, gives a partial list of 34 MSS,¹⁴¹ and at least 39 survive in Iran alone¹⁴²—, and as such may well be authentic.¹⁴³ In any event, its treatment of the subject represents a persuasive application of the Shaykh al-Ra’īs’s system to the mysterious isolated quranic letters. In the *R. al-Nayrūziyya* Ibn Sīnā/Pseudo-Ibn Sīnā deploys the numerological aspect of elementary letterist theory to support his conception of the stages of the generation of the cosmos, then extrapolates from the result to establish the philosophical meaning of the *muqatta‘āt*. Neither Sufi nor gnostic, semi-philosophical and semi-hermetic, Ibn Sīnā’s approach here may be loosely styled intellectual letterism—a term of convenience that will be applicable to Ṣā’ib al-Dīn’s project as well.¹⁴⁴ The intellectual continuity obtaining between the *R. al-Nayrūziyya* on the one hand and Ibn Turka’s letterist thought on the other, separated though they are by some four centuries, may be seen in the fact that one of the manuscripts

¹³⁹ Alternate titles include *Fawātiḥ al-Suwar*, *Asrār al-Ḥurūf*, *R. fī l-Ḥurūf al-Hijā’iyya li-Fawātiḥ ‘Iddat Suwar min al-Suwar al-Qur’āniyya*.

¹⁴⁰ Mahdavi, *Fihrist-i Nuskha-hā*, no. 127.

¹⁴¹ Yaḥyā Mahdavi, *Fihrist-i Nuskha-hā-yi Muṣannafāt-i Ibn-i Sīnā*, Tehran, 1333 Sh./1954, no. 127.

¹⁴² AB.

¹⁴³ Lory, *La science des lettres*, 87-88.

¹⁴⁴ Cf. Ṣā’ib al-Dīn’s cosmological concerns in the *Mafāḥiṣ*.

that preserves Ibn Sīnā’s treatise, MS Majlis 10319, also contains three of Šā’in al-Dīn’s letterist works, including the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, *R. Ḥurūf*, and *R. al-Inzālīyya*.¹⁴⁵

The *R. al-Nayrūziyya* is divided into three sections: section one provides a summary of Ibn Sīnā’s cosmogonical system; section two establishes the numerological correspondences of the *muqatta‘āt*; and section three applies the result in a full list of the philosophical meanings of each lettergroup. I summarize sections two and three below:¹⁴⁶

In section two, the philosopher first associates the single digits as represented by their letters in the *abjad* order as follows:

The first principles (represented by the units):

	In itself (<i>bi-mā hiya dhawāt</i>)	Qualified by that below it (<i>bi-mā hiya muḍāfa li-mā dūna-hā</i>)
God (<i>al-bāri‘</i>) Intellect (<i>al-‘aql</i>) Soul (<i>al-nafs</i>) Nature (<i>al-ṭabī‘a</i>)	A = 1 B = 2 J = 3 D = 4	H = 5 W = 6 Z = 7 Ḥ = 8
Prime matter (<i>al-hayūlā</i>)	Ṭ = 9 (does not interact with any other principle)	

¹⁴⁵ See §2.1.1 above.

¹⁴⁶ The *R. al-Nayrūziyya* was printed Ḥasan ‘Āṣī, *Tis‘ Rasā’il fī l-Hikma wa-l-Ṭabī‘iyyāt*, 92-97; as it is unreliable, I emend certain readings on the basis of MS Feyzullah Efendi 1213/6 ff. 107a-8b. The treatise has been variously summarized in Gril, “The Science of Letters,” 134-35; Lory, *La science des lettres*, 78-81; Nasr, *Islamic Cosmological Doctrines*, 209-14; as none of these summaries include a full translation of the third section, however, I provide one here.

The second principles as derived from the first and the products of their combination, encompassing the descent from the origin and return thereto (represented by the products of multiplication of the units and the addition of these products):

Atemporal creation (<i>ibdā'</i>) ¹⁴⁷	$Y (10) = B (2) \times H (5)$
Command (<i>amr</i>)	$L (30) = H (5) \times W (6)$
Temporal creation (<i>khalq</i>)	$M (40) = H (5) \times \bar{H} (8)$
Generation (<i>takwīn</i>)	$K (20) = H (5) \times D (4)$
Command + temporal creation	$LM = ' (70)$
Temporal creation + generation	$MK = S (60)$
Atemporal + temporal creation ('the two letters of existence')	$YM = N (50)$
Command + temporal creation + generation	$LMK = \S (90)$
The inclusion of all in atemporal creation	$Y \times Y = Q (100) = \S (90) + Y (10)$
The return of all to the first (<i>al-awwal</i>)	$Q \times 2 = R (200)$

Applying the foregoing scheme in section three, Ibn Sīnā's interprets the *muqatta'āt* as God's swearing by the various elements and phases in His creation of the cosmos as follows:

- **ALM** (Q 2, 3, 29, 30, 31, 32): The First (A), source of the creative command (L) and temporal creation (M).
- **ALMR** (Q 13): The First (A), source of the creative command (L) and temporal creation (M), and as First and Last simultaneously the origin and point of return of all things (R).
- **ALMŞ** (Q 7): The First (A), source of the creative command (L) and temporal creation (M), and producer (*munshi'*) of all [through the intermediation of the command, temporal creation and generation (Ş)].
- **Ş** (Q 28): Universal providence (*al-'ināya al-kullīyya*) [as constituted by the command, temporal creation and generation (Ş)].
- **Q** (Q 50): Atemporal creation as inclusive of the whole with the intermediation of the Intellect (Q).

¹⁴⁷ The terms *ibdā'*, *khalq* and *takwīn* as used by Ibn Sīnā may be defined as follows: "In connection with the production of things Ibn Sīnā uses four main terms. First, '*ihdāth*', which is the wider term and denotes producing temporal or non-temporal things. Second, '*ibdā'*', which is used for producing eternal and incorruptible things without an intermediary. Third, '*khalq*', which is used for the producing with or without intermediary of corporeal beings whether they are corruptible or not. Lastly, '*takwīn*', which is used for the producing with intermediary of corruptible beings" (Muammer İskenderoğlu, *Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī and Thomas Aquinas on the Question of the Eternity of the World*, Leiden, 2002, 46 n. 174).

- **KHY'S** (Q 19): The relation the world of generation (*K*) bears to the first principle (*al-mabda' al-awwal*) (*H*) by way of atemporal creation (*Y*), followed by the qualifying through the intermediation of atemporal creation (*Y*) of temporal creation by the command (*'*), followed by generation through the intermediation of the command and temporal creation (*Š*). *KH* thus encompasses, [in decending order,] the necessary relation of atemporal creation [to the first principle], then that of temporal creation [to the same], then that of generation, temporal creation and the command [to the same].
- **YS** (Q 36): The beginning of the creative emanation (*fayḍ*), i.e., atemporal creation (*Y*), and its end, i.e., temporal creation as encompassing generation (*S*).
- **HM** (Q 40, 41, 43, 44, 45, 46): The world of nature (*H*) as produced by temporal creation (*M*).
- **HM'SQ** (Q 42): That signified by the intermediation of temporal creation (*M*) in the existence of the world of nature (*H*) through the relation of temporal creation to the command (*'*), and the relation of temporal creation to generation (*S*) by which the latter draws on the former, by which process the universal atemporal creation, encompassing all the worlds, is completed; taken in a general sense, these worlds bear no relation to the First except via this universal atemporal creation (*Q*).
- **TS** (Q 27): The material world (*al-‘ālam al-hayūlānī*) (*T*) as produced by generation as produced by temporal creation (*S*).
- **TSM** (Q 26, 28): The material world (*T*) as produced through temporal creation encompassing generation (*S*), as well as through the command produced by atemporal creation (*M*).¹⁴⁸
- **N** (Q 68): The world of generation and the world of the command, i.e., the whole of existence (*majmū‘ al-kull*) (*N*).¹⁴⁹
- **[TH** (Q 20): Prime matter (*T*) as qualifying the first principle (*H*).]¹⁵⁰

Characteristically, the Shaykh al-Raʿīs (pretender though he may be) concludes the treatise with a categorical assertion: “These letters categorically cannot signify other than what I have described; and there are further secrets that can only be explained in person.”¹⁵¹

In his article on this treatise, Lory surveys previous attempts to make sense of the work within the context of Ibn Sīnā’s oeuvre and the intellectual developments of his day. Louis Massignon, for his part, focused on the Ismaʿīli origins of such speculation in a 1952 article.¹⁵²

¹⁴⁸ This last phrase seems not to fit *M*, which refers only to temporal creation.

¹⁴⁹ This again seems a bit forced, as he defines *N* above as the conjunction of atemporal and temporal creation.

¹⁵⁰ The *TH* is inexplicably dropped in the copies of this treatise available to me, but can be reconstructed according to the established pattern.

¹⁵¹ “R. al-Nayrūziyya,” 110.

¹⁵² “La philosophie orientale d’Ibn Sīnā et son alphabet philosophique.”

Two works are salient here: the *K. al-Kashf*, attributed to Ja‘far b. Manṣūr al-Yaman, a Fatimid scholar who died in the late 4th/10th century, but (according to Madelung) more probably a pre-Fatimid source; and the *K. al-Iftikhār* of Abū Ya‘qūb Sijistānī (d. btw. 375-80/985-90), which includes information on earlier Isma‘ili cosmological thought based on the procession of letters (especially *KUNY-QDR*). Lory observes, however, that Isma‘ili versions of cosmogonic letter speculation possess a very different emphasis from Ibn Sīnā’s purely metaphysical approach, and are primarily soteriological in tone; moreover, they manifest no concern with the *muqatta‘āt*, the topic at issue in the *R. al-Nayrūziyya*. The *Rasā’il* of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’ are a far more likely source for the treatise, although, again, important differences must be noted.

Lory then examines two earlier Sufi sources not available to Massignon: the *R. al-Ḥurūf* of Sahl Tustarī, and the *K. Khawāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf wa-Ḥaqā’iqi-hā wa-Uṣūli-hā* of Ibn Masarra (which explicitly draws on Tustarī’s work). Both of these works manifest an exegetical approach similar to that of Ibn Sīnā, and deal specifically with the *muqatta‘āt*, which Ibn Masarra, like Ibn Sīnā, treats in systematic order. However, neither work shares the numerological emphasis of the *R. al-Nayrūziyya*. In the final analysis, of course, we need not assume that Ibn Sīnā knew of either treatise, since they are as marginal to their respective authors’ oeuvres as the *R. al-Nayrūziyya* is to Ibn Sīnā’s. The point that must be emphasized is that this type of letter speculation was already widespread in both Shi‘i and Sunni circles by the late 4th/10th century.¹⁵³ For all its numerological-metaphysical gymnastics, then, the *R. al-Nayrūziyya* is wholly symptomatic of its era, and prepared the way for later intellectual approaches to lettrism.

¹⁵³ Lory, *La science des lettres*, 82-87.

4.2: Lettrism in classifications of the sciences (4th-9th/10th-15th c.)

To understand Ṣā'in al-Dīn's presentation of lettrism, involving both theory and praxis, as distinct from Sufism on the one hand and philosophy on the other, we must take note of two distinct processes at work in the *taṣnīf al-'ulūm* genre¹⁵⁴ from the 4th/10th century onwards: 1) the increasing recognition of Sufism as a religious (Islamic) science in its own right; and 2) the simultaneous but more gradual assimilation of the science of letters or letter magic (*sīmiyā'*)¹⁵⁵ as an Islamic science through its association with Sufism. As we will see, letter magic was considered exclusively as a standard occult science until the mid-8th/14th century, and as such part of natural philosophy (*al-'ilm al-ṭabī'ī, furū'-i ṭabī'ī*) and therefore non-religious (pre-Islamic).¹⁵⁶ The category of *sīmiyā'* itself was defined differently by different encyclopedists, and at times ignored altogether, but for our purposes here it may be seen as broadly linked with occult sciences dealing in letters and numbers, particularly the science of talismans and divination; a loose consensus held it to be a type of magic but distinct from sorcery (*siḥr*). Thus the *Jawāmi' al-'Ulūm* of Ibn Farīghūn (d. after 344/955), for example, an early administrative encyclopedia, assigns astrology, divination, magic, talismans and alchemy to the category of natural philosophy, without explicitly mentioning *sīmiyā'* as a distinct science.¹⁵⁷

The early divide between Sufism as a religious science and the occult sciences as natural sciences is exemplified in the *Rasā'il* of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' (late 4th/10th c.). Among their other

¹⁵⁴ For surveys of this genre see Bakar, *Classification of Knowledge*; Biesterfeldt, "Arabisch-islamisch Enzyklopädien"; idem, "Medieval Arabic Encyclopedias"; Heck, "The Hierarchy of Knowledge"; Pellat and Vesel, "Mawsū'a," *El'*; Stearns, "Writing Natural Science"; Vesel, *Les encyclopédies persanes*.

¹⁵⁵ On *sīmiyā'* see Ullmann, *Die Natur- und Geheimwissenschaften*, 361-2.

¹⁵⁶ On the unity of the occult sciences, cf. the characterization by Brian Vickers (On the Function 265): "There are sufficient internal resemblances among astrology, alchemy, numerology, iatromathematics, and natural magic for one to be able to describe the occult sciences as forming a unified system. They all invoke a distinction between the visible and invisible worlds; they all depend on the designation of symbols relating to this dichotomy; they all make great use of analogies, correspondences, and relations among apparently discrete elements in man and the universe."

¹⁵⁷ Vesel, *Les encyclopédies persanes*, 24.

virtues, it appears that the *Epistles* have the distinction of being the first Islamic encyclopedia of knowledge to recognize Sufism more or less on its own terms among the positive sciences of the Shari'a, dividing it into the related categories of mysticism and asceticism. Occult sciences such as divination, magic and alchemy, for their part, are classed among the propaedeutic (*riyāḍiyya*), or life-improving, sciences. (The neoplatonic-neopythagorean lettrist component of the *Epistles* was discussed in §4.1.1 above.) The distinction between pre-Islamic and Islamic sciences, then, would seem to hold; however, the *Rasā'il* may be seen as hinting at later developments in its functional grouping of religious sciences and occult sciences together in the final section of the encyclopedia (treatises 43-52).¹⁵⁸

As may be expected, Sufism begins to come into its own as an Islamic science in the works of Ghazālī (d. 505/1111), which provided the main impetus for the growing recognition of Sufism as an independent science. Ghazālī himself, however, does not treat Sufism as a subcategory of formal study, but rather subsumes Sufi practice under the category of ethics (*'ilm al-akhlāq*) and posits Sufi theory, the science of unveiling (*'ilm al-mukāshafa*), as the esoteric component of the 'science of the path to the hereafter' (*'ilm ṭarīq al-ākhir*).¹⁵⁹ At the same time, Ghazālī classifies non-religious sciences as either commendable, blameworthy, or permitted, and under this schema dismisses the occult sciences as blameworthy.¹⁶⁰

With a nod to Ghazālī and the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā', the *Yavāqīt al-'Ulūm wa-Darārī al-Nujūm* (wr. before 573/1177), written for the Seljuq governor of Qazvin, is the first Persian encyclopedia to include Sufism as an independent Islamic science, i.e., one on a par with hadith, jurisprudence, etc.¹⁶¹ In its concern to present the Islamic sciences (*'ulūm-i avākhir*) and the pre-Islamic or

¹⁵⁸ See Pellat, "Mawsū'a," *El*²; de Callatay, *Ikhwan al-Safa'* 60-61.

¹⁵⁹ Bakar, *Classification of Knowledge* 203-26; Ingalls, "Subtle Innovation." 200-1.

¹⁶⁰ Pellat, "Mawsū'a," *El*².

¹⁶¹ *Yavāqīt al-'Ulūm*, 67-78.

rational sciences (*‘ulūm-i avā’il*) on equal terms, however, it continues the standard classification of the occult sciences (magic, incantations, divination, astrology) under the rubric of natural philosophy.¹⁶² The latter category is further refined by Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī (d. 606/1209) in his Persian *Jāmi‘ al-‘Ulūm*, which classes talismans and alchemy under natural philosophy, and astrology, geomancy and incantations/amulets (*‘azā’im*) under the mathematical sciences.¹⁶³ (Like Muḥammad Kh^wārazmī’s (d. 387/997) *Mafātīḥ al-‘Ulūm* and Ibn Ḥazm’s (d. 456/1064) *R. Marātib al-‘Ulūm*, the *Jāmi‘ al-‘Ulūm* contains no mention of Sufism as a separate science.¹⁶⁴) As it gathered steam, this trend toward recognizing Sufism as an independent science began to extend even to encyclopedias of philosophy; the *Durrat al-Tāj li-Ghurraṭ al-Dībāj* of the illuminationist philosopher and astronomer Quṭb al-Dīn Shīrāzī (d. 710/1311), for example, a Persian encyclopedia heavily weighted toward the mathematical sciences, lists Sufism as a separate science in its epilogue.¹⁶⁵

Mention must also be made of the anonymous *Masālik al-Mubtadī wa-Masā’il al-Muqtadī*, which apparently survives only in a unicum copied in 712/1312 and preserved in the Topkapı Palace Library.¹⁶⁶ This rather circumscribed encyclopedia treats twelve disciplines in the following order: grammar, logic, theology and dogma (*uṣūl al-dīn*), legal theory (*uṣūl al-fiqh*), jurisprudence, sects (*‘ilm al-khilāf*), Sufism (*‘ilm al-ṭarīqa*), the science of letters, astronomy (*‘ilm al-hay’a*), medicine, and music. Given the nature of the arrangement, with *‘ilm al-ḥurūf* occurring between Sufism and astronomy, it is unclear on the face of it whether the author

¹⁶² Vesel, *Les encyclopédies persanes*, 17–9. The overarching *awā’il/awākhir* distinction becomes standard from the 6th/12th century onwards.

¹⁶³ See *Jāmi‘ al-‘Ulūm*, 586–7, 593–4. It is the first Persian encyclopedia in the narrow sense of the term, containing 60 sciences (hence its alternate title *Sittīnī*) in three broad categories—traditional, rational, and practical (Vesel, “Mawsū’a,” *El*²).

¹⁶⁴ Ingalls, “Subtle Innovation,” 199–200.

¹⁶⁵ Vesel, *Les encyclopédies persanes*, 14.

¹⁶⁶ MS 6638 A. 2542, copied in 712/1312 by ‘Umar b. ‘Abd al-Ḥusayn b. ‘Alī b. Abī Bakr al-Baṣrī.

treats it as an Islamic or pre-Islamic science, although the term *‘ilm al-ḥurūf* itself suggests letter magic as adopted into Sufism, rather than *sīmiyā’* proper. In any event, an examination of this MS may reveal it as representing an important stage in the naturalization of the science of letters as a distinctly Islamic science.¹⁶⁷ As in the *Yavāqūt al-‘Ulūm*, Sufism appears to be treated as being on a par with such Islamic sciences as grammar and jurisprudence.

There was by no means a consensus on this latter point even by the early 8th/14th century, however. In the Arabic *Irshād al-Qāṣid ilā Asnā l-Maqāṣid* of Shams al-Dīn Ibn al-Akfānī (d. 749/1348), whose schema privileges the Greek sciences, Sufism is conceived of not as a separate Islamic science but simply as the practical application of metaphysics (*al-‘ilm al-ilāhī*), the most universal and noblest of the sciences. In this connection Ibn al-Akfānī mentions Ibn ‘Arabī’s *al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya* as the greatest work on the subject. The ideal figure is the *mujtahid* who begins his path with philosophy and ends it with mystical self-purification, as did Socrates, Plato and Suhrawardī, the latter’s *Ḥikmat al-Ishrāq* combining philosophical and mystical insight.¹⁶⁸ Continuing the earlier consensus, *sīmiyā’* is listed among the natural sciences and grouped with judicial astrology, sorcery, talismans and alchemy.¹⁶⁹

The contemporary importance of Sufism was finally canonized in Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad Āmulī’s (d. 753/1352) *Nafā’is al-Funūn fī ‘Arā’is al-‘Uyūn*, a climax of the genre in Persian in its complexity and exhaustiveness,¹⁷⁰ where for the first time it is classified not simply as one religious science among several but as a science distinct from and on a par with

¹⁶⁷ See Bayāt, “al-Makḥṭūṭāt al-‘Arabiyya fī Maktabat Ṭūbqābī Sarāyī bi-Istanbūl,” 415. I have not yet been able to access this MS.

¹⁶⁸ *Irshād al-Qāṣid*, 30; Ingalls, “Subtle Innovation,” 201-2.

¹⁶⁹ *Irshād al-Qāṣid*, 51. Ibn al-Akfānī defines it with utmost brevity (and rather inexplicably) as that branch of magic dealing with things unreal (*ghayr al-ḥaqīqī min al-siḥr*), i.e., equivalent to what is usually called *sha‘wadha/sha‘badha*, legerdemain or the production of optical illusions. An etymology of the term *sīmiyā’* is given: > Hebrew *shem Yah*, ‘the name of God,’ indicating the science’s association with the divine names as loci of magical power.

¹⁷⁰ Vesel, “Mawsū‘a,” *El*². Āmulī was a Shī‘i *mudarris* in Sultaniyya under Öljeytū (r. 703-16/1304-16).

all the other religious sciences (jurisprudence, hadith, theology, etc.) combined. Moreover, the *Nafā'is* represents another important first in its inclusion of the science of letters (*'ilm al-ḥurūf*) as a specifically Sufi (and therefore Islamic) science.¹⁷¹ Yet Āmulī does not relinquish the category of *sīmiyā'*, letter magic, as an applied natural science; indeed, he expands upon earlier treatments of the science, presenting it as a broad category comprising talismans, planetary invocations and incantations.¹⁷² Āmulī's sophisticated and nuanced classification thus posits three new elements that constitute the immediate context for Ibn Turka's reformulation of lettrism some 70 years later: 1) Sufism as the supreme Islamic science; 2) *'ilm al-ḥurūf* as a subset of Sufism; and 3) *'ilm al-ḥurūf* and *sīmiyā'* as two aspects of a single science, the first an element of religious theory at its most rarefied and the second a mode of applied natural philosophy.

Several decades later, Ibn Khaldūn (d. 808/1406), the most authoritative contemporary voice in the western Islamicate world,¹⁷³ similarly synthesized in his *Muqaddima* the categories of Sufism and *sīmiyā'*. It is unclear to what extent the *Nafā'is al-Funūn*, as a Persian encyclopedia, may have exerted a westward influence on a thinker like Ibn Khaldūn, and it should be noted that the latter's classification of lettrism is more ambiguous than Āmulī's while reiterating his approach in its basic outlines. Ibn Khaldūn does recognize Sufism as an independent religious science, though unlike Āmulī he does not equate it to all of the other religious sciences *in toto*. Nor does he discuss *'ilm al-ḥurūf* in his section on the science of Sufism, rather maintaining its more standard classification, in the guise of *sīmiyā'*, among the occult natural sciences, immediately preceding his discussion (and refutation) of astrology and

¹⁷¹ *Nafā'is al-Funūn*, 2/91-110. But cf. the *Masālik al-Mubtadī* above.

¹⁷² *Nafā'is al-Funūn*, 3/183-218; Vesel, *Les encyclopédies persanes*, 39.

¹⁷³ It should be noted that the respective residences of Ibn Khaldūn and Ibn Turka in Cairo overlapped by at least ten years; the former moved to Cairo in 1383 and remained there until his death in 1406, and the latter spent most of the period ca. 1393-1408 in the same city.

alchemy.¹⁷⁴ Ibn Khaldūn accordingly describes *sīmiyā'* as being primarily materialistic and empirical in nature, and personally vouches for its magical efficacy:

The fact that it is possible to be active in the world of nature with the help of the letters and the words composed of them, and that the created things can be influenced in this way, cannot be denied. It is confirmed by continuous tradition on the authority of many (practitioners of letter magic).¹⁷⁵

At the same time, he explicitly associates *sīmiyā'* with Sufism, which in due course generated *'ilm al-ḥurūf* as a subset of *sīmiyā'*:

The science originated in Islam after some time of (its existence) had passed. When the extremist Sufis appeared, they turned to the removal of the veil of sense perception, produced wonders, and were active in the world of the elements. At that time, they wrote systematic works on (Sufism) and (Sufi) terminology. They believed in the gradual descent of existence from the One. They believed that verbal perfection consists in helping the spirits of the spheres and the stars (through words). The natures and secrets of the letters are alive in the words, while the words, in turn, are correspondingly active in the created things. The created things have been moving in the different stages of (creation) and telling its secrets since the first creation. These (Sufi beliefs) caused the science of the secrets of the letters to originate. It is a subdivision of the science of *sīmiyā'* 'letter magic.' It is an unfathomable subject with innumerable problems. Al-Būnī, Ibn al-'Arabī, and others in their wake wrote numerous works on it. These authors assume that the result and fruit of letter magic is that the divine souls are active in the world of nature by means of the beautiful names of God and the divine expressions that originate from the letters comprising the secrets that are alive in the created things.¹⁷⁶

Like Ṣā'in al-Dīn, Ibn Khaldūn associates the practical and theoretical components of lettrism with Būnī and Ibn 'Arabī respectively. The foregoing passage thus echoes the distinction drawn by Āmulī between *'ilm al-ḥurūf* and *sīmiyā'*, although Ibn Khaldūn, unlike Āmulī, and certainly

¹⁷⁴ Note that Ibn Khaldūn classes talismans and *sīmiyā'* as distinct sciences, while Āmulī includes talismans under the rubric of *sīmiyā'*. Ibn Khaldūn clarifies this point: "At the present time, this science is called *sīmiyā'* 'letter magic.' The word was transferred from talismans to this science and used in this conventional meaning in the technical terminology of Sufi practitioners of magic. Thus, a general (magical) term came to be used for some particular aspect (of magic)" (*The Muqaddimah*, trans. Rosenthal, 3/171).

¹⁷⁵ *The Muqaddimah*, 3/174.

¹⁷⁶ *The Muqaddimah*, 3/171-72.

unlike Ibn Turka, explicitly makes the former a subset of the latter. The theory of Ibn ‘Arabī notwithstanding, the reader’s sense is that the historian here considers Būnī to be the most definitive representative of the science, and favors the definition of lettrism as being primarily letter magic, a form of natural magic in that it relies on the natural properties of the letters and the names of God. It is a licit type of magic, moreover, because its practitioner is essentially passive, unlike sorcery, which consists of the direct imposition of the *magus*’s will (*himma*) upon reality.¹⁷⁷

The *Muqaddima* thus enshrines the above-noted trends in *taṣnīf al-‘ulūm* works between the 4th-9th/10th-15th centuries toward understanding Sufism as an Islamic science in its own right¹⁷⁸ and toward distinguishing between two forms of lettrism, one as derivative of Sufism and a second, *sīmiyā’* or letter magic proper, classified among the natural sciences. The greater emphasis Ibn Khaldūn places on letter magic as a practical discipline, compared to Āmulī’s valorization of *‘ilm al-ḥurūf* as a Sufi science, may perhaps be explained as illustrating the contrast between the respective north African and western Iranian contexts of each writer.¹⁷⁹ Indeed, Ibn Khaldūn remarks that the sciences have long enjoyed a uniformly higher level of sophistication in Khurasan and Persian Iraq than they have in the Islamicate west, though somewhat impaired in his own day.¹⁸⁰

¹⁷⁷ Asatrian, “Ibn Khaldūn on Magic,” 101-3.

¹⁷⁸ This becomes standard from 9th/15th century onward, e.g. in Jalāl al-Dīn al-Suyūṭī’s (d. 911/1505) *Itmām al-Dirāya li-Qurrā’ al-Nuqāya* and Zakariyyā al-Anṣārī’s (d. 926/1520) *al-Lu’lu’ al-Naẓīm fī Rawm al-Ta’allum wa-l-Ta’līm* (Ingalls, “Subtle Innovation,” 204-7). A later Ottoman example of the genre, the *Tartīb al-‘Ulūm* of Sāḥaqlīzāde (d. 1145/1733), continues this approach (69-70).

¹⁷⁹ Ibn Khaldūn’s emphasis on letter magic does however tally with Ṣā’ in al-Dīn’s complaint in the *R. Ḥurūf* to precisely this effect.

¹⁸⁰ *The Muqaddimah*, 2/431; 3/314-15, 337.

4.2.1: Ibn Turka's reclassification of lettrism

Ṣā'īn al-Dīn's presentation of lettrism clearly engages and contests the views of contemporary and near-contemporary encyclopedists. *Pace* Ibn Khaldūn, lettrism is far more than simply a subset of letter magic, though it is indeed essentially Islamic in its total dependency on the Quran as the transcript of reality, and is particularly to be identified with the writings of Būnī and Ibn 'Arabī. *Pace* Ibn al-Akfānī, metaphysics cannot be the most universal of the sciences; the palm here must go to lettrism. However, the point that Sufism is simply applied metaphysics is well taken—Ṣā'īn al-Dīn similarly links philosophy and mysticism as two necessary approaches in the quest for wisdom that are best combined. *Pace* Āmulī, lettrism is hardly a subset of Sufism, but rather encompasses both it and philosophy; Sufism should, however, be considered a science in its own right, and indeed one superior to the other Islamic sciences. Most significantly, Ṣā'īn al-Dīn's sharp distinction between the theoretical and practical components of lettrism and his championing of the former seems to be directly informed by Āmulī's unprecedented recognition of a *sīmiyā'*/*'ilm al-ḥurūf* binary and association of the latter component with Sufism, in his view the supreme Islamic science.

It appears, in sum, that Ibn Turka's conceptualization of lettrism is indeed unique by the standards of the early 9th/15th century, despite building on Āmulī's classification scheme in particular. While he does not deny the essential linkages between practical and theoretical lettrism on the one hand and lettrism, Sufism and philosophy on the other, he inverts the relative importance of each: theoretical lettrism, though unconscionably neglected, is superior to letter magic; and neither Sufism or philosophy, natural or otherwise, contain or give rise to lettrism, but as distinct, non-universal sciences are rather themselves encompassed by lettrism. According to Ṣā'īn al-Dīn's reclassification thereof, lettrism, as a neoplatonic-hermetic mode of knowledge intrinsic to the prophetic legacy throughout history and operative on all levels of reality, is alone capable of serving as a universal science organizing all of human knowledge

under its aegis. To borrow Vittoria Perrone Compagni's description of Agrippa's objective in his *De Occulta Philosophia*, Ibn Turka

proposes a total reorganization of [lettrism] as an umbrella science which, by gathering under a single roof all the cognitive data collected in the various fields of scientific research, would guarantee the effectiveness of each branch of research and make explicit its potential for acting upon reality.¹⁸¹

The promotion and development of this science must therefore constitute the core of his millenarian quest for knowledge.¹⁸²

4.3: Near-contemporary and contemporary forms of lettrism

As we saw in Chapter 3, Ṣā'in al-Dīn observes that Būnī's practical approach to the science of letters was the dominant one of his day. But other trends also emerged in Iran during the 8th-9th/14th-15th centuries; these may be loosely characterized as occupying a continuum of orientations from scholarly, philosophical or intellectual, to Sufi, to gnostic-messianic and post-Islamic.¹⁸³ In this section I will touch on a representative case of each by way of suggesting the living contexts in which Ṣā'in al-Dīn developed his aggressive lettrist project as the foremost disciple of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī. These are: Rashīd al-Dīn Ṭabīb and his *R. Ḥurūf*, representing the *intellectual* approach; Ni'mat Allāh Valī and his lettrist treatises, representing the mainstream *Sufi* approach; and Faḏl Allāh Astarābādī and the Ḥurūfiyya, representing the *gnostic-messianic* approach.¹⁸⁴ I will conclude this section with a brief look at 'Abd al-Raḥmān

¹⁸¹ See the introduction to her edition of *De Occulta Philosophia Libri Tres*, Leiden, 2006, 16, quoted in Kavey, "Building Blocks," 36-37.

¹⁸² Cf. the Enlightenment doctrine of the universality of science.

¹⁸³ It should be noted that all of these orientations were imamophilic to greater or lesser degrees.

¹⁸⁴ For reasons of space I omit here the prominent contemporary lettrist thinker Ḥāfiẓ Rajab Bursī (ca. 743-813/1342-1411), whose *K. Mashāriq Anwār al-Yaqīn fī Ḥaqā'iq Asrār Amīr al-Mu'minīn* represents the extremist Sufi-Shi'i approach, and thus may be said to occupy a position somewhere between Ni'mat

Bisṭāmī's candid self-positioning in the lettrist tradition as a means of assessing what texts Ṣā'in al-Dīn may have studied and which transmitters he may have met in Egypt, since he is far more reticent than his Ottoman counterpart on such matters.

4.3.1: Rashīd al-Dīn Ṭabīb and intellectual lettrism

I should first clarify what is meant here by 'intellectual lettrism.' As I suggested in my discussion of Ibn Sīnā's lettrist treatise above (§4.1.3), this type of lettrist thought is best defined by what it is not, or by what trends it holds itself aloof from. Thus Ibn Sīnā's approach can be characterized neither as Sufi nor gnostic-messianic, but rather as philosophical (neoplatonic-neopythagorean) with hermetic overtones; its primary concern is cosmological. 'Intellectual lettrism' is therefore used in this study purely as a term of convenience to denote various strains of lettrist thought developed in rationalist, philosophical or otherwise scholarly contexts. Any divide posited between philosophical or scholastic thought on the one hand and mystical theory on the other is, of course, necessarily artificial in the context of Islamic intellectual history, particularly in the late medieval and early modern periods with their proliferation of mystico-philosophical syntheses. Nevertheless, it appears to the present writer

Allāh Valī and Faḡl Allāh. Bursī lived for the first part of his life in Hilla, the most important Imami Shi'i center of learning in Iraq at that time, studying with such luminaries as al-Shahīd al-Awwal (d. 786/1384); he soon earned a reputation for extremist views and was forced to seek the protection of the small Sarbidarid state in Khurasan. He is said to have been buried either in Mashhad or, more probably, north of the Zavāra fortress near Ardastan, with the latter location featuring a shrine called simply the Buq'a-yi Ḥāfiẓ Rajab. His lettrist thought as formulated in the *Mashāriq* is primarily cosmological and theological in orientation, and often draws on Ibn 'Arabī, Ḥallāj and Ibn al-Fāriq; it is moreover overtly Imami in its concern to demonstrate the occult supremacy of the Fourteen Infallibles and to develop the doctrine of the *walāya* of the Imams—both themes common to the Shi'i-Sunni or imamophilic lettrism of the period, to be sure, but here taken to a confessional level: he declares the twelve Imams to be eternal principles, going so far as to assert the divinity of 'Alī (Ja'fariyān, *Naqsh*, 61). Despite its extremism, the *Mashāriq* came to be extensively referenced and commented upon, particularly in the Safavid period. For a discussion of Bursī's significance as a Shi'i Sufi and lettrist thinker, see al-Shaybī, *Tashayyu' u Taṣavvuf*, 239-71; Lawson, "The Dawning Places of the Lights of Certainty"; Rajabī, "Niḡāhī bi Kitāb-i Mashāriq Anvār al-Yaqīn"; and Rizā Mukhtārī, "Bursī, Raḡī l-Dīn Ḥāfiẓ Rajab b. Muḥammad," *DJI*. The first 22 chapters of his *Mashāriq* as translated by Henry Corbin were published as *Les Orient des lumières*, ed. and intro. Pierre Lory, Paris, 1996. Bursī's other lettrist works include *al-Lum'a min Asrār al-Asmā' wa-l-Ṣifāt wa-l-Ḥurūf wa-l-Āyāt wa-l-Da'awāt* and *Khawāṣṣ al-Asmā' al-Ḥusnā* (Bīdābādī, "Mu'arrafi-yi Mashāriq Anvār al-Yaqīn," 143-44).

that no other term can justifiably be applied to Ṣā'in al-Dīn's lettrism in particular, since he is at such pains to differentiate it from both Sufism and philosophy, yet uses the science almost exclusively for metaphysical and theoretical ends.

The lettrist thought of Rashīd al-Dīn Ṭabīb (d. 718/1318), the eminent historian, polymath and vizier of Ilkhanid Iran, provides further justification for such a category.¹⁸⁵ As we will see, his short *R. Ḥurūf* testifies to his multiple professional interests in medicine,¹⁸⁶ politics, geography and tafsir, while being bare of the more esoteric, Sufi or philosophical lettrist tendencies examined throughout this chapter. It is wholly scholarly in tone; its primary objective is to set the stage for a much longer discussion of the doctrine of *ijāz al-Qur'ān*, a topic close to his heart as an exegete.¹⁸⁷ To call this type of lettrism 'scholarly-polymath' seems overly specific—'intellectual' will do. In any event, Rashīd al-Dīn's interest in lettrism, albeit for theological ends, signals its emergence by the late 7th/13th century as a distinct, fully-fledged science not without attraction for mainstream thinkers.¹⁸⁸

(Although purely incidental to the present argument, it may be noted that there was presumed to have been a close relationship between Rashīd al-Dīn and Ṣā'in al-Dīn's grandfather Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka, a prominent philosopher; he is said to have written two

¹⁸⁵ This is the main reason I include Rashīd al-Dīn in this section, although characterizing him as a near-contemporary to Ṣā'in al-Dīn is, needless to say, a stretch. Perhaps more to the point, Rashīd al-Dīn's lettrism provides a useful contrast to the Sufi lettrism promoted by his later contemporary and employee of the Ilkhanid state, Shams al-Dīn Āmulī, in the latter's *Nafā'is al-Funūn*, which Ṣā'in al-Dīn appears to both build upon and contest.

¹⁸⁶ In this treatise Rashīd al-Dīn, for example, compares individual letters to medicinal substances which take on new properties in various compounds (for medical references see points 4, 5, 11 and 14 in the summary below); cf. Ibn Turka's medical comparison in *R. Su'l al-Mulūk* (see Part 2, §T.4 below).

¹⁸⁷ Cf. Ibn Barrajān's lettrist prediction of the reconquest of Jerusalem in 583/1187 on the basis of Q 30:1-5, which is often cited in Mālikī 'aqīda texts as a proof for the same doctrine; see §5.2.1.1 below. On the debates surrounding the doctrine of *ijāz al-Qur'ān* from the 2nd-7th/9th-13th centuries see Travis Zadeh, "Translation, Geography, and the Divine Word," 376-418 (presumably a discussion to be included in his forthcoming *The Vernacular Qur'an: Translation and the Rise of Persian Exegesis*, Oxford, 2012); see also van Ess, *Theologie und Gesellschaft*, 4/608-12.

¹⁸⁸ Cf. Sharīf Jurjānī's (d. 816/1413) *R. Ḥarfīyya fī Ma'ānī l-Ḥurūf*, which is simply a treatise on linguistics.

philosophical works for the vizier, and may have been one of the executors of the latter's estate.¹⁸⁹)

Rashīd al-Dīn's *R. Ḥurūf*, addressed to Öljeytū (r. 703-16/1304-16), is the eighth treatise in his *Bayān al-Ḥaqāyiq* collection, comprising 20 (or 17) of the author's treatises on theological and other issues, particularly focusing on Quran commentary.¹⁹⁰ The purely lettrist content of the treatise occupies only the first 13 pages of its edition, or approximately one-fourth of the whole;¹⁹¹ the remaining three-fourths of the text consists of material (*favāyid*) from the third section of the author's *R. Kanz al-Ma'ārif*,¹⁹² together with a three-page appendix constituting a brief reply to a friend's question as to the difference in status between God's speech in the Qur'ān versus His speech in the form of *ḥadīth qudsī* and in Prophetic hadiths; Rashīd al-Dīn gives a general response and then provides a two-page summary of his arguments on the subject in both *R. Kanz al-Ma'ānī* and *R. Sulṭāniyya* (here given as *K. Sulṭāna*).¹⁹³ The imported section from the *R. Kanz al-Ma'ārif*, taken from an earlier collection, the *Laṭāyif al-Ḥaqāyiq*, deals with the mode of God's Speech (*kalām*) and the manner of the prophets' audition of that

¹⁸⁹ That is, if Rashīd al-Dīn's correspondence is not rather a Timurid-era forgery, as seems probable (see Morton, "The Letters of Rashīd al-Dīn: Īlkhānid Fact or Timurid fiction?"; an unpersuasive defense of their authenticity is offered in Soudavar, "In Defense of Rašīd-od-dīn and His Letters"), in which case the question is simply transposed into another key: why was it important to the political and intellectual context of 9th/15th century Iran to posit a close relationship between Rashīd al-Dīn and Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka? For more on the relevant letters between the two men see §1.1 above.

¹⁹⁰ Only two copies of this collection exist, a defective Persian version, MS Majlis 1329 (copied 8th/14th c., treatises 5-20), which is missing the beginning and end, and an Arabic version, MS Süleymaniye 854 (copied by Muḥammad b. Sayyid Isfarā'inī in 711/1311, from the Kılıç Ali Paşa collection, 20 treatises; it leaves instances of Persian verse untranslated). The Arabic copy is similarly defective; up through the middle of treatise no. 11 the MS folios are badly arranged with many being out of order, and the microfilm of this copy made by Mīnuvī suffers from blackened and illegible pages. The Persian edition of this text by Hāshim Rajabzāda (Tehran, 2007) reconstitutes missing phrases from the Arabic and provides the Arabic text of missing pages in the footnotes. It contains treatises 1-10, 13, 15-16, with detailed summary descriptions of all 20 original treatises from the beginning of MS Majlis 1329 (ff. 1-42). An edition of the Arabic version is under preparation by Judith Pfeiffer.

¹⁹¹ "R. al-Ḥurūf," in *Bayān al-Ḥaqāyiq*, 275-88.

¹⁹² "R. al-Ḥurūf," 288-318.

¹⁹³ "R. al-Ḥurūf," 319-21. The *R. Sulṭāniyya*, an important late medieval source for political theology, is currently being edited by Judith Pfeiffer in its Persian and Arabic versions.

Speech.¹⁹⁴ I translate below the detailed Persian summary of the *R. Hurūf* found at the beginning of MS Majlis 1329, leaving aside the longer section on the strictly theological material imported from the *R. Kanz al-Ma'ārif* as extraneous to my immediate purpose here:

This treatise comprises a single section (*aṣl*) and conclusion (*tatimma*), and is concerned to explicate the science of letters.

1. Opens with reference to Q 2:32: *Glory be to You! We have no knowledge save what You have taught us*; mentions the reason for the work's composition.
2. An affirmation to the effect that each letter in the Quran, whatever its position, has a property, particularity and meaning peculiar to it; no two letters resemble each other in every respect. This is so in two senses, a general sense, referring to all books, including the Quran, this comprising nine parts; and a specific sense, referring to the Quran alone, this comprising a single section.
3. Part one of the general sense, consisting of an affirmation that no two things are similar to each other in every respect; here the A as such is compared to the human species, and individual As to individual human beings, [all differing among themselves despite belonging to the same species].
4. Part two, consisting of an affirmation that each letter that is put into association with another letter takes on a different particularity; here a comparison is made between individual letters and individual medicinal substances [that have different medical effects in different compounds].
5. Part three, consisting of an affirmation that just as adding a single letter to a construction (*tarkīb*) gives it a different meaning, so too does adding two letters, three or three letters, and so on. This point is compared to the office of a physician vis-à-vis a patient, and the effect of his treatment and presence of the physician himself, and his equal attention to every group of people.
6. Part four, consisting of an affirmation that the letters of an word (*lafẓ*), however many they may be, do not impart the benefit of their verbal construction (*tarkīb-i lafẓī*) until such is complete, and after the construction is complete it comes to have a further benefit greater than the sum of the benefits of the construction itself together with those of its constituent letters. The comparison is here made to commanders of troops of a thousand men, a hundred men or ten men down to a [small] band of soldiers.¹⁹⁵ A discussion of the coining of words (*vaz'*) and deriving the etymology of words (*ishtiqaq*).
7. Part five, consisting of an affirmation that each verbal construction produces a meaning, and each letter of each of its words takes on a different meaning according to the dictates of the construction, and likewise with constructions of two or three [words] and so on. The above comparison to commanders of troops is extended.
8. Part six, consisting of an affirmation that when a verbal construction is expressed in metrical (*mawzūn*), [i.e., poetical], form it acquires a benefit different from those discussed above, this likewise differing with each meter (*vazn*). The comparison is

¹⁹⁴ "R. Kanz al-Ma'ānī," in *Laṭāyif al-Haqāyiq*, 2/417. The first two sections 1) analyze proofs for the oneness (*vaḥdāniyyat*) of God, the Necessary Existent; and 2) expound upon the phrase 'the One from which proceeds only the One' (*al-wāḥidu lā yaṣḍuru 'an-hu illā l-wāḥid*) (ibid., 2/417).

¹⁹⁵ I.e., the Mongol system of army organization according to decades.

made to the scholars and exegetes of every community and the benefits [of guidance and instruction] they provide to all.

9. Part seven, consisting of an affirmation that the verbal construction of every premise (*muqaddama*) must be identical to that of its conclusion (*natīja*) in order to create further meanings. This is compared to describing a city and its constituent parts; [none can be omitted without rendering the city unlivable].
10. Part eight, consisting of an affirmation that the properties of all the words and letters in a given treatise or book must needs differ from those of other treatises or books. The comparison is again made to cities or towns, each of which is unique [in its particularity (*khāṣṣiyyat*)].
11. Part nine, consisting of an affirmation that books which treat of a particular science fail to impart the particularity of that science unless they encompass all of its branches. The comparison is made to medicine as one of the natural sciences, as well as to geography, [in that one can only know the properties of a clime or region by knowing all of its landforms, towns, etc.].
12. The specific sense applying only to the letters of the eternal, uncreated Quran in their individual uniqueness, representing the culmination of all the above general considerations, and informing the doctrine of the inimitability (*iʿjāz*) of the Quran. The above considerations thus do not enter into the special quranic sense here in view in any direct way.
13. The first of several comparisons with respect to this specific sense: [the status of the Quran vis-à-vis other books] is compared to the fact that a king participates in certain ways in the basic humanity (*bashariyyat*) shared by his amirs and subjects (*raʿāyā*), but is wholly unique in his royal attributes and virility (*muruvvat*).
14. It is further compared to simple and compound medicines, and the process of creating further compounds of simple and compound elements; a discussion of the exceptional properties of the antidote mithridate (*tiryāq-i fārūq*).
15. It is further compared to unset jewels and their arrangement in ornaments, with the differing values of each jewel, and particularly to the jewel-encrusted royal crown, whose value lies not in itself but in the sovereign it adorns.
16. An exposition of the appropriateness of the above comparisons to the status of the Quran, which stands to all other books as a king to his subjects (*raʿiyyat*), and is capable of delivering them from the poison of destructive forces or from hell (*dūzakḥ*); for the king's crown is wholly covered with jewels.
17. It will be objected that, although all the foregoing affirmations, both general and particular, are self-evident, how can there be an epistemological standard when it is claimed that *J* in one word connotes divine majesty (*jalāl*), while in another it connotes hell (*jaḥīm*)? Furthermore, how can we know that the special status attributed to the Quran does not apply to any other book?
18. In reply it is argued that continuous transmission (*tavātur*) by a series of exponents considered trustworthy by all entails certain knowledge (*ʿilm-i qaṭʿī*) with respect to this doctrine; thousands of authorities have upheld it, as may be shown at length.¹⁹⁶ The discussion is here directed at those who deny the properties of letters, but not [the superiority of] the Quran itself.¹⁹⁷

¹⁹⁶ Cf. ʿAlī Ṣaḥī Kāshifī's emphasis on *experiential/experimental* evidence (*tajriba*) for the properties of letters and their effects—reflective of early 10th/16th century intellectual sensibilities as opposed to those of the 7th-8th/13th-14th; see §4.4.4 below.

¹⁹⁷ *Bayān al-Ḥaqāyiq*, 31-33, corresponding to "R. Ḥurūf," in *Bayān al-Ḥaqāyiq*, 275-88.

4.3.2: Ni‘mat Allāh Valī and Sufi lettrism

Like Rashīd al-Dīn’s, the lettrism of Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh Valī (ca. 730-834/1330-1431)¹⁹⁸ is highly colored by the Sufi master’s intellectual and spiritual predilections. Ni‘mat Allāh was a prolific writer said to have authored several hundred treatises (including brief expository letters sent to various disciples); seven explicitly lettrist works, all in Persian, may be counted among those that survive, apart from lettrist discussions in other, more general works, such as his wide-ranging *R. Taḥqīqāt*,¹⁹⁹ or in expository epistles, such as the *R. dar Bayān-i Ḥurūf-i Aṣliyya u Māhiyyat*.²⁰⁰ Ni‘mat Allāh, a tireless promoter of Ibn ‘Arabī’s thought, appears to have derived his lettrism largely from the Andalusian master’s definitive treatment of the subject in the second chapter of his *Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya*. Indeed, in this sense Ni‘mat Allāh’s lettrist thought represents the most complementary of contemporary forms of the science with respect to Ṣā’id al-Dīn’s own project; for despite its broader intellectual orientation, it too draws heavily on the Sufi letter theory of Ibn ‘Arabī. (It must further be emphasized that Ni‘mat Allāh is not an original thinker in any sense, given that in his writings the master is solely concerned to rehash the complicated doctrine of Ibn ‘Arabī in simpler, usually Persian, form for the benefit of his many disciples.²⁰¹ It is precisely his unoriginality, however, that makes him a useful representative of the status quo of Sufi lettrist thought of early 9th/15th century Iran.)

¹⁹⁸ Born in 730/1330 or 731/1331 in Aleppo, Nūr al-Dīn Ni‘mat Allāh studied theology in Shiraz in his youth and was initiated into Sufism by the Yemeni historian and hadith scholar ‘Abd Allāh al-Yāfi‘ī (d. 768/1367), whose circle he joined in Mecca at the age of 24. Upon his master’s death, Ni‘mat Allāh began a long itinerant phase, traveling to Egypt, Syria, Iraq, Azarbayjan and Khurasan, finally settling in Kirman and Mahan. There he continued his pursuit of agriculture, recommending it to his disciples as ‘the true alchemy.’ Ni‘mat Allāh died in Mahan in 834/1431 (Algar, “Ni‘mat-allāhiyya,” *Et*²).

¹⁹⁹ *Maktūbāt*, 36-51; the lettrist section occurs at 39-40.

²⁰⁰ *Maktūbāt*, 787.

²⁰¹ Specifically, Ni‘mat Allāh’s treatises are largely cobbled-together translations from Qayṣarī (personal communication with Professor Chittick).

It is therefore not surprising to find a close link posited between Ni‘mat Allāh, Ṣā‘in al-Dīn and Ṣā‘in al-Dīn’s master Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī in later Ni‘matullāhi hagiographic sources. Relevant material is contained in two of these in particular. The first is that by ‘Abd al-Razzāq Kirmānī (fl. 900/1495), who wrote his *Tazkira dar Manāqib-i Ḥaẓrat Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh Valī* at the request of Ni‘mat Allāh II.²⁰² In this treatise ‘Abd al-Razzāq is concerned to emphasize the deference shown to Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh by Ṣā‘in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī on the one hand, and to award credit to Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh for initiating Ṣā‘in al-Dīn’s fruitful discipleship under Sayyid Ḥusayn on the other:

Kh^wāja Ṣā‘in al-Milla wa-l-Dīn ‘Alī al-Turka al-Iṣfahānī, that eminent site of gnostic truths, refuge of virtues, master of wondrously exact sciences and source of occult knowledge, together with Mawlānā Sharaf al-Dīn ‘Alī al-Yazdī, that eminent *crème de la crème* and paragon of preeminent knowers of truth, sought audience with the most venerable master Shāh Nūr al-Dīn Ni‘mat Allāh in the town of Kūnubān [Kūhbanān, near Kirman], returning home after communicating their deepest respect. I likewise heard that they went to Syria to become disciples of the holy Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī at his holy eminence’s [i.e., Ni‘mat Allāh Valī’s] direction, and [accordingly] learned the letters of *jafr* from that eminence.²⁰³

‘Abd al-Razzāq continues by relating that Ṣā‘in al-Dīn studied under his elder brother Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka together with Qāẓizāda Rūmī, and of his works listing the *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*, *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* and “*Sharḥ-i Tamhīd-i Taṣavvuf*.” Beyond this, however, he assumes the reader’s familiarity with Ibn Turka’s importance: “The sun needs no introduction” (*wa-l-shamsu lā yaḥtāju ilā l-ta‘rīf*).²⁰⁴

The *Savānīḥ al-Ayyām fī Mushāhadat al-A‘vām* (aka *Silsilat al-‘Ārifīn*) of Ṣun‘ Allāh Ni‘matullāhī is a second hagiographical source on Ni‘mat Allāh’s life and miraculous deeds; Aubin conjectures that it is contemporary to ‘Abd al-Razzāq’s *Tazkira* but for some reason is unknown

²⁰² Aubin, *Majmū‘a*, intro., 4.

²⁰³ Aubin, *Majmū‘a*, 70.

²⁰⁴ Aubin, *Majmū‘a*, 70-71. ‘Abd al-Razzāq further notes that Ṣā‘in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn were forced to go to Herat due to the plotting of certain people diseased with egotistical desires.

to the latter, despite the fact that both men hailed from Kirman, and further exhibits a more fabulous streak. It is also concerned to establish Ni‘mat Allāh’s Shi‘i inclinations, which may suggest rather an early Safavid provenance. We know of the *Savāniḥ al-Ayyām* only through excerpts in Mufīd Mustawfī’s (fl. 1091/1680) *Jāmi‘-i Mufīdī*; the Safavid historian assures us that he has not tinkered overmuch with the text, but it is clear that he has amplified Ṣun‘ Allāh’s account with material from Shūshtarī’s (d. 1019/1610) *Majālis al-Mu‘minīn*.²⁰⁵

A passage in the *Savāniḥ al-Ayyām* renders the spiritual pedigree of Ni‘mat Allāh Valī into verse; most importantly for our purposes here, it identifies one Mīr Muḥammad Āftāb [Āftābī] as Ni‘mat Allāh’s master, whose master in turn was Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī.²⁰⁶ However accurate this account might be, it is certainly concerned to link Ni‘mat Allāh with Sayyid Ḥusayn to a degree greater than the *Tazkira* of ‘Abd al-Razzāq. It also presents Ni‘mat Allāh, Ṣā‘in al-Dīn, Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī and Qāsim-i Anvār as a tight-knit band of traveling companions, together with a shaykh known as Pīr Tāj Gīl.²⁰⁷

It has been reliably related that the saintly eminence [Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh Valī] met with Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī [at the latter’s house] on the bank of the Nile. The circumstances of that meeting may be briefly characterized as follows: During that period [Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh traveled to Egypt] in the company of Shāh Qāsim-i Anvār (that pearl in the ocean of the pious), his eminence Khwāja Ṣā‘in al-Dīn Turka, Mawlānā Sharaf al-Dīn ‘Alī Yazdī (that noblest and most excellent of scholars), and Pīr Tāj Gīl. When they arrived in the vicinity of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī’s residence, the latter became aware of their approach and directed his servants to invite them to take their ease in a guesthouse (*suffa*) near the Sayyid’s seclusion chamber, and sent them a platter of sweetmeats ahead of their meeting. But [Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh] said to those present, “It would be better to move to a different room,” and removed elsewhere with his four companions. As soon as they had exited the roof of that guesthouse collapsed—all were astonished.

After this had transpired Sayyid Ḥusayn emerged from his seclusion and first embraced [Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh] before receiving his companions. When they had all sat down together Sayyid Ḥusayn addressed that noble eminence: “Ni‘mat Allāh! I would benefit from your mystical states (*ḥālāt*).” But the latter remonstrated: “[I] from yours, from yours!” So Sayyid Ḥusayn demonstrated for them certain aspects of occult sciences

²⁰⁵ Aubin, *Majmū‘a*, intro., 7-8.

²⁰⁶ Aubin, *Majmū‘a*, 144-45; see also Farzām, *Tahqīq dar Ahvāl*, 45-46.

²⁰⁷ On Pīr Gīl (or Kīl), a disciple of Qāsim-i Anvār, see Bashir, *Sufi Bodies*, 97.

such as alchemy and the talismanic arts (*kīmiyā*, *hīmiyā*, *sīmiyā*). Shāh [Ni‘mat Allāh] said to Sayyid Ḥusayn [in reply]: “I can claim but the alchemy of Muḥammadan poverty.” ...

The next day Shāh [Ni‘mat Allāh] bade his companions farewell and set off for the Ka‘ba. After traveling some distance he sent a sealed box (*ḥuqqa’ī sar basta u muhr namūda*) back to Sayyid Ḥusayn by the hand of a dervish. Upon opening this box Sayyid Ḥusayn found in it a piece of cotton together with a burning flame. Amazed, he said: “A pity I did not benefit from Ni‘mat Allāh!”²⁰⁸

‘Abd al-Razzāq describes the same episode, giving more detail as to Sayyid Ḥusayn’s alchemical demonstration but omitting mention of Ni‘mat Allāh’s four companions or his miraculous sealed box of cotton and flame:

Sayyid Ḥusayn opened a window, and it appeared that the entire Nile had become blood. He then closed the window and opened it again, whereupon the river appeared to be a flow of severed hands and feet. He repeated the process, whereupon the river appeared to be milk. He repeated the process a [fourth] time, and the river was once again water. The holy eminence [Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh] said, “I do not have such states,” and promptly left.²⁰⁹

Both accounts exhibit a similar hagiographic strategy, seeking first to establish Akhlātī’s supremacy as master of the occult sciences, then reveal Ni‘mat Allāh to be greater still. ‘Abd al-Razzāq, however, does this by portraying Ni‘mat Allāh as being dismissive of Akhlātī’s occult powers, whereas Ṣun‘ Allāh counterposes Ni‘mat Allāh’s own wonderworking abilities.

While I have found no overt references to Ni‘mat Allāh Valī in Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s works that might support the picture presented above, there survives a letter in Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s correspondence that suggests the younger man’s respect for the great Sufi master. During the last phase of his life in Mahan, Ni‘mat Allāh visited Shiraz in 816/1413-14 at the invitation of Iskandar Mīrzā, then governor of Fars.²¹⁰ His visit appears to have bracketed Shāhrukh’s campaign in western Iran and removal of Iskandar from power, as Ṣā’in al-Dīn sent a letter from

²⁰⁸ Mufīd Mustawfī, *Jāmi‘-i Mufīdī*, 3/16-17; Aubin, *Majmū‘a*, 156-57.

²⁰⁹ Aubin, *Majmū‘a*, 38.

²¹⁰ Algar, “Ni‘mat-allāhiyya,” *El*². Ni‘mat Allāh also occasionally visited Yazd and Taft during this period, so presumably would have continued to cross paths with Ṣā’in al-Dīn there.

Isfahan to Yazd to be communicated to Shāhrukh by Ni‘mat Allāh in reply to Shāhrukh’s summons to attend his court. That Ṣā‘in al-Dīn sought the mediation of Ni‘mat Allāh in this regard is significant; given his close association with Iskandar’s court, he no doubt felt his position in the expanding Shahrukhid state to be tenuous and thought it prudent to protect himself with the eminence of the Sufi master. In this letter Ṣā‘in al-Dīn is accordingly at pains to convey his admiration and well-wishing to the newly-ascendant Shāhrukh, and assures the ruler that he will soon attend his court.²¹¹

Finally, Ni‘mat Allāh and Ṣā‘in al-Dīn were similarly the objects of later 9th/15th century Naqshbandi distaste, though for different reasons, as reflected in Jāmī’s deliberate omission of both figures (as well as Sharaf al-Dīn) from his *Nafaḥāt al-Uns*.²¹²

In contrast to Rashīd al-Dīn’s theologically-driven and rather tentative scholarly foray into the properties of the letters, Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh’s lettrist treatises are overtly Sufi in treatment and terminology. They manifest a particular interest in astrological correspondences and macrocosmic-microcosmic relations. Moreover, the author at times uses imagery that reflects his passion for agriculture, which he called ‘the true alchemy.’²¹³ While heavily indebted to the highly technical mystical theory of the Ibn ‘Arabī school, Ni‘mat Allāh’s Persian writing style is very simple and direct, and typically prosimetrical; he frequently provides lists of conceptual equivalencies or correspondences. I summarize his main lettrist treatises below, providing occasional translated excerpts that exemplify his method and style.²¹⁴

²¹¹ TMN/M f. 148a, TMN/MS pp. 11-12, TMN/D pp. 170-73; see §2.1.3.1 above, letter no. 16.

²¹² See Binbaş, “Sharaf al-Dīn,” 86; Algar, “Ni‘mat-allāhiyya,” *El*². Cf. Jāmī’s dismissive comments with respect to Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī as recorded in the *Maqāmāt-i Jāmī* of ‘Abd al-Vāsī’ Niẓāmī Bākhārī (106-7; the passage is translated in §8.2.2 below). Note that Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī appears to have had connections to the Ni‘matullāh family in Taft as well, although Binbaş concludes that their relationship was likely no more than one of “co-existence between local dignitaries” (“Sharaf al-Dīn,” 83).

²¹³ Algar, “Ni‘mat-allāhiyya,” *El*².

²¹⁴ For a brief discussion of the contents of his lettrist treatises see Farzām, *Tahqīq dar Aḥvāl*, 256, 405-7, 478-80, 485-6, 502-3.

1. R. Ḥurūf (I)²¹⁵

A brief introduction to the quranic *muqatta'āt* featured at the head of 29 suras. After listing these in full, Ni'mat Allāh asserts that knowledge of the esoteric meaning of these letters is a prerequisite to becoming the *khalīfa* of God. He then cites Q 4:171, *His Word that He committed to Mary, and a spirit from Him*. Ni'mat Allāh defines 'Word' as used in this verse as the spiritual reality of Jesus, deriving from the self-manifestation of the Breath of the All-merciful (*nafasiyya-yi raḥmāniyya*). Sufis, he says, hold Gabriel to be the natural spirit animating the world of the elements. In one sense, then, Jesus represents the spiritual form of Gabriel, and Mary the greater elemental form, with Gabriel accordingly representing physical bodies. His station is the lote tree of the furthest extent (*sidrat al-muntahā*), which occupies a liminal position (*maqām-i barzakhi*) between the elemental world of nature (*'ālam-i ṭabī'at-i 'unṣuriyya*) and the universal world of nature (*'ālam-i ṭabī'at-i kulliyya*).

The author proceeds to list all 28 Arabic letters and identify them according to element; thus A is fiery, B is earthy, T is airy, Th is watery, J is fiery, and so on, there being seven letters pertaining to each element. This is followed by a list of the signs of the zodiac identified according to element: Aries is fiery, Taurus is earthy, Gemini is airy, Cancer is watery, Leo is fiery, etc. These correspondences may be manipulated by the adept to whatever end he desires.

2. R. Ḥarf²¹⁶

In this treatise Ni'mat Allāh lists symbolic correspondences and equivalencies relating to the letters as well as between various Sufi concepts in a direct and elementary style, dealing with

²¹⁵ *Maktūbāt*, 768-69.

²¹⁶ *Maktūbāt*, 770-75.

such topics as prophethood (*nubuvva*) vs. sainthood (*valāya*), angelology, etc. All pivots on the *ẓāhir-bāṭin* binary. The first half of the work is concerned with letters, the second half more general in its concerns; it concludes with a mystical discussion of the five pillars and related spiritual exercises.

A notable feature of this short work is the author's use of agricultural symbolism to make his points, making several references to planting, seeds and irrigation. A representative passage:

Muḥammad is the ocean into which feeds all other seas, i.e., earlier prophets; they in turn were fed by lesser prophets and saints, representing rivers, who in turn were fed by Companions and Followers and scholars, representing streams or canals. The untutored masses are the earth which is irrigated by these canals; if fertile it will bear fruit, but if barren the water will bring no benefit.²¹⁷

3. *R. Taḥqīqāt-i Hurūf*¹⁸

A prosimetrical list of the letters with their associated macrocosmic values. The author opens with this premise:

In both knowledge (*ilm*) and in entity (*ayn*) the cosmos is the site wherein the human reality manifests, this reality in turn serving as the site of manifestation for the divine names. The fixed entities (*a'yān-i sābita*) are part of the human entity, and all spiritual, imaginal and sensory forms are but forms of the human reality; all spirits are parts (*juz'īyyāt*) of the supreme human spirit (*rūḥ-i a'zam-i insānī*). For this reason God's folk call the cosmos the Great Man (*insān-i kabīr*) [or macrocosm].²¹⁹

As a representative example, Ni'mat Allāh's treatment of *H*:

²¹⁷ *Maktūbāt*, 773-74.

²¹⁸ *Maktūbāt*, 776-84.

²¹⁹ *Maktūbāt*, 776.

To the Real (be He exalted) belongs absolute perfection in preeternity; to the cosmos belongs absolute perfection in temporality. To comprehensive engendered being belongs absolute perfection in both preeternity and temporality.

In its temporality and preeternity see its perfection
see its beauty, see its majesty.²²⁰

On Q:

The manifest aspect of the cosmos is the site of manifestation of the Real's name the Manifest (*al-ẓāhir*), and its hidden aspect the site of manifestation of the Real's name the Hidden (*al-bāṭin*). The name the Manifest brings about the manifestation of the cosmos; the name the Hidden brings about its occultation (*buṭūn*). The two names mutually differ in that the first represents Lordship (*rubūbiyyat*) while the second represents subjecthood (*marbūbiyyat*), yet from the perspective of the reality of realities (*ḥaqīqat al-ḥaqā'iq*) the manifest is identical to the hidden and the hidden identical to the manifest. *He is the First and the Last, the Outward and the Inward; He has knowledge of everything* (Q 57:3).

He is our lover—yet also our beloved
our seeker—and our sought.²²¹

4. R. Asrār-i Ḥurūf²²²

This short treatise may be translated in full:

Friend, recite well the *basmala*
seek all you desire in the *basmala*.

My brother (God support you with His holy spirit), may it be known to you that the divine names are infinite, yet the keys to [all these] names lie in the spoken form of the letters. The existence (*inniyyat*) of the names is thus in the letters; the existence of the letters in the breath (*anfās*); the existence of the human breath in the spirit (*arvāḥ*); the existence of the spirit in the heart; and the existence of the heart belongs to the Turner of Hearts (*muqallib-i qulūb*). The multiplicity (*ta'addud*, *takassur*) of the names of the Real becomes apparent in their sites of manifestation, but with respect to the Real Himself (His majesty be exalted) there is neither multiple nor single (*na'adad ast va na vāḥid*).

Singularity and multiplicity—know they're both subjective (*i'tibārī*)

²²⁰ *Maktūbāt*, 776.

²²¹ *Maktūbāt*, 778.

²²² *Maktūbāt*, 785-86.

thusly read the transcript of reason.

A is the origin of the letters, and its upright straight (*mustaqīm*) motion derives from its self-subsistence (*qayyūmiyyat*). The self-subsistent (*qayyūm*) exists without subsisting through anything else—all else subsists through it.

It must be Living (*ḥayy*) and Self-subsistent
for all the world subsists and persists through its presence.

Now someone may ask why the letters are 28 in number:

Hear well my gnostic answer
which should be obvious to the knowledgeable:

The letters' entities, which manifest in the world of elements (*'ālam-i 'unṣurī*), bear a connection to those elements; although there are many causes (*sabab*), the elements are the most immediate of them all. The elements are temporally originated from the motions of the spheres, and these latter are divided into 28 houses. The production of letters from a breathing individual (*mutanaḥḥis*) is by means of his breath. [Thus produced], they still retain a correspondence (*munāsabat*) to the elements; human breath involves expelling hot air from within to without and drawing in cold air from without to within. The cosmos originated from the breath of the All-merciful (*nafas al-Raḥmān*), by which all things are brought from the unseen (*ghayb*) to the visible (*shahādat*) and returned from the visible to the unseen. Given its correspondence to the elements, human breath takes form according to the celestial houses (*manāzil-i falakiyya*) and manifests on the most perfect plane of the products of the 28 letterforms (*akmal-i nash'a-yi muvalladāt-i ṣuvar-i ḥurūf-i bīst u hasht*) as derived from the 28 houses.

The *lām-alif* combination, corresponding to the lunar node (*jawzahar*) (i.e., between two circles that are moving apart), signifies that which is traversing these houses—the planets (*kavākib-i sayyāra*).

It is said that the letters of the Names are the angels that govern (*mudabbirān*) spiritual beings (*malā'ika-yi rūḥāniyyāt*) in the realm of spirits, these letters being the bodies of these angels; the letters thus exert their effect on the spirits, not on sensible forms. The various ranks of the angels of spiritual beings is according to the the order of the letters, this being in my view dependent on their respective points of articulation (*makhārij*). The first point of articulation is occupied by the letter *H* (or some say *hamza*), and the last by *W*; the highest of the angels thus has the name *hā*, the lowest the name *wāw*.²²³

The construction of words in the human transcript (*nuskha-yi insāniyya*) goes from two-letter to five-letter, whether conjoined or detached. The divine Speech that has been revealed thus builds from letter, to word, to verse, to sura, to suras, to book.

The Perfect Man—i.e., that comprehensive engendered being (*kawn-i jāmi'*) that encompasses all universal properties of necessity (*aḥkām-i vujūb-i kullīyya*) and of possibility (*imkāniyya*)—is a revealed Book (*kitābī-st nāṭiq*): *Not a thing fresh or withered but it is in a Book manifest* (Q 6:59).

²²³ Cf. R. dar Asrār al-Ḥurūf, in *Maktūbāt*, 790–91, where Ni'mat Allāh gives the letters' order in verse: "Hamza and hā, 'ayn and ḥā, ghayn and khā/ qāf and kāf, jīm and shīn and also yā/ dād and lām, nūn and rā, tā and dāl/ tā and zā, sīn and ṣād, zā and thā/ dhāl and fā, bā and mīm and also wāw/ —remember thou my saying!"

Read well from this manifest Book
penetrate, like the gnostics, its meaning.

5. *R. dar Asrār al-Ḥurūf*²²⁴

In this somewhat longer treatise, Ni‘mat Allāh evinces particular interest in the astrological correspondences of the letters in the context of a discussion on the macrocosm; for example, he provides the following list of correspondences between various divine names, the 28 lunar mansions (*manāzil*) and their associated letters, as well as days of the week:

1. The Creator (*al-Badī*): the First Intellect, the letter ‘ [A], al-Sharaṭān [β γ Arietis].
2. The Resurrector (*al-Bā‘is*): the Preserved Tablet (i.e., the universal soul), the letter H, al-Buṭayn [ε δ ρ Arietis].
3. The Hidden (*al-Bāṭin*): universal nature (*ṭabī‘at-i kullīyya*), the letter ‘, al-Thurayyā [Pleiades].
4. The Last (*al-Ākhir*): the substance of dust (*jawhar-i habā*) (i.e., the universal matter (*hayūlā-yi kullī*)), the letter H, al-Dabarān [α Tauri].
5. The Manifest (*al-Zāhir*): the universal body (*jism-i kullī*), the letter Gh, al-Haq‘a (Ra’s al-Jawzā’) [λ φ¹ φ² Orionis].
6. The All-wise (*al-Ḥakīm*): shape (*shakl*), the letter Kh, al-Han‘a [γ ξ Geminorum].
7. The Encompassing (*al-Muḥīt*): the Throne (‘*arsh*), the letter Q, al-Dhirā’ [α β Geminorum].
8. The All-thankful (*al-Shakūr*): the Footstool (*kursī*), the letter K, al-Nathra [ε γ δ Cancrī].
9. The All-sufficient (*al-Ghanī*): the sphere of Atlas, the letter J, al-Ṭarf [χ Cancrī λ Leonis].
10. The Apportioner (*al-Muqaddir*): the sphere of the lunar mansions, the letter Sh, Jabhat al-Asad [ζ γ η α Leonis].
11. The Lord (*al-Rabb*): the sphere of Saturn (*kayvān*), Saturday, the letter Y, al-Kharātān [Zubra, δ θ Leonis].
12. The All-knowing (*al-‘Alīm*): the sphere of Jupiter, Thursday, the letter Ḍ, al-Ṣarfā [β Leonis].
13. The Omnipotent (*al-Qāhir*): the sphere of Mars (*bahrām*), Tuesday, the letter L, al-‘Awwā’ [β η γ δ ε Virginis].
14. The Light (*al-Nūr*): the sphere of the Sun (the heart of the heavens and residence of the pole of human spirits), the letter N, al-Simāk [α Virginis].
15. The Former (*al-Muṣawwir*): the fifth sphere, Friday, the letter R, al-Ghafr [ι κ λ Virginis].
16. The Reckoner (*al-Muḥṣī*): the sixth sphere, Wednesday, the letter Ṭ, al-Zubānā [α β Librae].
17. The Manifest (*al-Mubīn*): the sublunary sphere, Monday, the letter D, al-Iklīl [β δ π Scorpionis].

²²⁴ *Maktūbāt*, 788-801.

18. The Constrictor (*al-Qābiḍ*): ether (including comets and meteors), the letter *T*, Qalb al-Athīr [α Scorpionis].
19. The Living (*al-Ḥayy*): air (and all that manifests therein), the letter *Z*, al-Shawla [λ υ Scorpionis].
20. The Life-giver (*al-Muḥyī*): water (and all that manifests therein), the letter *S*, al-Naʿāʾim [γ δ ε η σ φ τ ζ Sagittarii].
21. The Slayer (*al-Mumīt*): earth (and all that manifests therein), the letter *Ṣ*, al-Balda [under π Sagittarii].
22. The Mighty (*al-ʿAzīz*): minerals, *Z*, Saʿd al-Dhābiḥ [α β Capricorni].
23. The All-provider (*al-Razzāq*): plants, the letter *Th*, [Saʿd] Bulaʿ [ν and μ Aquarii].
24. The Debaser (*al-Mudhill*): animals, the letter *Dh*, Saʿd al-Suʿūd [β ξ Aquarii c¹ Capricorni].
25. The All-strong (*al-Qawī*): angels, the letter *F*, Saʿd al-Akhbiya [γ π ζ η Aquarii].
26. The All-subtle (*al-Laṭīf*): jinn, the letter *B*, al-Fargh al-Muqaddam [α β Pegasi].
27. Allāh: man, the letter *M*, al-Fargh al-Muʾakhkhar [γ Pegasi α Andromedae].
28. The Lofty, Possessor of the Throne (*Raḥīm al-Darajāt Dhū l-ʿArsh*): levels of subjective affairs (*umūr-i iʿtibārīyya*), the letter *W* (the first perfect number), al-Rashā [Baṭn al-Ḥūt, β Andromedae].²²⁵

A few pages later the author reasserts knowledge of the meaning of the *muqattaʿāt* as a condition for attaining to the status of Perfect Man (*insān-i kāmīl*), when as microcosm one mirrors the order of the cosmos:

The perfect man has 28 waystations (*manāzil*), equal to the number of single letters; each of his waystations in turn comprises numerous other waystations. When [he attains] to the station of comprehensiveness of being (*maqām-i jamʿ-i vujūd*) various indications manifest that denote the Real—5,838 of them, to be precise. The Verifier (*muḥaqqiq*) thereupon assumes the office of deputy and vicegerent (*niyābat, khilāfat*) to the Real, for he has attained his knowledge not by study and instruction but by unveiling and direct sight, and therewith penetrates the meanings of the single letters that were revealed at the beginning of 29 quranic suras.²²⁶

6. R. Hā²²⁷

Here Niʿmat Allāh offers a series of short prosimetrical meditations on the divine pronoun *Huwa/Hu*, referring to the divine ipseity (*huviyyat*), with almost exclusive attention to the initial

²²⁵ *Maktūbāt*, 792–93. Star identifications are taken from Ullmann, *Die Natur- und Geheimwissenschaften*, 352.

²²⁶ *Maktūbāt*, 796.

²²⁷ *Maktūbāt*, 802–8.

hā. He first observes that the two letters *hā-wāw* encompass all of manifest and nonmanifest being inasmuch as *hā* originates at the deepest point of articulation, *wāw* at the outermost. As the most esoteric letter, *hā* represents a circle composed of the two bows (*qawsayn*) of Q 53:9, i.e., that of exclusive unity (*aḥadiyyat*) and inclusive unity (*vāḥidiyyat*), with the interior line as supreme *barzakh* and the Perfect Man.²²⁸

Another representative meditation: The word *nuqṭa* consists of four letters, which when tallied according to the *ḥisāb-i jummal-i ṣaghīr* method—*N* (50 > 5) + *Q* (100 > 10) + *Ṭ* (9) + *H* (5)—comes to 29, i.e., all the letters of the alphabet, including the *alif-lām* digraph. This is the meaning of ‘Alī’s statement: “Knowledge is a dot (*al-‘ilm nuqṭa*).”²²⁹

7. R. ‘Ayniyya²³⁰

Finally, in this short work Ni‘mat Allāh offers a brief, highly technical discussion centered on *alif* as the primal letter, consisting as it does of three dots. These three dots in turn represent the production of the fixed Muḥammadan entity (*‘ayn-i sābita-yi Muḥammadiyya*) from exclusive unity (*aḥadiyyat*) and inclusive unity (*vāḥidiyyat*).

4.3.3: Faḥl Allāh Astarābādī and gnostic-messianic lettrism

The lettrist thought of the 9th/15th century is associated in existing scholarship almost exclusively with the gnostic-messianic Sufi movement of Faḥl Allāh Astarābādī (d. 796/1394) that came to be known as the Ḥurūfiyya, together with the splinter group of Maḥmūd Pasīkhānī (d. 831/1428) known as the Nuḥṭaviyya, which, unlike the Ḥurūfiyya, survived into the Safavid

²²⁸ *Maktūbāt*, 802.

²²⁹ *Maktūbāt*, 805.

²³⁰ *Maktūbāt*, 809-10.

period. The reason for such scholarly interest is clear:²³¹ the Hurufis as a group are a prime representative of the resurgence of extremist Sufi-Shi'i messianism in Iran that characterizes this period, but unlike many of these messianic movements (e.g., the Nūrbakhshiyya,²³² the Musha'sha'iyya²³³) they take this energy to its logical extreme—hence Faḡl Allāh's proclamation of a new, universal, effectively post-Islamic dispensation centering on himself as messiah and Persian as the new language of revelation. Here it must be emphasized that the more extreme aspects of Hurufi doctrine do not appear to have been propounded by Faḡl Allāh himself but by his disciples after his death, animated as they were by the fervent expectation of the second coming of their leader; the founding document of Hurufism, Faḡl Allāh's *Jāvdān-nāma*, while certainly extremist (and extremely confusing) in some respects, itself remains largely within the ambit of late 8th/14th century Sufism.²³⁴ The desire to definitively break with Islam as the religion of the Arabs and inaugurate a new dispensation appears to be more explicit in the voluminous writings of Paṣīkhānī, who proclaimed himself the 'Persian soul' (*nafs-i 'ajamī*) and 'unique person' (*shakhṣ-i vāḥid*) of the new, Persian cycle (*dawr-i 'ajam*).²³⁵

On the level of cultural patterning, the Hurufis may be thought of as retrieving the type of gnostic-syncretist letter speculation that first emerges in the Islamic context with such figures

²³¹ For more on the Hurufis see the recent studies of Shahzad Bashir (*Fazlallah Astarabadi and the Hurufis*, "The Alphabetical Body," "Deciphering the Cosmos"), Orkhan Mir-Kasimov ("Étude de textes hurūfī anciens: l'oeuvre fondatrice de Fadlallāh Astarābādī," "The Hurūfī Moses," "Notes sur deux textes hurūfī"), Kathryn Babayan (*Mystics, Monarchs, and Messiahs*), Kathleen Burrill (*The Quatrains of Nesimī*), and 'Alī Mīr-Fiṭrūs ("Junbish-i Hurūfiya") in particular. Earlier studies include those of E. G. Browne ("Some Notes on the Literature and Doctrine of the Hurufi Sect," "Further Notes on the Literature of the Hurufi Sect"), Clément Huart (*Textes persans relatifs à la secte des houroûfis*), Helmut Ritter ("Studien zur Geschichte der islamischen Frömmigkeit"), Abdūlbāki Gölpınarlı (*Hurūfîlik Metinleri Kataloğu*), and Şādiq Kiyā (*Vāzha-nāma-yi Gurgānī*). On the Nuḡtavis see e.g. Şādiq Kiyā, *Nuḡtaviyān yā Paṣīkhāniyān*, and Abbas Amanat, "The Nuḡtawī Movement of Maḡmūd Paṣīkhānī."

²³² See Bashir, *Messianic Hopes and Mystical Visions*.

²³³ The Musha'sha'iyya were active in Arabistan (Khuzistan), and used magic and hermetic teachings to mesmerize followers and transform them into warriors impervious to pain (Tucker, *Mahdis*, 117-18).

²³⁴ See e.g. Mir-Kasimov, "*Jāvdān-nāma*," *Elr*.

²³⁵ Amanat, "The Nuḡtawī Movement," 285.

as al-Mughīra b. Saʿīd (d. 119/737) and Abū l-Khaṭṭāb (d. ca. 138/755), although Hurufi thought is of far greater sophistication than the latter's and reflects much of the intervening philosophical and mystical developments examined above.²³⁶ The popular success of Hurufism in its various iterations was, I argue, precisely due to the ubiquity of lettrism in Sufi, Sufi-Shīʿi and intellectual circles by the late 8th/14th century. Faḡl Allāh is nevertheless the first figure in the Islamic lettrist tradition to depose Arabic from its theretofore unassailable preeminence as the language of the Quran, the final revelation and faithful transcript of reality. Faḡl Allāh's revolutionary incorporation of the additional letters of the Perso-Arabic alphabet represents a definitive shift to Iran and to Persian as the language of the new dispensation.²³⁷ This feature harks back in some sense to the Khaṭṭābī doctrine of spiritual adoption, which opened the door to the spiritual empowerment of the *mawālī* vis-à-vis their Arab patrons, and is more than a little reminiscent of Shuʿūbī sentiments.²³⁸

Like Niʿmat Allāh Valī, Faḡl Allāh emerged from the Sufi milieu of the later 8th/14th century, one pregnant with millenarian rumblings. His early career as renowned dream interpreter and Sufi was, however, cut short by a shattering revelation that transformed him into a universal savior of dual natures: the reincarnation of Jesus (the final, Persian *kalām Allāh*) and the promised Mahdi from the line of the Prophet through his descent from the Imam Mūsā al-Kāẓim. His doctrine centers on elaborate numerological interpretations of the 32 letters of the Perso-Arabic alphabet and their correlation with the human form, and particularly the human face and its seven hair lines as locus of divine manifestation.²³⁹ He envisions three

²³⁶ Tucker, *Mahdis and Millenarians*, 120; see §4.1.1 above.

²³⁷ Faḡl Allāh equates the shift from Arabic to Persian with that from prophecy to divinity. In the new dispensation, moreover, the Arabic quranic text may be read as if it were Persian (Bashir, *Fazlallah*, 69–70).

²³⁸ Amanat, “The Nuḡṭawī Movement,” 285.

²³⁹ Algar, “Ḥurufism,” *Elr*. The correlation of the letters with the human form was to prove particularly popular in Bektashi circles as well, which may be said to have indirectly inherited the mantle of the

progressive cycles: that of prophethood (*nubuvvat*) from Adam to Muḥammad, followed by that of sainthood (*vilāyat/valāyat*) (higher than prophethood in that those possessing it disclose the inner meanings of prophetic revelation) from ‘Alī to Ḥasan al-‘Askarī/Faḡl Allāh (pre-revelation), and culminating with that of divinity (*ulūhiyyat*), essentially equivalent to the person of Faḡl Allāh (post-revelation) and continuing until the imminent apocalypse.²⁴⁰ Faḡl Allāh’s *Jāvdān-nāma* is thus considered to be the supreme esoteric exegesis of the Quran—which now may be read as a Persian, not Arabic, text—, and in fact supersedes it, as the Quran itself superseded earlier revelations. Despite this, Hurufism cannot be considered a variety of extremist Shi‘ism in that it does not divinize ‘Alī;²⁴¹ the entire emphasis is rather on Faḡl Allāh himself as Word, knowledge of whom constitutes paradise in this world, and ignorance of whom constitutes hell.

Temür, however, took a dim view of such extremist doctrine, and at his order Faḡl Allāh was imprisoned and executed by Mīrānshāh b. Temür at the fortress of Alinjaq in 796/1394. This was the genesis of a Hurufi cult of pilgrimage to Alinjaq and a ritualized antipathy toward the Timurid dynasty;²⁴² Shāhrukh’s rule in particular was punctuated by periodic Hurufi uprisings,²⁴³ and he accordingly persecuted the group as a threat to the state. As a result of this continued persecution the Ḥurūfiyya as such were relatively short-lived in Iran, yet survived in the Nuḡṭaviyya, its most significant offshoot, active in Iran and India through Safavid/Mughal

Hurufis in Anatolia and the Balkans (Mélikoff, *Hadji Bektach*, 52-55, 116-26, 235-40; Tschudi, “Bektashiyya,” *El’*; Usluer and Yıldız, “Hurufism Among Albanian Bektashis”).

²⁴⁰ Bashir, *Fazlallah*, 56. Hurufism (and Nuḡṭavism after it) may also be seen as continuing the tradition of Perso-Shi‘i dissent as exemplified by Nizari Isma‘ilism up to the 13th century, though we have little documentation of direct links between the two movements (Amanat, “The Nuḡṭawī Movement of Maḥmūd Pisikhānī,” 281-82).

²⁴¹ Cf. Rajab al-Bursī’s extremist Shi‘i lettrism, which does divinize ‘Alī; see §4.3 (218 n. 184) above.

²⁴² In particular, the site of his execution became the religious focal point, the new Ka‘ba, of the sect, with elaborate pilgrimage rituals based on Hurufi symbology (Bashir, *Fazlallah*, 41-42, 86-90; idem, “Enshrining Divinity”).

²⁴³ Including two in Isfahan and Tabriz in 835/1432, the year of Ṣā‘in al-Dīn’s death.

times.²⁴⁴ Due to certain similarities of doctrine sprung of preoccupation with Hurufi texts, the Bektāshīyya, active in Anatolia in the Balkans, are often taken as representing a vehicle of Hurufi influence to the northwest.²⁴⁵

Şā'in al-Dīn's own tribulations came about through the ease with which his establishment enemies were able to tar him with the Hurufi brush—this despite the fact that his lettrism is patently intellectual in orientation and confessionally mainstream, as the present chapter demonstrates. I noted above that Shāhrukh appears to have been more than happy to let this false association stand, and in 830/1427 used the pretext of the possibly staged assassination attempt by the Hurufi Aḥmad-i Lur to imprison, torture and exile Şā'in al-Dīn and expel from Herat other prominent individuals with claimed Hurufi sympathies.²⁴⁶ Given the irreparable damage the Hurufis did to his career and his lettrist project, then, Şā'in al-Dīn's feelings toward the group were understandably of bitter resentment and naked hostility. (I examine Şā'in al-Dīn's damning evaluation of the Hurufis in Chapter 8.) In general terms, then, Şā'in al-Dīn may be said to consciously synthesize the intellectual and Sufi approaches to lettrism, while execrating the popular-messianic, politically subversive and heterodox character of the Hurufi movement.

²⁴⁴ Algar, "Horufism," *Elr.* The Nuḡṭaviyya, or Pasīkhāniyya, founded by Maḥmūd Pasīkhānī (d. ca. 831/1427) who broke away from Faḡl Allāh due to ideological differences; in particular, he left aside the letters (*hurūf*) to concentrate on their dots (*nuḡṭas*), and exalted Persian to the status of universal language (Bashir, *Fazlallah*, 112-13). See Amanat, "The Nuḡṭawī Movement of Maḥmūd Pasīkhānī."

²⁴⁵ See e.g. Mélikoff, *Hadji Bektach*, 52-55, 116-26, 235-40; Bashir, *Fazlallah*, 115-22; Algar, "The Hurufi Influence on Bektashism"; De Jong, "The Iconography of Bektashism"; Tschudi, "Bektashīyya," *El'*; Usluer and Yıldız, "Hurufism Among Albanian Bektashis."

²⁴⁶ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 9, 114-19.

4.3.4: ‘Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī’s pedigrees

The present study unfortunately cannot attempt an account of occult philosophy and the occult sciences as pursued in the early 9th/15th century Ottoman context, which given their widespread popularity there would be to prise open a veritable Pandora’s box. I have remarked above (§I.3), however, that the Isfahan Circle in Iran and the Neo-Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’ in Anatolia represent two nodes of a single intellectual network whose members pursued the same universalist project, each according to his interests and abilities. This intellectual continuity is claimed by Ṣā’ in al-Dīn himself, who often complains that, while his writings are prized in Anatolia and India, regressive but powerful scholarly factions make it difficult to work in Iran.²⁴⁷ As previously stated, the Ottoman context is currently being studied by İhsan Fazlıoğlu and Cornell Fleischer, together with the latter’s Chicago Circle; most relevant materials remain in manuscript.

In particular, I suggested in Chapter 1 that the writings of Ṣā’ in al-Dīn’s younger counterpart in Anatolia, ‘Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī, promise to shed considerable light on the shared project of Ṣā’ in al-Dīn, Sharaf al-Dīn and their ‘Devoted Brethren’ to the northwest. I cannot hope to summarize his occult doctrine here; for the purposes of the present chapter, however, mention may be made of the *isnāds* and book titles ‘Abd al-Raḥmān lists at the beginning of his important lettrist work *Shams al-Āfāq fī ‘Ilm al-Ḥurūf wa-l-Awfāq*, which provide an overview of the state of lettrist instruction in Egypt and Syria in the late 8th/14th and early 9th/15th century. (It was shown above that at least two of the pedigrees found at the end of Pseudo-Būnī’s *Shams al-Ma‘ārif al-Kubrā* are taken from Bisṭāmī’s works, suggesting the high degree to which the two occultists were associated in the later lettrist tradition. In particular, the Būnī pedigree in the *kalimat al-shahāda* (§4.1.2.1, *isnād* A) clearly derives from that in Bisṭāmī’s *Shams al-Āfāq*, *isnād* A.1 below; and the Būnī pedigree in *‘ilm al-ḥurūf* (*isnād* C) is almost

²⁴⁷ See e.g. “Nafṣat al-Maṣdūr II,” 209-10.

identical to that in an early copy of Bisṭāmī's *al-'Ujāla fī Ḥall al-Anmāṭ al-Mu'arrafa bi-Jam' Abī al-'Abbās Aḥmad*.²⁴⁸) Ṣā'in al-Dīn may be supposed to have studied most if not all of the same texts that 'Abd al-Raḥmān mentions, but he is far more reticent than the latter about the course of his education in the occult sciences. Indeed, Ṣā'in al-Dīn declines to identify himself with any teacher but Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī, and only mentions Ibn 'Arabī and Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī as his textual sources in the *Mafāḥiṣ*—other lettrist writings being but “toughened, jerked meat.”²⁴⁹ Reiterating this theme, in the *R. Ḥurūf* he justifies his failure to cite any earlier authorities by characterizing their treatments of the subject as “frequently stale and timeworn.”²⁵⁰ 'Abd al-Raḥmān, by contrast, is eager to show in detail his place in the western lettrist tradition.

A. Genealogy of the science in the Islamic west:

1. Bisṭāmī's pedigree in the study of *'ilm al-ḥurūf wa-l-awfāq*.²⁵¹

1. Abū 'Abd Allāh Muḥammad b. Muḥammad b. Ya'qūb al-Kūmī al-Tūnisī al-Mālikī (d. 810/1407)²⁵²
2. Abū l-'Abbās al-Dahhān/Dahhānī
3. Abū l-'Abbās al-Khārimī/Jārimī²⁵³
4. Abū l-'Azā'im Māḍī [b. Sulṭān]²⁵⁴
5. Abū l-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī (d. 656/1258)
6. Abū Muḥammad 'Abd al-Salām b. Bashshīsh al-Ḥasanī al-Fāsī
7. Abū Muḥammad 'Abd al-Raḥmān al-Madanī
8. then from *quṭb* to *quṭb* back to
9. al-Ḥasan b. 'Alī, first of the *quṭbs*

²⁴⁸ Süleymaniye MS Bağdatlı Vehbi 930 ff. 6b-7a (836/1433) (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 36-37).

²⁴⁹ MS Majlis 10106 ff. 52a, 53b..

²⁵⁰ MS Majlis 10196 f. 157a, MS Majlis 10004 p. 51; see Part 2, §T.2.2 for a translation of this treatise.

²⁵¹ MS Adnan Ötüken 1005 f. 7a.

²⁵² Cf. Būnī's *isnād* for the *kalimat al-shahāda*, which features al-Kūmī as the most recent link (A1).

²⁵³ MS Carullah 1543/1 ff. 5b-6a, representing an abridged copy of Bisṭāmī's *Rashḥ Adhwāq al-Hikma* featuring a briefer version of the same *isnād*, appears to read 'al-Jāfī' (Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge?” 37).

²⁵⁴ Cf. MS Carullah 1543/1 ff. 5b-6a, 'Abū l-'Azā'im Māḍī b. Sulṭān'; and cf. Būnī's *isnād* for the *kalimat al-shahāda*, §4.1.2.1.A2.

10. Muḥammad

2. Biṣṭāmī's lettrist studies in Alexandria, Cairo and Damascus²⁵⁵:

- A. Cairo, 807/1404-5, with the late 'Izz al-Dīn Muḥammad Ibn Jamā'a al-Shāfi'ī al-Dimashqī [d. 819/1416, son of Badr al-Dīn, chief preacher/judge].²⁵⁶
 1. Abū l-'Abbās al-Būnī, *al-Lum'a al-Nūrāniyya fī l-Awrād al-Rabbāniyya*²⁵⁷
 2. Jamāl al-Dīn Yūsuf al-Nadrūmī al-Maghribī (fl. 807/1404-5), *Qabas al-Anwār wa-Jāmi' al-Asrār*²⁵⁸
- B. Cairo, 808/1405-6, with Abū l-Ṭāhir Muḥammad al-Miṣrī:
 1. Ya'īsh al-Umawī al-Maghribī (fl. late 8th/14th-early 9th/15th c.), *Kayfiyyat al-Ittiḥāq fī Tarkīb al-Awfāq*²⁵⁹
- C. Alexandria, 811/1408-9, with Abū Muḥammad 'Abd al-Raḥmān al-Maghribī²⁶⁰:
 1. Muḥammad b. Muḥammad b. Ya'qūb al-Kūmī al-Tūnisī (d. 810/1407), *Taysīr al-Maṭālib*²⁶¹
- D. Damascus, 815/1412-13, with Musā'id b. Sārī b. Mas'ūd b. 'Abd al-Raḥmān al-Hawārī al-Ḥimyarī:²⁶²
 1. Muḥammad al-Kūmī al-Tūnisī, *Taysīr al-Maṭālib*

²⁵⁵ MS Adnan Ötügen 1005 ff. 7a-7b.

²⁵⁶ Cf. Būnī's *isnād* for *'ilm al-awfāq*, D1².

²⁵⁷ Biṣṭāmī wrote a commentary on the same entitled *Rashḥ Adhwāq al-Ḥikma al-Rabbāniyya*.

²⁵⁸ Shaykh 'Izz al-Dīn studied this work with its author.

²⁵⁹ Shaykh Abū l-Ṭāhir studied this work with its author.

²⁶⁰ Imam of the Friday mosque on the west side of the city.

²⁶¹ Shaykh Abū Muḥammad studied this work with its author. According to the copy in MS Majlis 12501/2 ff. 6b-43a, this work opens with an introduction on the science of fraction of numeration (*'ilm al-kasr* [or: *al-taksīr*] *wa-l-baṣṭ*), a technique of letter magic. Specifically, the practitioner "unjoins the letters of one of the divine names and intersperses them with the letters of the word(s) designating his goal in a single line, then, performing an operation known to initiates, rearranges the order of the letters on two lines. This is repeated until the first line is in order, and from it is taken the names of the angels and the supplications used to address them. The practitioner then continues these supplications until the goal is achieved" (Ḥājji Khalīfa, *Kashf al-Zunūn*, 2/1475).

²⁶² Apparently then resident in the village of شيبا. Biṣṭāmī states that while in Damascus he also saw the *quṭb* of Syria, and had a dream there in 815/1412 in which he beheld the Prophet stroking his chin (? *yusarriḥu dhaqana-hu*), and saw him again in a second dream the same night.

2. Muḥammad al-Kūmī al-Tūnisī, *al-Īmā' ilā 'ilm al-Asmā'*
3. *Sirr al-Jamāl*
4. *al-Kanz al-Bāhir fī Sharḥ Ḥurūf al-Malik al-Zāhir*
5. *Izhār al-Kunūz wa-Ibdā' al-Rumūz*²⁶³
6. Muḥammad al-Kūmī al-Tūnisī, *R. al-Huwa*²⁶⁴

Immediately apparent is the fact that the texts and teachers 'Abd al-Raḥmān mentions in these lists are predominantly Maghribi or Syrian. Notably, he fails to mention Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī, who had died in 799/1397, some nine years before the Cairo trip 'Abd al-Raḥmān notes here.²⁶⁵ The dates given in this list suggest that 'Abd al-Raḥmān is likely to have overlapped with Ṣā'in al-Dīn in Cairo in 807-8/1405-6, since the latter only returned to Isfahan after Temür's death in 807/1405, and perhaps as late as 810/1408. Finally, it will be noted that Muḥammad al-Kūmī al-Tūnisī (d. 810/1407) appears to have figured as major lettrist authority of the period.

At the end of the *Shams al-Āfāq* Biṣṭāmī gives a list of those Sufis who discussed the objective of assuming the divine attributes signified by the Names in justification of his practical approach to the same (*takhalluq bi-asmā' Allāh*):²⁶⁶ Abū l-Qāsim al-Qushayrī (d. 465/1073), Abū l-Ḥakam Ibn Barrajān (d. 536/1141), Abū Ḥāmid al-Ghazālī (d. 505/1111), Abū l-'Abbās al-Iqlīshī,²⁶⁷ and Abū l-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī (d. 656/1258).

²⁶³ Nos. 3-5 are perhaps also by Muḥammad al-Kūmī.

²⁶⁴ Musā'id b. Sārī studied this text with the author.

²⁶⁵ 'Abd al-Raḥmān does, however, mention Akhlāṭī in his *Naẓm al-Sulūk* (Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 141).

²⁶⁶ MS Adnan Ötüken 1005 f. 236a.

²⁶⁷ Presumably to be identified with Abū l-Qāsim al-Iqlīshī al-Andalusī, who wrote a treatise on *khawāṣṣ al-ḥurūf* (Ahlwardt, *Verzeichniss*, no. 4132; Maddison and Savage-Smith, *Science, Tools & Magic*, 1/66).

In another work, *K. al-Durra al-Nāsi'a*, Biṣṭāmī is concerned to legitimize lettrism by adducing the ancient authorities for the science, adding to this list a second of more recent (primarily Maghribi) lettrists.²⁶⁸ These lists may be summarized as follows:²⁶⁹

A. Ancient and earlier Muslim authorities

1. Āṣaf b. Barakhyā b. Shamū'īl, Solomon's vizier, to whom three books are attributed: *al-Jafr al-Jāmi' wa-l-Nūr al-Lāmi'*, *Sifr al-Khafāyā*, *K. Dhāt al-Dawā'ir wa-l-Ṣuwar*
2. *Sifr Ādam*
3. *Sifr Shūth*
4. *Sifr Nūh*
5. *Sifr Ibrāhīm*
6. Hermes Trismegistus (*Hirmis al-Harāmisa*), *K. Kanz al-Asrār wa-Dhakhā'ir al-Abrār*²⁷⁰
7. The *Sharḥ* of Tankalūshā al-Bābilī
8. The *Sharḥ*s of Thābit b. Qurra al-Ḥarrānī and Ḥunayn b. Isḥāq al-'Abbādī, on magic squares and letter magic
9. Zarathustra (*Zarādusht al-Fārisī*), *K. al-Zand*; a contemporary of Moses and the prophet of fire
10. Ptolemy (*Baṭlīmūs*), *K. al-Thamara*; he propounded the theory of precession of the equinoxes
11. Aristotle, *K. al-Astumātīs* and *K. al-Ahtumākḥīs*, wherein he mentions four talismans
12. Kītāsh the Indian, *K. al-Ashnūṭās* and *K. al-Mallātīs*; he is said to have invented talismans (*nīranjāt*) and lived for 840 years
13. The book (*kitāb*) of Eudemus of Rhodes (? *Hardīmūs*)
14. *K. al-Afālīq*
15. The book of Sarāsīm al-Hindī
16. The book of Saqba b. Dāmīr al-Hindī, said to have invented chess for king Bahrām
17. Nīhālīs the Sage, *K. al-Sirr al-Khafī*; he is the first to philosophize in Egypt and to recover sunken ships through divine inspiration
18. *Kitāb al-Zarādusht*, on numerology, wherein is described the *wafq muthannā* (2x2 magic square)
19. The secret book (*khāfiya*) of Sāmūr b. Asnū' al-Hindī
20. The secret book of the divine Plato
21. Archimedes (*Arsamīdis*) the Sage, *K. Sirr al-Khafī*; he was the first to make fire-throwing machines
22. Pythagoras the Sage, *K. Sirr al-Asrār wa-Nūr al-Anwār*; his birth of a virgin is said to have been predicted by monks, and he is credited with laying down the principles of music in accordance with the rhythms of celestial movements

²⁶⁸ This concern to show the ancientness of the occult sciences is even more endemic to Renaissance occult thought.

²⁶⁹ MS Hafid Efendi 461 ff. 254b-56a. For a fuller discussion of these lists and references see Masad, "Medieval Islamic Apocalyptic," 108-17.

²⁷⁰ See Kevin van Bladel, *The Arabic Hermes*, for more on Hermes' ubiquitous role in Arabic and Persian occultist writings.

23. The secret book of Imām Ja‘far al-Šādiq
24. The book of Sufyān al-Thawrī
25. The book of Jābir b. Ḥayyān al-Šūfī
26. al-Sakkākī, *K. al-Shāmil*
27. *Kitāb Sādāt*
28. Shihāb al-Dīn Suhrawardī, *K. al-Shih*

This list is immediately followed by another identifying works written primarily according to the Maghribi lettrist tradition:²⁷¹

B. Maghribi authorities

1. *al-Jafr al-Jāmi‘*, as used to devise a table listing the kings of Egypt
2. Abū l-‘Abbās al-Būnī, *K. Shams al-Ma‘ārif wa-l-Laṭā‘if al-‘Awārif* and nine other works
3. Ibn ‘Arabī, *al-Mabādī‘ wa-l-Ghāyāt fī Asrār al-Ḥurūf* and *Baḥr al-Wuqūf fī ‘Ilm al-Ḥurūf*
4. The *Kanz al-Ḥurūf* of the prophet Idrīs, as used by Aristotle to teach Alexander and explained by Ibn Sab‘īn
5. Abū l-Ḥasan al-Ḥarrānī,²⁷² *Shams Maṭālī‘ al-Qulūb*; this master of letters deciphered the divine names for the Sufi master Abū l-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī
6. Abū ‘Abd Allāh b. Ya‘īsh al-Umawī, *Kayfiyyat al-Ittifāq fī Tarkīb al-Awfāq*,²⁷³ *Lawāmi‘ al-Ta‘rif fī Maṭālī‘ al-Taṣrīf* and *al-Mawāhib al-Rabbāniyya fī l-Asrār al-Rūḥāniyya*; he also explained the *K. Kanz al-Asrār* [of Hermes]
7. al-Jurjānī, *Asrār al-Ḥurūf* and *Muhjat al-Āfāq fī ‘Ilm al-Awfāq*
8. Abū l-‘Abbās al-Sabtī,²⁷⁴ *K. al-Zā‘irja*; it is possible to derive the science of alchemy and other sciences from this book
9. Several unattributed books: *al-Durr al-Manẓūm*,²⁷⁵ *al-‘Iqd al-Manẓūm*, *Asās al-‘Ulūm*, *al-Kanz al-Bāhir*,²⁷⁶ *Lawāmi‘ al-Burūq*, *Izhār al-Rumūz wa-lbdā‘ al-Kunūz*
10. [Jamāl al-Dīn Yūsuf al-Nadrūmī al-Maghribī], *Qabas al-Anwār* [wa-jāmi‘ al-Asrār]
11. The [Tafsīr] of Ibn Barrajjān²⁷⁷

²⁷¹ MS Hafid Efendi 461 ff. 256a-57a.

²⁷² This individual is perhaps to be identified with Abū l-Ḥasan al-Ḥarrālī, one of Būnī’s teachers; see §4.1.2.1, F.2 above.

²⁷³ Bisṭāmī studied this text in Cairo in 808/1405-6 with Abū l-Ṭāhir Muḥammad al-Miṣrī.

²⁷⁴ To be identified with Aḥmad b. Muḥammad b. Ṭāhir al-Ḥusaynī al-‘Alawī, a contemporary of Lisān al-Dīn Ibn al-Khaṭīb (713-76/1313-75) and the last sayyid of Sabta (Ceuta) (“Zāyija,” *Dihkhudā, Lughatnāma*).

²⁷⁵ Perhaps to be identified with the *al-Durr al-Naẓīm* of ‘Abd Allāh al-Tamīmī al-Yāfi‘ī (d. Mecca 768/1367); see §4.4.4 below.

²⁷⁶ In the *K. Shams al-Āfāq* Bisṭāmī gives its full title as *al-Kanz al-Bāhir fī Sharḥ Ḥurūf al-Malik al-Zāhir*, perhaps written by Muḥammad al-Kūmī al-Tūnisī (MS Adnan Ötügen 1005 f. 7b).

²⁷⁷ Masad states that this title is illegible in the MS.

Later in the same treatise Bisṭāmī identifies the five distinct sources from which one may receive the science of letters, together with the authorities associated with each:²⁷⁸

1. Divine inspiration (*al-waḥy al-rabbānī*), vouchsafed to the prophets (e.g., Adam, Moses, Idrīs/Enoch, Jesus)
2. Full unveiling and direct transmission (*al-kashf al-ṣarīḥ wa-l-naql al-ṣaḥīḥ*), vouchsafed to the members of the House of the Prophet
3. Clear unveiling and transcendent speculation (*al-kashf al-jalī wa-l-fikr al-‘alī*), experienced by the mystics (e.g., Sufyān al-Thawrī, Abū Bakr al-Shalabī, Sahl b. ‘Abd Allāh al-Tustarī, Dhū l-Nūn al-Miṣrī)
4. Reliable transmission and wide comparison [of sources] (*al-samā‘ al-shāfi‘ wa-l-qiyās al-wāfi‘*), the approach of scholars (e.g., Abū Bakr al-Bāqillānī, al-Ghazālī,²⁷⁹ al-Ṭabarī, Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī)
5. Visions, dreams, physiognomy and inspirations (*ru’yā, manāmāt, firāsa, ilhāmāt*), the route used by ancient sages (e.g., Hermes, Pythagoras, Plato, Archimedes)

It may be noted parenthetically that ‘Abd al-Raḥmān’s characterization of Hermes as an ancient sage or philosopher rather than a prophet had become standard in the Islamic context by the 5th/11th and 6th/12th centuries.²⁸⁰ The ubiquity of Hermes as the ‘prophet’ of science (particularly astrology and alchemy) in later Islamic intellectual history is due in particular to the recognition accorded him by the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’ as an authority on a par with other prophets and philosophers. The *Ṣiwān al-Ḥikma* (4th/10th c.) and al-Mubashshir b. Fātik’s *Mukhtār al-Ḥikam* (wr. 440/1049), gnomological histories of the ancient sages, assign Hermes to the same category as Plato and Aristotle, thereby leading to his integration into the history of

²⁷⁸ MS Hafid Efendi ff. 274a-74b.

²⁷⁹ As Masad observes, Ghazālī is often identified as a lettrist in the tradition perhaps as early as the 7th/13th century, e.g., in a summary of a chapter from *K. Qabas al-Asrār*, attributed to Būnī (MS Hamidiyye 189 f. 238b); other names given in this summary include Ja‘far b. Yaḥyā, Ibn Sab‘īn, Idrīs al-Shiblī, al-Sabtī al-Ḥallāj, Inādiqlis (Anbāduqlis, Empedocles), Luqmān, Fīthāghūruth (Pythagoras), Tālīs, ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib, and Būnī himself (ff. 237b-38b; Masad, “Medieval Islamic Apocalyptic,” 116 n. 45). Cf. Bisṭāmī’s inclusion of Ghazālī in a list of Sufis who discussed the objective of assuming the divine attributes signified by the Names (*takhalluq bi-asmā’ Allāh*) (*Shams al-Āfāq*, MS Adnan Ötügen 1005 f. 236a). On the misattribution of works on occult sciences to Ghazālī, see Emilie-Savage-Smith, “Magic and Islam,” in Maddison and Savage-Smith, *Science, Tools & Magic*, 1/66, cat. 21, no. 4; and §4.4.4 below.

²⁸⁰ European Renaissance occultists seem to have regarded Hermes more as a prophetic figure; reflecting the general consensus of hermetic circles, for example, Ficino “seems to have believed that all great learning came ultimately from either the tradition begun by Moses or that begun by Hermes” (Lehrich, *The Occult Mind*, 4).

philosophy proper. Suhrawardī (d. 587/1191) appears to have been the first Arabic philosopher to recognize Hermes as an important intellectual forebear and spiritual ancestor. Hermes also became a standard figure in Persian poetry; in his *Iqbāl-nāma*, for instance, the learned Niẓāmī Ganjavī (d. ca. 605/1209) associates him with Aristotle, Apollonius, Socrates, Plato, Valens and Porphyry.²⁸¹

4.4: Intellectual lettrism in the later Timurid and early Safavid periods: Ibn Turka's legacy

Given the relatively undeveloped state of research, it is beyond the scope of this study to evaluate the later fate of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's brand of intellectual lettrism in Iran with any thoroughness. However, mention may be made of several sources—sources which quote Ṣā'in al-Dīn on occasion—that suggest its vital persistence into at least the beginning of the 10th/16th century. Furthermore, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's image as a preeminent lettrist of the first half of the 9th/15th century and chief disciple of Akhlāṭī is confirmed in some of these sources.

That the intellectual approach to lettrism promoted by Ṣā'in al-Dīn and the Isfahan Circle was not unattractive to other thinkers in the later Timurid period, this despite the misadventures of Hurufism, may be seen in the example of two thinkers in particular: Ḥusayn Vā'iz Kāshifī and Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī.

4.4.1: Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī and intellectual lettrism in the mid-9th/15th century

In this section I will briefly examine the philosopher and theologian Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī's (830-908/1427-1503) forays into this science in his *R. Tuḥfa-yi Rūḥānī fī Khavāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf* and *R. Tahlīliyya* as evidence of the continuation of intellectual lettrism in late 9th/15th and early 10th/16th century Iran in mainstream scholarly circles.

²⁸¹ Van Bladel, *The Arabic Hermes*, 222-33.

1. *R. Tuḥfa-yi Rūḥānī fī Khavāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf*

Reza Pourjavady has recently established that out of some 80 surviving works on diverse topics ranging from philosophy, theology and ethics to astronomy, Sufism and legal theory, Davānī devoted a separate treatise to the science of letters,²⁸² together with a relevant section in his *R. Tahlīliyya* (a commentary on *lā ilāha illā Llāh*).²⁸³ It should be noted that the copy of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *R. Nuqṭa* preserved in MS Markazī 1021/14 ff. 112b-16b is also misattributed to Davānī by the cataloger of the Mishkāṭ collection and by Ismā'īl Vā'iz Javādī.²⁸⁴ The Persian *R. Tuḥfa-yi Rūḥānī fī Khavāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf* (sometimes simply titled *Khavāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf*)²⁸⁵ has yet to be edited and survives in the following known MSS:

1. MS 12559, pp. 249-64, Majlis Library, Tehran.
2. MS 5180/43, pp. 413-23, Majlis Library, Tehran.
3. MS 2986, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh).²⁸⁶
4. MS 1257/24, Ḥikmat Collection, Central Library, Tehran University (Dānishgāh).²⁸⁷
5. MS 5981 (*ḥikmat*), Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad.²⁸⁸
6. MS 8286 (8283 *akhlāq*), Āstān-i Quds Library, Mashhad.²⁸⁹

²⁸² Pūrjavādī, “Kitābshināsī-yi Asār-i Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī,” 124-25.

²⁸³ Pūrjavādī, “Kitābshināsī,” 83-84; it has been edited and published four times, most recently by Firishta Furūzanda as a separate volume (Tehran, 1373 Sh./1994). Pūrjavādī also mentions the section on mathematics in his *R. Unmūdhaj al-'Ulūm* as containing lettrist material (“Kitābshināsī,” 126-27), but it is simply a brief examination of perfect numbers (i.e., 6, 28, etc.) (Davānī, *Thalāth Rasā'il*, 327-28).

²⁸⁴ Shīrvānī, *Mishkāṭ*, 6/2247, who bases his attribution of the treatise to Davānī on its style and context; Javādī, “Asār-i 'Allāma,” 17; see Pūrjavādī, “Kitābshināsī,” 89. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *R. Nuqṭa* is discussed at §2.1.2, no. 25.

²⁸⁵ Pūrjavādī identifies *R. Khavāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf* and *R. Tuḥfa-yi Rūḥānī* as separate treatises, but they appear to be alternate titles for the same treatise. It is also likely that the *R. Istikākāt al-Ḥurūf* of MS no. 10, identified by Pūrjavādī as possibly being a separate treatise, is again the same treatise tagged with a more descriptive title.

²⁸⁶ Muẓaffariyān, *Kāzirūn dar Āyīna-yi Farhang-i Īrān*, 361.

²⁸⁷ Muẓaffariyān, *Kāzirūn*, 361.

²⁸⁸ Muẓaffariyān, *Kāzirūn*, 361.

²⁸⁹ Muẓaffariyān, *Kāzirūn*, 361.

7. MS 9480/53, pp. 227-32, Majlis Library, Tehran; this appears to be a paraphrase or summary of Davānī's treatise.
8. MS 1231Ṭ, ff. 1a-2b, Majlis Library, Tehran; this is an extract from the beginning of the treatise.
9. MS 1093/6, Murad Molla Collection, Süleymaniye Library, Istanbul.
10. MS 3862, Alisher Navoi State Library, Tashkent.²⁹⁰ The treatise is here titled *Istikākāt al-ḥurūf wa-ṭabā'ī'u-hā wa-a'dādu-hā wa-mā yata'allaq bi-hi a'dād wa-l-ḥurūf min al-masā'il al-mawsūm bi-arithmāṭiqī*; it is possible, but unlikely, that this represents a separate work.

This treatise was first mentioned by Mudarris Tabrīzī under the title featured in MS Tashkent 3862, *Istikākāt al-Ḥurūf*; he states that Davānī wrote this treatise at the request of his student Jamāl al-Dīn Naṣr Allāh and at the latter's insistence sent a copy to Sultan Ghiyās al-Dīn Muḥammad Shāh III (r. 867-887/1463-82), the Bahmanid ruler.²⁹¹ This suggests a date of composition in the 1460s or 1470s. In the preface the author states that he has written the treatise in Persian for ease of comprehension by all.²⁹²

Unlike the lettrist section of Davānī's *R. Tahlīliyya*, discussed below, his *Tuḥfa-yi Rūḥānī*²⁹³ is primarily practical-magical in orientation, and consists of a dedicatory preface, a historical overview of the science of letters, 11 sections and a conclusion. The body of the treatise is concerned to establish the astrological correspondences of the letters (sections 1-2), the use of a name or birthdate to predict a person's fate (section 3), the properties of the letters (particularly astrological) and their practical-magical applications (sections 4-5), methods of letter-based divination (sections 6-10), and the conditions for practicing this science (section 11). The author quotes several authorities by name, particularly Ja'far al-Ṣādiq, Būnī and Sa'd

²⁹⁰ Muẓaffariyān, *Kāzirūn*, 362.

²⁹¹ Mudarris Tabrīzī, *Rayḥānat al-Adab*, 2/33. The ruler's name is given as Ghiyās al-Dīn 'Iyān-Shāh in the dedicatory preface to this work (MS Majlis 5180/43 pp. 413-23, MS Majlis 12559 pp. 249-64).

²⁹² MS Majlis 5180 p. 414.

²⁹³ I here evaluate this treatise on the basis of MS Majlis 5180/43 pp. 413-23 (copied 25 Jumādā I 1069/18 February 1659) and MS Majlis 12559 pp. 249-64.

al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī, and many others anonymously, including one reference to Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *R. Su'l al-Mulūk*.

Of particular interest for the purposes of this study is Davānī's historical overview of the science of letters from the vantage point of the later 9th/15th century. His brief account of the development and transmission of this science is virtually identical to Ṣā'in al-Dīn's and 'Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī's.²⁹⁴ Most notably, he, like Ṣā'in al-Dīn, identifies Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī as the foremost practitioner of *'ilm al-ḥurūf* and *jafr* of the 8th-9th/14th-15th centuries. As we will see below, any mention of Akhlāṭī from the mid-9th/15th century onwards appears to implicitly include Ṣā'in al-Dīn as his most important disciple and systematizer of his teachings, and indeed Ṣā'in al-Dīn for his part is at pains to present himself as such. Unlike Ṣā'in al-Dīn, Davānī observes that the theoretical, rather than the practical, aspect of this science is most often discussed by its exponents; this hardly tallies with Ṣā'in al-Dīn's complaints that its theoretical aspect is sorely neglected. This discrepancy suggests that the Isfahan Circle did in fact succeed to some extent in raising the profile of intellectual lettrism. Finally, in section seven Davānī cites Ṣā'in al-Dīn's prediction at the end of his *R. Su'l al-Mulūk* of the duration of the Timurid state on the basis of Shāhrukh's name as a standard method of political forecasting.²⁹⁵

Davānī's introduction may be paraphrased as follows: The principles of this science were laid down by and have been carried over from such eminent ancient philosophers as Pythagoras, Apollonius of Tyana, Plato and Aristotle, who in turn drew from the teachings of contemporary prophets, e.g. Pythagorus from Solomon. Aristotle in his *K. Iṣṭikākāt* (*Book of Conjunctions*) speaks allusively of his view that each letter derives from a planetary conjunction (*iṣṭikāk-i kawkabī*) and manifests in a specific level. Socrates, held by some Greeks to be the prophet of his day, also spoke at length about the letters. These sages also developed the

²⁹⁴ See §4.3.4 above for Bisṭāmī's *isnāds*, as well Ṣā'in al-Dīn reconceptualization of the history of this science as treated in §4.2.1.

²⁹⁵ See §5.4 below.

numerological or mental (*lubābī*) aspect of the letters. Other sages drew a comparison between the 28 letters and the houses of the moon. This legacy passed to the community of Muḥammad, who was *given all the words* and whose revelation enshrined all these secrets in an inimitable Book in summary form. The secret to this science was, however, entrusted to ‘Alī, who produced the *al-Jafr al-Jāmi’*; this text passed down through the line of the Imams after him, particularly Ja‘far al-Ṣādiq, who expounded its finer points (note the resemblance between *jafr* and Ja‘far). The science then passed to other saints of God, such as the Seal of Sainthood Shaykh Muḥyī l-Dīn-i A‘rābī [Ibn ‘Arabī], the Pole of Saints Shaykh Sa‘d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī, Shaykh Abū l-‘Abbās Būnī, Shaykh Abū l-Ḥasan Shādhilī²⁹⁶ and others. Each had his own approach to this science but all discoursed on the secrets of the properties of letters. Closer to the present author’s own day, the master of matters occult, Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī, encompassed all the principles and applications of this science.²⁹⁷ Because the mental-spiritual form of the letters is the most noble and subtle of its levels, corresponding to these latter as spirit to body, most of these masters’ discussions have concentrated on this level. Nevertheless, the author pledges to provide in this synopsis a representative example of each of the methods proper to this science.²⁹⁸

Because Davānī’s interest in this treatise is primarily in the practical-magical manipulation of the properties of the letters, I will provide only representative examples that suggest the nature of applied lettrism in Iran during the latter half of the 9th/15th century—in this case as reported by one of the leading philosophers and theologians of the later Timurid period. Davānī’s autobiographical references to his own applications of this science, however odd and

²⁹⁶ D. 656/1258.

²⁹⁷ I.e., as systematized by his chief disciple Ṣā‘in al-Dīn.

²⁹⁸ MS Majlis 5180/43 pp. 413-23, MS Majlis 12559 pp. 249-64.

out of character they may appear to us, testify to the ubiquity of interest in lettrism even in philosophical-theological circles.

It should first be noted that Davānī holds the astrological properties of the letters to be most fundamental. The first three sections of this treatise are concerned to show the correspondences linking each letter and its ruling planet, this as a basis for astrological letter magic or divination. Section one, ‘On the simple forms (*basāyit*) of the letters and their divisions,’ opens by listing the astrological origin of each letter and its creaturely association:²⁹⁹

1. Mars transited the first degree of Aries, which conjunction (*iṣṭikāk*) produced A; it is associated with birds (*tuyūr*).
2. The moon transited the third degree of Taurus, producing J; it is associated with the human (*ādamī*).
3. The moon transited ten degrees of Cancer, producing L; it is associated with cattle (*davābb*).
4. The moon transited eight degrees of Leo, producing S; it is associated with birds.
5. The moon transited Virgo, producing F; it is associated with wild animals (*vuḥūsh*).
6. The sun transited the first degree of Aries, producing H; it is associated with birds.
7. Venus transited the first degree of Taurus, producing Sh; it is associated with the human.
8. Mercury transited the first degree of Gemini, producing Ş; it is associated with wild animals.
9. Mercury transited 15 degrees of Virgo (being thus in exaltation), producing Q; it is associated with man (*insān*).
10. The sun transited the first degree of Cancer, producing H; it is associated with cattle.
11. The sun transited the first degree of Leo (its own sign), producing ‘; it governs man (*mustawī bar insān*).
12. Mercury transited the first degree of Aquarius, producing D; it is associated with aquatic creatures (*jānvarān-i ābī*).
13. Mars transited Scorpio, producing T; it is associated with cattle.
14. Mars transited Capricorn, producing M; it is associated with the human.
15. Mars transited 21 degrees of Pisces, producing R; it is associated with cattle.
16. Jupiter transited 18 degrees of Cancer, producing Ṭ; it is associated with wild animals.
17. Jupiter transited the first degree of Cancer, producing W.
18. Saturn transited 20 degrees of Gemini, producing Dh; it is associated with birds.
19. Jupiter transited the first degree of Sagittarius, producing K; it is associated with the human.
20. Jupiter transited Pisces, producing Ḍ; it is associated with cattle.
21. Saturn transited 20 degrees of Libra, producing Th; it is associated with living things (*ḥayy*).

²⁹⁹ The versions of this list given MS Majlis 5180 pp. 415-16 and MS Majlis 12559 pp. 253-54, my sources for this treatise, are both defective, incomplete and in places contradictory; the reconstruction I provide here should be considered approximate.

22. Jupiter transited 23 degrees of Capricorn, producing *Kh*; it is associated with wild animals.
23. Jupiter transited the first degree of Aquarius, producing *Gh*; it is associated with beasts of prey (*sibāʿ*).
24. Venus transited 29 degrees of Aries, producing *Z*; it is associated with birds.
25. Etc. [the letters *Y*, *N* and *B* are missing from this list].³⁰⁰

Thus of the 28 letters there are four letters proper to each of the planets:

Saturn:	<i>Dh Th Kh Gh</i>
Jupiter:	<i>Ṭ W K Ḍ</i>
Mars:	<i>A T M R</i>
Sun:	<i>Ḥ H ʿ [Y]</i>
Venus:	<i>Sh Z [N B]</i>
Mercury:	<i>Ṣ Q Ḍ Ṣ</i>
Moon:	<i>J L S F</i>

Section two lays out the zodiacal divisions of the letters and discusses the theory of astrological-letter correspondences. It then indicates how this information is to be used in practical-magical applications: if the transit of Mars through the first degree of Aries produced *A*, for example, one must wait for the same moment to activate the letter *A* to a desired end associated therewith, such as inducing support for one's cause (*taʿlīf-i qulūb*), increasing personal intelligence or power, elevating a person above their peers, etc.³⁰¹

Section three refers very briefly to the practice of using a person's name or birthdate to discover their fate.³⁰² The example is given of a man named 'Alī; if the sun is in the first degree of Aries between dawn and noon, his affairs will prosper, but between noon and sunset they

³⁰⁰ Cf. the similar list given by Niʿmat Allāh Valī in his *R. dar Asrār al-Ḥurūf* (for which see §4.3.2 above).

³⁰¹ Majlis 5180 pp. 416-17, Majlis 12559 pp. 253-56.

³⁰² Cf. John Stuart Mill (d. 1843): "The only names of substance which connote nothing are proper names ... A proper name is merely an unmeaning mark ... which we endeavor to connect with the idea of the object in our heads ... Objects thus ticketed with proper names resemble, until we know something more about them, men and women in masks. We can distinguish them, but can conjecture nothing with respect to their real features" (*A System of Logic Ratiocinative and Inductive*, Books IV-VI and Appendices, ed. J. M. Robson, Toronto, 1974, 980-81). Far to the contrary, the technique of *taksīr* rests precisely on a posited direct correspondence between a person's name and the real contours of their fate.

will not. It is also possible to discover whether two people will be in harmony with each other or at odds by performing an operation on their names in conjunction. However, these methods require total clarity and concentration of mind so one is capable of discerning every nuance.³⁰³

Section four comprises a list of the letters in general *abjad* order with their respective properties (particularly astrological) and the magical applications to which these may be put.

For example, A:

It is said that to induce favor (*ta'lif*) or love (*dilgarmī*) one should, when the Ascendant enters the first degree of Aries, inscribe seven As on a lead plate (*takhta-yi usrub*), apply aloe wood and incense and bury it under a fire. It is also said that a thousand As [inscribed] at this moment and then hung around the neck ... will impart great intelligence (*zakā, fiṭnat*) to the wearer.³⁰⁴

In discussing methods in sections six and seven of predicting events on the basis of letters, Davānī holds up Ṣā'in al-Dīn's prediction in his *R. Su'l al-Mulūk* of the duration of the Timurid state on the basis of Shāhrukh's name,³⁰⁵ without, however, identifying Ṣā'in al-Dīn by name:

It is transmitted that a certain prominent scholar from among the latter-day [authorities on this science] (*ba'zī afāzil-i muta'akhhirīn*) calculated (*istinbāt*) on the basis of the name Shāhrukh that the state associated with the ruler so named would endure the length of the ninth Islamic century (*mi'a-yi sāmīna az hijrat*).³⁰⁶

Davānī then gives an account of the circumstances surrounding his own accurate, if inadvertent, prediction of Sulṭān-Abū Sa'īd's (r. 855-73/1451-69) death in the aftermath of his battle against Uzun Ḥasan (r. 861-82/1457-78) in 873/1469 near Ardabil.³⁰⁷ Given its political import, I translate the passage in full in Chapter 5 (§5.3) below.

³⁰³ Majlis 5180 pp. 417, Majlis 12559 pp. 256.

³⁰⁴ Majlis 5180 pp. 417, Majlis 12559 pp. 256.

³⁰⁵ *R. Su'l al-Mulūk*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 178b.

³⁰⁶ Majlis 5180 pp. 420, Majlis 12559 pp. 260.

³⁰⁷ Majlis 5180 pp. 420-21, Majlis 12559 pp. 260-61.

Continuing this theme, in section ten Davānī cites the example of Shaykh Najm al-Dīn Kubrā (d. 618/1221), who employed the technique of *taksīr*³⁰⁸ to learn the intentions of Chinggis Khan and Sultan Muḥammad Kh^wārazmshāh against Transoxania on the basis of their names (the result: they would utterly destroy the region); performing a second operation in which he added his own name to the mix, it emerged that he would perish in the Turko-Mongol invasion in seven years' time. The first transposition produced: *Kh R A B Y J H A N A M D V Sh V D V Y R A N*³⁰⁹ (*kharābī-yi jahān āmad u shavad (?) vayrān*, 'the destruction of the world came and it becomes (?) desolate'). The second transposition (adding a *T* for the Turks): *Sh H A D T Sh Y Kh* (*shahādat-i shaykh*, suggesting the shaykh's death as a resistance fighter).³¹⁰

Finally, in the conclusion Davānī enjoins his reader to the effect that one may only practice this science in purity of heart and mind and in full observance of the Shari'a. Further, one may never use the methods he has outlined to harm anyone, save in those rare instances where such is demanded by law, as in defending against an oppressor, and only then when all other means have failed. It is a powerful and effective science and hence not to be trifled with under any circumstances.³¹¹

³⁰⁸ *Taksīr* is often used synonymously with *jafr* given the frequency of its use in the latter. I repeat here Ḥājji Khalīfa's definition of this technique: The practitioner "unjoins the letters of one of the divine names and intersperses them with the letters of the word(s) designating his goal in a single line, then, performing an operation known to initiates, rearranges the order of the letters on two lines. This is repeated until the first line is in order, and from it is taken the names of the angels and the supplications used to address them. The practitioner then continues these supplications until the goal is achieved" (*Kashf al-Ẓunūn*, 2/1475).

³⁰⁹ So Majlis 5180 p. 421; the more defective Majlis 12559 p. 262 has *Kh R A B Y J H A N A M V R A D V D A N*.

³¹⁰ Majlis 5180 pp. 421-22, Majlis 12559 p. 262.

³¹¹ Majlis 5180 pp. 422-23, Majlis 12559 pp. 263-64.

2. *R. Tahlīliyya*

As befits his intellectual profile, of course, Davānī's interest in lettrism was not confined to practical-magical applications. The most direct evidence for his appreciation of the usefulness of the purely theoretical-philosophical aspects of the discipline for representing cosmological realities comes in his Persian *R. Tahlīliyya*,³¹² written in 868/1464 for Shujā' al-Dīn 'Ulyā.³¹³ This concise treatise is divided into two main sections (*maqām*), the first being an exoteric analysis of the phrase from linguistic (*lughavī*) and rational (*'aqlī*) points of view, the second an esoteric analysis from mystical (*shuhūdī*) and lettrist points of view. It will be noted that Davānī's arrangement of this treatise in itself reflects Ṣā'ib al-Dīn's distinction between Sufism and lettrism, as well as his elevation of the latter to universal science; this arrangement clearly implies that lettrism is to mysticism as philosophy is to linguistics, and is therefore superior to mystical theory in the same degree that philosophy is superior to, i.e., more universal than, linguistics.

The lettrist section (*mawqif-i duvvum*) is entitled 'On the levels of the letters and choice subtleties associated with the words at each level' (*dar marātib-i ḥurūf u laṭāyif-i muta'allaq bi alfāz-i ān*); it may be paraphrased as follows:³¹⁴

Letters have three levels: 1) Spiritual-mental, wherein the letters take form in the human mind before being expressed, in this corresponding to God's knowledge of realities before their coming into being; these letters are called the high letters (*ḥurūf-i 'āliyāt*) or ratiocinative letters (*ḥurūf-i fikriyya*). 2) Oral, wherein the letters are expressed in audible form; these are called the medial letters (*ḥurūf-i wuṣṭā*). 3) Written, wherein the letters are made visible to *men*

³¹² Ed. Firishta Furūzanda, Tehran, 1373 Sh./1994. Cf. Jāmī's shorter *R. Tahlīliyya*, which is primarily grammatical and mystical in character and devoid of lettrist content (MS Majlis 4168/12 ff. 230a-34a; MS Mar'ashī 6744 ff. 499b-500a; MS Tiflis 566/3).

³¹³ Or possibly for Ḥabīb al-Dīn Muḥibb Allāh, grandson of Ni'mat Allāh Valī.

³¹⁴ *Tahlīliyya*, 65-74.

of might and vision (Q 38:45);³¹⁵ these are called the low letters (*hurūf-i sāfila*). Furthermore, letters have spirits, bodies and hearts. Their spirits represent their numerical values, their hearts their oral form, and their bodies their written form.³¹⁶

The phrase *lā ilāha illā Llāh*, which is formed of three letters—A, L and H—, may be analyzed on the basis of this premise:

1) *On the written form of the letters:*

A represents the first entification (*avval-i ta'ayyunāt*) given its graphic representation as a single line composed of repeated dots (sg. *nuqta*); as such it is the source of all the other letters. L represents the expansion of existence through the [fixed] entities (*vujūd-i munbaṣiṭ bar a'yān*) given its graphic representation as a line, A, combined with a tail, N, connoting the cycle of engendered being (*dā'ira-yi kawn*). H represents the totality of the cycle of engendered being. This phrase thus refers to the true oneness (*vaḥdat-i ḥaqīqī*) and its basic levels of downward unfolding (*uṣūl-i marātib-i tanazzulāt-i ū*), from the first manifestation of God to the whole of engendered existence via the process of expansion through the entities, with everything being underlain by the flow (*sarayān*) and repetition (*takarrur*) of manifestation represented by the dot. Thus does the true oneness manifest in all things, though not in an incarnationist or unificationist sense.

Second, the fact that the phrase is entirely composed of the letters of the name *Allāh* indicates that just as in the conventional meaning of the term alone connotes unity, so too does

³¹⁵ See §6.2 for Ṣā'in al-Dīn's technical use of this phrase. Notably, Davānī is here reiterating the special link posited by Ṣā'in al-Dīn between the written form of the letters and the *men of might and vision*.

³¹⁶ Cf. Lehrich, *The Language of Demons and Angels*, 120: "Nevertheless, Josef Vachek and a few other linguists have studied writing as a distinct form of language. Their conclusions are surprising: some argue that written language constitutes an almost entirely separate mode of language from speech, having its own *langue* and *parole*; to use functionalist terminology, there are both spoken and written *norms*. In the context of these norms (or *langues*), Fred Householder has even made the suggestion that in logical terms, *written language is prior to spoken*."

the true, rational meaning describe true unity's levels of descent in a way that no other could. On the basis of this subtle point (which has apparently occurred to no one else) the perspicacious may derive many further matrices of wisdom and knowledge, one of which is that the totality of engendered beings corresponds to the word unity (*tawhīd*), which comprises the stages and levels of the manifestation of true oneness and denotes the comprehensive, exclusive oneness (*aḥadiyyat-i jam'ī*), and hence the term unity is the cosmos in its entirety in its emergence from God; and there are other secrets I will not adumbrate here.

Another point on the written form of this phrase: All of its letters are straight and upright, with the exception of two *H*s, and the *L*, which is both straight and curved. Now the template for all letters is either a straight or a curved line, with every other letterform being a modification of one of these two types. The curved line moreover is derived from the straight line. The *A* thus connotes exclusive oneness (*aḥadiyya*), and *H* connotes dispersion (*tafriqa*)—so representing the beginning and end of the process of manifestation (*zuhūri*); on the level of perception (*shu'ūrī*) *A* connotes union (*jam'īyyat*) and *H* total separation (*tafriqa-y maḥẓ*). *L* connotes the joining (*jam'*) of both extremes, i.e., the combination of the straightness of the *A* and the curvedness of the *H*.

2) On the vocal form of the letters:

The percipient reader is aware that I do not understand here the circuit of the world of generation and corruption, i.e. the contingent realm, to mean the process of transformation (*istiḥāla*) proper to the elements (sg. *'unṣur*), according to the usage of the peripatetics (*mashshā'iyān*), but rather the creation and annihilation effected by the two divine names Expander (*bāsiṭ*) and Contracter (*qābiẓ*). For creation entails the manifestation of the king of expansion (*bast*), and annihilation is the firman of the steward of contraction (*qabẓ*); all divine judgments are but the application of these two general approaches. The manifestation of

contingency—corresponding to the term unity (*tawhīd*)—is entailed by expansion. All the letters in this phrase are of this type: they are vocally produced by openness of the palate and lips and without the contraction of any muscles.

Another point: It is clear to those acquainted with the significance of letters that the A, connoting exclusive oneness, is present in every word in the phrase, whether explicitly or implicitly; as I stated, the phrase is composed of *alif*, *lām* and *hā'*, the names of each of which also feature A. This indicates that existence and all its manifestations arise from that exclusive oneness or its names.

3) *On the mental form of the letters:*

The numerical values of the letters of this phrase are limited to three: 1, 5 and 30. One represents the first descent of true, absolute unity, given that the latter transcends the reach of rational thought, nor can the rays of perception attain to its surface; these may only penetrate to the hems of its attributes and descents (*azyāl-i malābis-i šifāt u tanazzulāt-i ū*). It is obvious that absolute unity negates duality (*sanaviyyat*) in all its aspects; it is likewise clear that perception (*shu'ūr, idrāk*) is based upon duality and multiplicity (*ta'addud*). However far the mystic traveler (*sālik*) might go there will always remain a gap interposing between him and absolute unity. Thus the number 1 corresponds to the first of the levels of descent from the true unity, and the process of its flowing (*sarqayān*) puts it into relation with the other numbers in the same way that the flow and manifestation of true unity occurs in multiplicities (*kaṣarāt*). For this reason 1 refers to exclusive oneness and 5 to the extreme of multiplicity at the furthest remove from the circumference (*muḥīṭ*) of unity.

The perfection of each number lies in the relationships intrinsic to it. For example, the perfection of 3, the denominator (*makhraj*) of $1/3$ (*suls*) and 3, like 10, which comprises $3 \times 1/3$, or 1, plus 3×3 , or 9; this is equivalent to 5×2 , since 2 is the denominator of $1/2$ and double

(*ẓīf*). Five comprises 1/2 of 2, or 1, plus 2 x 2, or 4. Since 2 represents the beginning of multiplicity, 5, its perfection, represents the end of multiplicity, while at the same time being closer to true unity, since the cycle of every level is perfected through 9. After 9 comes 10, representing inclusive oneness (*vāḥidiyya*), which is the first of the decades. Because after 1 there is nothing but true, absolute unity, 5 is of all numbers the farthest from that unity. For this reason all the [bodily] extremities each end in 5 digits; this is why there are 5 senses, representing the end of the process of manifestation and the beginning of the process of perception; 5 types of sensible body (*ajsām*), the heavenly bodies (*falakiyyāt*) and the four elements; 5 types of time, the 4 seasons and the stream of moments that we imagine connects them and by which motions are measured; the 5 extremities of the human body, the head, two hands and two feet; the 5 digits of each hand in foot; the 5 pillars of Islam, the extremity of the level of perception; the 5 categories of engendered beings of the lower realm, the 4 elements and the temperaments produced by their intermixture (*imtizāj*); and many other examples could be cited as have been discussed at length elsewhere. The number 30 is the first of the odd numbers above 1 (*afrād*) of the decades, and relates to 10 as 3 does to 1.

Numerologically, then, this phrase refers to the beginning and the end of the processes of manifestation and perception, marking the point of transition between the two: 1 is the origin of the process of manifestation, while 5 is the end of that process and at the same time the beginning of the process of perception, which returns to 1. The number 30, representing multiplicity experienced after the unity of perception has been achieved, indicates the foothold of the mystic traveler in a given station, for after the mystic (*‘ārīf*) has attained to unity he retraces his steps back to multiplicity in order to perfect and empower others. This is so because the manifestation of multiplicity cannot occur without the triplicity (*taslīs*) of subject, object and the relationship that connects them. The mystic therefore returns from union with the true unity to the realm of multiplicity, the realm of actions (*aḥāl*), to embody the name

Manifest (*zāhir*). Thirty refers to this level, and the correspondence is clear: 30 is multiplicity in the sense of 3 after the unity of perception, just as this level of perception of multiplicity is the same as the level of 3 after the perception of true unity. *As He originated you so will you return* (Q 7:29)—all originated from Him and to Him returns.

4.4.2: Ḥusayn Vāʿiz Kāshifī's lettrist tafsir

Ḥusayn Vāʿiz Kāshifī (d. 910/1505), the preeminent polymath of late Timurid Herat, cuts a remarkable figure. Like his Egyptian contemporary, Jalāl al-Dīn al-Suyūṭī (d. 911/1505), he wrote on almost every branch of learning in a quest to standardize and popularize the cultural patrimony of his time and preserve it for future generations. Like his Italian contemporary Pico della Mirandola and other Renaissance polymaths, his universalist project privileged the occult sciences, including alchemy, astrology, magic and lettrism. Despite Kāshifī's profound importance to late medieval Islamic intellectual history, however, few of his works have yet to receive anything approaching adequate attention.³¹⁷ He is known primarily for his 'Alid martyrology, the *Rawzat al-Shuhadā*, used as a standard text in Shi'ī mourning rituals from the Safavid period to the present;³¹⁸ the *Anvār-i Suhaylī*, an ornate reworking of the *Kalīla wa-Dimna* animal fables;³¹⁹ the *Mavāhib-i 'Aliyya*, his popular, concise and entertaining Quran commentary;³²⁰ and the *Akhlāq-i Muḥsinī*, a work on ethics and statecraft.³²¹ Predictably, his

³¹⁷ Subtelny, "Husayn Vāʿiz-i Kashifi: Polymath, Popularizer, and Preserver," 463.

³¹⁸ Such rituals have come to be called *rawza-kh'wānī* after this text; see the important study of the *Rawzat al-Shuhadā* by Abbas Amanat, "Meadow of the Martyrs."

³¹⁹ The *Anvār-i Suhaylī* was generally held in high regard by English Persianists through the end of the 19th century—portions even figured in the program for the Persian examination in the Indian Civil Service—, though even Edward Eastwick apologizes for its ornate style in the preface to his full translation of 1854. This admiration soon soured into condemnation, however, with both A. J. Arberry and E. G. Browne expressing disgust at what they felt to be its "debased" style (van Ruymbeke, "Kashifi's Forgotten Masterpiece," 573-74). On the importance of form to content in the literary-intellectual productions of the Timurid period see the Excursus below.

³²⁰ The *Mavāhib-i 'Aliyya* was published in Tehran in 1938-50 (ed. M.-R. Jalālī Nāʾinī; see Subtelny, "Kāshifi,

works on the various occult sciences remain virtually untouched.³²² These include the *Sab‘a-yi Kāshifiyya*, or Septet of Kāshifī, a *summa* of astrology, of which the last treatise only survives;³²³ *Mafātīḥ al-Kunūz* and *Sharḥ-i Kitāb al-Surūr fī ‘Ilm al-Ṣan‘a*, on alchemy; *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, on letter magic; *al-Tuḥfa al-‘Aliyya fī ‘Ilm al-Ḥurūf wa-Bayān Asrāri-hā*, on letter theory;³²⁴ *R. dar ‘Ilm-i A‘dād*, on numerology; and *al-Marṣad al-Asnā fī Istikhrāj Asmā’ al-Ḥusnā*, on the divine Names.³²⁵

To this list must be added Kāshifī’s *Tafsīr al-Javāhir*, the first—and perhaps last—lettrist tafsir of the Quran.³²⁶ It is likewise exceptional for its refined Persian literary style, rivaled only by Rashīd al-Dīn Maybudī’s (d. 530/1165) *Kashf al-Asrār va ‘Uddat al-Abrār*; in this regard too the *Tafsīr al-Javāhir* is the last of its kind.³²⁷ In this work Kāshifī brings together esoteric and lettrist material drawn from a great range of authorities, including Būnī, Ibn ‘Arabī and Ḥamuvayī—as

Kamāl-al-Dīn Ḥosayn Wā‘ez,” *Elr*; Sands, “On the Popularity of Husayn Va‘iz-i Kashifī’s *Mavāhib-i ‘aliyya*,” 470).

³²¹ See Subtelny, “A Late Medieval Persian *Summa* on Ethics.”

³²² Two rare but welcome treatments are Lory, “Kashifī’s *Asrār-i Qāsimī* and Timurid Magic,” and Tourkin and Vesel, “The Contribution of Husayn Va‘iz-i Kashifī to the Transmission of Astrological Texts”; see also Subtelny, “Kāšefī,” *Elr*.

³²³ Scil., the *Lavāyih al-Qamar*, or *Ikhtiyārāt al-Nujūm* (wr. 878/1473), dealing with elections (*ikhtiyārāt*) (see Tourkin and Vesel, “The Contribution,” 590–91). The popularity of this work is suggested by the fact that at least 93 MSS of this work are preserved in Iran alone (AB).

³²⁴ The *al-Tuḥfa al-‘Aliyya* is an otherwise unknown work compiled for Shaykh ‘Abd Allāh Naqshbandī (Yousofi, “Kāshifī,” *El*²).

³²⁵ Subtelny, “Husayn Va‘iz-i Kashifī,” 464. For a description of these works see the editor’s introduction to Kāshifī’s *Javāhir al-Tafsīr*, 79–81.

³²⁶ See editor’s intro., *Javāhir al-Tafsīr*, 97–98. Note, however, the Andalusian lettrist Abū l-Ḥasan al-Ḥarrālī (d. 637/1239), said by al-Dhahabī (d. 348/1347) to have authored a tafsir “replete with postulations that have no basis in the Arabic language” and “speculated on the science of the letters and of the numbers, claiming that he derived thereby the time of the coming of the Dajjāl and the rising of the sun from the west” (Dhahabī, *Siyar A‘lām al-Nubalā’*, 23/47, no. 33; my thanks to Yousef Casewit for directing me to this reference).

³²⁷ Editor’s intro., *Javāhir al-Tafsīr*, 97–98. Sayyid Muḥammad ‘Alī Ayāzī notes that subsequent Arabic tafsirs did combine an ornate literary style with mystical theory—e.g., the *Tafsīr Rūḥ al-Bayān* of Ismā‘īl Ḥaqqī Bursavī (d. 1127/1724), which quotes Ḥāfiz, Sa‘dī and Rūmī, and the *Bayān al-Sa‘āda* of Sultān ‘Alī Shāh Gunābādī (d. 1327/1909)—, but in Persian Kāshifī’s tafsir had no successor (“*Javāhir al-Tafsīr-i Mullā Ḥusayn Kāshifī*,” 52–53).

well as Ibn Turka: he quotes from both the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* and the *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*. This ambitious tafsir, dedicated to ‘Alī Shīr Navā’ī, was never completed; the author broke off work at verse 84 of Sūrat al-Nisā’ to write in its place the more popular and wholly exoteric *Mavāhib-i ‘Aliyya*; the latter tafsir was written between 897-99/1491-94 and also dedicated to ‘Alī Shīr. As it stands, however, the two volumes of the *Javāhir al-Tafsīr* that Kāshifī did produce, the first in 890/1485 and the second incomplete in 892/1487, are in themselves quite hefty.³²⁸ To date only the introduction and first section on the Fātiḥa has been edited and published.³²⁹

Consistent with his all-encompassing intellectual program, Kāshifī’s lettrist writings represent the continuation, even a culmination, of the intellectual approach to lettrism so vigorously promoted by Ṣā’ib al-Dīn and the Isfahan Circle as centerpiece of their own universalist project. As no manuscript copies of Kāshifī’s *al-Tuḥfa al-‘Aliyya*, which promised to describe the state of the lettrist art in Iran at the end of the 9th/15th century, appear to have survived, I will limit my discussion here to the *Javāhir al-Tafsīr*, with particular focus on those passages in which Kāshifī quotes or paraphrases Ṣā’ib al-Dīn.

Concluding his discussion of the superiority of the Quran to every other revealed book, Kāshifī sets the stage for the lettrist material that follows by citing, as an argument-clincher, the magical properties unique to it; the fact that the Quran allows one to achieve total control over engendered existence (*taṣarrufāt-i kullī dar ‘ālam-i kawn u fasād*) proves its essential identity with the fabric of reality:³³⁰

³²⁸ Subtelny, “Kāšefi,” *Elr*.

³²⁹ Ed. Javād ‘Abbāsī, Tehran, 1379 Sh./2000.

³³⁰ *Javāhir al-Tafsīr*, 261-62. As Kathleen O’Connor states, “The Qur’ān in Muslim life and practice is ... the central arena for observing the permeability of ‘licit magic’ in Islam. As Islam’s most religiously authoritative, rigorously liturgical, and legal conservative source, the Qur’ān also comes down to the present as Islam’s most intimately negotiated, vernacularly creative, and magically effective venue of religious action” (“Popular and Talismanic Uses of the Qur’ān,” *EQ*, summarizing Primano, “Vernacular Religion and the Search for Method in Religious Folklife,” 44-51).

It having thus been demonstrated with traditional and rational proofs that this Book is the noblest and greatest of all revealed scriptures, its verses clearer and superior to those of other codices, its inimitability (*muʿjiz*) more evident than any other prophetic miracle (*muʿjizāt*), the divine names it contains greater than all those given in previous scriptures, it follows that its particularities (sg. *khāṣṣiyyat*) must be more beneficial and more manifold than the properties of any other book—and indeed, by means of its particularity one may achieve total control over engendered existence. The inner meaning of the hadith *The Opening of the Book is the healing of every sickness* (*fātiḥatu al-kitābi shifāʾ min kulli dāʾ*)³³¹ refers plainly to this fact. The account of spells (sg. *ruqya*) and amulets (sg. *taʿwīdh*)³³² based on quranic words referenced by the holy Messenger (God bless him and keep him and his House) likewise constitutes a reliable proof in this regard.

Kāshifī supports this argument by referring his reader to the ‘Corpus Būnianam’ (*rasāʾil-i Būniyya*),³³³ the *al-Khawāṣṣ al-Tamīmiyya* and *al-Durr al-Naẓīm* of ʿAbd Allāh al-Tamīmī al-Yāfiʿī (d. Mecca 768/1367),³³⁴ as well as the works of Aḥmad al-Sabtī (fl. 8th/14th c.),³³⁵ Ibn Khaldūn (d. 808/1406), Abū ʿAbd Allāh al-Zakzākī and others.

Ibn Turka does not appear to figure prominently as an authority in the *Javāhir al-Tafsīr*. There are, however, three paraphrasing quotes from Ṣāʿin al-Dīn’s works, two from the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* and the third from the *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*. As the first two are attributed only to “the author of the *Mafāḥiṣ*” and the third to one “Kh^wāja,” it is entirely possible that Kāshifī simply fails to attribute further quotes to Ibn Turka as the source. It should also be borne in mind that my analysis here only includes the first, published volume of the *Javāhir*.

First, Kāshifī concludes his discussion on the significance of the letter *B* as the first letter of the Quran by citing two passages from the *Mafāḥiṣ*:

³³¹ Dārimī, *Sunan*, *Kitāb Faḍāʾil al-Qurʾān*, *Bāb Faḍl Fātiḥat al-Kitāb*, no. 3247; Bayhaqī, *Shuʿab al-Īmān*, *Bāb fī Taʾẓīm al-Qurʾān* (19), no. 2370.

³³² See O’Connor, “Popular and Talismanic Uses of the Qurʾān,” *EQ*.

³³³ This term was coined by Jan Just Witkam in his recent study, “Gazing at the Sun,” 183.

³³⁴ Yāfiʿī was the master of Niʿmat Allāh Valī, suggesting that the two works listed here were important sources for the latter’s own lettrist thought. The *al-Durr al-Naẓīm* has recently been edited by Muḥsin ʿAqīl (Beirut, 1999).

³³⁵ Aḥmad b. Muḥammad b. Ṭāhir al-Ḥusaynī al-ʿAlawī, a contemporary of Lisān al-Dīn Ibn al-Khaṭīb (713-76/1313-75) and the last sayyid of Sabta (Ceuta) (“Zāyija,” *Lughat-nāma-yi Dihkhudā*).

By way of concluding the foregoing discussion we may cite the author of the *Mafāḥiṣ* (God gladden his grave): The letter *B* connotes the presence of inclusive oneness (*ḥaẓrat-i vāḥidiyyat*), the beginning of the chain of existents (*silsila-yi mawjūdāt*), as suggested by the saying ‘From *B* manifested being (*wa-mina l-bā’ zahara l-wujūd*).’³³⁶ That the [divine] Speech opens with this letter, the mover of the chain of witnessing (*muḥarrik-i silsila-yi shuhūd*), is thus not inappropriate. The same author says: The letter *B* connotes the first entification (*ta’ayyun-i avval*), also called the Muḥammadan Reality (*ḥaqīqat-i Muḥammadī*) (the profoundest blessings be upon him and his house). The correspondence of the letter *B* to this reality is clear, in that the union of opposites (*ta’ānuq-i aṭrāf*), one of the noble particularities of the Seal (*ḥaẓrat-i khatmiyya*)—as the poet sings:

For me opposites embrace, the rug of otherness
rolled away: all things are equal.³³⁷

—is realized at the level of this letter. Its embodiment of two is simultaneously the most proximal to one and the most distant therefrom; it also comprehends both primacy (*avvaliyyat*) and duality (*zawjiyyat*); it therefore unites opposites (*mu’taniq-i aẓdād*). This, as is clear to people of mystical knowledge (*‘irfān*), is precisely a quality peculiar to the Seal. Whoso listens to the call [*I have time with God*] wherein no angel can share³³⁸ and the declaration *I am but human* (Q 18:110, 41:6) with the ear of understanding, whoso beholds the manifest beauty of *Bilal*, give us relief³³⁹ and the coquetry of *Talk to me, little fair-skinned one*³⁴⁰ with the eye of insight,

He knows what the path of all-comprehensiveness (*jāmi’iyyat*) is like.

More, according to the verse *A messenger from among yourselves* as qualified by *gentle, compassionate* (Q 9:128), a portion of what has been written

will become plain to intelligent minds.

It by virtue of this relation that one of the great names applied to the holy [Prophet] (the blessings of the All-merciful be upon him and his house) in the Quran is precisely the adjective ‘second’: *The second of the two when the two were in the cave* (Q 9:40). The precedence of the reality of the Prophet is clear, and the correspondence of *B* therewith firmly established; hence the appropriateness of opening the [divine] Speech with reference to the master of mankind (*sayyid-i anām*) (blessings and peace be upon him and his house) by way of this letter.

Certain knowers of secrets (*ahl-i asrār*) hold that *B* opens [the Quran] because of its comprehensiveness (*iḥāṭa*). In the *Shams al-Ma’ārif al-Kabīr* it is stated, for example, that the letter *B* is a hidden mystery that imparts its blessing (*barakat*) to all things whenever it

³³⁶ See Ḥaydar Āmulī, *Jāmi’ al-Asrār*, 563; and Rajab Bursī, *Mashāriq Anwār al-Yaqīn*, 52.

³³⁷ Ibn al-Fāriḍ, *al-Tā’iyya al-Kubrā*, l. 227.

³³⁸ See al-‘Ajlūnī, *Kashf al-Khafā’*, 2/173, no. 2159.

³³⁹ I.e., by performing the *adhān* to initiate the prayer; see al-Ṭabrisī, *K. al-Iḥtijāj*, 2/501.

³⁴⁰ Ḥumayrā’, addressing ‘Ā’isha; see al-Bayhaqī, *K. al-Maḥāsin wa-l-Masāwī*, 297-98.

manifests. It is related more plainly in the *Futūḥāt* that Shaykh Abū Madyan (may He sanctify his secret) once said: ‘I see nothing but that it has a *B* written upon it.’³⁴¹ All such statements speak at base of the all-comprehensive nature (*maqām-i jam’*) [of the *B*], showing the way via the secret *Through me does everything subsist and become manifest*³⁴² and making known the essence of the statement *He is with you wherever you are* (Q 57:4)—but this withness (*ma’iyyat*) and union (*ittiṣāl*) is beyond the compass of howness (*kayfiyyat*) and cannot be grasped through reason³⁴³

That this passage is immediately preceded by a quote from Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī’s *R. Ta’arrufī Ma’nā l-Takashshuf* and Qūnavī’s *Tafsīr al-Fātiḥa* and immediately followed by quotes from the *Shams al-Ma’ārif al-Kubrā* of Būnī and the *al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya* of Ibn ‘Arabī further suggest an appreciation for Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s lettrist *summa*, given that it explicitly draws on some of the same sources.

In a second passage, Kāshifī appears to cite Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s introduction to his commentary on the *al-Tā’iyya al-Kubrā* of Ibn al-Fāriḍ, although he refers to the author only as “Kh^wāja.”³⁴⁴ This work is said to have a discussion of the fact that salvation and spiritual ascent are only possible through the joining of exoteric and esoteric knowledge, and hence every believer should partake of the mystical truths imparted by the saints as a support to their faith.³⁴⁵

In a sense, Kāshifī’s objectives as a lettrist exegete represent an expansion of Rashīd al-Dīn Ṭabīb’s theological purpose in his *R. Ḥurūf*. Unlike his Ilkhanid predecessor, however, Kāshifī explicitly identifies the properties of the quranic text as harnessed in the occult sciences (*‘ulūm-i gharība*) as a major foundation of the doctrine of *ijāz al-Qur’ān*, drawing particular attention to the science of letters as propounded by the Imams and the saints of Islam in equal

³⁴¹ Ibn ‘Arabī, *al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya*, 1/102.

³⁴² Ibn ‘Arabī, *al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya*, 1/102.

³⁴³ Kāshifī, *Javāhir al-Tafsīr*, 344-46.

³⁴⁴ ‘Kh^wāja’ (occasionally ‘Ḥaẓrat’) appears to be the standard title used for Ṣā’in al-Dīn in late Timurid and early Safavid sources, as opposed to e.g. ‘Mawlānā’ for Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī. Cf. Kāshifī’s reference to Ibn ‘Arabī as simply ‘Shaykh’ when quoting from his *Mawāqī’ al-Nujūm* (*Javāhir al-Tafsīr*, 727).

³⁴⁵ *Javāhir al-Tafsīr*, 282.

and complementary measure. And like Ṣā'in al-Dīn, he identifies Ibn 'Arabī and Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī as perhaps the most influential among those with such an approach to the Quran:

The seventh aspect of [quranic] inimitability is the fact that it comprises various types of sciences and knowledge (*'ulūm u ma'ārif*) the Arabs could not have known, or even the Messenger (God bless and keep him and his House) himself before the commencement of his prophetic mission. These include the occult sciences with which God (be He exalted) infused His letters and words, the knowledge of which He has entrusted to certain of the elite at His glorious court: the Imams of the House of the Prophet (*a'imma-yi ahl-i bayt*) (peace be upon them), who possessed some of this [occult knowledge] by way of divinatory principles (*qavānīn-i jafriyya*), keys to the treasure-houses of the mysteries of the Quran and hadith; and a number of great [mystics] among the saints of this community, such as Shaykh Muḥyī l-Dīn Ibn al-'Arabī and Shaykh Sa'd al-Dīn al-Ḥamuvayī (God sanctify their secrets) and others, who discovered another part of it by way of unveiling (*kashf*)³⁴⁶

We will see what relationship Ṣā'in al-Dīn posits between the occult knowledge of the Imams and that of the Sufis in Chapter 6; it suffices to say here that Ṣā'in al-Dīn, like Kāshifī, holds there to have been a division of labor between the Imams and the saints of Islam in developing this science, but imparts a more urgent millenarian and universalist nuance to what seems to have become the standard view in lettrist circles of the 9th/15th century.

4.4.3: Ibn Turka's image in late Timurid Herat

A survey of late 9th/15th and early 10th/16th biographical sources suggest that several primary, related themes constituted Ṣā'in al-Dīn's image in late Timurid Herat: 1) his close relationship to Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī, fellow disciple of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī in Cairo; 2) his status as Sayyid Ḥusayn's chief disciple, and by extension Sharaf al-Dīn's own teacher; and 3) Ṣā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn as the two most prominent intellectuals of Shahrukhid Iran. This accords with Ṣā'in al-Dīn's self-presentation as the expounder and systematizer of Akhlāṭī's teachings, and testifies to the fact that, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's personal tribulations notwithstanding, the Isfahan Circle's universalist and occultist project was held in wide esteem. In this section I

³⁴⁶ *Javāhir al-Taḥsīn*, 255.

provide translations of the relevant passages; I exclude ‘Alī Shīr Navā’ī’s (d. 906/1501) *Mecālisü ’n-Nefāyis* (wr. 897/1491-92) and *Nesāyīmü ’l-Maḥabbe* (wr. 901/1495-96) as neither work mentions Ṣā’ in al-Dīn.

1. *Ṣā’ in al-Dīn Turka and Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī as the two most prominent intellectuals of Shahrūkhi Iran*

The biographer Dawlatshāh Samarqandī (d. 900/1494 or 913/1507), writing in 892/1487, explicitly identifies Ibn Turka and Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī as the two most prominent intellectuals of Shahrūkhi Iran, with the two Sufi masters of comparable status being the Kh^wājagānī shaykh Muḥammad Pārsā (d. 822/1419) and the Kubrawī shaykh Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī (d. ca. 839/1436);³⁴⁷ he also lists among the outstanding Shahrūkhi-era poets Kātibī, whom he elsewhere identifies as Ibn Turka’s disciple in “*ilm-i taṣavvuf*”:

As for the shaykhs, notables, scholars and poets of Sultan Shāhrukh’s time, they include the sultan of scholars and verifiers Shams al-Milla wa-l-Dīn Muḥammad al-Ḥāfiẓī al-Bukhārī, known as Kh^wāja Muḥammad Pārsā (God sanctify his spirit); Kh^wāja Ṣā’ in al-Dīn Turka-yi Iṣfahānī; the learned Mawlānā Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī; and the model and pride of scholars Mawlānā Sharaf al-Dīn ‘Alī Yazdī. Among the great poets [of that period] are Shaykh Āzarī, Bābā Sawdā’ī, Mawlānā ‘Alī Shihāb, Amīr Shāhī Sabzavārī, Mawlānā Kātibī Turshīzī and Mawlānā Nasīmī, whose compositions and divans are known throughout the inhabited world³⁴⁸

Compare the faint praise of Ṣā’ in al-Dīn by Kh^wāndamīr (d. ca. 941/1535), the great late Timurid/early Safavid historian, writing between 921-35/1515-29:

³⁴⁷ *Tazkirat al-Shu‘arā*, 340. This Mawlānā Kamāl al-Dīn Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī should not be confused with the later and more famous Kubrawī shaykh Kamāl al-Dīn Ḥusayn Kh^wārazmī, Makhdūm-i A‘ẓam (d. 958/1551) (DeWeese, *The Kashf al-Hudā* 63).

³⁴⁸ *Tazkirat al-Shu‘arā*, 340, 384.

Khwaja Sayinuddin Ali Isfahani was renowned for his personal excellence and philanthropy. Among his works in Arabic and Persian on various topics are a commentary on the *Fusûs'l-hikam*, the *Kitâbu'l-mafâhis*, and a commentary on Ibn al-Farid's qasida. He died in Herat on the 14th of Dhu'l-Hijja 83[5] [August 12, 1432].³⁴⁹

This may be contrasted with his considerably more effusive entry on Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī as fellow historian ("the noblest of the learned men of Iran")³⁵⁰ and Kātibī as chief among the poets of the period ("[f]or subtle poetic nature and sharpness of intellect he was the most outstanding of all the poets of Shāhrukh's time").³⁵¹ As Kh^wādamīr appears to privilege poets, historians and Sufis, his lack of interest in Ṣā'in al-Dīn perhaps stems from the fact that the latter did not fall into any of these categories.

2. Ṣā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn as two of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī's closest disciples

In his *Majālis al-'Ushshāq*, Kamāl al-Dīn Ḥusayn Gāzurgāhī, writing in 909/1503-4, opens his entry on Sulṭān Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī as follows:

Sulṭān Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī, that holy abode (*bayt al-ma'mūr*) in the desert of *This is My path* (Q 6:153), was an ocean brimming with gems of wisdom and [occult] secrets and the choicest parts of sciences beyond counting. He lived in Cairo. Ibn al-Qāzī Rūmī, peerless in learning, was one of his disciples and devotees. This holy man possessed total mastery of the recondite points of elite sciences (*ghavāmiz-i 'ulūm-i khāṣṣ*). Among his disciples were Ḥazrat Ṣā'in al-Dīn Turka and Mawlānā Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī, both of whom were masters of the exoteric and esoteric sciences (*majma' al-baḥrayn*); they spent years engaged in intensive spiritual exercises (*riyāzāt u mujāhadāt*) in an apartment on the ground level (*zīrkhāna*) of [Sayyid Ḥusayn's] house, with their teacher's living quarters on the main floor above (*bālākhāna*).³⁵²

³⁴⁹ *Habibu's-Siyar*, 356. The correct date of death is supplied by Faṣṭḥ Kh^wāfī, *Mujmal al-Tavārikh*, 270.

³⁵⁰ *Habibu's-Siyar*, Tome 3, Pt. 3, 359.

³⁵¹ *Habibu's-Siyar*, Tome 3, Pt. 3, 360-61.

³⁵² *Majālis al-'Ushshāq*, *majlis* 34, 189. The entry goes on to describe a visit by Sultan Barqūq to Akhlāṭī's residence where this *bālākhāna* is explicitly said to be Akhlāṭī's house and feature a door to the outside. The sultan approaches this door, has someone open it and achieves a glimpse of Akhlāṭī within; he then kisses the ground and retreats. Gāzurgāhī then comes to the amorous episode for which he has included Akhlāṭī in his work: One of Barqūq's courtiers, a handsome man, was also a student of Akhlāṭī, and one day came to his master's house bearing three platters, one filled with pure gold, one with gold coins, and one with precious stones, as a gift from the sultan. Akhlāṭī received him and invited him to be seated.

That Gāzurgāhī includes Qāzīzāda Rūmī among Akhlāṭī’s disciples serves to corroborate the existence of a warm relationship between the astronomer and Ṣā’ in al-Dīn in particular, undoubtedly dating to the period they spent as students together in Samarkand under Ṣā’ in al-Dīn’s elder brother Ṣadr al-Dīn.³⁵³

Gāzurgāhī’s entry on Sharaf al-Dīn is very brief, and centers on two of his ghazals on amorous themes. Sharaf al-Dīn’s originality as a thinker is emphasized:

Mawlānā Sharaf al-Dīn ‘Alī, that dawning-point of splendiferous lights, possessed a total command of the exoteric and esoteric sciences and penned many excellent works containing rare knowledge; in his treatises is much that has occurred to no one else. They include the *Kunh al-Murād* [on numerology], *Ḥulal-i Muṭarrāz*, [on the logograph genre], *Ḥaqāyiq al-Tahlīl*,³⁵⁴ *Mavāṭin*,³⁵⁵ and *Sharḥ-i Qaṣīda-yi Burda*. He also has lovely poetry in the manner of Ḥāfiẓ. He often adopts the stance of lover (‘āshiq) [in his verse], and has various ghazals on this theme³⁵⁶

3. Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī as Ṣā’ in al-Dīn’s chief disciple

In his hagiography of Jāmī—which, it must be noted, was checked and approved by Jāmī

He then summoned several eunuchs of the court who were also his companions to prepare their alchemical instruments, whereupon they produced silver and gold and similar gems to send back to the sultan. It emerges that Akhlāṭī is smitten with the young courtier, called the Marrakeshi, and sends to the sultan a request, encoded in a detailed description of alchemical processes, that he release the young man to his own service. The sultan delays in acceding to Akhlāṭī’s request, but finally does so upon Akhlāṭī’s offer to teach him alchemy. Thus one day Akhlāṭī is sitting immersed in sorrowful longing for the young man when the latter appears; Akhlāṭī takes him into his service and he quickly becomes a great saint. The episode ends with the observation that the true end of alchemy, as a prophetic and saintly science, is to turn the copper of existence to gold—for this reason the handsome young courtier had but to behold Akhlāṭī to become a great mystic. Finally, the date of death here ascribed to Akhlāṭī, 777/1375-76, is incorrect (perhaps chosen for its numerological virtue?); we are informed that his grave is in Cairo.

³⁵³ Eichner, “Afḍal al-Dīn Turka,” *El*³; Ragep, “Qāḍī-zāda Rūmī,” *El*².

³⁵⁴ Perhaps a source for Davānī’s *R. Tahlīliyya*?

³⁵⁵ I was unable to identify this work.

³⁵⁶ *Majālis al-‘Ushshāq*, *majlis* 49, 234.

himself—,³⁵⁷ ‘Abd al-Vāsi‘ Bākharzī reports on his master’s dim view of Sharaf al-Dīn and Ṣā’in al-Dīn:

[‘Abd al-Raḥmān later] evaluated Mawlavī Sharafī [i.e., Sharaf al-Dīn] as follows: “He was able to speak about the theory behind some of the issues and technical vocabulary of Sufism (*uṣūl-i masāyil u muṣṭalaḥāt-i qawm*), but not in such a way as to admit of ready comprehension (*taṣarruf-i zihnī*); as a result his presentation remained unconvincing. Yet somehow the thinkers contemporary with [Sharaf al-Dīn] held him to be the most all-encompassing of scholars (*mānand-i vay jāmi‘ī bi naẓar-i shuhūd-i arbāb-i fahm u idrāk dar namī-āmad*), while he himself held that [all his knowledge] was but an instance of the philanthropic impulses (*ḥasanāt*) of Kh^wāja Ṣā’in al-Dīn Turka, and constantly glorified him to all and sundry.”³⁵⁸

That Ṣā’in al-Dīn was regarded as the leader of the Isfahan Circle is confirmed by Akhlāṭī’s letter to Ṣā’in al-Dīn preserved in MS Majlis 10196, wherein he addresses his disciple (*khalīlī*) as the leading luminary among his circle of brethren (*wāsiṭat ‘aqd ikhwānī-hi*).³⁵⁹ In any event, I will examine Bākharzī’s account in full in Chapter 8 (§8.2.2) for the light it sheds on the question of Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s view of and relationship to organized Sufism; here it must only be noted that even an account so patently hostile as Bākharzī’s corroborates Dawlatshāh’s statement that Ṣā’in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn were considered the two leading intellectuals of their day.

4.4.4: Lettrism in the early Safavid period

While far less prolific than his father, Ḥusayn Vā‘iz Kāshifī’s son Fakhr al-Dīn ‘Alī Ṣafī (d. 939/1533) authored several important works, including a definitive history of the Naqshbandi tradition,³⁶⁰ and followed in his father’s footsteps as a famous preacher in Herat.³⁶¹ What

³⁵⁷ Binbaş, “Sharaf al-Dīn,” 72 n. 116.

³⁵⁸ Bākharzī, *Maqāmāt-i Jāmī*, 107.

³⁵⁹ *TMN/M*, front matter; see §2.1.3.1 above. This letter is transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.2 below. Note that Akhlāṭī’s use of *ikhwān* here may be in reference to the *Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’* network; see Binbaş, “Sharaf al-Dīn,” 79–82.

³⁶⁰ His *Rashaḥāt ‘Ayn al-Ḥayāt* has been recently edited by M. Qāzānī and ‘A. I. al-Kayyālī (Beirut, 2008); see

survives of his oeuvre indicates that he shared his father's interest in the occult sciences. His *Tuḥfa-yi Khānī* (aka *Kashf al-Asrār*), for example, on *sīmiyā* and *rīmiyā*,³⁶² was written in 928/1522 for Kh^wāja Muẓaffar Bitikchī³⁶³ in response to the Safavid governor's request that the author extract from his father's famous *Asrār-i Qāsimī* straightforward, easy to understand sections and expand upon them for the benefit of nonexperts, given that the authorities on such sciences habitually obscure their knowledge with highly allusive and recondite discussions lest the unworthy misuse it.³⁶⁴

More important to our present purposes is his *Ḥirz al-Amān min Fitan al-Zamān*, a scholarly, consolidating treatment of the science of letters and its various spiritual and worldly applications.³⁶⁵ In the work's preface 'Alī Ṣafī particularly recommends the science to rulers, given that it enables the adept to bend others to his will, repulse enemies, and achieve other politically useful ends.³⁶⁶ The treatise is arranged according to a 5-5-12 pattern in honor of the *ahl al-kisā'* and the 12 Imams: five *maqālas* having five *bābs* each, with each *bāb* having 12 *faṣls*. (This should not be taken as proof of the author's Shi'i identity; like his father and most

Bashir, *Sufi Bodies*, 96-97. Like his father, 'Alī Ṣafī was active in Naqshbandi circles; he studied under Kh^wāja Aḥrār in Samarkand and married the daughter of Kh^wāja Muḥammad Akbar b. Sa'd al-Dīn Kāshgharī, the son of Jāmī's master (Hanaway, "Ṣafī, Fakhr al-Dīn 'Alī," *El*²).

³⁶¹ His Persian *Anīs al-Ārifīn* collects his spiritual admonitions (*mavā'iz*), and has been recently edited by 'Abd al-Rizā Sayf (Tehran, 1388 Sh./2009).

³⁶² MS Majlis 1065 pp. 175-256, MS Majlis 12575/2 pp. 273-84. *Sīmiyā* here denotes the manipulation of *khayālāt*, imaginal entities, for magical purposes; *rīmiyā* denotes *shu'bada*, conjuring (MS Majlis 1065 pp. 190, 225; see also Lory, "Kashifi's *Asrār-i Qāsimī*," 532-36).

³⁶³ The addressee is identified only as *a'lā-ḥaẓrat-i sulṭānī* and referred to as ruler of Khurasan; this tallies with Kh^wāja Muẓaffar Bitikchī (or Tabakchī), first personal *vazīr* to Shah Ismā'īl, who was given the *laqab* of Sulṭān and appointed governor-general of Khurasan in 927/1521 (Savory, "Some Notes of the Provincial Administration of the Early Safavid Empire," 117).

³⁶⁴ MS Majlis 12575 pp. 273-74.

³⁶⁵ It may be assumed to draw heavily on Ḥusayn Vā'iz's *al-Tuḥfa al-'Aliyya fi 'Ilm al-Ḥurūf*, which is apparently lost.

³⁶⁶ *Ḥirz al-Amān*, Lucknow, 1873, 2-3.

Timurid intellectuals, ‘Alī Ṣafī, a staunch Naqshbandi, was a thoroughgoing imamophile.³⁶⁷)

Most notably, in this work ‘Alī Ṣafī explicitly locates Ṣā’in al-Dīn in the eastern lettrist tradition as the chief disciple of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī, confirming that Ibn Turka’s self-presentation as systematizer and expounder of his master’s works was widely acknowledged in the later lettrist tradition.

Although the bulk of the *Ḥirz al-Amān* is concerned with practical-magical applications of the science of letters, in the first seven sections (*faṣl*) of the first chapter (*bāb*) of the first *maqāla* of the treatise ‘Alī Ṣafī offers a comprehensive overview of the lettrist tradition and its preeminent authorities from the perspective of early 10th/16th century Iran. In particular, it should be noted that in section 1.1.5 the author lists as his primary sources for the treatise such standard eminences as Būnī, Muḥammad al-Kūmī al-Tūnisī, Ibn ‘Arabī, ‘Abd Allāh al-Yāfi‘ī and Ibn Waḥshiyya, adding to this list Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī and his disciples—Ṣā’in al-Dīn most prominently among them—as well as his own father, Ḥusayn Vā‘iz, to whom he attributes no less than five lettrist works.³⁶⁸ Section 1.1.4 reproduces the division between the *ahl-i ḥaqīqat*, i.e., those concerned with the letters’ underlying reality, and the *ahl-i khāṣṣiyyat*, i.e., those concerned with their active properties, that Ṣā’in al-Dīn assumes in his *R. Ḥurūf*; examples of the approach of each camp are then given in sections 1.1.6 and 1.1.7 respectively.³⁶⁹ Given the degree to which this overview reflects the canonization of the broader lettrist tradition surveyed in the present chapter, I accordingly summarize or translate these seven sections in full:³⁷⁰

³⁶⁷ See §1.4 above.

³⁶⁸ These being his *Javāhir al-Tafsīr*, *Tafsīr-i Mavāhib*, *Tuḥfa-yi ‘Aliyya*, *Marṣad al-Asnā fī Istikhrāj al-Asmā’ al-Ḥusnā*, and *Lavā’ih al-Qamar* (see section 1.1.5 below). The inclusion of the *Mavāhib-i ‘Aliyya* and the *Lavā’ih al-Qamar* is somewhat inexplicable, given that the first is a tafsir with little esoteric content, and the second is wholly concerned with astrological elections.

³⁶⁹ Cf. §3.1 above.

³⁷⁰ *Ḥirz al-Amān*, Lucknow, 1873, 4-10. As this lithograph printing is often defective, I have emended

1.1.1: *The science of letters as transmitted by the Imams*

The author defines *‘ilm al-ḥurūf* or *‘ilm al-jafr* as dealing with the realities (*ḥaqā’iq*) and properties (*khawāṣṣ*) of the letters, the divine names and quranic verses,³⁷¹ and associates the science with the five members of the house of the Prophet in the first place, beginning with ‘Alī and transmitted down through the line of the succeeding 11 Imams, particularly Ja‘far al-Ṣādiq. ‘Alī Ṣāfi states that the preface of the *K. al-Sirr al-Maṣūn wa-l-Jawhar al-Maknūn*, attributed to Ghazālī,³⁷² expresses the book’s derivation from ‘Alī’s book, *al-Jafr wa-l-Jāmi‘*. Apart from the Imams only a few individuals of advanced learning know this science. Ja‘far al-Ṣādiq is most responsible for the form in which it exists.

1.1.2: *On using jafr to predict events*

‘Alī is reported as identifying Q 42:1-2 (*ḤM ‘SQ*) as particularly useful with respect to using *jafr* to predict events. Both the *Tafsīr* of al-Tha‘labī and a certain treatise by al-Qushayrī relate that when this verse was revealed to the Prophet he appeared exhausted, this because of its predicting great woes to befall humanity at the end of days. Another episode is related in which Imam Ḥusayn was asked the meaning of Q 19:1 (*KHY‘Ş*), to which he responded by saying that were he to divulge its meaning his listeners would be able to walk on water.

various readings on the basis of MS Majlis 15708 ff. 4a-8a and MS Majlis 4317 ff. 3a-7a.

³⁷¹ I.e., including both theoretical and applied aspects of the science.

³⁷² ‘Abd al-Raḥmān Badawī (*Mu‘allafāt al-Ghazālī*, 341-42, no. 208) notes the existence of three MSS with this title attributed to Ghazālī, including MS Süleymaniye 919, which is presented as Ghazālī’s collection of statements from ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib’s *K. al-Jafr*. Note also MS FB 16/2 in the National Library, Ankara, which preserves a work entitled *Sharḥ Jafr al-Imām al-A‘zam* attributed to Ghazālī. In addition, two treatises were printed in Cairo (undated) under the general title *al-Awfāq li-l-Imām al-Ghazālī*: *R. al-‘ilm al-Maknūn wa-l-Sirr al-Maṣūn* and *R. fī Kayfiyya wa-Kitābat al-Jafr*. A slightly different title, *al-Sirr al-Maṣūn al-Mustanbaṭ min al-Qur‘ān al-Maknūn*, is preserved in several further MSS (*Mu‘allafāt*, 284-85, no. 109).

1.1.3: Examples of predicted events

An episode involving Ma'mūn and Imam Mūsā al-Riḍā. The reconquest of Jerusalem in 583 A.H. by Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn as foretold [by Ibn Barraḡān] on the basis of Q 30:1-4 and discussed in the second chapter of Ibn 'Arabī's *al-Futūḡāt al-Makkiyya*.³⁷³

1.1.4: On the nobility of this science and the classes of its practitioners

The science of letters is a universal science (*az jumla-yi 'ulūm-i kulliyya*), and as such many venerable scholars have investigated it deeply. The definition given by Būnī in his *Shams al-Ma'ārif*. There are two classes of practitioners of this science: those concerned with the letters' underlying realities (*ahl-i ḡaḡīqat*), and those concerned with its active properties (*ahl-i khāṣṣiyyat*).

1. The *ahl-i ḡaḡīqat* are capable of deriving all types of knowledge from various sciences, encompassing all the levels of existence from the divine presence to the degrees of the physical realm, from the letters. Examples of works which treat of this type of theoretical letterism: source works such as *Jafr-i Kabīr*, *Jafr-i Jāmi'* and *Jafr-i Khābiya*, and recent works such as the *R. al-Sajanjal* and *K. al-Maḡbūb* [of Ḥamuvayī], *Dā'ira-yi Saniyya* [or *Sabtiyya*], *Kashf al-Ma'ād fī Tafsīr Abījād*, *K. al-Alfayn*, etc.
2. The *ahl-i khāṣṣiyyat* are far more numerous and well-known than the first group, and are concerned with the active properties of the forms of the letters, whether spoken or written. They hold that when a person utters or writes at a set time certain letters or a certain word or quranic verse or sura a set number of times, and then contemplates it, or buries it, or erases it, or leaves it in a particular place, a specific benefit will accrue to him in that regard, whether physical or spiritual in nature. Most people use the science of letters in this fashion, i.e., to attract a benefit or defend against harm.

Most of the quoted material in this treatise is concerned with the second approach and its practical applications.

³⁷³ See §5.2.1.1 below.

1.1.5: The major exponents of this science and the main books referenced or quoted in this treatise

The great exponents of this science mastered both approaches, theoretical and applied. They include:

1. Shaykh Abū l-‘Abbās Aḥmad b. ‘Alī al-Qurashī al-Būnī (d. 7th/13th c.), *Shams al-Ma‘ārif* (*Akbar u Aṣghar*), *Ta’līqā* (*Kubrā u Ṣuḡhrā*), *al-Lam‘a al-Nūrāniyya wa-l-Lamḥa al-Rūḥāniyya*, *Khatamāt al-Suwar al-Qur’ānī*, *Alwāḥ al-Dhahab*, etc. All of his works on the subject are widely used, particularly the *Shams al-Ma‘ārif* and *Khatamāt*, both of which are frequently quoted in this treatise.
2. Shaykh Abū ‘Abd Allāh Muḥammad b. Muḥammad b. Ya‘qūb [al-Kūmī] al-Tūnisī al-Maghribī (d. 810/1407), *Taysīr al-Maṭālib*,³⁷⁴ this is frequently quoted here.
3. Shaykh Muḥyī l-Dīn Muḥammad b. ‘Alī [b.] al-‘Arabī (d. 638/1240), *al-Madkhal fi ‘Ilm al-Ḥurūf*. Ibn ‘Arabī is renowned as a master of both approaches.
4. Shaykh Taqī l-Dīn ‘Abd Allāh b. ‘Alī b. Ḥasan al-Tujībī (Andalus?), *al-Lamḥa*, on the realities and spiritual meanings of the letters.
5. Shaykh Abū Ḥāmid Muḥammad al-Ghazālī (d. 505/1111), *al-Sirr al-Maṣūn wa-l-Jawhar al-Maknūn*,³⁷⁵ he is renowned as a master of both approaches.³⁷⁶
6. Shaykh ‘Afīf al-Dīn ‘Abd Allāh b. As‘ad al-Tamīmī al-Yāfi‘ī [al-Yamānī] (d. Mecca 768/1367),³⁷⁷ [*Mukhtaṣar*] *al-Durr al-Naẓīm fi Manāfi‘ al-Qur’ān al-‘Azīm*,³⁷⁸ on the properties of the divine names, verses and suras. Much of the fourth and fifth *maqālas* in the present treatise consist of quotes from this work. He is also renowned as a master of both approaches.

³⁷⁴ See Ḥājjī Khalīfa, *Kashf al-Zunūn*, 1/519. Cf. Būnī’s *isnād* for the *kalimat al-shahāda*, which features al-Kūmī as the most recent link (A1).

³⁷⁵ See section 1.1.1 of the present paraphrase.

³⁷⁶ For Bisṭāmī’s inclusion of Ghazālī in the lettrist tradition see §4.3.4 above.

³⁷⁷ ‘Afīf al-Dīn ‘Abd Allāh b. As‘ad al-Yāfi‘ī was the Shaykh al-Ḥaramayn (Fāsī, *Dhayl al-Taḥyīd fi Ruwāt al-Sunan wa-l-Masānīd*, 2/29, no. 1105). He also compiled a collection of stories of saints entitled *Rawḍ al-Rayāḥīn*. Yāfi‘ī’s version of the *al-Durr al-Naẓīm* was printed in Cairo in 1282/1865, 1315/1898 and 1323/1905, and more recently in Beirut in 1999 (ed. Muḥsin ‘Aqīl); it is apparently a condensed version of the *al-Durr al-Naẓīm* of Ibn al-Khashshāb (d. ca. 1252) (Huart, *A History of Arabic Literature*, 348). The preface states that it is conceived of as a synthesis between the *al-Barq al-Lāmi‘ wa-l-Ghayth al-Hāmi‘* of Qāḍī Abū Bakr Ghassānī and the *Khawāṣṣ al-Qur’ān* and *Fawātiḥ al-Suwar* of Ghazālī, and it often quotes from Būnī and Abū l-Ḥasan ‘Alī al-Shādhilī (d. 656/1258), as well as from the two books *Mustawjibat al-Maḥāmid fi Sharḥ Khātām Abī Ḥāmid* and *Shifā’ al-Ṣudūr wa-l-Abdān fi Sirr Manāfi‘ al-Qur’ān*; the Persian translation printed in Bombay in 1311/1894 does not appear to correspond to the Arabic text (Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī‘a*, 8/83, no. 306; 13/245, no. 886).

³⁷⁸ This work was translated and commented upon by ‘Abd al-‘Alī Bīrjandī in 901/1496, as noted in the later Persian translation by Aḥmad b. al-Ḥājj Muḥammad Sakkākī Ṭabasī completed in 926/1520 (Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī‘a*, 4/101, no. 474).

7. Shaykh Muḥammad b. Ibrāhīm al-Tamīmī al-Kāzīrūnī, *Khawāṣṣ al-Qur'ān*; the *al-Durr al-Naẓīm* of Shaykh 'Afīf al-Dīn quotes extensively from this work, and so it too is frequently quoted in the fourth and fifth *maqālas* of the present treatise.
8. Shaykh Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī (d. 606/1209), *Lawāmi' al-Bayyināt*,³⁷⁹ on the divine names and attributes.³⁸⁰
9. Mawlānā Ya'qūb Charkhī (d. 851/1447),³⁸¹ *R. Khawāṣṣ Asmā' Allāh*.
10. *K. Sirr al-Āyāt*, the statements of Ibn 'Abbās (d. 69/688) compiled by his students; it is frequently quoted in this treatise.

There are many other works on this subject, whether penned by the ancient sages (*ḥukamā-yi mutaqaḍdimīn*) or latter-day scholars (*'ulamā-yi muta'akhhirīn*), that are referenced in this treatise, e.g.:

1. The book of the sage Yaghmārbūs [Yaghmādnūsh?], a strange and wonderful book treating of the effects produced by the active properties of letters. He was one of Aristotle's foremost students and one of the philosophers at Alexander's capital.
2. Ḥakīm Abū Bakr 'Alī Ibn Waḥshiyya (d. 318/930), *K. al-Hayākil wa-l-Tamāthīl*,³⁸² Ibn Waḥshiyya is of course famous and held by scholars to have a comprehensive mastery of this science.
3. Shaykh Najīb al-Dīn Ḥusayn Sakkākī, a treatise on the properties of the letters.³⁸³
4. Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (d. 799/1397), who has many short tracts and treatises on the science; he in turn inspired a number of scholars (*muqtabisāt-i mishkāt-i ḥaqāyiq-i īshān*), in particular Kh^wāja Ṣā'īn al-Dīn Turka,³⁸⁴ who is renowned as a master of both approaches.
5. *K. Durra-yi Maknūna*, written by one of the great masters of this science and comprising rare material on the properties of letters.
6. *K. Ḥall Qawā'id al-Jafr al-Kabīr*, written by one of the students of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī.

³⁷⁹ Rāzī's *Lawāmi' al-Bayyināt fī l-Asmā' wa-l-Ṣifāt* is preserved in MS Dānishgāh 4154 (dated 4 Jumādā II 1095/19 May 1684) and MS Āstān-i Quds 426 (Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī'a*, 18/365, no. 483).

³⁸⁰ Cf. Abū Bakr Rāzī's (d. 313/925 or 323/935) *K. al-Asrār*, the source for most of Būnī's treatment of alchemy in the *Shams al-Ma'ārif* (Ruska, "Die Alchimie ar-Rāzī's").

³⁸¹ Ya'qūb Charkhī, from the region of Ghaznī, was a successor of Bahā' al-Dīn Naqshband and master of 'Ubayd Allāh Aḥrār.

³⁸² Nothing is known of this work; see Fahd, "Ibn Waḥshiyya," *El*².

³⁸³ Perhaps the *K. al-Shāmil* attributed to Sakkākī by Biṣṭāmī in his *K. al-Durra al-Nāsi'a* (MS Hafid Efendi 461 f. 254b)?

³⁸⁴ MS Majlis 15708 p. 54 gives his name as simply Kh^wāja Ziyā' al-Dīn, and Āqā Buzurg in his summary of this list inexplicably has Nizām al-Dīn Turk (*al-Dharī'a*, 6/393, no. 2439).

7. Finally, the five letterist works³⁸⁵ written by the author's father, Ḥusayn Vā'iz Kāshifī (d. 910/1504): *Javāhir al-Tafsīr*,³⁸⁶ *Tafsīr-i Mavāhib*,³⁸⁷ *Tuḥfa-yi 'Aliyya*,³⁸⁸ *Marṣad al-Asnā fī Istikhrāj al-Asmā' al-Ḥusnā*, and *Lavā'ih al-Qamar*.³⁸⁹

The author has relied on all the works listed above in composing this treatise and draws upon them frequently.

1.1.6: Positing the spirits and natures of the letters according to the ahl-i ḥaqīqat

In his explication of the fourth hadith cited in his *K. al-Aḥādīth*, Ṣadr al-Dīn Qūnavī states that each individual letter exists as such before becoming compounded (*tarkīb*) with the properties (*khavāṣṣ*) and benefits (*manāfi'*) imparted to it by its associated spirit; all such things are effects and actions that arise from the realities (*ḥaqāyiq*) behind the letters. In commenting on Ṣadr al-Dīn's view, one of the Verifiers (*ahl-i taḥqīq*) states that the term 'spirits' (*arvāḥ*) as applied to the letters may be taken as standing metonymically for their natures or natural properties (*ṭabā'iyi'*), involving the mix of heat, cold, wetness and dryness peculiar to each. Each of these natural properties in turn has its own entification (*ta'ayyun*) specific to the species (*naw'ī*) and individual (*shakhṣī*) in a particular form. When the spirituality (*rūḥāniyyat*) of a given letter is represented to those experiencing unveiling (*ṣāḥib-i kashf*) in an imaginal form (*ṣūrat-i misālī*), that form must needs be distinct from all other imaginal forms. Thus each of the 28 letters possesses its own form at a species level, and each individual representative of a species has its own individual form. The individual forms of each of these 28 species appears to those who experience unveiling in a single, universal form (*ṣūratī vāḥid-i kullī*) in the imaginal realm termed the *barzakh*; it is from these imaginal forms—the spirits or realities of the letters—that universal, encompassing effects (*āṣār-i kullī*) manifest in the world of generation and corruption. The experiential findings (*tajriba*) of the lettermasters (*arbāb-i ḥurūf*) stand irrefutable testimony to this.

³⁸⁵ Kāshifī also devoted a work to numerology, *R. dar 'Ilm-i A'dād* (Subtelny, "Kāṣefi," *Elr*).

³⁸⁶ The *Javāhir al-Tafsīr li-Tuḥfat al-Amīr* was written for 'Alī Shīr Navā'ī; Kāshifī stopped work on this *tafsīr* at the beginning of the fourth sura and instead embarked on his much more streamlined and popular *Mavāhib-i 'Aliyya* (Sands, "On the Popularity of Husayn Vā'iz-i Kashifī's *Mavāhib-i 'aliyya*," 470).

³⁸⁷ I.e., the *Mavāhib-i 'Aliyya* or *Tafsīr-i Ḥusaynī*, written in 897-99/1491-94 for 'Alī Shīr Navā'ī; it was edited and published in Tehran in 1938-50 (see Subtelny, "Kāṣefi, Kamāl-al-Dīn Ḥosayn Wā'ez," *Elr*; Sands, "Kashifī's *Mavāhib*").

³⁸⁸ The *al-Tuḥfa al-'Aliyya fī 'Ilm al-Ḥurūf wa-Bayān Asrāri-hā* is an otherwise unknown work compiled for Shaykh 'Abd Allāh Naqshbandī (Yousofi, "Kāshifī," *Elr*²).

³⁸⁹ The *Lavā'ih al-Qamar*, or *Ikhtiyārāt al-Nujūm*, was written in 878/1473 as part of the author's *Sab'a-yi Kāshifiyya*, treating of astrology and astronomy; it seems that it is the only book of the Septet to have survived, or perhaps the other books were never completed (see Tourkin and Vesel, "The Contribution of Husayn Vā'iz Kashifī"; Subtelny, "Kāṣefi," *Elr*). The popularity of this work is suggested by the fact that at least 93 MSS of this work are preserved in Iran alone (AB).

That class of sages who focus on the properties of letters attribute these effects to the peculiar nature (*khāṣṣiyyat*) of the letters, and hold that reason is incapable of finding any purchase on this subject through ratiocination (*naẓar-i fikrī*)—indeed, it is wholly beyond the reach of reason, as the author of the *Garden of Secrets* (*Gulshan-i Rāz*) sings:

Man has beyond his reason yet another rung
by [climbing] which he learns of secrets hidden.

Experimentation (*tajriba*) aimed at manifesting the effects and properties of the letters has often been successfully repeated; and experiment is among the forms of proof that produce certainty (*tajriba yakī az isbāt-i yaqīn ast*).³⁹⁰

1.1.7: *Positing the spirits and natures of the letters according to the ahl-i khāṣṣiyyat*

Know that a group of the experts in this discipline hold that the spirits of the letters obtain by virtue of their associated numbers, and the forms of the letters and the shape of the numbers' written bodies in magic squares (*alwāḥ-i vafqī*) and other [arrangements] by means of a powerful harmony and agreement between the spirits and numerical realities of the letters many wonderful properties and strange effects manifest, as is considered clear and demonstrable by the masters of this discipline in a way that admits of no doubt. In his *Shams al-Ma'ārif al-Akbar* Shaykh Sharaf al-Dīn Būnī states: 'The numbers have secrets [or: effects], just as the letters have effects.' In his *Alwāḥ al-Dhahab* [the same author] relates that in the time of the kings of Persia Kāva the blacksmith went out against Żahhāk, for the latter had killed one of his sons and was purposing to kill another. Despite Żahhāk's royal power Kāva slew him, released Farīdūn from prison and installed him as king, all this through the aid of the properties of numbers and the effect of the numerical realities of letters. For one of the sages of the time had constructed for Kāva a magic square; having bound it on the top of a spear, Kāva went out and many people flocked to him, and he performed glorious deeds beyond the compass of men by virtue of the blessing imparted by those numerical tables. This spear came to be called the Kāvyanī standard, and such was its efficacy that it remained to the house of the kings of Persia for two millennia. But God knows best.

‘Alī Ṣafī's emphasis here on the experimental validity of the science of letters may be noted in particular. Unlike some earlier lettrist works, which stress the reliability of the chain of authorities from which their information derives,³⁹¹ late medieval and early modern lettrist

³⁹⁰ Cf. the *kutub al-mujarrabāt* or books on occult medicine comprising tried and true techniques, e.g. the *Mujarrabāt* of Abū ‘Abd Allāh Muḥammad b. Yūsuf al-Sanūsī (d. 895/1490) and Aḥmad al-Dayrabī (d. ca. 1151/1739) (O'Connor, "Popular and Talismanic Uses of the Qur'ān," EQ). The more precise term used for experimental testing or verification is *i'tibār* (lit., 'to take account of') (see Kheirandish, "Science and *Mithāl*: Demonstrations in Arabic and Persian Scientific Traditions," 468, 470).

³⁹¹ Cf. Rashīd al-Dīn Ṭabīb's assertion to this effect in his *R. Ḥurūf* (see §4.3.1 above, point 18), as well as Ibn

thinkers assert the wholly objective, replicable nature of this science. ‘Alī Ṣafī’s statements to this effect in section 1.1.6 above therefore bear repeating:

The experiential findings (*tajriba*) of the masters of the letters (*arbāb-i ḥurūf*) stand irrefutable testimony to [the fact that the imaginal forms of the letters can be harnessed to produce effects in the physical world] ... Experimentation aimed at manifesting the effects and properties of the letters has often been successfully repeated; and experiment is among the forms of proof that produce certainty (*tajriba yakī az isbāt-i yaqīn ast*).

Or as his father says in the *Javāhir al-Tafsīr* in a discussion on the medicinal properties of letters:

“What is seen firsthand needs no explanation (*al-‘iyān lā yaḥtāj ilā l-bayān*).”³⁹²

4.5: Epilogue: The fate of intellectual lettrism in Iran in the modern period

Suggestive as ‘Alī Ṣafī’s scholarly presentation is, it is beyond the remit of this study to delve further into Safavid-era and later developments. The continuation of popular Hurufism directly in the Nuṣṭawī movement of Maḥmūd Pasīkhānī on the one hand³⁹³ and indirectly in the Bektāshī dervish order in Anatolia and the Balkans on the other³⁹⁴ has attracted some

Khaldūn’s in the *Muqaddima* (3/174; see §4.2 above): “The fact that it is possible to be active in the world of nature with the help of the letters and the words composed of them, and that the created things can be influenced in this way, cannot be denied. It is confirmed by continuous tradition on the authority of many (practitioners of letter magic).”

³⁹² Kāshifī, *Javāhir al-Tafsīr*, 260.

³⁹³ See e.g. Amanat, “The Nuṣṭawī Movement of Maḥmūd Pisīkhānī and His Persian Cycle of Mystical-Materialism”; Kiyā, *Nuṣṭaviyān yā Pasīkhāniyān*. Interestingly enough, Hurufism was revived in the modern era by the Lettrist movement founded by Isidore Isou (d. 2007) in Paris in the mid-1940s, whose philosophy bears a striking resemblance in certain respects to that of the Faḏl Allāh. Indeed, a recent Situationist tract, “The End of the Age of Divinity (On the Death of Isou)” (<<http://antisystemic.org/SW/TheEndOfTheAgeOfDivinity-Enkutatach409.pdf>> (accessed 10/11/11)), explicitly identifies Isou’s death as closing the age of divinity opened by Faḏl Allāh’s death and inaugurating a new age, that of the proletariat. Note the modification to Faḏl Allāh’s claim to have initiated the age of divinity during his lifetime, as well as the announcement of the age of the proletariat; the interest of Azerbaijani and Iranian Marxists active in the 1960s and 1970s in Faḏl Allāh and the Turkish Hurufi poet Nesīmī (d. 820/1417) as early, ultimately unsuccessful champions of a nationalistic historical materialism begs to be explored in this connection (Bashir, *Fazlallah*, 123).

³⁹⁴ See §4.3.3 above.

scholarly attention, as have the writings of Shaykh Aḥmad al-Aḥsā'ī (d. 1214/1826), who argued forcefully for the understanding of the world as text.³⁹⁵ Given the precedent of the Shaykhiyya, Sayyid 'Alī Muḥammad Shīrāzī (d. 1267/1850), the Bāb, appears to have been a lettrist in no less measure; for example, in his *K. Panj Sha'n* the Bāb credits God with the statement:

I have created the letters and made them the keys of every science (*maḥātīḥ kull 'ilm*) ... [C]onsider everything from the most exalted heights to the lowliest atom: you shall behold it all in the twenty-eight letters, just as you have beheld all the letters in it; and you shall behold all the spirits of the letters in their spirits ... In brief, all things are confined to the twenty-eight letters (of the alphabet). Likewise, the creation of all things is confined to the meanings contained in these letters.³⁹⁶

As we have seen in this chapter, such a statement could equally well have been made in 7th/13th century Damascus, 8th/14th century Cairo, 9th/15th century Isfahan, or 10th/16th century Herat. There is little need to posit specifically Hurufi influences given the ubiquity in Iran of more mainstream forms of lettrist thought, although the messianic nature of both movements does invite comparison.³⁹⁷ Finally, another starting point for further inquiry is the

³⁹⁵ Cole, “The World as Text: Cosmologies of Shaykh Ahmad al-Ahsa’i.” Shaykhism in turn gave rise to Babism and the Baha’i faith, both of which movements attribute great importance to lettrist symbolism (Amanat, “The Persian Bayan,” 339; Windfuhr, “Jafr,” *EIr*).

³⁹⁶ The rest of the passage in full: “Among the bounties bestowed by God on the Point of the Bayān (i.e. the Bāb) is the knowledge of all things in a single person (*nafs-i wāḥid*), so that he may behold the creation (*takwīn*) in the world of letters, with the eye of certitude. This is a perfect proof unto all men, like the verses. It was one of those things hidden in the divine knowledge which was not sent down until now and it is more glorious than any other knowledge. All the (holy) books were sent down and shall be sent down on the basis of this knowledge ... In brief, all things are confined to the twenty-eight letters (of the alphabet). Likewise, the creation of all things is confined to the meanings contained in these letters. God has collected together these letters in eleven degrees within His knowledge (i.e. 11 degrees corresponding to the sum of the letters *hā'* and *wāw*, representing existence or *huwiyya*) and has established them as the talisman (*haykal*) of the Primal Will (*mashiyyat-i awwaliyya*), which is the Primal Man (*insān-i awwal*). The outward form (*ẓāhir*) of the talisman is the *hā'* (= 5), while its inward nature (*bāṭin*) is the *wāw* (= 6). He then created eighteen talismans in the shadow of this talisman, within the ocean of names (i.e. in the world of the divine names). Nor can they become twenty, for the utmost limit of the number of the names is the name *mustaghāth* (= 2001)” (trans. in MacEoin, *The Messiah of Shiraz*, 542-44). As a natural application of lettrist theory the Bāb placed a premium on the science of talismans (ibid., 544-56). For more on Babism and Baha’ism see the seminal studies by Abbas Amanat (e.g., *Resurrection and Renewal*; “The Persian Bayan and the Shaping of the Babi Renewal,” esp. p. 339), Todd Lawson (e.g. *Gnostic Apocalypse and Islam*), and Juan Cole (e.g., *Modernity and Millennium*).

³⁹⁷ As Denis MacEoin notes, “while many of [the Bab’s] ideas and the forms in which they are cast find important and sometimes detailed parallels in Ismā’īlī and Ḥurūfī thought in particular, it is not, I think,

work of Kh^wāja Muḥammad b. Maḥmūd Dihdār Shīrāzī, *takhalluṣ Fānī* (d. 1016/1607), who appears to have been an important lettrist in the tradition of western Iran and transmitter of such to India.³⁹⁸

In the absence of focused research, however, we cannot know the extent to which the type of intellectual lettrism promoted by universalist thinkers like Ibn Turka prospered or flagged. Interest in the practical-magical applications of lettrism is certainly little abated in the modern period, especially in the Maghrib—with the advent of printing Būnī is more ubiquitous now than ever he was. Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s championing of the theoretical aspect of the science notwithstanding, however, it seems that its popular forms have proved more resilient in the face of the ‘Enlightenment’ objectification or denaturing of language.³⁹⁹ As I note in the Conclusion, Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s reputation as the preeminent lettrist thinker of Shahrukhid Iran appears to have been seriously compromised by the Qajar period, when his lesser philosophical-mystical works, particularly the *Tamhīd al-Qawā’id*, came into vogue during the revival of Sadrian philosophy in the late 13th/19th century; this gave rise to Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s

necessary to look for direct influences from these sources” (*The Messiah of Shiraz*, 330). Indeed, one of the burdens of the present study is to show the ubiquity of lettrism in late medieval and early modern Islamicate thought, freeing researchers of the need to refer to the Hurufis specifically when more general considerations will do.

³⁹⁸ As Corbin notes, “He is the representative *par excellence* of the mystical theosophy of Shiism, in the tradition of Rajab al-Bursi. He also practised divination (*jafr*) and arithmosophy—in short, the sciences which are the equivalent in Islamic gnosis of the techniques of the Cabbalah. He wrote about ten works, all of which are worthy of study. We can mention here only *The Pearl of the Orphan*, and *The Letter ‘Alif as a Symbol of the Human Form*, which discusses the knowledge of the degrees of the soul up to the degree of the cosmic man or macrocosm. The following is an extract: ‘Know that the metaphysical reality of man is the metaphysical reality of Muhammad. I shall begin, therefore, with the *tafsir* of two surahs one of which is the surah ‘The Morning’: ‘Did not your lord find you as an orphan, and did he not give you hospitality?’” (*History of Islamic Philosophy*, 337). His works include *I’jāz Mafātīḥ al-I’jāz*, *R. al-Wijdāniyyāt wa-l-Dhawqiyyāt*, *Nafā’is al-Arqām*, *Durr-i Yatīm*, *Raqā’iq al-Ḥaqā’iq*, *R. Niẓām Shāh/R. bi Jihat-i Niẓām*, *R. dar Dhawq*, *Manẓūma fī l-Taḥqīq* and *Ishrāq al-Nayyirayn*.

³⁹⁹ Horkheimer and Adorno, *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, 1-34; Foucault, *The Order of Things*, 35-49, 321-27. This is not to say, however, that intellectual-Sufi lettrism is wholly without practitioners. Suleyman Joukhadar, whose research focuses on lettrism, currently has a small following of Shadhili students in Damascus; moreover, certain members of the Perennialist school, particularly René Guénon (d. 1951) and his disciples, embrace a form of Sufi lettrism (I am indebted to Yousef Casewit for alerting me to this fact).

reception in modern scholarship as a standard-issue Shi'i mystical philosopher, which ignores the main thrust of our occult philosopher's project. The internal cultural process whereby intellectual lettrism became marginalized in Qajar Iran specifically and the modern Islamicate world generally is a topic that begs study.

CHAPTER 5

Political uses of lettrism

*Let also Turpitude, Derision, Contempt, Loquacity, and Imposture descend, and into that seat, let there succeed Magic, Prophecy, and all divination and prognostication judged to be good and useful by their effects.*¹

—Giordano Bruno

It is difficult making predictions, especially about the future.

—Niels Bohr

Applied lettrism, concerned as it frequently is with prognosticating the rise and fall of states and charting the cycles of history, cannot but have political ramifications. This is unsurprising given its origin in the science of *jafr*, or divination, which was identified wholly with the House of the Prophet by way of protest in the wake of the ‘Alid political defeat.² As Ṣā’in al-Dīn and many other lettrists aver, the quranic *muqaṭṭa’āt* were understood from the beginning to contain information on the rise and fall of states, with particular reference to the political fortunes of the Muslim community.

In this chapter, then, I briefly survey various political uses of lettrism, centering on three in particular: 1) the construction of books of *jafr*; 2) political prognostication based on the Quran as a technique of dynastic legitimation; and 3) predictions based on the names of

¹ *Spaccio della bestia trionfante*, ed. Michele Ciliberto, Milan, 1985, 818; trans. in de León-Jones, *Giordano Bruno and the Kabbalah*, 159.

² Masad, “Medieval Islamic Apocalyptic,” 107ff.; Fahd, “Djafr,” *El*².

political actors or associated terms. This last includes Šā'in al-Dīn's prognostication, made for Shāhrukh, of the duration of the Timurid state.

5.1: Definition of *jafr*

The term *jafr*, in practical terms, is often taken to refer to lettrism in general; that is to say, *jafr* and *‘ilm al-ḥurūf* are often used interchangeably. Technically, however, it refers to the science of book divination, particularly with respect to political events.³ In the Islamicate context this science derives from the *K. al-Jafr al-Jāmi‘* attributed to ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib and passed down through the line of the Imams.⁴ Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī defines *jafr* as follows:

The lexical meaning of *jafr* is calfskin; it is used in a technical sense by the folk of reality (*ahl-i ḥaqq*) to refer to the procedure of deriving (*istikhrāj*) [knowledge of] worldly and human affairs and detailed historical information (*juz’iyyāt-i dahr u naba’-i zamānī*), this to the extent of human ability, [through the construction of a book of *jafr*].⁵

Nevertheless, a certain confusion as to the precise meaning of the term persisted even into the 12th/18th century. Muḥammad Salīm al-Wā‘iẓ al-Mawṣilī al-Ḥanafī (fl. 1144/1732), for example, states that his uncertainty on the subject led him to survey various definitions of the science of *jafr* in the first section of his treatise *al-Kawākib al-Durriyya fī l-Uṣūl al-Jafrīyya*.⁶ As he observes, he has found the books of Ibn ‘Arabī to be the most useful introductions to the subject. He accordingly opens with (Pseudo-)Ibn ‘Arabī’s definition, followed by

³ On the evolution of this term see Masad, “Medieval Islamic Apocalyptic,” 124-26; Fahd, “Djafr,” *El²*; Windfuhr, “Jafr,” *Elr*. Ibn Khaldūn devotes a section of his *Muqaddima* to the practice of divination, dwelling in particular on the *K. al-Jafr* transmitted on the authority of Ja‘far al-Šādiq and containing prophetic information on the fate of the members of Muḥammad’s house and the esoteric meaning of the Quran (2/200-10). Windfuhr further relates *jafr* to the *mu‘ammā* genre (“Riddles and Chronograms”); cf. Sharaf al-Dīn’s lettrist theoretization of the *mu‘ammā* in his *Ḥulal-i Muṭarraz*.

⁴ Modarressi, *Tradition and Survival*, 1/4-12, 17-20.

⁵ MS Majlis 16359 ff. 67a, MS Majlis 14374/2 ff. 6a.

⁶ Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī‘a*, 18/179. See e.g. Ankara MS Milli A 309/4 ff. 19a-41b.

(Pseudo-)Qūnavī's expansion thereupon:

The subject of this science is the letters taken as sources of information in their own right (*naba' mustaqill bi-l-dalāla*). Its method (*dalīl*) is close investigation (*istiqrā'*); its virtue is [that it allows its practitioner] to attain to the comprehension of the Muḥammadan address. This can only obtain through knowledge of the science of the holy and heavenly (*malakūti*) Arabic language peculiar to Muḥammad (peace be upon him)—it being his ultimate cause (*'illatu-hu l-ghā'iyya*) ... Al-Qunawī states in his commentary on the *al-Shajara al-Nu'māniyya* [attributed to Ibn 'Arabī]: “The subject of the science of *jafr* is the demonstration of the power of God Most High. You are well aware that what the Shaykh (God sanctify his holy secret) held as to what [this science] does and does not consist in represents the truth of the matter, so consider: he defined it as a science whose subject is the letters and their parts—which are themselves letters⁷—insofar as they serve to indicate events (*ḥawādith*), [knowledge of which is] contained within the treasures of the letters and their parts by decree of divine wisdom. The knowledge of such indications is dependent upon planetary conjunctions (*al-iqtirānāt al-kawkabīyya*) in their proper celestial spheres and detailed information about these spheres, as well as the types of benefit and harm with which God most high has invested them. He has made the [letters] the sites of manifestation for such things, although the [letters] do not exert any effect (*ta'thīr*) of themselves, not even a partial effect, apart from their status as sites of manifestation. God Most High is Himself the Agent (*fā'il, mu'aththir*), while man and other [existents] such as the planets and spheres are typical intermediary causes wholly without the ability to affect the decree of God most high”⁸

Mawṣilī's conservatism in this regard comes through most clearly in his apology for *jafr*; he explains away jurists' condemnation of the science as being motivated by their concern to keep the unqualified from dabbling in matters beyond their ken, for *jafr* is only to be practiced by the most learned of scholars. He goes so far as to argue that *jafr* should not even be considered an occult science, that is, one dealing with matters invisible (*ghayb*), since it depends on well-established principles and numerous conditions (*qawā'id maḍbūṭa wa-sharā'it ma'dūda*) like any other standardized discipline; it is certainly less occult than algebra (*'ilm al-jabr wa-l-muqābala*), for example, which gives knowledge of things more recondite than does *jafr* yet is hardly considered occult.⁹

⁷ I.e., the names of letters as deconstructed (*alif* = *ALF*, etc.) and employed accordingly.

⁸ Ankara MS Milli A 309/4 f. 20a. It is unclear where the quote from Qūnavī ends.

⁹ MS Milli A 309/4 f. 20b.

It must be emphasized that the texts that Muḥammad Salīm here cites, *al-Shajara al-Nu'māniyya fī l-Dawla al-Uthmāniyya* attributed to Ibn 'Arabī and Qūnavī's commentary thereon, are pseudopigraphic productions of the 10th/16th century at the earliest, and reflect the popularity of political divination among the Ottoman ruling elite of that period.¹⁰ Ibn 'Arabī was awarded the status of patron saint of the Ottoman Empire largely on the strength of this work, together with his *Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya* and *'Anqā' Mughrib*.¹¹ In Ottoman sources he is accordingly “described not only as the rediscoverer of prophetic knowledge of past, present, and future, but also as the prophet of Ottoman victory at the end of time.”¹² In this sense, Ibn 'Arabian lettrism came to be closely identified with the science of divination utilized to political ends.

In the present section, then, I am concerned with the practice of *jafr* as it later crystallized into a formal technique centered on the construction of a divinatory book. Fortunately, in various of his surviving works Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī provides us with clear descriptions of this process as practiced in the late 8th/14th century. In a brief introductory treatise on the science, for example, he neatly defines the two basic premises (*muqaddama*) necessary to the construction of a book of *jafr* as divinatory matrix:

Premise 1: Know that the lexical meaning of *jafr* is calfskin; it is used in a technical sense by the folk of reality (*ahl-i ḥaqq*) to refer to the procedure of deriving (*istikhrāj*) [knowledge of] worldly and human affairs and detailed historical information (*juz' iyyāt-i dahr u naba'-i zamānī*), this to the extent of human ability. The term *vaz'* literally means ‘to set down,’ and is used in a technical sense by practitioners of *jafr* to refer to the process of writing out *abjad hawwaz ḥuṭṭy* and so forth, i.e. the 28 letters [of the Arabic alphabet] in total, [in all their permutations], devoting 28 pages to each letter, 28 lines to each page, 28 cells to each line, and four letters to each cell (this given the quadrilateral nature of the *abjad* divisions). The number of pages in a [book of] *jafr* thus comes to 784.

¹⁰ See Fleischer, “Seer to the Sultan,” 294-95; Gril, “L’énigme de la *šajara al-nu'māniyya fī l-dawla al-uthmāniyya*.” Qūnavī himself expresses little interest in *jafr* (personal communication with Professor Chittick).

¹¹ On the last work see Elmore, *Islamic Sainthood in the Fullness of Time*.

¹² Fleischer, “Seer to the Sultan,” 297.

Premise 2: Know that the term ‘clime’ (*iqḷīm*) is used to refer to a letter of the alphabet; there are thus 28 ‘climes’ [in a book of *jafr*]. The term ‘city’ (*shahr*) refers to the pages of a ‘clime’; ‘district’ (*maḥalla*) refers to the lines on a page; and ‘house’ (*khāna*) refers to the cells that constitute the table (*jadval*) drawn on each page. In the first cell of the first line on the first page four *alifs* are written, while in the last cell on the last page of the final section four *ghayns*. In writing out the letters (*ḥurūfāt*) extreme care should be taken against making the slightest mistake, since if even one line in the book is incorrect, out of place, repeated or dropped, all subsequent pages will be affected and thereby invalidated; all one’s painstaking effort will be for naught. Furthermore, the first and last pages of the *jafr-i jāmi’* are to be duplicated, this being one of the secrets of this noble science. Care must also be taken to write the dots clearly for those letters that have them. Finally, it is imperative that the whole procedure be undertaken with total concentration and in seclusion with similarly single-minded companions so as to avoid any distractions. The writing should proceed as follows:

AAAA AAAB AAJ AAAD AAAH AAAW AAAZ AAAḤ AAAT AAAY AAAK AAAL
 AAAM AAAN AAAS AAA‘ AAAF AAAṢ AAAQ AAAR AAASh AAAT AAATh AAAKh
 AAADh AAAD AAAZ AAAGh

This pattern is continued until the page is complete, with the final cell being AAGhGh.¹³

Toufic Fahd notes that a book of *jafr* entitled *K. al-Jafr al-Jāmi’ wa-l-Nūr al-Lāmi’ li-l-Imām ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib*, copied in 1130/1718 in Egypt and preserved in the Topkapı Palace Library as MS Revan 1767, contains a long *isnād* tracing the work to ‘Alī (f. 1a), as well as a colophon that gives the particulars of its contents: 784 pages, with 784 cells and 3,136 letters per page, resulting in 87,808 cells and 2,458,624 letters in total.¹⁴

In a second treatise Akhlāṭī elaborates on the conditions one must observe when constructing a book of *jafr*:

[T]he person who prepares a book of *jafr* (*kātib*) must have a firm belief and clear intentions, and should receive sufficient support for himself and his dervishes. He must be a *sayyid*, i.e. a descendant of ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib through Ḥusayn. He must be provided with an open airy place surrounded with green plants and waters. He must be willing to spend one

¹³ MS Majlis 16359 ff. 67a-69a, MS Majlis 14374/2 ff. 6a-9b. This treatise appears to be part of a larger assemblage of *faṣls* attributed to Akhlāṭī; the two premises translated above are followed by two sections where basic operations are applied.

¹⁴ *La divination arabe*, 221 n. 1 (note that a misprint gives the incorrect figure 2,458,424). He further notes that the same codex is represented by MS Lala İsmail 279, Süleymaniye Library, copied in 509/1115; MS Damad İbrahim Paşa 844, undated; and MS Şehit Ali Paşa 1810, undated.

thousand and one days in seclusion. In this period of time, he must finish 784 pages, and he must not work at night (*dar khawf u kūf*) on Fridays, Tuesdays, and when the moon is in the sign of the Scorpion. He must fast on Mondays and Thursdays, on days of calamity, and it would be better if he could perform the ablution every morning. He must write one page per day. He must repeat the name of the ruler who commissions the sacred book, and finally he must not exchange letters with anybody. Nothing is unknown to him who knows the secrets of the *jafr*, and all creatures (*makhlūqāt*) submit to whoever owns a book of *jafr*.¹⁵

5.2: Lettrist political divination based on the Quran

The use of the Quran for bibliomancy was, and continues to be, widespread in the Islamicate world, as was a similar use of the Bible in Europe. Bibliomantic practices range from simple ‘open at random and point’ affairs to complex operations informed by astrological considerations. There are two basic approaches to Quran divination, *istikhāra* and *fa’l*; the first is concerned with the expediency of a given action planned by the questioner, while the second goes beyond determining the mere advisability of an action to chart its character and trajectory. Sergei Tourkin characterizes the practical difference between the two techniques as follows:

In the former the diviner uses the first line, or a part of it, on a randomly opened page, while in the latter he refers to the first complete *āya* and makes his predictions for the beginning and for the end of a matter in accordance with his interpretation of the beginning and end of this *āya*.¹⁶

The popular use of the Quran as a book of divination reflects, of course, the fundamental lettrist doctrine that holds the Book to be the matrix of reality.¹⁷ However, in this section I will

¹⁵ Akhlāṭī, *R. Jafr-i Jāmi‘*, Süleymaniye MS Haşim Paşa ff. 32b-35a (1 Rabī I 1311/12 Sept. 1893); trans. in Binbaş, “Sharaf al-Dīn,” 152-53.

¹⁶ “The Use of the Qur’ān for Divination in Iran,” 388.

¹⁷ In Iran the *Dīvān* of Ḥāfiẓ is of course frequently used in the same way (Tourkin, “The Use of the Qur’ān,” 387; Gruber, “The ‘Restored’ Shī‘ī *muṣḥaf* as Divine Guide?” 32).

be concerned with quranic prophecy as such—specifically, with one famous passage in particular, Q 30:1-5:

ALM. The Greeks have been vanquished in the nearer part of the land; and after their vanquishing they shall vanquish in a few years. To God belongs the command before and after, and on that day shall the believers rejoice in God's help. God helps whomsoever He will; He is the All-mighty, the All-compassionate.

As the only explicit political prophecy in the Quran, the first five verses of Sūrat al-Rūm have long been the site of much debate and speculation in the tafsir tradition. In what follows, I discuss two representative cases, one Ayyubid and one Aq Quyunlu, that show how lettrist interpretations of these verses, centering on the two words *biḍ' sinīn* ('a few years'), increasingly came to be wielded as proof of a rising dynasty's political and military supremacy and religious legitimacy within the larger post-caliphal Islamicate polity.

5.2.1: Sūrat al-Rūm 1-5

Being as they are the only clearly predictive verses in the Quran, the history of tafsir on Q 30:1-5 is long and complex; it suffices here to mention that at various times the Sūrat al-Rūm prophecy had been interpreted in the tafsir literature as referring to crucial acts of reconquest, whether for the edification of Muslims or for the vindication of Islam. Given the exceptional importance of this passage to strategies of dynastic legitimation, I offer here a brief sketch, taken from an overview of the subject by Nadia Maria El Cheikh,¹⁸ of the special complexities these verses have offered to commentators and the general development in their interpretation that may be observed as taking place vis-à-vis the changing political context.

The exegetical treatment of the first five verses of this sura can be broadly divided into two phases based on changes of emphasis. Variants in vocalization attested by the earliest

¹⁸ "Sūrat al-Rūm: A Study of the Exegetical Literature."

sources gave rise to a primary reading and a main variant as well as two exceptional readings of the passage, the four mutually exclusive in the function of each as defining a specific historical reality; this is complicated by the overtly political nature of the prediction, the only such in the Quran. Early commentaries mention only one reading, *ghulibat-sayaghlibūn* ('was vanquished-will vanquish'), with the explicit historical referent being the Persian-Byzantine confrontation, the reason for the revelation of these verses being to hearten the Muslim community with an example of believers (the Byzantines, a people possessed of a scripture) eventually winning out over unbelievers (the idolatrous Persians)—i.e., the Persian-Byzantine wars as rehearsal for the Muslim-Qurayshi wars. As the commentary literature began to develop, the reading *ghulibat-sayaghlibūn* continued to dominate but with the variant reading *ghalabat-sayughlabūn* ('vanquished-will be vanquished') sometimes recorded. With Ṭabarī (d. 310/923) comes a categorical dismissal of any but the earlier reading *ghulibat-sayaghlibūn*, a dismissal enshrining the consensus view of the first two and a half centuries of commentary.

The Byzantine revival, however, coupled with the beginning of the Crusades in 489/1096, marked a sharp change in exegetical emphasis, including the rehabilitation of the later reading *ghalabat-sayughlabūn* as applied to the Byzantine-Muslim confrontation: the believers' rejoicing was now seen as being excited by an eventual Muslim victory over the Christians—a flat denial of the previous ideological affiliation between Islam and Byzantium. This victory achieved, in the wake of the Mongol conquests of the 7th/13th century and with the increasingly tenuous nature of Islamic political legitimacy sights turned inward, away from the Christians and toward rival, insufficiently Muslim powers.

5.2.1.1: Ibn Barraġān's famous prediction

Arguably the most iconic of prognostications based on the Sūrat al-Rūm passage is the Sevillian Ibn Barraġān's (d. 536/1141)¹⁹ famous prediction of the reconquest of Jerusalem in 583/1187 by Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn al-Ayyūbī (Saladin). In particular, many later lettrist thinkers, including Ibn 'Arabī,²⁰ Ibn Turka,²¹ 'Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī²² and 'Alī Ṣafī Kāshifī,²³ hold up Ibn Barraġān's prediction as a prime example of successful prognostication based on the Quran. This is not to suggest that its fame was limited to lettrist circles; for example, the linguist and exegete Abū Ḥayyān al-Andalusī (d. 745/1344) cites it in his *Tafsīr al-Baḥr al-Muḥīṭ* on the authority of Abū Ja'far Ibn al-Zubayr.²⁴ The prediction came to figure prominently even in later Ash'ari 'aqīda commentaries, such as that by the Maliki historian Aḥmad al-Maqqarī (d. 1042/1632), the versified *Īdā'at al-Dujunna fī 'Aqā'id Ahl al-Sunna*, where he states that a prime support for the doctrine of *i'jāz al-Qur'ān* is

¹⁹ His full name is Abū l-Ḥakam 'Abd al-Salām b. 'Abd al-Raḥmān Ibn Barraġān al-Lakhmī al-Ishbīlī. Cf. A. Faure's articles "Ibn Barraġān," "Ibn al-'Arīf," and "Ibn Ḳasī" in *EI*², in which several misconceptions about Ibn Barraġān still survive in tempered form, particularly with respect to his supposed political agenda and the reasons for his arrest and execution. I am indebted to Yousef Casewit for a copy of his unpublished study of Ibn Barraġān's important concept *al-ḥaqq al-makhlūq bi-hi l-khalq*, often used by Ibn 'Arabī in particular, which contains a useful review of problems relating to the Sevillian master's biography ("A Preliminary Study of Ibn Barraġān's Doctrine"). As 'Abd al-Salām al-Gharmīnī notes, Ibn Barraġān was known as the 'Ghazālī of al-Andalus' for good reason: being as he was author of a commentary on the divine names as well as of an unusual tafsīr, well versed in the quranic sciences and hadith, and, above all, possessed of a dangerous interest in *kalām*, he readily lent himself to the comparison (*al-Madāris al-Sūfiyya al-Maghribiyya*, 134). See also Yousef Casewit's forthcoming dissertation for a treatment of Ibn Barraġān's legacy in the Sufi tradition of the Maghrib.

²⁰ See §5.2.1.1.1 below.

²¹ *R. Su'l al-Mulūk*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 178a, MS Majlis 10004 p. 200. It should be noted that here Ṣā'in al-Dīn attributes to Ibn Barraġān the numerological calculation that is provided rather by Ibn 'Arabī, without mentioning the astrological rationale Ibn Barraġān offers in his *K. Īdāḥ al-Ḥikma*; see §§5.2.1.1.1 and 5.4 below.

²² In his *Miftāḥ al-Jafr al-Jāmi'* Bisṭāmī credits Ibn Barraġān with making this prophetic prediction on the basis of the secret science he inherited from Adam and his lettrist analysis of Q 30:1-5; see MS Esad Efendi 1984 f. 95b, MS Hafid Efendi 204 f. 58b; and Masad, "Medieval Islamic Apocalyptic," 115 n. 42.

²³ *Ḥirz al-Amān*, section 1.1.3; see §4.4.4 above.

²⁴ Beirut, 1983; Masad, "Medieval Islamic Apocalyptic," 115 n. 42.

what [the Quran] comprises of news of
the unknown, whether explicitly or in hints;
Of such matters there are many
and some discover them through inspiration (*al-fayḍ*).
Among them is what Ibn Barraġān disclosed
as to the conquest of holy Jerusalem
On the basis of His saying *a few years* (*biḍ' sinīn*)
beforehand—and it came to pass in the year foretold.²⁵

Ibn Barraġān's prediction appears to have gone largely unnoted until four years before Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn's successful reconquest of Jerusalem. The circumstances in which it was vaulted to fame are as follows: When Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn reconquered Jerusalem on 27 Rajab 583/2 October 1187, he chose one Muḥyī l-Dīn b. Zakī l-Dīn to give the first Friday sermon after the conquest. As the sources imply, this Shafi'i jurist and man of letters²⁶ was singled out for such an honor due to his prediction four years prior that Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn would take Jerusalem, expressed in a celebrated line from a panegyric ode in *B* composed upon the sultan's reconquest of Aleppo:

Your taking the Gray Citadel in Ṣafar
heralds the conquest of Jerusalem in Rajab.²⁷

When asked how he came to make his prediction, he identified his source as being Ibn Barraġān's tafsir on the first four verses of Sūrat al-Rūm.²⁸

²⁵ *Īḍā'at al-Dujunna fī 'Aqā'id Ahl al-Sunna*, 112-13; my thanks to Yousef Casewit for directing me to this passage. Note that a commentary on *al-Shajara al-Nu'māniyya* of Pseudo-Ibn 'Arabī is attributed to al-Maqqarī, entitled *al-Namaṭ al-Akmal fī Dhikr al-Mustaqbal* (Gril, "L'énigme de la *Šağara al-nu'māniyya*"). In his commentary on the *Īḍā'at al-Dujunna*, 'Abd al-Ghanī al-Nābulusī (d. 1143/1731) notes that Ibn Barraġān obtained the correct date for the reconquest of Jerusalem through astrological calculation (*fa-dhakara ishārat^{am} falakiyyat^{am} stakhrāja min-hā ḥuṣūla l-faṭḥi l-madhkur*) (*Īḍā'at al-Dujunna*, 112). Cf. Rashīd al-Dīn Ṭabīb's similar emphasis on lettrism as a natural support for the doctrine of *i'jāz al-Qur'ān* (see §4.3.1 above).

²⁶ It may be incidentally noted that the Ibn al-Zakī family acted as Ibn 'Arabī's protectors in Damascus; the latter died in Ibn Zakī l-Dīn's house and was buried in the family's *turba* on the slopes of Mount Qāsiyūn (Ateş, "Ibn 'Arabī, Muḥyī 'l-Dīn," *Et*). It is therefore possible that Ibn 'Arabī's attention was first drawn to Ibn Barraġān's prediction by Ibn Zakī l-Dīn himself.

²⁷ *Wa-faṭḥu-ka l-qal'ata l-shahbā'a fī Ṣafarⁱⁿ / mubashshir^{um} bi-futūḥi l-Qudsi fī Rajabi*. Al-'Ulaymī records the first hemistich as *Wa-faṭḥu-ka Ḥalab^{an} bi-l-sayfi fī Ṣafarⁱⁿ*.

There exists some confusion as to the precise nature of Ibn Barraġān's oeuvre. The sources agree in attributing to him two works: a commentary on the divine names,²⁹ and a large tafsir which he was apparently unable to finish.³⁰ Denis Gril has described in a recent article³¹ the manuscript evidence known to date, tentatively identifying Ibn Barraġān's output as including not one but two tafsirs, a major and a minor. In his works Ibn 'Arabī (d. 638/1240) mentions only one tafsir by Ibn Barraġān, calling it also 'his book' (*kitābu-hu*) and *K. ʾIdāḥ al-Ḥikma*; nowhere does he mention the title *K. al-Irshād*, often applied to the major tafsir.³² As will be seen in the following section, certain of these references are to Ibn Barraġān's famous prediction of the reconquest of Jerusalem—these refer to the major tafsir where this prediction occurs. When in his *Futuḥāt al-Makkiyya* Ibn 'Arabī criticizes Ibn Barraġān for making his prediction on astrological bases, however, it would appear that he is referring to the minor

²⁸ For this episode see Ibn Khallikān, *Wafayāt al-A'yān*, 564-68; a fuller account, but minus the mention of Ibn Barraġān's *tafsir*, is given by Mujīr al-Dīn al-'Ulaymī (d. 928/1522) (*al-Uns al-Jalīl bi-Ta'rīkh al-Quds wa-l-Khalīl*, 332-40). Ibn Khallikān (d. 681/1282) confesses himself intrigued: "Upon learning of this verse and the [related] account I diligently sought out [a copy of] Ibn Barraġān's *tafsir* until I had ascertained that it contained just such a passage [as Ibn Zakī l-Dīn had described]. However, [in the copy I was able to find] the relevant part was copied in the margin in a different hand, so I do not know whether [the passage] is authentic (*min aṣl al-kitāb*) or a later addition (*mulḥaq bi-hi*). [In either case, the text in the margin] records a long calculation (*ḥisāb*) in this connection and the method to be used in working (*istikhrāj*) it, this calculation being derived from the quranic phrase 'a few years' (*biḍ' sinīn*)" (*Wafayāt*, 564). It is probable that the manuscript that Ibn Khallikān examined was in fact MS Murat Mulla 35 (306 ff., completed in 612/1215), one of two surviving copies of Ibn Barraġān's minor or supplementary tafsir, *K. ʾIdāḥ al-Ḥikma*; in the margin next to the full text of the commentary on Sūrat al-Rūm (ff. 186b-88b) another hand has copied the section from Ibn Barraġān's major tafsir containing the calculation Ibn Khallikān refers to (MS Yusuf Aġa 4746 ff. 108b-110b)—the only place in the text that such a marginal addition occurs.

²⁹ Entitled variously *Sharḥ Asmā' Allāh al-Ḥusnā*, *Sharḥ Ma'ānī Asmā' Allāh al-Ḥusnā*, or *Tarjuman Lisān al-Ḥaqq al-Mabthūth fī l-Amr wa-l-Khalq*. Denis Gril mentions five MSS of this work, one each in the British Library and the Bibliothèque Nationale, and three in the Süleymaniye ("La 'lecture supérieure' du Coran," 512). A critical edition has been produced by Purificación de la Torre, *Šarḥ Asmā' Allāh al-Ḥusnā* (*Comentario Sobre los Nombres Más Bellos de Dios*), Madrid, 2000.

³⁰ MS Yusuf Aġa 4744-4745-4746 does in fact represent an incomplete commentary, with suras 105-14 missing from the end. (The Sūrat al-Rūm section occupies ff. 108b-119a of the same.) Moreover, the *K. ʾIdāḥ al-Ḥikma*, itself complete and almost certainly referencing the *Tafsir* throughout, appears not to do so in this final portion.

³¹ "La 'lecture supérieure' du Coran," 512-15.

³² "La 'lecture supérieure' du Coran," 514.

tafsir, since it is only in this work that this astrological rationale becomes explicit. Ibn ‘Arabī, then, appears to have studied both works; we may suppose that in his copy they were bound together or otherwise identified as being of a piece, since he says *K. Īdāh al-Ḥikma* even when he is clearly referencing the *Tafsīr*.³³ For convenience’s sake, I refer here to the major tafsir as the *Tafsīr* and to the minor tafsir as *K. Īdāh al-Ḥikma*.³⁴ The murky relationship between these two tafsirs (their titles being frequently swapped in the surviving MSS) with respect to the passage in question may therefore be summarized as follows: the major tafsir, entitled *K. al-Irshād* or simply *Tafsīr Ibn Barraġān*,³⁵ contains the famous prediction and calculation, while the minor tafsir, entitled *K. Īdāh al-Ḥikma*, contains the astrological rationale for the prediction given in the major tafsir.

It should be noted that Ibn Barraġān’s stance in his *Tafsīr* is squarely that adopted by the rational commentaries (sg., *tafsīr bi-l-ra’y*) of his time in response to the Christian aggression; it emphatically cannot be the Persians that are referred to as enemy, but the Byzantines. But Ibn Barraġān’s position is at the same time unprecedented in the literature in that he asserts the necessity of interpreting the passage based on a simultaneous validation of both main readings,

³³ See §5.2.1.1.1 below.

³⁴ The minor tafsir is preserved in only two MSS known to date: Mahmut Paşa 3-4 and Murat Mulla 35. MS Mahmut Paşa 3-4 (275 and 262 ff.), both volumes datable to 596/1200, is entitled *K. al-Īdāh fī l-Tafsīr*, then more precisely as *Īdāh al-Ḥikma bi-Aḥkām al-‘Ibra*. The title suggests, and a comparison of the text with that of the *Tafsīr* confirms, that it is a supplement to the *Tafsīr*.

³⁵ The oldest available copy of the major *tafsīr* is from Konya, the excellent three-volume MS Yusuf Ağa 4744-4745-4746 (243, 182 and 365 ff.); it is undated, but belonged to two people before being acquired by Şadr al-Dīn Qūnavī (d. 673/1274), Ibn ‘Arabī’s stepson and most important disciple, and is thus datable to around the beginning of the 7th/13th century. The MS is titled simply *Tafsīr Ibn Barraġān*. The passage containing the prediction of the reconquest of Jerusalem in 583/1187 occurs at 4746 ff. 109a-109b. Many other copies are extant, including: MS Reīsulküttap Mustafa Efendi 30 (667/1269), 31 (1128/1716); MS Damad Ibrahim Paşa 25 (677/1278), 26 (1129/1717), 27 (1128/1716); MS Carullah 51M (738/1338); MS Ismihan Sultan 38 (829/1426); MS Şehit Ali Paşa 73 (1127/1715); MS Darülmünevi 42. Gril notes that those copies found in the Süleymaniye are systematically labeled as *K. al-Irshād* due to Ḥājjī Khalīfa’s mention of it as such (*Kashf al-Zunūn*, 1/70, 437); this alternate title may have been introduced after the fact to further distinguish the major tafsir from the *Īdāh al-Ḥikma*. MS Munich 83 (part 2 only), entitled *Tanbīh al-Afhām ilā Tadabbur al-Kitāb al-Ḥakīm wa-Ta‘arruf al-Āyāt wa-l-Naba’ al-‘Aẓīm* (GAL 1/434 (559), GALS 1/775), is presumably a copy of the major tafsir.

ghulibat-sayaghlibūn and *ghalabat-sayughlabūn*, holding them both in solution together as it were. Only thus, Ibn Barrajān says, can the cycling of interpretation between the two opposing readings mirror the cycling of a changing political context, which in turn must mirror the cycling of the heavens—all revolutions decreed before the creation of the universe.

I translate here the relevant passages from the major and minor tafsirs given their importance to subsequent discussions, whether lettrist or nonlettrist:

Tafsīr, MS Yusuf Aḡa 4746, 108b-10a:

The Byzantines (al-Rūm) have been vanquished (ghulibat) in the nearer part of the land; and after their being vanquished (ghalabi-him) they shall vanquish (sa-yaghlibūna) in a few years (fī biḍ' sinīn) (Q 30:2-4). The majority reading has the first verb as passive, whereas 'Alī and Ibn 'Umar read it in the active as they have vanquished (ghalabat). Ibn 'Umar reads it ghalbi-him [for ghalabi-him], their being vanquished, although the latter majority reading has been reported of him as well. Those who read it in the passive as they have been vanquished (ghulibat) read [the continuation of the passage] in the active as and after their being vanquished (ghalabi-him) they shall vanquish (sa-yaghlibūna); those who read it in the active as they have vanquished (ghalabat) read [the second verb] in the passive as they shall be vanquished (sa-yughlabūna).

God's wisdom in the cycles of [His] decreeing (*dawā'ir al-taqdīr*) provides for the [perpetual] returning of things to their initial state.³⁶ These cycles include both those whose timeframe is circumscribed (*muqaddara*) and those whose timeframe is much larger (*muwassa'a*), according to the extent God wills for them and [to the purpose He desires to accomplish] through them. When God gave [us] to know that the Byzantines were vanquished *in the nearer part of the land*, i.e., Syro-Palestine (*al-Shām*), He was giving [us] to know what would come to pass (this according to the passive reading *they have been vanquished* [ghulibat]), a tiding He announced to the Messenger of God and the believers. As the Messenger of God said upon waking [suddenly] one night, [face flushed], *Woe to the Arabs from an evil that has drawn nigh; today [in] the barrier (radm) of Gog and Magog [a breach] like this has opened*, making a circle with his thumb and forefinger.³⁷ This was God's informing him of what would come to pass, and [indeed] this very thing happened two hundred [years] later, and more specifically, upon the advent of the 'Abbasid state and their employing [in their empire-building] the Khurasanians, Turks, Daylamites and other peoples inhabiting those areas [near the barrier]; the barrier (*sadd*) itself however will not be breached until the coming of what He has promised (*majī' al-wa'd*). Thus He did not minimize the scope of the Byzantines' [role], and mentioned them with reference to this conquering (*fath*) since their employing [those peoples] was, in a way, an act of conquest

³⁶ *Rujū' awākhir al-ḥukm ilā awā'ili-hā.*

³⁷ Found in e.g. Bukhārī, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *al-Fitan*, bab 28, no. 7135: "Wayl^{un} li-l-'arabi min sharrⁱⁿ qadi qtaraba; futiḥa l-yawma fī radmi Ya'jūja wa-Ma'jūja mithlu hādhihi," wa-ḥallaqa bi-iṣba'ay-hi l-ibhāmi wa-llatī tali-hā.

[on the part of the latter in that they displaced ‘Abbasid forces]. When the Arabs turned away (*tawallī*) [from the right path], God brought [upon them] these [peoples];³⁸ as He said: *If you turn away, He will substitute another people instead of you, and they will not be like you* (Q 47:38). The Messenger of God’s saying, *Woe to the Arabs from an evil that has drawn nigh*, was a warning [to the Arabs] because of their turning away, their forfeiting their position of authority and role in the military struggle (*taṣyīr al-amr wa-l-jihād*) to others; it was also His giving [us] to know the moment [His] decreeing [would come into effect] (*waqt al-taqdīr*), for [His actual act of decreeing] preceded the creation of the universe (*yataqaddamu l-kawna*). So the decreeing of such [an eventuality was manifested] that night, as may be gathered from his saying that that night [a breach] was opened [in the barrier]. *And God knows best what He has sent down* (Q 16:101).

Likewise, God’s saying *The Byzantines have been vanquished* gives [us] to know the tiding of that decree made beforehand and now manifest,³⁹ there [occurring during] the time of ‘Umar b. al-Khaṭṭāb [the Muslims’] conquest (*ghalab*) of the towns of Syro-Palestine and their wresting (*istikhrāj*) Jerusalem from [the Byzantines’] hands. Said He, [*In a few years* (*biḍ’ sinīn*)—‘a few’ [in the Arabic language] being [an unspecified quantity] between three and nine. This sura was revealed in Mecca, and that within the timeframe of a few multiples of seven years (*biḍ’ asābi’ sinīn*), from the beginning of the year 20 to the year 28.⁴⁰ Thereafter [their rate of] conquest continued [apace] and [its scope] assumed the dimensions that had been willed by divine decree.

He next says, *And after their*—i.e., the Byzantines’—*being vanquished they shall vanquish in a few years*, that is to say, they will be vanquished and then vanquish [in their turn], and then after this vanquishing they will [again] be vanquished. By this He gives [us] to know the property (*ḥukm*) of [His] decreeing’s cycles, [which provides] that they will conquer [us believers] twice and we will conquer [them] twice, this apart from the first conquest that we had through the Companions. [The Byzantines’] first conquest of us in Syro-Palestine corresponds to the Companions’ conquest [of them] within [the timeframe of] 40 or 50 weeks, i.e., seven multiples of seven (*sab’at asābi’ fī mithli-hā*) and contained within [the period defined by] seven times nine (*fī ḍimn sab’ fī tis’*). [The Byzantines’] conquest however only encompassed the forward strongholds (*thughūr*) of Syro-Palestine, and afterwards the Muslims launched a counterattack (*karra*) and wrested from their hands what they had taken, [also] taking control of Armenia [in the process]. [The Muslims] were then subjected (*idāla*) [once again] by a second conquest [on the part of the Byzantines] in the year 489,⁴¹ with [the Byzantines] taking Syro-Palestine in its entirety, including Jerusalem. This was [near] the end of the sixth “year” (*al-sana al-sādisa*), with year here being defined as one thousand lunar months (*alf shahr min shuhūr al-‘arab*) so as to substantiate (*taṣdīq*) His saying *In a few years*, [since otherwise the phrase could only refer to events within ten normal years of its revelation at most]. [In this scenario, then], the sixth “day” (*sādis ayyāmi-hā*) of [a few years] constitutes the beginning of the year 500 (1106-07), with seven of such “years” equaling the year 583 and four months (*thulth sana*).⁴²

³⁸ Or, these Byzantines?

³⁹ *Al-taqdīr al-mutaqaddim al-zuhūr al-kā’in*.

⁴⁰ I.e., 640/41-648/49.

⁴¹ I.e., 1096, the year of the First Crusade to conquer Jerusalem; this objective was realized in 1099.

⁴² I.e., the beginning of Jumādā I 583, corresponding to July-August 1187. A thousand lunar months equals 83.33 solar years; with this figure taken as the definition of the astrological ‘year’ here being used, six

The second reading [of this passage] entails a different meaning (*dalīl*), since in the view of all the ulama it has a different status (*mathāba ukhrā*), with the two readings being equal with respect to their function as a binding source of proof and basis for recitation, equally to be accepted as valid.⁴³ [Thus] His saying *The Byzantines have vanquished in the nearer part of the land; and after their vanquishing* (ghalabi-him)⁴⁴ *they shall be vanquished in a few years*, [with the first verb] in the active, gives [us] likewise to know of their conquest of the Muslims, that being [carried out] within the space of 49 weeks; He then proceeds to speak of our subsequent victory over them. (I have already discussed the necessary

such 'years' equal the year 500, and seven such years equal the year 583.33—i.e., the beginning of Jumādā I of that year. The identification of the thousand lunar months as a specimen of the astrological 'year' is problematic in that it does not appear to occur in any other known system, the commonest of whose 'years' are periods of 1,000, 360 or 240 solar years. Perhaps the single mention of 'days' (*sādis ayyāmi-hā*) indicates that the period 83.33 solar years is to be rather construed as a 'day' of a 'year' of approximately 30,415 solar years; but again, examples of this figure are not found in the available texts. In any case, that Ibn Barrajān is here using the concept of the astrological 'year' seems the only possible explanation for the passage (personal correspondence with Dr. Eva Orthmann, 11/12/06).

This then is the famous prediction which Ibn Zakī l-Dīn cites as his source and to whose calculation Ibn Khallikān attests; problematically, however, it fails to give the correct month of the reconquest of Jerusalem, Rajab (October), and in fact does not specifically mention Jerusalem as being won from the Crusaders in that year—so whence Ibn Zakī l-Dīn's couplet? It is tempting to speculate that it is this apparent misidentification of the month of the reconquest that Ibn 'Arabī has in view when in his remark above he criticizes Ibn Barrajān for tainting his results through his astrological approach, thus merely approximating the date (*qāraba l-amra*); but Ibn 'Arabī himself in demonstrating the correct method is only concerned to obtain the year of the reconquest, not the month. Moreover, Ibn Barrajān does not draw an explicit connection between his figure of 583.33 and the reconquest of Syro-Palestine. This connection is only construable if *biḍ'* necessarily equals seven; and, while most commentators on these verses define the term as being a number between three and nine or three and ten, there would seem to be support for *biḍ'* equaling seven in, for example, Abū Bakr Ibn al-'Arabī's (d. 543/1148) *Aḥkām al-Qur'ān* (3/1489-91), despite its upholding of the traditional view that the verses refer to the Persian-Byzantine confrontation. Ibn 'Arabī transmits the tradition of Abū Bakr's wager (*rihān*) with one of the unbelieving members of the Quraysh in which the *biḍ'* of these verses was defined by the two parties as six; Abū Bakr would win the wager if the Byzantines (favored by the Muslim community) defeated the Persians (favored by the polytheist Quraysh) in six years, i.e., if the quranic prediction held true. The prediction indeed held true and the Byzantines defeated the Persians—but in the seventh year rather than the sixth. Abū Bakr Ibn al-'Arabī then records the opinions of the *ahl al-lughā* as to the definition of *biḍ'*, of which he identifies five: *biḍ'* equals 1) a number between two and ten or twelve and twenty; 2) seven only (asserted by al-Khalīl, presumably on the basis of the account of Abū Bakr's wager); 3) a number between three and nine; 4) a number between one and four; 5) a number between five and seven (asserted by Ya'qūb on the authority of Abū Zayd); Abū Bakr Ibn al-'Arabī himself says the correct view is that it equals a number between three and ten. This account of the wager, then, often reiterated in the classical commentaries, appears to be Ibn Barrajān's justification for implying that *biḍ'* must equal seven, i.e., that the year 583 is the last year possible for the reconquest of Jerusalem if the quranic prediction is to hold true; and although he does not mention the reconquest of Jerusalem specifically, the context of his argument indicates that this is what is intended—in any event, it was certainly how his prognostication was understood. Failing this explanation, we might lend some credence to Ibn al-Zubayr's (d. 108/1308) statement that one Abū Zakariyyā Yaḥyā b. Abī l-Ḥajjāj al-Lublī was responsible for deriving the actual, explicit prediction from Ibn Barrajān's cryptic words (*Ṣilat al-Ṣila*, 370; see Goldziher, "Ibn Barraḡān," 546).

⁴³ *Siyyān fī wujūb al-istidlāl bi-himā wa-l-tilāwa wa-l-taṣdīq la-humā*.

⁴⁴ The noun *ghalab* can be construed as either active or passive depending on the voice of the attendant verb.

property of the cycles of [His] decreeing as providing for what obtains to the promised.) He then says, *And after their being vanquished*—i.e., their being vanquished by the Muslims⁴⁵—*they shall vanquish*, i.e., the cycle, [turning], will turn against [the Muslims], just as it had before turned in their favor. [The Byzantines] did in fact conquer [us] a second time, this being that [conquest] which occurred in the year 489 [1096], and still the holy promise (*al-wa'd al-karīm*) that *they shall be vanquished* remains [to be fulfilled]. This [last] conquest of them is the third of three [conquests to date], the first being the Companions' victory over them, and their recent (*al-yawma*) victory⁴⁶ the second of their two victories, although the scope of the first of these was not so extensive. The condition of their [dominion] during the period in which the Quran was revealed and the Messenger of God was active in Mecca was a sixth condition (*ḥāl^{um} sādīsat^{um}*).

Whoso contemplates (*tadabbur*) the cycles of [God's] decreeing as manifest in the difference between night and day, in the difference between ages (*azmān*) and in the concomitant transformation of beings (*taqlīb al-kiyān*) in the changing of their fortunes (*taghyīr al-aḥwāl*) as to conquest (*idālāt*), [in which territory is both] gained and lost (*al-ziyāda wa-l-nuqṣān*), may well come to understand somewhat thereof and what will come to be out of this [perpetual changing]—this being one of the most useful aspects of that certain knowledge (*min anfa' fawā'id al-yaqīn*) of the end of times (*tamām al-āmād*), the completion of ages (*kamāl al-ājāl*), the ineluctable advent of the Last Day (*wujūb zuḥūr al-yawm al-ākhir*), the realization of the knowledge of the resurrection (*al-ba'ṭh*) and [the fulfillment of] the promise and the threat (*al-wa'd wa-l-wa'id*), and beyond.

It is however possible that the meaning of His saying is to be construed on the basis of the reading *they shall vanquish* (*sa-yaghlibūna*), in the active, i.e., that [the Byzantines] will have victory [over the Muslims] *in a few years*, as was discussed above as [meaning] 'in a few multiples of seven years' (*fī biḍ' asābi' sinīn*). The meaning of the reading *they shall be vanquished* (*sa-yughlabūna*) *in a few years*, in the passive, would be giving [us] to know [that, as] said the Messenger of God when he spoke of the Mahdī, *He will fill the earth with justice and equity, even as [till now] it has been filled with injustice and oppression; he will live among you seven years (or as another version has it, nine years)*,⁴⁷ we will conquer them on that day, since it will be us who are on the offensive (*karra*) and they in retreat (*farra*) without chance of offensive during that period (*mudda*), God willing. What has just been discussed is certain and true—praise be to God, Lord of the worlds. Thus the passage *The Byzantines have vanquished in the nearer part of the land; and after their vanquishing*—i.e., a second time—*they shall be vanquished in a few years* gives [us] to know of the Muslims' victory over [the Byzantines] through [the leadership of] the just leader (*al-imām al-'adl*), [the Mahdī]—God be pleased with both us and them—as the [Prophetic] reports have described. And God is the One besought.

The passage continues, *God's is the command, before and after; and on that day shall the believers rejoice in God's help* (Q 30:4-5). God gives [us] to know what will happen to this

⁴⁵ *Ay ghalabi-him li-l-muslimīna.*

⁴⁶ This had occurred within a few decades prior to the *Tafsīr*'s composition, which, according to MS Fayzullah Efendi 35 f. 388, was completed in 522/1128. The relevant passage will of course have to be checked in other MSS to confirm this rather late date—Ibn Barrajān died in 536/1141 and in 522 had yet to compose both the commentary on the divine names and the supplementary commentary (personal correspondence with Professor Gerhard Böwering).

⁴⁷ Abū Dā'ūd, *Sunan*, K. *al-Mahdī*, bab 1, no. 4287: *Yamla'u l-arḍa 'adl^{an} wa-qisṭ^{an} kamā muli'at jawr^{an} wa-zulm^{an}, ya'īshu fī-kum sab'a sinīna.*

community [of believers] (*umma*) by way of entanglements with the Byzantines (*min waqā'i al-Rūm*), some of which [we] will win and some lose. He then proceeds to indicate the approach of their demise (*iqtirāb al-inqirād*) as the final [outcome] of these entanglements, this being the victory of the Muslims over them through [the leadership of] the foretold leader (*al-imām al-mubashshar*) [at the time of] the [great] war (*malḥama*). His saying *God's is the command, before and after; and on that day shall the believers rejoice in God's help*—[this day refers to the appearance of] none other than the Antichrist (*al-dajjāl*)—God's curse be upon him—followed by [the appearance of] His Word (*kalimat Allāh*), His servant, His messenger Jesus, son of Mary, [who will come to join battle against him], then the disappearance of the righteous (*dhahāb al-ṣāliḥīn*) [from the face of the earth], then the Last Hour (*al-sā'a*). His was the command before the revelation of the Quran and will continue to be so after these times are fulfilled—indeed, His was the command before the creation of the universe (*ijād al-khalīqa*) and will continue to be so after [its] demise (*inqirād*); as He says, *On that day shall the command belong to God* (Q 82:19), and *On that day shall the kingdom, the true kingdom, (al-mulk al-ḥaqq), belong to the Merciful* (Q 25:26).

He then says, *And on that day shall the believers rejoice in God's help*. Here lies the proof (*al-dalīl al-dāll*) that what I have here discussed is in fact what is meant by this passage, *contra* those commentators who hold that it refers to the Persians' victory over the Byzantines and the Byzantines' victory over the Persians; if this were the case, these [victories] are a thing of the past. The purpose (*gharad*) [of this passage] however is not to inform [us] of [the Persians' confrontation with the Byzantines], nor of the Persians being helped [to victory] over the Byzantines and the Byzantines over the Persians; [these events are not what] God announced to the believers in the revealing of His holy book and the communicating of His mighty word, since [such information] would not serve as an [appropriate] admonition (*'ibra*) nor exhortation (*'iza*) nor good tidings (*bushrā*) to believers. This is despite the fact that in their attempt to make sense (*taḥqīq*) of this passage [these commentators] found it expedient (*ta'allul*) to assert that the believers identified (*mayl*) with the Byzantines inasmuch as they [too] possess a revealed scripture (*aṣḥāb kitāb*). But after their rejection of Muḥammad's claim [to prophethood] the Byzantines are no longer the object of [God's] mercy (*marḥūmūn*) referred to in His saying *And He is the All-mighty, the All-compassionate* (al-Raḥīm) (Q 30:5), and when they subject (*idāla*) others (just as others subject them) it is due to God's *surpassing wisdom* (Q 54:5) in the matter, that He should give certain evildoers (*ẓālimūn*) dominance (*tawliya*) over other evildoers according to the fruit of their actions. [God] always speaks of His vengeance (*intiqām*) [upon unbelievers] in terms of guile (*ghirra*) and of His prevailing mercy (*raḥma*) toward believers in terms of mercy, a fact that contradicts [these commentators'] discussions when brought to bear against them. In the divine Address (*al-khiṭāb*), good tidings and mercy are proper to believers, and threats, censure, and reproach (*al-wa'id wa-l-taqrī wa-l-tawbīkh*) proper to unbelievers (*ghayru-hum*)—so understand.

K. *Īdāḥ al-Ḥikma*, MS Mahmut Paşa 4, 52a-53b:

His saying *ALM* (Q 30:1) is a clear text (*kitāb muḥkam*) deriving from the preserved Tablet (*al-lawḥ al-maḥfūz*), differentiated (*fuṣṣila*) as the content of this surah. I have already discussed His saying *The Byzantines have vanquished* (Q 30:2), in the active, [in my *Tafsīr*]⁴⁸—

⁴⁸ *Qad taqaddama l-kalāmu fī-hi/qad taqaddama l-dhikru fī dhālika*—a phrase frequently repeated in this work. Since within the context of the commentary on Sūrat al-Rūm many of these instances clearly refer to Ibn

and God it is Who increases [us] in knowledge and understanding of His [word]. *And after their vanquishing they shall be vanquished* (Q 30:3), in the passive, *in a few years* (Q 30:4)—this is [yet in] the future. Said the Messenger of God, *Even were this world but one day [in duration], God would protract that one day until there accedes to authority a man from my stock* (‘itra) *whose name shall be the same as mine; he will fill the earth with justice and equity, even as till now it has been filled with injustice and oppression*, mentioning further that this blessed ruler’s (wālī mubārak) period [of rule] would be seven years (or in another version, nine years).⁴⁹ The attestation (miṣdāq) to this as found in the Quran has already been discussed [in the *Tafsīr*]. And as another version has it, the Byzantine kings will be led to him in chains.

This brings us to His saying *God’s is the command, before our current situation today as it is*, [having since suffered defeat at the hands of the Byzantines] despite the conquest of the Companions and their being [divinely] helped, *and after the days of the Messiah, Jesus, son of Mary, and the righteous individuals that will [rally] to him—upon them all be the peace of God and His blessings* (*Our Lord, we believe; record us among the witnesses* (Q 5:83)⁵⁰)—and so on as to the events subsequent, till the [world’s] demise (*al-inqirāḍ*) and beyond. He adjoined [this statement] with the conjunction *and* to the description of that day in His saying, *And on that day the believers will rejoice in God’s help—God helps whom He will, and He is the All-mighty, the All-compassionate* (Q 30:4-5), mighty in wreaking vengeance on His enemies, compassionate to His friends.

The promise of God; God fails not His promise (Q 30:6). Who fails to recognize that God’s promise is as ineluctable as the cycle of day and night [with the ineluctability of] the return of cycles’ ends to their beginnings and their beginnings’ advancing toward their ends, fails to give the ineluctability [of His promise] its due—and in point of fact, God’s promise is more ineluctable by far than the [perpetual] cycle of day and night. This is His exertion of authority (*ḥukm*) and His act (*fi’l*); He enacts it if He so wills, He promises if He so wills. And He *fails not the tryst* (Q 13:31), this [absolute dependability] being one of His qualities (*ṣifa*): He is the Truth (*al-Ḥaqq*) and His promise true (*al-ḥaqq*).

Then He says, *But most people know not; they know [only] an outward aspect of the present life* (Q 30:6-7). The objects of knowledge of this present life (*ma’lūmāt al-ḥayāt al-dunyā*) are many; says God, *You have been taught what neither you nor your fathers knew* (Q 6:91). But the specific manifest and knowable object (*khāṣṣat al-ma’lūm al-ẓāhir*) here meant by the divine speech is that which has been discussed as to the knowledge of cycles’ revolutions (*ma’rifat tadwār al-dawā’ir*)—[the cycle of] day and night, [the revolutions of the] sun, moon, and stars—these revolutions being *according to a calculation* (*ḥusbān*) (Q 55:5). Any knowledge (‘ilm) that does not involve this association and use this model⁵¹ is not yet complete

Barrajān’s discussion in his *Tafsīr*, I date the *Īdāḥ* as subsequent to the *Tafsīr*, *contra* Ḥājī Khalīfa. The purpose of the present work is a supplementary one in that it appears to provide the keys to understanding the author’s full intent in the *Tafsīr*. It also has a decidedly more esoteric flavor, noting in particular the emphasis here given below to the classical occult principle of the extrapolation of what is below from what is above and vice versa, possible because of the fundamental unity of all things—i.e., applied *tawḥīd*.

⁴⁹ The same hadith as quoted in the relevant section of the *Tafsīr*, above, although here more of it is given, similar to the version found in Abū Dā’ūd, *Sunan*, K. *al-Mahdī*, bab 1, no. 4287.

⁵⁰ This in the mouth of those Christians who recognized the divine origin of the quranic revelation.

⁵¹ *Kullu ‘ilmⁱⁿ lam yuqran bi-‘ibrati-hi*. The term ‘ibra is used several times in this passage; this suggests that it is a running theme of the K. *Īdāḥ al-Ḥikma*, the fuller version of whose title is K. *Īdāḥ al-Ḥikma bi-‘Aḥkām al-‘Ibra*. The question remains as to why Ibn ‘Arabī in his *Mawāqī‘ al-Nujūm* associates this title with the *Tafsīr*.

(*tāmm*), for it is a manifest aspect of the [divine] command (*zāhir min al-amr*); [complete knowledge] entails drawing this connection [between the cycles of the heavens] and that under consideration (*īṣālu-hu bi-‘ibrati-hi*) [here below], to wit, the connection that is drawn by means of astrology (*al-‘ilm bi-dawā’ir al-aflāk*),⁵² the calculation (*ḥusbān*) being according to the state of things in the hereafter. Just as night comes when day ends and vice versa, so will this world’s day end and the Last Day come [in its stead]. The Last Day itself comprises such things as are indicated by the cycles [of the heavens] from week to week, month to month, year to year, on up to years in multiples of seven (*asābi‘ sinīn*) and in decades of multiples of seven (*‘asharāt asābi‘ sinīn*)—and how much vaster is the hereafter, far more vast! I have discussed previously that it is through knowledge (*‘ilm*) of what is here [present] that one may extrapolate (*ya’buru ilā*) knowledge of [our] encountering God [on the day of resurrection] and the appearing of the sublime manifestation (*ẓuhūr al-tajallī al-‘alī*), and [more generally] knowledge of that manifest reality (*al-ḥaqq al-mubīn*) at those [levels of being] in the [full] vastness of existence [there]. That which leads one to such knowledge is precisely this act of extrapolation from the existence of what [we see] here to the existence of what is there; and the most immediate and accessible, yet [at the same time] most comprehensive, [method of extrapolating this knowledge] is [through astrological] knowledge of the cycles’ revolutions,⁵³ with the understanding of God’s wisdom [as manifest] therein.

Although it seems that the *Īdāḥ al-Ḥikma* soon fell into disregard, the *Tafsīr* took on a somewhat legendary quality and was recopied until at least 1129/1717, i.e., over a period of some six centuries; Goldziher notes that the Egyptian litterateur ‘Abd al-Raḥmān b. Nājir al-Sadīd (b. 537/1143) already held that with a correct understanding of Ibn Barraġān’s *Tafsīr* one can prognosticate events up to the day of resurrection.⁵⁴

5.2.1.1.1: Ibn ‘Arabī’s critique of Ibn Barraġān’s prediction

Ibn ‘Arabī first refers to Ibn Barraġān’s *Tafsīr* in a letter to the companions of ‘Abd al-‘Azīz al-Mahdawī written in 590/1194 on his return from Tunis, noting that he had just studied the

⁵² Here Ibn Barraġān identifies the specific basis of his calculation in the *Tafsīr* as being astrological.

⁵³ *Wa-aqsaru-hu wa-aqrabu-hu ma’khaḍh^{an} wa-ajma’u-hu l-‘ilmu bi-tadwāri l-dawā’iri*. It is this assertion that astrology is the best means of fathoming God’s decree that draws Ibn ‘Arabī’s criticism below; he rather holds up *‘ilm al-ḥurūf* as preeminently the science of the saints (Gril, “The Science of Letters,” 123).

⁵⁴ “Ibn Barraġān,” *ZDMG*, 68 (1914), 546.

work with al-Mahdawī during his stay there the same year.⁵⁵ The first evidence of this study of the *Tafsīr* occurs in his early work *Mawāqīʿ al-Nujūm wa-Maṭālīʿ Ahillat al-Asrār wa-l-ʿUlūm*, composed five years later during Ramaḍān of 595/1199,⁵⁶ in a passage of which he holds up Ibn Barrajan’s prediction of the reconquest of Jerusalem as prime example of a certain waystation (*manzila*) proper to the charismas of the heart (*karāmāt al-qalb*):

Among the waystations [of the heart’s charismas] is that in which God gives one to know the cause and occasion (*ʿilla wa-sabab*) for which any given thing exists or does not exist, whatever [kind of] engendered being (*kawn*) in the universe it might be, whether spiritual (*rūḥānī*) or not, without exception. Once one knows this [cause], one looks to see whether it have a divine effect (*taʿthīr ilāhī*) or not. If it does, he prepares himself to receive it; if however it have a destructive effect (*taʿthīr ḥalāk*), he warns his fellow believers [against it]. And if it be an effect of mercy (*raḥma*), he announces it to the elite (*al-khāṣṣa*) from among his fellow [believers] and they prepare themselves to receive it with thanksgiving and praise, just as in the former case supplication and entreaty are incumbent upon them, and wariness against disasters that come depredating from afar (*ḥawādith jāriyya ṭāriqa*) like floods, winds, earthquakes, wars. Ibn Barrajan did precisely this in his book *Wisdom’s Clarification* (*K. ʾIdāḥ al-Ḥikma*)⁵⁷ in announcing the [re]conquest of Jerusalem (*bayt al-maḥdis*) and specifying the year this would take place, as did Quss b. Sāʿida [al-Iyādī] and others in the time before the Prophet’s [mission had begun] when they announced the coming of [another] prophet and the time of his advent (with God’s Messenger [standing there] listening [to this foretelling of his mission] in the ʿUkāz marketplace), and the like from [those having] this station. This is an exalted waystation not attained by just anyone, but by those only whom God has singled out from among His servants; and despite the fact that it is so exalted, it is nevertheless necessary that the one for whom it obtains not feel too complacent in it, as within lurks deception (*makr*), a subtle baiting of which few are aware [even as it lures them astray].”⁵⁸

Ibn ʿArabī was later to temper his opinion of Ibn Barrajan’s prediction in his *Futūḥāt al-*

⁵⁵ *Risāla*, 31. For convenience’s sake Claude Addas calls it *Risāla fī l-walāya*, since sainthood is its chief subject (*Quest for the Red Sulphur*, 127).

⁵⁶ A reference to Ibn Barrajan’s concept of *al-imām al-mubīn*, equated by Ibn ʿArabī with *al-lawḥ al-mahfūz*, i.e., everything (*kull shayʿ*), occurs in an earlier work, *al-Tadbīrāt al-Ilāhiyya fī ʾIṣlāḥ al-Mamlaka al-Insāniyya*, 102. This work is referred to in the author’s *K. Mashāhid al-Asrār al-Qudsiyya*, also written in 590/1194 on his return from Tunis, so is earlier; but as Ibn ʿArabī first studied the *Tafsīr* during this visit to Tunis, i.e., after composing the *Tadbīrāt*, this reference to Ibn Barrajan is probably a later interpolation.

⁵⁷ With this title Ibn ʿArabī must be referring to the *Tafsīr* since the prediction and calculation occur only in this text, while the explicit reference to astrology as his underlying rationale is found in the work here identified as the supplementary tafsir, *K. ʾIdāḥ al-Ḥikma*.

⁵⁸ *Mawāqīʿ al-Nujūm*, 403-4.

Makkiyya, in which the Sevillian master is referred to by name eight times,⁵⁹ and certain terms coined by him, such as *al-ḥaqq al-makhlūq bi-hi* ('the Real through Whom creation takes place'), referred to numerous times.⁶⁰ Indeed, while still holding him in high regard,⁶¹ Ibn 'Arabī came to suspect Ibn Barrajjān of having fallen prey to the deception inherent in the predictive mode of *kashf*, or realization unmediated by discursive trappings. In the long second chapter of the *Futūḥāt*, dedicated the science of letters, Ibn 'Arabī demonstrates the correct way of deriving the date 583 AH for the reconquest of Jerusalem on the basis of this science, noting in a parenthesis that Ibn Barrajjān used instead an astrological method to arrive at this date. Five hundred fifty-six chapters later Ibn 'Arabī reiterates the proper calculation and again refers to Ibn Barrajjān's prediction in this connection, this time however criticizing him for tainting his results by using the incorrect method, i.e., the astrological one identified in chapter two:

God—blessed and exalted may He be—had twenty-nine suras begin with these isolated letters, a number that represents the perfection of form: “And We have ordained stages for the moon” (Q. 36:39). The twenty-ninth is the pole (*qutb*), the sphere's axis, and the cause of its existence, as in sura [*Āl-ʿImrān*], which begins with *Alif-Lām-Mîm-Allāh ...* (Q. 3:1-2) without which the twenty-eight letters would have no stability. Given their repetition in the Qur'ān, there are seventy-eight of these letters. The “eight” are the true meaning of “and some” [*(biḍ')*] in the words of the Prophet—may peace be upon him: “faith entails seventy-some ramifications.”⁶² A servant has thus not penetrated all the secrets of the faith until he knows the essential realities of each of these letters in their respective suras.

To the objection that the specific meaning of 'some' (*biḍ'*) is unknown in Arabic—since it refers to a number from one to nine, why decide on the number eight?—my response is that I reached this number through personal unveiling (*kashf*), which is the path that I

⁵⁹ *Futūḥāt*, 1/60, 297, 2/60, 104, 577, 649, 3/77, 4/220.

⁶⁰ E.g., *Futūḥāt*, 1/731, 2/60, 783, etc. For a discussion of this concept see Casewit, “A Preliminary Study,” 11-23.

⁶¹ Although, it should be noted, his attitude to him is slightly reserved in comparison to the wholly unreserved tone he adopts when speaking of Ibn al-ʿArīf (d. 536/1141), explicitly regarding him as one of his masters and a man of spiritual fulfillment (*muḥaqqiq*) (Addas, “Andalusī Mysticism and the Rise of Ibn 'Arabī,” 927).

⁶² Muslim, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *al-ʿImān*, bab 14, no. 162: *al-ʿImānu biḍʿun wa-sabʿuna aw biḍʿun wa-sittūna shuʿbatun fa-afḍalu-hā qawlu lā ilāha illā Llāhi wa-adnā-hā imāṭatu l-adhā ʿan al-ṭarīqi wa-l-ḥayāʾu shuʿbatun mina l-ʿimāni*. Bukhārī records it as *biḍʿun wa-sittūna* only. Note that in the passage immediately preceding that next quoted from the *Futūḥāt*, however, Ibn 'Arabī gives an alternate reason for *biḍ'* equalling eight, namely the fact that Mecca was taken in year eight of the *hijra* (4/220).

follow and the cornerstone that supports my knowledge in all fields. But I can also offer some insight in regard to the number. Ibn Barraġān—may God have mercy on him—did not deal with the issue in the same way in his book, but he did touch on the subject from an astrological (*‘ilm al-falak*) point of view. He hid his direct personal unveiling under this veil, when he predicted the conquest of Jerusalem in 583 (1187). Similarly, [I too may either speak directly from my experience of personal unveiling, or veil [the expression of this unveiling] in [a discussion of the properties of] numbers, as I choose.]

We will say, then, that the “some” in sura *al-Rūm* means “eight.” Let us take the numerical value of the letters *A.L.M.* according to the “small estimation,”⁶³ which results in eight. Let us add the eight from “some,” which makes sixteen. We then take away one, because it comes from the *alif* that marks the beginning (*uss*, of letters and numbers), and fifteen remain, which we shall set aside. Let us begin the same operation again, by means of the “great sum,” or “estimation.”⁶⁴ Let us then multiply eight by seventy-one, with the thought that we are dealing with years, and the product is 568. Let us add the fifteen that were set aside, which adds up to 583 years, that date of the reconquest of Jerusalem, according to the reading [*ghalabati l-Rūmu*], “the [Byzantines] conquered ...” In 583, the Muslims conquered and took control of the pilgrimage from the Infidels.⁶⁵

Then from chapter 558 of the *Futūḥāt*:

Abū l-Ḥakam Ibn Barraġān, however, did not derive [his calculation] from [the science of letters as it relates to] this presence of conquest (*ḥaḍrat al-faṭḥ*), and thereby committed an error (*ghalaṭ*) that people failed to notice. I explained this to one of my companions when he brought [Ibn Barraġān’s] book [for discussion] such that it became clear to him that [Ibn Barraġān] was indeed in error—although he did manage to obtain more or less the correct result (*qāraba l-amra*)—, the reason for this [error] being that he applied to [the question] a method not proper to it, thereby tainting (*ifsād*) it.⁶⁶

It bears noting that Ibn ‘Arabī’s disapproval of Ibn Barraġān’s astrological rationale as improper to lettrist prognostications is somewhat perplexing, and certainly unrepresentative of standard lettrist practice. As we saw in Chapter 4, judicial astrology and lettrism were considered to be

⁶³ *al-Jazm al-ṣaġhīr*. This is based the the *abjadiyya* order; it reduces decades to units (thus $A = 1, L = 30, M = 40; 1 + 30 + 40 = 71; 71 = 7 + 1 = 8$).

⁶⁴ *Al-Jummal al-kabīr wa-huwa l-jazm*. This is based on the long alphabet (*ABTṬḥ*); it preserves decades. *Jummal* refers to sum or gematria.

⁶⁵ *Futūḥāt*, 1/59-60, trans. in Gril, “The Science of the Letters,” 165-66.

⁶⁶ *Futūḥāt*, 4/220.

mutually inextricable sciences even by Sufis such as Ni‘mat Allāh Valī, an ardent promoter of Ibn ‘Arabian thought.⁶⁷

5.2.1.2: Lettrist Aq Quyunlu propaganda

We saw above that Ibn Barrajān was responsible for demonstrating the special political utility of the Sūrat al-Rūm prophecy, correctly interpreted; his prediction therefore set a precedent that would be redeployed by rising dynasties in subsequent centuries as an attractive means of political legitimation. The most prominent instance of this redeployment in 9th/15th century Iran is in the imperial propaganda of Uzun Ḥasan (r. 861–82/1457–78).⁶⁸

The Turkmen ruler appears to have first seized upon Q 30:1–5 as a prop to Aq Quyunlu imperial ambitions in a *fathnāma* sent to the Mamluk sultan al-Ashraf Qāytbāy (r. 872–901/1468–96) declaring his victory over the Timurid Sulṭān-Abū Sa‘īd (r. 855–73/1451–69) in 873/1469. This *fathnāma*⁶⁹ exhibits Uzun Ḥasan’s claim to religio-political superiority in an absolute and incontestable sense by identifying his victory with the opening verses of Sūrat al-Rūm in the third paragraph; by means of gematria (*ḥisāb-i jummal*) it is proved that his conquests are prophesied by the Quran itself, and as such represent the unifying hope of the

⁶⁷ While Ibn ‘Arabī often uses astrological symbolism for rhetorical purposes, as in his *Mawāqī‘ al-Nujūm wa-Maṭālī‘ Ahillat al-Asrār wa-l-‘Ulūm*, he manifests little interest in astrology as such (personal communication with Professor Chittick).

⁶⁸ The present section has been adapted from Melvin-Koushki, “The Delicate Art of Aggression,” 202–3, 211–13.

⁶⁹ There are two versions of this letter, one preserved in Evoğli’s collection of correspondence (Abū l-Qāsim Ḥaydar İvāghlī (Evoğli), *K. Majmā‘at al-Murāsālāt az Sulṭān Alp Arsalān tā Avākhir-i Salāṭīn-i Şafaviyya*, University of Toronto microfilm (1660?), source MS unknown; my source here is the transcription given by ‘Abd al-Ḥusayn Navā‘ī (*Asnād u Mukātabāt*, 561–70), and the other an Ottoman archival copy preserved as Topkapı Sarayı E. 10727 (transcr. and trans. in Fekete, *Einführung in die persische Paläographie*, no. 11, 123–43; facsimile, plates 30–39; and in Keçik, *Briefe und Urkunden*, no. 18, 166–78, 227–45; facsimile, plates xl–lvii). The former is a copy of the letter sent to the Mamluk court by the hand of an Aq Quyunlu amir, while the latter, sent to the Ottoman court by the hand of another state officer, is distinguished by an extended discussion of Ḥasan-‘Alī b. Jahānshāh Qara Quyunlu, presumably of less interest to the Mamluks.

greater Islamic polity. Uzun Ḥasan's defeat of Jahānshāh Qara Quyunlu at the Battle of Muş in 872/1467 marks the starting point of his ascent and the anchor of his legitimacy; when calculated the numerical value of *biḍ' sinīn*, "a few years," indeed gives 872. The Byzantines (*al-Rūm*) become the Aq Quyunlu⁷⁰ and "the nearer part of the land" (*adnā l-arḍ*), the site of their victory, becomes the Jazira, i.e., Arminiya, including Muş.

The upshot is, of course, that Uzun Ḥasan, as divinely foretold champion of Islam, enjoys direct legitimation from on high and his victories constitute Islam's very destiny. As the present *fathnāma* confirms, this theme had already become a core element of Aq Quyunlu ideology within a year of Jahānshāh's defeat in 872/1467, and was developed by such intellectuals as Jalāl al-Din Davānī (d. 908/1503)⁷¹ and the Aq Quyunlu court historiographers, who often added other astrological and numerological proofs;⁷² it is given particularly involved form by Faḍl Allāh b. Rūzbihān Khunjī-Işfahānī (d. 927/1521) in his *Tārīkh-i 'Ālam-ārā-yi Amīnī*.⁷³ That Uzun Ḥasan himself saw this as central to his claim to superiority is further confirmed by his letter of ca. 877/1472 to Şarabdar Ḥamze Beg, the Ottoman governor-general of the province of Rumiya,⁷⁴ which enumerates fourteen ways in which Uzun Ḥasan is superior to Amir Temür himself (and by extension the Ottomans, whom Temür had trounced seventy years before at

⁷⁰ The dynasty's original base was Āmid (Diyarbakr), thus Rūm in the sense of Anatolia.

⁷¹ The introduction to his *Lavāmi' al-Ishrāq fī Makārim al-Akhlāq*, commonly known as the *Akhlāq-i Jalālī*, contains one of the earliest references to it (10). See §4.4.1 above and §5.3 below on Davānī's qualifications as lettrist.

⁷² Woods, *The Aqquyunlu*, 102. This usage was apparently unique to the Aq Quyunlu during this period; while the *fathnāmas* issued by other powers infrequently use parts of the Sūrat al-Rūm section, they do so without drawing on its explicitly prophetic aspect. In the Ottoman context, see e.g. Bāyezīd's *fathnāma* to Ya'qūb (?) on his victory over the Aq Kirman (Feridun Beg, *Münşe'at*, 1/294-97), which uses only the phrase Q 30:4c-5a, *Wa-yawma'idhⁱⁿ yafrahu l-mu'minūna bi-naşri Llāh* (ibid., 297), as does Meḥmed II's *fathnāma* to Jahānshāh on the conquest of Istanbul (ibid., 244-48, p. 247); by comparison, Meḥmed II's two other *fathnāmas* on this subject, to al-Ashraf Īnāl and the Meccan Sharīf (ibid., 235-38, 240-43), use quranic quotes far more sparingly, certainly nothing from Sūrat al-Rūm.

⁷³ *Tārīkh-i 'Ālam-ārā-yi Amīnī*, 31-35.

⁷⁴ Woods, *The Aqquyunlu*, 103.

the Battle of Ankara); the first item is the foretelling of his ascendancy in the Quran versus the Quran's silence on the career of Temür.⁷⁵ The rhetorical thrust, in short, is unmistakable: unlike the Mamluks, the Aq Quyunlu rule by divine right.

Moreover, a related theme developed in Aq Quyunlu historiography in which Uzun Ḥasan is identified as the *mujaddid* of the ninth Islamic century. Khunjī-Iṣfahānī, interestingly enough, conflates Uzun Ḥasan with his son Ya'qūb for this purpose, referring to Ibn al-Athīr's *K. Jāmi' al-Uṣūl* to prove that *mujaddid*-hood need not be limited to one individual nor even a *faqīh*, as the demands of each century are different; the genesis of their mission lies, of course, in the words *biḍ' sinīn*.⁷⁶

Aq Quyunlu hegemony was not to be, however, and their claim to Q 30:1-5 was soon contested. The Aq Quyunlu defeat by the Ottomans at the Battle of Başkent in Rabī I 878/August 1473 having invalidated Uzun Ḥasan's grandiose claims to be the foretold renewer of Islam, the Sūrat al-Rūm passage was reassociated with Fātiḥ Meḥmed's victory at Başkent in Idrīs Bidlīsī's (d. 926/1520) *Hasht Bihisht*, a Persian history of the Ottomans in the ornate style of Khunji-Isfahani's *Tārīkh-i 'Ālam-ārā-yi Amīnī*—indeed, the two had worked together at the Aq Quyunlu *dīvān-i inshā'* under Sultan Ya'qūb, hence the intimate familiarity with the theme demonstrated by Bidlīsī in his detailed counterargument.⁷⁷

⁷⁵ This letter is preserved as Topkapı E. 11602 and 11440 and transcribed in Baykal, "Uzun Hasan'ın Osmanlılara Karşı Kat'i Mücadeleye Hazırlıkları," 274-78; the point in question is on p. 275 l. 14: "Firstly, the solicitude of the Creator—be He exalted!—with regard to the career of the padishah [Uzun Ḥasan] exceeds that shown to [Temür], as may be easily proved; various quranic verses and hadiths were revealed to precisely this effect, and leading scholars (*akābir*) [e.g., Davānī] have treated of this point, as I'm sure you are well aware."

⁷⁶ *Tārīkh-i Ālam-ārā-yi Amīnī*, 157.

⁷⁷ *Hasht Bihisht*, MS Tokat 9 ff. 243b-46a, National Library, Ankara; MS BL Add. 7647 ff. 107a-8b; see Woods, *The Aqquyunlu*, 266 n. 146. Bidlīsī's history as a whole was criticized as being too lenient on the Persians, however, and he did not receive payment for his work (Ménage, "Bidlīsī, Idrīs," *Et*²).

5.2.1.3: Hurufi interpretations

Not all interpretations of the Sūrat al-Rūm passage were political in nature. A notable contemporary exception to this trend is the reading offered by the Hurufi Mīr Fāzīlī, a direct disciple of Faḡl Allāh Astarābādī, in which the Byzantines (*Rūm*) are associated with the seven signature lines of the human face (*rū-yi man*),⁷⁸ and their defeat in the nearer part of the land is taken to connote the creation of a being lesser than Adam, i.e., Eve, at some point after his creation. Because it is through Eve's deficiency that the human race was generated, however, her advent activates the cosmic plan and thus *al-rūm*, the seven lines that dwell on the human face, are said to triumph after their initial defeat.⁷⁹

At the same time, it must be noted that such allegorical interpretations did not detract from Hurufi appreciation of the predictive power of Q 30:1-5. Most importantly, the *biḡ'*, here equaling 830 (i.e., 1426-27), seems to have been taken as designating the year of Faḡl Allāh's second coming. This apocalyptic expectation was expressed by Faḡl Allāh's leading disciple 'Alī al-A'ālā (d. 822/1419) in his *Kursī-nāma* as follows:

The source of all will indeed become apparent at the time of the 'few' (*biḡ'*)
Understand the appearance of God's grace (*fazl-i haqq*) to be the seeds the farmer
spread on the earth
On that day, the believers will rejoice in God's aid and the infidels will be in distress⁸⁰

⁷⁸ This reading reflects Faḡl Allāh's hermeneutical principle that the Arabic Quran could now be read as if written in Persian (Bashir, *Fazlallah*, 70).

⁷⁹ *Risāla*, MS Ali Emiri Farsça 990 ff. 3a-b, Millet Library, Istanbul, as summarized in Bashir, "The Alphabetical Body," 286.

⁸⁰ Trans. in Bashir, *Fazlallah*, 95-96. The last line translates Q 30:4-5.

5.3: Davānī's use of political divination

In Chapter 4 (§4.4.1) I discussed Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī's Persian treatise on applied lettrism, the *R. Tuḥfa-yi Rūḥānī fī Khavāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf*, for the purposes of the present chapter the value of this treatise as a summary of lettrist methods useful for political ends as practiced in Iran in the 9th/15th century should be emphasized. A prime example is, of course, Shaykh Najm al-Dīn Kubrā's inquiry as to the course of the Turko-Mongol invasion on the basis of *taksīr*, which revealed that he would perish as a resistance fighter in the onslaught.⁸¹

Intriguingly, in the same treatise Davānī gives an account of the the circumstances surrounding his own accurate, if inadvertent, prediction of Sulṭān-Abū Sa'īd's (r. 855-73/1451-69) death in the aftermath of his battle against Uzun Ḥasan (r. 861-82/1457-78) in 873/1469 near Ardabil—the same event described in the Aq Quyunlu *fatḥnāma* just examined. Davānī's express purpose in doing so, moreover, is to exculpate himself, for the benefit of a royal Aq Quyunlu audience, of his involvement in Timurid affairs. I provide a translation of this account for its intrinsic interest as a record of the type of everyday political lettrist speculations thought routine by the intellectual elite of the period:

Among the rare subtleties pertaining to this discussion is the [following episode]: In the year 873 [1469] Sulṭān-Abū Sa'īd Bahādur Gūrakān departed his royal seat in Samarkand for [Persian] Iraq, passing through with the intent of entering Anatolia (*Rūm*). Having encamped for a few months at Ardabil, one of the cities of Azarbayjan, to pursue his quarrel with the divinely helped Jahāngīr, heir (*vāris*) to the rule of Abū l-Naṣr Ḥasan Beg Bahādur Sulṭān⁸² (the standards of his rule be raised to the sky's circuit and his enemies be expunged from the face of the earth), he pressed this humble writer to attend one of the princes (*shāhzādagān*) of the previous [sultan] who had been wounded, and I assented. In brief, I joined the camp of Sulṭān-Abū Sa'īd, and after two or three days it suddenly occurred to me that the present year was numerically equivalent to *DJ*. Now the benediction spoken or written for the dead, 'God cool his resting place (*maḍja*),' is well-known; this sentiment is particularly suitable to [the climate of] Samarkand. It then occurred to me that for this reason Sulṭān-Abū Sa'īd must surely die this year.

⁸¹ See *R. Tuḥfa-yi Rūḥānī*, Majlis 5180 pp. 421-22, Majlis 12559 p. 262.

⁸² I.e., Uzun Ḥasan. The Aq Quyunlu rulers' tenures appear to be unaccountably switched here—Jahāngīr's tenure (848-61/1444-57) preceded that of his brother.

Later I was in Ardabil visiting the khanaqah (*kiryās-i buq‘a*) of the eminent Shaykh Ṣaḥī l-Dīn Ardabīlī (God sanctify his pure spirit), one of the great saints [of the age], when I and my companions saw [soldiers] leading one of Sulṭān-Abū Sa‘īd’s elephants (*fil*) as we were passing in the way. The moment my gaze fell upon the elephant I involuntarily exclaimed, *Have you not seen how your Lord did with the Men of the Elephant?* (Q 105:1), thus confirming my earlier speculation (*ẓann*). I explained as much to my companions, and they were quite taken aback. Two months later when I had reached [Persian] Iraq I heard the news of Sulṭān-Abū Sa‘īd’s defeat and execution. Furthermore, in a remarkable instance of synchronicity (*az navādir-i ittifāqāt*) it emerged after this news arrived that his place of death corresponded [numerologically] precisely to his date of death—but one of many strange examples of lettrist subtleties⁸³

5.4: Political divination in Ibn Turka’s *R. Su’l al-Mulūk*

Among his minor lettrist treatises, Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s *R. Su’l al-Mulūk* appears to be the only to contain pointedly political content. This is not surprising given its subject matter and addressee; it was written in or before 829/1426 at the request of Bāysunghur b. Shāhrukh as an introductory work treating of both the practical-magical (e.g., alchemical and talismanic) and the theoretical aspects of lettrism, and gives a broader overview of the science than is found in the author’s other lettrist treatises.⁸⁴ We have seen that there appears to have been obvious interest in Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s lettrist doctrine among members of the Timurid elite, in particular Iskandar and Bāysunghur; further to the west, ‘Abd al-Raḥmān Biṣṭāmī’s lettrism came to serve as an important prop to Ottoman messianic self-understanding.

Most notably, at the end of the *R. Su’l al-Mulūk* Ṣā’īn al-Dīn offers a political prediction of his own: he determines, based on Shāhrukh’s name, that the Timurid-Shahrukhid dispensation will be coterminous with the 9th Islamic century. I mentioned above that this prediction appears to have been common knowledge in the later Timurid period, since Davānī, for example, references it in his *R. Tuḥfa-yi Rūḥānī* as a prime example of the method of making

⁸³ Majlis 5180 pp. 420–21, Majlis 12559 pp. 260–61. Davānī here proceeds to copy a chronogram he composed on this occasion to indicate the date of Sulṭān-Abū Sa‘īd’s death.

⁸⁴ See §3.1 above for more on this treatise.

political predictions based on the names of the actors involved.⁸⁵ In the same section Ṣā'in al-Dīn holds up Ibn Barrajān's prediction as an example of the straightforward use of this science while citing, however, the proper lettrist calculation provided by Ibn 'Arabī; this is followed by a hint to the effect that more allusive and cryptic methods of prognostication, such as those employed by Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī, provide more robust information, but are beyond the scope of an introductory treatise. I translate this final section here:⁸⁶

It is now necessary to mention by way of example some of the ways in which the rest of the isolated letters at the beginning of the quranic suras have been interpreted. First, [reference may be made to] that which earlier authorities discovered and made known. Abū l-ʿĀliya,⁸⁷ one of the leading men among the Successors (*tābiʿīn*), narrated from the Imams of the Family of Sanctified Power and Guidance [their statement to the effect] that these *muqattaʿāt* indicate the rise and fall of states (*zamān-i dawlat-i qawmī ... u vaqt-i inqizā-yi ān*). It is also related in the *Taysīr al-Tafsīr*⁸⁸ as follows: "It is said with regard to ALM that each of the isolated letters mentioned in the Quran refers to a matter of great and weighty import in that they make known the full extent of the [Muslim] community's rule (*muntahā mulk tilka l-umma*) and the culmination of its power (*zuhūr al-ḥaqq fī-him*), as well as the number of their leaders and caliphs and the number of territories which Islam shall come to control."

Among those [predictions] which have been derived according to this premise is that of ʿAbd al-Salām Ibn Barrajān, who during the period when the Franks (*afranj*) had occupied and taken control of Jerusalem, their site of pilgrimage, derived the date when the Muslims would [re]conquer the city on the basis of [the verses] ALM. *The Greeks have vanquished in the nearer part of the land; and after their vanquishing they shall be vanquished* (Q 30:1-3) (reading the second verb in the passive)—and it came to pass as he had said. His methodology in deriving [this date]: ALM equals 71 according to *jummal-i kabīr*, which is then multiplied with the numerical value of *biḍʿ*, in principle equivalent to eight, giving a product of 568. Thus far *jummal-i kabīr*; a further operation must be performed according to *jummal-i ṣaḡhīr*: according to the latter type of gematria ALM equals 8, the sum of the two numbers of its value according to *jummal-i kabīr*, and when added to *biḍʿ*, or eight, the sum is 16. From this sum one is subtracted, giving 15, which is added to the first number to give the year: 583 [1187]. This was precisely the year that the Muslims liberated

⁸⁵ Majlis 5180 pp. 420, Majlis 12559 pp. 260; see §4.4.1 above.

⁸⁶ Although space does not permit a full translation of this long treatise, I provide an edition in Part 2, §T.4.1.

⁸⁷ Abū l-ʿĀliya al-Riyāḥī (d. 111/729).

⁸⁸ Perhaps the *Taysīr al-Maṭālib* of Muḥammad al-Kūmī al-Tūnisī?

Jerusalem, the site of pilgrimage for the Christian Franks and Byzantines, from the control of the latter.⁸⁹

Ibn Khallikān likewise relates in his chronicle that a Maghribi scholar declared that a great earthquake would occur in the year 702 [1302-3], basing his assertion on the evident meaning of the verse *When the earth is shaken with a mighty shaking* (Q 99:1), and so it happened that in that year many regions were hit by an earthquake; in Egypt numerous buildings were destroyed and throughout most of the east (*bīshtar-i ‘ajam-zamīn*) minarets were toppled.

Such instances were derived from the apparent forms of the letters; equally common are [predictions] derived according to more symbolic and allusive methods (*ishārāt u zabān-i rumūz*). An example is that derived by the Pole of the Saints and Verifiers Shaykh Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī (God sanctify his secret) from the name Muḥammad, and specifically its two Ms, on which basis he derived the conditions and circumstances of the great states; speaking cryptically, he indicated the rise and fall of each. Likewise, in the *K. al-Maḥbūb* he has it that “the two Ms refer to the place of the two feet (*mawḍi‘ al-qadamayn*), that is, Samarkand and Damascus.” While this was indeed accurate, this type of treatment, because written in a cryptic manner, is difficult to enter into further here, and to do so would only inspire boredom [in my readers]. These then are some of the approaches taken by previous authorities, who discerned in the isolated letters the circumstances of the world and its political entities (*aḥvāl-i ‘ālam u dawlat-hā-yi ān*).

The legends of Khusraw and Shīrīn are but overtold tales—
I’d far rather hear the story of your love.

The principles and rules of these sciences having manifested in the current day, secrets of every stripe have been made known; whoever meditates on the present lines first with the eye of sight (*baṣar*) and then with the eye of insight (*baṣīrat*) will, after becoming conversant with basic numerological principles, be able to derive the length of each state’s duration ...

Given that further discussion of these geometrical figures (*ruqūm-i handasī*) would be wearisome, it seems most appropriate to conclude this treatise with a [last] illustrative point that will demonstrate the basic principles of this science and at the same time suggest the perdurance of this ascendant [Shahrukhid] state (*īn dawlat-i rūz-afzūn*). According to the saying “Titles of honor are heaven-sent” (*al-alqābu tunzalu mina l-samā’*), we are to understand that it is possible to learn a person’s fate (*sar-anjām-i aḥvāl-i ū*) from his honorific—indeed, the fate of any thing from its name⁹⁰—inasmuch as it hails from the heaven of holiness; and the letter (*ḥarf*) descends [upon us] to show forth all that is. The several letters associated with a given person therefore constitute a book wherein his

⁸⁹ As noted above in §§5.2.1.1 and 5.2.1.1.1, this numerological rationale is not present in Ibn Barraġān’s text, but is supplied by Ibn ‘Arabī in conjunction with his critique of Ibn Barraġān’s reliance on an astrological method in deriving the date. Šā’in al-Dīn’s attribution of the calculation to Ibn Barraġān suggests that he did not have access to the latter’s *Tafsīr* or *K. ʿIdāḥ al-Ḥikma*, or perhaps given the introductory nature of the *R. Su’l al-Mulūk* he deemed it better to simplify the matter.

⁹⁰ Cf. Jābir b. Ḥayyān’s statement to the same effect in his *K. al-Baḥth*: “A group of people says that the knowledge of matters relating to the four natures (*aḥwāl al-ṭabā’i*), as well as an understanding of the qualities (*kayfiyyāt*), may be attained by a more suitable method: that is, by means of the names (*asmā’*) of food, drugs, organs of animals, and parts of animals and plants. We have called this method the Balance of Letters. In it lies a meticulous science (*‘ilm daqīq*) through which one reaches an understanding of the real characteristics of natural objects (*ḥaqā’iq aḥwāl al-mawjūdāt*)” (MS Carullah 1721 f. 110a, quoted in Kraus, *Jābir ibn Ḥayyān*, 223 n. 7; trans in Haq, *Names, Natures and Things*, 81).

circumstances are revealed. Some people derive a person's Ascendant sign from his name, but these individuals, being unfamiliar with the principles of the science of letter (*'ilm-i ḥarf*), simply offer an approximation on the basis of experience (*tajriba*)—certainly not a method to inspire confidence!

When the sun rises, illuminating the world
light penetrates every covert.

Given this premise, know that it is evident from the name of the present faith-fostering king (*īn pādshāh-i taqvā-panāh*) that he stands as sovereign of this century, what in high Arabic usage is called 800 (*samān-mi'a*); the royal name thus indicates that this state will endure until the end of the current century, God willing. For *R* equals 200, and *Kh* 600, the sum of which is 800; by this measure, the meaning of [the name] Shāh Rukh is 'shah of 800' (*shāh-i RKh*). Furthermore, the manifestation of this meaning in this blessed name comes about through its correspondence with the [divine] name the Manifest (*zāhir*), one of the four universal names by which Muḥammad (God bless and keep him) described the divine essence (*huviyyat-i ilāhī*), making it known to all.⁹¹ Those who would seek rational proof of this are acquainted with the fact that the bud of hope bloomed fresh at the beginning of the 9th century (*qarn-i hashtsad*) on the day of [this king's] emergence (*burūz*) from the mead of felicity and prosperity, and the tree of favor blossomed in the garden of good fortune and firm rule. We anticipate that until its term of expiry

This garden will produce each instant fruits
each fresher than the last.⁹²

⁹¹ I.e., the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Hidden; see e.g. Muslim, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *al-Dhikr wa-l-Du'ā' wa-l-Tawba wa-l-Istighfār* (49), bab 17; Tirmidhī, *Sunan*, K. *al-Da'awāt 'an al-Rasūl* ʕL'M (44), bab 87.

⁹² R. Su'l *al-Mulūk*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 178a-b, MS Majlis 10004 pp. 200-203. For more on such operations see Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī's detailed manual of the various lettrist methods of extracting information from personal names and honorifics, recently published as *Sifr-i Jafr*, ed. Zuhayr Ṭayyib, Tehran, 1386 Sh./2007.

CHAPTER 6

Ibn Turka's intellectual hierarchies

6.1: Ibn Turka's seven-tiered hierarchy in the *R. Shaqq-i Qamar*

In the foregoing chapters we have seen the clear centrality of lettrism to Šā'in al-Dīn's project; it is somewhat puzzling, then, that in his famous intellectual hierarchy Šā'in al-Dīn does not seem to award lettrism the highest rank. In his *R. Shaqq-i Qamar u Bayān-i Sā'at*, a short commentary on Q 54:1 (*The Hour has drawn nigh: the moon is split*) written at the beginning of 829/1426,¹ Šā'in al-Dīn presents us with a seven-tiered intellectual hierarchy that may be considered the key to his thought and the thought of the Neo-Ikhwān al-Šafā' more generally. Here the verse is subjected to seven different interpretations representative of the increasing sophistication of their associated groups:

- 1) The first and lowest level is represented by the jurists and traditionists, who know nothing beyond the literalness of outward form (*ahl-i ṣāḥir*);
- 2) the next level in ascending order is represented by the dialectical theologians (*mutakallimān*), also partisans of the outward form but ones who have progressed beyond mere literalness through their use of reason;
- 3) third are the peripatetic philosophers, also called 'latter-day philosophers' or sages of the exoteric (*ḥukamā-yi ṣāḥir u muta'akhhirān*);

¹ I.e., the same year of his second trial in Herat and composition of his first, hyper-Sunni apology, the *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* I (together with *R. I'tiqādāt*).

- 4) fourth are the illuminationist philosophers, previously called the ancient school of philosophy (*ḥukamā-yi qadīm*);²
- 5) fifth are ‘verifying’ or theoretically penetrating mystics, especially those of the school of Ibn ‘Arabī (*muḥaqqiqān-i ṣūfiyya*), advocates of the direct, intuitive experience of reality (*ahl-i shuhūd*);
- 6) sixth are the lettrists (*ramz-khʷānān-i ḥurūf-i qurʾānī, arbāb-i ʿilm-i ḥurūf*);
- 7) and seventh and highest is ‘Alī and the line of the Imams after him, the sole mediators of the Prophetic legacy.³

All well and good—lettrists such as Ṣāʿin al-Dīn therefore preside over the rest of the hierarchy from their vantage point at level six, but cannot attain to the seventh and highest level, which, in a gesture of deference, is reserved for the Imams. The hierarchy thus seems straightforward and unremarkable apart from its Shīʿi and lettrist slant, simply being a schema that indicates the relative importance Ṣāʿin al-Dīn assigns to the six religious-intellectual currents of his day from the perspective of his own project.

A closer examination of the text, however, suggests that the seventh level is not entirely what it seems. After referring to the Imams, here called *ūlū l-aydī wa-l-abṣār*, ‘men of might and vision,’ in reference to Q 38:45,⁴ he says: *zuhūr-i īn ṭawr makhṣūṣ-i hamīn zamān-i saʿādat-qirān ast*, that is, the manifestation of this supreme level of knowledge is peculiar to the present time, inaugurated by a significant celestial conjunction, a fact which has been communicated to him

² As Corbin notes, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn’s discussion of the illuminationists is quoted verbatim in the *Dabistān-i Mazāhib*, an important Ādhar Kayyānī pseudo-Zoroastrian text written between 1645-58 in India (“Typologie,” 261 n. 83; see Mujtabāʾī, “Dabestān-i Madāheḥ,” *Elr*). This is evidence for Ṣāʿin al-Dīn’s assertion that his books are much in demand in India, among other places (“Nafsat al-Maṣḍūr II,” 209-10).

³ Cf. the three-tiered hierarchy Ṣāʿin al-Dīn gives in his *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*, translated in §E.2.1 above: philosophers, Sufis, lettrists—none of whom require the medium of poetry to access supernal truths (*Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*, 5-6).

⁴ Remember also Our servants Abraham, Isaac and Jacob—men of might and vision.

by his teacher Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (*sayyid-i mā*).⁵ He continues by referring to previous attempts to plumb the esoteric heritage of the Imams encompassing total knowledge of past, present and future, which, however, remains the sole preserve of the Pillars of the Prophetic House (*asāṭīn-i ahl-i bayt*), i.e., ‘Alī and his august sons (*amīr u awlād-i amjād-ash*) who have left to us the technique of *jafr*.⁶

It will immediately be noted, of course, that in identifying his supreme level seven with the divinatory science of *jafr* Ṣā’īn al-Dīn effectively awards the highest epistemological status to lettrism: the same lettrism of level six, that is, but taken to its occult extreme and reserved for the elite of the elite. More importantly, what Ṣā’īn al-Dīn seems to be suggesting here is that comprehensive occult knowledge is simply *latent* in the Imams and has only begun to be *actualized* by the author and his circle—a rather more daring thesis and, needless to say, one profoundly millenarian in tone. As such, it further implies a doctrine of progress. Yet this presents us with a paradox: how can latter-day knowledge be simultaneously superior to that of the Imams yet wholly subsidiary to it? To negotiate this impasse we must look elsewhere for clues as to the precise identity of the seventh and highest group, these *men of might and vision*.

⁵ Ṣā’īn al-Dīn only mentions Akhlāṭī as *sayyid* or with references to his ‘Alid status, never by name or honorific; given his imamophilism, Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s veneration for his teacher was due not least to the latter’s blood connection to the Imams. E.g., speaking of his time as Akhlāṭī’s disciple in Cairo with Yazdī, he says: “In due course the subtleties of divine favor were vouchsafed me on a journey [to Cairo] in the company of a group [of friends], the dearest [to me] among them being my brother in God Sharaf al-Dīn ‘Alī al-Yazdī, there to meet that garrison (*miṣr*) of sanctified power (*walāya/wilāya*) and guidance, the sublime Sayyidic Threshold (*al-sudda al-saniyya al-sayyidiyya*) (God’s peace be upon him and his noble forebears). [Under his tutelage] I came under the sway of such a measure of blessing (*ni’ma*) as has never before been granted to teacher or taught” (*K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 52b). Cf. Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s reference to Khwāja Muḥammad Pārsā in his *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* I as ‘*khwāja-yi mā*’ (193).

⁶ “R. Shaqq-i Qamar,” 111-12, 116.

6.2: Lettrists vs. men of might and vision

Significantly, in the alternate seven-tiered hierarchy he gives in his *R. Madārij Afhām al-Afwāj*, Šā'in al-Dīn is more explicit about the identity of the members of the seventh level: it consists of “the members of the House of the Prophet (*maḥramān-i ḥaramsarāy-i khatmī*) and those who can riddle their cryptic utterances from among the perfected saints of Islam, and the sages of antiquity (*ḥukamā-yi qadīm*), disciples of the prophets of God.”⁷ As an example of the second category, in the *R. Anjām* he cites Anaxagoras, Pythagoras and Socrates as disciples of Solomon and his companions.⁸

This list, moreover, may be expanded at will. In a short work on defending against the plague, for example, ‘Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī explicitly defines these same *ūlū l-aydī wa-l-abṣār*, “those who have plucked from the niche of the realm of lights the secret truths,” as including

⁷ “*R. Madārij Afhām al-Afwāj*,” 89. In full, the alternate hierarchy Šā'in al-Dīn presents in his *R. Madārij Afhām al-Afwāj fī Tafsīr Āyat Thamāniyat Azwāj*, a relatively detailed commentary on Q 6:143-44 (*Eight couples: two of sheep, two of goats, ... two of camels, two of oxen*), is arranged according to the views of seven groups on Q 6:143-44 in ascending order: exoteric exegetes, Sufis of outward practice, philosophers, the verifiers (*muḥaqqiqān*) among the Sufis, the Sufi elite (*ẓurafā'*), those who can understand the language of the prophets and interpret the forms of the revelations they have brought (*vāqifān-i zabān-i hidāyat-bayān-i anbiyā-yi mursal u kāshifān-i ṣuvar-i munzala-yi ilāhī u 'ulūm-i sharḥī u ṣadrī*), and finally the members of the House of the Prophet and those who can riddle their cryptic utterances from among the saints of Islam, and the sages of antiquity, disciples of the prophets of God (*maḥramān-i ḥaramsarāy-i khatmī u vāqifān-i zabān-i mu'ammā-nishān-i īshān az kummāl-i awliyā-yi muḥammadī va ḥukamā-yi qadīm ki talāmiza-yi anbiyā-yi Allāh-and*). It differs from that in the *R. Shaqq-i Qamar* in its collapsing theologians and peripatetic and illuminationist philosophers into a single category, and giving fully three categories to various classes of Sufis. Šā'in al-Dīn also devoted a separate treatise, the *R. Aṭvār-i Salāsa*, to the analysis of an alternate three-tiered Sufi hierarchy: *muḥaqqiqān*, *abrār* and *akhyār*.

⁸ *R. Anjām*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 157b. Similar assertions are seen in the *Mafāḥiṣ*, e.g. in a discussion of the division of the number one into the two complementary concepts of *aḥadiyya* and *wāḥidiyya* where the ancients (not named) are collectively styled the disciples of Solomon: *al-ṣadru l-awwalu minā l-ḥukamā'i wa-humu l-ladhīna qtabasū anwāra l-ḥikmatī l-ḥaqqatī min mishkāti l-nubuwwatī l-Sulaymāniyya* (MS Majlis 10196 f. 57b, MS Esad Efendi 1731 f. 17a). See also section 2.8 of the same work (MS Majlis 10196 f. 77b) for more on the theme of the ancient sages as disciples of the prophets. Cf. the alternative classification given by Shāh Ni'mat Allāh Valī (d. 834/1431), which explicitly dissociates philosophers and prophets (“*R. Fuṣūl II*,” 362): “Those who travel the Path (*ahl-i sulūk*) are of two classes: those who do so through inferential reasoning (*istidlāl*), and those who do so through ascetic practice (*riyāzat*). Among the first class, if they follow a prophet they are called theologians (*mutakallimīn*), and are called philosophers (*ḥukamā*) if they do not follow a prophet. Among the second class, if their goal is union with the Active Intellect (*'aql-i fa'āl*) they are illuminationists (*ishrāqiyyīn*), and Sufis if their goal is rather the Holy Lights (*anvār-i qudsiyya*). While the Active Intellect is fully realized through action (*fi'l*), it is impeded by the sensible imagination (*wahm*); as for the Holy Lights: Know that sensible imagination has no part therein:/ you attain direct tasting (*zawq*) through tasting, O reader!”

in the first place Hermes Trismegistus (*Hirmis al-Harāmisa*) and Luqmān, and secondarily a number of other ancient authorities such as Apollonius of Tyana (*Bālīnās*), Solomon’s vizier Āṣaf b. Barakhyā, Euclid (*Iqlīdūs*), Aristophanes (*Aristāfānūs*), Eudemus of Rhodes (*Hūdimīs*), etc., who may be presumed to have acquired their knowledge from contemporary prophets.⁹ As noted in Chapter 4 (§4.3.4), ‘Abd al-Raḥmān expands considerably on this list in his *K. al-Durra al-Nāsi’a*, which includes ancient prophets such as Adam, Seth, Noah, Abraham, Hermes and Zarathustra; various Babylonian, Egyptian and Indian sages; and Pythagoras, Plato, Aristotle, Archimedes and Ptolemy.¹⁰

Finally, Ṣā’īn al-Dīn removes all doubt on the matter in his *R. al-Inzāliyya*, where he states that it is specifically lettrists (*ahl al-ḥarf*) who must be considered the associates of the Prophet Muḥammad and his true heirs (*aṣḥāb al-khātam wa-warathatu-hu*); it is they who understand the meanings of the letters according to their three forms, numerological, symbological and phonological.¹¹ Indeed, as Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* is devoted to systematically explicating each of these three forms of the letters, by this definition it may be considered a manual for attaining to an Imam-like status.¹²

The seventh and highest level described in the *R. Shaqq-i Qamar*, then, should be understood as referring both to the Imams and to ancient prophets such as Hermes Trismegistus—as well as to “those who can riddle their cryptic utterances”: the ancient

⁹ *Wasf al-Dawā’ fī Kashf al-Āfāt wa-l-Wabā’*, 16. The list includes other names I was unable to identify: Isqīlūnūs, servant of Idrīs/Enoch; Lādan (Phaedon?); Ṭafīṭūhīsh; Hirdūrīs (Herodotus?); and Darhāyūsh (Darius?). Aristotle, Plato and Galen are also mentioned as having cured or helped to cure the plague.

¹⁰ MS Hafid Efendi 461 ff. 254b-56a.

¹¹ “R. al-Inzāliyya,” 144.

¹² More specifically, in the *Mafāḥiṣ* (section 3.7) Ṣā’īn al-Dīn notes that the spoken form of the letters pertains to prophethood, given its mission to benefit the masses, while the other two forms, the mental and written, are peculiar to *walāya*: the first to the elite members of this category, and the second to the Seal of Sainthood (here presumably ‘Alī), his family and his heirs (*li-khātami-hā wa-ahli-hi wa-warathati-hi*). This is shown by the fact that the Prophet dwelt almost exclusively on the spoken form of revelation and did not refer to its mental or written forms except allusively (MS Majlis 10196 f. 85a, MS Esad Efendi 1731 f. 83b).

philosophers, on the one hand, and Ṣāʿin al-Dīn and his lettrist colleagues on the other, who thus stand equal to such giants as Pythagoras, Socrates and Euclid. More—it is their destiny, as heralded by a recent celestial conjunction, to actualize the occult prophetic legacy from their privileged position at the beginning of the 9th Islamic century. Or *reactualize*?

6.3: *Prisca sapientia*: progress or restoration?

*And I, though I follow so late in time,
attain to that beyond the ken of the ancients.*¹³

—al-Ma‘arrī

*Mankind does not represent a development toward something better or stronger or higher in the sense accepted today. ‘Progress’ is merely a modern idea, that is, a false idea. The European of today is vastly inferior in value to the European of the Renaissance: further development is altogether not according to any necessity in the direction of elevation, enhancement, or strength.*¹⁴

—Friedrich Nietzsche

In stating his dependency on the “cryptic utterances” of the likes of ‘Alī and Hermes, Ṣā’in al-Dīn invokes the principle of *prisca sapientia*, and embraces the paradox implicit within it: all evolution is revolution, all progress is restoration. In early modern Europe, of course, the Renaissance was birthed in the quest for intellectual rebirth through the recovery of ancient wisdom, whence the pervasive esotericism of the period. In the 17th and 18th centuries, we find Newton (d. 1727) poring obsessively over old alchemical texts in a bid to piece together the pristine truth of the science from scattered and corrupted hints; and Francis Bacon (d. 1626), father of the ‘Scientific Revolution,’ putting forward in the *New Atlantis* his vision of a great instauration of society through the retrieval and advancement of lost knowledge, thereby

¹³ *Wa-innī wa-in kuntu l-akhīra zamānu-hu/ la-ātⁱⁿ bi-mā lam tastati[‘]-hu l-awā’ilu*, from qasida illa fī sabīli l-majdi mā anā fā’ilu. Ṣā’in al-Dīn quotes this line at the beginning of his *R. dar Qābiliyyat* (271).

¹⁴ *The Antichrist*, in *The Portable Nietzsche*, trans. W. Kaufmann, New York, 1954, 571.

restoring humanity to its primordial golden age of harmony with God and dominion over nature.¹⁵

As Wouter Hanegraaff observes, the double paradox of progress by regress or recovery over against the exclusive truth claims and posited historical superiority of revealed religion (in this case Christianity) was never adequately resolved; far from stymieing progress, however, this tension was the source of creative dynamism.¹⁶ At the same time, an attempt was made in Europe to resolve the paradox of *prisca theologia* in the form of the doctrine of *philosophia perennis*, whereby the wisdom tradition was seen as fundamentally static and not subject to historical development, refinement or extension. Yet the latter concept gives rise to a paradox of its own; by placing the golden age of human civilization at the dawn of time, it cannot avoid positing the ineluctable decline of history as it ‘progresses’ further from the source of wisdom, and is profoundly conservative as a result.¹⁷ The focus here is on entropy: by supreme effort continuity with the past may be achieved, in the absence of which only degradation can result.

But what of complexity? In macrohistorical terms, entropy is counterbalanced by, and itself generates, a steady increase in the complexity of natural systems. What is resolved downward in terms of entropy is resolved upward in terms of complexity. In biological evolution, natural systems lower their energy density by increasing the complexity of their structure, thereby sequestering the pull of entropy. The same principle has generated a steady increase in the complexity of human societies and networks from prehistory to the present, the agricultural revolution leading to the industrial revolution and the technological revolution following hard on the latter’s heels, itself leading (as computing power increases exponentially)

¹⁵ Principe, “The Alchemies,” 209-10; McKnight, “Wisdom of the Ancients,” 91-92.

¹⁶ Hanegraaff, *Dictionary of Gnosis* 1126-7, s.v. Tradition; see also Mulsow, “Ambiguities of the *Prisca Sapientia*.” On the increasing association of millenarianism with the idea of human progress in early modern England see Escobedo, “The Millennial Border Between Tradition and Innovation.”

¹⁷ The standard association of the category ‘post-classical’ with decline and decadence derives from this concept, although it is now primarily reserved for the civilizations of the global South.

to what certain contemporary writers have termed the Singularity—thus do the cycles of history and whorls of matter and mind wind ever tighter toward their centerpoint, a black hole, an event horizon. In the view of medieval Muslim thinkers like Ibn ‘Arabī and Ibn Turka after him, man himself is precisely this singularity, the tip of the spire of creation mediating between heaven and earth, the black dot on the codex of reality mediating between language and unlanguage¹⁸—he is nonbeing and being, fully human and fully divine, God’s own portal to Himself: “A great miracle, Asclepius, is man.”¹⁹ The purpose of creation is therefore to produce the *insān kāmil*, the Perfect, Prophetic Man, who ascends (*mi‘rāj*) to spirit and in ascending returns to Being, who descends to matter and in descending returns to Nonbeing, laden with revelation, to constellate it with the words of Being. Thus does the prophetic cycle lead inexorably to the end of history (*ma‘ād*), there to be transposed to a higher level of being and begin anew.²⁰

Passé though it might be, then, the principle of complexity would seem to enjoin a teleological interpretation of history—such is embraced by our occult philosopher, Ṣā’ib al-Dīn. He holds the ancient wisdom, obscured in late antiquity, to have already been recovered with the advent of Islam and the marriage that was contracted between quranic doctrine and pre-Islamic philosophy from the 1st/8th century onward, with each successive generation of Muslim thinkers building on the achievements of the last, or renewing them as necessary by

¹⁸ Whence that proof-text of lettrism, ‘Alī’s statement *Anā l-nuqtā allatī taḥt al-bā*, ‘I am the dot beneath the B [that opens the Quran].’ See Ṣā’ib al-Dīn’s *Sharḥ-i Ḥadīṣ-i Nuqṭa*.

¹⁹ Pico’s *Oration*, of course, is an extended meditation on the same theme.

²⁰ As Rūmī sings (*Masnavī*, trans. Nicholson, 3/3901): “I died as a mineral and became a plant,/ I died as plant and rose to animal./ I died as animal and I was Man./ Why should I fear?/ When was I less by dying?/ Yet once more I shall die as Man, to soar/ With angels blest; but even from angelhood/ I must pass on: all except God doth perish./ When I have sacrificed my angel-soul,/ I shall become what no mind e’er conceived./ O let me not exist! For Non-existence/ Proclaims in organ tones ‘To him we shall return!’”

way of *tajdīd*.²¹ From Ṣā'in al-Dīn's standpoint in the early 9th/15th century, the process of retrieving the knowledge of the ancients was already nearly a millennium old in the Islamicate world. Within this overarching narrative of progress, however, Ṣā'in al-Dīn hails his teacher Akhlāṭī as a pioneer precisely in his status as restorer of occult philosophy in the late 8th/14th century after a long lapse.²² He also manifests a paradoxical preference for earlier authorities in certain fields of knowledge, which may be seen, for example, in his manual of logic, *K. al-Manāhij*, where he rejects certain developments in post-Avicennan Arabic logic as breaking unduly with the teachings of the ancients.²³

²¹ The principle of *tajdīd* was established in the Islamic context by the Prophet's announcement that the Muslim community would be renewed through the agency of a *mujaddid* at the head of every century—e.g., Ghazālī at the head of the 6th century AH and Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī at the head of the 7th. The increasing interpenetration of religious and political spheres in later centuries led to the frequent assumption of *mujaddid* status by rulers; Shāhrukh himself, for example, was first declared the *mujaddid* of the 9th Islamic century in the *Naṣā'ih-i Shāhrukhī* of Jalāl al-Dīn Qāyini (d. 838/1435), this acclamation being repeated in Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's *Ẓafarnāma* and 'Abd al-Razzāq Samarqandī's (d. 887/1482) *Maṭla' al-Sa'dayn* (Subtelny and Khalidov, "The Curriculum," 212).

²² See e.g. R. Ḥurūf, MS Majlis 10196 f. 156b: "Knowledge of this noble science having been all but erased a long time since, it has happily been and is currently being revived in our own day through the blessed efforts of the disciples of the Sayyidic Presence (*ḥaẓrat-i sayyidī*), [Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī]—God's peace be upon him and his noble fathers!"

²³ See El-Rouayheb, *Relational Syllogisms*, 145. Ṣā'in al-Dīn wrote this work in 833/1430 in Natanz for his son Jamāl al-Dīn Muḥammad.

6.4: Ibn Turka's millenarian doctrine of progress

*Intelligence evolves when the occult and magical
become the objective-scientific.*²⁴

—Timothy Leary

How then does Ṣā'in al-Dīn attempt to resolve the paradox of restoration as progress, entropy as complexity, in the context of prophetic history? His definitive statement on this theme occurs in the *R. Anjām*:

[K]now that this science of wisdom (*'ilm-i ḥikmat*) was more prevalent in the time of the previous prophets, and especially in the time of Solomon, on whose teaching and the teaching of his companions great thinkers such as Anaxagoras, Pythagoras, Socrates and others have drawn—truly, their noble philosophies (*ḥikmat-hā*) have beautified the lineaments of the age, as anyone with a modicum of insight may see from their magnificent writings.

When the Tartar roe grazes among the blossoms
the breeze bears the scent of musk to market.²⁵

But by the time that the blessed advent of the Arab prophet Muḥammad drew near and the dawn of his being broke from behind the horizon of felicity, the starry ranks of these sciences of wisdom and philosophy (*'ulūm-i ḥikmī*) had departed the heaven of manifestness for the veil of occultation, with but a small fraction of them being communicated and discussed. The reemergence of the mainstream version of philosophy (*ḥikmat-i muta'āraf*) familiar to schoolmen (*ahl-i madrasa*), which derives from Aristotle, the First Teacher, and was reformulated by Ibn Sīnā, its latter-day master, received its impetus from the new revelation—that point at which the sun of wisdom gave forth the rays of prophecy's Seal who, long obscured behind the west of the Arabs, now rose from the east of the Quraysh, illuminating the world and time with the lights of guidance. Basking in this nourishing Seallight (*partav-i anvār-i khatmī*) the gardens of wisdom-philosophy again grew fresh and verdant and under the warm radiance of its subtleties the fields of knowledge and gnosis (*'ilm u ma'rifat*) sprouted luxuriantly anew, each mead blooming with innumerable flowers and each branch on its all-encompassing tree (*dirakht-i*

²⁴ Foreward to Robert Anton Wilson, *Cosmic Trigger: The Final Secret of the Illuminati*, Tempe, 1977.

²⁵ Nizāmī, *Khusraw u Shīrīn*.

jam'īyyat-ash) groaning with every kind of fruit. In short, the garden of knowledge and learning saw the growth of the most rarefied sciences and choicest modes of wisdom and the flowerbed of realities and meaning bloomed with the subtleties and glories of gnosis (*ma'ārif*).

Each instant this garden produces fruits
each fresher than the last.

Out of an elevated sense of purpose a group of the leading scholars of this community held it requisite to adhere to the example of the Prophet, and by dint of their emphasis on his holy custom beautified their inner and outer selves through tireless self-examination and effort; in so doing these exemplary individuals became hosts to wisdom and from the blessed breath of each proceeded diverse occult sciences (*gharāyib-i 'ulūm*)—this fact is obvious to those who are savvy traders in the market of acumen and the shop of knowledge, being well acquainted with the worth of the capital possessed by the merchants of knowledge in each era. The cycling of the ages of history (*dawr-i zuhūr-i aṭvār-i zamānī*) having thus drawn ever closer to its centerpoint of sanctified power (*nuqṭa-yi valāyat/vilāyat*), the edifice constructed upon the foundational truths of these sciences became ever grander and its soaring turrets reached new heights. These developments are clear to the intelligent whose feet are firmly planted at the station of perspicacity and whose insight prompts them to the examination of the works of these great thinkers as fully compatible with the approach of organized and prescriptive religion (*subul-i rusūm u taqlīdāt*).²⁶

In his earlier lettrist treatise, the *R. Ḥurūf*, Ṣā'in al-Dīn defines these “new heights” as follows:

Among the signs of the upward progress of the age (*taraqqī-yi zamān*) and the [improved] ability of our contemporaries to grasp sciences dealing with [ultimate] realities is the fact that in our own blessed day (*vaqt-i dawlatmandī*) a variety of angelic principles (*malakāt-i malakī*) have been made the ornament of mighty works of dominion and a number of realities and varieties of gnostic knowledge (*ma'ārif-i darvīshāna*) have been formulated in all their glory and magnificence.²⁷

²⁶ *R. Anjām*, MS Majlis 10196 ff. 157b–58a. Cf. Bistāmī's view of intellectual history (Fleischer, “Ancient Wisdom,” 234): “... Bistami traces the lineage of his prophetic science to Adam, whence it was transmitted through a string of biblical prophets (particularly Daniel) ultimately to Imam Ali ibn Abi Talib, the ‘legatee of the Prophets’ in the Islamic era, and thence to his first six successors; it was subsequently preserved and practiced by a spiritual lineage of prominent gnostics. Knowledge of the future, in particular, was vested in the sixth imam, Ja'far al-Sadiq (died 765), who encoded it in a ‘comprehensive prognostication’ (*al-jafr al-jamī*), such that prophetic wisdom was preserved but occluded from the commonality of mankind until Ibn Arabi rediscovered it through inspiration. He ‘reunited’ mystical and philosophical wisdom in a manner that was itself effectively prophetic, in that he inaugurated a new era of the expansion and concordance of natural, philosophical, scriptural, and mystical knowledge, precisely what Bistami and his brethren pursued. The cycles of time, the clues afforded by history, and the nature of spiritual and temporal sovereignty became as significant objects of analysis as the movements of the heavens.”

²⁷ *R. Ḥurūf*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 154a.

In historical terms, then, Šā'in al-Dīn's intellectual hierarchy as presented in his *R. Shaqq-i Qamar* and elsewhere represents the cyclical contraction (synthesis) and incremental upward development of the Islamic tradition specifically and human knowledge generally, all building toward what he terms the "centerpoint of sanctified power"—knowledge as a series of soaring, tapering turrets arrayed in a galactic pattern. Ancient prophetic and philosophical knowledge having been occulted, it was restored in the wake of Muḥammad's advent and flourished increasingly within the Islamic tradition. Everything began, of course, with the systematic study of the Quran and hadith. Dialectical theology then arrived to expand upon the literalist approach of the traditionists, but fell short of the thoroughgoing rationalism of the peripatetic philosophers. Illuminationist philosophy developed as a technical refinement of Avicennan peripateticism and attempted to reincorporate mystical concepts, styling itself the 'ancient' philosophy. The mystical philosophers of the school of Ibn 'Arabī criticize all of these groups for being blinded by the specific forms of their belief, each thinking themselves to have a monopoly on truth, and emphasize experiential unveiling as the antidote. Finally, the lettrists take the insights of theoretical mysticism and philosophy and, returning to the raw text of revelation, synthesize the whole into a new master science predicated upon the occult effusions of the Imams and the ancients. The ascent from literalism and return to lettrism, in short, constitutes the full ambit of human knowledge. This lettrist synthesis thus comprises all the Islamic and pre-Islamic sciences, but rendered down into a standardized, efficient and hyperliteral tool for analyzing the constituent atoms of the two Books, the Quran and the cosmos.

Šā'in al-Dīn's disciple Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī espouses a similar vision of evolutionary progression in the theoretical introduction to his work on the *mu'ammā* or riddle/chronogram genre, the *Ḥulal-i Muṭarrar*. Here he posits an intellectual evolution beginning with the revelation of the Quran, whose language is the key to all knowledge, from which first sprang

the 12 Arabic sciences (e.g. Quran, hadith, *fiqh*, *kalām*, grammar, prosody, rhetoric, etc.); this is followed by the age of the *khātam al-walāya*, i.e., that of the Imam/Seal of Sainthood, whose potential for universal knowledge has not been actualized until the present day (*magar dar īn ‘ahd-i humāyūn va li-llāhi l-ḥamd*).²⁸

In sum, Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s presentation of lettrism as the defining science of a new age, as shown above, is part of a grander doctrine of the upward evolution of humanity as conceived through and actualized by a neoplatonic-lettrist-hermetic theory and praxis. He sees the actualization of the prophetic legacy as mediated by the Imams and the ancients as being effected through the teachings of Akhlāṭī as well as his own writings and those of his students and peers—*men of might and vision*.²⁹ As every occult philosopher must, Ṣā’īn al-Dīn upholds the principle of *prisca sapientia*; at the same time, he insists on an unprecedented and millenarian doctrine of progress.³⁰

²⁸ MS Majlis 10196 ff. 374b-375a, MS Majlis 31 ff. 2b-3b. It is significant that the beginning of Sharaf al-Dīn’s theoretical introduction was copied in MS Majlis 10196, the earliest and most comprehensive collection of Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s works; see §2.1.1.1 for more on this collection.

²⁹ I.e., both theoretically and technically capable. As he states elsewhere: “Recently a number of locks securing the veils that shroud the quranic grandeur have been opened and an exposition of its eloquent texture has been given through the good offices of the moon-splitting writings of Sayyid [Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī] (*arqām-i aqmār inshiqāq-i sayyidi*), such that the one to whom it is granted that the black radiance of those scrawls (*arqām*) give to the light of the scouts of his seeing and scrutiny the power to comprehend a color of this type may thereby join the ranks of those who understand the language of the new generation (*naw-khāstagān-i zamān*) and partake of the brides of the marriage chamber of the letters, the eternal Speech” (*R. Anjām*, MS Majlis 10196 ff. 158b-59a). He likewise expresses his discontent with earlier formulations of lettrism at the end of the *R. Ḥurūf* (MS Majlis 10196 f. 157a): “The present author’s approach in penning this treatise has been to ignore the opinions of others and present only the firstfruits of our own time; accordingly I have declined to quote from books with their frequently stale and timeworn treatments of the subject.”

³⁰ Cf. Obrist, “Views on History,” 226: “During the Middle Ages, the prevailing conception of the history of alchemy was that of a genealogical line of descent — both carnal and spiritual — where the original paternal figure was invested with the role of ensuring unity of knowledge. The relationship between this figure and its descendants was one of genus and species. On an epistemological level, the genealogy of knowledge entails the idea of an initial full revelation of knowledge, and its subsequent (partial) loss and recovery. Fundamentally, this view precludes the idea of progress. However, within the frame of history of salvation, alchemy was being assigned a particular role. In writings of, or associated with, Franciscan spirituals, it was meant to provide both material and spiritual support for fighting the Antichrist. From the early fourteenth century onwards, the adherence to a Christocentric and anthropocentric perspective favoured the idea of progress, in the sense that human knowledge of natural and artificial

transformations was considered to be increasingly complete. This progress was considered primarily to be one of spiritual perfection, aimed at restoring the nature of man.”

CHAPTER 7

The Book of Inquiries

*The whole curiosity of our thought now resides in the question: What is language, how can we find a way round it in order to make it appear in itself, in all its plenitude?*¹

—Michel Foucault

7.1: The *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* as *summa* of Islamicate lettrism

Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, or *Book of Inquiries*, is the cornerstone of his oeuvre and the key to his universalist project.² More, as the definitive systematization of the lettrist teachings of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī,³ it is perhaps the single most important work for understanding the thought and self-positioning of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' intellectual network in the early 9th/15th century, both in Timurid Iran and Ottoman Anatolia. It treats of the meanings of the letters according to their three forms, numerological (*iḥsā'ī*), symbological (*kitābī*) and phonological (*kalāmī*), as well

¹ *The Order of Things*, 334.

² This may be seen from the fact that Ṣā'in al-Dīn refers the reader to the *Mafāḥiṣ* in many of his other works, while also referring the reader to his other works in the *Mafāḥiṣ*. The earliest copy of this work, MS Majlis 10196, features autograph sections at the beginning, middle and end of the copy. The same copy contains marginal notes referring to the reader to the author's *Sharḥ al-Basmala* (f. 84a) and his unfinished *K. al-Iṣbāḥ* (f. 89a) respectively for more detail on certain points; the author states his hope to expound more fully on the esoteric aspects of a verse in section 3.7 (f. 85a). The main text also refers the reader to the author's *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam* (f. 75a), *R. al-Muḥammadiyya* (f. 76a) and *R. Asrār al-Ṣalāt* (f. 77a). Ṣā'in al-Dīn refers to the *Mafāḥiṣ* in his *Iṣbāḥ al-Anwār* (MS Majlis 10196 f. 407b) and *R. Nuqṭa* (ed. 'Alī Farrukh, 184, 190). Confusingly, the Arabic *Sharḥ al-Tā'iyya al-Kubrā*, presumably written in Cairo, i.e., before 806/1404 (?), also refers to the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* (ed. Majīd Hādīzāda, 86).

³ Cf. the letter sent by Akhlāṭī to Ṣā'in al-Dīn urging his accomplished disciple to write a work establishing the propositions (*muqaddamāt*) and associations or conjunctions (*iqtirānāt*) proper to the science of letters; the *Mafāḥiṣ* thus represents Ṣā'in al-Dīn's answer to this call (see §2.1.3.1.2, no. 1; the letter is transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.2 below).

as the letters as they are in themselves (*fī anfusi-hā*). As Ṣā'in al-Dīn elsewhere states, knowledge of these three forms is the sole preserve of the companions and true heirs of the Prophet (*aṣḥāb al-khātam wa-warathatu-hu*)—i.e., those *men of might and vision* occupying the seventh and highest epistemological rank in his intellectual hierarchy and identified in the first place with the Imams.⁴ By this definition, then, the *Mafāḥiṣ* must be considered a manual for attaining to an Imam-like status.

The author states that his primary purpose in this work is to demonstrate the roots of all manifestation in the One and schematize the mechanics of multiplicity's derivation therefrom. This information, in turn, will allow the adept to manipulate the letters—the uncreated, creative matrices through which the One self-manifests—to access and control every epistemological and ontological level of the cosmos, thus constituting a continuum from ultra-rarefied letter theory to purely practical letter magic. The supreme dignity of its object necessarily renders lettrism the supreme science:

The subject of the science we have here in view is the One (*al-wāḥid*) insofar as it is one, regardless of the form in which it manifests in all the variety of its significations. The all-pervasive, all-encompassing nature of One with respect to existence being obvious, this science is therefore necessarily superior to all other sciences by an order of magnitude.⁵

Ṣā'in al-Dīn elsewhere contrasts the object of lettrism with the philosophical concept of absolute existence (*al-wujūd al-muṭlaq*), the focus of his *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*; because this concept is only relevant to things that exist, it can hardly serve as the object of a universal science. Only the letter encompasses all that is and is not, all that can and cannot be; it alone is the *coincidentia oppositorum*.⁶ It must be noted that Ṣā'in al-Dīn is here updating the Ibn 'Arabian

⁴ “R. al-Inzāliyya,” 144.

⁵ MS Majlis 10196 f. 53b.

⁶ See e.g. MS Majlis 10196 ff. 55a, 58b. I discuss Ṣā'in al-Dīn's positioning of lettrism vis-à-vis both philosophy and Sufism in Chapter 3 above.

concept of the creative imagination (*khayāl*) as all-encompassing faculty, making explicit what the Andalusian master left relatively implicit by privileging the role of the letters with respect to the creative imagination's mechanics and outworkings.⁷

Moreover, the lettrist theory formulated in the *Mafāḥiṣ* deliberately breaks with earlier treatments of the subject. In his lettrist works Ṣā'in al-Dīn often criticizes the existing literature as being “stale and timeworn”⁸ and compares it to “toughened, jerked meat,”⁹ this fact justifying his failure to cite previous authorities; indeed, he asserts that lettrism had long been in decline before Akhlāṭī appeared on the scene to revive it:

Knowledge of this noble science having been all but erased a long time since, it has happily been and is currently being revived in our own day through the blessed efforts of the disciples of the Sayyidic Presence (*ḥaẓrat-i sayyidi*)—God's peace be upon him and his noble fathers!¹⁰

Ṣā'in al-Dīn therefore enjoins his readers:

[To benefit from this book] ... seekers must first rid themselves of all standard preconceptions that have been well cooked by the flames of their yearning in the pots of conjecture and seasoned with the soporific condiments of imitation of those who have gone before.¹¹

In particular, he ignores lettrist precedent by promoting the written (*kitābī*) form of the letters over the oral (*kalāmī*), which had long been awarded epistemological precedence in the

⁷ That is to say, letters, as the most fundamental of images, represent the atoms of the imaginal realm (*‘ālam al-mithāl*) (personal communication with Professor Chittick). On the similar importance of the creative imagination to thinkers in late medieval and early modern south India, for example, see Shulman, *More than Real*.

⁸ R. *Ḥurūf*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 157a; see Part 2, §T.2.2 for a translation of this treatise.

⁹ K. *al-Mafāḥiṣ*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 52a.

¹⁰ R. *Ḥurūf*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 156b.

¹¹ K. *al-Mafāḥiṣ*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 53a.

tradition due to its association with prophetic revelation.¹² For Ṣā'in al-Dīn, however, it is the written form that is uniquely associated with the *men of might and vision*—whom, we have seen, he identifies with the Imams and the ancients, as well as the members of his own circle—, for it is they alone who bring to actualization what is contained *in potentia* in the prophetic revelation as delivered orally.¹³ The emphasis here is thus on the unbroken *textual* tradition reaching back through the mists of time and preserving true, occult knowledge of history and the cosmos. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's unprecedented lionization of the letters' written form is, in effect, a quintessential expression of his millenarian consciousness, his conviction that he was witness to a new phase of human evolution made possible to his generation through its ability to encompass all of the accumulated knowledge of the elite of humanity in all ages, whether that knowledge be prophetic or philosophical, mystical or magical, theoretical or applied, particular or universal.

Ṣā'in al-Dīn's dismissal, out of hand, of the intervening lettrist tradition aside, he identifies its previous high-water mark with the lettrist writings of Ibn 'Arabī and Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī. Indeed, the only textual sources he admits into this, his magisterial systematization of Akhlāṭī's oral teachings, are Ibn 'Arabī's *Futūḥāt* and Sa'd al-Dīn's *K. al-Maḥbūb*.¹⁴ His extreme regard for these two authorities stems from his perception of them as unparalleled sources of prophetic-

¹² See summary of section 2 below, §7.2. As Ṣā'in al-Dīn clarifies in section 3.7 (MS Majlis 10196 f. 85a, MS Esad Efendi 1731 f. 83b, paraphrased): The spoken form of the letters pertains to prophethood, given its mission to benefit the masses. The other two forms, the mental and written, are peculiar to *walāya*: the first to the elite members of this category, and the second to the Seal of Sainthood, his family and his heirs (*li-khātami-hā wa-ahli-hi wa-warathati-hi*). This is shown by the fact that the Prophet dwelt almost exclusively on the spoken form of revelation and did not refer to its mental or written forms except allusively.

¹³ See §6.2 above. Note that Davānī, following Ibn Turka, also posits a link between the written form of the letters and the *men of might and vision* (*R. Tahlīliyya*, 65). Cf. Lehrich, *The Language of Demons and Angels*, 120: "Nevertheless, Josef Vachek and a few other linguistics have studied writing as a distinct form of language. Their conclusions are surprising: some argue that written language constitutes an almost entirely separate mode of language from speech, having its own *langue* and *parole*; to use functionalist terminology, there are both spoken and written *norms*. In the context of these norms (or *langues*), Fred Householder has even made the suggestion that in logical terms, *written language is prior to spoken*."

¹⁴ To these sources should be added e.g. Jābir b. Ḥayyān's *K. al-Khamsīn*, quoted in section 5 of the introduction as translated in §7.3.1 below.

grade knowledge as expressed in the undammable flood of their occult outpourings; his retrieval and promotion of their lettrist thought therefore naturally constitutes an important element of his own project. That they achieved the highest rank of *walāya* may be seen from the fact that they alone were able to answer the famous 157 questions posed by Ḥakīm Tirmizī.¹⁵

The focus of the *Mafāḥiṣ* as specified in section 2.6 is therefore the form of the letters as revealed to the prophets and the elite among the saints, and specifically that which admits of no admixture with any conventional meanings external to the letters. This is contrasted with the form of the letters that does admit of such admixture, the purview of such thinkers as Ghazālī and Ibn Sīnā, as well as Ṣā'in al-Dīn's own grandfather Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka and elder brother Ṣadr al-Dīn.¹⁶

Running an average of 150 folios in the manuscript record, the *Mafāḥiṣ*, as *summa* of lettrism, is of rather compact size. Evidence suggests that Ṣā'in al-Dīn planned to write a more exhaustive work on the same subject (perhaps to be identified with the unfinished *K. Iṣbāḥ al-Anwār*),¹⁷ but the tribulations he experienced from 830/1427 onwards, leading to his early death in 835/1432, quashed this hope. The *Mafāḥiṣ* was completed in 823/1420,¹⁸ perhaps in Isfahan or Yazd, and revised and expanded in 828/1425;¹⁹ specifically, MS Landberg 146 contains an audition note at the end stating that the work was proofread and notes were added to it by the author in the company of Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī and a group of 'friends, students and children' (*fī*

¹⁵ "Nafṣat al-Maṣdūr I," 186.

¹⁶ This section is translated in §7.3.5 below.

¹⁷ See §2.1.2, no. 9 above.

¹⁸ Two dates are given in the earliest MSS: 1 Sha'bān 823/11 August 1420 (MS Landberg 146) or 19 Dhū l-Ḥijja 823/25 December 1420 (MS Majlis 10196); the latter date is supported by the entry on IT in Mīrzā 'Abd Allāh Iṣfahānī's *Riyāḍ al-'Ulamā'*, pt. 4, 240.

¹⁹ MS Majlis 10196 states in a marginal correction to Ṣā'in al-Dīn's autograph colophon that this date refers to its copying (*taswīd*) only.

jam‘ min al-khullān wa-ṭā’ifa min al-ṭullāb wa-l-wildān) in 828/1425.²⁰

For the purposes of the present chapter, then, I propose to first sketch the structure and main themes of the *Mafāḥiṣ*, then provide several translated sections judged to be representative of the author’s concerns. A more thorough analysis of this dense work is beyond the scope of the present study; my objective here is simply to provide a preliminary introduction to the *Mafāḥiṣ* as a basis for further research.²¹

7.2: The structure of the *Mafāḥiṣ*

Citing Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī as his sole oral source and Ibn ‘Arabī and Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī as his sole textual sources, Ṣā’in al-Dīn opens his *Book of Inquiries* with an exordium on the excellence of the divine or metaphysical sciences, here exemplified by lettrism. He identifies three ways in which this science may be successfully pursued which nevertheless differ in their specific levels or modes of attainment: 1) the way of those who deal with the realities behind the forms of the letters making up the names of things; 2) that of those who deal both with the form and meaning of letters; 3) that of those who attain to the inner essence of the realities by way of numerology (*‘ilm-i a’dād*), this last method being peculiar to ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib who received it via the Prophetic legacy. The present work is intended to encompass all three approaches.

The *Mafāḥiṣ*, as noted, is organized in three sections according to the three forms of the letters—mental, written and spoken—, followed by a fourth section treating of the letters as they are in themselves and more generally in the context of language and literature. (It may be

²⁰ See Āqā Buzurg, *al-Dharī‘a*, 21/309, no. 5218; Iṣfahānī, *Riyāḍ al-‘Ulamā’*, 4/240; Mudarris Tabrīzī, *Rayḥānat al-Adab*, 2/166. Cf. Āqā Buzurg’s reference (*al-Dharī‘a*, 2/44, no. 172) to a *R. Asrār al-Ḥurūf* by Mawlawī Aḥmad b. al-Qāḍī Naṣr Allāh al-Dabīlī al-Tatawī al-Mustabṣir (d. 998/1590) as being written in the manner of the *Mafāḥiṣ*.

²¹ I am currently engaged in producing a critical edition and full translation of the *Mafāḥiṣ* to the same end.

useful here to recall Davānī's summary of these levels: 1) Spiritual-mental, wherein the letters take form in the human mind before being expressed, in this corresponding God's knowledge of realities before their coming into being; these letters are called the high letters (*hurūf-i 'āliyāt*) or thought letters (*hurūf-i fikriyya*). 2) Oral, wherein the letters are expressed in audible form; these are called the medial letters (*hurūf-i wuṣṭā*). 3) Written, wherein the letters are made visible to *men of might and vision* (Q 38:45); these are called the low letters (*hurūf-i sāfila*). Furthermore, letters have spirits, bodies and hearts. Their spirits represent their numerical values, their hearts their oral form, and their bodies their written form.²²) Section four is more diffuse and wide-ranging, and dwells on a series of larger themes not covered in the three sections above. A dominant theme, for example, is that of letter as the *coincidentia oppositorum* (*majma' li-l-ṭarafayn wa-mu'tanaq li-l-mutaqābilayn*).²³ Specifically, the letter and the letter only can serve as matrix to the One since it is solely in the letter that opposites are united; every other existent, by contrast, is necessarily offset or relativized by its opposite.²⁴

The work also includes a number of diagrams. This includes in the first place a master diagram, the Ṭahawī Circle, that functions as a cosmological key encompassing the cosmos from the perspective of both absolute existence (*wujūd*) and engendered existence (*kawn*), and as such may be applied to cosmological data in numerous ways; its importance to Ṣā'in al-Dīn's thought is indicated by the fact that he refers to it separately in other works, e.g. the *Iṣbāḥ al-Anwār*²⁵ and the *R. Nuqṭa*.²⁶ The *Mafāḥiṣ* also contains master number tables referred to as

²² *R. Tahliyya*, 65-66.

²³ See e.g. MS Majlis 10196 ff. 58b, 76a. This is also referred to as *ta'ānuq al-aṭrāf* or *ta'ānuq ḍiddayn*.

²⁴ Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī explicitly identifies belief in the unity of opposites as peculiar to his own circle (Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 92-95). It may be noted in passing that Giordano Bruno likewise places great emphasis on the principle of *coincidentia oppositorum* (de León-Jones, *Giordano Bruno and the Kabbalah*, 24).

²⁵ MS Majlis 10196 f. 407b.

²⁶ Ed. 'Alī Farrukh, 190. The relevant section (1.15) is translated in §7.3.2 below.

jadāwil al-baḥr,²⁷ intended by the author to be a key or exemplar (*unmūdhaj*, *dustūr*) for all of the issues treated the same work, from which the experienced student may extrapolate the sapiential realities (*ḥaqā'iq ḥikmiyya*) contained within the letters of revelation.²⁸

In keeping with its title, Ṣā'in al-Dīn further structures each section of the *Mafāḥiṣ* into a series of 'inquiries' (sg. *faḥṣ*). The titles of these subsections most frequently follow the pattern 'faḥṣ^{un} x fī naẓmⁱⁿ x,' 'faḥṣ^{un} x fī ṣafḥⁱⁿ x,' 'faḥṣ^{un} x fī ḥikmatⁱⁿ x,' etc. For example, section 1.25 is entitled 'faḥṣ iḥṣā'ī fī naẓm kalāmī,' the first element referring to the mental-numerical theme of section one generally and the second element to a specific modulation or aspect of that theme; this subsection accordingly treats of the relationship between the numerological virtues of the letters and their oral form. Or section 2.3, 'faḥṣ kitābī fī ḥikma iḥṣā'iyya,' which may be rendered as 'An inquiry into the written form [of the letter] in terms of an instance of numerological wisdom.'

The introduction, then, has seven such inquiries; section 1, on the mental form of the letters, 36 inquiries; section 2, on the written form, 21 inquiries; section 3, on the spoken form, 18 inquiries; and section 4, on the letters as they are in themselves as well as their three forms in the context of language and literature, 74 inquiries.²⁹ I paraphrase below the opening inquiry of each section as a guide to the dominant themes of the work, and in §7.3.1 provide a translation of its introduction.

²⁷ MS Majlis 10196 f. 71a-b; this version is reproduced in §7.3.4 below.

²⁸ Ṣā'in al-Dīn reiterates this description of the tables in the *R. Nuḡṭa* (ed. 'Alī Farrukh, 190).

²⁹ This includes 22 *ḥarfī* inquiries, eight *iḥṣā'ī*, six *kitābī*, five *kalāmī* (including 14 on the *kalima* and six on the *basmala*), 14 *naḥwī*, four *ṣarfī*, and four on literary-rhetorical categories (*ma'nawī*, *bayānī*, *badī'ī*, 'arūḍī).

Section 1: On the mental form of the letters³⁰

In order to analyze the cosmos at the macro level it is necessary to use the most general, comprehensive categories possible; hence the use in metaphysics of such concepts as existence (*wujūd*), oneness (*waḥda*), quiddity (*māhiyya*), etc. Philosophers hold absolute existence (*al-wujūd al-muṭlaq*) to be the most comprehensive of all such general concepts. Yet even by the philosophers' own standard this concept cannot be all-encompassing, since it, like most philosophical concepts, is offset and relativized by its opposite, in this case forms of absolute nonexistence (*al-a'dām al-muṭlaqa*); forms of relative existence are likewise counterbalanced by forms of relative nonexistence (*al-a'dām al-muḍāfa*). In short, every positive category is twinned with its negative inversion. The sole exception to this rule is the concept of *waḥda*, the state of being one; because it cannot be thusly relativized, the One alone is all-encompassing. That is to say, every other concept, even multiplicity (*kathra*) itself, may be understood in terms of its singularity—it is a concept.

It is the One that necessitates, qualifies and constitutes the Many (*al-kathīr*); it alone is capable of being united with its opposite without impairing its essential integrity. Furthermore, the concept of One and its ascending numerical degrees is wholly self-evident (*badāha*), unlike the concept of existence, whose supposedly self-evident status nevertheless requires demonstration. This is why all the revealed prophetic books dwell exclusively on the One, not on existence as such.

Let the researcher therefore set aside his various misconceptions and inquire into the matter of number (*al-'adad*), for it is the fountainhead of all the sciences, the quarry of all realities, an ocean of insights both manifest and occult.

Section 2: On the written form of the letters³¹

The written form is the clearest (*ajlā*) of the letterforms and most fixed in its manifestation. The author first counterposes the view that this distinction belongs rather to the spoken form of the letters, in that speech is more universal than writing—indeed, even animals communicate through sound—, whereas only the educated elite of humanity, very few in number (*shirmidha khāṣṣa min aṣnāf al-insān*), become capable of expressing themselves through writing after years of training and laborious effort, and must spend further years developing the methods of critical thought. Ṣā'īn al-Dīn states in response to this that two considerations obtain here:

- 1) The prophetic mission must indeed rely on the spoken form of language in order to reach the greatest number of people, especially as its point is to exhort them to physical acts of piety; spoken words may also powerfully affect listeners precisely because they are fleeting. Spoken letterforms are thus most appropriate to the prophetic mission.
- 2) By contrast, the responsibility to guide laid upon those possessed of sanctified power

³⁰ MS Majlis 10196 f. 56b.

³¹ MS Majlis 10196 ff. 72b-73b.

(*wilāya/walāya*) is far better suited to the written form of language, since it is only through this medium that the full complexity of that contained implicitly within the prophetic mode may be expounded, this in a form that endures and is capable of communicating to each generation the central revelatory truths (*al-ḥaqāʾiq al-kashfiyya*).

The written form also has the distinction of being that form that fully intermixes (*imtizāj*) with the perception of them to the point of total identification (*ittiḥād*), unlike any other sensible form. This is because written letterforms are communicated to the light of vision (*nūr al-baṣar*) by light (*ḍiyāʾ*), and the meeting of separate rays of light results in total union rather than mere conjunction. Thus one can see two clashing colors at the same time without either being denatured (*fasād*) by the other, unlike all other types of sensory data such as sounds, smells, textures and tastes, wherein clashing instances are mutually denaturing when they occur simultaneously; if one hears two inharmonious sounds at once, for example, one cannot make out either, since their medium is air rather than light. In other mediums discrete sensory data must follow in succession to be perceived properly, whereas visible things may be seen simultaneously and still maintain their integrity. Written letterforms are thus not bodies and cannot clash, and for this reason they stand unique among sensory objects in their abstraction (*tajarrud*) from denaturing and obscuring material constraints (*al-mafāsīd al-hayūlāniyya wa-qādhūrāti-hā l-ẓulmāniyya*). By the same token, spoken letterforms as communicated through airwaves (*al-tamawwujāt al-hawāʾiyya*) that pass with the elapsing of each moment are susceptible to such denaturing by virtue of their medium.

In addition, the more descended (*anzāl*) such forms are, the more they are perfect, encompassing and comprehensive of special characteristics (*akmal wa-ajmaʿ li-l-khaṣāʾiṣ wa-ashmal*).³²

Section 3: On the spoken form of the letters³³

While it is the written form of the letter alone that remains imprinted on the pages of time across the ages, all peoples from ancient times to the present laboring to record and preserve the choicest insights of humanity in the form of various sciences, the spoken form of the letter, for its part, encompasses every mode of expression, both rational and irrational, that gives voice to the consciousness of man and animal. The final level of descent from existential oneness (*al-waḥda al-wujūdiyya*)—itself the shadow of the true or divine oneness (*al-waḥda al-ḥaqīqiyya*)—down through the chain of being that comprehends all is described by the technical term of oneness of genus (*al-waḥda al-jinsiyya*). This level in turn involves descent through levels of its own through which its fullness is expressed, this descent terminating in the low genus (*al-jins al-sāfil*), its fifth and final stage; this process is schematized in the Ṭahawī Circle. This lowest level, moreover, is reflected in

³² Ṣāʾ in al-Dīn makes a similar argument in his *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr* as to the primacy of sight vis-à-vis hearing; the latter, while being of widest compass among the senses, is biased toward the spiritual and therefore cannot render a form in its fullness, unlike sight, which registers spiritual and physical objects with equal accuracy (*SND*, 38-39; trans. in §E.2.2.5 below).

³³ MS Majlis 10196 f. 53a-b.

another type termed oneness of species (*al-waḥda al-naw'iyya*), the category comprising man as microcosm (*al-kawn al-jāmi'*). When this process of descent is complete, the last level becomes host to the divine Name the Living (*al-ḥayy*) and site of the manifestation of its properties, as well as those of all the Names subsidiary thereto. The first thing that is engendered from this blessed union (*jam'iyya*) is a perfect existential form that discloses the contents of consciousness termed the voluntary voice (*al-ṣawt al-ikhtiyārī*); this is what first manifests from an animal upon birth. The Ḥāmīmī Circle comprises a numerological explanation of the above.

Now it may be asked: How can vocal expression (*ṣawt*) be existential, for it is clear that it is but a transitory accident, a fleeting engendered thing? I answer: This refers only to the voluntary voice associated in the first place with the animal; it is evident that voice is necessarily attributable to existence when it constitutes a reality expressive of what is contained in the hidden levels of existence, yet remains an engendered accident insofar as it is borne to the hearing by soundwaves. The two properties are not mutually exclusive. This is the view of the speculative [philosophers and theologians] (*ahl al-naẓar*); in terms of sapiential insight (*al-wajh al-ḥikmī*), however, the voice is a corporeal representational form (*ṣūra jasadāniyya mithāliyya*) subsisting existentially in itself, regardless of the fact that it manifests through airwaves, in this respect being similar to light (*daw'*) (which topic was discussed in the section on the written form of the letter). For this reason the philosophers hold contradictory views on the subject, with some being of the opinion that the two are separate bodies. It is, however, clear to the intelligent that it cannot be a body qualified by flowing and moistness (*ruṭūba*) and subject to superficial alterations.

Given this premise, then, know that the spoken form of the letter is an accidental form pertaining to the voice and compounded of parts and vocalizations that serve to distinguish [utterances] according to context. This may be known from the fact that air, due to its subtle and balanced nature, is uniquely fitted to enter the kingdom of the human constitution as servant, there to wait upon its caliph, the holy secret (*al-laṭīfa al-qudsiyya*), and withdraw upon its command arrayed in robes of light. Thus no majlis or other gathering is worth the name if luminous words be lacking. The quranic reference here: *Surely good deeds will drive away evil deeds; that is a remembrance unto the mindful* (Q 11:114). That is to say, good things—the light of existence—must needs drive away evil things—the darkness of nonexistent engendered beings.

Insofar as the spoken form of the letter represents speech, then, it conveys the holy lights that negate the darkness of the material realms. It is for this reason that most of the religious duties God imposes on His servants have to do with this spoken form, such as ritual prayer and other forms of worship—this fact alone suffices to indicate its great dignity.

*Section 4: On the letters as they are in themselves, i.e., the material substance (mādda) underlying the letters' three forms as discussed above*³⁴

Having discussed the three aspects of the letters together with the properties, effects, accidents and concomitants of each—this discussion representing the choicest intellectual fruits of the age and providing the framework for extracting exalted types of wisdom from the revealed heavenly letters—, we must now turn to the letters themselves to explicate

³⁴ MS Majlis 10196 ff. 58b-90a.

their supreme eminence in the sensible realms of engendered existence; for the letters are the straight path for all seekers.

Every fixed substance and transient accident that exists in the visible world falls into one of two categories. The first comprises those that are luminous (*nūrānī*), i.e., those which are apparent in themselves and manifest other objects through their effects, such as the sun. The second comprises those that are dark (*ẓulmānī*), i.e., those which are nonapparent in themselves and obscure other objects, such as gross bodies (*ajrām kathīfa*). Given this premise, it will be clear to anyone with a modicum of discernment that only things that are in the first category may serve to provide us new information about what is unknown.

However, the first category comprises many subcategories, since substances and accidents differ widely in the extent to which they furnish such information. Some things only illuminate their immediate surroundings, such as a lamp, while others illuminate all sensible objects, such as the sun and moon. Despite their difference in degree, however, these two instances do not fundamentally differ in that both reveal objects to the perception without themselves perceiving; this category therefore represents the first level of light (*nūr*).

The second level of light comprises those things that are capable of perceiving objects in their own right as well as making the same objects perceptible to other things, such as the light of vision (*nūr al-bāṣira*) with respect to colors and luminosities. This level is superior to the first, yet is still incapable of fully expressing the category of light: for such things cannot perceive themselves nor occulted or absent objects, and those objects they do perceive they frequently perceive inaccurately—moving things as motionless, large things as small, etc.

The third level of light comprises that which is capable of perceiving itself as well as all other existents, whether sensory or immaterial, present or absent, occult or manifest, and of making such objects perceivable to others: this is the intellect or reason (*al-‘aql*). Yet it too, despite its great facility in revealing objects as they are, suffers from a certain incapacity in fully expressing the divine name Light (*al-nūr*), since by its nature it tends towards what is interior (*buṭūn*) and hence is best able to perceive universals and the categories of transcendence and incomparability (*taqdīs, tanzīh*); when it attempts to analyze that which is external (*ẓāhir*), however, involving rather a comprehensive awareness (*jam‘iyya*) of engendered particulars and the category of similarity (*tashbīh*), it is incapable of doing so directly and must rely upon other faculties. Given the necessity of such reliance, reason cannot but fall prey to various types of ambiguity and confusion (*talabbus, tashawwush*) and thereat hesitate and vacillate (*taraddud, tadhabdhub*). This is because the faculties upon which reason relies are often at cross purposes with each other, which leads to conflicting and contradictory data (*taqābul, ta‘āruḍ*). More, in seeking the assistance of these faculties reason’s own power is compromised and it cannot maintain its control over them; they rather interfere even in the arenas proper to reason and confuse its perception, such that it is rarely able to carry out its office free of doubt.

Finally, the fourth level of light comprises that which is able to reveal things as they are in an absolute sense, and pertains solely to the revealed heavenly form which is wholly unsusceptible to error from within or without: this is the letter. To it alone belongs the all-comprehensive sublimity (*al-‘uluww al-iḥāṭī*) that allows it to transcend all dichotomies (*mutaqābilāt*), through it alone are the scales of judgment preserved from any deviation or irregularity of measurement proper to most engendered beings. For every nature (*ṭabī‘a*), excepting the letter itself, must needs occupy one of two opposed categories (*mutaqābilayn*). The letter therefore stands to all dichotomies in the manner described by the verse: *Praise be to God Who has sent down upon His servant the Book and has not assigned*

unto it any crookedness (Q 18:1). For this reason the letter is uniquely capable of making perceptible not only things that exist (*mawjūdāt*) but also things that do not or cannot exist (*ma'dūmāt*, *mumtani'āt*), and this in equal measure. It alone may reveal the Absolute (*al-iṭlāq*) that otherwise transcends all perception and thought. The preeminence of the letters is such that God has included them (i.e., the *muqatṭa'āt*) among those holy substances He sent down to His servants by way of His prophets to guide them to felicity. The letter is the enlightening elixir (*al-iksīr al-munīr*); were a drop of it to strike the vaults of dark bodies that fill the realms of contingency (*al-'awālim al-imkāniyya*), it would forthwith dispel their intrinsic darkness and transform their substance from base to noble, rendering those gross bodies pure light to illumine the dark realms of matter and becoming.

After citing these demonstrative analogies and rhetorical-poetical proofs as to the ontological and epistemological supremacy of the letter, Ṣā'in al-Dīn proceeds to list selected quranic verses and hadiths that support his point, followed by sayings from the Companions and Successors (including 'Alī and Ḥusayn) and from the righteous *salaf*, such as Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal and al-Shāfi'ī. The author ends the opening section of part four by singling out Zamakhsharī's failure to recognize the intrinsic majesty of the quranic letters for special censure.

The remainder of part four pursues this theme by applying it in various ways to the three forms of the letters established above. It treats successively the supreme Name Allāh (*ALH*), the *basmala*, and various grammatical and rhetorical considerations, ending with an examination of the ontological and epistemological status of prosody.³⁵

7.3: Translated excerpts

7.3.1: The introduction³⁶

Praise be to God Who has equipped (*i'dād*) the number (*'adād*) of his servants to comprehend the perfection of His will by revealing the multiple (*a'dād*) expositions of the Book, Who has thereby made it the primary tool (*al-'udda al-mu'tadd bi-hā*) for knowledge

³⁵ This last inquiry is translated in §7.3.6 below.

³⁶ MS Majlis 10196 ff. 52a-56a.

of [our] return to Him (*ma'ād*) on the Day of Reckoning (*yawm al-ḥisāb*), Who in separating out a specific number of days (*ma'dūdiyyat ayyāmi-hi*) has clarified the appointed time for festivals wherein [we] draw near to Him and remain not afar off, traveling therein the right path, Who thereby made known to His servants the routes of ascent according to the capacity of each route to satisfy (*iḥsāb*);³⁷ and blessings be upon Muḥammad, the greatest among those given wisdom and the decisive address (*faṣl al-khiṭāb*), and upon his House and his Companions, the guides on the ways of certitude and conductors to the quenching pools for the intelligent.

To proceed: The divine or metaphysical sciences (*al-'ulūm al-ilāhiyya*), in all their methodological varieties and with all their programmatic differences, represent the highest object to which [human] ambition aspires and the ultimate point to which the chargers of generous natures are led. But it is only a science that admits of not the slightest insinuation of doubt that can truly show the [different] rankings [of its practitioners] as the finest riders compete on its racing grounds for the palm. To such a [science] gravitate the piercing stars of the revealed laws (*nawāmīs*) as they rise from the horizon of eloquent expression, with the lights of clarifying exposition radiating from its moonlike figures (*arqām*); the hearts of all wayfarers in the night (*sarā'ir sā'ir al-sā'irīn*) overflow from the heaven of its glorious height, the innermost beings (*khaṣā'is*) of all who tarry by the water gleam forth from the ground of its fertile recumbency.

I've seen Sa'ds of many nations
but never a Sa'd like Sa'd b. Mālik.³⁸

It is this [science] that God has spread out in the abode of His Islam as groundcloth for the repast of His Speech, favoring His servants with the varieties of growth that sprout forth from the ground of their preparedness at the banquets of His *Lawāmīm*, feeding them so as to strengthen them and bring them to maturity with the delicacies of the doves of His *Hawāmīm*, giving them to drink of [the water of] *Tasnīm* so as to revive them to an everlasting life from the cups of His *Ṭawāsīn*. How often have consummate and vigorous [thinkers] among the leading figures of this community sought to acquire it; driven by the burning cravings of their aspiration, they were not willing to settle for the toughened, jerked meat left by those who have gone before but rather strove to reach ripe and succulent truths from the boughs of each second of each hour, from now to eternity. Such individuals include those who make for the East of expansiveness and manifestation (*baṣṭ, zuhūr*) and succeed in picking the ripe fruits from the crown of the tree of His manifestation by way of speech (*kalāmī*), limiting their diet to this and seeking nothing further. They also include those who rather make for the West of constriction and hiddenness (*qabḍ, khafā'*) and are fortunate enough to amass priceless pearls from the submerged hoards of His manifestation by way of text (*kitābī*)—and upon my life, it is the latter who inherit the choicest truths (*khaṣā'is*) from the holy Seal (*al-ḥaḍra al-khatmiyya*).³⁹

³⁷ It will be noted that this series of wordplays on the root 'DD signals the numerological theme of the work as a whole.

³⁸ Ṭarafa b. al-'Abd, qasida: *qifī wadda'ī-nā l-yawma yā bnata Māliki*.

³⁹ The theme of 'west is best' similarly runs through Ibn 'Arabī's writings, and particularly in the '*Anqā' Mughrib*, where he identifies the Mahdi, for example, with the 'sun rising in the west' (*shams al-maghrib*) as sign of the Last Hour (see Elmore, *Islamic Sainthood*, 163-95). As Ibn 'Arabī states in his *R. al-Intiṣār* (4; trans. in Elmore, *Islamic Sainthood*, 175): "For the spiritual Opening of the West (*fath al-maghrib*) is unrivalled by any other Opening, since its allotted existential time is the Night (*al-layl*), and [the Night]

These include the oral (*matluwwa*) wealth he passed down to his heirs (*aqrabīn*), having himself inherited it from his noble forefathers, i.e., the preeternal Speech (*al-kalām al-qadīm*) taught him by one terrible in power, very strong, [who] stood poised (Q 53:5-6), as well as the new rarities he possessed, ripe fruits [unique] to the Seal's garden, i.e., the temporally-originated Speech (*al-kalām al-ḥadīth*) that he read from the [eternal] Tablet of *He revealed to His servant what He revealed* (Q 53:10). God reward these [pioneers] on our behalf with the greatest reward.

However, in restricting the path of superabundance to these two nodes, both among the Seal's most prized possessions, and making them the [only] path, [the leading scholars of the community] neglected the third [node], which is the rarest and choicest and serves to strengthen [the first two].⁴⁰ It is through this last that the gate of veriest truth (*ʿayn al-ṣawāb*)⁴¹ is opened, and behind this gate are the treasures of the Seal's glory and the protected space of his intimacy (*qurb*) which contain necklaces of precious jewels (*ʿuqūd farāʿid al-jawāhir*) and all else laid there in store. [The Seal] collected all this and provisioned therewith his son [ʿAlī b. Abī Ṭālib], the Seal of sanctified power (*wilāya/walāya*) and standard-bearer of understanding and guidance. These necklaces (*ʿuqūd*) are numerical knottings (*al-ʿuqūd al-ʿadadiyya*), the spiritual-intellectual form of the Book that was sent down from the highest Pen to the noble Tablet. Number (*ʿadad*), then, is the best means of acquiring sciences of great benefit and numerous as grains of sand, the primordial mine preserving the gems [at the core] of all the standard and mainstream sciences which, in the perception of those who think in formalized terms (*rusūm*) and use technical terminology (*iṣṭilāḥāt*), have been veiled with artificial terms and conventional descriptions (*awṣāf waḍʿiyya*) applied to them by these [scholars] and their predecessors—*God has sent down no authority touching them* (Q 12:40, 53: 23).

The verses that indicate the exalted status of number are numerous beyond reckoning, and may be divided into two categories: revealed heavenly recited or primary (*matluwwa*) verses, and emergent (*bāriza*) earthly reciting or secondary (*tālīya*) verses.

The first [category of verses] may be understood in their capacity as the qualifier (*nāʿit*) that reveals the divine gift (*al-ʿaṭāʾ al-ilāhī*) as expressed in His statement, *For a recompense from your Lord, a gift, a reckoning* (Q 78:36); likewise, solely through enumeration (*iḥṣāʾ*) may the gates of paradise be opened, as has been related: *To God belong ninety-nine names—a hundred save one; whoso enumerates them shall enter paradise*,⁴² drawing attention to this with the emphatic *a hundred save one*. This [category] is predicated upon the pool of its clarity and the richly flowing Kawthar of its multiplicities (*kawthar katharāti-hi al-mutakawthara*), from whence the Seal immediately distributes to his intimates from among every people parched of liver and longing in heart silver cups by the hand of ʿAlī, a

precedes the Daytime (*al-nahār*) in the Glorious Scripture in every passage. In [the Night] the 'Night-Journey' (*al-isrāʾ*) takes place for the Prophets, and therein the spiritual Benefits (*al-fawāʿid*) arise [for the Saints], and the Self-Revelation of the Real shall come to pass for His Servants ... For the 'Virgin-Secrets' (*abkār al-asrār*) are only 'deflowered' with us [in the West]. Thereafter, they emerge before you in your East (*mashriq-kum*) as 'Divorcees' (*thayyibāt*) who have ended their period of waiting. Then you marry them at the horizon of the Orient. For we share equally in the pleasure of 'marriage,' but we [in the West, particularly] win the pleasure of 'deflowering'!"

⁴⁰ Cf. Q 36:14: *When We sent unto them two men, but they cried them lies, so We sent a third as reinforcement* (*fa-ʿazzaz-nā bi-thālithⁱⁿ*).

⁴¹ *Ṣawāb* = 99.

⁴² See e.g. Bukhārī, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *al-Tawḥīd* (98), bab 12, no. 7392.

member of his House, filled with water; and whoso drinks of this water will never thirst again.

How great the gulf between him and the clouds:
they bestow drops; he, a flood.⁴³

These virtues are not a mere double draught of milk.⁴⁴

The second [category] of reciting or secondary verses may be observed in their capacity as the horn (*qarn*) in which all forms are gathered together.⁴⁵ Now the bases of manifestation of the Shari'a-ordained, making-perceptible (*mush'ira*) rites and the prophetic, making-known (*munbi'a*) institutions are built upon its places of knotting (*ma'āqid 'uqūdi-hi*), whose forms, revelatory of the essence of the whole (*kunh al-kull*), are sent down as though poured into the mold of [the horn's] regulating and limiting function (*ḍabṭu-hu wa-ḥudūdu-hu*). Given this, were the ritual prayer or alms tax or other such rites to be stripped of the knottings (*'uqūd*) of number and its [associated] substances (*jawāhir*) so regarded by the masses (*al-'amma*) neither entity nor trace (*athar*) would obtain to [these rites] on the visible plane nor would anyone have heard tell of them. Indeed, were one to investigate all of the specialized occupations, civil professions, norms of expression and customary rules of interpersonal engagement upon which the harmonious organization of the markets is predicated and through which dervish and other assemblies cohere, without exception, everything would be found to constitute the forms of [this category's] variegation, the sites of its expansion (*baṣṭ*) and its various fluctuations (*taqallubāt*). For there does not exist a single body of knowledge (*jam'iyya 'ilmiyya*) free of the ornaments of its gathering and its division (*jam', taqsīm*), nor an entified structure (*hay'a 'ayniyya*) divested of the garments of its ordering and differentiation (*naẓm, tafṣīl*).

As for myself, in the prime of my youth I strove diligently in pursuit of the primordial perfection (*al-kamāl al-aṣlī*) and the sciences of reality (*al-'ulūm al-ḥaqīqiyya*), not boastful [in my ability] but rather thankful for [the opportunity to do so], in the process searching far and wide in various lands and seeking out various authorities. In due course the subtleties of divine favor were vouchsafed me on a journey [to Cairo] in the company of a group [of friends], the dearest [to me] among them being my brother in God Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī al-Yazdī, there to meet that garrison (*miṣr*) of sanctified power (*walāya*) and guidance, the sublime Sayyidic Threshold (*al-sudda al-saniyya al-sayyidiyya*) [Sayyid Kamāl al-Dīn Ḥusayn al-Akhlāṭī] (God's peace be upon him and his noble forebears).⁴⁶ [Under his tutelage] I came under the sway of such a measure of blessing (*ni'ma*) as has never before been granted to teacher or taught:

⁴³ Mutanabbī, qasida: *a-rīqu-ki am mā'u l-ghamāmati am khamru*.

⁴⁴ Umayya b. Abī l-Ṣalt; the line continues: 'frothy with water, the whole ending in urine.' The poet is here dismissing rival tribes' claim to generosity and hospitality.

⁴⁵ MS Esad Efendi 1731 f. 3a, marginal note: 'The horn is that blown by Isrāfīl and is here used metonymically for number (*'adad*); the forms are the levels of numbers (*marātīb al-a'dād*).'

⁴⁶ The group of traveling companions Ṣā'in al-Dīn mentions likely included Ni'mat Allāh Valī, Qāsim-i Anvār and Qāzizāda Rūmī; see §4.3.2 below.

As though, for sheer conviviality, we lived
a day outside of time.⁴⁷

For the percolations of his perfection that were poured out upon me in the course of his teaching (*ishārātu-hu*) exceeded the (admittedly rather capacious) buckets of my capacity and I so benefited from [my fellow] circumambulants about the pavilion of his majesty as to outstrip the heavy rainclouds of my hope—God reward them beyond the measure of what a mere slave can hope for the elite (*al-muqarrabīn*)!

Moreover, I was wont to seek out the works of previous luminaries from among the professors of truth and unity (*ahl al-haqq wa-l-tawhīd*) and attend mystical gatherings (*majālis al-dhawq*) to explore their finest unveilings (*mukāshafāt*) and subtlest symbolic utterances (*marmūzāt*), as the poet has sung:

When I thirst for his saliva
I use wine as a substitute,
though it can't compare:
I'm but distracting my sick heart.⁴⁸

Amongst the books that are known to all I have seen none to match the works of the two redoubtable masters (God sanctify their spirits), the reviver (*muḥyī*) and disseminator of all the principles of supernal wisdom, from the most fundamental to the most rarefied, [Muḥyī l-Dīn Ibn al-'Arabī], and the auspicious star (*sa'd*) rising from the horizon of verification and revealing the symbolic aspects and allusions of its written signs, [Sa'd al-Dīn al-Ḥamuwayī].

Now whenever I chanced to meet with my companions and mention somewhat of the precious pearls of this necklace [of knowledge] and their perfect arrangement, I would invariably be pressed with great urgency to explain further. So the exigency of time (*qahramān al-zamān*), consistent with its tendency to strengthen the foundation of making-manifest and make manifest the principles of exposition, prompted me to write on certain general principles (*uṣūl jāmi'a*) pointing to the paths of guidance, i.e., those leading to the troves of allusions of the Book (*ishārāt al-kitāb*) in all of their various modes and genres (*madhāhib, shi'āb*), such that the intelligent may understand them and thereby be empowered to 'enter the houses by their doors' and climb the ascending stages of that path and its [increasing] hiddenness (*buṭūn*), opening the door of each [level] as it comes, progressing from kernel (*lubb*) to pith (*lubāb*). [This work] is thus meant to whet the appetite of seekers by giving them to taste of the succulent young meat and other delicacies of the age, and as per my obligation I give thanks [for having been given the wherewithal to carry out my task].

Thanks is rendered by the gracious gift itself—not by me.⁴⁹

[To benefit from this book], however, these seekers must first rid themselves of all standard preconceptions that have been well cooked by the flames of their yearning in the pots of conjecture and seasoned with the soporific condiments of imitation of those who

⁴⁷ Ibn al-Mu'tazz (d. 296/908).

⁴⁸ Ibn al-Mu'tazz.

⁴⁹ Mutanabbī, qasida *Ajāba dam'i wa-mā l-dā'i siwā ṭalali*.

have gone before; secondly, they must apply themselves to understanding it aright (*ṣawb ṣawābi-hi*) and unlocking its knottings and doors with utmost concentration and sincerest intention. The readership I here have in mind include those who are accustomed to the modes of signification (*asālīb al-dalālāt*); those whose vision is honed so as to be capable of driving the gazelles of tasting (*dhawq*) upon the fields of truth (*ṣidq*) and certainty (*yaqīn*), there to capture them; those tractable of spirit in the presence of accomplished adepts (*al-ghālibīn al-bālighīn*); those mentally aware (*yaqzān al-qarīḥa*); those who have attained to the flash [of insight] (*darrāk al-lamḥa*) despite its subtlety in indicating the symbol (*ramza*) and despite the hiddenness of its site—*And how few are they* (Q 38:24)! It is clear that the responsibility of teaching requires one to adhere to what is current among those who seek human perfection and strive in all earnestness to transcend the base imitation of the common run of people and attain to the pinnacle of certainty-instilling direct perception (*al-shu'ūr al-'iyānī al-īqānī*); and while the methodologies current among the nations are many and correspond to their different levels of attainment and purpose, the most straightforward and persuasive of these approaches relative to what people are familiar with is the rational-theoretical approach that depends on logical thought (*al-naẓar al-'aqlī wa-l-fikr al-ālī*) while at the same time swerving not from the highway of intuitive all-comprehensiveness (*jam'īyyatu-hu al-dhawqīyya*) into the thickets of thorny theoretical doubts on either side.⁵⁰ Given that my purpose here is solely to help the reader to comprehend shy and rarefied realities (*shawārid al-ḥaqā'iq*) and give seekers of guidance a tantalizing taste of the wondrous ripe fruits of the age—things discomfiting to most—, it therefore behooves me to employ in some measure such time-honored rationalistic terminology and premises [to this end].

I.1: A Sapiential Inquiry in Rationalistic Terms

Now it goes without saying that a work of this kind can only maintain its claim to comprehensiveness if its discussion be on a stable footing, its validity ensured by the scales [of reason] and its correctness attested to by the rules of valid demonstrative argument (*qawānīn ṣaḥīḥ al-burhān*); for only such a foundation can support the pillars of certitude and the edifice of expository instruction in the sciences. The conventional constitution (*al-mizāj al-ja'li*) that ensures the health of a body of text and the soundness of its arrangement is compounded of four principles, just as the four elements (*al-arkān al-arba'a*) bring to perfection (*takmīl*), in the first place, the whole of existence (*al-kull al-wujūdī*) and, in the second place, the experiential perfection of knowledge (*al-kamāl al-'ilmī al-shuhūdī*); indeed, it is the first process that allows this perfection of knowledge to emerge from out the depths of its nonmanifestness in an intelligible form—its overlay both spoken and written.

[The four principles constituting a given discipline or science are as follows:]

- 1) Its **subject** (*mawḍū'*), i.e., the soil in which the expository guideposts of that science are planted and from which derive the various ramifications of its judgments and investigations (*abḥāth*).

⁵⁰ I.e., mystical-philosophical syntheses as pursued, for example, by Ṣā'in al-Dīn's grandfather Ṣadr al-Dīn and by Ṣā'in al-Dīn himself in the *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*.

The subject of the science we have here in view is the One (*al-wāḥid*) insofar as it is one, regardless of the form in which it manifests in all the variety of its significations. The all-pervasive, all-encompassing nature of One with respect to existence being obvious, this science is therefore necessarily superior to all other sciences by an order of magnitude.

- 2) Its **theses** (*masā'il*), i.e., the means by which [a science] is demonstrated (*ithbāt*) through their extraction and the basis for discovery and expression [of new knowledge] through inquiry (*fahṣ*) and examination.

In this case, I will endeavor to lay out the names of the True One (*al-wāḥid al-ḥaqīqī*), which variously reveal the aspects of its existential descents (*tanazzulāt wujūdiyya*), sapiential-rational descents (*tanazzulāt ḥikmiyya 'aqliyya*), and textual-intuitive revelations (*inzālāt kitābiyya dhawqiyya*).

- 3) Its **principles** (*mabādī'*), i.e., the means by which [a science's] comprehensiveness is ensured in a way that lays out all of the above aspects, including those formulations (*taṣawwūrāt*) that attach to the realities of One's variations (*ḥaqā'iq tanawwu'āt al-wāḥid*) and those judgments (*taṣdīqāt*)⁵¹ that support the demonstration (*ithbāt*) of its properties (*aḥkām*) and parts (*aqsām*) revelatory of the qualities and effects of the All (*khaṣā'is al-kull wa-āthāru-hu*).

The principles of the science here in view involve the analysis (*taḥqīq*) of the meaning of One in its various parts (*aqsām*) and explanation of how the forms of these parts disclose the One in all of its various types (*anwā'*) and with all of its various properties (*aḥkām*), including on the one hand rational and numerical [forms] that ascend from the ground of fundamental capacities (*al-isti'dādāt al-aqliyya*), and on the other sensory and textual [forms] that descend from the heaven of holiness and grace (*wahb*). These two [categories of] forms are among the concepts (*ma'ānī*) denoted by *ṬH* (Q 20:1), to which the testimony of correspondences (*munāsabāt*) bears witness, wherein *Ṭ*, for example, signifies all the levels of ascent (*marātib al-ṭālī'*) and *H* all the levels of descent (*madārik al-hābiṭ*) and the most perfect of its loci of manifestation, as will be discussed below.

- 4) [Finally], its **objective** (*ghāya*), i.e., the goal sought by those a quest, that which spurs them onward in pursuit of that form of perfection (*al-ṣūra al-kamāliyya*) to which their passion aspires.

This refers here to the perfect point (*al-nuqta al-tamāmiyya*), [the constitutive] part of the perfect word (*al-kalima al-kamāliyya*), toward which redounds the ascendant point of its true meaning (*al-murād al-ḥaqīqī*) in the matter of making it manifest (*iḥḥār*) to all nations and peoples according to the dictates and provisions of the present moment, thereby investing them with certainty through open demonstration. This scenario can only be conceived of as taking place through the manifestation of the fullness of knowledge (*tamām al-'ilm*) and the perfection of power (*kamāl al-quḍra*) as part of the purpose behind the arrangement of the chain of manifestation and making-manifest (*silsilat al-zuhūr wa-l-iḥḥār*) as lashed to the knottings of perception and making-perceptible (*'uqūd al-shu'ūr wa-l-ish'ār*)—namely, [the existence of] the Arab Seal Muḥammad, God bless and keep him. Among the concepts (*ma'ānī*) denoted by

⁵¹ For formulation (*taṣawwūr*) and judgment (*taṣdīq*) as used in Arabic philosophy, see Harry Wolfson, "The Terms *Taṣawwūr* and *Taṣdīq* in Arabic Philosophy and Their Greek, Latin and Hebrew Equivalents," *Muslim World*, 33/2 (1943), 114-28.

[the command] *Say!* (*qul*) is a reference to these two levels [occupied by the Seal]: the *Q* refers to this power [scil., *quwwa*], the *L* refers to this knowledge [scil., *ilm*].

I.2: A Further Inquiry in This Vein

Know that the [object of] knowledge (*ilm*) that accrues to the servant (whoever he may be) as a result of his diligence is limited to two categories:

- 1) Engendered forms that veil [realities] (*al-ṣuwar al-kawniyya al-ḥājiba*), on which are trained our reductive mental faculties (*al-madārik al-bashariyya al-ḥāṣira*), involving especially the capacity of critical, rational-theoretical thought and its indubitable premises derived from immediate perception (*shir*) or an [external] address (*khiṭāb*). The organ that controls this category of knowledge is the sacred intellect (*al-aql al-qudsī*), and the types of sciences derived therewith consist of the knottings of belief (*al-uqūd al-iṭiqādiyya*) and reductive definitions based on customary usage (*al-ḥudūd al-maḥṣūra al-iṭiyādiyya*). In this is exemplified the connection (*munāsaba*) that obtains between root and branch or between child and parents. The acquisition of the exoteric and rationalistic sciences is wholly confined to this mode, whose secret is suggested by [the similarity of] the two terms intellect (*aql*) and knotting (*aqd*). This approach itself derives from that of the angelic host (*al-mala' al-a'lā*) who pursue it through praise and sanctification, as well as certain of those human beings who follow the same path.
- 2) Existential forms that disclose [realities] (*al-ṣuwar al-wujūdiyya al-kāshifa*), on which are trained our intuitive perceptive faculties (*al-mashā'ir al-insāniyya*) with their vast compass, involving especially absolute, all-comprehensive unity (*al-aḥadiyya al-jam'iyya al-iṭlāqiyya*) and its revealed heavenly forms and primordial knottings based on receptivity (*al-uqūd al-aṣliyya al-istiḍādiyya*). The organ that controls this category of knowledge is the human heart (*al-qalb al-insānī*), the form of the existential Adamic reality by virtue of which man assumed vicegerency over all of creation and surpassed even the angels; its product is an existential expansiveness (*inshirāḥ, inbisāt*) of knowledge through unveiling (*kashf*), this too exemplifying the correspondence mentioned above. This approach is peculiar to the human race, and more specifically to prophets and saints. Now these disclosing existential forms differ in the ways in which they find expression; here pride of place goes to the revealed forms with which the Arab Seal Muḥammad was sent (God's blessings and peace be upon him and all his family). Likewise, the primordial knottings based on receptivity are only fully intelligible through the forms [brought by the Seal]. Absent them, we in our humanity would not have been able to penetrate to the core of the matter; at most we would possess the [above] aspect of intellectual knotting as applied to [this latter category of knowledge], which would not be sufficient to convey us to pastures of verification and the springs of certitude—as He says, *You knew not what the Book was, nor belief* (Q 42:52).

I.3: A Subsidiary Inquiry, Fed from Its Spring and Bearing Fruit

It is thus established that all knowledge that accrues to the servant belongs to one of these two categories. He attains to the first solely by virtue of his Adamic (*Ādamī*) nature, i.e., his general relation to [Adam], by which he is able to realize part of his perfection and become possessed of a rational knotting (*aqd aqlī*); he attains to the second by virtue of his direct

descent from Adam (*ibn Ādam*), i.e., his sound relation to him, by which he is able to realize the fullness of his perfection, inherited from God, and become possessed of an expanded breast (*dhū sharḥ ṣadrī*). Given this, it should be easy to understand that with respect to that which accrues to the servant in terms of revealed forms, that which he seeks out deep within the layers of its definitive expression (*bayān khatmī*), precisely the same applies. We [seekers] may therefore also be categorized according to our relative shares of these revealed forms. Some restrict their meanings to conventional knottings (*mawḍūʿāt ʿaqdiyya*) and conceptualized beliefs (*mafhūmāt iʿtiqādiyya*) delimited on all sides by what is deemed unacceptable according to the usage of lexicologists (*ahl al-lughāt*), disallowed according to the rules of grammarians, or simply not used either in modes of common interpersonal address according to the exigencies of circumstance or in intellectual debate dedicated to finding precise expressions to communicate fine points of doctrine. Others do not restrict the meanings of these forms, but rather formulate (*taṣawwur*) their meanings with reference to their sources (*maṣādir*), descriptive of that which occurs to expansive hearts (*al-ṣudūr al-munshariḥa*) through this process and encompassing the origin and end of all things from preeternity to posteternity. Meanings so formulated are divested of the restrictive trappings of normative [usage], the knottings that veil the true meanings of those forms; these knottings include lexical restrictions, technical conventions, and customary usage, whether natural or conventional, and the meanings derived by human perceptive faculties from such forms are necessarily delimited on all sides by these veils, these trappings, these artificial, conventional and contrived knottings—paths that [in themselves] lead away from the desired goal (*al-murād*), paths of the rebel Satan (Q 4:117, 22:3), who blocks the path of return (*maʿād*).

For those who require an indubitable testimony from the Prophetic Sunna (*al-ishārāt al-khatmiyya*), consider well the following hadith: [*The Messenger of God*] drew a line [*in the sand*] and said, “*This is the path of God.*” He then drew a number of lines on either side of this line and said, “*These various paths—at the head of each stands a devil calling people to it,*” then reciting: *This is My path, straight—follow it* (Q 6:153).⁵² This point is emphasized in an injunction from Sayyid [Kamāl al-Dīn al-Akhlāṭī] included in his most edifying correspondence [with me]:

You must deliberate upon each letter and each word, putting out of your mind all conventions (*mutaʿārafāt*) currently observed in the sciences and cleaving rather to their occult aspect (*sirriyya*), where abides that which satisfies the soul and delights the eyes. The Messenger prepared the way for all, hale and sickly alike, by reciting, after he had drawn a line, *This is My path, straight—follow it, and follow not the diverse paths lest they scatter you from His path.*

Those who wish to understand the true meaning (*murād*) behind the various significations of the letters must empty their minds (*maḥall idrāki-hi*) of all conventional usages, whether the common usage used in interactions with one’s fellow human beings generally or the elite usage acquired through painstaking study and debate with scholars more proficient than oneself, including all technical terminology and accepted creedal terms. This injunction holds true for [all] three [registers of] conventional usage, in the absence of whose delimitation the meanings of the above forms cannot be comprehended, although some usages are more accurate than others.

Know, then, that this is the sublimest (*anhā*) point that may be communicated to seekers after guidance—[a point] this book is devoted to elucidating. Within [this point] are contained manifold points of wisdom; among them is a manifest numerological aspect

⁵² Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal, *Musnad*, *Musnad ʿAbd Allāh b. Masʿūd* (1), nos. 4225, 4523.

which explicates most expressively that hadith contained in the *Ṣaḥīḥ* of Bukhārī: *The Qur'ān was revealed in seven letters (aḥruf)*.⁵³ This statement—if one ponders well its evident meaning—is one of the many made by the Seal through which the moons of realities in the heaven of meanings are split (Q 54:1)—therefore take heed.⁵⁴

I.4: A Sapiential Inquiry in Numerological Terms

Now (assuming you have no wish to desist at this point in your knowledge of sapiential (*ḥikmī*) principles) whenever the forms through which the One manifests in its descents, both those of manifesting and making-manifest (*zuhūrī, iẓhārī*), hide within them the property of opposition (*ḥukm al-taqābul*), from the rays of whose effects the veils of engendered being (*al-ḥujub al-kawniyya*) are reflected in the realms of contingency (*al-'awālim al-imkāniyya*), this property is capable of making [One] manifest (*iẓhār*) and uniquely able to serve as the foundation of both its perception and its making-perceptible (*shu'ūr, ish'ār*) in the process of generating the meaning of its desired goal and its mysteries. As those who are familiar with the variegated forms of One in their entirety know, nothing is more efficacious in this process than Three. Reproduction of any kind cannot take place except through it; therefore you behold the revealed forms manifesting in their descent from their [point of origin], their heavenly exaltation and nondelimitation (*iṭlāq*) solely through Three. When its perceptible (*shu'ūrī*) aspect is factored together with its making-perceptible (*ish'ārī*) aspect it becomes Six, as is evident from that pointed out above.

With respect to Three as such, these forms include, first, an oral (*kalāmī*) form transmitted through the air as sound waves in the form of articulations moving from inside the body outwards, perceived only by the sense of hearing; second, a written form [visible] in light with the various transmutations of the shapes that are traced, black on white, perceived only by the sense of sight; and third, a mental-spiritual (*'aqlī ma'nawī*) form manifesting in the realities of things themselves with the variegation of their modes of manifestation betwixt being and nonbeing, perceived only by the heart (*qalb*) (called in Qur'ānic usage *fu'ād*). You thus find that there is frequent reference to these three senses in the Qur'ān, where they are extolled as being among those great blessings with which He showered his servants; as such, He deemed that no praise can be considered adequate in return, for indeed, they are far sublimer than the capacity of our actions to render the necessary praise. Such verses include: *And He appointed for you hearing, and sight, and hearts; little thanks you show* (Q 32:9, 67:23); *It is He Who produced for you hearing, and sight, and hearts; little thanks you show* (Q 23:78). These perceiving senses, then, constitute the perfection predicated upon the breathing of the auxiliary spirit (*naḥkh al-rūḥ al-idāfi*) into those who are prepared to receive it (*musta'idd*), and it is this perfection that brings it from out the covert of the invisible and nonmanifest into the open of the visible and manifest. This is evident from the first verse for those who consider it well, for He said: *And He breathed His spirit into him, and He appointed for you hearing, and sight, and hearts; little thanks you show* (Q 32:9). He furthermore identified these senses as being among those blessings that impose responsibility on the recipient: *The hearing, the sight, the heart—all of those shall be questioned of* (Q 17:36).

It is for this reason that I have organized this book into three sections (*ṣaḥā'if*),

⁵³ See e.g. Bukhārī, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *al-Khuṣūmāt* (44), bab 4, no. 2458; idem, K. *Faḍā'il al-Qur'ān* (66), bab 5, nos. 5043, 5095; Muslim, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *Ṣalāt al-Musāfirīn wa-Qaṣri-hā* (7), bab 48, no. 1936.

⁵⁴ See the author's *R. Shaqq-i Qamar* for more on this theme (§2.1.2, no. 27; §6.1).

together with the present introduction, as well as a conclusion as a fourth section in which are treated various aspects of these three according to the special properties of each, as, God willing, shall follow below.

I.5: A Further Sapiential Inquiry in Rationalist Terms

Know that the proper subject (*mawḍūʿ*) of the highest science, (*al-ʿilm al-aʿlā*), [or metaphysics], known to the latter-day philosophers as “absolute wisdom” (*al-ḥikma al-muṭlaqa*) or “the first philosophy” (*al-falsafa al-ūlā*),⁵⁵ is the absolute existent (*al-mawjūd al-muṭlaq*) insofar as it is existent; this is because there is no other concept (*maʿnā*) commonly used by them that brings together all the diverse categories (*maqūlāt*) in the way that it does. For the entities (*aʿyān*) that this “absolute wisdom” has as its object of study include substances (*jawāhir*), quantities (*kamiyyāt*) and other categories. The only tried and true (*muḥaqqaq*) concept capable of comprehending all of these categories is the reality represented by the concept of existence (*wujūd*), which alone may be posited as the basis for the articulation of such inquiries—a shared (*mushtarak*) subject, [as it were], with all such categories figuring simply as its modes (*ḥālāt*) and accidents (*ʿawāriḍ*).

Now it is clear that existence, despite its possession of a measure of comprehensiveness (*ʿumūm, iḥāṭa*), nevertheless does not subsume within itself its opposite (*muqābil*) [concept] in a truly comprehensive manner, such that both sides of the equation are balanced. Rather, [the concept of existence] properly applies only to things that are existent (*mawjūdāt*), not to things that are nonexistent or impossible (*maʿdūmāt, mumtaniʿāt*). It thus deviates from the straight and high road of comprehensiveness, and is therefore not nearly so suited to figure as the subject of “absolute wisdom” [or metaphysics]—the inquiry to which we have dedicated this book—as that which is in fact free of any such deviation: the letter (*ḥarf*) in its absolute sense. It alone encompasses all opposites among things existent, nonexistent and impossible in a manner that is comprehensive and holds sway over the cosmos (*al-kull*) with perfect ontological and epistemological integrity, for it neither favors one of a pair of opposites (*mutaqābilayn*) in any respect, nor deviates a whit from the path of balance. Says [God] Most High, *Praise belongs to God Who has sent down upon His servant the Book and has not assigned unto it any crookedness* (Q 18:1).

Ask not thusly: How is such comprehensiveness conceivable with respect to the letter, since it is governed by the category of state (*al-kayf*) according to one of its two types? For what I mean here by letter is rather the revealed form [descended] from the heaven of the unseen dimension of that ipseity (*ghayb al-huwiyya*) that unlocks the gates of existence in their entirety, from the first stage of its manifestation (*ṣuhūr*) to the total sway of its making-manifest (*iḥḥār*), this by means of its perfect word (*kalimati-hi l-tāmma*), termed by exoteric scholars as being deficient (*al-nāqiṣa*). [Hardly an appropriate term]: this [letter] is the perduring originary principle that subsists in itself and constitutes all existent things without exception. But in the view of those same scholars [such a definition] is but an impossibility derived from another impossibility, both being categorized under a single part of those general categories that pertain to that which exists. The percipient reader, however, need not pay heed to this type of formalized, arbitrary, wholly subjective terminology—*touching which God has never sent down authority* (Q 7:71, 12:40, 53:23)—except to refute it and distance oneself from it.

⁵⁵ Cf. Ibn Sīnā’s characterization of metaphysics in precisely these terms in his *al-Shifāʾ* (*The Metaphysics of The Healing*, 3).

Resist the calls of wrangling talk,
and save yourself
from false claims and their assaults,
which truly aim only to be heard⁵⁶

If we therefore dispense with such formalized and arbitrary usages and inquire into what may best serve as the proper object of metaphysics (*al-‘ilm al-a‘lā, al-ḥikma al-muṭlaqa*), we find that there is nothing better suited to this office than the letter and its own originary principle the point (*nuqta*). It is necessary that you realize that here these are not simply convenient conceptual fictions (*al-aṭrāf al-mutawahhima*), as is usually assumed by exoteric scholars, but rather the source [of all] that unlocks [every level of reality] and originary principle of the cosmos (*al-kull*), as such transcending all attempts at expression or allusion. As Imam [‘Alī] answered Kumayl when the latter questioned him as to the [ultimate] Reality (*al-ḥaqīqa*): [*It is*] the unveiling of the glories of Majesty [directly], without allusion. This dictum refers to the True One, the fundamental referent of this discussion, the properties of whose variegations (*tanawwu‘āt*)—called the Doubled Seven (*al-sab‘ al-mathānī*) and the glorious Quran (Q 15:87)—cannot manifest and thereby be subject to expression and scholarly discussion and interpretation as long as this One does not descend into the [abovementioned] three forms with their various modulations and shapes as perceived by the [relevant] three senses possessed by man. This, then, is the letter, the object of our science.

Given the foregoing, it will be clear to you that the science that has such an object is wisdom (*al-ḥikma*) [itself], this being defined as the noblest science with the noblest object (*afḍal ‘ilm bi-afḍal ma‘lūm*). In its furnishing knowledge of the ultimate causes (*al-asbāb al-quṣwā*) of all things, it bears therefore the same definition of metaphysics (*al-‘ilm al-ilāhī*) as understood by the exoteric philosophers: a science concerned with metaphysical matters both nominally and existentially. Ontologically, the letter and the point and their derivative properties and concomitants precede and transcend matter, as discussed above. This science is concerned with things that do not transcend matter only in the event that they are not ontologically dependent on matter. This point is corroborated by [Jābir b. Ḥayyān], the disciple of Imam al-Ṣādiq, in his *K. al-Khamsīn*:

The line and the point can be taken either as substance (*jawhar*) or as accident (*‘araḍ*). If they are taken as existing in a physical sense (*mawjūda li-l-aṭrāf*) or understood from their definition as being relative (*iḍāfa*), they are accident; if they are taken as not having dimensionality in themselves, they are substance. And if they are accounted substance, dimensionless and without limit, they are soul or intellect ... or other such things.

He likewise states:

The first Speech does not resemble [our daily] speech; for speech at the level of the soul is more perfect—more explicit and clearer, brighter and more radiant—, gathering together as it does all the virtues of specification (*tamyīz*) and comprising the full range of the instruments (*adawāt*) proper to the sciences. It pertains to the

⁵⁶ Ibn al-Fāriḍ, *al-Tā’iyya*, l. 189; trans. in Homerin, ‘*Umar Ibn al-Fāriḍ*, 129.

All; [our speech] here pertains to the part. It is wholly unadulterated; [our speech] is adulterated with engendered existence.⁵⁷

I.6: A Further Inquiry as to the Written Form

The One has two aspects with respect to its manifestation as reflected in its veils and relations. In the first place, it is the originary principle of the All, i.e., reality as it is in itself; in this sense it is not subject to expression or allusion, as we have seen, abiding as it does in utter hiddenness (*buṭūn, khafā*). In the second place, it is the terminus of the All, i.e., the individual entification (*al-ta'ayyun al-shakhṣī*) through which it manifests in external [existence], representing the limit of manifestness (*ẓuhūr, jalā*). Likewise, the point, which corresponds to [the One], has two aspects with respect to making-manifest. In the first place, it is the originary principle of the letter and the line in its totality; in this sense it is not subject to expression or allusion, as suggested above. In the second place, it is the terminus of the All, i.e., the principle of individual specification (*al-tamayyuz al-shakhṣī*) giving knowledge of every letter and its entified particularity (*khuṣūṣiyyati-hi l-'ayniyya*) and manifesting therein in external [existence], as witnessed in written letterforms. It is to these two aspects that the [Imam's] dictum refers: *Knowledge is a point multiplied through the ignorance of the ignorant*.⁵⁸

7.3.2: The Ṭahawī Circle⁵⁹

1.15: An Instructive Numerological Inquiry

You have therefore recognized that the descent (*tanazzul*) from the height of the circumference and the holiness of essential oneness (*quds al-waḥda al-dhātiyya*) is termed revelatory or sending-down motion (*al-ḥaraka al-inzāliyya*);⁶⁰ through it manifests the making-perceptible letterforms (*al-ṣuwar al-ish'āriyya al-ḥarfiyya*)⁶¹ upon the surfaces of speech and the realms of writing. For as long as the moving [One] (*al-mutaḥarrik*)⁶² does not

⁵⁷ These two passages from the *K. al-Khamsīn* are not among those published by Paul Kraus (*Jābir ibn Ḥayyān*, 1/489-500).

⁵⁸ See e.g. Ibn Abī Jumhūr, *'Awālī al-La'ālī*, 4/129, no. 223. Note that I leave untranslated here the seventh and final section of the introduction as I am unsure of Ṣā' in al-Dīn's meaning here, which in general is a meditation on love (*ḥubb*) as a fundamental principle of existence.

⁵⁹ MS Majlis 10196 ff. 62b-64b.

⁶⁰ Cf. the Persian line, *vujūd bā 'asākīr-ash tanazzul mīkunad*.

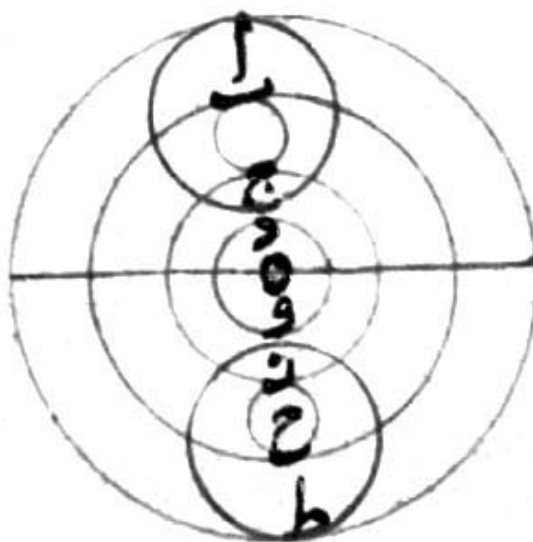
⁶¹ I.e., the *naḥās al-Raḥmān*, composed of the 28 letters.

⁶² Qūnawī discusses this in his *Miftāḥ al-Ghayb*; the *mutaḥarrik* is that which descends and becomes a human being, i.e. the divine mystery (see Chittick, "The Circle of Spiritual Ascent According to Qūnawī"). Cf. the circles and diagrams in Ḥusayn Āmulī, *al-Muqaddimāt min Naṣṣ al-Nuṣūṣ*, 546ff. (plates 1-30; MS Majlis 1714/2 ff. 143-277).

descend from the circumference of nondelimitation (*iṭlāq*) (the proper domain of essential oneness which can have no internal distinction (*tamāyuz*)) to the center of delimitation (*taqayyud*) and terminus most distant from the circumference (the proper domain of the reflective play of the rays of making-manifest (*al-ashi‘a al-iḥārīyya*)), it will not be capable of manifestation (*ẓuhūr*) nor is it conceivable that it may make-manifest (*iḥār*), [an operation] upon which all perception (*shu‘ūr*) is predicated. And you have likewise recognized that the fifth level from among the levels of the [nine] digits (*al-‘uqūd al-‘adadiyya*)⁶³ is the one that has this [latter] status, in that it occupies, as is obvious, the furthest point from the circumference of unbounded oneness.

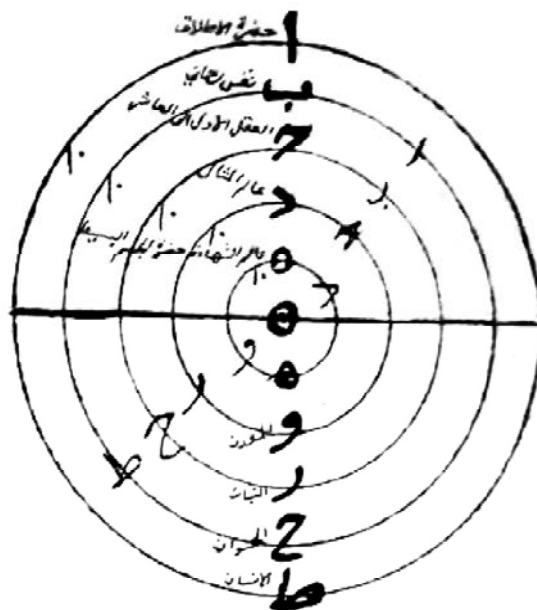
Know then that that motion [whose course runs] from the beginning of its ascent from the presences of the Names to the terminus of their stationing and manifestation in the engendered realms (*al-‘awālim al-kiyāniyya*) has four levels, these being constituted by the stages of its descent and the vestments of its concealment (*katm, khafā*). It then arrives at the fifth [level] in which it finds itself reflected, and therein the stages of its descent become the stages of its ascent and the vestments of its concealment become the agents of its unveiling (*kashf, inshirāḥ*). This may be seen in the following circle, which contains all levels, including those of the becoming entities (*al-a‘yān al-ṣā‘ira*), the pervading realities (*al-ḥaqā’iq al-sā‘ira*) and the soaring angels:

*The Ṭahawī Circle*⁶⁴



⁶³ The levels which can be numbered, e.g., First Intellect, soul, etc. The term *‘uqūd* literally means knottings, i.e., things become specified. The tenth level represents the return to the totality of the circle after all its levels have been traversed.

⁶⁴ The first diagram is from MS Majlis 10196 f. 62b; the alternative diagram below is from MS Selimiye 231 f. 32b. Cf. diagram in Murata, Chittick and Weiming, *The Sage Learning of Liu Zhi*, 169.



Now it may be asked: What principle governs this circle and on what basis does the proof of its composition and ordering rest? For none of the Verifiers have taken this view nor has it been suggested by any of the leading figures on the racecourse of perfection, those who open the locks on the gates of verification with the keys of their intuitions and unveilings; indeed, it is at variance [with all that has gone before].

I answer: As for rational proofs and intuitive evidence, some of these are dealt with in what precedes as well as what follows in a form recognizable to the intelligent and attentive, and as for revealed heavenly verses and the original quranic forms from which such unveilings derive and by which their principles (*uṣūl*) are determined and the subjects of their discourse established, from the most general to the most specific, they are as I have described them. Now that which best indicates the nature of this circle, its center and circumference, its foundations and branches, is His saying, *ṬH* (Q 20:1); for this reason it has been termed the Ṭahawī Circle.⁶⁵ It is obvious to anyone with a modicum of intelligence that the combination of these two letters and their composite form must needs entail a wondrous matter from among the majestic secrets of wisdom that abrogate all else and the principles of gnostic knowledge that efface all besides, as you will see below. As for my predecessors and their cryptic allusions, it is obvious to the intelligent believer that these stand in relation to the Speech with which the Seal was charged and the realities it contains as is expressed by the line,

Who rides the sea thinks little of creeks.⁶⁶

This is because there are in each age certain ways of dealing with the sciences of wisdom

⁶⁵ Ibn Turka's choice of the sura-initial *Ṭā-Hā* here, and below of *Yā-Sīn*, is informed by the metonymic use of these two letter pairs for the Qur'ān or the Islamic creed as a whole (as in "the tribe of *Ṭā-Hā* and *Yā-Sīn*"), thus suggesting that these two circles represent the definitive presentation of Islamic cosmology.

⁶⁶ The hemistich is from a qasida by al-Mutanabbī in reference to Kāfūr al-Ikhshīdī (d. 357/968).

peculiar to its circumstances that the minds of previous thinkers could not grasp nor were they able to investigate or express. This statement is supported by what is related about the Seal Muḥammad, that he often quoted the following line:

The [coming] days will show you what you knew not,
one you did not provision will bring you news.⁶⁷

This reference will suffice a free man (*ḥurr*).⁶⁸

As for a more detailed discussion of these principles and instances of wisdom (*ḥikam*, *uṣūl*) just indicated, these two letters indicate, in the first place, the two arcs of perfection by which the entire circle is formed and through whose existence the Adamic reality is actualized. It is through the witnessing of the two [arcs'] nearness (*shuhūd qurbi-himā*) that the preeminent prophets and saints are distinguished from the rest of humanity, and it is through the Seal's witnessing of the [two arcs'] state of being nearest (*aqrabiyya*)⁶⁹ that he was elevated above all others and singled out with the qualities of sealhood. This state of being nearest is expressed in the revealed Speech by *Or nearer* (Q 53:9), just as the [first] nearness is expressed therein by *Two bows' lengths* (Q 53:9).⁷⁰ Secondly, the two letters indicate a certain peculiarity they have as derived from their universal levels (*kulliyyāt al-marātib*), and also clarify the peculiarities of [each level] whether related to manifestation or to perception (*zuhūriyya*, *shu'ūriyya*) and demonstrate the origin (*mabda'*) of the whole and its final return (*ma'ād*), i.e., its end or seal. This is so due to the fact that as long as the two abovementioned arcs, which disclose the totalities of the levels of the whole in terms of manifestation and perception, do not reach to the [innermost] circle of *H* they remain mutually distinguished, and thus you see them as expressive of the making-perceptible (*mush'ir*) ten; the *H* circle itself incorporates the ten with its perfection of manifestation. From thence it is clear that all engendered existents, apart from the Two Weights (*al-thaqalayn*),⁷¹ possess actual perception (*al-shu'ūr bi-l-fi'l*) without any effort to acquire it and without undertaking a single act from among the actions that take place through them (*min ḥawādith al-a'māl*)—in this, again, unlike these two [Weights]. This is what is demonstrated by the general form of this circle in its totality.

As for a detailed discussion of the peculiarities of what is in these circles and an investigation into what their two arcs contain, firstly in terms of their separate state and secondly in terms of their joined and encompassing state, they indicate the characteristics and properties of what is in the existential levels from the beginning of the manifestation of ipseity (*huwiyya*) and the simple essence (*dhāt sādhiya*)⁷² to the [lowest] level of sensory

⁶⁷ The line is from the *mu'allaqa* of Ṭarafa b. al-'Abd. The statement that Muḥammad often quoted a verse of poetry runs up against a theological sticking point, i.e., that Muḥammad never quoted poetry (cf. Q 36:69).

⁶⁸ A line of poetry used as a proverb; the phrase as a whole: "The slave is beaten with a stick but a free man needs no elaboration (*ishāra*)"—i.e., a few words to the wise suffice.

⁶⁹ I.e., the point at which they meet to form a complete circle.

⁷⁰ Qūnawī and Farghānī often dwell at length on the *two bows' lengths*.

⁷¹ Here denoting humanity and the jinn (*al-jinn wa-l-ins*).

⁷² I.e., the unnamable divine essence, *huwa*.

perception and the visible world.⁷³ In this scenario, [the various letters have the following denotations]:

[Existence and its self-actualized levels (silsilat al-mawjūdāt)]

- A denotes the state of exclusive unity (*al-ḥaḍra al-aḥadiyya*)⁷⁴ that is the first of the entifications (*ta'ayyunāt*) that comprise the properties of both nonentification and entification.⁷⁵
- B denotes the state of inclusive unity (*wāḥidiyya*) through which begins the chain of existents (*silsilat al-mawjūdāt*); this is termed the breath of the All-merciful (*nafas al-Raḥmān*) that wafts over all as its Creator.⁷⁶
- J denotes the first of the entifications characterized by distinct-vision (*istijlā'ī*), termed the World of Command, i.e., the First Intellect (*al-'aql al-awwal*) that comprises

⁷³ MS Majlis 10196 f. 63b, marginal note, presumably by the author: “Know that the two primary arcs comprising the circumference of this circle, which, given the manifestation of the properties of the source within it, is not obscured by what descends upon it as entailed by stations and loci of manifestation, nor is it contaminated through its producing for the two arcs certain characteristics causing perception (*ish'ārī*); for this reason the letter *Ṭ* was mentioned first [even though it occupies the nadir of the circle]. For this reason too you observe the A as retaining the perfection of its uprightness in both of the circle's arcs, although the descending arc has clothed it in an all-encompassing and comprehensive form that contains all; this, however, does not change the upright position of the A. As for the exposition of the characteristics that belong to these two arcs alone, they possess various levels upon their emergence from the coverts of hiddenness, each of these levels revealing a type of reality. The first is that which the two arcs constitute without reference to anything beyond them; for it is through these arcs that the circle takes form and the completeness is revealed, one which goes under the technical term simple essence (*dhāt sādhiya*), as will be discussed below. The second is considering the arcs' existence divested of reference to extraneous description of them; it is under this aspect that the Adamic reality in which everything participates is disclosed, that is, the *barzakh* that obtains between the necessary (*wujūb*) and the possible (*imkān*) and comprehends their distinct properties. The third is considering the distinguishing relation to existence, that is, the nearness of the two arcs, for it is on the basis of this mutual nearness that levels become distinguished within the human species (*naw'*), some surpassing others according to the perfection which has been determined for this reality as it is in itself; the specific features that define the levels of this mutual nearness are indicated in His saying, *Then he drew near and suspended hung, two bows'-length away* (Q 53:8-9). The fourth is considering the doubling (*taḍ'īf*) of that distinguishing relation referred to as mutual nearness, that is, the state of being nearest (*aqrabīyya*) that belongs to the Seal and the inheritors of his perfection along, and on its basis their sciences are ordered as are all of their peculiar characteristics; this is indicated in His saying, *Or nearer* (Q 53:9). Now these four levels proper to these two arcs that provide for perception and disclosure ... although it comprises all the other circles ... these two arcs between the former and the latter, that is, the circumference and the center, are characterized by their effect of making-manifest and making-perceptible (*izhār, ish'ār*), as will be discussed below; this is indicated by the [author's] statement ‘These two letters indicate in the first place’ etc.”

⁷⁴ *Aḥadiyya*, as opposed to the following *wāḥidiyya*: both refer to unity or oneness, but here the first may be taken as higher and therefore exclusive and the second as secondary and therefore inclusive. Ibn 'Arabī does not distinguish between the two terms; cf. Jāmī's distinction in his *Ashī'at al-Lama'āt*. A distinction is already made between *aḥad* and *wāḥid*, however, by 'Alī in the *Nahj al-Balāgha* (see Ṭabāṭabā'ī, *A Shi'ite Anthology*).

⁷⁵ The distinction between entification and nonentification is made by Qūnavī, not Ibn 'Arabī.

⁷⁶ I.e., the presence of divine knowledge.

everything and binds (*āqid*) it to the forms of its unfolding (*burūz*), or the Highest Pen that records it in the storehouses of its treasures; this may also be realized by considering the reflection of the form of the First Expansion (*al-baṣṭ al-awwal*) in it together with the descents (*tanazzulāt*) it undergoes as represented by the form of the arc that links it to the final state of expandedness (*al-inbisāṭ al-akhīr*), called the Active Intellect (*al-ʿaql al-faʿāl*) by the Peripatetics.

- *D* denotes (*dāll*) the imaginal world, the reflection (*ʿaks*) of the joining arc associated with the World of Command together with its inclination toward density (*kathāfa*), which entails its declination (*inhirāf*) from the synthesizing phase (*al-dawr al-jamʿī*) and retreat to the seclusion of density and its imaginal corporeality.
- *H* indicates the visible world and the level of the corporeal body (*jism*), while its form represents the thronelike form of comprehensive perfection indicated by His saying, *The All-merciful sat Himself upon the Throne* (Q 20:5).
- *W* as associated with the arcs ascending from the last denotes the First Offspring (*al-walad al-awwal*) resulting from the marriage of the two Progenitors (*al-wālidayn*), the higher and the lower, i.e., the mineral (*maʿdan*).⁷⁷
- *Z* denotes that which grows (*zāʿid*) in all the regions [of the world] (*fi l-aqtār*) through its own impulse (*bi-l-dhāt*), i.e., the vegetable (*nabāt*).
- *Ḥ* denotes the living [creature] (*ḥayy*) whose [role] is fundamental to the whole edifice, that is, the animal (*ḥayawān*).
- *Ṭ* denotes the [central] point (*nuqṭa*) of that totality, that is, the human (*insān*), through whose rational nature (*nuṭq*) the various gates of the knottings of this arrangement (*abwāb ʿuqūd dhālika l-niẓām*) are sealed.

Now it may be objected that this [scheme] does not correspond to what was discussed before about the primordial order and arrangement of existence. In response, I say that a certain variation of meanings operative within conventional terminology (*al-dalālāt al-waḍʿiyya*) is certainly not unknown in the usage of exoteric scholars (*lisān ahl al-ẓāhir*), given what I have pointed out in terms of the realization of the coincidence of opposites (*atrāf, aḍḍād*) therein, nor does this situation discomfit them due to their trenchant navigation of the straits of the formal disciplines and their bold mastery of the high passes of the various restrictive technical terminologies. Each word and each letter has various meanings according to what meanings are denoted within certain constructions (*tarkībāt*), meanings appropriate to every totality of semantic connections linked to those words in various [syntactical] orderings. It is thus in no way unexpected that the same [semantic ambiguity] should obtain in those explicatory intuitive allusions presented by the original forms sent down from the heaven of holiness in all its unboundedness, for it alone is the font of realities and instances of wisdom in all the diversity of their boughs and the multitudinousness of their branches. Given this, then, you may see that whenever an intelligent and attentive person closely studies this circle he obtains a type of knowledge that is beyond the compass of things expressible in commonly accepted terms.

The aspects listed above according to their specified meanings manifest from that [circle] to the stage wherein they are made-perceptible (*minaṣṣat al-ishʿār*) when the consideration of the perceptive is directed toward existence and its levels that are actualized in themselves (*mutaḥaqqiqā fi anfusi-hā*). But when it is rather directed toward engendered existence (*kawn*) and its levels manifesting at sites of manifestation (*maẓāhir*),

⁷⁷ I.e., the beginning of the chain of *muwalladāt* or *mawālīd*, generated by the two Progenitors, i.e., the four elements and seven spheres (*al-ummahāt al-sufliyya wa-l-ābāʾ al-ʿulwiyya*).

they will find this circle of perfection with its all-encompassing word (*bi-jāmi‘ kalimati-hā*) to correspond to [engendered existence], for this circle with its notations also alludes to all of the manifest levels of engendered existence together with the characteristics specific to each. In this reading [the letters have the following denotations]:

[Engendered existence and its levels of manifestation]⁷⁸

- A denotes the simple absolute (*al-basīṭ al-muṭlaq*) which has no declension whatever toward the twists and enfoldings (*zawāyā*) of density, remaining in the holiness and purity of graphic singularity (*al-wahda al-khaṭṭiyya*).
- B denotes the mineral, the form of the expansiveness of the physical body (*ṣūrat baṣṭ al-jism*) and by which it is made manifest (*iḥḥār*).
- J denotes the vegetal, which has the same expansiveness given the joining and encompassing arc promoting nourishment, growth and progeniture of similars, thus arriving at another level of development (*inbisāṭ*).⁷⁹
- D denotes the animal, the reflection of that arc given its increase of perceptible manifestation derived from the angle (*zāwiya*) of opposition and balance (*taqābul, ta‘ādul*).
- H denotes the human, which [category] possesses total all-comprehensiveness (*jam‘iyya, iḥāṭa*).

These constitute the [circle’s] descending arcs; as for its ascending arcs:

- W denotes the level of *walāya/wilāya*,⁸⁰ human perfection.⁸¹
- Z denotes the increase (*ziyāda*) of that perfection, which [increase] is termed prophecy.
- Ḥ denotes rule (*ḥukm*) and vicegerency (*khilāfa*).
- Ṭ denotes the furthest extremity (*ṭaraf*) of that perfection, i.e., sealhood (*khatm*).⁸²

The above is according to the levels of manifestation and existence only; when the perception of the intelligent alights on the levels which make-manifest and make-perceptible (*al-marātib al-iḥḥāriyya al-ish‘āriyya*), however, the circle [may be seen to] also reference their characteristics and properties in an exhaustive manner (*bi-mā lā mazīd ‘alayh*). Thus with respect to the divine Speech (*kalām*) which holds the reins of making-manifest and making-perceptible (*iḥḥār, ish‘ār*):

⁷⁸ Cf. a similar diagram in Murata et al., *The Sage Learning*, 275.

⁷⁹ There are 5-7 vegetal faculties in all.

⁸⁰ *Wilāya* means nearness to God, which entails being given power and control, *walāya*. It is impossible to tell the difference between the two root meanings of the *maṣḍar*; the term as used here and elsewhere seems to mean both at once, friendship and power, hence the ‘sanctified power’ of the saints (see Izzi Dien and Walker, “Wilāya,” *Et*²).

⁸¹ *Walāya/wilāya* here is thus seen to include a multitude of levels, e.g., prophecy, messengerhood, etc., and is permanent, whereas a level such as prophecy is temporary.

⁸² It should be noted that the ascending hierarchy given here, i.e., sainthood, prophecy, vicegerency, sealhood, is somewhat unusual.

- The first of its levels must necessarily be its descent from the realm of the Names and the heaven of their essential nondelimitation to
- [its second level,] the loci of self-disclosure pertaining to the worlds of possibility and the site wherein is extended (*inbisāt*) the Pen and the Tablet, the former inscribing upon the latter;⁸³ this is denoted by the pair A and B.
- There is then a further descent from that state of extension to the all-comprehensive form⁸⁴ of Jabraʿīl, denoted here by J due to the fact that the written form of this Speech contains various types of correspondence (*munāsaba*) with its developed form (*al-ṣūra al-inbisāṭiyya*), which is the reflection of the first development from which it derives and to which it corresponds; it is also the descending arc beginning from the limiting angle (*al-zāwiya al-hādḍa*) passing beyond the limit of its original nondelimitation in such a way as to allow for its admixture (*imtizāj, ikhtilāt*) with what is below it, and ending with a third type of expansiveness (*bast*) opposite it through which [Jabraʿīl] appears to the prophets and teaches them the true nature of the realities that are in that first expansion.
- D denotes what is revealed to the prophets in terms of Speech indicative of the Real's summons to His Abode of Peace.⁸⁵
- H guides (*hādī*) [us] to the true path by the easiest gate by means of its all-comprehensive recitation (*qurʿān*) informing [us] of all things, from the very pinnacle of the highest quiddities to the depths of the lowest ipseities.
- W describes (*wāṣif*) the stallion (*ṭirf*) [roaming] all the ways of that guide (*ṭuruq tamām dhālika l-hādī*) in all of its states and resting points, i.e., the differentiating units (*al-wahādāt al-furqāniyya*)⁸⁶ which are the best means given its being firmly established (*ʿind istiḳāmati-hi*), and the camels of ecstasy and finding (*ibīl al-wajḍ wa-l-wujūd*) [hailing] from the heaven of generosity and largess; through it one gains control of the realm of sanctity and power (*wilāyat al-walāya/wilāya*) and obtains power to [search out] the realms of knowledge and understanding.
- Z records (*zābir*) in its ledgers the provision allotted wayfarers [on the path] and embellishes (*zāʿin*) the swells of its sea with the florescences of the increase of perfection proper to the Seal as living being (*al-ḥayy al-khatmī*) and his triumphant inheritors (*warathatu-hu l-fāʿizūn*).
- Ḥ, the discourse (*ḥadīth*) of the Seal and what it brings forth in the gardens of his realm in terms of clear instances of verbally expressed wisdom (*al-ḥikam al-ḥarfīyya*), the fragrance of whose verification breathes forth *repose and fragrant tranquility* (Q 56:89) and the first dawn streaks of whose gifts and expressions of acclaim gleams with what the press of created things cannot touch.
- Ṭ, the way (*ṭarīqa*) peculiar to [the Seal], comprising various exquisite realities and

⁸³ The Pen here represents *ijmāl*, undifferentiation, and the Tablet represents *tafṣīl*, differentiation; alternatively, the Pen represents *tafṣīl* while its ink represents *ijmāl*. In either case, these implements write the three books, Qurʿān, man, cosmos; all things are thus *āyāt*.

⁸⁴ I.e., encompassing both the differentiated (*mufaṣṣal*) and undifferentiated (*mujmal*).

⁸⁵ Cf. Qūnavī's discussion of this.

⁸⁶ I.e., individual instances of being a differentiating force, a *furqān*, whereby one is able to see and discern clearly. The Qurʿān is here *ijmāl*, and the Furqān is *tafṣīl*.

instances of wisdom, not ancient but wondrously new, i.e., the expansiveness of numerical multiplicity—a cataclysm (*tāmma*)⁸⁷ greater than any other.

If you find the foregoing sound, it will be clear to you that the *H* in all of these scenarios possesses perfect all-comprehensiveness and constitutes the site inundated by existential lights (*al-anwār al-wujūdiyya*) and the fountainhead to the flow of gnostic secrets of witnessing (*al-ma'ārif al-shuhūdiyya*). It is for this reason that the author of the *Maḥbūb* made its circle the centermost circle comprising [knowledge] both manifest and occult. The percipient [reader] will thus be able to extrapolate some portion of that contained in the allusions of the holy Seal and his heirs from [the following four sayings]: The saying of God Most High, *There is nothing His like* (Q 42:11); two of the Prophet (God bless him and keep him), *God created Adam in His own image*,⁸⁸ and *Time cycles according to its shape* (*hay'a*) *on the day God created the heavens and the earth*,⁸⁹ and [finally] the line:

I declare, under afflatus of the holy Spirit:
the Real exists through the number five.⁹⁰

Know furthermore that the above considerations constitute but a single gleam from the lights of the letters and but a single drop from the swollen flood of their sea, provided here to encourage seekers and rouse them from their [mental] slumber; this is by no means an exhaustive discussion of the fundamental truths here in view. For contained within each letter, each word and each verse-sign are numerous instances of wisdom that one cannot discover except by [thoroughly] establishing those rules (*qawānīn*) of which the chapters of this book treat only in part—God grant us success to this end.

7.3.3: The Yāsīnī Circle⁹¹

1.22: A Numerological Inquiry into a Textual Aspect in Mental Terms

Assuming you have understood the above explanation—i.e., that the odd numbers are governed in their [inner] realities by division (*tafriqa*) and analytical differentiation (*tafāṣīl*) and as such correspond to the level of knowledge (*'ilm*) and making-perceptible (*ish'ār*),

⁸⁷ The term is sometimes used to denote the stage of final expansion/realization, e.g. by Suhrawardī in his Persian treatises.

⁸⁸ See e.g. Bukhārī, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *al-Isti'dhān*, bab 1, no. 6299; Muslim, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *al-Janna wa-Ṣifat Na'imi-hā wa-Ahli-hā*, bab 12, no. 7342.

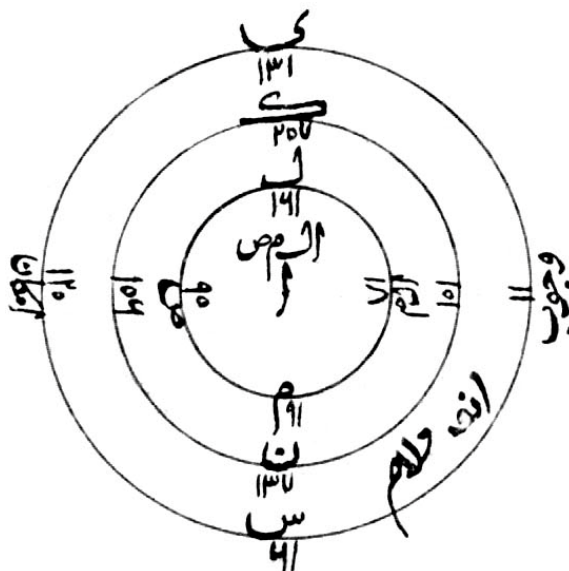
⁸⁹ See e.g. Bukhārī, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *Bad' al-Khalq*, bab 2, no. 3233; Muslim, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *Ṣalāt al-Musāfirīn wa-Qaṣri-hā*, bab 52, no. 1967.

⁹⁰ This line is also quoted by Ibn 'Arabī in the *Futūḥāt*, as well as, notably, by Mullā 'Alī Nūrī (d. 1247/1832) in his commentary (*al-Ta'līqāt*) on Mullā Ṣadrā's *Mafātīḥ al-Ghayb* (1/700). More recently, in his *Khaṣāyis-i Fāṭimiyya* Mullā Muḥammad Bāqir Kujūrī (d. 1255/1839) cites the line in reference to the ontological primacy of the *ahl al-kisā'* (trans. Sayyid 'Alī Jamāl Ashraf, Qom, 1380 Sh./2001, 1/327).

⁹¹ MS Majlis 10196 ff. 65b-67a.

constituted as it is of that form which encompasses all the parts of that which is known in a way similar to that of an odd/singular form that precludes its parts being clothed in the raiment of union (*jam'*), hiding them rather with a variety of covers; and likewise, that the even numbers are governed by the properties of union and the beauty of undifferentiation and as such correspond to the level of manifestation (*ẓuhūr*) and making-manifest (*iẓhār*), constituted as it is of that division (*qisma*) that divides among its parts in a way similar to the division of the sections of the pair that characterize it and manifest it with a variety of effects (*āthār*)—: Assuming, then, that you are cognizant of this, you will understand that the letters of light (*al-ḥurūf al-nūriyya*) that stand at the head of each section of the Holy Book and commence the suras of that glorious Tiding, though that Sublime See be barred in the faces of those who inquire and its gates secured with the locks of their diacritical pointings (*i'jām*) against the entry of all, both traditionalists (*muqallidūn*) and independent thinkers (*muḥaqqiqūn*) of every stripe, have in the very first of their admixed aspects, i.e. their doubled aspects, which stand over against the first principles (*al-awwaliyyāt*) for which man is naturally disposed and of which a proof is constructed, clearly expressed both of these levels in the most eloquent and incisive fashion; they do so, however, by means of this numerological code that serves as the basis of this language. Consider how the Ṭahawī Circle fully expresses the first of these two levels with reference to two odd numbers both confined to the upper of the two sides, then compare it with the Yāsīnī Circle, which fully expresses the entirety of the second level:⁹²

⁹² A marginal comment (MS Majlis 10196 f. 65b) clarifies: “Know that one of the most sublime properties of this circle is the knowledge of the reality of the cosmos, and that that which manifests in it in terms of existential forms are precisely the unjoined letters that stand at the head of the quranic suras, in particular *alif-lām-mīm*, through which manifests the *lamiyya* [or *lammiyya*, connectedness?] of the nature of the cosmos as well as its cosmicality as such, part of which may be understood as part of [an examination of] its properties. Know also that the word of each circle has four copies (*nusakh*) which demonstrate its four sides (*aṭrāf*), the greater and that which approximates it and the lesser and that which follows it. The greater side of each denotes the side of the manifestation of that word and its engendered generality (*‘umūmu-hā al-kawnī*), and the lesser side [of each denotes] the side of its existential nonmanifestness (*buṭūnu-hā al-wujūdī*) and its particularity. The two remaining sides are the intermediate zones (*barzakhān*) that pertain to both, such as *al-salām* and *al-sā‘a* (?) in the first ring together with the necessity (*wujūb*) and possibility (*imkān*) that pertain to them both, and in the second ring intellects (*‘uqūl*) and hearts (*qulūb*) together with their concomitants heaven (*samā‘*) and height (*‘uluww*), and in the third ring *L* and *M* upon which *Ṣ* and *‘* are dependent. Such indications suggest the precious wisdom [contained in this circle] for those who contemplate it, an example being that expressed by the second ring to the effect that the relative height of heaven derives in descending fashion from the true height (*al-‘uluww al-ḥaqīqī*) of the earth; time does not permit mention of further examples.”



This is so because the circumference of this circle is the balanced equivalency (*al-sawīyya al-idliyya*), the true scale (*al-mīzān al-qawīm*) upon which are weighed entities (*a'yān*) and engendered beings (*akwān*), and the superior are separated from the inferior, the first preponderant and heavier and the second insubstantial and lighter upon the circumference of time, the balance beam (*lisān*) of that scale. If you consider it closely you will find that this circumference is that which, when it descends from the full comprehensiveness of its two arcs (as indicated by the quranic *Two bows'-lengths* (Q 53:9)) by one level, expresses the perfect word, [*Kun!*], the combination of whose two letters and the resulting synthesis between their respective sides being the necessary condition for the delivery (*khurūj*) of the fetuses from out the wombs of contingency (*imkān*), having been hidden in the coverts of power (*kann baṭā'in al-quwwa*). With the joining of the *K* and *N* the host of engendered beings manifests and the disarray of division, which precludes the realization of any type (*lawn*) in visible existence, is put in order. In short, this circle has three levels in accordance with the conditions of creation (*tijād*) and engendering (*takwīn*) in terms of perpetual knotting (*al-'aqd al-sā'ir*) and pervasive coupling (*al-nikāḥ al-sārī*) [among the atoms of the cosmos]. The first is the outermost circumference, whose form is *Y*; it possesses all-comprehensive unity (*al-waḥda al-jam'iyya*), and its substratum (*mādda*) is *S*, which possess the fullness of multiplicity, i.e. balanced equivalency. The whole is what the Sufis refer to as the *Two bows'-lengths*. The second is the center, whose form is *L*, the terminus of descent for the form; its substratum is *M*, the fullness of the ascent of the spiritual-material form (*al-hay'a al-ma'nawīyya al-māddīyya*). As the author of the *Maḥbūb*, [Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamūwayī], says in Persian in his comprehensive manner that serves to clarify the obscure:

⁹³ This example of the diagram reproduces that in MS Majlis 10196 f. 65b.

When form reaches its limit it becomes a *lām*
as when the insinuations of the soul become inspiration (*ilhām*).

On this basis, then, you may see that the matter and form that in it join naturally and combine in a basic and firm way serve as a proper site of manifestation and flowing garment for the A, as will be treated below. As for the intermediate zone (*barzakh*) encompassing all types of matter, from the preeternal beginnings of the origin (*mabda'*) when it took form as the stages of its ascent to the posteternal stretches of the return (*ma'ād*), it is the middle ring comprising the subtleties of the circumference and the grossness of the center through the combination of its *K*, meet for the purpose of circular encompassing (*al-ihāṭa wa-l-dawr*) given its possession of two units (*waḥda*) comprising both sides, with the *N* of the garden of density (*thikhan*) and deep groves of the center given its total and complete association with multiplicity. For according to the author of the *Maḥbūb*, "The *K* in this word [*Kun!*] derives from the *K* in angel (*malak*) and its *N* from the *N* in devil (*shayṭān*)."

Know furthermore that there are certain points of contrast between this circle and the Ṭahawī Circle, points which express various instance of wisdom. These are as follows:

- 1) The entities (*a'yān*) of the Yāsīnī Circle [are shown] having descended from the height of their oneness (*waḥda*) by one level and become clothed with the properties (*aḥkām*) of the level itself, unlike the entities of the Ṭahawī Circle, which all remain at the level of their essential height and original oneness.
- 2) The form of the Ṭahawī Circle, i.e., the outmost circle or circumference, is odd/singular, while the form of this [circle] is even/dual. The same applies to the ruling [numbers] (*ṣāhib*) of each, but in reverse, a fact that is simultaneously manifest and hidden in each circle; the ruling [number] of the Ṭahawī Circle is 10 and that of the Yāsīnī Circle is 7 knottings (*'aqd*).

Now it might be objected that this is simply what the tongue of this relation (*lisān al-munāsaba*) perpetually repeats, speaking as it does in our [everyday] language; in any event, it is established that the level of tens constitutes the relation between perception (*shu'ūr*) and making-perceptible (*ish'ār*), not the level of single digits. I answer, yes, that is true, but only at first glance; if you consider the matter further, you will see that this tongue is in fact speaking most eloquently indeed. When you examine the perceptible forms of knowledge (*al-ṣuwar al-shu'ūriyya al-'ilmiyya*) and understand their distinguishing characteristic by which the engendered forms of the entities (*al-ṣuwar al-'ayniyya al-kā'ina*) are mutually separated, you will find that it is through these forms of knowledge, although they have in their essences separating differentiations (*tafṣīlāt farqiyya*), that the known (*ma'lūm*) is enabled to manifest to each knower (*'ālim*) in one of its various aspects. Now the known appears to a nearby [observer] in its original, essential aspect representing its basic reality (*kunh haqīqati-hi*), and to a faraway observer in its other, accidental (*'araḍī*) aspects; nevertheless, it possesses a singular structure (*hay'a waḥdāniyya*) which unites the knower with the known. In this the forms of knowledge differ from the engendered forms of the entities, which in their essences possess only a global undifferentiation (*ijmāl jam'ī*) that veils such aspects. It is for this reason that the leading rationalist thinkers (*a'immat al-naẓar*) hold that the genus (*jins*), together with the rest of its peers (*aqrān*),⁹⁴ shares with

⁹⁴ I.e., the other four universal predicables.

the species a single existence; these five predicables⁹⁵ (*aqrān*) may only be differentiated from each other by the intellect, yet they also appear to the sensing individual (*mudrik*) as mutually distinct and separate from him, seeming to be somewhat distant and opposed. If, then, you have understood the nature of these distinguishing aspects (*jihāt imtiyāziyya*) and considered the separating aspect (*jiha fāriqa*) that belongs to the odd/singular vis-à-vis the even/dual, this is precisely the point at which you balked above, viz., attributing an excess of expressiveness (*ifṣāḥ*) to the tongue of this relation. However, my characterization of one of these circles in terms of knowledge and the other in terms of entity goes back to the quranic text, the first being identified with ṬH (Q 20:1) and the second with YS (Q 36:1). Considered from this standpoint, the specification (*ikhtiṣās*) of these circles is manifest; considered under the other aspects that they possess intrinsically (*fī dhāti-himā*) there emerges a way of speaking about them both together wholly devoid of any specification, as you have seen in reference to the Ṭahawī Circle according to its aspects which correspond to various engendered entities, divine realities and various types of existents and engendered beings in their entirety.

Given this, then, the specification of the level of tens as pertaining to making-perceptible does not contradict what we have previously discussed. The forms of the letters belong in their entirety to the category of making-perceptible, but their significations (*dalālāt*) differ according to their associations in a given context. A single letter may thus signify one meaning in one context and its opposite in a different context, yet this does not negate either meaning; this is the case with all conventional usage (*waḍʿ jaʿlī*). As for usage that reflects reality (*waḍʿ ḥaqīqī*), however, the subject of our discussion here, its vast [semantic] spaces encompass widely differing meanings—a point which the intelligent reader should keep in mind at all times, not letting himself be distracted by customary usages (*ʿādāt*) that impose various kinds of [semantic] restrictions.

Other [points of contrast between the two circles] include:

- 3) The Ṭahawī Circle is fivefold in nature as it appears to the senses and the bodily extremities, while the Yāsīnī Circle is threefold and serves as the foundation for the elemental pillars of generation and creation (*arkān al-tawlīd wa-l-ijād*).
- 4) In the first circle, the upper *many* (*al-ʿālī al-kathīr*), i.e., that which is temporally originated (*ḥadīth*), is represented by the outer encompassing sphere of the diagram, pertaining to the known, and the lower *few* (*qalīl*), i.e., that which is eternal (*qadīm*), is represented by the innermost sphere hidden below it in the same way that the essence of the known is hidden within the outer sphere. In the second circle this arrangement is reversed; the eternal, representing the essence, is above, while the temporally originated is below. The subtle wisdom contained in this difference will not be lost on the intelligent.
- 5) The interior of the first circle, represented by its center, possesses a singular (*waḥdānī*) form incorporating its likeness-forms (*ṣūra mithliyya*) and united with [the center] in the same way that knowable objects (*al-maʿlūmāt*) (which are themselves likeness-forms (*al-ṣuwar al-mithliyyāt*)) are incorporated into the interior of the knower and united with him. The interior [or center] of the second circle possesses a

⁹⁵ According to Porphyry's *Isagoge* as received in the Arabic philosophical tradition, the *quinque voces* or five basic terms are as follows: genus (*jins*), species (*nawʿ*), difference (*faṣl*), particular property (*khāṣṣa*), and accident (*ʿaraḍ*).

form composite (*murakkab*) of the two different things (*al-mukhtalifayn*),⁹⁶ and tending to multiply it in the same way that engendered existents are composed of mutually opposed elements (*al-mutakhālifāt*) and are multiplied by virtue of this. From this you may also see the engendered form of knowledge (*‘ilm*), i.e., the word *‘ilm* itself that signifies knowledge when uttered and through which the whole circle, from center to circumference, manifests. This is because *‘ilm* represents the form of the Doubled Seven (*al-sab‘ al-mathānī*) in the making-perceptible ten, i.e., it doubles the seven,⁹⁷ the ruling number of this circle and the form of [*‘ilm*’s] likenesshood (*ṣūrat mithliyyati-hi*) according to both its undifferentiated and differentiated aspects. This may be seen from what is known to be the case with *‘ilm* with respect to these two aspects, as is clear to those who understand the forms of rational arguments (*asālīb al-naẓar*) as used by their practitioners; the rays of their perceptive faculties light upon the fact that *‘ilm* has these two forms, i.e. the undifferentiated form constituted by its ‘ and the differentiated form indicated by its *LM*. Such are among the brilliant signs of the correspondence of the engendered forms of the letters with the primordial realities of existence, inasmuch as the engendered form peculiar to *‘ilm* among various other forms corresponds to this circle, which encompasses everything in the two worlds at both extremes [of undifferentiation and differentiation], in the same way that all of the other forms of knowledge correspond to what is contained in the *‘ayn*/entity.

- 6) The manifest aspect (*al-ẓāhir*) of the first circle as contained and expressed in the quranic text is its circumference and center, which together constitute the manifest and the unmanifest which both manifest in the perceptible forms of knowledge. The manifest aspect of the second circle as contained in the quranic text is its circumference in its twin extremities, i.e., its manifest aspect is limited to the circumference in the same way that the engendered forms are themselves limited to that extremity.

1.23: A Numerological Inquiry into a Portion of the Wisdom Contained in This Circle

As has been clarified for you, when the Real One (*al-wāḥid al-ḥaqīqī*), having as it does no opposite (*muqābala*), descends from its original exalted height by a level it is clothed in certain relations (*nisab*) characterized by multiplicity, thereby becoming hidden; [simultaneously], the *qābil* (?) ascends in that same level from the debased lowness of nonexistence and is clothed in certain relations characterized by singularity (*nisab waḥdāniyya*) mirroring the above type, thereby becoming manifest. Consider then this circle, which regales you with this tale in most eloquent fashion, while also clarifying the properties of each of these undelimited disclosing levels (*al-marātib al-jalā’iyya al-ittilāqīyya*), termed the divine presences (*al-ḥaḍarāt al-ilāhiyya*), down to the [relative] levels where such disclosure is witnessed ([*al-marātib*] *al-istijlā’iyya*), termed the cosmos (*al-‘ālam*). For in this circle the *Y*, the form of that comprehensive One not set in apposition to the Many, occurs over against the *S*, the form of wholly overflowing multiplicity and the defining characteristic of the *qābil*—it is to [the *S*] that all multiplicity belongs and no other [letter]. This circle thus indicates an entification (*ta‘ayyun*) wherein the two arcs of singularity and multiplicity face off, evident to the intellect as necessity and contingency respectively.

⁹⁶ I.e., the subject and object?

⁹⁷ Or: the form of the seven multiplied by the ten, making the seven manifold?

When the One then descends to [the level of] the second circle it is therein clothed with another form newly produced from its absolute forms, which forms are known as the terminus of multiplicity (*nihāyat al-kathra*), becoming hidden within this form, while the *qābil* manifests (*tajallī*) over against it in the form appropriate to its manifestation, i.e., the grand apex (*al-ghāya al-‘uẓmā*) beyond all others. From this it may be seen that the mirroring (*taqābul*) that occurs at [the level of] this presence (*ḥaḍra*) is distinguished by an excess of manifestation (*ẓuhūr*); thence breaks the dawn of the day of existence amidst the pitchy night of nonexistence, as expressed by the copies (*nusakh*) of [the One and the *qābil* respectively] at both extremes of the circle. When the One then descends to [the level of] the third circle it is decked in raiment appropriate to the all-comprehensiveness of that level, representing as it does total all-comprehensiveness; this is made clear in this circle. For that with which the *qābil* is clothed in this third entification is mixed (*imtizāj*) to the point of unification with that with which the One is clothed, as in the other circles, but this admixture possesses a total all-comprehensiveness that does not have space for anything whatsoever. It is here that this circle differs from the preceding circles, in that the admixture obtaining between the two arcs in each of the latter possesses an empty space (as is clear to anyone who examines these arcs). By means of this type of admixture between the *qābil* and the One the site and act of manifestation (*maẓhariyya*, *zāhiriyya*) are realized and warrant the name of Cosmos and Man (*‘ālamīyya*, *ādamiyya*) respectively, and it is thus that the ‘*ayn* applies to it truly. As for the the preceding two levels, they clearly represent the two entifications, for in this level the *qābil* ascends until it arrives at the point to which the One descends, whereat the two are mixed and unified, thus doing away with all intermediaries. Through this correspondence the site of manifestation (*maẓhar*) is perfected, becoming the vicegerent (*khalīfa*) of the Manifest (*al-ẓāhir*) and resembling Him exactly. As sang the poet,

The glass is clear, the wine limpid,
they resemble each other wholly;
It is as though the wine [floats] cupless,
as though the cup [dances] without wine.

This then is what is indicated by the six letters in their respective levels (*bi-zubari-hā*). Were I to delve into all the implications of the proofs they furnish and into their transcribed [forms] (*nusakh*) the wisdom of it would fill volumes. Accompanying each circle are numerical figures (*ruqūm handasiyya*) from which various occult sciences may be extrapolated—do not overlook them.

1.24: A Further Inquiry in This Vein

The third and innermost circle represents the balanced mixture wherein unification takes place (*al-mizāj al-‘idlī al-ittiḥādī*), necessitating the manifestation of the properties of the One circulating between these levels; in this capacity it is called the cosmos (*‘ālam*). Here the One manifests in the form of the *L*, and its numerological value (*iḥṣā’*), [i.e., 161], expresses its first half, while the circle expresses the second half. The *qābil*, on the other hand, manifests in the form of the *M*; their conjunction expresses that which constitutes man (*al-insān*). It is thus clear that this mixture is precisely the human mixture. Within the composite structure (*al-hay’a al-tarkībiyya*) of these two letters they take two forms. The first is that which accrues to it upon the opening of the gates of the special properties of the *L*, i.e., the manifest side of engendered existence (*kawn*) necessitating the

unqualified absolute (*al-iṭlāq al-ṣarf*), the denotation of negation—[the particle *lam*]. Likewise, when the properties (*aḥkām*) of these special properties (*khaṣā'is*) do not obtain the latter redound to the nonmanifest side [of engendered existence], and the word [these two letters constitute] signifies the *lam*-ness of those forms. One of these two forms signifies the terminus of manifestation and the farthest extent of its levels, and the other signifies the [corresponding] terminus of nonmanifestation and the farthest extent of its levels. Now if the 'ayn, [representing] the product of the numerological calculation of the side of the One, is added to this structure, it takes on the same two states; and when the gates of its 'aynī specificities (*khuṣūṣiyyāt*) are opened, one beholds it as a signpost ('*alam*) in the desert of making-manifest (*izhār*). When its specificities do not obtain, it likewise reverts to the nonmanifest (*buṭūn*).

1.25: A Numerological Inquiry as to the Spoken Form [of the Letters]

Given that the Fourth represents the first [number] from which the lights of the perfect, all-comprehensive oneness (*waḥda*) radiate, whereas multiplicity is predicated on and the gates of its eruptive wisdom sealed by the Third, know that the Third has two senses:

- 1) It refers to the Third vis-à-vis [a preceding] Two, as is seen with the joining relation (*al-nisba al-jam'iyya*) between two things, [e.g., knowledge as uniting knower and known]; this is its aspect of existential all-comprehensiveness.
- 2) It refers to the Third of Three, this pertaining to its multiplicity and pure contingency (*muḥūḍat imkāni-hi*). Every number has these two [contrastive] aspects, one existential and collective (*jam'i*) and one nonexistential and separative ('*adamī farqī*).

What may be known from this examination is the reason why those who hold that God is the third of three are committing unbelief (according to the verse, *They are unbelievers who say, 'God is the Third of Three* (Q 5:73)), as well as why He is considered the fourth of three (*Three men conspire not secretly together, but He is the fourth of them, neither five men, but He is the sixth of them, neither fewer than that, neither more, but He is with them* (Q 58:7)). Included here is the aspect of perfect all-comprehensiveness possessed by L as distinct among the letterforms; it signifies the Real One (*al-wāḥid al-ḥaqīqī*), manifesting it in all other meanings, and further signifies its special property of making-perceptible to all, as, God willing, will be discussed below.

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١٧٠	١٧١	١٧٢	١٧٣	١٧٤	١٧٥	١٧٦	١٧٧	١٧٨	١٧٩	١٨٠	١٨١	١٨٢	١٨٣	١٨٤	١٨٥	١٨٦	١٨٧	١٨٨	١٨٩	١٩٠	١٩١	١٩٢	١٩٣	١٩٤	١٩٥	١٩٦
١٩٧	١٩٨	١٩٩	٢٠٠	٢٠١	٢٠٢	٢٠٣	٢٠٤	٢٠٥	٢٠٦	٢٠٧	٢٠٨	٢٠٩	٢١٠	٢١١	٢١٢	٢١٣	٢١٤	٢١٥	٢١٦	٢١٧	٢١٨	٢١٩	٢٢٠	٢٢١	٢٢٢	٢٢٣
٢٢٤	٢٢٥	٢٢٦	٢٢٧	٢٢٨	٢٢٩	٢٣٠	٢٣١	٢٣٢	٢٣٣	٢٣٤	٢٣٥	٢٣٦	٢٣٧	٢٣٨	٢٣٩	٢٤٠	٢٤١	٢٤٢	٢٤٣	٢٤٤	٢٤٥	٢٤٦	٢٤٧	٢٤٨	٢٤٩	٢٥٠
٢٥١	٢٥٢	٢٥٣	٢٥٤	٢٥٥	٢٥٦	٢٥٧	٢٥٨	٢٥٩	٢٦٠	٢٦١	٢٦٢	٢٦٣	٢٦٤	٢٦٥	٢٦٦	٢٦٧	٢٦٨	٢٦٩	٢٧٠	٢٧١	٢٧٢	٢٧٣	٢٧٤	٢٧٥	٢٧٦	٢٧٧
٢٧٨	٢٧٩	٢٨٠	٢٨١	٢٨٢	٢٨٣	٢٨٤	٢٨٥	٢٨٦	٢٨٧	٢٨٨	٢٨٩	٢٩٠	٢٩١	٢٩٢	٢٩٣	٢٩٤	٢٩٥	٢٩٦	٢٩٧	٢٩٨	٢٩٩	٣٠٠	٣٠١	٣٠٢	٣٠٣	٣٠٤
٣٠٥	٣٠٦	٣٠٧	٣٠٨	٣٠٩	٣١٠	٣١١	٣١٢	٣١٣	٣١٤	٣١٥	٣١٦	٣١٧	٣١٨	٣١٩	٣٢٠	٣٢١	٣٢٢	٣٢٣	٣٢٤	٣٢٥	٣٢٦	٣٢٧	٣٢٨	٣٢٩	٣٣٠	٣٣١
٣٣٢	٣٣٣	٣٣٤	٣٣٥	٣٣٦	٣٣٧	٣٣٨	٣٣٩	٣٤٠	٣٤١	٣٤٢	٣٤٣	٣٤٤	٣٤٥	٣٤٦	٣٤٧	٣٤٨	٣٤٩	٣٥٠	٣٥١	٣٥٢	٣٥٣	٣٥٤	٣٥٥	٣٥٦	٣٥٧	٣٥٨
٣٥٩	٣٦٠	٣٦١	٣٦٢	٣٦٣	٣٦٤	٣٦٥	٣٦٦	٣٦٧	٣٦٨	٣٦٩	٣٧٠	٣٧١	٣٧٢	٣٧٣	٣٧٤	٣٧٥	٣٧٦	٣٧٧	٣٧٨	٣٧٩	٣٨٠	٣٨١	٣٨٢	٣٨٣	٣٨٤	٣٨٥
٣٨٦	٣٨٧	٣٨٨	٣٨٩	٣٩٠	٣٩١	٣٩٢	٣٩٣	٣٩٤	٣٩٥	٣٩٦	٣٩٧	٣٩٨	٣٩٩	٤٠٠	٤٠١	٤٠٢	٤٠٣	٤٠٤	٤٠٥	٤٠٦	٤٠٧	٤٠٨	٤٠٩	٤١٠	٤١١	٤١٢
٤١٣	٤١٤	٤١٥	٤١٦	٤١٧	٤١٨	٤١٩	٤٢٠	٤٢١	٤٢٢	٤٢٣	٤٢٤	٤٢٥	٤٢٦	٤٢٧	٤٢٨	٤٢٩	٤٣٠	٤٣١	٤٣٢	٤٣٣	٤٣٤	٤٣٥	٤٣٦	٤٣٧	٤٣٨	٤٣٩
٤٤٠	٤٤١	٤٤٢	٤٤٣	٤٤٤	٤٤٥	٤٤٦	٤٤٧	٤٤٨	٤٤٩	٤٥٠	٤٥١	٤٥٢	٤٥٣	٤٥٤	٤٥٥	٤٥٦	٤٥٧	٤٥٨	٤٥٩	٤٦٠	٤٦١	٤٦٢	٤٦٣	٤٦٤	٤٦٥	٤٦٦
٤٦٧	٤٦٨	٤٦٩	٤٧٠	٤٧١	٤٧٢	٤٧٣	٤٧٤	٤٧٥	٤٧٦	٤٧٧	٤٧٨	٤٧٩	٤٨٠	٤٨١	٤٨٢	٤٨٣	٤٨٤	٤٨٥	٤٨٦	٤٨٧	٤٨٨	٤٨٩	٤٩٠	٤٩١	٤٩٢	٤٩٣
٤٩٤	٤٩٥	٤٩٦	٤٩٧	٤٩٨	٤٩٩	٥٠٠	٥٠١	٥٠٢	٥٠٣	٥٠٤	٥٠٥	٥٠٦	٥٠٧	٥٠٨	٥٠٩	٥١٠	٥١١	٥١٢	٥١٣	٥١٤	٥١٥					

7.3.5: Approaches to the Light Verse⁹⁹

In section 2.6 Ṣā'in al-Dīn surveys a range of interpretations of the Light Verse (Q 24:35) as a model from which to extrapolate, including those of Ghazālī, Ibn Sīnā, and Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī, as well as the author's grandfather Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka and brother Ṣadr al-Dīn; Ṣā'in al-Dīn then offers a new lettrist interpretation. The section in full:

2.6: An Inquiry into the Written Form [of the Letter] with Respect to Sapiential, Law-governed Realities

Assuming you have understood the import of the Ṭahawī Circle as to the fact that every type of descent, regardless of trajectory or direction, remains incomplete until it traverses five stages (*madārij*)—any less and it cannot reach that endpoint (*ghāya*) that will allow it to reascend as an object in motion (*mutaḥarrik*), the arrow of its purpose thereby missing its desired target in the arc (sg. *qaws*) of that motion—, [you will realize that] the same applies to the One with respect to true oneness, [that One] whose property manifests in mutually distinct multiplicities: as long as it does not descend along those numbered stages it cannot realize that oneness or attain to the perfection unique to it, its longed-for desire.

Put briefly, [these five stages are as follows]: When the unqualified One necessitates the motion of love (*al-ḥaraka al-ḥubbiyya*)¹⁰⁰ and assumes the nature of a thing in motion, it becomes a substance (*tajawhur*); after [traversing] these two levels it acquires dimension (*bu'd*), thereby becoming able to plumb the three intersecting dimensions as a body capable of manifesting properties and effects, which stage is brought to perfection through organic growth (*numuww*); finally, the motion of that unqualified oneness reaches its terminus in the animal, the fifth stage of its descents and furthest depth to which its ipseities extend (*anhā hāwiyat huwiyyāti-hi*). You will observe that on this basis the oneness of genus (*al-waḥda al-jinsiyya*) attains to its own apex, as I have discussed in my *R. al-Muḥammadiyya*, and thereby becomes a source of the voluntary voice (*al-ṣawt al-ikhtiyārī*) through which is manifested that which is hidden, in the first place, to the disclosure sites of that which is manifest, in the second place. In this way [the descending and ascending motion proper to absolute oneness] provides for the conjunction of opposites (*majma^{an} li-l-ṭarafayn wa-mu'tanaq^{an} li-l-mutaqābilayn*), to wit, the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Hidden (Q 57:3).

Bearing this premise in mind, then, know that that every level of visible [reality] and every realm of engendered existence, even that of inanimate objects (*jamādāt*), with all their varieties of subtle or gross essences, constitutes a book containing verse-signs and letters in their two types of engendered forms, as has been made clear. But the latter too occupy levels that widely differ among themselves in attribution and in level as to their

⁹⁹ MS Majlis 10196 ff. 75b-77a.

¹⁰⁰ This refers in the first place to Q 5:54 (*He loves them and they love Him*), as well as to the *ḥadīth qudsī*, ubiquitous in Sufi circles: *I was a hidden treasure, but I loved to be known; therefore I created the creatures in order to be known.*

expression of various meanings; this is because the letters that manifest in their two forms within the books of existents and articulations of external entities (*makhārij al-a'yān al-khārijīyyāt*) fall into four levels with respect to their connection to these meanings and the ways in which they signify them:

- 1) First are those that are [written] upon the pages of bodies (*ajrām*) and articulations produced by their mutual interactions by way of sounds (*aṣwāt*) and characters (*arqām*). Even though the forms of the letters of this first category pervade all entities in external existence, including minerals, plants and animals, they and their significations are only comprehended by the very choicest of the elite of the elite among humankind.
- 2) Second is that form of voluntary voice peculiar to certain entities, being that which is used by animals by necessity to instinctively express their distress when they lack the necessities of life and are in search for what they need, thus making known what is within them by way of a struggle to gain that which will sustain their existence when they stand in need of such. This is only understood by other members of the same species that happen to be in the same locality and time and of the same level [of being].
- 3) Third is that peculiar to the human species by which its reality is constituted, namely the ability to speak and reason (*nuṭq*), allowing them to first express in detail what they need by way of natural subsistence and [the accoutrements of] civilization, this by necessity; and second to express the characteristics of visible or invisible realities, whether present or future, this in order to express their concern with the quest for rational perfection decreed to humankind on a voluntary basis.

Now humankind includes [two types]:

- 1) Those who are capable only of the first mode of the letter, and are therefore indistinguishable [in their use of language] from other species of animal. For while they employ the substances of the eternal heavenly letters, they do so only to base and worldly ends, bandying about the precious [elements] of the revealed Books and that sent down upon the messengers in their search for particularities of base matters; indeed, they use them to utter lies or to ridicule things with mocking statements and coarse descriptions. Whence the statement of the Most High: *They are like cattle—nay, they are even further astray* (Q 7:179).
- 2) Those who are capable of both modes, seeking from the letters that which will restore the seekers' primordial realities; such are not content [to use them] merely to supply bodily needs and maintain their natural, animal energy, but rather exert themselves with [the letters'] aid in search of spiritual sustenance by which to fortify their higher, unembodied faculties (*quwā-hu l-mujarrada*). Through the letters they descry the realities of both the visible things of the kingdom (*al-mulk*) [or corporeal world] and the invisible things of the dominion (*al-malakūt*) [or spiritual world], attaining to the levels of the angels of the divine presence (*al-mala' al-muqarrabīn*) who are pure of the pollution of temporal becoming (*ḥadath al-ḥudūth*) and the filth of the human condition (*danās al-nāsūt*). This second category has in turn various levels and differing approaches, including:

- 1) Those who in this quest restrict themselves to what the basic sense of language specifies in its particular convention (*waḍ'ī-hā l-shakhṣī*), never going beyond this; in using words they only consider their lexical significations strictly as they relate to the truth.
- 2) Those who transcend this level by including also that which derives from and corresponds to the basic sense of language in the signification of those words; that is, they include therein all types of figurative language and allusion, accepted phrasings, rare constructions and choice metaphors. However, for all that they pass beyond the particular convention [of language] to the disposition of species (*al-waḍ' al-naw'ī*) and incorporate what is there, in restricting the aspects of that correspondence to what they have learned of the usages of the Arabs and their leading rhetoricians and making the faithful reproduction of their constructions the condition for achieving such aspects, they are sidetracked from the reality of things—for each latter-day [rhetorician] (*khalaf*) simply accepts (*taqlīd*) what his predecessors (*salaf*) held.
- 4) Fourth is that peculiar to the perfected prophets and purified saints. This [category] also has various levels, including 1) that which admits of admixture with conventional, lexical signification, and 2) that which admits of no admixture with anything external to it. For the members of this category the foundations of signification are confined to written or spoken allusions (*ishārāt*) or numerical relations (*al-nisab al-'adadiyya*), these being the dispositions (*awḍā'*) necessary for the letters when revealed to each of the prophets; all other types of external dispositions that serve as the foundation of signification as it is commonly understood only descends with reference to the former, as you will see. This signification, then, based as it is on the three denotations (*ishārāt*) intrinsic to the letter, is the primordial signification that belongs to the letters as they are in themselves, free of the mediation of any type of convention (*ja'l, waḍ'*), and pertains solely to the tribe of the Seal (*al-ḥayy al-khatmī*) whose doctrine is wholly based thereon.

As for the first category, i.e., that which admits of admixture with conventional, lexical signification, [the prophets] share this with the verifiers among Sufis and philosophers who have drunk somewhat of the spring of human perfection, for all that they differ among themselves in their levels and their goals. This may be seen, for example, in how they understand the 'niche' (*mishkāṭ*) spoken of in the Light Verse (Q 24:35) [as representing] the sensory spirit (*al-rūḥ al-ḥassās*). Some, like al-Ghazālī, construe this on the basis of the fact that its light emanates from numerous apertures (*thuqab*), such as the eyes, ears and nostrils. Some, like Ibn Sīnā, understand it to represent that faculty of preparedness (*al-quwwa al-isti'dādiyya*) proper to the soul vis-à-vis the intelligibles; [this faculty] they term the material intellect (*al-'aql al-hayūlānī*), comparing it to the primordial matter empty in itself of all forms but prepared to receive them, though not in equal measure, this due to the lack of uniformity in its surfaces and the openings within them. Some, like my grandfather [Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka] in his *R. al-Nūriyya*, understand it to represent the human body (*ḥay'at al-badan al-insānī*), which encompasses the heart from all sides and has specific apertures, openings and channels through which the animal spirit courses, thereby illuminating the noble inward parts. Some, as was revealed to my brother and teacher [Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka] as discussed in his treatise [on the subject], understand it to represent the thick covering of the skull and all the members

encompassing the brain as the seat of the animal spirit (*al-rūḥ al-naḥsānī*); the form [of the skull] with respect thereto is like the form of a hollow sphere preserving a subtler luminous (*naḥyir*) body within it, with various apertures and openings through which that luminous [body] can shine, reflecting its light externally, just like the light in the niche: the animal spirit seated in that sphere first passes through the openings and then its light is reflected to the members, giving rise to sensation and voluntary motion. Some, like those who tread the ways of the Seal's tribe and who comprehend their wise Arabic dictums (*ḥikam*) as eloquently expressed in expository language, understand it to represent the visible world, since it is dark in itself and its reception of the light of existence is uneven and differs in its parts in serving as a site of manifestation of that light, which is one in itself and multiple through the multiplicity of the individual sites of manifestation the world comprises in the same way that the sensible fiery light, one in itself, becomes multiple according to the multiplicity of the apertures within the niche's lattice. And some, as [Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuwayī] has intimated in his *al-Maḥbūb*, understand it to represent Adam and Eve and their offspring, and likewise understand the lamp (*miṣbāḥ*) to represent the letter, the dot and their expression (*i'rāb*), and the glass to represent prophethood, messengerhood and sainthood. These then are the views of the leading thinkers of previous times with respect to this verse—God illumine their graves with His mercy and good pleasure.

[Another interpretation is however possible]: [the niche] may be understood to represent the written and spoken measurements (*maqādīr*) whereby dotting (*naṭq*) and articulation (*nuṭq*) are measured, initially insofar as they are engendered accidents (*a'rād kawniyya*) dark in themselves, and subsequently, when the existential material (*al-mādda al-wujūdiyya*) extends them into those two forms and illuminates their consonant surfaces received by their light and that matter is evaluated according to their measurements, the letterforms come into existence—they being like the glass to the lamp of illuminating, making-perceptible meanings. And this glass is the *glittering star kindled from the blessed tree* of humanness (*ādamiyya*), which is defined neither by *the East* of necessary existence (*wujūb*) or *the West* of contingent existence (*imkān*). The repetition of *glass* in the verse apprises us of the fact that the letter has two forms, just as the proximity of its *oil*, the material support of light in its shining, apprises us of the numerical meaning of the letter that is manifest in itself without need to be touched by the fire of its illuminating forms.

I have only discussed this first category at length, recounting the various significations understood by each of those who derive primordial instances of wisdom from the revealed heavenly forms, by way of providing an exemplar (*unmūdḥaj*) for the percipient to [aid in] understanding the supernal realities behind the unveiling expressions communicated through the Seal and deriving that which is in the interior [folds] of the Book, and a criterion (*mi'yār*) for the perceptive in his effort to harness his clear talents to allow him to ascend the rungs of human perfection as the time to do so draws near, and a ladder for the seeker in his quest to gain the prospect of the heights of the inward [senses] of this verse, thereby becoming ready to ascend the rungs of its semantic limits (*ḥudūd*) and import (*muṭalla'*). For all of these aspects are expressed by the tongues of the correspondences that admit of admixture with lexical conventions.

As for those aspects expressed by the letters according to their primordial significations and which admit of no admixture with any external [convention] whatsoever, facilitating the expression of most of their limits and import, it is only possible to reveal them after investigating the principles upon which they depend;

the present *Inquiries* (*al-Mafāḥiṣ*) are put forward precisely to explain in introductory fashion a selection of these [principles]. God Most High grant us success in accomplishing this goal—He is the Guide to the straight path—by virtue of the light of the Seal, the lamp of the confluences of perfection.

7.3.6: The ontological and epistemological status of prosody¹⁰¹

4.74: A Sapiential Inquiry with Respect to Prosody

Equilibrium (*i'tidāl*), in terms of its abovementioned structure (*hay'a*) and manifest, well-known traces (*zilāl*), possesses a form through which it manifests at every level whatsoever, whether those of existence or of manifestation, those of making-perceptible or of perceiving. Know then that that form is called the Balance (*al-mīzān*) insofar as it signifies the various levels of this equilibrium and constitutes the point of departure for distinguishing between its upper and lower registers.

It is evident that the signification of all such balances, distinguishing as they do between the various properties of things and the levels of their realization, obtain according to the true disposition (*al-waḍ' al-ḥaqīqī*) this book is devoted to explicating as the basis of its inquiries (*mafāḥiṣ*) and chapters. You will recall from the foregoing that the signification proper to the letters themselves with respect to the [supernal] meanings is solely according to this [true] disposition; what is evident here is that the significations of the balances are according to the levels of that weighed (*al-mawzūnāt*) [therein] and the properties of each when tested with the touchstone of reflection on the resplendent sign-verses that signify just such a disposition to the mass of mankind; at the same time, they signal their reliability to reason when it essays to probe things unknown free of the handicap of doubt. It is therefore evident that the signification which the letters themselves possess occupies this rank [of truth and certitude] among all their other types of significations.

Bearing this in mind, then, know that this balance, regardless of the variety of its instantiations, derives from the three fundamental principles discussed in the present book, these representing the form of the universal sites of [divine] self-disclosure proper to the perduring letters as revealed forms—the standard by which all balances are themselves weighed. Each of these sites of self-disclosure has a balance proper to it. The general balance employed by the common run of people in evaluating the values of things in all their interactions and congresses is that relating to sight (*al-hay'a al-mīzāniyya al-mubšara*), which corresponds to the written form of the letter. Likewise, the poetry (*al-ash'ār*) commonly quoted by them in their conversations and majlises relates to hearing (*al-hay'a al-mīzāniyya al-masmū'a*), corresponding to the spoken form [of the letter]. As for the construct (*hay'a*) that is related to its mental-numerical form in terms of what is perceptible to the senses, this is the arranged form (*al-šūra al-intizāmiyya*) proper to musical notes (*al-naghamāt al-mūsīqiyya*) and the noble composition (*mizāj*) produced through the harmonious deployment of those relations in a mutually balanced manner. Know that it is through this composition and its relations that the notes become capable of moving intent listeners, for the connection that obtains between strong relations

¹⁰¹ MS Majlis 10196 ff. 118b-19a.

necessarily allows the [respective] secret [essences] (*sirr*) of two related things to interpenetrate.

There is a further subtle point having to do with principles the intelligent [reader] must consider here: You are aware that proper to the letterforms are two types of signification (*dalāla*) according to the two different dispositions governing the individual instances of each. The first [type of signification] is conventional and technical (*ja'li*, *šinā'i*), devised by people [to express specialized concepts], while the second is real and natural (*ḥaqīqī*, *ṭabī'i*) and cannot be devised by man—this [type] is sent down from heaven to the hearts of the prophets. Likewise, the three balances relating to the [three letter]forms are governed by precisely these two types of disposition. That corresponding to the conventional disposition with respect to the written form [of the letter] is the common balance used by people simply to determine quantities of things; that corresponding to the real disposition is the noble and fundamental harmoniousness (*tanāsub*) termed beauty (*ḥusn*), against which qualities and quantities and the shapes composed thereof are evaluated. Corresponding to the conventional disposition with respect to the spoken form [of the letter] are the meters of prosody (*al-buḥūr al-'arūḍiyya*) by which words and their meters are scanned, these relating to the category of quantity; that corresponding to the real disposition is that noble form proper to speech termed in literary theory (*šinā'at al-adab*) inimitable (*i'jāz*), as alluded to by [the Prophet] (God bless and keep him): *Some eloquence is magic.*¹⁰² This last comprehends all quantities, all qualities, all dispositions. The apex of eloquence with respect to speech, i.e., its inimitability, is constituted by that noble, all-comprehensive relation between these levels with respect to the hearing—the all-comprehensiveness of beauty; [here beauty] seen is equivalent to [beauty heard]. Finally, corresponding to the conventional disposition with respect to the spiritual-mental form [of the letter] are work ditties (*al-aqwāl al-mūsīqiyya*) and the steady, rhythmic tones produced by craftwork performed by artisans skilled in the given craft and masters of its principles and instruments; corresponding to the real disposition is that which comprises the noble, perfecting relation by virtue of which every sick man is restored to health and every blameworthy failure is made to reach the goal. All those who achieve this relation and discover the path to its acquisition attain to glorious heights and exalted stations, as I have often mentioned.

Now this science [of letters] is one governed by [very specific] principles and rules, this according to its practitioners from among the sages (*ḥukamā'*) [of times past], disciples of the prophets and saints; none may understand it but those who can penetrate their [cryptic] styles of writing (*asālīb alsinati-him*) and terminology (*luḡhāt*). In the discourse of such perfected [thinkers], emulators of the prophets, are rarefied instances [of wisdom] whose underlying source may well be chanced upon by those who contemplate them deeply—for here each *knows his drinking place* (Q 2:60, 7:160).

The above observations being parenthetical, let us return to the main point under discussion here, to wit, the instances of Prophetic wisdom contained within the rules and principles of prosody and the secret of their pervasiveness therein. As you know, of the letterforms the spoken form is [considered to be] the highest, enabling and bringing to perfection as it does the mission of the prophets. It is for this reason that the balance peculiar to this form, i.e., that of the meters of prosody, is perceptible to all; whether educated or uneducated, everyone is able to immediately distinguish between sound and defective meter without recourse to any instrument and without pausing for a moment's reflection. By extension, then, the constituent parts of the original forms (*ummahāt*) of

¹⁰² *Inna mina l-bayāni la-siḥr^{an}*; see e.g. Bukhārī, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *al-Ṭibb*, bab 51, no. 5826; Abū Dā'ūd, *Sunan*, K. *al-Adab*, bab 94, nos. 5009, 5011.

such meters as *hazaj*, *ramal* or *rajaz* derive from the Doubled Seven (*al-sab‘ al-mathānī*); if these meters be free from defect, their letters—the Doubled Seven—give form to these metered forms and spoken shapes. The same applies to the other meters; if you closely analyze their parts, weighing them in the ready balance of number, you will find correspondences thereto among the various forms of light that stand at the head of the quranic suras.¹⁰³

¹⁰³ There follows a last sentence in which Ṣā‘in al-Dīn cites an instance of correspondence obtaining between the connected letters (*muwaṣṣalāt*) that body forth the Doubled Seven on the one hand and their true forms on the other, presumably the quranic *muqatta‘āt*; I leave it untranslated here as I am unable to follow his explanation on this point.

EXCURSUS

Form and content

*The more art is controlled, limited, worked over, the more it is free ... Whatever diminishes constraint diminishes strength. The more constraints one imposes, the more one frees one's self of the chains that shackle the spirit.*¹

—Igor Stravinsky

*No non-poetic account of reality can be complete.*²

—John D. Barrow

The present excursus serves to highlight two elements essential to understanding Ṣā'in al-Dīn's larger project but beyond the immediate scope of this study: his ornate literary style, which is informed by and synergetic with his lettrist thought; and his complex relationship to what may be termed the Ibn 'Arabī school, particularly in its tradition of mystico-literary commentary. As a case study I examine Ibn Turka's commentary on the *Tā'iyya al-Kubrā* of Ibn al-Fāriḍ (d. 632/1235), the *Sharḥ-i Nazm al-Durr*, vis-à-vis earlier and later commentaries of the Ibn 'Arabī school; such an examination will shed light on both of the elements just mentioned, since his commentary must be recognized as the first to repoeticize this decidedly antipoetical commentary tradition, to recuperate form as vital to meaning. More broadly, I speculate that the direct link obtaining between lettrist theory and literary practice in Ibn Turka's oeuvre may be generalizable in some measure to the artistic culture of early 9th/15th century Iran.

¹ *Poetics of Music in the Form of Six Lessons*, trans. A. Knodel and I. Dahl, New York, 1947, 66-68.

² *New Theories of Everything*, Oxford, 2007, 245.

E.1: Ibn Turka's ornate literary style

Although at first glance it may seem an issue wholly separate from his lettrist theory, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's choice of literary technique, ornate or artistic prose (*naṣr-i fannī*) often tending toward the prosimetrical, is to be understood as part and parcel of his larger project. We should not expect otherwise from a thinker who demonstrates such a clear will to synthesis and universalism. His literary style may be understood simply as a concrete expression of that will: it strives to encompass the Persian and Arabic literary traditions in the same measure that his theory strives to encompass all of reality through language.

In his definitive *Sabk-shināsī*, Malik al-Shu'arā' Bahār (d. 1370/1951) singles out Ṣā'in al-Dīn's prose style for special praise, identifying him as the first writer to use an ornate literary (*adabī*) style for theoretical (*ilmī*) subjects.³ He traces the specific pedigree of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's prose style back to 'Aṭā'-Malik Juvaynī (d. 681/1283), governor of Arab Iraq and Khuzistan under the Ilkhanids, whose *Tārīkh-i Jahān-gushāy* is the best source of information on Chinggis Khān's conquests and admired as a model of style.⁴ (Bahār continues by saying that Ṣā'in al-Dīn's style is, however, more elegant (*balighat*) and less labored (*bī-takalluft*) than that of Juvaynī.) Persian works of history were increasingly written in ornate prose from this point onwards; representative works include Waṣṣāf's (d. 735/1334) *Tajziyat al-Amṣār wa-Tazjiyat al-Aṣṣār*,⁵ conceived as a sequel to Juvaynī's work; Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's *Ẓafarnāma*, treating of

³ *Sabk-shināsī*, 3/352; this includes both his Persian and Arabic writings. Bahār devotes a separate section to Ibn Turka at 3/223-34. Note that Bahār owned MS Majlis 10196, the earliest, most complete and most reliable collection of Ibn Turka's works; see §2.1.1 above.

⁴ Bahār, *Sabk-shināsī*, 3/231.

⁵ See Pfeiffer, "A Turgid History"; it is often referred to simply as *Tārīkh-i Waṣṣāf*. Peter Jackson remarks of the work, "Waṣṣāf did not merely emulate Juvaynī's florid and bombastic style but perpetrated even greater excesses, which were in turn to provide a model for subsequent Persian historiography. Although the two viziers [Rashīd al-Dīn Faḡl Allāh and Sa'd al-Dīn] allegedly praised the *Tārīkh* and declared that no finer combination of Persian and Arabic had ever been achieved in any historical work, Öldjeitü was unable to understand a word of the passage which Waṣṣāf read to him (*Tārīkh-i Waṣṣāf*, 405). Modern historians have often shared the Il-Khān's incomprehension ..." ("Waṣṣāf," *El*²). Note Jackson's assumption that floridness is an intrinsically negative quality regardless of period taste. Needless to say,

Temür's conquests;⁶ Fazl Allāh b. Rūzbihān Khunjī Iṣfahānī's (d. 927/1521) *Tārīkh-i 'Ālam-ārā-yi Amīnī*, a history of the Aq Quyunlu dynasty under Ya'qūb Beg b. Uzun Ḥasan (r. 883-96/1478-90); and Idrīs Bidlīsī's (d. 926/1520) *Hasht Bihišt*, the first Persian history of the Ottomans and template for subsequent Ottoman historiography in Turkish.⁷ As noted above, the practice of *inshā'* also developed a formulaic, highly coded floridity during this period. Strictly theoretical works, in contrast, tended toward utilitarianism or fluidity of prose. With the precedent of Ṣā'īn al-Dīn's writings, however, thinkers began to blend the literary and the theoretical; subsequent examples include Abū l-Faẓl 'Allāmī's (d. 1011/1602) *Ā'in-i Akbarī*, Book 3 of his *Akbarnāma*, and the works of Qā'im-Maqām Mīrzā Abū l-Qāsim Farāhānī (d. 1251/1835) on theology, philosophy, prosody and rhetoric.⁸ Bahār's admiration of Ṣā'īn al-Dīn's literary style is all the more remarkable given the poet laureate's dismissal of ornate Safavid-era prose as sterile and empty of meaning.⁹

Literary taste in the Timurid period was nothing if not mannerist. Ṣā'īn al-Dīn was, by the 'artificial' standards of his age, a vigorous, masterful stylist in prose and verse; indeed, it is sometimes difficult to disentangle his doctrine from the intricacy of its literary expression.¹⁰ In analyzing thinkers like Ṣā'īn al-Dīn it has long been customary to ignore the literary hull of their writings in an effort to penetrate to the theoretical kernel of their system; in this methodology form and content are entirely divorced fields of inquiry. This would seem,

the association of the newcomer Mongols with modern historians in terms of their incomprehension of Arabicized prose does not necessarily reflect well on the latter.

⁶ Sharaf al-Dīn in fact wrote five chronicles, two of which are well known—the *Muqaddima* and the *Zafarnāma*—, with another three (**Fatḥnāma-yi Ṣāhibqirānī*, **Fatḥnāma-yi Humāyūn*, and the *Second Maqāla*) surviving only in fragmentary form (Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 10).

⁷ Bahār, *Sabk-shināsī*, 3/293.

⁸ Bahār, *Sabk-shināsī*, 3/352-53.

⁹ Bahār, *Sabk-shināsī*, 3/293-95.

¹⁰ For example, he often makes mystico-philosophical points through the apposite quotation of verse, without elaborating further.

however, to be an instance of not taking such texts on their own terms. In recent scholarship on Islamicate historiography of the medieval period, there is a trend toward giving due attention to the literary form of ornate works of history and official documents, in which formal structure and phrasing have been shown to communicate information complementary to—or, more often, at odds with—the ostensible sense of the text.¹¹ I have shown elsewhere that in the royal *inshā'* or chancery material of the 9th/15th century form frequently functions as content.¹²

However, the scholarly treatment of literary works as such, and especially poetry, has lagged behind; the ornate prose style of the period is typically censured as *mutakallaf*, labored and impenetrable, and the poetry dismissed as artificial, pretentious and above all derivative. The Persian poetry and prose of the late 9th/15th to the 12th/18th century is often rejected out of hand as symptomatic of an age of decline, of decadence: mannerist—that is to say, purely imitative and consolidating, not creative, driven by such an intensity of focus on form that content shrivels.¹³ 'Abd al-Raḥmān Jāmī (d. 898/1492) becomes the last great classical Persian poet, not through his originality but through his comprehensive (and sometimes dry) mastery of all that went before.¹⁴ In this reading, the emergence of the *mu'ammā* or logograph genre, which enjoyed such vogue from the 9th/15th century onward, is taken as representative of the formal preoccupations of this period; here the index of a riddle's sophistication is the tenuity of

¹¹ See e.g. Waldman, *Toward a Theory of Historical Narrative*, a case study of Bayhaqī's (d. 470/1077) *Tārīkh*. This tension between text and subtext creates a rich semantic matrix limited only by a writer's subtlety and erudition, and is indeed designed to showcase such; thus eulogy could be made to serve the purposes of mockery for those sharp enough to perceive it, as had long been the case in Arabic poetry.

¹² This feature is common, moreover, to the procedure of courts as widely distant as those of the Mamluks in Egypt and the Bahmanids in India. I treat of an example drawn from Aq Quyunlu royal *inshā'* in a recent article, "The Delicate Art of Aggression: Uzun Ḥasan's *Faṭḥnāma* to Qāyṭbāy of 873/1469."

¹³ See e.g. Yarshater, *Shi'r-i Fārsī dar 'Ahd-i Shāhrukh*.

¹⁴ Vittor, "The Herat School," 854.

the formal clues the author leaves as to his (usually pedestrian or functional) intent.¹⁵

It is true that the poetry of the Timurid period is characterized by its push toward consolidation of the poetic canon, this through the technique of *naẓīra-gū'ī*, the practice of challenging, or *istiqbāl*, welcoming, the poems of 'classical' poets (Ar. *mu'āraḍa*). Indeed, it was by this process that the classical canon of Persian poetry was created during this century. It is also true that much of the poetry of the period is mediocre or without merit,¹⁶ and that prose could be unreadably bombastic. It does not follow, however, that such a dual preoccupation with formalism and the precedent of tradition necessarily militated against creativity.¹⁷ Yes, this was an age of encyclopedic works,¹⁸ dictionaries,¹⁹ anthologies, commentaries upon supercommentaries—of canon formation, in short. But this did not preclude intellectual creativity and individualism, which was geared rather toward subtlety, synthesis and subversion within the bounds of an increasingly complex tradition.²⁰ To assume otherwise is to

¹⁵ Losensky, *Welcoming Fighānī*, 154–55, 160. Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī, author of the well-known *Ḥulal-i Muṭarrāz*, was a noted authority on the *mu'ammā*, as was Jāmī, who authored no less than four (short) works on the genre (all simplifications of Yazdī's *Ḥulal*; see Storey, *PL*, 3.2/221–23). Losensky suggests that *mu'ammās* functioned as calling cards, and a proficiency in constructing them at a moment's notice was considered *de rigueur* for participation in polite society (*Welcoming Fighānī*, 157–59). In the Mamluk context, Thomas Bauer advances the view that far from being vapid, such formal preoccupations indicate rather the extraordinary extent to which poetry permeated society during this period, an observation that applies no less to Iran; once we lay aside our Western preconceptions as to what literature should be or do, we might well admire “a culture that achieved a great deal of poetization of everyday life and made the reaffirmation of cultural values and the training of linguistic consciousness a permanent trait of daily routine” (Bauer, “Mamluk Literature,” 109).

¹⁶ It should however be noted that such mediocrity has much to do with the great increase in poetic production, with even artisans and butchers entering the fray, as well as the blurring of boundaries between popular and educated literature; a certain 'bourgeois' tendency is evident in this connection (Bauer, “Mamluk Literature,” 109–10).

¹⁷ See Ingalls, “Subtle Innovation,” 244–50.

¹⁸ On late medieval Arabic encyclopedism see e.g. Muhanna, “Oceans of Knowledge.”

¹⁹ Ibn Manẓūr's (d. 711/1311) *Lisān al-'Arab* most notably.

²⁰ The truism that there can be no creation without tradition or art without strict limitation comes to mind. Cf. Stravinsky's remarks in his *Poetics of Music* on tradition: “Far from implying the repetition of what has been, tradition presupposes the reality of what endures. It appears as an heirloom, a heritage that one receives on condition of making it bear fruit before passing it on to one's descendants ... Tradition thus assures the continuity of creation” (59). On artifice and limitation: “The more art is

neglect the obvious *ẓāhir-bāṭin* dichotomy so fundamental to the medieval Islamic worldview, in which form is to be cultivated as springboard for meaning.²¹ As Ṣāʿin al-Dīn and many other thinkers of the period constantly emphasize, the undelimited absolute as source of all meaning must remain relatively sterile and meaningless in itself except to the extent that it manifests in the delimitedness of form, especially beautiful form, there to return the human observer to transcendence—whether spiritual, intellectual or aesthetic. A lettrist dictum runs: the more a thing is hidden, the more it is manifest.²² By extension: the more formally sophisticated a poem (for instance) is, the more meaning it is capable of conveying.

I argue, then, that this principle is generalizable to the literary creativity of the period, with the implication that the theoretical and the literary must here be considered inextricable.²³ Otherwise, how to understand a figure like Ṣāʿin al-Dīn Turka, who deems language the very fabric of reality, who makes philosophical points through the calculated quotation of poetry, who deconstructs the words of revelation in ornate prose? Nor is he alone in this; many of the great 9th/15th century lettrist thinkers touched on in this study, including

controlled, limited, worked over, the more it is free ... My freedom thus consists in my moving about within the narrow frame that I have assigned myself for each one of my undertakings. I shall go even further: my freedom will be so much the greater and more meaningful the more narrowly I limit my field of action and the more I surround myself with obstacles. Whatever diminishes constraint diminishes strength. The more constraints one imposes, the more one frees one's self of the chains that shackle the spirit ... 'It is evident,' writes Baudelaire, 'that rhetorics and prosodies are not arbitrarily invented tyrannies, but a collection of rules demanded by the very organization of the spiritual being, and never have prosodies and rhetorics kept originality from fully manifesting itself. The contrary, that is to say, that they have aided in the flowering of originality, would be infinitely more true'" (66-69). Such arbitrary limitation is, however, not to be confused with bombast, which betrays the purpose of form; here Stravinsky contrasts Wagner's infinite becoming of form, aggravating and pointless, with Verdi's aristocratic artificiality.

²¹ Thus Ibn ʿArabī, for example, was a *ẓāhirī* in matters of *fiqh*.

²² *SND*, 6. Note that this observation occurs, ironically, in Ṣāʿin al-Dīn's description of lettrists' disinterest in poetry. This principle, in turn, recalls the definition of information as a measure of probability; since information consists in the production of novelty, the unexpected, more improbable—that is, more artificial—data carries more information. For more on the suggestive correspondences between lettrist theory and the new physics of information see §C.2 below.

²³ This inextricability is the main premise of Giancarlo Maiorino's study *The Cornucopian Mind and the Baroque Unity of the Arts*.

Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī, ‘Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī and Ḥusayn Vā’iz Kāshifī, were also noted literary stylists, literary theorists and poets.²⁴ Any casual survey of their views on literary form must throw into ironic relief our misapprehension of the vital and very conscious link that obtained between style and substance in the 9th/15th century: witness Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī, the foremost authority on the subject and Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s chief disciple, who asserts that the emergence of the *mu‘ammā* genre stands as harbinger of a new chapter of human progress in understanding the cosmos precisely *because* it is so trained upon the form of language.²⁵

Assuming such a marriage of theoretical meaning and literary form can only shed light on heretofore obscure aspects of these poorly understood centuries—a period glossed over not due to a paucity of sources but rather to their sheer profusion, whose difficult formal qualities often prove discouraging to researchers. Received wisdom dismisses the later medieval Islamicate period in Iran as an age of decadence, rescued only by the 11th/17th century advent of the school of Isfahan in philosophy and the 12th-13th/18th-19th century *bāzgasht-i adabī* or neoclassical movement in poetry.²⁶ This view, however, derives in no small part from the colonialist and nationalist perspectives dominant since the mid-13th/19th century, wherein the earlier, vigorous and rightly vaunted classical phase in Arabic and Persian literature is sharply contrasted with the centuries of intervening decline and stagnation, this so as to justify the paternalistic, violent intervention of a now ascendant West in hopes of reviving the

²⁴ On Kāshifī’s baroque style, for example, see van Ruymbeke, “Kāshifī’s Powerful Metaphor.” This trend continued into the Safavid period, which “witnesses the interesting fact that most of its great philosophers and gnostics were also poets, some of commendable quality” (Nasr, “Spiritual Movements,” 662). These include Mīr Dāmād (*takhalluṣ* Ishrāq), Lāhijī (Fayyāz), Mullā Muḥsin Kāshānī (Fayz), and Mullā Hādī Sabzivārī (Asrār), as well as figures like Shaykh Bahā’ al-Dīn al-‘Āmilī.

²⁵ Sharaf al-Dīn’s theoretical introduction to his definitive work on the *mu‘ammā* genre, the *Ḥulal-i Muṭarrāz*, presents a vision of evolutionary progression similar to that in Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s *R. Anjām*, with the *mu‘ammā* serving as a useful skill in the lettrist’s technical repertoire; more, the appearance of the *mu‘ammā* genre in itself constitutes the harbinger of a new age (MS Majlis 10196 ff. 374b-375a; MS Majlis 31 ff. 2b-3b; see §6.4 above).

²⁶ The brilliance of the tradition of book painting at the Timurid, Mughal and Safavid courts is duly appreciated in the literature usually in isolation from its literary and intellectual context.

Orient's well-nigh expired lifespan.²⁷ The present excursus therefore takes as its point of departure the work of Paul Losensky, Shamsur Rahman Faruqi and Charles Vittor, who explode the myth of poetical (and, by extension, cultural) decline during the Timurid-Turkmen and Safavid-Mughal periods, and Thomas Bauer, who reappraises the Arabic literature of the Mamluk period to the same end.²⁸ While space does not allow elaboration here, I suspect that, in particular, Losensky's masterful rehabilitation of the infamous artificiality of Safavid-era poetry—dismissed as representing a decadent 'Indian style' (*sabk-i hindī*) by its later detractors but dubbed by its exponents the 'fresh style' (*ṭarz-i tāza*)²⁹—may be usefully juxtaposed with the present study's focus on the burgeoning of lettrist thought in Timurid Iran as two complementary approaches to the universalist, *textualist* zeitgeist of the 9th/15th and 10th/16th centuries.³⁰ As we saw in Chapter 6, Ibn Turka proclaims the necessity of ascending from the literalism of the traditionists to the lettrist theory of his own circle—and the equally pressing necessity of returning from lettrism to literalism. His oeuvre makes it abundantly clear that this literalism includes the literary.

Not surprisingly, the widespread lettrist sensibilities of the early 9th/15th century manifested even in common turns of literary phrase; writers of the period habitually describe reality in textual terms—events are forever being inscribed on the pages of circumstance, *bar*

²⁷ Bauer, "Mamluk Literature," 106.

²⁸ See e.g. Bauer, "In Search of 'Post-Classical Literature'" and "Mamluk Literature: Misunderstandings and New Approaches." Cf. 'Umar Mūsā Bāshā's similar rehabilitation of Mamluk- and Ottoman-era Arabic literature in his two-volume *Tārīkh al-Adab al-'Arabī*, Vol. 1: *al-'Aṣr al-Mamlūkī*; Vol. 2: *al-'Aṣr al-'Uthmānī*. Indeed, it will be useful here to treat Timurid and Mamluk literary practice as of a piece.

²⁹ Losensky, *Welcoming Fighānī*, 4 et passim.

³⁰ Losensky cautions, however, that it would be somewhat rash to speak of such a tendency toward literary ornateness as having its intellectual moorings in the work of such lettrists as Ṣā'ib al-Dīn. Rather, Ṣā'ib al-Dīn's project represents a profound 'poeticization' of the intellectual tradition. Notwithstanding this need for circumspection, Losensky's current project, titled the Poetics of Effulgence, seeks to explore possible consonances between Ṣā'ib's (d. 1086-87/1676) poetics and Safavid-era philosophy and its views on the nature of creativity (personal communication with Professor Losensky).

ṣafahāt-i awzā'. The opening benediction from Ṣā'in al-Dīn's ornate *Munāẓara-yi Bazm u Razm* may be cited as a typical example:

Boundless praise be to the King, the radiance of whose sword of staggering majesty exalts the sway of His glory on the battlefield (*razmgāh*) of our inborn nature (*fiṭrat-i ūlā*)—having deftly split the pen of fate it inscribes its lines on the mirrored surface of the worlds, and from the soft scratching of its inscription echoes the claxon of creation across the tracts of the world of generation and corruption, the feathall (*bazmgāh*) of primordial totality (*jam'iyat-i aṣlī*); and excellent and pure blessings be strewn before the holy court of the master of creation and choicest of creatures,

Muḥammad, on whose dust the world is drunk—
a thousand thousand blessings on his pure soul!³¹

Indeed, Ibn Turka's two ornate mystico-philosophical romances, the *Munāẓara-yi Bazm u Razm* just referenced and the popular *Munāẓarāt-i Khams* (aka 'Aql u 'Ishq), approach the question of form and content on explicitly literary, rather than lettrist, grounds. As the titles indicate, these works are structured as a debate between two parties who then seek the arbitration of the sultan. Both the *munāẓara* and the philosophical romance were well established genres by Ṣā'in al-Dīn's time, with such notable precedents as Ibn Sīnā's (d. 428/1037) allegories³² and Ibn Ṭufayl's (d. 581/1185) *Ḥayy b. Yaqẓān*, a more famous reworking of Ibn Sīnā's version; Suhrawardī's (d. 587/1191) allegories and recitals were particularly influential in the later development of this genre.³³ For its part, the *munāẓara* is an ancient genre already present in Akkadian and Sumerian literature, and has remained perennially popular in Arabic, Persian and Turkic literatures up to the present;³⁴ a favorite theme is that of sword vs. pen.³⁵ Other notable

³¹ MS Majlis 10196 f. 162b.

³² I.e., his *R. al-Ṭayr*, *Salāmān u Absāl* and *Ḥayy b. Yaqẓān*.

³³ E.g., his *R. al-Ṭayr*, *Āvāz-i Par-i Jibra'īl*, 'Aql-i Surkh, *Ṣafīr-i Sīmurgh*, etc.

³⁴ For the contemporary popularity of the genre in Central Asia see e.g. Jarring, *Some Notes on Eastern Turki (New Uighur) Munazara Literature*.

³⁵ As in the passage from Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *Munāẓara-yi Bazm u Razm* just cited; see e.g. Gully, "The Sword and the Pen in the Pre-Modern Arabic Heritage."

9th/15th century *munāẓaras* include al-Qalqashandī's (d. 821/1418) *R. fī l-Mufākhara bayn al-'Ulūm* and 'Alī Shīr Navā'ī's (d. 906/1501) *Muḥākamat al-Lughatayn*.³⁶ Given the oppositional dichotomy that is the basis of the *munāẓara* genre, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *Munāẓara-yi Bazm u Razm*, for example, may potentially be read as a heated debate between literary form (beauty) on the one hand and religio-philosophical content (reason) on the other, only to be resolved through the mediation of Sultan 'Ishq (the poet-philosopher)—Ṣā'in al-Dīn himself.

Finally, the link between lettrist theory and literary form appears to be equally extendable to the calligraphic practice of early Timurid Iran. It seems no accident that the famous Baghdadi calligrapher, Ma'rūf Khaṭṭāt, was implicated together with Ṣā'in al-Dīn and others in the Hurufi attempt on Shāhrukh's life of 830/1427; nor that the Timurid prince to take the most interest in Ṣā'in al-Dīn's lettrist thought was Bāysunghur b. Shāhrukh, a famous calligrapher in his own right.³⁷ Much further research is necessary along these lines, to say the least, but it may be observed here that lettrism, as a central intellectual mode of the 9th/15th century, can no longer be safely discounted in studies of the cultural productions of the period.

In sum, Ṣā'in al-Dīn, as the leading lettrist of early 9th/15th century Iran, is also the first writer in Persian to couch theoretical discussion in ornate prose, to use new hybrid literary genres in his synthesis of multiple intellectual traditions; his anthologizing technique heralds the creation of the Persian poetical canon.³⁸ I contend that, far from obscuring his insights, the formal qualities of his work synergistically enhance and activate their meaning, and were understood to do so by the author and his contemporaries. As such, Ibn Turka must be

³⁶ While the two examples mentioned are more theoretical than poetic, the *munāẓara* was often extended into a finished romance, as in Lāmi'ī's (d. 937 or 38/1530 or 31) *Munāẓara-yi Behār u Shitā* (Gibb, *History of Ottoman Poetry*, 3/21).

³⁷ See e.g. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *R. Su'l al-Mulūk*, an overview of the practical and theoretical aspects of lettrism, written at Bāysunghur's request; see §2.1.2, no. 40.

³⁸ In particular, Ṣā'in al-Dīn is one of the first writers to consistently quote Ḥāfiẓ (d. ca. 792/1390), his earlier contemporary, in his writings.

considered a quintessentially mannerist figure both as a thinker and as a writer.

E.2: Ibn Turka's repoeticization of the Ibn 'Arabī school commentary tradition

*I went to visit my friend Bob, who said to me:
"We reach the real by overcoming the seduction of images."
I was overjoyed, until I realized
Such abstinence will never be possible for me.
I caught myself looking out the window.³⁹*

—Charles Simic

Şā'in al-Dīn's relationship to the Ibn 'Arabī school as it developed in Anatolia and Iran is less than straightforward. On the one hand, he is assumed to belong more or less wholly to the mystico-philosophical tradition formulated by Şadr al-Dīn Qūnavī (d. 673/1274) and later members of the school, whose various attempts at synthesis between peripatetic-illuminationist philosophy and theoretical mysticism began to dominate the eastern intellectual scene from the mid-7th/13th century onwards.⁴⁰ A significant portion of Ibn Turka's oeuvre, in particular his *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, certainly supports this assumption; indeed,

³⁹ "A Letter," *The Voice at 3:00 A.M.: Selected Late & New Poems*, Orlando, 2003, 22. I am indebted to Professor Losensky for alerting me to this poem.

⁴⁰ The 6th/13th century school of Bahrain, for example, Shi'i thinkers with tenuous links to the Ibn 'Arabī school proper, was among the first to embrace this project (see al-Oraibi, "Shī'i Renaissance"; and §2.1.2, no. 42 above). Perhaps the best studied of these syntheses from the late medieval period is that achieved by Ibn Abī Jumhūr al-Aḥsā'i, who welded together philosophy, mysticism and Shi'i theology and doctrine into a seamless whole, providing a template for the feted school of Isfahan of 10th-11th/16th-17th century Safavid Iran (see Schmidtke, *Theologie, Philosophie und Mystik*; Madelung, "Ibn Abī Ğumhūr al-Aḥsā'i's Synthesis of *Kalām*, Philosophy and Sufism").

his commentaries on Ibn ‘Arabī’s *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*,⁴¹ the *Lama‘āt* of Fakhr al-Dīn ‘Irāqī (d. 688/1289) and the *Gulshan-i Rāz* of Maḥmūd Shabistarī (d. after 740/1340) serve as badges of his membership in the Ibn ‘Arabī school. In particular, his commentary on Ibn al-Fāriḍ’s *Tā’iyya al-Kubrā*, the *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*, explicitly continues that school’s two-century commentary tradition on the poem as a favorite teaching text. Even ‘Abd al-Raḥmān Jāmī (d. 898/1492), despite his patent disdain for and hostility toward the members of the Isfahan Circle, relies substantially on Ṣā’in al-Dīn in his own commentary on the *Tā’iyya*.⁴²

On the other hand, Ṣā’in al-Dīn parts ways from the ‘mainstream’ of the Ibn ‘Arabī school in his lionization of the occult sciences, and lettrism in particular. Although earlier members of the school were no strangers to lettrist theory,⁴³ Ṣā’in al-Dīn openly promotes it in a way that is unprecedented in the tradition—and cites Ibn ‘Arabī himself as one of his primary textual sources to this end. Even his commentary on the *Fuṣūṣ* is unique; unlike the host of other commentaries on this text, his is thickly veined with lettrist excursuses. A millenarian and universalist thinker, Ṣā’in al-Dīn saw his own role as a systematizer and synthesizer of a broader and more ancient tradition. As Binbaş states: “Although deeply influenced by the philosophical theology of Ibn al-‘Arabī,” Ibn Turka and his circle in western Iran “seem to have

⁴¹ He also wrote a short commentary on ten verses from Ibn ‘Arabī’s divan, *Sharḥ-i Dah Bayt-i Muḥyī l-Dīn Ibn-i ‘Arabī* (see §2.1.2, no. 29).

⁴² See §8.2.2 below. Jāmī also reworked Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī’s *Ḥulal-i Muṭarrāz* (as well as his *Muntakhab-i Ḥulal-i Muṭarrāz*), which he criticized as too recondite for general use; in the process he very advisedly stripped from the text Sharaf al-Dīn’s theoretical, lettrist discussion as to the occult significance of the *mu‘ammā* in a bid to quarantine and minimize what he saw as the unhealthy influence of the Isfahan Circle. In effect, Jāmī is concerned to convert the lettrist technique of *mu‘ammā* into a simple poetical exercise or literary pastime—and he appears to have wholly succeeded in his purpose (Binbaş, “Sharaf al-Dīn,” 87-89).). In contrast, the *mādda tārikh* or chronogram genre, similarly lettrist in orientation, enjoyed a greater and more persistent vitality in subsequent centuries (see Losensky, “Mādda Tārik,” *Elr*).

⁴³ E.g. Qūnavī’s *Tafsīr al-Fātiḥa*, cited by Kāshifī as a lettrist source in his *Javāhir al-Tafsīr* (344). In the later lettrist tradition, particular in the Ottoman context, Qūnavī is frequently mentioned as a (pseudopigraphic) commentator on Pseudo-Ibn ‘Arabī’s famous *al-Shajara al-Nu‘māniyya fī l-Dawla al-Uthmāniyya* (Fleischer, “Seer to the Sultan,” 295, 297; see §5.1 above).

developed their own language”—a thesis the present study is devoted to exploring.⁴⁴ As a result, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn is concerned to differentiate himself from the *muḥaqqiqān* or ‘verifiers’ among the Sufis, who as a group are more or less equivalent to the Ibn ʿArabī school broadly conceived.⁴⁵ It must be emphasized in this context that Ṣāʿin al-Dīn did not consider himself to be a Sufi. He maintained friendly relations with several prominent Sufi masters, to be sure, particularly with those who promoted Ibn ʿArabian thought, such as Niʿmat Allāh Valī, Qāsim-i Anvār and Aḥmad Sarṃarqandī; but he states clearly that Sufism as such is inferior in scope and effects to lettrism, his preferred vehicle of thought.⁴⁶ This attitude naturally set him at odds with Jāmī, who strove rather to marry the Ibn ʿArabī tradition with ‘orthodox’ Sufism of the Naqshbandi variety. In particular, Jāmī condemns Ṣāʿin al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī for refusing to live as professional Sufis, preferring rather to be dependent on court patronage.⁴⁷

As we saw in the preceding section, moreover, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn’s embrace of lettrism also made him preternaturally attentive to the form of language in concrete, literary terms. In his commentaries on the staple teaching texts of the Ibn ʿArabī school, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn accordingly has the distinction of being the first to repoeticize texts that had been treated simply as bearers of content by earlier exponents of that school, who effectively discounted the poetical form of these texts as a convenient but otherwise irrelevant shell in their concern to access the pith within.

For the purposes of the present section, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn’s relationship to the Ibn ʿArabī school commentary tradition and his repoeticization of that tradition may be demonstrated through a brief examination of one of his most famous works, the *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Dūrr*, from the

⁴⁴ “Sharaf al-Dīn,” 9.

⁴⁵ In his famous seven-tiered hierarchy, for example, he assigns them to level five, reserving levels six and seven for intellectuals of his own stripe; see §§6.1 and 6.2 above.

⁴⁶ See §3.1 above.

⁴⁷ Bākhazī, *Maqāmāt-i Jāmī*, 106–7; see §8.2.2 below.

standpoint of both form and content. Before doing so, however, it will be useful to survey the development of the Ibn ‘Arabī school commentary tradition on the *Tā’iyya al-Kubrā* of Ibn al-Fāriḍ (d. 632/1235)⁴⁸ in which Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr* figures so prominently.

Virtually upon its completion, the *Tā’iyya* had been adopted by Qūnavī as a favorite teaching text; he would often close the day’s lectures by reciting a line from the poem and then cryptically expounding upon it in Persian, and frequently exhorted his students to memorize it and commentate on it in their duty as Sufis.⁴⁹ Qūnavī’s student Sa’īd al-Dīn Farghānī’s (d. 700/1301) commentaries on the poem, the *Mashāriq al-Darārī*, in Persian, and its Arabic translation and expansion, the *Muntahā l-Madārik*, were the first of their kind,⁵⁰ and represent an important systematization of the Ibn ‘Arabī school tradition.⁵¹ Other stalwarts of the school continued the practice, including ‘Afīf al-Dīn al-Tilimsānī (d. 690/1291) and Dāwūd Qayṣarī (d. 751/1350 or 745/1344). Though not properly a member of the Ibn ‘Arabī school, ‘Izz al-Dīn

⁴⁸ The poem is also commonly known as *Naẓm al-Sulūk*, so named, as the tradition runs, by order of the Prophet himself (Jāmī, *Nafahāt*, 542); this name however was probably given it by Ibn al-Fāriḍ’s grandson, ‘Alī Sibṭ Ibn al-Fāriḍ, with the oldest name apparently being *Naẓm al-Durr* and so appearing in Farghānī’s commentaries (*Dīwān Ibn al-Fāriḍ*, ed. Scattolin, 66 n. 1).

⁴⁹ Jāmī, *Nafahāt*, 542.

⁵⁰ There exists a *Tā’iyya* commentary incorrectly ascribed to Ibn ‘Arabī, precisely because of the identification of the poem with the Ibn ‘Arabī school; this is in fact a commentary by one ‘Abd Allāh Busnavī, called ‘Abdī Efendī (d. 1054/1644), on a *qaṣīda tā’iyya* by Ibn ‘Arabī (GAL, 1/581 (136, 138), GALS, 1/800 (138); the *qaṣīda* is no. 757 in Osman Yahya’s *Répertoire général*, and the commentary, entitled *Qurrat ‘Ayn al-Shuhūd wa-Mir’āt ‘Arā’is Ma’ānī al-Ghayb wa-l-Wujūd*, no. 688 (misprinted as 988); as Yahya notes, this long mystical poem is in the same genre as Ibn al-Fāriḍ’s *Tā’iyya*, although less lyric and more overtly metaphysical.) See also *Kashf al-Zunūn*, 1/cols. 265–66, where Ḥājjī Khalīfa reports that Ibn ‘Arabī is said to have written five notebooks’ (*kurrāsa*) worth commenting on the *Tā’iyya* and given them to Qūnavī, who drew on them in his own lectures on the poem. Discounting this, then, Farghānī’s commentaries are the earliest known to be written on Ibn al-Fāriḍ’s masterpiece and in their wealth and rigor set the standard for those that followed. Perhaps too high a standard: “In the introduction to his commentary on Ibn al-Fāriḍ—especially the Arabic version—he displays a desire to clarify al-Qūnavī’s teachings on these questions to the greatest extent possible. Later figures in Ibn ‘Arabī’s school for the most part ignore much of the complexity of his analysis” (Chittick, “The Five Divine Presences,” 126 n. 24).

⁵¹ Ibn al-Fāriḍ is reputed to have called Ibn ‘Arabī’s *al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya* his poem’s true commentary; this legendary account may be taken as explaining the structural importance of the *Tā’iyya* to the development of the Ibn ‘Arabī school tradition as formulated by Qūnavī and his disciples.

Kāshānī (d. 735/1335)⁵² adopted a so-called ‘monistic’ approach reminiscent of the school in his commentary on the poem, entitled *Kashf al-Wujūh al-Ghurr li-Ma‘ānī Naẓm al-Durr*.⁵³

In initiating a long tradition of written commentary specific to the *Tā’iyya*, Farghānī provided in the process the most coherent and systematic (*mazbūt u marbūt*) exposition of the doctrines of what may be called the Ibn ‘Arabī school—so asserts Jāmī, immensely well-read, making his judgment based on two centuries of prolific output by that school.⁵⁴ As such, Farghānī’s commentaries represent a choice interpretive nexus upon which later thinkers drew in varying degrees in composing their own Arabic or Persian commentaries on not only the *Tā’iyya* but also Fakhr al-Dīn ‘Irāqī’s (d. 688/1289) *Lama‘āt*, itself a commentary on Ibn ‘Arabī’s *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*, as well as commentaries on the *Fuṣūṣ* (or the author’s abridgement thereof, the *Naqsh al-Fuṣūṣ*) directly; this is not to mention Farghānī’s role as a primary source to important Persian poets like Muḥammad Shīrīn Maghribī (d. 810/1408).⁵⁵ Ṣā’in al-Dīn’s commentary

⁵² ‘Izz al-Dīn Mahmūd b. ‘Alī Naṭanzī Kāshānī/Kāshī (*Nafahāt*, 481–82) is primarily known as the adapter to Persian of the ‘*Awārif al-Ma‘ārif*’ of Shihāb al-Dīn ‘Umar Suhrawardī (entitled *Miṣbāḥ al-Hidāya wa-Miftāḥ al-Kifāya*) (Jāmī, *Nafahāt*, 481–82). His *Tā’iyya* commentary is often misascribed to Kamāl al-Dīn ‘Abd al-Razzāq Kāshānī, master to Qayṣarī (Qayṣarī, *The Wine of Love*, xviii n. 21).

⁵³ Homerin, *From Arab Poet*, 29.

⁵⁴ *Nafahāt*, 559; this assessment refers in particular to Farghānī’s theoretical introduction, often used independently as a teaching text due to its unmatched thoroughness and rigor. On Jāmī’s engagement with the tradition, Chittick notes, “Jāmī is more original, and also much more widely read, than most [*Fuṣūṣ* commentators]. He makes active and conscious use of all the major figures of the school back to Qūnawī, as is clear not only in his *Naqd al-nuṣūṣ* ... but also in his other prose works on Sufism and in some of his *mathnawīs*” (“Spectrums of Islamic Thought,” 207 n. 1).

⁵⁵ There are two writers in particular, contemporary with Ṣā’in al-Dīn, who draw extensively on Farghānī’s commentaries. The first is Muḥammad Shīrīn Maghribī (d. 810/1407), of Ammand near lake Urūmiya in Azarbayjan, after ‘Irāqī, Qāsim-i Anvār, and Shabistarī the most important Persian Sufi poet of Ibn ‘Arabī’s school in the late 8th/14th–early 9th/15th centuries (Lewisohn, “Shīrīn Maghribī,” *El*²). His poems, sometimes bilingual, combine a romantic lyricism and imagistic brilliance with exegesis of Ibn ‘Arabī’s doctrines; his very *takhalluṣ*, Maghribī, honors the eastern custom of referring to Ibn ‘Arabī as Ibn al-Maghribī (Chittick, “Ibn ‘Arabī and His School,” 55–56; Jāmī, *Nafahāt*, 613). One of his works is of particular interest here: *R. Jām-i Jahān-numā*, consisting mainly of selections from Farghānī’s *Mashāriq* (Lewisohn, “Shīrīn Maghribī,” *El*²). Maghribī’s treatise or digest was in turn the subject of a number of commentaries, the most notable of them being those of Aḥmad Farzand Mūsā Rishtī, one of Maghribī’s disciples, and ‘Alā’ al-Dīn ‘Alī Mahā’imī of Gujrat, the Indian philosophical commentator on the *Fuṣūṣ* and Qūnawī’s *Nuṣūṣ*. His dependence on the *Mashāriq* in this treatise suggests it as a primary inspiration for his verse more generally (GAL, 1/450 (585.32.5.a), 2/221 (286.4.1); GALS, 1/789, 2/310.4.1). The second is ‘Alā’ al-Dīn Yār-‘Alī Shīrāzī (d. ca. 812–16/1410–14); little is known about his life. His commentary on

likewise depends in the first place upon Farghānī's. The virtues of the *Mashāriq-Muntahā* as a definitive expression of the legacy of Ibn 'Arabī as structured by Qūnavī and further refined and systematized by Farghānī served to firmly secure the *Tā'iyya* as a favorite text of the Ibn 'Arabī school, and ensured that school's domination of the commentary tradition on the poem for the next several centuries; this wedded the two in the minds of partisans and detractors alike.⁵⁶

In keeping with the theme of the present excursus, mention may be made of those criticisms leveled against the commentaries of Farghānī and his successors for their failure to engage with Ibn al-Fāriḍ's poetical text as art, that is, their dismissal of form in the service of theoretical meaning.⁵⁷ Jaroslav Stetkevych suggests, indeed, that such an absence of literary-critical concern is the besetting sin of the medieval Islamic commentary genre.⁵⁸ He identifies Ibn 'Arabī as a particular offender in this regard; a poet himself, and possessed of the theoretical sensitivity to raise the interpretive act out of its classical, simple rigidity, yet in commentating on his own poetry he too succumbs to the weight of tradition and reduces his own poems' multivalent artistry to a series of reductive quid pro quo interpretations. Given such treatment, the poem becomes a mere hollowed out vessel for abstract cargo, unreal as a human beloved's face; the old dichotomy of form and meaning is maintained, but now form,

'Irāqī's *Lama'āt*, itself a commentary/adaptation of the *Fuṣūṣ*, draws on Farghānī and Qūnavī to expound 'Irāqī's text far more than does Jāmī in his commentary on the same, *Ashī'at al-Lama'āt* ('Irāqī, *Divine Flashes*, xvi n. 3); Yār-'Alī Shīrāzī's preferred method of exposition is the quotation of passages from the works of both (Chittick, "The School of Ibn 'Arabī," 514). Assuming it to be a primarily Persian work, this would put the *Mashāriq* as a primary source for his commentary.

⁵⁶ With Ibn Taymiyya and Ibn Khaldūn famously among the latter; see e.g. Chittick, "Farḡānī," *Elr*, and Homerin, *From Arab Poet*, 31. As Chittick notes, "Farghānī found many devotees among the later students of *waḥdat al-wujūd* because, in contrast to Ibn 'Arabī in the *Fuṣūṣ*, he dealt with each point of doctrine in a systematic manner, and in contrast to Qūnavī, he explained each point in detail" (Chittick, "Rūmī and *waḥdat al-wujūd*," 80).

⁵⁷ See Chittick, "Farḡānī," *Elr*. Scattolin, Ḥilmī and Homerin have criticized Farghānī along these lines, although Homerin's criticisms are more nuanced than those offered by the first two scholars; he freely draws on Farghānī's commentaries, among others, in his glosses to his translation of the *Tā'iyya*.

⁵⁸ *The Zephyrs of Najd*, 89-102. His observation takes place in an illuminating subchapter on Ibn al-Fāriḍ, "The Delicate Balancing of a Stubborn Structure."

rather than meaning, must be mistrusted.⁵⁹ As we will see, Ṣā'in al-Dīn is precisely concerned to remedy this imbalance.

Tied prominently to the fortunes of the Ibn 'Arabī school, the *Tā'iyya* commentary tradition's gradual relocation eastwards to Iran during the 8th/14th century had dramatic implications for its form. By mid-century Bābā Ruknā Shīrāzī's (d. 769/1367) commentary on the *Tā'iyya*, most probably in Persian and, if his *Fuṣūṣ* commentary is any indication, the first to quote verses from Jalāl al-Dīn Rūmī's *Masnavī* in support of its points, appears to signal the shift to Persian as the language of choice, while remaining heavily dependent on the Arabic commentaries of Farghānī, 'Izz al-Dīn Kāshānī, and Qayṣarī.⁶⁰

Some sixty-odd years later, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr* becomes the first commentary in this tradition to take a fully poetical approach.⁶¹ Consciously dependent on Farghānī's *Mashāriq* and *Muntahā* and Ibn 'Arabī's *Fuṣūṣ* in its theoretical flights, it also situates the *Tā'iyya* in its larger literary context by the frequent interjection into his discussion of lines of Persian and Arabic poetry, both mystical and profane, from poets pre-Islamic to

⁵⁹ Stetkevych, *The Zephyrs of Najd*, 92-95. He refers to Ibn 'Arabī's *Tarjumān al-Ashwāq*, upon which the Andalusian master wrote his reductive commentary *Dhakhā'ir al-A'lāq*.

⁶⁰ Rukn al-Dīn Maṣ'ūd b. 'Abd Allāh Bayẓāwī Shīrāzī, known as Bābā Ruknā and originally of Bayẓā, a district of Shiraz, was disciple to both 'Abd al-Razzāq Kāshānī and Dāwūd Qayṣarī, as well as to one Nu'mān Kh'ārazmī; like Kāshānī, he had an affiliation with the Suhrawardiyya. He lived and worked in Iṣfahān and was buried in the city's Takht-i Fūlād cemetery; his tomb, continuously the object of devotion, has never suffered defacement, unlike those of his contemporaries (*Nuṣūṣ al-Khuṣūṣ*, ii). His most important work is his commentary on the *Fuṣūṣ*, *Nuṣūṣ al-Khuṣūṣ fī Tarjumat al-Fuṣūṣ*, the first to be written in Persian (Chittick, "The School of Ibn 'Arabī," 518); it was undertaken at the instigation of Nu'mān Kh'ārazmī and completed in 743/1342-43. In it Bābā Ruknā touches upon many of the same points as are discussed by his masters Kāshānī and Qayṣarī in their commentaries on the *Fuṣūṣ*, while at the same time inquiring into other points not previously touched upon. It also appears to be the first commentary on the *Fuṣūṣ* to quote from Jalāl al-Dīn Rūmī's *Masnavī* in support of its arguments, as well as showcasing some of the author's own Persian verse (*Nuṣūṣ al-Khuṣūṣ*, xix). Bābā Ruknā's *Tā'iyya* commentary, *Kashf al-Ghurr fī Naẓm al-Durr*, does not appear to have been especially influential given the paucity of surviving manuscript copies; as it was probably composed in Persian, however, it may be directly dependent on Farghānī's *Mashāriq*.

⁶¹ It is said that he first composed his commentary in Arabic and then, at the behest of friends, translated it into Persian to facilitate their understanding; a passage in his introduction confirms this (SND, xciii; the passage in question is on p. 11). This introduction provides the theoretical basis for his interpretation and comprises one main section (*faṣl*) and 14 subsections (*vaṣl*); the text throughout dwells on the theme of divine love and existence's springing from passion (*ishq*).

contemporary. The edited text of his commentary runs 304 pages; containing some 890 lines of Persian poetry and 212 lines of Arabic, it quotes an average of three lines per page. The Persian poets Ṣā'in al-Dīn favors most are, of course, Niẓāmī, 'Aṭṭār, Rūmī, 'Irāqī, Sa'dī, Amīr Khusraw, and Ḥāfiẓ, as well as Awḥadī Marāgha'ī and Salmān Sāvajī; also quoted, but less frequently, are Khayyām, Sanā'ī, Kamāl al-Dīn Ismā'īl, Kamāl Khujandī, and Ni'mat Allāh Valī; he also quotes a few lines each from a panoply of other Persian poets, such as Firdawsī, Anvarī, Khāqānī, Shabistarī, and Qāsim-i Anvār, as well as Humām Tabrīzī, disciple to Farghānī himself.⁶² The Arabic poets he favors include al-Mutanabbī, Ibn 'Arabī, al-Ḥallāj, and al-Bahā' Zuhayr, and includes as well a judicious sprinkling of verses from such classical sources as Umayya b. Abī l-Ṣalt, Abū Nuwās, Abū l-'Atāhiya, al-Ṣāhib Ibn 'Abbād, and al-Buḥturī, and the early Sufis Rābi'a al-'Adawiyya and Bāyazīd Bisṭāmī; he also quotes 54 lines from other poems by Ibn al-Fārid.⁶³

⁶² Akram Jūdī-Ni'matī, the editor, identifies in a useful appendix some of the Persian and Arabic poets quoted by Ṣā'in al-Dīn. In chronological order, these Persian poets include: Firdawsī (d. 410 or 416/1019 or 1025); Abū Sa'īd b. Abī l-Khayr (d. 440/1049), Sufi shaykh and *rubā'ī* poet; Bābā Ṭāhir (d. ca. 11th cent.); Khayyām (d. ca. 517/1123); Sanā'ī (d. 535/1130); Mahsatī Ganjavī (d. 12th cent.), poetess at the court of the Seljuqs Maḥmūd of Ghazna and Sulṭān Sanjar; Anvarī, the great *qaṣīda* poet (d. ca. 585/1189-90); Khāqānī (d. 595/1199); Ṣāhib-i Fāryābī (d. 598/1201-2), panegyric *qaṣīda* poet; Bābā Afzal Kāshānī (d. ca. 610/1214), one of the greatest masters of the quatrain, mystic, and expositor of peripatetic philosophy; Niẓāmī (d. ca. 613/1217); 'Aṭṭār (d. 618/1221); Kamāl Ismā'īl Iṣfahānī (d. 635/1237), admired panegyrist of the Seljuqid-Khwarazmshahid period and disciple of Shihāb al-Dīn Suhrawardī; Rūmī (d. 672/1273); 'Irāqī (d. 688/1289); Sa'dī (d. 691/1292); Humām Tabrīzī (d. 714/1315), vizier of Azerbaijan under the Mongols and disciple to Sa'īd al-Dīn Farghānī; Maḥmūd Shabistarī (d. between 718-20/1318-21), author of the *Gulshan-i Rāz*; Amīr Khusraw (d. 725/1325); Rukn al-Dīn Awḥadī Marāgha'ī (d. 738/1338), author of the famous *masnavī Jām-i Jam*; Salmān Sāvajī (d. 777/1375); Ḥāfiẓ (d. ca. 792/1390); Kamāl Khujandī (d. 803/1400-1), lyric poet, mystic, and *shaykh al-Islām* in Tabriz; 'Imād al-Dīn Nasīmī (d. 820/1417-8), early Timurid-Ottoman poet and Hurufi mystic; Ni'mat Allāh Valī (d. 834/1430-1), founder of the Ni'matullāhiyya order; Qāsim-i Anvār Tabrīzī (d. 837/1433), mystic, poet (*Anīs ul-'Ārifīn*), leading *dā'ī* of the Ṣafaviyya order and powerful shaykh in Herat. (The editor's attribution of a few lines to Kamāl al-Dīn Vaḥshī Bāfqī (d. 991/1583), panegyrist for Shāh Ṭahmāsp, must be a mistake, as the poet was born a century after Ibn Turka's death; perhaps in the lines concerned Vaḥshī is quoting a poet contemporary to Ibn Turka.) Of the 890 lines of Persian poetry quoted, perhaps two-thirds are identifiable to the above poets; this leaves roughly one-third of the lines unidentified, some of which may be Ṣā'in al-Dīn's and members of his circle, such as Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī and Kātībī.

⁶³ As identified by Jūdī-Ni'matī, the Arabic poets include, in chronological order: Umayya b. Abī l-Ṣalt (d. 7th cent.); Majnūn Laylā (d. 7th cent.); Yazīd b. Mu'āwiya (r. 60-4/680-3, d. 64/683), the second Umayyad caliph; Nuṣayb al-Akbar b. Rabāḥ (d. btw. 108-13/726-31); Bashshār b. Burd (d. late 2nd/8th cent.); Rābi'a al-'Adawiyya (d. 185/801); Abū Nuwās (d. btw. 198-200/813-5); Abū l-'Atāhiya (d. 211/826); Bāyazīd Basṭāmī (d. 261/875 or 234/848); al-Buḥturī (d. 284/897); al-Ḥallāj (d. 309/922); al-Mutanabbī (d. 354/955); Abū Firās al-Ḥamdānī (d. 357/968); al-Ṣāhib Ibn 'Abbād (d. 385/995), vizier under the Buyids; Ibn Sīnā (d. 428/1037) as author of the *'Ayniyya*; Nāṣiḥ al-Dīn al-Arrajānī (d. 544/1149-50); al-Bahā' Zuhayr (d.

For the first time, Ṣā'in al-Dīn puts each verse of the *Tā'iyya* into dynamic relationship with several verses of classical or contemporary Persian and Arabic poetry by mystic masters or master poets, thus constellating simultaneously the literary and the mystico-philosophical universes in which the *Tā'iyya* was seen to be a living text.⁶⁴

In doing so, Ibn Turka was channeling the incipient zeitgeist of the Timurid-Turkmen period, with its impulse toward consolidation of the Perso-Islamic cultural heritage. I noted above that the systematizing trend that emerged in 9th/15th-century Iran, informed by a total attention to form, has long been dismissed as responsible for the decline of Persian literature into a morass of artificiality, resulting in the overwrought dead-end of the *sabk-i hindī* or 'Indian style'; as studies by Losensky and others have shown, however, it was precisely this artificiality that, far from propelling a decline, made possible the invention, integration, and reinvention of the canon, upon which poets drew in increasing formal sophistication.⁶⁵ This was facilitated by the prolific use of *istiqbāl* or *javāb-gū'ī*, the practice of 'answering' or 'welcoming' the poems of one's predecessors or peers as a formal constraint in composition.⁶⁶ The necessary and

656/1258). Out of the 212 lines of Arabic verse quoted, only 92 have been identified by the editor as belonging to these poets, leaving 120 unidentified. Ibn al-Fāriḍ is most quoted at 54 lines, Ibn 'Arabī the second-most at 8, al-Mutanabbī the third-most at 6; quoted from the remaining identified poets are 4 lines of al-Ḥallāj, 3 lines of al-Bahā' Zuhayr, 2 lines each of Abū Nuwās, al-Ṣāhib Ibn 'Abbād, and Rābi'a al-'Adawiyya, and one line each of the rest.

⁶⁴ Ibn Turka's contemporaneity with Ḥāfiẓ should be noted in particular. Moreover, his attention to Kamāl-i Khujandī, Nesīmī, Shāh Ni'mat Allāh Valī and Qāsim-i Anvār show his awareness of the developments taking place in institutionalized Sufism in Iran during his time and suggest his desire to weave such trends into his already grand synthesis of the mystico-theoretical legacy of the commentary tradition with the *Tā'iyya*'s broad literary-critical context; this is characteristic of his program of comprehensive harmonization between revealed religion, mysticism, reason, and the literary arts. Around the same time Muḥammad Shīrīn Maghribī (d. 810/1407) achieved a similar synthesis in his own poetry, maintaining a tension between its purely poetic artistry and the mystical theory of Ibn 'Arabī (as mediated, especially, by Farghānī) it enshrines.

⁶⁵ See Losensky, *Welcoming Fighānī*; Faruqi, "A Stranger in the City" and "'Five (or More) Ways for a Poet to Imitate Other Poets"; Vittor, "The Herat School." In particular, Losensky notes that the assumption that form was the sole focus of the poetic practice of the 9th/15th century willfully ignores its equally total systematizing attention to content (*Welcoming Fighānī*, 164).

⁶⁶ Whence the title of Losensky's study, *Welcoming Fighānī*.

corresponding rise in literary-critical awareness is a feature of the Timurid-Turkmen period, in which the literary salon, the *majlis*, was the center of cultural life in town and court, and literary-critical acumen and poetical talent the surest index of socio-political savvy.

In continuing the Ibn ‘Arabī school *Tā’iyya* commentary tradition, then, Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s *Sharḥ* marries, for the first time, the poem’s mystical content with the purely formal in its status as anthology-as-commentary; by bringing each line of the poem into conjunction with several Persian or Arabic lines of verse, both contemporary and classical, it effectively welds together the two bodies of literature into a single unbroken tradition. This has the effect of transferring the canonicity of the classical Arabic corpus to the not-yet-classical Persian poets such as Ḥāfiẓ (d. ca. 792/1390), Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s earlier contemporary,⁶⁷ while simultaneously integrating the mystico-philosophical as the default interpretive frame for this broadened poetic tradition.

A word should be said about the anthology-as-commentary genre, one of the new hybrid genres of the period.⁶⁸ It first emerges in Mamluk Egypt with Ibn Nubāta’s (d. 768/1366) *Sarḥ al-‘Uyūn fī Sharḥ Risālat Ibn Zaydūn*, treating of Ibn Zaydūn’s (d. 463/1070) *R. Hazliyya*. This was then emulated by Ibn Nubāta’s student al-Ṣafadī (d. 764/1363) in his *Tamām al-Mutūn fī Sharḥ Risālat Ibn Zaydūn*, as well as in his *al-Ghayth al-Musajjam fī Sharḥ Lāmiyyat al-‘Ajam*, on the Seljuq poet Ṭughrā’ī’s (d. 514/1120) famous poem.⁶⁹ Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s familiarity with the new genre doubtlessly dates to his extended residence in Cairo; Ibn Ḥijja al-Ḥamawī (d. 837/1434), the famous *munshī* and poet in Cairo and Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s contemporary, penned the most popular and

⁶⁷ Ṣā’īn al-Dīn makes particularly apposite use of Ḥāfiẓ in his apologies, especially on the theme of imposter Sufis. As noted above, Ṣā’īn al-Dīn is one of first writers to consistently quote Ḥāfiẓ in his works.

⁶⁸ It was noted above that the 8th-9th/14-15th centuries represent the golden age of anthologies. Rather than a sign of a lack of originality, this spate of anthologizing is an index of the dynamic literary culture of the period, which for all its appreciation of ‘classical’ models was obsessed with the contemporary literary pulse (Bauer, “Mamluk Literature,” 122).

⁶⁹ Bauer, “Mamluk Literature,” 113.

comprehensive work of this kind, the *Khizānat al-Adab wa-Ghāyat al-Arab*.⁷⁰ The genre was continued in subsequent centuries by Ibn Maʿšūm (d. 1117/1705), ʿAbd al-Ghanī al-Nābulusī (d. 1143/1731), and al-Ṣalāḥī (d. 1265/1849). Ṣāʾin al-Dīn’s innovation here lies in his application of this hybrid genre to mystical texts.⁷¹

Ṣāʾin al-Dīn’s efforts to wed the mystico-theoretical context of the *Tāʾiyya* (here dependent upon and innovative within the tradition established by Farghānī) with its classical and contemporary literary context were continued a half a century later in Jāmī’s verse translations of the *Tāʾiyya* into both *rubāʿī* and *qaṣīda* forms.⁷² As Jāmī states in his partial commentary on the poem, the *Sharḥ-i Qaṣīda-yi Tāʾiyya*, the *rubāʿī* form is the one most suited to the concise explication of its verses. After a brief grammatical and theoretical discussion, a short summary primarily of Farghānī’s and Ibn Turka’s commentaries, Jāmī translates each verse into a separate *rubāʿī* in language manifestly informed by the commentary tradition; while they are literary by definition, these translations remain more commentary than poetry, and are too free to be considered *istiqbāl*.

Some two hundred years after Farghānī, then, the commentary tradition, in the persons of Ibn Turka and Jāmī, had become very much aware of the *Tāʾiyya*’s formal poetic qualities and recuperated them into its interpretation. While this interpretation is still distinctly mystico-philosophical,⁷³ it achieves a full-bodied literary consciousness such as might satisfy the most

⁷⁰ This work, also known as *Sharḥ al-Badīʿiyya al-Musammā bi-Taqdīm Abī Bakr*, is perhaps the single most useful source for early 9th/15th century literary practice and rhetorical theory in Arabic.

⁷¹ Cf. the prosimetrum genre of texts such as Aḥmad Ghazālī’s (d. 517/1123) *Savāniḥ* and ʿIrāqī’s (d. 688/1289) *Lamaʿāt*.

⁷² These have been published as “*Sharḥ-i Qaṣīda-yi Tāʾiyya-yi Fāriziyya*” (2000) and *Tāʾiyya-yi ʿAbd al-Raḥmān Jāmī* (1997) respectively. Losensky identifies Jāmī as being probably the writer to most fully embrace the whole of the Persianate literary tradition; as such, his “flexible and inclusive” poetic method provided a “comprehensive summation of the literary tradition” (*Welcoming Fighānī*, 170); see also Vittor, “The Herat School,” 854.

⁷³ As, indeed, is the *Tāʾiyya* itself.

disappointed modern critic.⁷⁴

In sum, the commentary tradition on this great Arabic poem became increasingly detached and reductive from its inception to the mid-8th/14th century, at which time its extension to Iran, in the person of Bābā Ruknā, signaled the beginning of an awakening to the poem's formal qualities and the consequent enrichment of interpretation. The seeds of this awakening may well lie in Farghānī's general praise of Ibn al-Fāriḍ's poetic skills, but al-Tilimsānī's defensiveness, 'Izz al-Dīn Kāshānī's thoroughgoing reductionism, and Qayṣarī's brevity preclude any attention to the poem's formal qualities; indeed, 'Izz al-Dīn explicitly divests the *Tā'iyya*'s theoretical content of its poetical form, declaring it nothing less than a sin (*ithm*) to imagine any physicality of reference.⁷⁵ As even this brief overview demonstrates, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's commentary, in the context of this classical anti-poetic interpretive methodology, may be considered a reinception of the tradition so solidly conceived by Farghānī and a reinvention of the genre of mystico-literary commentary.

E.2.1: Ibn Turka on the role of poetry

Before turning to the commentaries on the *Tā'iyya* mentioned above, mention must first be made of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's view on the role of poetry in expressing supernal truths as expressed in the preface to his *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*.⁷⁶ His argument may be briefly summarized as follows:

⁷⁴ Through the efforts of Ibn Turka and Jāmī, moreover, by the beginning of the 10th/16th century Ibn al-Fāriḍ's *Tā'iyya* and *Khamriyya* (or *Mīmiyya*) became choice subjects for the commentating pen of any cultured man of letters with an interest in things mystico-theoretical. An example is Idrīs Bidlīsī (d. 926/1520), sometime *nishānjī* at Sulṭān Ya'qūb Aq Quyunlu's court in Tabriz and historian to the Ottomans; his *Hasht Bihišt*, commissioned by Bāyezīd II, is an ornate piece of historiography in the high Persian literary style on the model of Faẓl Allāh Khunjī-Iṣfahānī's *Tārīkh-i 'Ālam-ārā-yi Amīnī*. Apart from his history and works on *kalām* and *fiqh*, Idrīs Bidlīsī wrote commentaries on Ibn al-Fāriḍ's *Khamriyya* and Ibn 'Arabī's *Fuṣūṣ* (see Ménage, "Bidlīsī, Idrīs," *El'*; and Mehmet Bayrakdar, *Bitlisli İdris*, Ankara, 1991, 35).

⁷⁵ *Kashf al-Wujūh al-Ghurr*, 185/39.

⁷⁶ Cf. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's rather more abstruse discussion on the ontological and epistemological nature of prosody in the final section (4.74) of the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, translated in §7.3.6 above.

The prophetic message is, of course, far too exalted to have need of the beguiling manipulativeness and artistic complexity and ambiguity of poetry, and must be communicated in relatively unvarnished terms to serve its salvific purpose; the three groups that see it as their task to unpack the divine Speech—to wit, philosophers, Sufis, and lettrists—likewise have little use for that medium. Yet poetry, particularly as set to music, is the only truly effective means of raising lesser intellects above the level of mere physical existence. More importantly, the increasing proliferation of mystical poetry that expresses the same supernal truths in such artistically compelling form, exemplified in the first place by Ibn al-Fāriḍ's *Tā'iyya*, heralds a new phase of human development; knowledge of the structure of reality is no longer the sole preserve of the intellectual and spiritual elite.⁷⁷ Ṣā'in al-Dīn drives home this last point by his ironic and ostentatious use of a gorgeous prosimetrical style—precisely that style which, as a lettrist, he claims he should abjure.

Given its intrinsic interest with respect to the topic at hand, I translate here the revelant section from his preface in full:

Boundless praise be to God—who in the very act of selecting out the shoot of being and nonbeing from the garden loam of *God* was coupled it with the seedbed of the loveseeds of *He loves them*, making it spring verdant and fresh through the irrigation of *My mercy encompasses everything* and primed for the flowers and fruits of *they love Him*—and choicest blessings be strewn upon the pure earth of the chosen one—with the name of whose stemming [i.e., *HMD*] the arbor of the standard of praise (*ḥamd*) is denoted and with whose praised (*maḥmūd*) epithets the gilt crescents of the guiding banners of perfection's station are arrayed.

His being become being's very root
Muḥammad's largess ranges far from his tent.⁷⁸

God bless and keep him and his house as perpetually as he is remembered by those who remember, though his mention be neglected by the heedless.

To proceed: It is not hidden from those who research the true reports from transmitters of instances of *God's guidance* and derive sound knowledge from the clear

⁷⁷ On the popularizing ethos of the period see §C.2 below.

⁷⁸ Viz., seeking out its recipients and not having to be sought.

contours of God's *template*⁷⁹ that the fundament of Law, the devices of the Throne, the virtue of Sirius, the prophetic station—the most perfect blessings and prayers be upon its holder—are too exalted for the foot of their concern to tread the path of poetic analogy, and the palace of heaven and threshold of apostleship too inaccessible for the buffeting waves of poetic meter (*baḥr*, sea) to lap but the hem of their height; all the more so the chosen one himself, whose moonrending finger⁸⁰ bears the seal-ring (*khātam*) of supreme rulership's fulfillment (*khatmiyyat*) and whose worlds-shielding shoulder bears the seal-mark (*khatm*) of noble caliphate's apotheosis (*khātamiyyat*)⁸¹—how could the phoenix of his purpose (*himmat*) flit its shadow over such things? *We have not taught him poetry; it befits him not.*⁸²

The bridesmaids of exposition lead this their most beautiful and chaste virgin to the marriage chamber of manifestation, there to present her to those who betroth untouched truths, those who have attained the ranks of the chivalrous and manly and whose powers of apperception are free of impotence or clumsiness (*bī-zawqī*) in their deflowering, with consummate sensitivity, sure knowledge; and these bridesmaids adorn their charge after three fashions:

First are those who tread the paths of rational proofs and are familiar with the byways of intellectual argument; they find the texture of such speech [i.e., poetry] to be unacceptable, constituted as it is of tempting conceits (*mukḥayyilāt*) and manipulative affectations (*mumavvihāt*), and keep their writing naked of lying hyperbole that it be not unadorned with the bangles (*zīvar*) of truth; for they think [poetry] to renege on its promises. There is indeed no doubt but that the skirts of the chamberlains (*iqbāl-khuddām*) of that palace are free of the taint of such things and their expressions untrammelled by the mechanisms of fantasy and similitude (*khayālī, misālī*).

There where signs lose their way
there where imagination bites its finger⁸³

Second are those who seek the rule of gnostic truths (*ḥaqāyiq-i ḥikmī*) and pray the flood of intuitive knowledge (*ma'ārif-i zawqī*); they see that those who would be the standard-bearers of praise, that is those who would establish the divine forms, may perform their office by raising aloft their banner of blessing and sovereignty through disparate forms (*ṣuvar-i mutafarriqa*) according to the exigencies of multiplicity (*kasrat*)—as [the Prophet says]: *Three things from this world of yours were made dear to me*⁸⁴—, in this way discharging their obligation to make known the true unicity [of existence] (*vaḥdat-i ḥaqīqī*)

⁷⁹ Q 30:30.

⁸⁰ Cf. Q 54:1; the splitting of the moon is popularly said to be one of Muḥammad's miracles.

⁸¹ Apparently a reference to the protuding lump on Muḥammad's upper back, said to denote his status as seal of the prophets.

⁸² Q 36:69.

⁸³ Lit., imagination's finger is to its mouth: the conventional sign of *ta'ajjub*. The verse is by Kamāl al-Dīn Ismā'īl Iṣfahānī (d. 635/1237), admired panegyrist of the Seljuqid-Khwarazmshahid period and disciple of Shihāb al-Dīn Suhrawardī.

⁸⁴ This hadith forms the centerpiece of Ibn 'Arabī's chapter on Muḥammad in his *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*, certainly the reference here.

as well as the legal bounds [of behavior] (*aḥkām-i ḥudūd*), as will be discussed elsewhere. Given this necessary premise, which in their case is expressed in words or even individual letters and whatever other signs are inconstruable by human perception, any form of speech composed of hemistichs defined by their rigid craftedness and unifying imagery is not suited to [the dignity of] their office, for no part of such speech can express unicity; thus they do not and cannot produce it. *He speaks not from caprice; this is but a revelation revealed.*⁸⁵

Third are those who read the text of the Tablet and divine the letter symbolism of the divine Address; they consider it manifest that the Lawgiver (according to his saying *I have been given the encompassing words*) clothed in the collected forms of law the aspects of that essence, the various shapes of whose manifestation are seen in the lines of the Throne; under these conditions, the more that essence is hidden, the more it is manifest. For at the level of essence, each form deriving therefrom and perceptible to sight reveals its meaning to each person according to the dictate *All the people knew their drinking-place.*⁸⁶

No one reads the letter I read
no one understands the sign (*ramz*) I understand.⁸⁷

So many subtle meanings are hid in the down on her lip (*khaṭṭ-i yār*)
of which you are unaware, litterateur—but I know them.⁸⁸

The exigencies of proclamation (*tablīgh*) and legislation (*tashrī*) thus preclude the expression of that essence on the level of letterforms through the adducing of poetical proofs (*mushāhid-i shiʿrī kardan*), that its import may be fully understood; for

Show that gorgeous face to everyone
and the rigid sober will convert to the drunkards' creed.

The reins of the [prophetic] speech have therefore of necessity been entrusted to the capable hands of its heirs till that the tongue of time begin inditing *Call out the name of the one you love and spare me your circumlocutions*,⁸⁹ and the shoot of sanctified power (*niḥāl-i vilāyat*) whose bare branches have put forth the leaves of the formal sciences (*ʿulūm-i rasmī*) shed those leaves as no longer necessary, and the various intellectual and traditional arts (*funūn-i aqsām-i ʿaqlī u naqlī*) produced by the proliferation of bodies (*tashʿīb-i afnān-i tan-hā*) irrigated by the water of ineffability (*bī-iʿtibārī*) be wiped from the tablet of the minds of the intelligent.

The perfumes and virtues of the blossoms and fruits of that shoot of power and grace (*dawlat u iqbāl*) having saturated time's nose and palate, in view of this situation wherein

⁸⁵ Q 53:3-4.

⁸⁶ Q 2:60.

⁸⁷ The verse is by Saʿdī (d. 691/1292).

⁸⁸ Kamāl-i Khujandī (d. 803/1401), lyric poet, mystic, and *shaykh al-Islām* in Tabriz.

⁸⁹ The second hemistich of a famous verse by Abū Nuwās, addressing Amīn upon being jailed; the verse in full: *Fa-lā ḍayr^{mn} fī l-ladhdhāti min dūni-hā sitr^{mn} / fa-buḥ bi-smi man tahwā wa-daʿ-nī mina l-kunā* ('There is no sin in pleasures taken in secret...').

Millions of roses abloom yet no song of the nightingale—
what has befallen them, what transpired?⁹⁰

it upbraids the newsprouted in the garden of being. The narcissus having observed this
rears up and calls out

Come and see, if you've a sharp eye—
the land's gravel is all coral and gems

so alerting the world's percipient. The violet swings its head in the dancing ecstasy⁹¹ of
the state *he hears through Me*, chanting

What blackened my days with pain is gone,
my heart's sighs have died away!

so proclaiming the glad advent of blissful intoxication (*sawr-i surūr*) to the isolated and
sorrowful. Every instant the rosebud trots forth with a different face the bride of her
beauty in the park of manifestation, or in other words,

Let fall the leaves of the painter's album:
a branch can make every leaf bloom.⁹²

With impeccable finesse the water-lily casts the prayer-rug of munificence upon the
subtle-waved sea of imagination's waterlike nature (*baḥr-i laṭāfat-amvāj-i khayāl-i āb-misāl*),
making

The time is past when like a delicate flower
my rubyred face was fringed with yellow,
mouth open like a sweetsmiling rose
but heart tight like a bud from pain

the anthem for those who limn visionary forms (*naqshbandān-i šuvar-i misālī*). With a
hundred voices the lily exhorts the heedful in worship's fraternity (*ḥalqa*) and the freeborn
in form's (*šūrat*) khanaqah,

Come sufi, the cup makes a perfect mirror—
see in it the ruby wine's clarity⁹³

uttered in reproachful tones. With consummate taste (*zawq*) the rose from benevolent
mead declaims for the benefit of the miserable occupants of the alley of pain from the
pages of the tome of rare spiritual meanings,

⁹⁰ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *yārī andar kas namī-bīnīm yārān-rā chi shud*.

⁹¹ Lit., at the *samāʿ* session of ecstasy.

⁹² Salmān Sāvajī (d. 777/1375).

⁹³ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *ṣūfī biyā ki āyina-yi ṣāfi-st jān-rā*.

So come—for Moses’s fire has begun to kindle—
hear from his bush the discourse of oneness.⁹⁴

With a thousand songs (*hazār dastān*)⁹⁵ the percipient nightingale explicates all the secrets of supernal realities to the students of the madrasa of meanings:

From atop a cypress branch the nightingale with holy strains
gave last night a lesson on the stations of the spirit.⁹⁶

In *such a season conducive to such passion* when the north wind of virtue blows strong upon the face and the eastern zephyr of youth breezes from the quarter of love, the saying *There is no good in pleasures taken in secret*⁹⁷ proclaims,

The saqi issues the tablecall from his laughing rubyred lips
and pours out wine and sweetmeats for his sops.⁹⁸

And its messmates at the feasthall raise a drunken clamor thereat, singing in tasteful strains,

You’ve learned a secret you’ve long kept from yourself
a dawn has broken forth whose cover of darkness you yourself were.⁹⁹

In short, that which had been jealously guarded by the elite and expressed only in hints and allusions is now paraded before all spectators in the marketplace of proclamation.

How long will you keep pointing out the peak and its two valleys?
The matter’s more obvious than a fire on a hill!¹⁰⁰

Thus are reports of those sweetmeats and that cup heard by the abject denizens of the alley of intuition and the despairing traders in the market of passion, each according to his own lights, such that the coiners at the shop of discernment distinguish between the import of each expression according to *Some of them We prefer in produce to others*;¹⁰¹ they

⁹⁴ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *bulbul zi shākh-i sarv bi gulbāng-i pahlavī*.

⁹⁵ The compound *hazār-dastān* also refers to the nightingale as such.

⁹⁶ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *bulbul zi shākh-i sarv bi gulbāng-i pahlavī*.

⁹⁷ A variation on the first hemistich of a famous verse by Abū Nuwās, the second hemistich of which was quoted above; the verse in full: *Fa-lā ḍayr^{un} fī l-ladhdhātī min dūni-hā sitr^{un}/ fa-buḥ bi-smi man tahwā wa-da‘-nī minā l-kunā* (‘There is no sin in pleasures taken in secret/ call out the name of the one you love and spare me your circumlocutions’).

⁹⁸ ‘Irāqī, ghazal: *ṣalā-yi ‘aysh [‘ishq] ki sāqī zi la‘l-i khandān-ash*.

⁹⁹ Ḥallāj?

¹⁰⁰ The first line of a poem by Abū l-Ḥasan al-Shushtarī (d. 668/1269) or Ibn Sab‘īn (d. 669/1270).

¹⁰¹ Q 13:4.

grant funds to those whose understanding properly accords with the unmediated insights of perfected prophets and saints. And those who wander confused through the deserts of seeking whose delicacy of devotion is hidden deep within them—those who would have otherwise remained errant in the trackless wastes of hopelessness heaped with the veils of darkness and the shrouds of material [things]—through the aid of such expressions of yearning and love-infused words fix the halter of desire about the neck of their souls and are thereby drawn from out the sordid pits of debasement. Those perishing of thirst in the deserts of seeking need no longer despair, for this path is flush with many [writings] of this type ...

Since it is evident that a form stamped with singularity (*ṣūrat-i vaḥdānī-mizājī*) is closer to true oneness and the orderly arrangement of many parts (*tartīb-i ajzā-yi kasīra*) has more harmoniousness (*tanāsub*), [a composition that comprises both] must have the greater [aesthetic] effect (*dar ta'sīr qavī-tar*). For the same reason we explain the concept of beauty (*ḥusn*) precisely in terms of symmetry of members (*tanāsub-i a'zā*). Thus in the arrangement of letters and the composition of words this basic principle establishes that the more its form is arrayed with the ornaments of symmetry and the jewels of orderly disposition (*intizām*), the more resplendent will its necklace of approval be upon people's hearts and the more pronounced its captivating effect on people's sensibilities. Experience offers persuasive support for this claim, for the qadi of the senses, issuing his fatwa of passionate feeling (*vijḍān*), rules categorically that poetry (*naẓm*) accords with our natures to a greater extent than does prose (*naṣr*) and exerts a more profound effect. Likewise, when the composed form of poetry is set to music its effect as received by the ears is different; [poetry] sung with appropriate notes (*naḡhamāt*) imparts a special elevatedness of experience (*zawq*). The more the delicate relations of harmony (*raqāyiq-i tanāsub*) are developed in multiple [and complex] ways, the more powerfully does the tow of beauty draw the sensibilities of the lovecrazed.

Don't loosen the knot in your tress
don't make things difficult for your lovers.

[It will, however, be asked:] Is not the mission of the prophets (peace be upon them) precisely to communicate their message to the widest possible audience? Why then should they have no need of poetry? [I answer:] Because their legislating discourse is distinguished by its sacred power and spiritual beauty: *God-given beauty needs no beautician.*

Beauties are adorned with bangles
but you, bangleless, adorn bangles with your beauty.¹⁰²

Many are the great saints and illuminated scholars who have written texts in this vein and with the aid of their highly-developed intuition and the mediation of overflowing ecstasy promulgated this type of discourse for the benefit of those seeking guidance on the stages of seeking and those awander with the caravans of pain and exhaustion—yet [the verse of] none, it may be said, can match the peerless taste of the winesloshed verses and intoxicating poetry of that verifying master, quarry of the jewel of elegance and bowel of the mine of sanctified power (*valāyat*), Sharaf al-Dīn 'Umar, known as Ibn al-Fāriḍ al-Miṣrī (God sanctify his secret), who without exaggeration may be called a verse-sign from the Sura of the Poets (*Sūrat al-Shu'arā'*),¹⁰³ nay, a sura from the Book that confounds all

¹⁰² Sa'dī, ghazal: *tū az har dar ki bāz ā'ī bidīm khūbī u zibā'ī*.

¹⁰³ Q 26.

imitators among the eloquent ...

Moreover, his truth-disclosing poem, that is, his *qasida* entitled *Naẓm al-Durr*, stands as centerpiece of the necklace of his renowned poetical output. In the fineness of its amorous tone (*taghazzul*) it evokes *necklaces of pearl about the necks of buxom maids*; in the purity of its phrasing and its cultivation of rhetorical devices (*ṣanāyi'-i badī'ī*), each line constitutes a veritable treasurehouse of rare and brilliant examples of internal rhyme (*tarṣī*) and exceptional types of paranomasia (*tajnīs*)—further, its every hemistich a gate letting onto rarities of allusion (*kināyat*) and euphemism (*ta'rīz*) and subtleties of similitude (*mumāṣala*) and balanced distribution (*taqṣīm*).¹⁰⁴ In its encompassing of the pearls of poetical ideas (*durar-i ma'ānī*) it is a vast sea, and a flawless necklace in its incorporation of the ornaments of truth.

I opened a page of his poetry:
secreted speech under its every fold.¹⁰⁵

E.2.2: Select commentaries on Ibn al-Fāriḍ's *Tā'iyya al-Kubrā*

The process whereby the commentary tradition on Ibn al-Fāriḍ's *Tā'iyya al-Kubrā* was repoeticized may be demonstrated by a diachronic presentation of the approaches taken by Farghānī, 'Izz al-Dīn Kāshānī, Qayṣarī, Ibn Turka, and Jāmī.¹⁰⁶ As noted above, Ṣā'in al-Dīn is chiefly responsible for this repoeticization, with Jāmī following modestly in his wake. I translate below their respective discussions of the first verse of the *Tā'iyya* as being representative of each commenatator's approach. The first verse of Ibn al-Fāriḍ's *Tā'iyya* reads:

Saqat-nī ḥumayyā l-ḥubbi rāḥatu muqlat-ī
*wa-ka's-ī muḥayyā man 'anī l-ḥusni jallatī*¹⁰⁷

¹⁰⁴ More specifically, *taqṣīm* refers to a rhetorical device in which a sequence of nouns is followed by a sequence of adjectives that correspond on a one-to-one basis (personal communication with Professor Losensky's; the translation 'balanced distribution' is his).

¹⁰⁵ *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*, 3-10.

¹⁰⁶ The commentaries of al-Tilimsānī and Bābā Ruknā are also not considered here as I have not yet been able access them. While al-Tilimsānī's commentary, reportedly a paraphrase of Farghānī's, does not promise to be vital to this study, Bābā Ruknā's commentary may well represent an important turning point, as suggested above. It should also be noted that al-Būrīnī's (d. 1024/1619) grammatical commentary, paired with that of al-Nābulusī in modern editions, has occasion to note Ibn al-Fāriḍ's direct dependence on various of his predecessors, e.g., al-Buḥturī (d. 284/897).

¹⁰⁷ *Dīwān* (ed. Scattolin), 66; meter is *al-ṭawīl*.

The palm of my eye served me heady lovewine
my cup a face of one beyond beauty.¹⁰⁸

1. Farghānī, *Mashāriq al-Darārī*, 191-92:

Heady wine (*ḥumayyā l-ka's*), meaning the first rush of intoxication from the cup; palm (*rāḥa*), meaning the hand (*kaff*), plural *rāḥ*; face (*muḥayyā*), meaning countenance (*wajh*).

By which the poet means: At first in partaking of love's wine and the drunkenness of passion (*āshiqī*) my vision (*naẓar*) was my saki and my cup the face of my beloved, but not in such a way that it was delimited by any physical (*ḥissī*) or spiritual (*rūḥānī*) face so that such beauty—harmoniousness of parts, of qualities, and of character—[as made me drunk] could be attributed to it; it was rather that which might manifest (*ẓuhūr*) in every face without its manifestation in a locus (*maẓhar*) or a face being tied thereto. It is apparent existence (*ẓāhir-i vujūd*) as the beauty and face of God, with His essence (*zāt*) necessitating their [unchanging] eternality and perpetuity (*davām u baqā*), just as He said: *Yet still abides the Face of thy Lord, majestic, splendid* (Q 55:27), that is, with respect to its absolute interiority (*min ḥaythu bāṭini-hi l-muṭlaq*), majestic in its univocal manifestation outspread over all engendered beings (*munbaṣiṭa 'alā l-kā'ināt*). So when I behold a physical face (*ṣūrat-i ḥissī*), I see it to be a locus and mirror (*maẓhar u āyīna*) for manifest existence in [the latter's] true singularity (*bi vaḥdati-hi l-ḥaqīqīyya*) ... That which gives one to perceive such absolute beauty constitutes an existential mystery (*sirr-i vujūdī*), conjuncted with the relative particle (*man*, who) [of the verse] and deriving therefrom (*bi man muẓāfast u far'-i ū-st*). It is a property of the essence of a branch (*far'*) that in the absence of any hindrance (*mānī*) it inclines to its root (*aṣl*); thus the perception (*yāft*) of branch and root, the awareness (*shu'ūr*) of their branchhood and roothood (*far'īyyat u aṣliyyat*) upon which such an essential inclination (*mayl-i zātī*) is based, comes about by means of my first glimpse [of this beautiful face], this glimpse attaching to this face I perceive as the mirror of his-her absolute beauty (*āyīna-yi jamāl-i muṭlaq-ash*).

Thus vision (*naẓar*) is the saki serving the wine of love (*sharāb-i 'ishq*), and his-her face the cup for that wine; the [resulting] drunkenness (*mastī*) signifies being overcome by love's effects (*ghalaba-yi aḥkām-i 'ishq*). [The poet] means by this love essential love (*maḥabbat-i zātī*), not love dependent on qualities (*maḥabbat-i ṣifātī*); yet the manifestation of the property and attractive bond (*ḥukm u ta'alluq*) of this essential love occurs in the physical world (*'ālam-i ḥiss*), given its dependence (*mawqūf*) on a physical face. Thus vision is necessarily the instrument (*ālat*) enforcing this attractive bond (*ta'alluq*), not that upon which vision the root of love is dependent. But God is the only guide.

2. Farghānī, *Muntahā l-Madārik*, 146-50:

Serving drink (*saqy, suqyā*): giving someone something to drink; providing with drink (*isqā'*): providing for someone drink from which they may serve themselves. Both are transitive verbs. Heady wine (*ḥumayyā*): a term for wine denoting the flush of the first

¹⁰⁸ Trans. in Homerin, 'Umar Ibn al-Fāriḍ, 75.

stages of drunkenness (*sawrat ḥarārati-hā*) and the overpowering effect such has on the mind and faculties, serving indeed to obliterate (*ifnāʾ, talāshī*) them. Similarly, wine is termed *khamr* for its veiling effect on the intellect, or again *rāḥ* in that it is imbibed by aid of the hands (*rāḥ*, sing. *rāḥa*, palm).¹⁰⁹ Love (*ḥubb*) is an inclination toward something on the basis of its perceived or imagined perfection, as in the classical phrase, “the camel lay down,” being aggrieved and keeping its place as though inclined toward it, seeking relief (*rāḥa*) therein. The eyeball (*muqla*): the eye’s interior (*bāṭin al-ʿayn*). Cup (*kaʿs*): a vessel containing wine (*sharāb*), as everyone calls it in the singular *kaʿs*; the phrases “empty *kaʿs*” and “I drank a *kaʿs*” are also used, although [technically] an empty cup is called *qadah* rather than *kaʿs*, with the *tās* (flagon) being a larger vessel containing wine from which one ladles with the *kaʿs*, a smaller vessel, with the *qadah* being smaller yet as that into which the saki pours from a *kaʿs*, thereby serving drink:

We drank [the wine] from *tāses*, *kaʿses* and *qadahs*

Face (*muḥayyā*): the visage in the sense of it being that which is greeted (*tahīyya*) upon meeting, used of rational beings (or of nonrational beings only by extension) in this form for singular and dual and as either masculine or feminine. Beauty (*ḥusn*): harmoniousness and proportionality (*mulāʾama, tanāsub*), of four categories according to popular usage. The first is physical (*ḥissī*), referring to harmoniousness between parts and members with respect to their form and coloring and their liveliness and freshness. The second is rational (*ʿaqlī*), referring to concepts (*maʿānī*) comprehended by the intellect such as justice, mercy, concord (*wifāq*). The third is spiritual (*rūḥānī*), concerned primarily with morals (*akhlāq*). The fourth is Shariʿa-based (*sharʿī*), concerned with religious matters such as observance of the Lawgiver’s command, regular attendance at congregational prayer (*luzūm al-jamāʿa*), right doctrine (*iʿtiqād ṣaḥīḥ*), and so on. The opposite of all such types of beauty is ugliness (*qubḥ*).

For God and God’s folk there exists a fifth category of beauty beyond that defined by popular understanding based on the above four categories; this fifth category of beauty has no corresponding concept of ugliness, as it is based upon the property (*ḥukm*) of the Singular Real (*al-muwahḥad al-ḥaqq*) and His attributes. It is this fifth category that is meant by the verse’s phrase, *one beyond beauty*; that is, beyond the conventional meaning of beauty according to the four categories. That a thing is beyond another or transcends it means that it is too exalted and too great to admit of association (*iḍāfa*) with that other thing or its qualities and characteristics (*awṣāf, khawāṣṣ*). Throughout this ode the beloved (*maḥbūb*) is identified as feminine (*anti*) in accordance with high Arabic style (*uslūb al-ʿarab al-ʿarbāʾ*), in which the beloved only occurs as female; or for the purpose of glorifying the [masculine] beloved by only mentioning him with honorific reference to his presence (*ḥaḍra*), [a feminine noun], thereby honoring him and reverencing his mention ...¹¹⁰

Know that the manifestations (*tajalliyāt*) that appear to God’s folk are of three categories (*qism*), those relating to act (*fiʿliyya*), those relating to name (*ismiyya*) and those relating to essence (*dhātiyya*). Proper to each are various paths (*turuq*), resorts (*mawārid*) and levels (*marātib*), innumerable except in their broad outlines.

[That concerning us here is] the active manifestation (*tajallī fiʿlī*), which appears when the soul’s veils have thinned to the point of translucence (*riqqa, shufūf*) through the

¹⁰⁹ Lane has the etymology of *rāḥ* as being rather wine’s effect of making the drinker sprightly, lively, and generous.

¹¹⁰ I drop here a short syntactical description.

removal of the effect of its deviations (*āthār al-inḥirāfāt*) [from the Shari‘a], including their expurgation from its faculties and attributes, and when the heavy weight of sinfulness (*athqāl awzār*) in hopes and dreams, habits and attachments, has been lifted from its shoulders. [This happens] either simply through [divine] solicitude and an experience of ecstasy (*‘ināya wa-jadhba*) [more than] equal to the acts of man and jinn (*tuwāzī ‘amal al-thaqlayn*), or through persistence in *dhikr*, or by actualizing the stations of submission (*maqāmāt islāmiyya*) and performance of their requirements and passing beyond basic premises of belief (*ta‘addī ba‘ḍ al-maqālāt al-īmāniyya*) until such time as the property of oneness and equity (*waḥda, ‘adāla*) overcomes it, counteracting the thronging force of deviant properties (*kathrat al-aḥkām al-inḥirāfiyya*) and the [mere] enactment of human and animal considerations. Then appears the effect of the relative, interior heart’s oneness in the soul’s true essence (*ḥaqīqat al-nafs*), i.e., the quality of its equitable management of the category (*ḥukm*) of sensory forms with both the category of life-meaning (*ma‘nā l-ḥayāt*) and the category of the spiritualized spirit (*rūḥ rūḥāniyya*) with which is associated the governance of nature and form (*tadbīr li-l-mizāj wa-l-ṣūra*).

The effect of such oneness and equity then obtains in all the fundamental attributes (*ṣifāt aṣliyya*) and loci of manifestation (*maẓāhir*) associated with the soul, such as sight, hearing, speech and intellect. When the wayfarer (*sā‘ir*) [subject to this process] then sees a thing with his sight filtered (*munṣabigh*) through the property of this oneness and equity, overcoming as it does the properties of multiplicity and deviation (*aḥkām al-kathra wa-l-inḥirāfāt*), that thing seen can only appear beautiful, harmonious and measured (*ḥasan^{an} mulā‘im^{an} mu‘tadil^{an}*), just as one who is jaundiced and overcome by a bilious yellowness (*al-mādda al-ṣafrāwiyya*) affecting his eyes sees nothing but it has a yellow tint. Particularly [to our purpose here], when the object beheld by such a wayfarer¹¹¹ is a person who moves with physical or spiritual beauty¹¹² and its manifestation is most perfect,¹¹³ his vision of [that person] coincides with his [faculty of] sight filtered by oneness and equity in the [perception of] its object’s beauty, a true, unified and pure attentiveness (*tawajjuh ṣaḥīḥ waḥdānī khālīṣ*) to the presence of his sought-for Beloved (*maḥbūb, maṭlūb*), God most high and holy.

It may so happen that by means of such beauty the act of God, obtaining in every cause and effect (*sabab wa-musabbab*), appears to him nakedly and above embodiment (*tajarrud*), and the oneness of the act of God is revealed to him by way of his relative heart (*qalb nisbī*), without however the true Agent (*al-fā‘il al-ḥaqīqī*) God manifesting to him. This is exemplified by one who sees the form of a puppeteer behind the conjured forms (*ṣuwar khayāliyya*) [of his puppets]; he sees [the puppeteer’s] acts—movements and pauses—apparently issuing from the solid forms [of the puppets], as issuing in fact from the man behind the curtain (*mustatir bi-sitārati-hi*) because of the transparency (*shufūf*) of that separating [such acts] from the doer of those acts that are seen and supposed to be issuing from the [puppets’] solid forms; thus the viewer for whom the curtain is transparent [in this way] sees the act of the agent without seeing the agent himself. It is likewise the case here: when his veils become thin and transparent he sees the unified act of God without seeing the Agent. This is witnessing (*shuhūd*) by way of the eye of certainty (*‘ayn al-yaqīn*), rather than with certain knowledge (*‘ilm al-yaqīn*) tied to the totality (*al-kulliyya*) [even] with the presence of the veil (*bi-ḥāl al-ḥijāb*) or with certain reality (*ḥaqq al-yaqīn*)

¹¹¹ *Sā‘ir al-nāẓir* I read here as *al-sā‘ir al-nāẓir*, pending access to dependable manuscripts.

¹¹² *Mukhtaṭiyy^{an} bi-khaṭwat al-ḥusn al-ṣūrī aw al-ma‘nawī*.

¹¹³ *Kāna jtilā’u l-ḥusni thumma atammu wa-akmalu*.

dependent upon the witnessing of the Agent's manifestation (*tajallī*) by way of His names and attributes or by way of His essence (*dhāt*).

By means of this witnessing [with the eye of certainty], then, the wayfarer's resolve (*ṭalab*) is strengthened and increased in earnestness for the journey and his attentiveness in power, at which point the singular, active manifestation witnessed in the guise of singular (*waḥdānī*) beauty associated with the object [of the wayfarer's witnessing] at first glance exerts (*jadhb*) an effect of true, fundamental love operative in all things and hidden in the essence (*ḥaqīqa*) and innermost heart (*sirr*) of the wayfarer, rousing him and impelling him on this journey. This effect [of love] appears from his interior being (*bāṭinu-hu*) and attracts him to his attractor, this same active manifestation and its oneness and equity, that appears in the form of his object's beauty. Thus appears the love effect indicated by His saying, *Till I love him*—or rather, *Till I make appear* a specific effect of the essence of love (*ḥaqīqat al-ḥubb*) (rather than its entity) indicated by His saying, *And when I love him*. The entity (*'ayn*) of love only appears at the moment of manifestation through the [divine] names or essence in the essential, pure and godfearing heart.

For the poet, the object upon which this love effect is dependent (*muta'alliq*), expressed by his phrase *It served me heady lovewine*, is this very same active manifestation, but by way of absolute beauty (*al-ḥusn al-muṭlaq*), which relates to all loci of manifestation equally. This absolute beauty is here expressed in his phrase, *My cup a face of one beyond beauty*, that is, the presence of my vision's object—that upon which my love is dependent—transcended limited (*muqayyad*) beauty as it is commonly understood and experienced. That upon which his love is dependent was thus not this same active manifestation with respect to any limited beauty [lest it be thought] his love might attach itself to any specific, limited object, as he indicates in the following verse.

Those who experience this active manifestation and its consequent love attachment are of various kinds according to the differences in their preparedness (*isti'dād*). For some, their limited preparedness (*quṣūr isti'dādi-hi*) arrests them with a specific form, such that the active manifestation cannot occur to them except through the intermediation (*ḥaythiyya*) of that form; their love becomes attached and limited to that form, and they cannot pass beyond specific forms [thereafter] as long as they have opportunity to move from one to the next. [The active manifestation] obtains to them only in a specific object with the bond of attachment (*ḥabl tashabbuth*) persisting till the end of their life. For others, the power of their preparedness allows them to pass beyond the delimited particular (*al-mu'ayyan al-muqayyad*) to the undelimited absolute, although this happens only by means of their first being arrested by an accident (*tawaqquf li-'ārid*); they pass beyond it when that accident eventually departs. It may be that such an obstruction (*'awāq*) faces them multiple times until they rid themselves of the bond and ascend (*taraqqī*) to the absolute vision of this manifestation (*iṭlāq ru'yat hādihā l-tajallī*) in every object. Some ascend to such absolute [vision] (*al-iṭlāq*) with great dispatch with a slight amount of distraction (*tawaqquf*) in the process, as with the case of Abraham (*al-khalīl*); others in their perfect preparedness pass beyond [such objects] and ascend with the utmost speed like a flash of lightning without the slightest pause or let, like those possessed of intuitive tasting (*dhawq*). *His eye swerved not, nor swept astray* (Q 53:17): the eyes [of the latter] do not swerve to witness any delimited particular (*muqayyad muta'ayyin mu'ayyan*) for an instant, nor do their hearts or their love sweep astray even momentarily to cognizance of the traces or any other object (*al-aghyār*). As said the Prophet, *Were I to take a bosom friend* (*khalīl*) *I would have chosen Abū Bakr; but [although] he is my brother and companion, God has taken [me], your companion, as His bosom friend—[and so I am unable to take Abū Bakr as my bosom friend]*, indicating a disavowal of precisely this delimitation (*taqayyud*) and an affirmation of instant ascent to the vision and love of absolute beauty.

Says the poet, *My cup a face of one beyond beauty*, [a phrase which together with] the following verse expresses just this intuitive tasting. Given that it is in love's property to burn away the veils of differentiating judgment (*al-aḥkām al-imtiyāziyya*), so removing them from the lover, [the poet here] associates with love such heady wine (*ḥumayyā*)—that wine (*qahwa*) characterized by great warmth and intoxicating power—and [its ability to] do away with the intellect's and the senses' control (*ifnā'u ḡuhūri aḥkāmī l-'aqli wa-l-ḥiss*). Thus he says, *Heady lovewine*.

To paraphrase the verse: The saki of my glance (*naẓra*) served me the wine of love, wine characterized by great warmth and the rush of intoxication (*sawra*), in a beautiful form, [that is], in the cup of that beautiful form's countenance (*tal'a*). Immediately upon seeing this countenance I found it a locus (*maẓhar*) for the unitive, active manifestation associated with His absolute beauty (*jamāl*) and His universal beauty (*ḥusnu-hu l-'āmm*) comprising every act (*maḥūl*), with both His perfect beauty (*jamāl kāmil*) and His universal beauty (*ḥusn shāmil*) being associated with the presence of the All-merciful (*al-ḥaḍra al-raḥmāniyya*). [The presence of the Merciful in turn] transcends delimitation (*taqayyud*) by delimited beauty as it is commonly experienced, with its corresponding ugliness. Thus my drunkenness (*nashwa*) comes from the wine of love absolute in its attachment (*qahwat al-maḥabba al-muṭlaq ta'alluqi-hā*) and not specific to delimited drink dependent upon its attributes and effects bibbed from any delimited, particular cup.

3. 'Izz al-Dīn Kāshānī, *Kashf al-Wujūh al-Ghurr li-Ma'ānī Naẓm al-Durr*, 182-85/37-39:¹¹⁴

... Every [instance of] beauty (*jamāl*) has a face wherein it manifests. The face of essential beauty (*wajh jamāl al-dhāt*) is its undelimited existence (*wujūd muṭlaq*), the mirror (*mir'āt*) of essential and absolute beauty. The face of attribute-dependent beauty (*wajh jamāl al-ṣifāt*) is its relative existence (*wujūd muḍāf*), the mirror of attribute-dependent beauty. The face of active beauty (*jamāl al-af'āl*) is its delimited existence (*wujūd muqayyad*), the mirror of beauty (*jamāl*) delimited by acts (*muqayyad bi-l-af'āl*) and referred to as beauty (*ḥusn*). ... *My cup the face of one beyond beauty* indicates that [the poet] is lover to the essence through witnessing its beauty, given that only [the essence] can transcend beauty through its holiness, free (*nazāha*, *quds*) of the stigma of correspondence (*waṣmat al-munāsaba*). This indication supports the term *ḥumayyā*'s connotation of power and forcefulness (*quwwa*, *ishtidād*), for overwhelming drunkenness (*shiddat al-sukr*) particularly characterizes essential love. The verb “transcend” (*jalāla*) is in the feminine because the term essence (*dhāt*) is feminine; it is not referred to explicitly here so as to defer to its greatness, properly veil its beauty,¹¹⁵ and observe the niceties of amorous dalliance. Beware lest you imagine that the poet here has taken a [mere] woman as his beloved and indited these words about her! And beware lest you suppose that by wine he means other than what I

¹¹⁴ Although 'Izz al-Dīn Kāshānī's discussion of the first verse occupies two pages, the section chosen for translation here aptly demonstrates his quid pro quo interpretive method; as noted above, it may be seen that he brings to the table an explicit repulsion to things physical and, by extension, things formal. In his zeal to exonerate divine beauty and love of its human forms, he does violence to the verse's meaning and invalidates the notion that human beauty acts as a mirror to the divine; as an interpretive position it is also clearly outside the Ibn 'Arabī school.

¹¹⁵ A variant has *khāl*, beauty-mark, for *jamāl*.

have discussed—beauty and love! Such supposition would be a sin (*ithm*) as is only committed by those who have no understanding of the words of the masters of intuitive tasting (*arbāb al-dhawq*)

4. Qayṣarī, *Sharḥ Qayṣarī*, 7:¹¹⁶

That is: The palm of my eye's pupil (*insān 'ayn-ī*) served me the wine of love (*sharāb al-maḥabba*), with the circumstantial phrase (*ḥāl*) [governed by the conjunctive] meaning that the cup [in which] that wine [was served] was the face of one who transcended and was exalted (*ta'ālā*) above beauty (*ḥusn*).

5. Ibn Turka, *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*, 37-39:

Considering true love (*'ishq-i ḥaqīqī*) to be the feasthall's saki and as such the locus of manifestation and making-manifest (*zuhūr u izhār*), the source of perception and making-perceptible (*shu'ūr u ish'ār*)—receptivity's (*qābiliyyat*) primacy leading inexorably to union (*jam'iyyat*)—, it becomes the means whereby the cups of the beloved's coquetry are quaffed and the flagons of her perfect beauty drunk, to which love's flush (*ḥumayyā ḥubb*) is an allusion; at each instant the human eye's (*'ayn-i insānī*) faculty of sight—the eye's pupil (*insān-i 'ayn*) being manifestation's aperture (*ḥadaqa*), nay, the spring (*'ayn*) feeding the fruit of the tree of being's garden (*ḥadīqa-yi vujūd*)—exerts itself in this office.

Eye shows heart the beloved's image (*ḥikāyat*)
and has no view to keeping it from falling in love.¹¹⁷

It is a light compared to which the sun (*nayyir-i a'zam*), though lord of the realm of manifestation, is at this level but a servant in attendance at its court. The subtle realities have been dressed like brides in gross physicality (*malābis-i kaṣāyif-i jismānī*) and material substance (*mavādd-i hayūlānī*) for the purpose of realizing union (*jam'iyyat*), first decked out through its capable services with the jewelry of colors and tones (*aẓvā'*), then presented in the eyes' bazaar on the bridal throne of declaration (*i'lān*) till that the perceptive among them leads these realities, relative-singular of form (*ḥay'atī vaḥdānī-yi nisbī*) and essential-collective of image (*ṣūratī 'aynī-yi ijtimā'ī*), to the courtyard of reception (*qabūl*) with the hand of its diffusive, all-embracing rays, there to present them for review by the chamberlains of the august palace of the heart.

I'll complain no longer about my shredded heart
since my pain's my eye's fault in all;
this passion wouldn't've sent my heart into such straits

¹¹⁶ Qayṣarī's brief and philologically-minded commentary often offers a highly condensed summary of Farghānī; the passage translated is somewhat atypical in its lack of theoretical concern.

¹¹⁷ Sa'dī.

had my eye not seen such glory before it.¹¹⁸

In speaking of King Love (*salṭanat-panāh 'ishq*) [the poet] allows for the transcendence of the singular outward form (*ṣūrat-i vaḥdānī-yi vajhi*) (free of all qualifiers and alluded to by the term face (*muḥayyā*)) above that relative collective form (*hay'at-i majmū'ī-yi nisbi*) [assumed by subtle realities] (expressed here by the term beauty (*ḥusn*)).

Spake he Reality—and heard himself that speech
showed himself—and saw himself his face.¹¹⁹

[The poet] does not privilege here the faculty of sight but considers it but one sense among others in the act of mediation, rather privileging the faculty of hearing—does this not imply a non-specificity of form (*bī-mukhaṣṣaṣī-yi ṣūrat*) [so perceived]? For however much the other senses may participate in the apperception of entifications' forms (*ṣuvar-i ta'ayyūnāt*) and the extrapolation (*iṣāl*) of that underlying reality therefrom, only [sight] can truly grasp that singular-collective outward image of which all images are the expression. Most senses grasp only bodily shapes (*ṣuvar-i jasmānī*), with material substances empty and withdrawn from the subtleties of spiritual bonds (*laṭāyif-i nisab-i rūḥānī*) and the hidden realities of meaning (*maknūnāt-i ḥaqāyiq-i mā'ānī*); the rational faculty itself, within whose compass perceived objects (*muta'allaqāt, mawzū'āt*) certainly fall insofar as it is informed by all the senses, still remains incapable of comprehending them as they should be comprehended—[*Not every protected knowledge is divulged*]/ *nor can everything gazelles' eyes dictate be transmitted*. Thus given sight's [superior] apperception of all such objects—in both their spiritual-divine (*rūḥāniyya, ilāhiyya*) and physical-existential (*jusmaniyya, kiyāniyya*) aspects, together with the singularity of their essential unicity (*aḥadiyyat jam'iyyati-hā l-dhātiyya*), the principle (*mabda'*) from which all forms arise—, whenever the conveyance and partaking of the winecup is spoken of it is this faculty that should be privileged.

Only a nightingale knows the measure of a rose yet to bloom—
not all who scan bookleaves understand them.¹²⁰

Although the faculty of hearing has a wider compass of perception and, [like the eye], operates on both physical and spiritual planes (*ṭarafayn*), precisely by reason of its bias toward the spiritual and its tendency toward aloof sublimity (*tanazzuh u taqaddumī rutabī*) it is incapable of accurately rendering a form in its fullness, the mechanics of which were touched upon in the preface. Since it is the nature of comprehensiveness (*jāmi'iyyat*) to be the principle underlying all forms and the source of their essential receptivity (*qābiliyyat*) [to attributes], and given the fact of hearing's bias toward the spiritual and transcendent singlemindedness (*vaḥdat-i tanazzuh-nishān*), its status as a medium is in every case second to that of sight; this order is thus observed in [Ibn al-Fāriḍ's] poem. This also explains why

¹¹⁸ A quatrain by Kamāl al-Dīn Ismā'īl.

¹¹⁹ *Khūd guft ḥaqīqat u khūd ashnīd / vān rūy ki khūd nimūd khūd dīd*. This line from 'Irāqī's (d. 688/1289) *Lama'āt* appears in its turn to be a quote from Awḥad al-Dīn Kirmānī (d. 635/1238).

¹²⁰ Ḥāfiz, ghazal: *ṣūfī/ārīf az partav-i may rāz-i nihānī dānist* ('The sufi scries secrets occult in wine's glint').

[the poet] is obliged to use the feminine in every reference to the beloved.¹²¹

Since the intoxication of ‘love’s flush’ (*ḥumayyā ḥubb*) (rising from the coverts of potentiality to the stage of actuality by means of sight) severs external relationships (*nisab-i khārījī*) and does away with apparent multiplicity (*kasrat-i vahmī*) and the distinguishing properties (*aḥkām-i imtiyāzī*) [of objects], this resulting in the emergence of the true unicity (*vaḥdat-i ḥaqīqī*), in every case the point of reference of such acts of disassociation (*marja’-i ān ta’sīrāt*) is absolute unicity (*vaḥdat-i muṭlaqa*), expressed here by the term face (*muḥayyā*). The relative distinction (*tamāyuzī nisbī*) between [objects] according to the simple relationship [expressed by the verse],

Saki, drinking partner, wine, tavern are one,
candle, candlestick, flame, moth are one

and represented by the exact equivalence and relative distinction which the letters of *ḥumayyā* (flush) have with *muḥayyā* (face), references precisely this point.

6. Jāmī, *Sharḥ-i Qaṣīda-yi Tā’iyya-yi Fāriziyya*, 410:

The cup’s heady wine (*ḥumayyā l-ka’s*): the first rush of intoxication (*awwal sawrati-hā*). Palm (*rāḥa*): hand (*kaff*). Face (*muḥayyā*): countenance (*wajh*). Transcend (*jalāla*): ascend [beyond] (*irtifā*).

By heady lovewine is meant love of the [divine] essence (*maḥabbat-i zātī*). Given that it may be that the manifestation (*zuhūr*) of this spiritual [act] (*ma’nā*) assumes a form through the witnessing of absolute beauty in physical, existential loci (*maẓāhir-i kawnī-yi hissī*), such a transfer (*ḥavālat*) is effected through the medium of sight (*ālat-i baṣar*). By face is meant apparent existence (*ẓāhir-i vujūd*) in its true oneness (*bi-waḥdati-hi l-ḥaqīqīyya*), i.e., absolute beauty, the face of God, in its essentially necessary eternality and perpetuity (*davām u baqā*). By the relative pronoun (*mawṣūl ma’a ṣilati-hi*)¹²² is meant God’s essence (*zāt*) with respect to its undelimitedness (*iṭlāq*), that is, the reality of existence (*ḥaqīqat-i vujūd*) without reference to any delimitation by a particular.¹²³ Thus [the poet] disassociates from his Beloved that beauty which is rooted in multiplicity (*kasrat*) and delimited by the realm of spirits (*‘ālam-i arvāḥ*).

To paraphrase: In bibbing the wine of love my own vision (*naẓar*) was my saki and my cup (*jām*) the beloved’s face (*rū-yi dil-ārāmī*). [His-her] essence with its exalted attributes (*zāt-i muta’ālī-yi ṣifāt-ash*) transcends any relation to [mere] beauty, which consists of harmoniousness of attribute and character (*mulāyamat-i awṣāf u akhlāq*) and of

¹²¹ This argument is closely related to Ṣā’ in al-Dīn’s unprecedented privileging of the written form of the letter, proper to sight, in his lettrist thought. As he contends in the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, vision is the only sense that when confronted with multiple conflicting stimuli does not denature them, given its relation to light as the principle of being; likewise, the written form of the letter is the most balanced, comprehensive and stable, and hence the appropriate vehicle for the occult effusions of the Imams and the ancients (section 2 preface, summarized in §7.2 above).

¹²² I.e., the *man* or elided “who” in *The face of one [who is] beyond beauty*.

¹²³ *Min ghayri ‘tibāri taqayyudi-hi bi-shay’in mina l-ta’ayyunāt*.

proportionality of parts and members (*munāsabat-i ajzā u a‘zā*).¹²⁴
[The verse interpreted as] quatrain:

First thing today I was so drunk as—don’t ask how
ecstatic with lovepain for my idol’s face—don’t ask how
my saki-eye having served me lovewine
from the circulating cup of my beloved’s face—don’t ask how.¹²⁵

¹²⁴ Precisely Farghānī’s phrasing.

¹²⁵ Cf. also *Tā’iyya-yi Jāmī*, 65: *Khūrdam sharāb-i ‘ishq bi chashm-am zi ṭal’atī/ ki ḥusn-i ū bayān na-shavad bā ‘ibāratī* (‘I drank with my eye lovewine from a face/ whose beauty is beyond expressing’).

CHAPTER 8

Ibn Turka vs. Sufis and Hurufis

8.1: Ibn Turka's view of Hurufism

As the foremost lettrist thinker of early 9th/15th century Iran, then, what was Ṣā'in al-Dīn's view of the Ḥurūfiyya? Rather surprisingly, Ṣā'in al-Dīn does not refer to Faḡl Allāh Astarābādī and his followers by name anywhere in his lettrist works, perhaps not wishing to dignify them with such recognition. The only time he clearly refers to the Ḥurūfiyya is in his second apology, written between ca. 832-35/1429-32, where they are described only as “the ringleaders of depravity and sedition (*daftar-i fasād u āshūb*)”; I will examine this passage in §8.3 below. It would seem, however, that he does allude elsewhere to the group generically and with patent hostility as one among several messianic Sufi movements characterized by antinomianism and worldly ambition. He confesses himself particularly incensed at such groups' lack of intellectual rigor; in the introduction to his *R. al-Bā'iyya*, for example, he gives the reason for its composition as being to combat “the teachings of certain Sufis (*mutaṣawwifa*) on the subject that are detestable to any seeking guidance given their use of baseless overinterpretations (*takallufāt wāhiya*) and ideological propagandizing (*tamaḥḥulāt*), utterly devoid of edificatory value,”¹ and contrasts this with his own lettrist approach.

In contrast, 'Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī does refer to Faḡl Allāh explicitly and denounces him as a satanic extremist in pursuit of worldly ends, studiously using the terms *ḥarfīyya* or *ahl al-ḥarf* to refer to the practitioners of intellectual lettrism, as opposed to the messianic and

¹ *R. al-Bā'iyya*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 122a.

incarnationist *ḥurūfiyya*.² (For his part, Ṣā'in al-Dīn refers to his fellow lettrists as *ahl al-ḥarf*, *ramz-kh'ānān-i ḥurūf-i qur'ānī*, or *arbāb-i 'ilm-i ḥurūf*.) Following Biṣṭāmī, I accordingly refer to the followers of Faḏl Allāh as Hurufis and their doctrine as hurufism, and to Ṣā'in al-Dīn and his circle as lettrists.

8.2: Ibn Turka's view of Sufism

Ṣā'in al-Dīn's view of much of the organized Sufism of his day tends to be negative as well. As we have seen, he identifies Sufism as a specifically religious science in its own right and highly necessary to achieving human perfection, but one that cannot compete with lettrism in the universality of its scope. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's concern (as expressed in his *R. Anjām* and elsewhere) is to draw a sharp distinction between the respective objectives of Sufism and lettrism: the objective of Sufism is the soul's purification and, being subjective, is hence moral and individual, while that of lettrism is the systematic and objective investigation of the two Books, a scientific and communal pursuit.³ This distinction is an index of the growing divide between the urban intellectuals of western Iran and the Sufi movements, increasingly messianic and political in their ideology on the one hand or bastions of establishment orthodoxy on the other. In his works Ṣā'in al-Dīn often dismisses his establishment opponents as *rasm-jūyān-i madrasa u khānaqāh*, Sufi-scholarly agents of conservatism and stultification.⁴ All their learning and

² Fleischer, "Ancient Wisdom," 234–35; Gril, "Ésotérisme contre hérésie," 186–87, 192–94.

³ Cf. Fleischer, "Ancient Wisdom," 234: "Bistami describes the science of letters, which incorporates all ancient hermetic and prophetic wisdom traditions (including Greek, Indian, Jewish, Christian, Sabaeen, and Muslim), as a rationally cultivable path to achieve the same knowledge of the divine and of the cosmos that was attained by mystics through inspiration. Indeed, Bistami regularly refers to the 'noble literalists (*sadat al-ḥarfiyya*) and noble Sufis (*sadat al-sufiyya*)' as representing parallel and equivalent 'professional' paths to illumination."

⁴ E.g. *R. Anjām*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 159b. Cf. Ghazālī's criticisms of khanaqah residents and Sufis in general as being for the most part mercenary sluggards, boy-loving dandies milking the system (e.g. *Iḥyā' 'Ulūm al-Dīn*, ed. Badawī Ṭabāna, 4 vols., Cairo, 1957, 2/249–50). Note that the madrasa-khānaqah binary had become a trope by this time, as seen e.g. in a line by Ṣā'in al-Dīn's disciple Kātibī Turshīzī (MS Majlis 7776 f. 31a): "Your outward form is known in the world through the learning of the madrasa/ your inward

sophistication, he says, is but pitiful, inept coquetry when compared to the ravishing new forms the sciences of reality have now taken.⁵ His disdain was more than reciprocated; Ṣā'in al-Dīn had long since fallen afoul of such powerful establishment scholars as the Damascene traditionist Muḥammad al-Jazarī (d. 833/1429) and the orthodox Sufi Zayn al-Dīn Kh^wāfi (d. 838/1435), eponym of the Zayniyya, based in Herat. These individuals he dismisses as being no more than mafiosos and backbiters, people of little learning but many designs, and the plague of true scholars.⁶ Ṣā'in al-Dīn further laments the fact that the majority of the scholars of his day are riddled with the moral diseases of jealousy, petulance, niggardliness and slander of their peers and superiors, given that they fail to first purge themselves of base motives before setting out on the path of knowledge.⁷

8.2.1: Friendly relations with contemporary Sufi masters

His frustration with both messianic and mafioso Sufis notwithstanding, Ṣā'in al-Dīn evinced great respect for many prominent Sufi masters of his day. The *Munsha'āt-i Turka* is our primary source in this regard, and testifies to his warm relations with Ni'mat Allāh Valī, Qāsim-i Anvār,

form known through knowing according to the usage of the khanaqah (*zāhir-at ma'lūm dar 'ālam bi 'ilm-i madrasa/ bāṭin-at ma'rūf dar 'irfān bi 'urf-i khānaqāh*)."

⁵ R. Ḥurūf, MS Majlis 10196 f. 154a.

⁶ "Nafṣat al-Maṣdūr I," 187; see Binbaş, Sharaf al-Dīn 107-29; cf. Brentjes, "Orthodoxy," *Ancient Sciences*, 36. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's comments about al-Jazarī in his second apology, written in exile, are particularly scathing. He dismisses the Damascene as knowing nothing beyond the science of Quran reading (*qirā'at*) and a smattering of hadith—this, the foremost teacher of hadith and Quran in the Timurid realm, was only able to secure a position for himself on the basis of his native Arabic. As he gained in prestige at court he began to cause problems for Ṣā'in al-Dīn's students and complain about Ṣā'in al-Dīn himself, all because Ṣā'in al-Dīn had once given a less-than-glowing account of him when pressed by the Mamluk sultan in Cairo ("Nafṣat al-Maṣdūr II," 211-2).

⁷ "Nafṣat al-Maṣdūr II," 210.

Aḥmad Samarqandī, ‘Alā al-Dīn Chishtī⁸ and Ḥasan ‘Aṭṭār,⁹ among others. This feature of his letters both corroborates the information he gives, for example, in his apologies as to his dealings with prominent Sufi shaykhs (chiefly in an admonitory role)¹⁰ and acts as a counterbalance to Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s criticisms of organized Sufism expressed in various works. Furthermore, the fact that the first three Sufis named were known as great promoters of Ibn ‘Arabī in the face of sometimes hostile reaction suggests this as a point of intellectual attraction for Ṣā’īn al-Dīn. As Shahzad Bashir notes, despite virtually unconditional support for Ibn ‘Arabī’s thought in Persianate lands, some Sufis, Zayn al-Dīn Khwāfī and Zayn al-Dīn Tāybādī most prominently among them, staged a vehement opposition to what they saw as its pernicious pantheistic influence.¹¹ Iran was thus not immune from the general controversy, more common in Egypt, “that pitted Sufis against each other depending on their appraisals of the ideas of the great theoretician Ibn al-‘Arabi.”¹² It is therefore not an accident that Ṣā’īn al-Dīn was persecuted precisely by Zayn al-Dīn Khwāfī and his circle; as a promoter of Ibn ‘Arabian theory, he could not fail to arouse their ire. Even Aḥmad Samarqandī—to whom, significantly,

⁸ See §2.1.3.1, letter 3, a letter of greeting to Shaykh ‘Alā’ al-Dīn ‘Alī [Chishtī] containing references to khanaqah life and *dhikr* (TMN/MS pp. 1-2). Shāhrukh appointed this Chishtī sayyid as administrator of his madrasa-khanaqah complex in Herat, completed in 813/1410 (Manz, *Power*, 223).

⁹ See §2.1.3.1, letter 36 to Khwāja Tāj al-Dīn Ḥasan ‘Aṭṭār (transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.1 below): a letter of greeting to the prominent Naqshbandi Sufi in eulogy of his spiritual stature and abilities as shaykh, with a postscript sending greetings to the shaykh’s disciples and residents of his khanaqah and expressing the author’s longing to visit (*yā layta-nī kuntu ma’a-hum*) (TMN/M f. 51b, TMN/MS p. 29, TMN/D pp. 206-7). This individual is presumably Khwāja Ḥasan ‘Aṭṭār, the son of ‘Alā’ al-Dīn ‘Aṭṭār (d. 802/1400), successor to Bahā’ al-Dīn Naqshband (d. 791/1389). His son Khwāja Muḥammad, based in Transoxania, was held in high esteem by Jāmī (d. 898/1492) (Gross and Urunbaev, *The Letters*, 85).

¹⁰ See §8.3 below.

¹¹ Bashir, *Sufi Bodies*, 98-99. Their position was summarized in the phrase *hama az ū-st*, ‘All is from Him,’ in contrast to the *hama ū-st*, ‘He is all,’ attributed to the proponents of the ‘unity of being’ (*vahdat-i vujūd*).

¹² Bashir, *Sufi Bodies*, 98; on the development and spread of this controversy see Knysh, *Ibn ‘Arabi in the Later Islamic Tradition*.

Şā'in al-Dīn sent a copy of his *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*—,¹³ the sometime chief disciple of Zayn al-Dīn Kh^wāfi, was disowned, declared an unbeliever and persecuted by the latter when he would not desist from teaching the *Fuṣūṣ* or reciting the verses of Qāsim-i Anvār, also a proponent of Ibn 'Arabī.¹⁴

Of the Sufi masters named above, Şā'in al-Dīn appears to have been the closest to Shāh Ni'mat Allāh Valī and Shāh Qāsim-i Anvār. With respect to the first, the *Munsha'āt-i Turka* preserves a letter that suggests the younger man's respect for the great Sufi master; this tallies with later Ni'matullahi hagiographical accounts, which present Şā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī as visiting his khanaqah in Kuhbanan and as Ni'mat Allāh's travel companions on a visit to Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī in Cairo.¹⁵ During the last phase of his life in Mahan, Ni'mat Allāh visited Shiraz in 816/1413-14 at the invitation of Iskandar Mīrzā, then governor of Fars.¹⁶ His visit appears to have bracketed Shāhrukh's campaign in western Iran and removal of Iskandar from power, as Şā'in al-Dīn sent a letter from Isfahan to Yazd to be personally communicated to Shāhrukh by Ni'mat Allāh in reply to Shāhrukh's summons to attend his court. That Şā'in al-Dīn sought the mediation of Ni'mat Allāh in this regard is significant; given his close association with Iskandar's court, he no doubt felt his position in the expanding Shahrukhid state to be tenuous and thought it prudent to protect himself with the eminence of the Sufi master. In this

¹³ See §2.1.3.1, letter 13, to Darvīsh Aḥmad Samarqandī, constituting Şā'in al-Dīn's note of greeting accompanying a copy of his *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr* (TMN/MS pp. 8-9; the letter is transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.1 below).

¹⁴ Bashir, *Sufi Bodies*, 99, 191; Manz, *Power*, 203, 231, 236-37.

¹⁵ See §4.3.2 above.

¹⁶ Algar, "Ni'mat-allāhiyya," *El*². Ni'mat Allāh also occasionally visited Yazd and Taft during this period, so presumably would have continued to cross paths with Şā'in al-Dīn there.

letter Ṣā'in al-Dīn is accordingly at pains to convey his admiration and well-wishing to the newly-ascendant Shāhrukh, and assures the ruler that he will soon attend his court.¹⁷

Because Qāsim-i Anvār was never the subject of an independent hagiography due to his perceived failure as a Sufi shaykh to properly control his disciples¹⁸—a failure to which Ṣā'in al-Dīn himself refers in explicit terms—,¹⁹ Ṣā'in al-Dīn's two letters to the charismatic master appear to be the only direct evidence for their relationship. Nevertheless, the tone of these two letters is quite warm, and one speaks of several days spent in Qāsim-i Anvār's company.²⁰

Nevertheless, the significance of Ṣā'in al-Dīn's relations with Sufis with respect to his intellectual project should not be overemphasized. The remainder of his letters to Sufi masters date to his period of exile after 830/1427; the fact that they occur among a group otherwise uncontextualized simple letters of greeting (letters 35-47) suggest that the author is here massaging his larger network of acquaintances, both Sufis and administrative officials, in hopes of resolving his intolerable situation or obtaining assistance during his wanderings in exile. For example, his letter to Sayyid Muḥammad b. Shaykh Kajujī, the *shaykh al-islām* and leading Sufi of Tabriz, was written ca. 831-32/1428-29 during the author's sojourn in Lahijan, and expresses gratitude for the assistance offered to him by one Ḥasan, presumably the shaykh's disciple, who

¹⁷ TMN/M f. 148a, TMN/MS pp. 11-12, TMN/D pp. 170-73; see §2.1.3.1 above, letter no. 16. The letter is transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.1 below.

¹⁸ Bashir, *Sufi Bodies*, 146.

¹⁹ See §8.3 below.

²⁰ See §2.1.3.1, letters 37 and 38; both are transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.1 below. The first is a brief letter of eulogy and friendship (among the descriptors Ṣā'in al-Dīn uses here is *niqābat-qibābī*, indicating that Qāsim-i Anvār held the position of *naqīb* in Herat); the author closes by asking after the shaykh's health, and a postscript sends greetings to the shaykh's disciples, expressing his particular regard for the jurist (*taqvā-qibāb-i fatvā-āyāt*) 'Azīz Jalāl Yūsuf, most probably Jalāl al-Dīn Yūsuf Awbahī, the loyal student of Sa'd al-Dīn Taftāzānī (d. 793/1390) and prominent member of the Herati ulama (see Manz, *Power*, 58) (TMN/MS pp. 29-30, TMN/D pp. 207-9). The second is a similarly brief letter to the shaykh written after the author spent several days in his company, presumably in Herat and either in 830/1427 or 834/1431; Ṣā'in al-Dīn describes Sayyid Qāsim with the notable eulogistic phrase *valāyat-panāhī-yi irshād-malāzī-yi siyādat-qibābī-yi ḥaqāyiq-ma'ābī-yi 'irfān-iyābī* (TMN/MS pp. 30-31, TMN/D pp. 209-10).

will inform Sayyid Muḥammad of the necessary details when he returns to Tabriz.²¹ In a letter to one Kh^wāja Ṣāḥir al-Dīn Muḥammad, Ṣā'in al-Dīn opens by praying against the wiles of the envious and hostile and invoking the spiritual support of the Sufis.²² Other Sufi addressees include Sayyid Bahā' al-Dīn (possibly Bahā' al-Dīn 'Umar Jaghāra'ī (d. 857/1453), a prominent Herati shaykh),²³ Mīr Makhdūm and his disciples,²⁴ and one Ṣāfir al-Dīn.²⁵ Finally, a letter to two unnamed Sufis dwells on various mystical themes and reports on the proceedings of a majlis.²⁶

The Naqshbandi connection would prove to be the most problematic in the subsequent generation. Despite Ṣā'in al-Dīn's apparently warm relationship with Kh^wāja Ḥasan 'Aṭṭār, successor to Bahā' al-Dīn Naqshband himself, and his recognition as preeminent lettrist by the Naqshbandi Kāshifīs, father and son,²⁷ and despite the fact that Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī appears in the *Rashaḥāt-i 'Ayn al-Ḥayāt* as a promoter of Ibn 'Arabī's thought,²⁸ 'Abd al-Raḥmān Jāmī appears to have been at pains to minimize the importance of the Isfahan Circle and quarantine

²¹ See §2.1.3.1, letter 35 (TMN/M f. 122a, TMN/MS pp. 28-29, TMN/D pp. 205-6). Sayyid Muḥammad was the son of Kh^wāja Ghiyās al-Dīn Muḥammad, known as Shaykh Kajujī (Kajūjānī) Tabrīzī (d. 778/1376), among the leading mystics of Tabriz and master of the main khanaqah there; he was also *shaykh al-islām* of the city, a position his son inherited (Abarqū'ī, "Musāfir-i Bukhārā," 62).

²² See §2.1.3.1, letter 46 (TMN/M f. 188b, TMN/MS pp. 33-34, TMN/D pp. 216-17).

²³ See §2.1.3.1, letter 39 (TMN/MS p. 31, TMN/D p. 210); Manz, *Power*, 59.

²⁴ See §2.1.3.1, letter 40 (TMN/MS p. 31, TMN/D p. 210).

²⁵ See §2.1.3.1, letter 47 (TMN/MS p. 34, TMN/D p. 217).

²⁶ See §2.1.3.1, letter 45 (TMN/MS pp. 32-33, TMN/D pp. 213-16).

²⁷ See §§4.4.2 and 4.4.4 respectively.

²⁸ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 86. In the same work 'Alī Ṣafī b. Ḥusayn Vā'iḏ Kāshifī is concerned to partially incorporate Qāsim-i Anvār into the Naqshbandi tradition. He portrays Kh^wāja Aḥrār as having immense respect for the charismatic master (Bashir, *Sufi Bodies*, 98).

them intellectually; in particular, he pointedly excluded both Šā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn from his seminal *Nafaḥāt al-Uns*.²⁹

8.2.2: Jāmī's disdain for the Isfahan Circle

Jāmī's exclusion of Šā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn from his *Nafaḥāt* stemmed from his general disdain for and suspicion of the project of the Isfahan Circle, an attitude captured most clearly in the *Maqāmāt-i Jāmī* of Jāmī's disciple 'Abd al-Vāsi' Niẓāmī Bākhārī. In this work the hagiographer describes a fraught meeting between Jāmī and Yazdī after the latter's move to Herat in the wake of the Sulṭān-Muḥammad debacle of 850/1446; it may thus be supposed that this meeting took place when Jāmī was perhaps in his late thirties and Yazdī in his late seventies or early eighties. During the course of their conversation Sharaf al-Dīn expresses his frustration and despair vis-à-vis the socio-intellectual climate of the day, and particularly hostility to intellectual forms of Sufism among the scholarly establishment. The younger Jāmī, however, is not impressed, and dismisses Sharaf al-Dīn's entire career (and Šā'in al-Dīn's by extension) out of hand:

During that interval in which Mawlānā Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī had taken up residence in Herat in the aftermath of his punishment by Shāhrukh Bahādur, the ruler of the age, for his personal connection with prince Sulṭān-Muḥammad b. Bāysunghur and the latter's bid to usurp control of [Persian] Iraq, [Sharaf al-Dīn] and ['Abd al-Raḥmān Jāmī] chanced to have a conversation on the banks of the Injīl canal. Their scholarly discussion turned to the reality behind the existence of two contradictory issues in Sufi practice (*du qaṣiyya-yi mutanāqiz az musta'malāt-i mutaṣavvifa*), and given that [Sharaf al-Dīn] had spent his life investigating such divine secrets (*rumūz-i rabbānī*) and virginal meanings (*mukhaddarāt-i ma'ānī*) ['Abd al-Raḥmān] asked him to elucidate this point. But [Sharaf al-Dīn] responded in a wholly defeated and disturbed tone: 'Ah, my young man (*makhdūm-i man*)! I've sworn before my God to never again after today discuss such matters with anyone.' His refusal stemmed from the fact that during the rule of Shāhrukh the jurists of the day spewed every type of vitriol and slander against this group (*tāyifa*). So ['Abd al-Raḥmān], piercing the pearl of meaning with the diamond of his exposition, said sagaciously: 'Given that you

²⁹ Ökten, "Jāmī," 175-77; Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 86, 90. 'Alī Shīr Navā'ī does, however, add Sharaf al-Dīn to his Chaghatay translation of the *Nafaḥāt*, the *Nasā'im al-Maḥabba*; for Navā'ī's additions to the *Nafaḥāt* see Brockelmann, "Nawa'is Biographien türkischer und zeitgenössischer Mystiker."

held it to be good for religious and practical reasons to attempt to associate yourself with an accomplished master (*ṣāhib-i kamālī*), you [at first] traveled the land wholly naked [of possessions];³⁰ but wreathed in the bleakness and straitness of your insufficient purpose, you [then] gave yourself into the power of every amir and bureaucrat,³¹ and in attempting to discourse on the principles (*tamhīd-i muqaddamāt*) [of Sufism] you supplied a weak defense unbecoming to the writings of the leading men of the age. This is not the way of a friend or an advocate.’ A strange thing then happened: [Sharaf al-Dīn], after demonstrating good faith and proper belief in abandoning his objection to speaking of such things, as he spoke gradually began to embellish the robe of his comportment with verbose discussion, yet his discourse was marred by a number of vapid statements that bore no connection whatsoever to his stated interest in rectifying the situation.

[‘Abd al-Raḥmān later] evaluated Mawlavī Sharafī [i.e., Sharaf al-Dīn] as follows: ‘He was able to speak about the theory behind some of the issues and technical vocabulary of Sufism (*uṣūl-i masāyil u muṣṭalahāt-i qawm*), but not in such a way as to admit of ready comprehension (*taṣarruf-i zihnī*); as a result his presentation remained unconvincing. Yet somehow the thinkers contemporary with [Sharaf al-Dīn] held him to be the most all-encompassing of scholars (*mānand-i vay jāmi‘ī bi naẓar-i shuhūd-i arbāb-i fahm u idrāk dar namī-āmad*), while he himself held that [all his knowledge] was but an instance of the philanthropic impulses (*ḥasanāt*) of Khwāja Šā’in al-Dīn Turka, and constantly glorified him to all and sundry.’

Mawlānā Kamāl al-Dīn Mas‘ūd Shirvānī made in Herat an honest and truthful comparison of [‘Abd al-Raḥmān] and [Sharaf al-Dīn] that may be cited in support of the above appraisal: ‘[First, Sharaf al-Dīn] was acquainted with the principles of scholarly discussion in general terms, but [‘Abd al-Raḥmān] is penetrating and learned in the intricacies of all classes of sciences to such an extent as to be beyond human capacity to describe. Second, [Sharaf al-Dīn’s] work was widely received as and accused of being heterodox and deviant (*sū’-i ‘aqīda u khabas-i i’tiqād*) (though his accusers bear the responsibility [for the truth of their assertions]), while [‘Abd al-Raḥmān] in his sincerity and purity of purpose treads the straight path of the Shari‘a and the unswerving course of the Sunna and Jamā‘a wholly upright and firm of foot. Furthermore, [Sharaf al-Dīn] spent his entire life connected to the courts of the rulers of the age, whereas [‘Abd al-Raḥmān’s] truth-shielding threshold is and will be by rights continually kissed by all the kings of the world. As for [‘Abd al-Raḥmān’s] superiority as to the perfections of his prose and verse, he has attained such a level [of artistry] that whenever the long-winged falcon of his effusive nature wishes to sing eloquently, the inspired parrot-[like poets] can and must do nothing but acknowledge their incapacity.’

The world is imperaled with his speech—listen!
His imperaling tongue like a candle—expire!³²

³⁰ Cf. *Jāmi‘-i Mufīdī*, 3/302.

³¹ *Har mughūl u tāzīk*, lit., ‘every Mongol and Persian.’

³² Bākhazī, *Maqāmāt-i Jāmī*, 106-7. It should be noted that Jāmī was able to examine the first draft of Bākhazī’s book before his death in 898/1492, meaning that this account may be supposed to accurately reflect Jāmī’s words and general attitude (Binbaş, “Sharaf al-Dīn,” 72 n. 116).

The ‘king-of-the-hill’ tendentiousness of Bākharzī’s hagiographic account suggests that some elements of the Naqshbandiyya of the later 9th/15th century, chief among them Jāmī, were at pains to consolidate their ascendancy by distancing themselves from the more strictly intellectual, and suspect, project of the Isfahan Circle. The latter were unfairly persecuted in the Shahrukhid period, it is true, but they simply weren’t up to snuff in the first place; their writings are inexpert and unclear and their opinions at times vapid, and in point of fact they may well have deserved the accusations of heterodoxy leveled at them—though they certainly didn’t deserve the wide regard in which they were held. Furthermore, they were failed Sufis, being rather dependent on court patronage. (A jab is even implied about their abilities as writers.)

The point that Bākharzī, and with him Jāmī, willfully ignores, of course, is that Ṣā’ib al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn explicitly rejected the notion of organized Sufism as the be all and end all of human development, and so felt no obligation to live as professional Sufis. As we have seen in the Excursus above, both Ṣā’ib al-Dīn and Jāmī were dedicated to incorporating the inspired outpourings of Ibn ‘Arabī into their works, but the considerable degree to which their respective projects stood at cross-purposes may be seen in Jāmī’s rather adolescent disrespect for the intellectual old guard of Shahrukhid Iran here on display.³³

³³ See Binbaş, “Sharaf al-Dīn,” 72-73.

8.2.3: Ibn Turka and Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī as failed Sufis

The image of Ṣā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn as failed Sufis, promulgated by Jāmī and his circle, was to persist through the 11th/17th century. Jāmī's reference to their early, abortive attempt to enter the Sufi path at the hand of a qualified shaykh was expanded upon in the Safavid-era *tazkira Sullam al-Samāwāt* of Shaykh Abū l-Qāsim b. Abū Ḥāmid Anṣārī Kāzirūnī (fl. early 11th/17th c.)³⁴ in a section quoted in the *Jāmi'-i Mufīdī*;³⁵ it should be noted that Kāzirūnī's source was likely Afzal al-Dīn b. Ḥabīb Allāh Turka (d. 991/1583), his teacher. This episode, part of an account of Sharaf al-Dīn and his works, may be paraphrased as follows:

Ṣā'in al-Dīn (author of a commentary on the *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*) and Sharaf al-Dīn (author of the *Zafarnāma*) embark on a quest to find an accomplished mystic of exalted spiritual state (*darvīsh-i ṣāhib-i ḥāl u valī-yi ṣāhib-i kamāl*) after completing their formal education. Lugging their many books and goods with them on their journey, they head first to Baghdad where they take up residence at a madrasa and begin inquiring after Sufi masters. They learn that there are two aged Sufis at a certain residence and go to interview them about their master. Ṣā'in al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn then arrange a meeting with this master; he comments disapprovingly about their excess of possessions and informs them that his method involves the abandonment of worldly goods (*tark*). The two postulants therefore return to their lodgings and give away all of their books and traveling supplies to students and other deserving parties, whereupon they become the master's disciples. They accompany him on his travels and perform all the spiritual exercises (*riyāzāt*) he prescribes; yet after spending considerable time in such pursuits they wholly fail to achieve an experience of mystical opening (*fath-i albābī*), nor do they witness any miraculous acts (*karāmāt u khāriq-i 'ādāt*). In frustration they abandon their shaykh and depart for Egypt, where they hear of a dervish possessed of a high mystical state who has remained in

³⁴ MS St. Petersburg A. 684 (12th/18th c.) (AB); partial copy, MS India Office 1909 (Ethé, *Catalogue*, 1/1059).

³⁵ Mufīd Mustawfī, *Jāmi'-i Mufīdī*, 3/302.

seclusion for a considerable period in the upper apartment of a khanaqah. Ṣāʿin al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn accordingly take up watch beside this khanaqah in hopes of meeting this dervish, but he eventually dies in seclusion. Disheartened, they return to Iran. In Tabriz they hear of a woman who is subject to states of mystical attraction (*majzūba*) and has knowledge of things unseen. They go to see her; without prompting she tells the two men their names and describes the details of their journey. Then comes the clincher: the woman reveals that the Egyptian dervish refused to meet with them due to their unfaithfulness to the shaykh in Baghdad.

In this retelling the moral is clear: for all of their scholarly attainments, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn failed as Sufis due to their impatience and spiritual superficiality.³⁶

8.3: Sufism and Hurufism in the apologies

Ṣāʿin al-Dīn's criticisms of organized Sufism and patent anti-hurufism notwithstanding, in 829/1426 Ṣāʿin al-Dīn's enemies were able to successfully accuse him a second time of—irony of ironies—*ṣūfīgarī*, Sufi bias. However, the irony is lessened by the fact that in Shahrukhid Iran the term seems to have functioned as code for messianic political aspirations, including hurufism in particular. In his *Nafsat al-Maṣdūr* I, an apology written after having been summoned to Herat to stand trial once again, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn is particularly concerned to undercut his enemies' arguments by showing that even if he, the accused, did at some point have Sufi inclinations—to which he does not admit—, true Sufis cannot by any measure be considered as deviating from the Sunna, but rather as epitomizing it. He enumerates many examples of the orthodoxy of prominent Sufi masters (e.g., ʿAbd Allāh Anṣārī, al-Ḥakīm al-Tirmidhī, Saʿd al-Dīn

³⁶ The account continues by praising Sharaf al-Dīn's *Zafarnāma* as universally acknowledged by historians to be a model of elegance, and lists a number of his other works, including *Ḥaqāyiq al-Tahlīl*, *Ḥulal-i Muṭarrāz* (and a *Muntakhab* therefrom), *Sharḥ-i Qaṣīda-yi Burda*, and *Kunh al-Murād dar ʿIlm-i Vafq-i Aʿdād* (Muḥid Mustawfī, *Jāmiʿ-ī Muḥidī*, 3/303).

Ḥamuvayī),³⁷ dwelling in particular on Kh^wāja Muḥammad Pārsā, the Naqshbandi leader and favorite of Shāhrukh.³⁸ Such Sufis are carefully distinguished from those charlatans who use their charisma and cunning to amass disciples and gain control over rulers, or who use Sufism as an excuse for laziness and libertinism, chanting ‘Everything is God!’ without bothering to pass beyond their basic animal natures, thereby descending into heresy (*mulḥid, zindīq*).³⁹ This barb, of course, is clearly directed at the followers of Faḡl Allāh, among others.

In his second apology, written after his arrest, torture and exile and as a result less guarded and angrier in tone, Ṣā’īn al-Dīn expands upon this last theme: mercenary and messianic Sufis gravitating toward libertinism. Significantly, he here admits to having received a *khirqā-yi tabarruk* from a great Sufi master before going abroad to study, i.e., during his residence in Samarkand, only to find that, upon his return to Iran a decade and a half later, this master’s disciples had fallen into antinomianism.⁴⁰ As a result, when Ṣā’īn al-Dīn next chanced to see this master he called him to account, whereupon their meeting quickly devolved into a shouting match. (We are reminded here of Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s father and brother, Afḡal al-Dīn and Ṣadr al-Dīn, who both attended the majlises of Faḡl Allāh himself during the early career of the latter as a Sufi and dream interpreter in Isfahan.⁴¹) The author proceeds to describe a

³⁷ “Nafṣat al-Maṣdūr I,” 173. The last named is one of Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s primary sources for his lettrist doctrine.

³⁸ It should be noted that Shāhrukh was responsible for promoting Anṣārī (d. 481/1089) as the patron saint of the Timurid dynasty, his unimpeachable Hanbali credentials being useful to the sultan’s Sunnizing project (Manz, *Power*, 219).

³⁹ “Nafṣat al-Maṣdūr I,” 176-7.

⁴⁰ “Nafṣat al-Maṣdūr II,” 212-13. It should be noted that Nī’matullahi sources claim that both Ṣā’īn al-Dīn and Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī sought out Shāh Nī’mat Allāh Valī to express their devotion to him (Farzām, *Tahqīq dar Aḥvāl*, 254-55; see §4.3.2 above).

⁴¹ Hurufi sources mention Afḡal al-Dīn Turka and Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka as having sought out Faḡl Allāh to have their dreams interpreted. Naṣr Allāh Nāfajī’s *Kh^wābnāma* relates that one Kh^wāja Ṣadr al-Dīn Turka attended an afternoon majlis held by Faḡl Allāh during which he related a troubling dream to the latter. In this dream he saw the Prophet sitting, and went up to kiss his hand; he then noticed that he had inadvertently left some saliva on the back of his hand and felt ashamed at committing such an impropriety. Faḡl Allāh interpreted this to mean that Ṣadr al-Dīn was planning to write a book

conversation he had with another Sufi master in Herat—almost certainly Qāsim-i Anvār⁴²—whose disciples were exhibiting antinomian behavior; this time he succeeded in convincing his interlocutor of the need to restrain his disciples from their native libertinism and messianic tendencies. Šā'in al-Dīn avers that he has attempted to reform many other Sufi masters in the same way. Most significantly for the purposes of our present inquiry, he concludes by describing a hostile confrontation he initiated in Isfahan with a group he identifies only as “the ringleaders of depravity and sedition (*daftar-i fasād u āshūb*) whose anarchic activities have cast such turbulence (*fitna*) into the world”—this can only refer to the Hurufis. As such, this appears to be the only time that Šā'in al-Dīn refers to the movement with any specificity, and his sense of outrage and injury here radiates from the page. The passage is worth quoting in its entirety

harmonizing religion and philosophy, but that he should abandon this plan so as not to risk shame before the Prophet. Later the same day, Kh^wāja Afzal al-Dīn Turka (described as pious, learned, reclusive, wise and *mu'allah/muwallah*, and a member of Šadr al-Dīn's house) joined the majlis and related a dream in which God appeared to him and said that He would build him a dome (Vatican MS Persian 17 ff. 32a-33a; cf. the more detailed account in the *Kh^wābnāma* of Kh^wāja Sayyid Ishāq, Millet MS Ali Emiri Farsça 1042 f. 23a; and see Bashir, *Fazlallah*, 15-18—my thanks to Prof. Bashir for graciously providing me with copies of the relevant MS pages).

⁴² Hagiographic materials of the 9th/15th century remark upon Qāsim-i Anvār “as a man of high spiritual attainment but unable to control those attracted to him ... Although he was clearly a remarkable man of his age, Qasim's hagiographic profile is marred by the fact that a number of authors pointedly criticize some of his disciples. 'Abd al-Rahman Jami writes that he had personally met some of Qasim's followers and considered them beyond the pale of Islam altogether. One follower, whom Jami considered a worthy Sufi, told him that Qasim himself told him not to stay with him because of some of his other followers. Jami's explanation for the contrast between Qasim's own undeniable excellence and the waywardness of some of his followers is that he was too generous a person to shun anyone who came to him because of his attractiveness. People inclined to worldly pleasures took unjust advantage of this by deriving meanings from his words that he did not intend. In Ahrar's words, as his hagiographer reports them, people explained Qasim's situation in two ways. They believed that he was either aware of his disciples' corruption, but suffered it as his fate, or these disciples were like the thorns put on top of walls around an orchard that keep thieves and animals away from the fruit. The prize protected by the thorns in this case was Qasim's true spiritual station, which he wanted to keep hidden from strangers. The same source that reports this provides the activities of Qasim-i Anvar's followers. It reports that Ahrar said that once, when Qasim had come to Transoxiana, his followers got together and went around the bazaar to collect beardless young boys (*pisaran-i amrad*) with whom they began to establish relations. Their explanation for this behavior was that they were observing the beauty of God in the beautiful forms of these boys. As this was going on, Qasim asked after his followers by saying, 'where have those pigs of mine gone?' ... While reports about Qasim absolve him from being responsible for the unnamed corrupt behavior of some of his followers, it is clear that he was seen as somewhat of a failure as a Sufi master” (Bashir, *Sufi Bodies*, 145-46). Cf. the *Rashahāt-i 'Ayn al-Ḥayāt*, which emphasizes Qāsim-i Anvār's concern for the scrupulous observance of etiquette (Bashir, *Sufi Bodies*, 97-98, 100).

as a direct testimony of the surging popular heterodoxy and messianism of early 9th/15th century Iran:

The present writer has never held with those who monopolize the marketplace of shaykhdom (*mashyakhat*) with the capital of the sciences of the Sufis and their exalted states, who cast their noose, woven of desirable ends (*raghāyib*) expressed in limpid and lovely form, about the necks of every community and rope them into their orbit. As Ḥāfiẓ has sung,

The Sufi has set his snare and opened his magic box
duping even trickster heaven.⁴³

Whenever I came across such individuals on my travels I unleashed on them the flails and cudgels of censure, vocally opposing all those positions by which they have seduced people and continue to do so, and two points in particular. The first is their announcement of the advent of the Mahdi (*khātām al-vilāya*), which they say is imminent and will in fact occur within the next two years; when he arrives the Sufis (*darvīshān*) will rule the world. The second is their giving free rein to the impulses of human nature and removing the bridle of Shari‘a-imposed duties. Both points are of course quite attractive to the masses, and anyone they convince of either becomes their captive. I discussed these points with such individuals privately, [in some cases] bringing them to the point of admitting their error. Their number even includes one of the great masters of the age from whom I myself had humbly received the *khirqa-yi tabarruk* before setting forth on my travels; when I had returned from abroad [after a number of years], however, I saw that a group of his followers had dispensed with observing the dictates of the Shari‘a in the manner required. When our paths crossed at a royal court the above considerations did not deter me from speaking with him, and in a private audience I dwelled on the abominableness of his position on these matters. Our discussion became so heated that we ended by railing at each other, whereupon I excused myself as is necessary in such situations. However, a number of his disciples, people who had been but a year or six months or even one month on the Sufi path, approached me in the hopes of eliciting a short treatise (*angusht-i kāghaz*) from my pen—it would have been hardly right of me to refuse their request.

[As for their master, he excused himself with the quote:]

“Come! The dignity of this workshop can be impaired
neither by the self-denial of someone like you
or the debauchery of someone like me.”⁴⁴

⁴³ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *ṣūfī nihād dām u sar-i ḥuqqa bāz kard*. As mentioned in the Excursus above, Ṣā‘īn al-Dīn is one of the first writers to frequently quote Ḥāfiẓ, his earlier contemporary, and some of Sharaf al-Dīn’s ghazals are in clear response to the latter’s. By way of example, I would here like to direct the reader’s attention to Ṣā‘īn al-Dīn’s pointed use of Ḥāfiẓ to criticize organized Sufism.

⁴⁴ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *dū yār-i zīrak u az bāda-yi kuhan dū manī*.

I said, “Indeed, the lofty height of your workshop is above such impairment, but these earnest disciples are taking your teaching to mean that observance of the dictates of the Shari‘a is unnecessary for those on the Sufi path, although this is not your actual intention, and are thereby becoming discouraged.”

He countered, “A person so easily turned aside I do not call a disciple.”

I replied, “One must put oneself in the place of weak disciples, as the holy Messenger said: *Travel at the pace of the weakest among you (sīrū sayra ad’afi-kum)*—in other words,

Don’t let him walk if he can ride.”⁴⁵

He said nothing to this.

On another occasion, the first time I traveled to this city [Herat] I came into the company of a prominent master who also happened to be here, and he was effusive in his affection and friendship toward me. However, I saw the same unacceptable behavior among his disciples, and so I spoke with him privately: “Far be it from you that your dignity as a master be dependent upon the number of disciples you have or that your disciples be considered spiritually lacking—but there are certain individuals who associate themselves with you whose behavior leads one to believe that you advocate dispensing with the obligations of the Shari‘a; they talk with everyone in a very disorderly fashion and claim all manner of things.” The shaykh was at a loss for words. And indeed, to be fair, it is extremely difficult to bring people under discipline these days—they have no capacity and are greatly inclined toward libertinism (*ibāḥat*).

I continued, “Given this reality, you must not give free rein to everyone. Those who sincerely desire to progress on the mystical path (*taraqqī*) and are capable of achieving the state of separation after unification (*farq ba’d al-jam’*), the preserve of perfected masters, may be given their own lead; the rest you must wholly disavow, for the current arrangement is causing much trouble (I take refuge in God). It is necessary to recognize the status of every entity (*‘ayn*), attribute or act: good from the good, bad from the bad. By this measure the place of each may be appropriately determined, and the good embraced, the bad eschewed. This is the message borne by all the prophets and communicated to perfection by our own Prophet (God’s blessings be upon him and upon them all).”

As it happened, this shaykh was receptive to my admonition; he disavowed a number of his ‘disciples’ and endeavored to correct their erroneous thinking as to the advent of the Mahdi, demonstrating that their view on the subject was at variance with that of the learned masters who, basing their calculations on the Quran and hadith, affirm that his advent is still well in the future (*hanūz tā ān zamān khaylī mānda*).

These two masters aside, I have met with and thoroughly admonished many other shaykhs in the same terms. A further instance may be mentioned here: Before I left for [Herat (?)], I met in Isfahan with the ringleaders of depravity and sedition (*daftar-i fasād u āshūb*) whose anarchic activities have cast such turbulence (*fitna*) into the world.⁴⁶ I addressed them in the manner described above, but our encounter quickly degenerated into recrimination [on my part] and ended with sheer brazenness [on theirs]. This episode is well-known.

⁴⁵ Sa’dī, ghazal: *kasī ki rū-yi tō dīdast ḥāl-i man dānad*. The line in full: *jafā u salṭanat-at mī-rasad valī ma-pasand/ ki gar suvār bi-rānad piyāda wā-mānad [bar-mānad]*.

⁴⁶ Cf. Muḥammad Ṭūsī’s censure of Faḏl Allāh Astarābādī in his *R. Majma‘ al-Tahānī u Maḥẓar al-Amānī*, dedicated to Bāysunghur (3/29-35).

My duty's but to communicate the message
whether 'tis received with outrage or yawns.⁴⁷

What is an intolerable and indigestible lump in my stomach and a source of unremitting pain to my head is the fact that it was precisely this group that made [preoccupation with the science of letters] a crime in the first place, yet this seeker of knowledge, this poor old man (*pīr-i bīchāra*), who has continually contended with them and admonished and opposed them most assiduously, broadcasting the error of their ways—how incredible it is that they have not suffered in any appreciable way from such an accusation, while this poor wretch's petition has gone for naught and the honor of a seven centuries-old family been polluted with the filth of this accusation and become a universal cud of gossip—a thing unthinkable indeed.

The tulip's in its cups, the narcissus is soaked—
yet I'm the one accused of debauch?⁴⁸

The primary purpose of this narrative, of course, is to show himself for Shāhrukh's benefit an implacable opponent of messianic and antinomian Sufism in all its guises. Yet the raw, outraged tone of Ṣā'īn al-Dīn's apologies also indicates the extent to which he laid blame for the crippling of his lettrist project at the door of both mercenary messiahs and insecure, reactionary schoolmen, Sufis and otherwise—and the Hurufis above all.

⁴⁷ Sa' dī, qasida: *tavāngarī na bi māl ast pīsh-i ahl-i kamāl*.

⁴⁸ "Nafsat al-Maṣdūr II," 212-5. The hemistich is from Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *man na ān rind-am ki tark-i shāhid u sāghar kunam*. The line continues: "I have many judges, O Lord: whom shall I make mine?"

CONCLUSION

*On their way toward modern science human beings
have discarded meaning.*¹

—M. Horkheimer and T. Adorno

*We should recognize the universe as a meta-
reality of information structures.*²

—Jacques Vallée

*It from bit.*³

—John Wheeler

C.1: The marginalization of Ibn Turka as lettrist

A central burden of this study has been to propose ‘intellectual lettrism’ as a useful, if artificial and catchall, category for the analysis of late medieval and early modern Islamic intellectual history. While such intellectual lettrism was birthed of Shi‘i gnostic-messianic and Sufi strains in equal measure and never fully disavowed its parentage, in these pages I have emphasized the

¹ *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, 3.

² “A Theory of Everything (Else): Another Physics for 2061,” TEDxBrussels, 22 November 2011, <http://www.tedxbrussels.eu/2011>.

³ “Information, Physics, Quantum: The Search for Links,” in W. H. Zurek, ed., *Complexity, Entropy, and the Physics of Information*, 5. The passage in full: “*It from bit*. Otherwise put, every it—every particle, every field of force, even the space-time continuum itself—derives its function, its meaning, its very existence entirely—even if in some contexts indirectly—from the apparatus-elicited answers to yes or no questions, binary choices, *bits*. It from bit symbolizes the idea that every item of the physical world has at bottom—at a very deep bottom, in most instances—an immaterial source and explanation; that what we call reality arises in the last analysis from the posing of yes-no questions, and the registering of equipment-evoked responses; in short, that all things physical are information-theoretic in origin and this is a *participatory universe*.”

specifically intellectual forms of the science in order to combat the prevailing assumption that, for example, the popular messianic-gnostic-Sufi Hurufi movement of Fażl Allāh Astarābādī defines 9th/15th century lettrism. It does not; rather, that movement’s vigor testifies to the religiocultural valency of lettrism in Iran at all levels.⁴ Given such origins, indeed, the emergence of a ‘philosophical’ lettrism is only to be expected. The progressive neoplatonization and neopythagoreanization first of gnostic-messianic Shi‘ism and then of its heir, Sufism, from the 2nd/8th to the 6th/12th centuries served to naturalize both letter theory and letter magic as legitimate intellectual pursuits; at the end of this process, lettrism had attained the status of a universal science, and as such was attractive to ambitious, universalist thinkers throughout the late medieval and early modern Islamicate world—Ibn Turka prominently among them.

Further research into the evolution of Islamic lettrism during the transition to the modern period and up to the European colonizations of North Africa, the Middle East and the Subcontinent will provide a much-needed counterbalance to the burgeoning scholarship on early modern and modern Western esotericism and its confrontation with the ‘Enlightenment’ divorce of meaning from language.⁵ It must be emphasized that because there was no such epistemological rupture in the Islamicate context the theory and practice of the occult sciences remained largely intact in their traditional forms, and hence required no syncretistic injections of more exotic content to survive—whereas in Europe, for example, the term ‘theosophy’ has

⁴ Bashir, *Fazlallah*, 66-69.

⁵ See Horkheimer and Adorno, *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, 1-34; on p. 13 they state: “For science the word is first of all a sign; it is then distributed among the various arts as sound, image, or word proper, but its unity can never be restored by the addition of these arts, by synaesthesia or total art. As sign, language must resign itself to being calculation and, to know nature, must renounce the claim to resemble it. As image it must resign itself to being a likeness and, to be entirely nature, must renounce the claim to know it.” See also Foucault, *The Order of Things*, 35-49, 321-27. These observations support Adorno and Horkheimer’s broader contention (as well as Foucault’s after them) that Enlightenment rationality was and is exclusionary and repressive in nature, and ultimately totalitarian (Horkheimer and Adorno, *op. cit.*, 4 et passim; Foucault, *Madness and Civilization*).

come to be associated almost exclusively with the post-Christian syncretism of Blavatsky, not the Christian mystical theory of Boehme.⁶ With the advent of globalization, of course, the intellectual modes of lettrism in particular have fallen by the wayside; but the popular vitality of letter magic is scarce diminished. Būnī's *Shams al-Ma'ārif al-Kubrā* is far more ubiquitous now than it ever could have been in the premodern period and seems to have no shortage of students.⁷

As a preeminent occult philosopher of the late medieval period, the marginalizations Ṣā'in al-Dīn Turka has suffered from his own day to the present are products of the tangled intellectual and sociopolitical factors that may be said to define the spirit of an age. In early Timurid Iran, we have seen the deleterious effects on Ṣā'in al-Dīn's person of the inhospitable intellectual environment created by the orthodoxizing ethos of the Shahrukhid state and its defensive alarm at the rise of mystical-messianic extremism, especially typified by the Hurufis. In late Timurid Iran, Naqshbandi ascendancy served to partially obscure Ṣā'in al-Dīn's legacy as a result of Jāmī's revisionism in particular, though the lettrist and occultist writings of the Kāshifīs, father and son, counteracted this development.⁸ By the mid-11th/17th century in Safavid Iran, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's image appears to have further diluted in popular memory to simply that of an important intellectual of Shahrukhid Iran and a failed Sufi—not necessarily a bad

⁶ On the influx of South and East Asian ideas into European and American esotericist thought see J. J. Clarke, *Oriental Enlightenment: The Encounter Between Asian and Western Thought*.

⁷ See e.g. Remke Kruk, "Harry Potter in the Gulf: Contemporary Islam and the Occult," 50. As an anecdotal example, in Amman in 2000 I was invited by an Iraqi streetside bookseller to accompany him to the caves of Karak in central Jordan to study Būnī's grimoire. Cf. Hanegraaff's discussion of the modern phenomenon of "disenchanted magic" wherein he argues that it was perfectly natural for magic to have survived the processes of modernization and secularization: "'Magic' survives because the spontaneous tendency of participation belongs to human nature; but it becomes 'occultist' magic because practitioners feel the need to legitimate their practice in a disenchanted world" ("How Magic Survived the Disenchantment of the World," 378).

⁸ It should be remembered that the Kāshifīs were themselves card-carrying Naqshbandis, and that Ḥusayn Vā'iz was in fact Jāmī's brother-in-law.

thing in the view of the Safavid state.⁹ In the Qajar period, no less a figure than Mullā ‘Alī Nūrī (d. 1246/1830), who was largely responsible for reviving interest in Mullā Ṣadrā’s *ḥikmat-i muta‘āliya* in Iran,¹⁰ appears to have been acquainted with Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s lettrist thought;¹¹ yet by the late 13th/19th century Ṣā’īn al-Dīn seems to have become identified almost exclusively with his *Tamhīd al-Qawā’id*, a synthesis of Ibn Sīnā, Suhrawardī and Ibn ‘Arabī/Qūnavī on the topic of absolute being, which began to be used as a staple teaching text in Imami seminaries. From that time to the present, then, Ṣā’īn al-Dīn has been (mis)appreciated as a reasonably important mystical philosopher linking Ibn ‘Arabī with Mullā Ṣadrā.¹² (Even with the flush of interest in Ṣā’īn al-Dīn in Iran during the last decades and admirable efforts to publish his other works, most of his purely lettrist works have been predictably neglected, chief among them the *Mafāḥiṣ*.) As has emerged in this study, the handle ‘mystical philosopher’ would have been cringe-inducing to the man himself. ‘Allāma Ṭabāṭabā’ī’s (d. 1402/1981) lionization of our thinker in his *al-Mīzān* as a preeminent synthesizer of peripatetic philosophy and theoretical mysticism (together with Fārābī and Suhrawardī) is not unwelcome—all publicity is good publicity—,¹³ but like most modern and premodern judgments is insensible of the central burden of Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s life’s work: the systematization and advancement of a thoroughgoingly

⁹ See §8.2.3 above. As a family, the Turkas remained prominent in the service of the Safavid state until the mid-11th/17th century, after which they appear to drop out of the historical record; see §1.1.

¹⁰ Sajjad Rizvi, “Mulla Sadra,” *SEP*.

¹¹ Nūrī owned the earliest and most comprehensive collection of Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s works now preserved as MS Majlis 10196, and his marginal comments may be seen throughout the *majmū‘a*. Significantly, he wrote extensive marginal comments on the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* in particular, indicating his deep interest in that text. That he was thoroughly familiar with Ṣā’īn al-Dīn’s lettrist doctrine is further confirmed by his marginal comments on such treatises as *R. Nuqṭa*, *R. Ḥurūf*, *R. Su’l al-Mulūk*, etc. For examples of such marginalia see Appendix P.4 below.

¹² See §2.1.2, no. 42 above for a discussion of this theme.

¹³ *Al-Mīzān fī Tafsīr al-Qur’ān*, 5/282–84. Lumping Ṣā’īn al-Dīn in with Fārābī and Suhrawardī, who exemplify levels three and four in the hierarchy of *R. Shaqq-i Qamar* or level three of that in *R. Madārīj Afhām al-Afwāj* and thus in the author’s estimation fall far short of any kind of universal knowledge, does our occult philosopher a patent injustice. At the same time, it does reflect the great (or overgreat) appreciation of the *Tamhīd* in scholarly Imami circles in the 20th century.

occult, prophetic philosophy and praxis centered on the quranic letters, distinct from and more universal than both philosophy and mysticism, as key to the human mastery of reality.

I suggested above that Šā'in al-Dīn's difficult career as an occult philosopher in early Timurid Iran may be usefully contrasted with that of 'Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī, his Ottoman cognate. Both endeavored to naturalize esotericism in their respective environments; however, where Bisṭāmī was highly successful in this endeavor, such that lettrism became foundational to Ottoman imperial messianic identity, Šā'in al-Dīn was less so, and given the sociopolitical realities of early 9th/15th century Iran his intellectual ambitions left him open to attack by his establishment opponents who effectively used his esotericism against him. His visionary proclamation of a new age is therefore tempered with a sense of grinding frustration with his countrymen. In the *R. al-Inzāliyya*, written sometime before 828/1425, he decries the current unpopularity of lettrism in Iran, and dismisses the simplemindedness of his local contemporaries as tantamount to suckling babies' rejection of solid food, not knowing that one cannot otherwise reach adulthood.¹⁴ (He elsewhere defines this adulthood as being spiritual fertility in the sexual sense, marked by the ability to become engorged and sensitized when confronted by the nubile shape of the letters of the eternal Words; by this process a true human being is conceived, possessed of eternal life.¹⁵) Šā'in al-Dīn and his circle were rewarded for their efforts to advance knowledge with the derisive messianic-gnostic label *naw-mulḥidān*, i.e., neo-bāṭinīs or even neo-Isma'īlis, given them by the establishment Sufi Zayn al-Dīn Kh^wāfī.¹⁶

¹⁴ "R. al-Inzāliyya," 144; cf. 138. Cf. Cornelius Agrippa's acerbic dismissal of his establishment critics: "I believe that the supercilious censors will object against the Sybils, holy Magicians and the Gospel it self sooner then receive the name of Magick into favor so conscientious are they, that neither Apollo, nor all the Muses, nor an Angel from Heaven can redeem me from their curse. Whom therefore I advise, that they read not our Writings, nor understand them, nor remember them. For they are pernicious, and full of poyson; the gate of Acheron is in this book; it speaks stones, let them take heed that it beat not out their brains" (*De Occulta Philosophia*, "Ad Lectorem," quoted in Chris Miles, "Occult Retraction: Cornelius Agrippa and the Paradox of Magical Language," 442).

¹⁵ *R. Anjām*, MS Majlis 10196 f. 159a.

The fact that Ṣā'in al-Dīn's opponents were able to make this label stick, with disastrous consequences, signals the successful 'heterodoxification' of his thought.

Ibn Turka's life and works thus provide us with a privileged look into the nexus of contested dichotomies that made intellectual, political and religious life in early Timurid Iran so fraught: orthodoxy and heterodoxy, conservatism and progressivism, philosophy and mysticism, mysticism and messianism, messianism and heterodoxy, lettrism and hurufism. The efforts of Ṣā'in al-Dīn and his circle to develop lettrism as a universal Islamic science appropriate to the requirements and possibilities of a new phase of human development did little more than implicate them in the rampant heterodox messianism and political intrigue of the day. Ṣā'in al-Dīn is a profoundly millenarian thinker by any standard, to be sure; but his proclamation of the advent of a new age, heralded by heavenly portent, in which the occult knowledge of the Imams and the ancients will be made manifest is unimpeachably Islamic in its insistence on the binding finality of the dispensation given through Muḥammad. In the final analysis, what sets the lettrists apart from the Hurufis and other messianic movements in early 9th/15th century Iran is motive: the gnostic Hurufis proclaim a new, Persian dispensation; the messianic Sufis promote themselves as political saviors; the lettrists present themselves as occult philosophers working within the tradition to expand the boundaries of human knowledge.

¹⁶ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Din," 124-29. It is difficult to precisely determine the connotations of this label. Does it indicate simply freethinking subversives, or rather neo-bāṭinīs, even Isma'ilis? The last is not beyond the realm of possibility, given the continued presence of and hostility to Isma'ilis under Temür and Shāhrukh; witness Shāhrukh's attempted purge of Isma'ilis in Quhistan in 1415. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's charismatic associate from his Cairo days, Qāsim-i Anvār, the influential Sufi and propagandist of the Ṣafaviyya order, was apparently claimed by Isma'ilis as one of their own; he was to be exiled from Herat in 1427, along with Ṣā'in al-Dīn, for such suspect connections (though it was his putative connection with the Hurufis that provided the official excuse) (Shafique Virani, *The Ismailis in the Middle Ages*, 103-4).

C.2: Deciphering the twin Books, the Quran and the cosmos

*Raising toward heaven our cabbalistic eyes ...*¹⁷

—John Dee

The central driver of Ṣāʿin al-Dīn's intellectual project is the profoundly millenarian quest to decipher the twin Books, the Quran and the cosmos. It must not be forgotten that such a quest in its late medieval and early modern context, whether in Shahrūkhid Iran or Renaissance Europe, necessarily encompassed both 'occult' and 'non-occult' sciences, wholly blurring the rigid boundaries now posited between them—the latter legitimate, the former illegitimate. As Ṣāʿin al-Dīn contends to the contrary, we can only achieve a global understanding of reality and its many ontological levels by developing an intellectual toolkit that is epistemologically global, that makes full use of every mode of knowing; and occult modes, in his view, cast the widest net. Thinkers like Ibn Turka or Giordano Bruno saw synergy where we assume rupture. As a result, Ṣāʿin al-Dīn and his circle, far from skulking occultly in a darkling corner, consciously developed their project in tandem with and contributed to the 'legitimate' scientific advances of the early Timurid period, especially in astronomy, as promoting their universalist ambitions.

The seamlessness obtaining between lettrism and astronomy in the early 9th/15th century¹⁸ is suggested by two points in particular. First, witness Ṣāʿin al-Dīn's close relationship with Qāẓīzāda Rūmī (d. ca. 835/1432), preeminent astronomer, mathematician and coauthor of

¹⁷ *Monas Hieroglyphica*, 175, trans. in Thorndike, *History of Magic and Experimental Science*, 6/457.

¹⁸ Cf. Heidrun Eichner's observation that theological texts following the new Maragha school template developed by 720/1320 exhibit a strong interest in astronomy ("The Post-Avicennian Philosophical Tradition," 501-2).

the *Zīj-i Jadīd-i Sulṭānī*, on both personal and intellectual levels.¹⁹ Their bond was formed when both men were students of the exoteric sciences under Ṣā'in al-Dīn's elder brother Ṣadr al-Dīn in Samarkand,²⁰ and held to such an extent that Qāzizāda followed his friend to Cairo to apprentice himself to Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī in the occult sciences.²¹ Qāzizāda's continuing appreciation of lettrism and admiration for Ṣā'in al-Dīn's project may be seen in his effusive letter of thanks sent to the latter in ca. 829/1426 upon receiving a copy of his lettrist *Sharḥ al-Basmala*.²² Notably, in this letter Qāzizāda eulogizes Ṣā'in al-Dīn's mastery of the whole of the Islamic tradition and his spiritual perfection as occultist, calling him 'the alchemical matrix of everlasting life and eternal collyrium' (*kīmiyā-yi ḥayāt-i abadī u tūtiyā-yi bīnā'ī-yi sarmadī*). Second, witness Ulugh Beg's (r. in Samarkand 811-53/1409-49) invitation to Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī to join the staff of the Timurid prince's famous observatory in Samarkand²³ in his capacity as prominent astrologer-astronomer and mathematician.²⁴ This invitation was in fact issued as an emergency measure, for Shāhrukh was determined to execute Sharaf al-Dīn for his (apparently very minor) involvement in Sulṭān-Muḥammad's rebellion in 849/1446; however, Ulugh Beg's son Mīrzā 'Abd al-Laṭīf successfully secured a reprieve by convincing Shāhrukh that his father

¹⁹ More specifically, Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn Mūsā Qāzizāda Rūmī was head professor at Ulugh Beg's madrasa, where he was presumably responsible for adding astronomy and mathematics to the curriculum, as well as one of two leading astronomers working at Ulugh Beg's observatory, the other being Ghiyās al-Dīn Kāshī (Manz, "Ulugh Beg," *El*²).

²⁰ Eichner, "Afḍal al-Dīn Turka," *El*³; Ragep, "Qāḍī-zāda Rūmī," *El*².

²¹ Or at least was presumed to have done so by the late Timurid period; see Gāzurgāhī, *Majālis al-'Ushshāq*, *majlis* 34, 189; 'Abd al-Razzāq Kirmānī, *Tazkira dar Manāqib-i Ḥazrat Shāh Ni'mat Allāh Valī*, in Aubin, *Majmū'a*, 70-71; and §§4.3.2 and 4.3.3 above.

²² *TMN/M* f. 153b; see §2.1.3.1 above. This letter is transcribed in Part 2, §P.2.2 below. A second copy was dedicated to Qāzizāda's employer Ulugh Beg; see the marginal addition in MS *Majlis* 10196 f. 332b.

²³ Ulugh Beg b. Shāhrukh's observatory in Samarkand was famed as one of the most important research centers in the Islamic world, second only to the Ilkhanid observatory in Maragha. As the standard observational reference of the period, the *Zīj-i Jadīd-i Sulṭānī* (or *Zīj-i Gūrkanī*) of Ulugh Beg was twice translated into Latin (London, 1652; Oxford, 1665). See George Saliba, "Persian Scientists in the Islamic World: Astronomy from Marāgha to Samarqand."

²⁴ See Mahdi Farhani Monfared, "Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī: Historian and Mathematician."

required Sharaf al-Dīn's services at his observatory.²⁵ There is little doubt that the posthumous influence of Qāzīzāda, as leader of Ulugh Beg's scholarly team and lettrist sympathizer, played some role in this maneuver. Unfortunately, there appears to exist no further information about Sharaf al-Dīn's activities in Samarkand.²⁶

Needless to say, such cross-fertilizations between occult and non-occult were hardly confined to the early 9th/15th century, as current research on early modern European thought definitively shows; given the almost total lack of similar studies on the late medieval and early modern Islamicate context, however, where the scholarly discussion is typically limited to history of science or philosophy, it is difficult to marshal specific examples here. (The main exception to this trend is the ongoing work of Cornell Fleischer and İhsan Fazlıoğlu and their students, as well as, for example, George Saliba's work on the relationship between astrology and astronomy.) One is the work of Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad Khafrī (d. ca. 957/1550), a prominent philosopher, astronomer and mathematician of the early Safavid period, who appears to have written a treatise on *jafr*, as well as two on geomancy (*raml*).²⁷ Certain earlier sources are also suggestive: the *Masālik al-Mubtadī wa-Masā'il al-Muqtadī*, for example, a rather circumscribed late 7th/13th-early 8th/14th century encyclopedia treating of twelve disciplines, assigns the science of letters a place between Sufism (*ilm al-ṭarīqa*) on the one hand and

²⁵ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 67-68; Aḥmad b. Ḥusayn b. 'Alī Kātib, *Tārīkh-i Jadīd-i Yazd*, 241-42; Bartol'd, *Mīr 'Alī Shīr* (in Barthold, *Four Studies on the History of Central Asia*, 1-72), 11; 'Alī Aṣghar Ḥikmat, "Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī," 175; on Sulṭān Muḥammad's rebellion see Manz, *Power*, ch. 8. An early 10th/16th century source reports that Yazdī was invited to Samarkand by Ulugh Beg at some point after 811/1409, but he is said to have declined the invitation with a cryptic and ambiguous verse: *zinhār Sharafzi Taft bī-rūy naravī / ki-āvāz-i duhul shanīdan az dūr khūsh-ast* (the verse is found in Ḥakīm Shāh Muḥammad Qazvīnī and Fakhrī Harātī's 929/1523 translation of 'Alī Shīr Navā'ī's *Majālis al-Nafā'is*, 199-200; see Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 42 n. 23).

²⁶ Binbaş, "Sharaf al-Dīn," 67.

²⁷ Saatchian, *Gottes Wesen—Gottes Wirken*, 51-54. This Persian treatise, entitled *R. dar Uṣūl-i Aḥkām-i Jafr*, is only known to be preserved in MS 52, Saryazdī Library, Yazd; it is there ascribed to an otherwise unknown Shams al-Dīn Fakhrī, which the cataloger conjectures was meant to be Shams al-Dīn Khafrī (*Nashriyya*, 4/421). For a discussion of Khafrī's importance as an astronomer, see Saliba, "A Sixteenth-Century Arabic Critique of Ptolemaic Astronomy."

astronomy (*‘ilm al-hay’a*) on the other.²⁸ Furthermore, the category of the occult may here be expanded to include the religious in general, as Robert Morrison has recently demonstrated in his study of the interpenetration of religious thought (including Sufism) and astronomy in the work of Niẓām al-Dīn Nīsābūrī (d. ca. 730/1330).²⁹

With respect to the occult sciences as such, an especially promising line of inquiry for future research is the increasing emphasis placed by Muslim occult philosophers on the experimental validity of such sciences as lettrism, rather than on the reliability of the chain of authorities from which their information derives. Held by thinkers from Jābir b. Ḥayyān to Būnī to Ibn Turka, this doctrine appears to have become fully mainstream by the early 10th/16th century. We see this with ‘Alī Ṣafī Kāshifī (d. 939/1533), who asserts the wholly empirical, replicable nature of lettrism:

The experiential findings (*tajriba*) of the lettermasters (*arbāb-i ḥurūf*) stand irrefutable testimony to [the fact that the imaginal forms of the letters can be harnessed to produce effects in the physical world] ... Experimentation aimed at manifesting the effects and properties of the letters has often been successfully repeated; and experiment is among the forms of proof that produce certainty (*tajriba yakī az isbāt-i yaqīn ast*).³⁰

This type of intellectual lettrism puts one in mind of the universal science posited by John Dee (d. 1608), archemastrie, which he describes as a “*Scientia Experimentalis*” or “Experimentall Science” whereby “the Archemaster steppeth in, and leadeth forth on, the Experiences, by order of his doctrine Experimentall, to the chief and finall power of Naturall and Mathematical Artes.”³¹ It bears noting in this connection, of course, that the advent of ‘modernity’ is often

²⁸ See §4.2 above for more on this encyclopedia.

²⁹ *Islam and Science: The Intellectual Career of Niẓām al-Dīn al-Nīsābūrī*.

³⁰ *Hirz al-Amān min Fitan al-Zamān*, section 1.1.6; see §4.4.4 above. Cf. Paul Kraus’s seminal treatment in his *Jābir ibn Ḥayyān of the Arab alchemist—a thoroughgoing lettrist*, as we saw in §4.1.1 above—as the first rigorous and systematic experimentalist in the alchemical tradition as inherited from antiquity.

³¹ *Mathematicall Praeface*, 48; the passage in full: “This Arte, teacheth to bryng to actuall experience sensible, all worthy conclusions by all the Artes Mathematicall purposed, & by true Naturall Philosophie

associated precisely with an emphasis on learning from experience,³² though we must be wary of simplistically vaunting early modern experimentalism as a ‘seed of modern science’ given its heavy emphasis on continuity with antiquity; by so doing we run the risk of demodernizing modernity itself.³³ It is precisely what was perceived to be the experimentally effective nature of lettrism, at all levels of reality, that earned it the status of an ancient and universal science from the 3rd/9th century onwards. More to the point, rather, it has often been observed that the late 10th/16th century saw a move from esotericism to exotericism in European and Jewish thought, including kabbalah.³⁴ That is to say, this move involved not a diminished interest in matters occult among the intellectual elite but rather the abandonment of that secrecy and circumspection so scrupulously observed by previous generations of esotericist thinkers.³⁵ The

concluded: & both addeth to them a farder scope, in the termes of the sames Artes, & also by his propre Method, and in peculier terms, procedeth, with helpe of the foresayd Artes, to the performance of complet Experiēces, which of no particular Art, are hable (Formally) to be challenged ... *Science* I may call it, rather, then an Arte: for the excellency and Mastershyp it hath, ouer so many, and so mighty Artes and Sciences. And bycause it procedeth by *Experiences*, and searcheth forth the causes of Conclusions, by *Experiences*: and also putteth the Conclusions them selues, in *Experience*, it is named of some, *Scientia Experimentalis*. The *Experimentall Science*.” Nicholas Clulee notes that Dee’s emphasis on experimental science is hardly new; specifically, it paraphrases Roger Bacon’s discussion in book six of his *Opus Majus* under the heading “De scientia experimentalis,” while at the same time incorporating a significant occult-magical dimension by associating archemastrie with Arabic talismanic and divinatory sciences (“At the Crossroads of Magic and Science: John Dee’s Archemastrie,” 58–65; see also Clucas, “Pythagorean Number Symbolism”). On Bacon’s earlier efforts in this direction see Easton, *Roger Bacon and His Search for a Universal Science*.

³² E.g., in Neville, *The Highroad Around Modernism*, 51, quoted in Robinson, *God and the World of Signs*, 282.

³³ As Clulee cautions (“At the Crossroads,” 65): “[E]ven if we admit that magic served as the stimulus that attracted Dee’s attention to experimental method and that it was in this way that magic in the Renaissance contributed to the foundations of a new science, still Dee’s Archemastrie does not support the argument of Yates and others that the magic responsible for this was the new style of magic that was developed in the Renaissance in conjunction with hermetic texts, the cabala, and late antique Neoplatonic writings. Whatever the significance of Dee’s ‘doctrine experimental,’ it is in no way novel in substance, part being a paraphrase of Roger Bacon and the remainder being inspired by him. If Dee was attracted to the concept of empirically testing theories of nature by an interest in magic, the magic was not any uniquely Renaissance or ‘hermetic’ variety, but medieval and Arabic.”

³⁴ Idel, *Absorbing Perfections*, 8.

³⁵ Cf. the injunctions of, for example, Ibn ‘Arabī and Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī against speaking of applied lettrism except allusively, if at all; see §§4.1.2.2 and 4.1.2.3 above. Note that this observation lends further support to Noah Gardiner’s argument (§4.1.2.1) that the greatest grimoire of the Islamic world, Pseudo-Būnī’s *Shams al-Ma‘ārif al-Kubrā* wherein so many secrets of applied lettrism are laid bare,

present study suggests that just such a process began in the Islamicate world somewhat earlier than it did in Europe, i.e., by at least the beginning of the 9th/15th century, and is marked by the advent of thinkers like Ṣā'in al-Dīn who sought, in a spirit of universalist openness, to popularize and naturalize occult philosophy as queen of the sciences.³⁶

In this context, then, Ibn Turka is but one of a host of late medieval and early modern thinkers, 'East and West,' to understand reality in textual terms.³⁷ As current scholarship on early modern European thought emphasizes, the theme of deciphering the book of nature—in conjunction, of course, with that other book of God, the Bible—dominated natural philosophy

is precisely a later compilation that matured only in the early 11th/17th century; as such, it reflects a popularizing ethos foreign to its purported early 7th/13th century origin.

³⁶ It should further be noted that this trend toward eschewing secrecy and elitism was mirrored in contemporary poetic practice, which began to manifest a decidedly 'bourgeois' tendency; even artisans and butchers now entered the fray, resulting in a great increase in poetic production during the 9th/15th century. Most significantly, this development served to blur the boundaries between popular and educated literature (Losensky, *Welcoming Fighānī*, 137-39; Bauer, "Mamluk Literature," 109-10; see §E.1 above). The advent of modernity is therefore perhaps best defined with respect to this new popularizing ethos. Cf. Ṣā'in al-Dīn's assertion that the role of mystico-philosophical poetry, typified by the *Tā'iyya* of Ibn al-Fāriḍ, is to spread accurate knowledge of the structure of reality beyond the ranks of the intellectual and spiritual elite, and for this reason heralds a new phase of human development. A typical expression of this sentiment: "[T]hat which had been jealously guarded by the elite and expressed only in hints and allusions is now paraded before all spectators in the marketplace of proclamation" (*Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-Durr*, 8; see §E.2.1 above).

³⁷ See Foucault, *The Order of Things*, 35-49, 321-7, for a discussion of this theme in the context of European Renaissance thought. In his incisive review of theoretical approaches to the subject, Håkan Håkansson characterizes Foucault's notorious account of early modern occultism as purely structuralist in approach and based on the assumption that a fundamental epistemological shift took place in Europe in the middle of the 17th century, when a definitive break was made from the earlier, 'prelogical' principle of resemblance. Under the latter principle, the search for knowledge constituted "a reading of signs, an exegesis by which the inner essence of a thing was uncovered by interpreting its outer form, or by a continuous mapping of the correspondences that traversed the world ... In Foucault's terminology, the Renaissance *épistémè* superimposed hermeneutics and semiology—that is, there existed no distinction between *interpreting* a sign and defining of what *constituted* it as a sign" Language and reality were thus awarded equal ontological status by premodern occult philosophers. Foucault's account therefore "restates many of the commonplaces in early anthropological studies of analogical thinking in non-western cultures." It nevertheless eschews the standard recourse to psychologism by insisting that all notions of truth and reality against which early modern occultism is judged and found wanting are simply constructions of the prevailing discourse—a line of argument that the later Foucault, having repudiated his structuralist approach, would advance to great effect, such that the objectivist view of knowledge has now become obsolete (*Seeing the Word*, 44-48). See also Cole, "The World as Text," 145-46.

through to the rise of modern science in Europe;³⁸ more, it may be argued that even today our understanding of the universe remains wedded to letter (= form: the life sciences, DNA, writing new life) and number (= spirit: theoretical physics, unified field theory, unseen forces).³⁹ In particular, the *textuality* of the lettrist approach to deciphering the cosmos and creating new realities through the magically operative manipulation of letters comes full circle in the concept of life as code composed of a chemical alphabet that can be decoded and recoded at will.⁴⁰ A more robust analogy is that of historical reality as software—readable, writable, and above all predictable in its output.⁴¹ Here *jafr* may be understood as an experimentally vetted technique of transcribing the code that underlies the past, present and future course of events and constitutes the physical-imaginal-intellective structure of reality.

More broadly, the current quest for a physics of information may have profound implications for our understanding of lettrism. Proponents of this new physics assert that information is the only concept in all of science that is self-explanatory, that does not lead to an infinite regression, and as such put it forward as the best candidate for the unifying principle of a potential Theory of Everything.⁴² (The reader may be reminded here of Šā'in al-

³⁸ See e.g. Killeen and Forshaw, eds., *The Word and the World*; Debus and Walton, eds., *Reading the Book of Nature*; and Germana, *Tommaso Campanella: The Book and the Body of Nature*.

³⁹ On this continuity see von Stuckrad, “Rewriting the Book of Nature.” The number : letter :: spirit : form analogy is a standard feature of kabbalistic thought and serves to validate all numerological operations. But Steven Rose observes (*Lifelines: Biology, Freedom, Determinism*, London, 1997, 120): “To continue the linguistic, information-theory metaphor within which genetic theory was now to be formulated, the directed synthesis of RNA on DNA was termed *transcription*, and the synthesis of protein on the RNA was *translation*. DNA had become the master-molecule, and the nucleus in which it was located had assumed its patriarchal role in relation to the rest of the cell. It is hard to know which had more impact on the future directions of biology—the determination of the role of DNA in protein synthesis, or the organizing power of the metaphor within which it was framed.”

⁴⁰ See Vedral, *Decoding Reality*, 47-55.

⁴¹ I am indebted to Professor Scott Boorman for suggesting this analogy. See Vedral, *Decoding Reality*, 22, 196.

⁴² The recent and accessible *Decoding Reality* (2010) by Vlatko Vedral, professor of quantum information theory at the University of Oxford, exemplifies this new trend. Defined very briefly, information may be understood as a measure of probability. That is to say, information consists in the production of novelty,

Dīn's argument with respect to the letters: as the matrix through which the undelimited divine creative power is expressed, they alone encompass all that is and is not, all that can and cannot be.) While modern physics has long recognized that energy and information are two sides of the same coin, until recently it has wholly focused its efforts on the former; this has resulted in a dogged search for ever more fundamental subatomic particles—a search curiously reminiscent of late medieval attempts to progressively refine the Ptolemaic model by piling epicycle upon epicycle.⁴³ Physicists therefore remain unable to reconcile relativity and quantum mechanics, both very successful theories in their own domains but perplexingly at cross purposes. The extreme weirdness of quantum theory notwithstanding, in many scientific circles the shackles of the mechanistic and materialistic view of the universe produced by the Enlightenment have in large part yet to be thrown off. I would suggest, in fact, that late medieval and early modern nonmaterialistic cosmologies, exemplified here by Islamic lettrism, may be seen as overemphasizing a physics of information at the expense of a physics of energy, while post-Enlightenment materialism does precisely the opposite. Yet both are necessary to the quest; and so the pendulum swings back again. Significantly, the informational approach has been seized upon by contemporary evolutionary theologians as the key to reinfusing life

the unexpected; the more improbable a datum is, the more information it carries. The informational structure of the universe is therefore expressed in the increase in complexity, especially biological complexity, in defiance of the Second Law of Thermodynamics. In his popular take on the subject Tom Siegfried predicts that the major scientific discoveries of the next century will result from approaching the universe from the point of view of information, rather than energy or fields. To express the importance of this new understanding he paraphrases Heisenberg's paraphrase of Heraclitus as follows: "Information is indeed the material of which all the elementary particles, all atoms and therefore all things in general are made, and at the same time information is also that which is moved ... Information can be transformed into movement, heat, light and tension. Information can be regarded as the cause of all changes in the world" (*The Bit and the Pendulum*, 8-9).

⁴³ Jacques Vallée, "A Theory of Everything (Else): Another Physics for 2061," TEDxBrussels, 22 November 2011, <<http://www.tedxbrussels.eu/2011>>. Vallée suggests four requirements for a new physics: 1) Recognize the universe we perceive as a subsystem of a metareality of information structures/associations, all simultaneous. 2) Recognize dimensions as a cultural artifact; we create dimensions because we have relatively miniscule libraries that may be conveniently accessed dimensionally, but infinite information cannot be so organized. 3) The present is overdetermined, both from the past and the future. 4) Consciousness traverses associations in this world of information, thus generating the mind's impressions of space and time.

with a revelatory narrative that embraces the stupefying randomness and profligacy of material existence. As Niels Henrik Gregersen contends, it is the interplay of energy—Spirit—and information—Logos—that is responsible for the endlessly novel evolutionary proliferation of forms. He defines this Logos as follows:

[T]he idea of the divine Logos ... relates to both cutting and shaping information (Logos as “Pattern”), to the life-informing aspects (Logos as “Life”), and to meaning information (Logos as “Word”) ... [O]ne might say that Logos is identified as the *divine informational resource*, which is creative by setting distinctions into the world (carving out ‘this’ and ‘that’) and by bringing informational patterns into motion and resonance (combining ‘this’ and ‘that’). We may speak of the Logos as the informational matrix for the concrete forms that have emerged and will emerge in the world of creation.⁴⁴

John F. Haught likewise emphasizes that the twin poles of order and disorder which govern the emergence and evolution of the cosmos represent precisely the parameters for the production of information:

If the universe is in some analogous sense an information system, then it would allow the unfolding of occurrences within it to make their way between the extremes of noise on one side and redundancy on the other ... The cosmic oscillation between noise and redundancy is parallel to the encoding of information from letters of an alphabet. Without nature’s capacity for moments of deconstruction no evolutionary “story” could be inscribed in it. Without a constant inclination toward a state of noise the universe could not be the carrier of a meaning.⁴⁵

Needless to say, such formulations are immediately adaptable to the logocentrism of Islamic theology in general and Islamic lettrism in particular.

⁴⁴ Gregersen, “God, Matter, and Information: Towards a Stoicizing Logos Christology,” 325, 339, 342.

⁴⁵ Haught, “Information, Theology, and the Universe,” 306, 310. Haught elaborates: “[I]nformational novelty requires as a condition of its emergence a base of subsidiary probability and redundancy ... Concretely, the universe is a *blend* of order and novelty, steering its way between absolute redundancy on the one hand and absolute noise on the other. It is intuitively evident from ordinary experience that information must walk the razor’s edge between redundancy and noise. It should not surprise us, therefore, that any universe that carries a meaning would permit its content to meander adventurously between the two extremes of deadly design and unintelligible chaos” (313, 315-16).

Faced with such grand, even (dare I say) occult, continuities, I hardly think that researchers in ye thickly wooded hinterlands of late medieval Islamic occult philosophy need scruple to import useful findings and methodologies from Renaissance and Western esotericism studies. (As Goethe enjoins: “He who knows himself and other, will also recognise that East and West cannot be separated.”⁴⁶) I remarked in the Introduction as to the striking similarities between the project of Ibn Turka and his circle on the one hand and the Picos, Brunos and Dees of Europe on the other, particularly on the lettrist front. All understood themselves to be in hard pursuit of the same universalist objective: total comprehension and control of the cosmos—a theory of everything.⁴⁷ Umberto Eco captures the early modern Italian scene, alive with kabbalistic speculation:

Thus, in a period in which Europe was becoming receptive to new sciences that would eventually alter the known face of the universe, royal palaces and the elegant villas in the Tuscan hills around Florence were humming with the faint burr of Semitic-sounding incantations—often on the lips of the scientists themselves—manifesting the fervid determination to win a mastery of both the natural and the supernatural worlds.⁴⁸

Unlike these Christian kabbalists, however, who worked with an often very imperfect command of Hebrew and were frequently preoccupied with extracting from the Hebrew Bible

⁴⁶ Quoted in Clarke, *Oriental Enlightenment*, 3.

⁴⁷ Such late medieval and early modern expressions of universalism stand in stark contrast with the fragmenting tendencies of modernism, expressed by R. C. Neville as follows: “With regard to the coherence of system, at least in the historical sphere, we must abandon the dream of totality and necessity and acknowledge instead that, as far as we know, there are many pockets of order, sometimes interrelated, sometimes not, often irrelevant and indeterminate with respect to each other, passing with tangential connections, partially overlapping, sometimes in conflict but even then not in coherent agreement about what the fight is about. History has many streams, many traditions, rising and falling, entering and leaving prominence, going underground to emerge with new meanings in unexpected places, rarely with the coherence to totalize a period” (*The Highroad Around Modernism*, 119). Yet in capitalizing on this fragmentation, postmodernism produces, ironically, Derrida’s declaration that “there is nothing outside the text” (*Of Grammatology*, trans. G. C. Spivak, Baltimore, 1976, 158). Moreover, postmodernism’s rejection of logocentric metaphysics as totalizing conspires to be totalizing in no less measure (Robinson, *God and the World of Signs*, 284.) On the ongoing quest for a Theory of Everything (TOE) in theoretical physics see e.g. John Barrow, *The Constants of Nature*, New York, 2003, 53-76.

⁴⁸ *The Search for the Perfect Language*, 125.

confirmations of Christian doctrine,⁴⁹ Muslim lettrists of intellectual bent pursued their operations in a native linguistic and religious environment, secure in the knowledge that they were thereby both advancing human knowledge of the cosmos and demonstrating the miraculous inimitability of the Quran as the clearest transcript of divine Speech in history.

C.3: Ibn Turka and late medieval intellectual history

Randall Collins's contention that minor philosophers are minor for good reason—"[t]he magnifying glass, where available, sometimes shows us intellectuals possessing considerable skill in rearranging, systematizing, and popularizing a position; but it confirms our picture that creativity is rare"⁵⁰—is well taken; Šā'in al-Dīn was indeed a rearranger, systematizer and popularizer in much of his work, and particularly in his lettrist project: but an apostle of Akhlāṭī the prophet. In this study, however, I have suggested that the 'magnifying glass' provided by the massive surviving corpus of later Islamic esoteric writings shows us a forgotten, surreal, yet strangely familiar intellectual landscape populated by ambitious thinkers like Ibn Turka and his circle—a landscape that remains largely unmapped due to the deeply ingrained scholarly bias against late medieval and early modern occult philosophy that dismisses it as occult irrelevancy, even intellectual truancy. As a result, reliable standards of comparison are still lacking. To be sure, judged against the priorities of a later period privileging 'serious philosophy' or 'hard science' such intellectuals appear as minor thinkers indeed; but this is to abuse the magnifying glass, or, what is worse, to pretend its nonexistence. Judged against his own priorities and those of the intellectual circles of his own day, Šā'in al-

⁴⁹ Eco, *The Search*, 123-25; see also Zinguer et al., eds., *Hebraic Aspects of the Renaissance*. Pico himself, the father of Christian Kabbalism, only acquired enough Hebrew to understand the language-specific symbolic interpretations in the kabbalistic texts translated for him by the Jewish convert Mithridates, and in any event his championing of kabbalism in the *Conclusiones* largely predates his acquaintance with Hebrew (Wirszubski, *Pico della Mirandola's Encounter with Jewish Mysticism*, 3-9).

⁵⁰ Collins, *The Sociology of Philosophies*, 63.

Dīn rightfully achieved renown as the most prominent occult philosopher of Shahrūkhid Iran. His synthesis of peripatetic-illuminationist philosophy and mystical theory which has in modern times earned him the status of minor philosopher was considered by the man himself to be of secondary, though certainly not minor, importance. (We might as easily account Pico a mere magician, Bruno a mere memorizer, Newton a mere mathematician.) History abounds with such ironies; the historian of ideas must peer past their picturesque fog.

What then is the importance of Ibn Turka's occult philosophy to late medieval intellectual history? This study has outlined some of the ways in which Ṣā'in al-Dīn contested, synthesized and extended the dominant intellectual (and literary) paradigms of his day, as well as the positive and negative receptions with which his efforts met in Iran during the century after his death; in the absence of a comprehensive study of his oeuvre and the avenues of its dissemination between India, Central Asia and Anatolia, however, any attempt to neatly define Ṣā'in al-Dīn's contribution must be premature.⁵¹ My purpose here has simply been to beat the beginnings of a path through the thorny undergrowth, while suggesting more broadly that later Islamic occult philosophy will richly repay study as a field in its own right.⁵² As noted above, a theme that begs to be explored in particular is Ṣā'in al-Dīn's quest to decipher the twin

⁵¹ In particular, the occult writings of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī, Ṣā'in al-Dīn's most important influence, demand close study; most of his works are preserved only in manuscripts largely inaccessible to me at the time of writing. Only his work on various lettrist methods of extracting information from personal names and honorifics has been published as *Sifr-i Jafr* (ed. Zuhayr Tayyib, Tehran, 1386 Sh./2007); additional scattered sections attributed to Akhlāṭī have been published as *R. fī Qawā'id al-Jafr wa-'Ilm al-Falak wa-Zayārij wa-'Ilm al-Ḥurūf* (Beirut, 1423/2002). It should be said, however, that Ṣā'in al-Dīn's works appear to be a better introduction to Akhlāṭī's thought and practice than the latter's own works in that they are more explicit and more systematic as a rule, as well as being far better preserved. More generally, late 8th/14th and early 9th/15th century Mamluk Egypt seems to have been a major center of occultist thought—'Abd al-Raḥmān Bisṭāmī's pedigrees make it clear that this was hardly limited to the sizeable circle around Akhlāṭī—and bears investigation as such.

⁵² For a theoretical overview of the recent tentative emergence of 'Western esotericism' as a separate but highly interdisciplinary field with close connections to history of science and philosophy—suggesting methodologies, information on traps to be avoided and spoils of battles won that may be useful for a putative field of Islamic occult philosophy—see Leirich, "Finding One's Place: Magic, Science, Religion, and Interdisciplinarity." An encouraging development is the launch of a *Societas Occulta Islamica* in late 2011, spearheaded by Dr. Saiyad Ahmad at the American University in Cairo; the web address is <http://www.occultaislamica.com>.

Books, the Quran and the cosmos, vis-à-vis contemporary advances in astronomy, and the implications of such cross-fertilization for history of science studies.

Ṣā'īn al-Dīn's promotion of a universal science to this end places him in august company indeed. The larger millenarian upthrust of such universal sciences from the 7th/13th century onwards is, however, still inadequately appreciated; we lack a universal taxonomy of universalisms that takes full account of Islamicate developments.⁵³ Yet even at this early stage of research it is possible to state definitively: Ibn Turka's significance within late medieval intellectual history centers precisely on his status as one of a panoply of late medieval and early modern thinkers to understand reality in textual terms, to be driven by the prospect of deconstructing, decoding and recoding the great Book of God. More broadly, in a period pulsing with millenarian, universalist energy, Ṣā'īn al-Dīn's emphasis on occult philosophy as actualizing human perfection may be seen as part of a wholesale cultural shift toward creative and subversive synthesis, consolidation, systematization, recalibration and extension that hits its stride in the Islamicate heartlands during the 9th/15th century. His project, profoundly humanistic, combines the standard principle of *prisca sapientia* with an unprecedented doctrine of progress; he asserts his generation to be the best generation, mind's golden age to be present. Like their Renaissance counterparts, late medieval Muslim thinkers like Ṣā'īn al-Dīn Turka may best be described as Janus-faced, peering simultaneously into the past and the future.⁵⁴

⁵³ Fleischer's forthcoming study of Mediterranean millenarianism during this period will do much to remedy this lacuna.

⁵⁴ See e.g. Forshaw ("Astrology, Ritual and Revolution," 191), who describes the great encyclopedist and esotericist Tommaso Campanella (d. 1636) in these terms.

PART TWO

Selected minor letterist treatises of Ibn Turka

In the name of God, all-merciful, ever-merciful

Praise be to God, [Muḥammad's] Protector (*valī*), and blessings on Muḥammad, His Prophet.

Upon a day the present writer, having been attended by good fortune and willingly taken up the traveling staff as per the dictum, *Say: Journey in the land* (Q 6:11, 27:69, 29:20, 30:42), traveled the length and breadth of the engendered realm (*‘ālam-i kawn*); I duly considered its every marketplace, and evaluated the product of every group according to a standard measure. I found myself passing by the colleges of formal sciences (*madāris-i ‘ulūm-i rusūm*), arenas wherein different understandings compete for precedence. I observed in particular that the discussion among traditionists (*ahl-i zāhir*) and theologians (*mutakallimān*) surrounding the splitting of the moon (*shaqq-i qamar*) (Q 54:1) was especially popular and intense, with each scholar attempting to establish its meaning. In the process they trot out this firstfruit of the palace of prophecy and inimitability (*ijāz*), wholly obscure to those who are strangers to the realm of reason and the avenue of reflection and to those fallen short of the level of chivalrous manliness (*futuvva, mardī*) whose powers of comprehension cannot reach the skirt of its inviolability (*iṣmat*), clothed as they are in the terminology of the traditional sciences—whereupon I beheld the moment inditing:

There where the garden cypress struts with legs of wood
we shall also make that silverbodied tree dance!¹

It therefore occurred to me to select from out the closet of *I have been given the totalizing words*,² the key to whose inheritance (*virāṣat*) has been vouchsafed to the dustdwellers of the alley of poverty through the blessedness of adherence to the Seal, a robe of honor meet for the requirements and needs of the age wherein to clothe it. I thus treat of this matter, a veiled bride await in the Prophetic pavilion, according to the usage of each group of travelers on perfection's highway, and unfurl the garment of her glory and inviolability, leading her from out her chamber of seclusion to the bridal canopy according to her seven meanings as per the dictum, *The Quran has seven layers of hiddenness*,³ there to present her to all seekers.

¹ Sa'dī, ghazal: *barkhīz tā yak sū nihīm īn dalaq-i azraq-fām-rā*.

² *Ūtūtu jawāmi‘ al-kalim*; see e.g. Muslim, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, K. *al-Masājīd wa-Mawāḍi‘ al-Ṣalāt*, bab 1, no. 1199; Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal, *Musnad*, *Musnad Abī Hurayra*, nos. 7521, 8266.

³ *Inna li-l-Qur’āni sab’atu abṭun^m*; Kulaynī, *al-Kāfī*, 2/599, *Bāb Faḍl al-Qur’ān*, no. 2: *Inna li-l-Qur’āni sab’atu buṭūn^m aw sab’ina baṭn^{an}*.

A form extracted from its imprint,
a figure poured from a new mold
These two little words are sufficient for your table:
touch what has never been touched⁴

Now such a premise must be clarified: the Prophetic saying *I have been given the totalizing words*, a defining characteristic of the Seal, makes it clear that his realities-expounding words encompass all modes (*aṭvār*) [of meaning]. Thus while those who travel the spiritual realm receive perfect gifts from the spread of its subtleties at each moment, those who are confined to the realm of outward form nevertheless do not go without; while the lusty bibbers in the taverns of deep inquiry (*taḥqīq*) perpetually sate themselves with the wine of beauty's subtleties gushing forth from the saloon of its overflowing (*fayz*), those cupsippers in the monasteries of imitation (*taqlīd*) also become drunk on the distillations of its perfect cup.

O You Who has separate business with every heart
and different merchandise in every lane⁵

For each creature partakes of the table of His universal gifts according to his capacity and by virtue of his fundamental preparedness (*istiḍād*), and receives from His unrestricted mercy a portion of perfection.

If you bring a cup, fill it with wine from the jar;
if you have a bowl, He will measure you a draught⁶

Given this, the bride waiting demurely in the pavilion of prophethood must be shown to each group in a form they are able to perceive and specially arrayed according to their respective faculties of sight.

Each sees your face by the measure of his own sight,
conjuring an association—but you are something else entirely

The respective levels of each group as measured by their doctrines and sciences may be ranked in ascending order. I have provided this classification of the basic position of each with respect to this important topic to serve as a general but accurate and useful model that diligent seekers and inquiring students may apply to other matters. These seven levels (*ṭabaqa*) are as follows:

Level One consists of exotericists (*ahl-i ṣāḥir*), i.e., traditionists who transmit the Prophetic words and preserve their literal forms, relying exclusively on the imitation (*taqlīd*) of what these contain and, being content therewith, having no interest in inquiring further. Their view with respect to this and similar topics is as follows: they insist on understanding the splitting of the moon literally and reject any inquiry into the manner of its occurrence as reprehensible innovation (*bid'at*) and irreligious (*bad*); they allow no meanings of the verse beyond this. As this constitutes the position of the majority of the common run of people (*'avāmm*), the

⁴ I am uncertain as to the meaning of the last hemistich: *dast nadīd ast bi ū dast kun*.

⁵ 'Aṭṭār, ghazal: *ay tū-rā bā har dilī kārī digar*.

⁶ Ni'mat Allāh Valī, ghazal: *nigār-mast-i man har dam zi naw bazmī bi-ārāyad*.

leadership of this group comes from their ranks, and as such the perfect wisdom of the All-wise, the All-knowing has confined their thought to this level.

In the rosegarden of His beauty exists a thorn—exoteric knowledge;
poor indeed are those who content themselves with a thorn!⁷

Level Two likewise consists of exotericists, but those who have progressed beyond the level of imitation and use rational reflection (*fikr, naẓar*) to arrive at certitude (*yaqīn*); these are the philosophers and dialectical theologians of Islam. The majority view of this group with respect to this and similar issues is identical to that of the first group. However, they do not disallow questioning, but rather construct proofs (*dalīl*) for the possibility and manner of such an occurrence, affirming as a foundational principle that God is a free agent (*fā'il-i mukhtār*) Who may do whatever He wills, and that celestial bodies, like other elemental bodies (*aḥsām-i 'unṣurī*), are sensory objects (*maḥsūs*) and are therefore subject to splitting and breaking and the like.

On the basis of these two premises, then, it is possible that such an event could occur at a prophet's command as a miracle to confirm his prophethood. Every proof brought to bear by philosophers to the effect that celestial bodies are not capable of being split is assiduously contested by them and rejected as false. Given that the principle informing the views of the first and the second groups is the same, with the latter admitting the use of reason only with respect to matters for which the Quran and the Sunna provide corroboration, the perfect wisdom of the All-wise, the All-knowing has confined their thought to this level as well. On the basis, then, of the fact that reason can prove the possibility of the moon's splitting, the clear statement of the holy Quran to this effect—*The Hour has drawn nigh: the moon is split* (Q 54:1)—, and hadiths that speak of this episode, they judge that the splitting of the moon at the Prophet's command was meant to serve as a retort to deniers who demanded a miracle of him to prove his prophethood.

The disc of the moon fell broken upon the plate of earth
begging like an indigent a scrap from the table of his wonderworking

Level Three consists of exotericist philosophers (*ḥukamā-yi zāhir*), particularly the latter-day [peripatetics] (*muta'akḥkhirān*), who reason that this sensory moon cannot be subject to splitting by virtue of the fact that it sits in a celestial sphere, nor is divine power (*qudrat*) capable of performing what is impossible (*muḥālāt*). It follows that the splitting of the moon as described in the Quran must have a different meaning. This meaning they construct on the basis of their premise that each planet (*kawkab*) and sphere possesses an internal aspect (*bāṭinī*), which they call an intellect (*'aql*); that belonging to the moon they term the Active Intellect (*'aql-i fa'āl*). A second premise of theirs is that the apex of human perfection, that of the Seal [Muḥammad], consists in one's association or union with the Active Intellect (though on this point there is a difference of opinion). Here a human being is said to attain to the level of the 'acquired intellect' (*'aql-i mustafād*), and whoever attains to this level is rendered capable of expressing what he experiences in that state without need of rational reflection. They hold this to constitute the highest level of human perfection.

On this basis, then, they construe the splitting of the moon as a metaphor (*kināyat*) for the penetration of its outward aspect and union with its internal aspect, the Active Intellect. Given that they see this as the highest level of human perfection, that of the Seal who constitutes the most highly evolved individual of the human species, the splitting of the moon is associated exclusively with the Prophet. This is how the matter is discussed by exotericist philosophers,

⁷ 'Irāqī, ghazal: *tā chand 'ishq bāzīm bar rūy-i har nigārī*.

i.e., the peripatetics (*mashshā'iyān*), who take Aristotle as their teacher and boast Ibn Sīnā as their head (*ra'īs*) and master (*shaykh*).

Having supplied yourself with Greek water, embark on the road to Yathrib
for one of the springs along this way is the path of the Greek scouts⁸

Level Four consists of the ancient philosophers (*hukamā-yi qadīm*), called in today's usage illuminationists (*ishrāqiyān*). This group too holds the splitting of the sensory moon to be impossible. They construe the meaning of this [operation] on the basis of their premise that light (*nūr*) constitutes the principle of the world's manifestation, and everything therein may be divided into two categories: that pertaining to sheer light, which does not contain any darkness of bodies; and that which may be intermixed (*mumtazij*) with the darkness of bodies. Knowledge of universals (*kullīyyāt*) and realities abstracted from matter pertains to the first light, which is wholly free of particulars (*juz'īyyāt*). As for the second category of light which is intermixed with darkness and sends out rays in every direction, it encompasses knowledge of both universals and particulars, after these have emerged from potentiality into actuality. This group likewise holds that the apex and terminus of the chain of existents entails that there must emerge knowledge in its fullness of all universals and particulars, for nothing can manifest while in a state of potentiality.

On this basis, then, they hold the splitting of the moon to connote that eventuality wherein the intermixed light, which is geared toward bringing all the knowledge contained potentially within it into actuality, manifests this knowledge by way of the reflection of the rays of the perfection of manifestation and making-manifest (*paydā-kunandagī*). The moon thus stands as a metaphor for this intermixed light, and its splitting refers to the manifestation of all types of knowledge and the perfection of manifestation and making-manifest that had been contained within it, with its splitting leading to the manifestation of these contents to the denizens of the world. They see the correspondences between each to be obvious and not in need of explanation. And since the terminus of the chain of existents and the apex of the level of engendered beings (*kā'ināt*), i.e., the level of the Seal, entails the manifestation of all the knowledge contained therein, the splitting of the moon in this sense must likewise be peculiar to the Prophet, in whom everything that is manifests and is made manifest.

In sum, my essence is the site wherein all things manifest—
yea, when I consider I find myself forsooth the Greatest Name⁹

Level Five consists of the verifying Sufis (*muḥaqqiqān-i sūfiyya*) and those with an experiential knowledge of the divine (*ahl-i shuhūd*). They construe the meaning of this matter on the basis of a certain premise that in turn exhibits a number of their principles: the principle of existence descends through the divine levels and the realms of engendered existence and manifests therein in every form in order to manifest its full perfection. This perfection is of two types and has two levels: the first is the level of manifestation (*zuhūr, paydā'ī*) wherein everything that is manifests as it is in its full completeness (*tamām*), which form is termed by them the human being, i.e., a reality that encompasses all levels of existents such that all universals and all particulars are contained within it, according to the dictum *Not a thing fresh or withered but it is in a Book Manifest* (Q 6:59); through it all things emerge into the realm of form and manifestation.

⁸ 'Aṭṭār, qasida: *a-lā ay Yūsuf-i qudsī bar-āy az chāh-i zulmānī*.

⁹ 'Irāqī, qasida: *shahbāz-am va shikār-i jahān nīst darkh^war-am*.

All that is is within thee:
seek from thyself all that thou wilt—thou art that¹⁰

The pith and subtle essence of every thing
is held in deposit within this *summa*

The second level of the perfection of existence is that of making-manifest (*izhār, paydā-kunandagī*) wherein everything that is is made manifest as it is in its full perfection. According to the usage of this group, the Seal (*khātam*) is that individual capable of filling this office and through whom this great work is effected. In the exteriorization of meaning it may derive from a form perfect in itself in its own level, and manifest this form in the world.

On the basis of this premise, then, the moon is a metaphor for that perfect form. Indeed, it is common among poets of all nations to refer to a perfect form as a moon; as the poet sings:

Moon of the house, veil your face
lest reason gutter into madness!¹¹

The splitting of the moon is likewise a metaphor for the emergence of meaning in its full perfection from that perfect form, thus bypassing the need for ratiocination using conventional means (*ālāt-i ja'li*) and syllogisms with rationally-derived premises (*tartīb-i muqaddamāt-i kasbī*); this route was vouchsafed the Seal.

Light of mine eyes, the age of sanctified power has arrived!
Go dunk your notebook in water—there's no point in talking now

Level Six consists of those who can decipher the quranic letters (*ramz-kh'ānān-i ḥurūf-i qur'ānī*), who derive their knowledge directly from these forms, revealed to the prophets from the heaven of holiness and the encompassing realm of divine incomparability (*muḥīt-i tanzīh*), without the mediation of rational reflection or practice, of inquiry or analysis. Their reading of this topic according to this method rests on the following premise: Existence has many levels which differ among themselves in the degree to which they admit of existence. Some are independent in that they can exist in themselves, such as the levels of spirits, of subtle bodies (*ajsād*) and of sensible bodies (*ajsām*); others are dependent, such as the levels of actions, of utterances (*aqvāl*), etc. Among the most foundational of these levels is that of speech (*kalām*), in which exists all that is in every divine or engendered level of being, whether universals or particulars (*az juz'īyyāt-i ḥaqāyiq u kullīyyāt-i ān*)—indeed, in it exist all impossible things (*mumtani'āt, muḥālāt*) that do not exist in those other levels. Among the particularities of this all-encompassing level is the fact that all meanings manifest therefrom, and all gnostic truths (*ḥaqāyiq, ma'ārif*) become evident therein and known to [us] worldlings, and the fullness of that concept which is the very essence of the Real and the Absolute Beloved (*maḥbūb-i muṭlaq*)

shall also appear on this throne.

Tarry till its secret be revealed
tarry till its affair become manifest

¹⁰ Rūmī, *Dīvān-i Shams*, pt. 11: *az sāya-yi 'āshiqān agar dūr shavī*. Cf. the Upanishadic *tat tvam asi*.

¹¹ Sa'dī, ghazal: *rūy bipūsh ay qamar-i khānaqī*.

Yet this level does not possess independent existence; it but borrows (*iqtibās*) the light of manifestation from the Speaker, and its existence is dependent upon His existence.

Based on this premise, then, the moon is a metaphor for this [all-comprehensive yet dependent] level [of existence]. First, it is so with respect to the fact that it is dependent for its manifestation [on another], for speech only manifests through the light of the manifestation of the speaker; likewise, the moon is [only illumined] through the light of the manifestation of the greater luminary, [the sun], without which it remains in the darkness of nonexistence. Second, the form [of speech] from this level that persists in a fixed state and manifests most clearly the effects and properties (*aḥkām*) of this level's existence is written (*raqamī*), as distinct from its other forms; for its spoken (*nuṭqī*) form has no enduring or fixed existence. [Speech] has no other form in external existence apart from these two. Furthermore, it is evident that *raqam* is identical to *qamar* on the basis of the letters. In this respect, then, the splitting of the moon is a metaphor for the emergence of primordial meaning from the written-textual (*raqamī-yi kitābī*) form [of speech] without the mediation of reflective thought (*fikr*) and its [analytical] efforts. This is at variance with the accepted method of deriving conventional meanings (*ma'ānī-yi vaż'ī*) and formal sciences (*'ulūm-i rasmī*), which are arrived at only through the mediation of the artificial assignment [of meaning] (*ja'l-i jā'il*) and its classificatory approach (*tartīb*)—not so the unveiled truths of this [sixth] group, which break forth of themselves from the coverts of written [speech]:

The escapee sees differently than the captive.¹²

I've seen Sa'ds of many nations
but never a Sa'd like Sa'd b. Mālik¹³

Level Seven is the level of the *men of might and vision*,¹⁴ the personal servants of the Seal and the heirs of his supreme perfection. The appearance of this type is peculiar to the present time, ruled by an auspicious conjunction: *through you our days are forgiven their trespasses*. This allusion may be briefly explicated as follows: The perfect speech of the Seal of prophecy (upon him be the richest of blessings and the most fervent of greetings)—symbolized here by the perfection of form [of the moon]—doubtlessly comprises all meanings, including the knowledge of what was, is and will be; all is comprised within it in the utterness of its perfection. Yet no one knows how these [meanings] may be derived [therefrom] and none have glimpsed their alluring aspect save by virtue of the pillars of the prophetic House (*asāṭīn-i ahl-i bayt*). [This dignity belongs to the Imams alone], even though many perfected men conversant with supernal truths have by means of the sublimity of their unveiling intuitions and gnostic verifications made progress in this direction; exalted ideas did occur to them, [it is true], but none understood the meaning in its fullness or the true import of that speech.

You have a thousand observers—yet none has seen your face
a hundred nightingales atrill—and you still in the bud¹⁵

¹² *Bar basta digar bāshad u bar rasta digar*. The hemistich is by Kh^wājū Kirmānī (d. 753/1352).

¹³ Ṭarafa b. al-'Abd, qasida: *qifī wadda'ī-nā l-yawma yā bnata Māliki*.

¹⁴ Q 38:45.

¹⁵ Ḥāfiz, ghazal: *rū-yi tū kas nadīd u hazār-at raqīb hast*.

But the same Family of the Seal (blessings and peace be upon him)—the Amir [‘Alī] and his glorious sons (peace be upon them)—possessed a transcript (*vaz’i*), called *jafr*, that remains [to us]; this demonstrates how to derive the meaning in its full perfection.

Given this premise, it may be said that the splitting of the moon, according to the expression found in the perfect quranic speech revealed to the Seal (blessings and peace be upon him), *The Hour has drawn nigh* (AL S A = 92): *the moon is split* (LF A M A F YM A = 283), is the demonstration of that path [of *jafr*] in the manner known to them and their servants.

We have spoken of but one point from this volume—it is this¹⁶

Further discussion is beyond the scope of the present treatise; should seekers be inclined to pursue this in detail they may refer to fuller treatments elsewhere.¹⁷

Discourse on the Meaning of the Hour

Given that in the holy verse the Hour is mentioned together with the splitting of the moon, it is fitting that its meaning be likewise explicated according to the same seven levels so that the meaning of the verse become evident in its fullness. It reads as follows: *The Hour has drawn nigh: the moon is split. Yet if they see a sign they turn away, and they say ‘A continuous sorcery!’* (Q 54:1-2). That is to say, the day of resurrection (*qiyāmat*) has drawn nigh and the moon is split, but if hypocrites and unbelievers see a sign they reject it and say, This is obvious sorcery. The verse may be translated thus. Now the meaning of the Hour: whatever has existed from the beginning of preeternity (*avval-i azal*) together with that which will come to be until the end of posteternity (*ākhir-i abad*), all will be judged according to the actions which they having manifested did perform, these being weighed in the balance of true justice. The folk of wretchedness (*ahl-i shaqāvat*) will be separated out, and each will take his station. [All] begins with Him and to Him returns (Q 11:123).

Level One consists of the jurists and traditionists, partisans of the exoteric (*ahl-i zāhir*), who hold that every atom of a human body that becomes dispersed therefrom in death will be reassembled and reinvested with life at that Hour. It is not permitted to ask how this will come about; it is incumbent upon us to simply accept (*taqlīd*) what the prophets and perfected men have communicated to us, and the holy Quran speaks in such terms in a number of places.

Level Two consists of the dialectical theologians and those who rely on reason and reflection (*ahl-i ‘aql u fikr*); they are not content to blindly accept [the ostensible sense of the quranic text] in such matters. They rather hold that God Most High is an entirely free agent and capable of doing as He will; He is thus able to reassemble the atoms of a human body that are dispersed upon death, thereby recreating precisely the same person, just as when He created him initially from nothing. Thus do they respond to the philosophers’ argument that it is impossible for something that has ceased to be (*ma’dūm*) to be again. Some theologians hold, however, that for a person to be fully reconstituted it is sufficient that only his original bodily parts be restored, [rather than each individual atom that originally constituted them].

¹⁶ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *kay shi’r tar angīzad khāṭir ki ḥazīn bāshad*.

¹⁷ As in the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, to which Ṣā’ib al-Dīn often refers his readers in other minor works.

Level Three consists of the peripatetic philosophers, who hold that only human spirits (*arvāḥ*) will be held to account on the Day of Judgment. This spirit is an immaterial substance (*jawharī mujarrad*), that is, its existence has no need of matter, which is subject to qualification by size, color, shape or location; it is created wholly free of such things. In this respect, [the spirit] is the site of various types of knowledge—indeed, the knowledge of all things—and achieves its full perfection when all things, from the beginning of preeternity to the end of posteternity, manifest within it and come to its knowledge. Upon attaining to this level it returns to its primordial origin. All this takes place within the immaterial realm far above the physical world of taint and admixture. Everything pertaining to that realm is fully known; ignorance and incapacity cannot occur there.

If you reach my beloved's alley
you will see its doors and walls as pure spirit

Level Four consists of the illuminationist philosophers, who also hold that this return is solely that of the spirit, which is immortal. According to this group, this spirit is a light that may become attached to the darkness of the world of the body. One of the properties of this light is that whenever it strikes a dark [(i.e., solid)] object and cannot pass through it, the light casts a shadow and returns whence it came with increased brightness due to the reflection. Therefore this existential light (*nūr-i vujūdī*) which has become attached to the world of the body, in which form it is called the human spirit or rational soul (*nafs-i nāṭiqā*), must necessarily be reflected and enhanced. Its enhancement consists in the fact that before [its contact with the material world] it can comprehend only universals, whereas after such contact it becomes capable of comprehending the particulars of the world in equal measure. When [the spirit] then attains to its fullness, no existent can remain unknown to it, whether among the universals of the supernal realm or the particulars of the lower realm. The saying *upon the day when the secrets are tried* (Q 86:9) thus refers to this level.

All that it was, or is, or will be
find within you—for there it is

Level Five consists of the Sufis, who hold that all things must return to the source from whence they came. This may be explained as follows: the manifestation of the form of the Real in its full perfection, in the sense that everything possible is realized, corresponds to the period of time from Adam (peace be upon him) to the Arab Muḥammad (blessings and peace be upon him), who is the Seal of prophethood. For the term prophet means someone who is able to fix (*vazʿ*) the form of the Real, and Muḥammad (God's blessings and peace be upon him) became the Seal of the prophets precisely through the perfection of the transcript (*vazʿ*) he established and the form that was revealed to him. This is a perfect form (*ṣūrat-i kāmīla*) such that, even were a more perfect form hypothetically possible, he would still serve as Seal to all that was revealed to him. Perfection of form consists in the fact that [through it] no meanings remain hidden in the depths of endless [time] and obscurity; rather, it shows forth all meanings in a form which is capable of revealing them.

Given this premise, whoever understands this perfect form as it is and in whom the perfection of its meaning is manifested thus comes to contain all that has been from the beginning of preeternity and will be to the end of posteternity.

Today, tomorrow, yesterday and the day before
all four will be one for you tomorrow

Level Six consists of the lettrists (*arbāb-i ‘ilm-i ḥurūf*), who likewise hold that all things return to their source. However, the form in which they do so is a holy and heavenly form wholly transcendent (*munazzah*) and divested of the taint of the world of the body and the admixture of the usages of creation (*taṣarrufāt-i khalq*)—this being the 29 letters revealed to the Seal of the prophets.¹⁸ When the meanings of those letters manifest in a form free of the usages of transcription and accretions (*taṣarrufāt-i vaṣ’ u dakhil-hā*) extraneous to the letters that attach thereto, according to the saying *The moon is split* as a sign of the Hour, the perfection of meaning manifests therefrom: all that is, from the beginning of preeternity to the end of posteternity, becomes manifest; nothing remains hidden.

If there were a substance (*gawharī*) beyond the letters
it would have been revealed in their place

Level Seven is that of the *men of might and vision* (*ūlī l-aydī wa-l-abṣār*) (Q 38:45), and is peculiar to the present time (*khāṣṣ-i īn zamān ast*). As our Sayyid (God keep him and his noble fathers) has made clear, what advanced [thinkers] and verifiers have made known in general terms represents the emergence of all the meanings contained within this perfect form [i.e., the Quran]; but they were unable to deduce (*istinbāt*) these [meanings] in their full detail or to [conclusively] establish their modes and dispositions (*aḥvāl u awzā’*). Thus while they did manage to speak somewhat as to the meaning of the Return [to God] (*bāzgasht u ma’ād*), they remained incapable of [construing the meaning of] the Day of Judgment, the Balance and the weighing of deeds, and the Pool (*ḥawẓ*)—all such [information] being the sole preserve of the Amir [‘Alī] (peace be upon him)—, and likewise did not discover the method of extracting meaning from the letters, the root of all things, without the aid of human effort (*kasb u ta’ammul-i shakhṣ*).

Here a thousand meanings finer than a hair:
a shaved head doesn’t make you a calender¹⁹

The details of all such meanings, then, may be construed on the basis of this most dependable of methods—[to wit, that of *jafr*]. The word *sā’a* [or Hour will thus be found to] comprise the meanings I mentioned within it when analyzed according to the method known to the servants of [the House of the Prophet].

Blessings and peace be upon Muḥammad, his holy House and his pure line; praise be to God, Lord of the worlds. [The treatise] was completed on 18 Rabī’ I 829 [28 January 1426].²⁰

¹⁸ I.e., reckoning the digraph *lām-alif* as a letter.

¹⁹ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *na har ki chihra bar-afrūkht dilbarī dānad*.

²⁰ This may alternatively refer to the date on which the treatise was copied.

بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم

سپاس و ستایش پروردگاری را که ظروف حروف و کلمات مستقر جواهر معارف و شناسائی حضرت تنزیه نضرت خود گردانیده از آسمان قدس و سای استغنا فرو فرستاد تا پویندگان شاه راه آفرینش و جویندگان گوهر دانش و بینش را رهنمایی کند و بسر انجام تمام مرام رساند، ﴿تَبَارَكَ الَّذِي نَزَّلَ الْفُرْقَانَ عَلَى عَبْدِهِ لِيَكُونَ لِلْعَالَمِينَ نَذِيرًا﴾ [۲۵:۱]، و هزاران درود و صلوات بر برگزیده‌ای که فرستاده آسمان هدایت بدولت رسالت او تمام فرود آمد و فرسوده زمین ضلالت باقبال دعوت و ارشاد او از حضيض نقصان باوج کمال بر آمد.

محمد که اصل هستی شد وجودش جهان گردی ز شاد روان جودش

پوشیده نماند که در این ریاض عالم آرایش و آمیزش درخت برومند سعادت و کمال همین شجره عرفان ثمره گرامی پیکر تمام گوهر آدمیست که سرو چمن پرستش و کوشش و نهال گلبن دانش و بینش است:

نخستین فطرت پسین شمار تویی خویشتن را بیازی مدار^۲

و از این روست که نوباوه حضرات قدس و ترمیوه بستان بقا و انس یعنی حروف کلامی و کتابی بر آورده درخت جمعیت اوست و برکشیده سنان و قلم او، اگر نه میامن رواج حقایق فوایح آن ثمره نامدار بودی خاکیان عالم هیولانی از جناب جلال و حضرت احدی چه نشان یافتندی و اگر نه بوی دلجوی او لطف نمودی و رهنمونی کردی محبوسان مطموره عنصر ظلمانی از صفای کرویّان ملاً اعلی و مقدّسان عالم روحانی چه اثر توانستندی دید.

گر باد نبودی که سر زلف ربودی رخساره معشوق بعاشق که نمودی^۳

فلولا شذاها ما اهتدینا^۴ لِحَانِهَا ولولا سَنَاهَا ما تصوّرَها الوَهم^۵

^۱ ما = مجلس ۱۰۱۹۶ ص ۱۱۵۴-۱۱۵۷؛ مب = مجلس ۱۰۰۰۴ ص ۱۳۷-۱۵۱.

^۲ فردوسی، شاهنامه.

^۳ سهروردی مقتول.

و از جمله آیات ترقی زمان و قرب [مب ۱۳۸] اهالی آن بادرک علوم حقایق آنست که در این وقت دولتمندی چند که صنوف ملکات ملکی را پیرایه عظیم کارهای مُلک گردانیده فنون حقایق و معارف درویشانه با فز و احتشام بزرگانه در سلک انتظام کشیده اند دیده همت بلند جنابشان فریفته خجسته مال رنگ جاہ بوی دنیا نشده بلکه مخدّره مدرسه و خانقاه به شیوه علم و دلال کمال از بازار دلربایی ایشان نومید باز گشته.^۶

همه را دیده بر حدیقه قدس همه را روی در حظیره حی

مکررا چنان نمودند که مقدمهء درخور وقت ایشانست که جامع اطوار علم حروف باشد، چنانچه مبتدی از فهم آن و امعان در او بسوی صورت و معنی حروف مهتدی و بهره‌ور گردد، هر چند وصول بمراقی این مرتبه نه در وسع این زمانست و نه در حدّ این فقیر.

بر آن اوج از چو من گردی چه خیزد که ابر آنجا رسد آتش بریزد^۷

ولیکن بحکم فرموده (ارباب الدول ملهمون) امتثال فرموده الهام انجامشان ناگزیر بود، هر آینده بر طبق مساعدت زمان آنچه عجله الوقت منشی ذوق بر جریدهء مشاعر ثبت داشت عبارتی شکسته بسته:

چو زلف یار پریشان چو کار من در هم

صورت تحریر یافت تا مسافران اقلیم طلب و سیّاحان بیابان جدّ و تعب را ما حضری باشد از مایدهء وقت و نوباوه‌ای از بستان زمان.

خوان ترا این دو نواله سخن دست ندیدست بدو^۸ دستکن^۹

و چون ادب تصنیف اقتضای بیان ترتیب تالیف میکند اوّلاً بعد از آن شروع در مقصود، هر آینه این رساله منطوی شد بر مقدمه‌ای که معرّست از معنی حرف و تحقیق اقسام اوّلی آن و سه اصل که مبین اقسام حروف و احکام کلی هر یک باشد علی التفصیل و تذهیبی که مشتمل بر معانی سبع المثانی بود تا مثالی شود ادراک آن اصول را.

^۴ یا (اهتدیث).

^۵ ابن فارض، قصیده (شرئنا علی ذکر الحبيب مُدامه / سکرتنا بما من قبل أن یُخلّق الکرم).

^۶ مب: (گشت).

^۷ نظامی، خسرو و شیرین.

^۸ یا (نکردست برو).

^۹ نظامی، مخزن الاسرار.

اما مقدمه در بیان معنی حرف و اقسام اولی او،¹⁰ حرف از روی لغت عرب طرف و نهایت هر چیز را گویند، و از روی تحقیق عبارت از صورتیست فرو فرستاده از آسمان قدس که هر چه هست او پیدا میکند و آشکارا میگرداند، بلکه آنچه نیست نیز و در دایره وجود در نیامده هم پیدا میکند و چگونگی او را هویدا میگرداند، هر آینه احاطت او شاملتر از وجود و شیء و هر عاقی باشد [مب ۱۳۹] که تصور کنند، پس او بر همه اشیا محیط بود و فرارسیده و یکسان بر همه که بهیچ طرف میل نکرده و بهمان احاطت اصلی خود راست استاده چه هر چه هست غیر از او میل بطرفی کرده و مقابل آن را گذاشته چنانچه وجود که عدم را گذاشته و همچنین شیء و امکان و هر چه تصور کنی، ﴿الحمد لله الذي أنزل على عبدي الكتاب ولم يجعل له عوجاً﴾ [۱۸:۱]، و آن صورت مذکوره را سه¹¹ مجلی آفریده شده است که در آنجاها خود را بنماید و نهایت هر چیز و کنه [ما ۱۵۴ب] او را هویدا گرداند. اول آن بصرست که عین (عبد) بدان اشارتست، دوم قلب که بآه بدان مشعرست، و سوم سمع که دال بدان دلالت میکند. پس حرف بر این تقدیر منقسم بر سه قسم شود، اول حرف رقی کنایی که بدستاری ابادی و اصابع بر الواح بیاض و فضای آن صورت تسطیر و تصویر مییابد و بر مجالی بصایر و ابصار کشف حقایق میکند و ارباب فهم آن اولوا الایدی و الابصارند. دوم حرف لفظی کلامی که بقوت السنه و طبقات مخارج بر هوای منتفس صورت تقریر و تصویر میگیرد و بر مجالی اساع و عقول تعبیر از حقایق میکند و اصحاب آن اهل ذکرند. سوم حرف معنوی لبابی که بقوت عاقله و متخیله در فضای فسیح معانی بر مجلای قلب صورت تحقیق و تبیین میپذیرد و اهل آن اولوا الالبابند، ﴿ومن يؤت الحكمة فقد أوتي خيراً كثيراً وما يذكر إلا أولوا الأبواب﴾ [۲:۲۶۹]. و هر یک از این اقسام بمشعری از مشاعر ثلاثه انسانی مخصوصست یعنی دل و سمع و بصر، و از این رو آن مشاعر ثلاثه در آیات منزله قرآنی بیشتر در یک سلک منتظم است و در اکثر یا تقدیم قلب نموده چنانچه در آیت ﴿إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَذِكْرَ لِمَنْ كَانَ لَهُ قَلْبٌ أَوْ أَلْقَى السَّمْعَ وَهُوَ شَهِيدٌ﴾ [۵۰:۳۷] و آیت ﴿لَيْسَ كَمِثْلِهِ شَيْءٌ وَهُوَ السَّمِيعُ الْبَصِيرُ﴾ [۴۲:۱۱] یا تقدیم سمع نموده چنانچه در آیت ﴿وَجَعَلَ لَكُمُ السَّمْعَ وَالْأَبْصَارَ وَالْأَفْئِدَةَ﴾ [۱۶:۷۸، ۳۲:۹، ۶۷:۲۳]، و همانا در ترتیب اول تقدیم ذاتی اصلی ملاحظه شده که قلب را واقعست نسبت با سایر جوارح بل با جمیع موجودات، و در ترتیب ثانی همانا تقدیمی معتبر شده که در حین ایجاد و خلقت چه در آن باب مقدم سمعست که سماع کلمه (کن) بر وجود دیگر جوارح و ادراک ایشان مقدمست ولیکن چون ادب تعلیم و تفهیم اقتضای تقدیم جزو اظهر میکند چنانچه در آیت ﴿أَبْصِرْ بِهِ وَاسْمِعْ﴾ [۱۸:۲۶] واردست، [مب ۱۴۰] هر آینه تقدیم صورت رقی در این مقام انسب و بمنهج صواب اقرب باشد و گویا خصوصیت صیغه امر در این آیت کریمه اشعار بمقام تعلیم و تفهیمست و در اینجا نکته‌ای است که هر چند صورت رقی اظهرست و صورت معنوی اخفی ولیکن اول محتاج باکتساب و تعلمست و ثانی احتیاج ندارد چه معرفت اعداد و مراتب آن بکسب محتاج نیست بخلاف معرفت رقوم حروف و اشکال که بی کسب و تعلم فهم آن صورت نبندد، و این معنی مبتنیست بر اصلی از اصول توحید که بر اهل آن پوشیده نماند.

بَدَتْ بِاحْتِجَابٍ وَاخْتَفَتْ بِمَظَاهِرٍ عَلَى صَبْغِ التَّكْوِينِ¹² فِي كُلِّ بَرْزَةٍ¹³

¹⁰ مب: (آن).

¹¹ مب: (سه) مسقوط شد.

¹² یا (صَبْغِ التَّلْوِينِ).

¹³ ابن فارض، تائیه، بیت ۲۴۶/۲۴۴.

اینجا سخنی دیگر هست که در مقدمه دانستن آن ناگزیرست که چون علم حروف از علوم کلیه است که محتوی بر بسی علمهاست که هر یک از جلالیل علومست و غایات ارجمند دارد و بر او مترتب منسوبان این علم هر آینه طوایف مختلفه اند ولیکن علی اختلاف طبقاتهم از دو صنف بیرون نیستند. **صنف اول** و اشهر اهل خواصند که بحث از خواص هر یک کنند بحسب هر صورتی از این صور ثلاثه که اگر کسی بوصفی معین و شرایط مخصوص آن را بخواند یا نگاه دارد فلان خاصیت بدهد از روی مراتب دنیوی یا معاملات اخروی و مدارج آن، چنانچه شیخ ابو العباس بونی¹⁴ و غیره از مشایخ و ایشان را تصانیف و رسایل بسیار هست و بیشتر مردم که منسوبند بدین علم و متوجه او غرضشان همین نوعست. و **صنف دوم** اهل حقایق اند که بحث ایشان از جهت معانیست و علوم کلی که هر چه هست از صنوف معارف و علوم خواه حضرات الهیه و خواه عوالم امکانیه و آنچه در او حادث میشود، جمله از کتاب آسمانی و حروف مقطعه قرآنی فهم کنند، و همچنین خواص هر چه در این عالم ظاهر شده و خواهد شد من الازل الی الابد همه را دریابند و بقدر قوت فهم و استعداد معلوم کنند. و غرض ما از این رساله چندی از اصول این طایفه است که طالب مسترشد را نوع انسی بدین علم بشود و بعد از آن بحسب جد و اجتهاد و قوت استعداد در اطوار کمال آن ترقی کند، و فقههم الله تعالی و ائانا الیه.

اصل اول

در بیان حروف رقی کتابی

﴿وهو الذی [مب ۱۴۱] أنزل إلکم الکتاب مفضلاً﴾ [۶: ۱۱۴] الآیه،¹⁵ و چون رقوم کتابی را مناسبت بطور ولایت که جانب معانی و حقایقست بیشتر افتاده و از این رو بسی بزرگان ولایت شعار طریق استکشاف حقایق را بر این مقصور گردانیده اند و بی تکلف بسی لطایف جلیله و دقایق ارجمند در طی هر رقی مندرجست، هر آینه از این رو چنانچه در آیت کریمه گذشت و از جهت ظهور نیز بحث او مقدم داشته شد.

حرف آب حیانتست و سیاهی ظلماتش هر کس که بدانست نفرسود حیاتش

و آن مشتمل بر چهار وصلست.

¹⁴ قس شمس المعارف الکبری، ص ۵: "أقول وبالله التوفیق والهدایة قد انقسمت مطالب الراغبین إلى قسمین دنیوی وأخروی، وینقسم کل واحد منهما إلى أقسام بحسب المقاصد. وقد تکلم الناس فی معارضة الأوقات والوقوف علی الکواکب والریاضات وأفعال الطلسمات قبل وضع هذا الکتاب والحديث علیه، وهذا العلم متسع رغب فيه خلق وثابروا علیه لاسیما من وجد لذلك أثرا عظیما؛ فأردت معارضة ذلك بوصف یجری مجری الخاصّة فیما نجاه أهل هذا العلم وتکلمت فیہ الحکماء الأوائل ووافق علی ذلك القول کثیر من الناس، فتلك إن کثرت فی الدنیا أضرت فی الآخرة، وهذا الذی أذکره لك تتنفع به فی الدنیا والآخرة."

¹⁵ ﴿أَفَعَبِّرَ اللَّهُ أَبْتَعِي حَكْمًا وَهُوَ الَّذِي أَنْزَلَ إِلَيْكُمُ الْكِتَابَ مُفَصَّلًا وَالَّذِينَ آتَيْنَاهُمُ الْكِتَابَ يَعْلَمُونَ أَنَّهُ مُنْزَّلٌ مِنْ رَبِّكَ بِالْحَقِّ فَلَا تَكُونَنَّ مِنَ الْمُفْتَرِينَ﴾

وصل اول در بیان کتیت رقهها

و آن عبارت از بیست و هشت یا بیست و نه صورتست اصلی و بیست و دو نقطه فرعی چنانچه مجموع پنجاه رقم باشد [ما ۱۵۵] صورت پنجاه نماز که بر محمد صلی الله علیه و سلم واجب شد لیلۃ المعراج و این تمام صورتست که کلام عرب که عبارت از تمام کلامست مشتمل بر آن خواهد بود و بمحمد عربی صلی الله علیه و سلم فرود آمده، و از این رو که او تمام صورتست و جوامع الکلم و معرب از کنه و نهایت هر چیز هر آینه صاحب او خاتم الرساله باشد چه هر که صاحب تمام صورت بود و بدو فرود آمده باشد و او واضع آن شده بین الامم غیر از او خاتم النبوه و الرساله نتواند بود، و پیشتر از محمد عربی در زمان انبیای سابق که قبل از ابراهیم علیه السلام بوده اند و در زمان او به بیست و چهار رسید که صاحب تحقیق باسماى ثبوتی حق است و بحکم فرموده ﴿وَإِذْ يَرْفَعُ إِبْرَاهِيمُ الْقَوَاعِدَ مِنَ الْبَيْتِ﴾ [۲:۱۲۷] او مؤسس بنیان حقایق ختمی شد و از این جهتست که در صلوات بر محمد اشعاری بتقدم او ماثور آمده چنانچه در شرح کتاب **فصوص الحکم** تحقیق آن مبسوط گشته اگر خواهند آنجا طلب کنند، و در زمان حضرت رسالت باربعهء معربه که منظوم بر عدد کاملست تمام گشت و سبع المثانی شد چنانچه تحقیق آن ظاهر خواهد شد.

چل روز از آن سبب گل آدم سرشته بود^{۱۶} تا قصر دین بخت وجودت شود تمام^{۱۷}

و واضع اشکال این رقوم حضرت ولایت اقطاع امیر المؤمنین علی علیه السلام بوده بطریقه ای که رسم الخط کوفیست بعد از آن ابن مقاله که وزیر القاهر بالله بوده از عباسیان آن را تغییری کرد، و بعد از آن بحسب هر زمان بتدریج از بساطت زاویه بتقوس کمالی میل کرد [مب ۱۴۲] از برای نکته ای که تحقیق آن در غیر این مجال کرده شده.

وصل دوم در بیان ترتیب ارقام

و آن بر دو وجه واقعست، یکی ترتیب ازدواجی که در آن همین جانب ظاهر رقوم مرعیست چنانچه بحث آن خواهد آمد، و دیگر ترتیب افرادی و مرعی در آن صورت معنوی عددیست چنانچه در اصل ثالث تحقیق آن میآید. و در ترتیب اول اختلافی نیست، اما در ترتیب دوم میان مغاربه و اهل این طرف در چند حرف معین اختلافست، و چون تحقیق آن معنی نسبت باغراض ما چندان دخلی و طایلی ندارد در آن شروع نمیرود و بهر تقدیر صور اصول این حروف مذکور پانزده بیش نیست یا شانزده، و آن اینست **ا ب ج د ر س ص ع ف ک ل م ن ه ل ا ی**، و اگر نقطه را یا همزه را اعتبار کنند که او نیز صاحب صورت رقیست هر چند جهت نکته که اینجا مجال تحقیق آن نیست معدود نمیشود هفده باشد که عدد رکعات صلاه مفروضه است این وقتیست که حروف باطلاق خود در حضرات قدس و تنزیه باشد بجهان آمیزش و آرایش ظاهر نشده و صورت ترکیب کونی نگرفته، چه هرگاه که بعالم آمیزش ترکیبی ظاهر گردد از صورتی چند که مظاهر شوند ایشان را ناگزیر

^{۱۶} اشاره است به حدیث قدسی: (خَمَرَتْ طِينَةَ آدَمَ بِيْدَيَّ اَرْبَعِينَ صَبَاحًا).

^{۱۷} کمال الدین اسماعیل، از ترکیب بند در وصف پیغمبر.

میشود و آن نه صورتست که بمنزله نه عرض میآید که مبنای عالم شهادت بر آنست و آن سه حرکتست که در افراد و ازدواج شش میشود و سکون و تشدید و مدّ. و در تطبیق میانه هر دو کتاب، یعنی کتاب وجودی ظهوری که عالم عبارت از آنست و کتاب رقی اظهاری که کلام اشارت بدانست، سخن مبسوط در کتاب **خصایص کمالی** رفته اینجا مجال بیش از این نیست.

وصل سوّم

چون معنی انزال که کتاب بدان ظاهر گشته حرکتست از بالا به زیر و از بلندی وحدت ذاتی و بود سوی پستی کثرت فعلی و نمود و روشنست که صورتی که اوّل از آن حرکت حاصل میشود صورت خطیست و آن صورت الف است که مقدّم حروفست و بعد از آن چون حقیقت ظهور و نمود که غایت آن حرکت انزالست مستتبع دیگر حرکات انبساطی خواهد بود بالضروره که ذات الیمین و ذات الشمال متقلّب گردد و بدایره منتهی شود پس اگر نهایت جمعیت آن حرکات را [مب ۱۴۳] بینند و تمام صورتی که از آن ظاهر گردد آن **میم** است، و اگر واسطه و برزخ میان این دو طرف ملاحظه کنند که نه بیساطت الف باشد و نه بجمعیت **میم** آن **لام** است چنانچه در اسم او اشعاری ظاهر بدین معنی هست، پس **ال م** جامع سایر صور رقی باشد بر این تقدیر چنانچه بر ارباب فطانت بعد از آن تنبیه همانا پوشیده نماند، و آنچه مؤید این اصلیت از حقایق حکمی آنست که¹⁸ ببرهان ثابت شده است که صورت تعلیمی جسم که هر چه در عالم حش و خیال ظاهر گشته [ما ۱۵۵ب] بسبب تلبّس بملاسل اوست، بلکه هر چه در طی صورت در آمده از آن عاری نمیتواند بود اصول آن از سه بیرون نیست یا خطّست که آن طول تهاست یا سطحست که آن طولست با عرض یا جسمست که آن طول و عرض و عمق است و ا صورت اولست و ل صورت دوّم و م صورت سوّم، و وجه تطابق بین الکتابین مقررست چنانچه بیشترک بدان اشارتی رفت.

وصل چهارم

بباید دانست که آن صور حرفی که اصول آن رقومند ایشان را با هم جهات امتیازیت که بدان متباین و متخالفند از هم و وجوه اشتراکی که بدان وجوه با هم یگانگی و اتحاد دارند و هر یک از این جهات تباین و اشتراک یا تامّست چنانچه هر باک و ج را با ح یا غیر تامّ چنانچه هر با م و ح را با ع، و هر یک از این وجوه متضمن فنون دقایق و صنوف حقایقست و این رساله لایق بیان آنها نیست در **خصایص کمالی** چندی مبین گشته آنچه اینجا ناگزیرست از بیان آن یک و جهست که این تقسیم کاشف آنست که هر حرفی که هست یا مفردست که شریک ندارد در صورت رقی همچون¹⁹ **الف و ها و کاف** یا مثانی که یک شریک بیش ندارد یا مثالث که دو شریک دارد و در میان این اقسام ثلاثه مثانی برزخ واقع شده و صاحب جمعیت اوست و لهذا در ترتیب ازدواجی که ملحوظ در آنجا صورت رقیست مثانی در میان واقع شده و جای قلب گرفته و

¹⁸ مب: (که) مسقوط شد.

¹⁹ مب: (چون).

آن چهارده حرفست که دو دو یک صورت دارند از دال تا قاف و در میان آن ترتیب واقع شده اند و هفت حرف مقدم شده است که یکی از آنها الف است که تقدم [مب ۱۴۴] اصلی دارد و شش دیگر مثالست که از ثوران حکم کثرت و غلبه امر وحدت حقیقی صورت تقدم یافته اند و هفت دیگر که مفرداتند در آخر واقع گشته و از این وصل وجه ترتیب اجمالی مجموع مزدوجه که ملاحظه صورت رقی کتابی رفته مفهوم میشود و وجه تفصیلی آن را در مبسوطات طلبند.

اصل دوم در بیان حروف کلامی

و وجه شرف آن در مطلع رساله شمه ای گذشته است و پوشیده نماند که اگر نه میامن انوار حروف و حسنات ذکر و کلام بودی از ظلمات سیآت آکوان عالم یکسر تیره و بی صفا ماندی چنانچه خجای آیت کریمه قرآنی بدان مفصح است که ﴿إِنَّ الْحَسَنَاتِ يُذْهِبْنَ السَّيِّئَاتِ ذَلِكَ ذِكْرٌ لِلذَّاكِرِينَ﴾ [۱۱۴:۱۱]، و این اصل مشتمل بر چهار وصلست.

وصل اول در بیان ترتیب آن و بعضی احکام کلی او

حال آنست که ترتیب وضعی او همان ترتیب رقیست بدان دو وجه که بیان کرده شده آنچه خاصه اوست ترتیب طبیعی است که در مخارج حروف واقع گشته چه حروف کلامی عبارت از هوایی متموجست که در طی مخارج صورت تموج او محسوس میشود و صاحب تقدم در این ترتیب هم الف است که از اقصای مخارج که مبدأ تموج آن هواست ظاهر میگردد و سایر حروف باعتبار این ترتیب منقسم به سه قسم میشود، حروف حلقی و زبانی و لبی، و از اصول مقررده این فست که هر قاعده که نه بر مقطعات حروف نورانی منطبق باشد و او بدان مفصح آن قاعده معتبر نباشد و نشاید که در استنباط معانی قرآنی آن را استعمال کنند، اما هر حکمی کلی و قانونی حرفی که آن صور مذکور محل انطباق آن باشد آن دلیل ین باشد بر اثبات آن حکم چنانچه الف لام میم نسبت بآن اصل کتابی که گذشت و نسبت به این اصل کلامی هم که بر این اصل نیز صاحب جمعیت کلیه واقع گشته چه الف صاحب تقدمست در حلقی و لام در زبانی و میم در لبی، پس این سه حرف جامع سایر حروف باشد بنابر این اصل چنانچه در اصل سابق کتابی بعینه.

وصل دوم در بیان تمیز میان مسمای حروف و اسهای ایشان

هر حرفی از حروف تهجی که مستقلاً ملفوظ میگردد آن لفظ را اسم آن حرف خوانند و اول آن اسم [مب ۱۴۵] هر چه واقع شده است مسمای او و صورتش همان رقیست که مکتوب میشود، پس هر اسمی که هست مشتمل بر مسماست و زیادی که آن را بینات آن حرف خوانند و آن در بعضی دو حرف میباشد و در بعضی یک و آنچه یک بود البتّه الف باشد چنانچه با تا ثا و آنچه دوتا باشد از آن دو یکی حرف مدّ باشد مگر الف که در اسم او حرف مدّ دخل ندارد و عین و غین

که در اسم او حرف مدّ هست ولی نه بصورت مدّی، پس این تقسیم نیز مثلث باشد و صاحب جمعیت در میان این اقسام عین و غین است و لهذا دلالت ایشان بطرف ظهورست و حروفی که بیّنات واقع میشود هشت حرف که حامل عرش اظهار و صور اسمای ایشانست، ﴿وَيَجْمَلُ عَرْشَ رَبِّكَ فَوْقَهُمْ يَوْمَئِذٍ ثَمَانِيَةٌ﴾ [۶۹:۱۷] و ترکیب الودّ منیف جامع همه است، و اینها اصول [۱۱۵۶] کلیهء حروفند چه جامع حروف مدّ و حروف دایرند.

وصل سوّم

همچنانچه در حروف کتابی بعضی مشتمل بر تمام دایره است چون ه و بعضی بر بعضی از دایره چون نون همچنین حروف کلامی نیز بعضی تمام دایره است چون واو که ابتدای ظهور از لب کرد و باقصای مخارج برفت و باز گردید بهمان جا که بنیاد کرده قطع کرد و این را حروف دایر خوانند، و حروف منعطفه نیز خوانند، و آن سه حرفست ن و م و نموّ جامع ایشانست و حروف ثلاثهء مدّ که ماده و باطن همه حرفست هر یکی باطن یکی از اینهاست، و الف که در میان ایشان مخصوص تقدّمست باطن واو است، پس او در میان ایشان صاحب تقدّم باشد و لهذا هرگاه که بحرف دایر کتابی یعنی ه جمع میشود هو است که صورت اسم اعظمست، و چون در بدایات عقول مبین است که دایره صورت جمعیت کامله است، هر آینه این حروف صاحب جمعیت باشند در میان حرفها و لهذا دلالت ایشان بر جمعیت است و علامت جمع واقع میشود.

وصل چهارم

هر حرفی را ظاهریست و باطنی، ظاهرش آنست که در وقت ترکیب آن حرف در جهان آمیزش و آرایش او ظاهر میشود و همانست که باعتباری دیگر او را مستی خوانند چنانچه معلوم شد، و باطنش آنست که در اسم وقتی که هنوز در موطن اطلاق و استقلال خود باشد پیشتر [مب ۱۴۶] از آنکه بعالم آمیزش و ترکیب در آید ظاهر گردد چرا که اسم صورت تفصیل مستقامست یعنی اجزا که در او مجمل واقعست و از این رو فهم از ادراک آن قاصرست و عاجز در اسم تفصیل مییابد و ظاهر میشود و بیان حقیقت او میکند چنانچه در حدّ عقلی نسبت با محدود واقعست که صورت تفصیلی اوست و در صنعت میزان مبین گشته و از این رو آنچه در اسم یافت شود از حروف آن را بیّنات مستی خوانند، چون لام که میم بیّنات اوست و باطنش، پس حروف بدین اعتبار منقسم بدو قسم میشود، حروف ظاهر و آن حرفیست که مستی باشد و حروف باطن و آن حرفیست که اسم شود، و حروف ظاهر متفاوتند در مراتب ظهور و هیچ حرفی ظاهرتر از صاد نیست که بر هفت مرتبه منطویست از طبقات بطون چنانچه از این ترتیب معلوم²⁰ میشود ص د ل م ی ا ف، و لهذا در هر جا که صاد بود او را دلالتی بر طرف ظهور مییابد، و این سخن که باطن بیّنات ظاهر گشته و او را ظاهر میگرداند هم از آن اصلست که ذکر رفت در معنی توحید.

باطن لا یکاد یخفی

²⁰ مب: (معلوم) مسقوط شد.

که من این صبح روشن ز شب سیاه دارم²¹

اصل سؤم در بیان صورت معنوی حرف و وجه لبابی آن

که عبارت از معنی عددیست، چه هر حرفی صورت مرتبه‌ای از مراتب عددست که در مجلای خارج و مرتبه حس ظاهر گشته چنانچه در ترتیب افرادی ایجاد معلوم میشود، و این صورت از میان صور حروف منبع بسی عجایبست و معدن مجموع لطایف حقایق و غرایب آن چنانچه آن حضرت در این حدیث نبوی بدان اشعاری فرموده که (تعلّموا أبا جاد وتفسیرها فإنّ فیها الأعاجیب کلّها، فویلّ لعالم جهل أبا جاد وتفسیرها)²². و این اصل هم مشتمل بر چهار وصلست.

وصل اوّل در بیان جلالت حال این صورت و کمال مرتبه این علم

پوشیده نماند که علم عدد از اجلّ علوم انبیاست و ادقّ مکاشفات خلصّ اولیا و لهذا از خصایص حضرت ختمی است که در زمان حقایق نشان ایشان این علم ظاهر گردد و خدام آستان معارف آشیان آن حضرت را بکمال آن راه باشد چه از غایت نفاست معلومات اوست که هر علم که نه بمیزان قویم او راست شود یا بمعیار مستقیم او [مب ۱۴۷] تمام باشد البتّه از غایت بی ضبطی یا خالی از فایده ماند و عاری از غایت و در جریده لغو مثبت گردد یا باطل و فاسد باشد و بسمت کذب موسوم شود: ﴿لَا يَسْمَعُونَ فِيهَا لَغْوًا وَلَا كِذَابًا جَزَاءً مَنْ رَتَّبَ عَطَاءً حِسَابًا﴾ [۳۶-۷۸:۳۵]، چه جای این که هر²³ صناعتی جزئی و معاملتی عرفی که نه بر محک او زنند و عیار راستی او باز دانند صحیح آن از فاسدش متمیّز نگردد و قلب از رایج جدا نشود:

خوش بود گر محک تجربه آید بمیان تا سیه روی شود هر که درو غش باشد²⁴

و این جمله خاصّیتی چند است که متفرّع بر آثار ظاهر عددست که عوامّ نوع انسان و خواصّ [ما ۱۵۶ب] در آن متشارکنند و انباز که اگر در بواطن علم عدد و خواصّ نسب آن نگاه کنند مخزن سایر عجایب غرایب یابند چنانچه نطق را قوت احاطت بر تعبیر عُشری از معشار آن نباشد.

²¹ سعدی، غزل (من اگر نظر حرامست بسی گناه دارم): مکنید دردمندان گله از شب جدایی\ که من این صبح روشن ز شب سیاه دارم.

²² دیلمی (۲۲۴۷) عن ابن عباس.

²³ مب: که هر که.

²⁴ حافظ، غزل (نقد صوفی نه همه صافی بی غش باشد).

بُنْطَقِي لَنْ تُحْصَى وَلَوْ قُلْتُ قَلَّتِ²⁵

و لهذا قدمای حکما گفته اند که کیمیای جملهء علوم و اکسیر صنوف غرایب و²⁶ عجایب علم عددست و از حضرت امام جعفر علیه السلام تعظیم این علم بسی ظاهر گشته و از ملازمان آستان ولایت آشیانش بسی تصانیف در این باب منتشرست ولیکن چون مسلک بیان آن مقصور بر رموز و اشارات خفیه است چنانچه دأب بزرگان و ادب تحریر ایشانست هر آینه هر کس حمل آن بر چیزی دیگر میکنند و قوت فهم آن از پرتو انوار حضرت خاتمی خواهد بود و زمان هدایت نشانش که فحوائی فرموده ﴿يَوْمَ يَقُومُ الْحِسَابُ﴾ [١٤:٤١] بر منصهء ظهور و اظهار در جلوه آید.

باش تا خطّ بناگوش و خم طره یار²⁷ عقل را گوش گرفته بدبستان آرند²⁸

و مدتی مدیدست که آثار اندراس بر معالم این علم شریف نشستہ بود تا زمان ما که بمیامن ملازمان حضرت سیدی سلام الله علی آبائه الکرام و علیه باز احیای این نوع علم شده و خواهد شد.

وصل دوم

چنانچه حرف از روی صور سابق ظاهری و باطنی دارد از روی این صورت معنوی نیز هنجنین ظاهری دارد و باطنی، ظاهر او همان عددست که معروفست در ابجد و باطن او عددیست که تعلق [مب ١٤٨] بیّنات او داشته باشد و آن را مراتبست از طرف بطون چه هر بیّناتی عددی دارد و آن عدد بیّناتی و عددی و همچنین تا آنجا که قوت فهم وفا تواند نمود و بیشتر از این معلوم شد که هر چند که باطن در طرف بطون متوغل میشود در تبیین ظاهر و افصاح آن میافزاید چنانچه گفته اند.

از خلاف آمد عادت بطلب کام که من کسب جمعیت از آن زلف پریشان کردم²⁹

متفطن ذکی را در استنباط معنی بدین طریق وجوه بسیارست که تحقیق و تبیین آن نه طور این رساله و نه حدّ این زمان و اهالی آنست مگر بمیامن انوار هدایت آثار ختمی بدان راه توان برد ﴿ذَلِكَ فَضْلُ اللَّهِ يُؤْتِيهِ مَنْ يَشَاءُ﴾ [٥:٥٤، ٥٧:٢١، ٦٢:٤].

²⁵ ابن فارض، تائیه، بیت ٣٥ (وَأَسْكُتُ عَجْزاً عَنْ أُمُورٍ كَثِيرَةٍ \ بُنْطَقِي لَنْ تُحْصَى وَلَوْ قُلْتُ قَلَّتِ).

²⁶ مب: بر.

²⁷ یا (خم زلف تو باز).

²⁸ سنائی، قصیده (عاشقانت سوی تو تحفه اگر جان آرند).

²⁹ حافظ، غزل (سألها پیروی مذهب رندان کردم).

ره روان را شب تاریک دلیلی باید ما بیوی خوش آن زلف سیاه آمده ایم

وصل سوّم

پوشیده نماند که همچنانچه بظاهر حروف سخن گفتن مسلک عامّه مردمست و بدلالات وضعی جعلی قصد مطالب عرفی کردن راه معهود ایشان همچنین مبنای سخن بر باطن حروف نهادن و بدلالات حقیقی ذاتی و غیره از مقاصد کلّی خبر دادن و از معانی و حقایق هر چیز بخصوصه پرده التباس گشودن و خاصیت اشیا بجملتها نمودن مذهب خاصّ اهل کمال انسانست یعنی انبیا و خواصّ اولیا که وارثان انبیا اند، و چون معلوم شد که حرف بحسب هر صورتی از این صور ثلاثه که دانستی ظاهری دارد و باطنی هر آینه بسایر وجوه سخن اهل کمال را معانی و مقاصد خواهد بود ولیکن طرف بطون آن وجه معنوی لبابی از همه اعلی و اتمست و احکام او عند الامعان از همه اشمّل و اعمّ، فاما چون مانوس طباع نشده است بیشتر فهمها از ادراک حقایقی که تعلق بدین وجه دارد دور افتاده و از این رو قاصر میاند و آنچه دلالت بدین معنی میکند آنست که در حدیث مبارک نبوی آمده که (أنا أوّل من تكلم بالضاد)،³⁰ و چه اگر متفطن لبیب حساب بیّنات تمام حروف بکند هر آینه فهم معنی این حدیث را قابل گردد و بداند که دلیلست مطابق و مؤید اصل مذکور.

یک نکته از این دفتر³¹ گفتیم و همین باشد³²

وصل چهارم

عدد بذات خود منقسم بدو قسم میشود، حقیقی وجودی و اعتباری عدمی، قسم اوّل [مب ۱۴۹] از عدد آنست که بذات خود قائم و ثابت تواند بود بی آنکه اعتبار غیری کنند و حکمی که او را نسبت بغیر باشد در وجود او دخل دهند چنانچه از یک تا نه و قسم دوّم از عدد آنست که وجود او بملاحظه غیر صورت بندد چنانچه باقی مراتب عدد که بی ملاحظه صفر وجود ندارد، و حکمای سابق که بیشتر ورثه و شاگردان انبیا اند جهت فهم آن معنی وضع رقوم هندسی کرده اند از آنجا استکشاف آن معنی باید کرد: (کَمْ خَبَايَا فِي الزَّوَايَا). چه هر کس که بامعان فهم و دقت نظر این تقسیم را در یابد و در این رقوم مسطور تأمل نماید بسی علوم و حقایق بیاطن او فرود آید بشرط آنکه محلّ را از شواغل رسوم عادی و نقوش تقلیدات اعتقادی پاک کرده باشد.

وعاد دواعي القيل والقالِ وَاُنْجِ مِنْ عَوَادِي دَعَاوٍ صِدْقُهَا قَصْدُ سُمْعَةٍ³³

³⁰ این حدیث در صحاح نیست.

³¹ یا (معنی).

³² حافظ، غزل (کی شعر تر انگیزد خاطر که حزین باشد).

³³ ابن فارض، تائیه، بیت ۱۸۹/۱۹۰.

دل چو بزم خاص دید از مجلس عامش مگو جان چو با جانان نشست از پیگ و پیغامش مگو³⁴

[ما ۱۱۵۷] و آن رقوم اینست: آدم ۴۵ من ۱ الی ط ۴۵ و من ۱ الی ید ۹۹، و از جمله آنچه از او مفهوم میشود معنی آدمست و آنچه نهایت کمال اوست یعنی خاتم ولی فهم این نوع علم از زبان اشارت طمع کنند نه از مجرد عبارت.

پیام اهل دلست این سخن که سعدی گفت³⁵ نه هر که گوش کند معنی سخن داند³⁶

تذنیب

در بیان معنی سبع المثانی

بباید دانست که بحسب هر وجهی از این وجوه ثلاثه که حروف را بیان کرده شد معنی جدا دارد که مخصوص بدان وجهست ولیکن ظاهرتر و جامعتر اینست که مثانی از روی لغت عرب جمع مثنی است و معنی مثنی دو دو است پس مثانی چهار چهار باشد چرا که اقل جمع پیش محققان در مثل این موضع دو چند مفرد میباشد چنانچه شیخ محیی الدین قدس سره در کتاب فتوحات مکی آورده که حضرت رسالت صلوات الله و سلامه علیه و علی آله بخواب دیده که از او پرسیدی که اختلافی میان علما واقع است که اقل جمع دو است یا سه تحقیق آن چون است در جواب اشارت فرمودی که اگر زوجست دو بار مفرد و اگر فردست سه، پس چون مثنی زوج است دو بار مفرد خواهد بود و دو دو چهار باشد، پس معنی سبع المثانی بدین وجه [مب ۱۵۰] عبارت از بیست و هشت باشد چرا که معنی سبع المثانی از این رو هفت و چهار باشد و آن بیست و هشت صور اصلی عربی خواهد بود که تمام کلام و کتابست و بغیر از خاتم کمی را قابلیت فرود آمدن آن صور بتمامه نیست چه هر که صاحب تمام صور باشد خاتم النبوه او تواند بود، این معنی جامعست میان وجوه ثلاثه حروف چنانچه پوشیده نماند و باعتبار با هر یک از این صور سه گانه معنی خاص دارد، اما باعتبار با صور کتابی معنیست که در اصل اول معلوم شد که چهارده حرف که در قلب آن ترتیب ازدواجی واقع گشته دو دو بر یک صورت آمده اند، و نیز معلوم شد که در این ترتیب قلب از آن رو واقع گشته که صاحب جمعیت اند از آن جهت که برزخ آمده اند میان وحدت و کثرت، پس سبع المثانی در این ترتیب کتابی اشارت بدین چهارده حرفست و آن چهارده را در کتاب وجودی انسانی مطابقی هست که آن عبارت از قوای سبعة انسانیست که در بدن او بصورت محسوس دو دو ظاهر شده چنانچه عینین و اذنین و شفتین و منخرین و یدین و اثتین و رجلین، و این صورت از سبع المثانی که در کتابین ظاهر گشته منظوری بر معانی جلیله است که امثال این رساله جای آن نخواهد بود و قننا الله تعالی لبیانہ. اینست معنی ظاهر سبع المثانی باعتبار با صور کتابی حروف و اما باعتبار با صور کلامی معنی ظاهر او صورت صادین است که در اقصی غایات صورت واقع شده اند از آن رو که هر یک را هفت مرتبه از مدارج بطون هست که بیانات ایشان میشوند و هیچ حرف از سه و چهار نمیگذرد و از این رو در میان ترتیب مزدوجه کلامی واقع اند و جای قلب گرفته اند و حدیث (انا اول) نیز مؤید این معنیست، و اما باعتبار با

³⁴ اوحدی مراغه ای، غزل (دل سرای خاص شد از مجلس عامش مگو).

³⁵ یا (هر خبر که سعدی داد).

³⁶ سعدی، غزل (کسی که روی تو دیده است حال من داند).

صور معنوی لبّی که کنه هر چیز بدان ظاهر و متبیین میگردد آنست که از وصول آن اصل اخیر معلوم شد که جامع تمام مراتب وجودی عدد نه است که تمام صور رقوم هندسه است که عبارت از اندازهء معقولاتست و آدم در این زبان بدان اشارتست و شک نیست که آن حقیقت آدمی وقتی بکمال وجود خود رسد و تمام [مب ۱۵۱] شود که آنچه در او بالقوه باشد از خصایص نسب اندرونی و کالات معنوی بطونی که مبدای غریب و عجایب اطوارست بالفعل ظاهر گردد و آن معنی در نود و نه صورت میندد که هر چه در نه بالقوه است از نسب اندرونی و احکام او همه در او بالفعل ظاهر گشته و صورت تحقیق^{۳۷} آن عقد چهارده است چنانچه بر اهل آن پوشیده نماند، پس معلوم شد که چهارده عبارت از صورت خاتمست که کمال آدم باشد - بیش از این روشن نشاید کرد راز. آنچه زبان وقت باملای آن مساحت نمود از معانی سبع المثانی، بیش از این امثال این مختصرات احتمال نخواهد کرد با وجود آنکه عهد منشی قلم آن شده که سر بگفتهء دیگران فرو نیارد و بغیر از نوباوه وقت هیچ بر زبان نراند و دست تحریر و تسطیر از سخنان نبشته و فرسوده گشتهء هر زبان کوتاه دارد.

گوش داری نکتهای اوحدی گر تو لولو باز دانی از خرز^{۳۸}

اگر طالبی را بعد از آنکه ذایقهء فهم او اینها هضم کند اشتهای شوقش طالب دیگر معانی باشد از این نوع کتاب خصایص کمالی را طلب کند که در آنجا استیفای این حقایق بیشترک شده و قننا الله تعالی لاتمام المرام والانخراط فی سلک قطن دار السلام بحرمه محمد خیر الانام و آله و اصحابه الکرام صلی الله علیه و علیهم اجمعین. اتفق تحریر هذه الرسالة فی يوم السبت عاشر رمضان المبارک سنه سبع عشر و ثمانمائه هجریه فی بلدة شیراز حمیت عن الآفات حامدا لله تعالی و مصليا علی نبیه النبیّه.

تم وحرّر فی ۱۴ ذی القعدة سنه ۸۲۸ یزد
حمیت عن الزلل.^{۳۹}

م

^{۳۷} مب: تحقیق.

^{۳۸} اوحدی مراغه ای، غزل (پاکبازان را چه خارا و چه خرز). یا (گوش داری گفتهای اوحدی/ تا که لولو را بدانی از خرز). مب: (خرف؟) بدل (خرز).

^{۳۹} مب: تمّ الکتابه فی ذی الحجه سنه ۹۰۳ هجریه.

R. ḤURŪF

On the Letters

In the name of God, all-merciful, ever-merciful

Praise be to the all-powerful King, Who, having raised the receptacles of letters and words—the repository of all knowledge of divine transcendence (*ḥaẓrat-i tanzīh*)—to their fullest glory, sent them down from the heaven of holiness and transcendence (*istighnā'*) to guide those who charge forward on the highway of creation and seek the treasure of knowledge and insight [with dedication] such that they finally reach their goal—*Blessed be He Who has sent down the Salvation upon His servant, that he may be a warner to all beings* (Q 25:1); and a thousand blessings be upon the Chosen One, the heaven-guided apostle by virtue of whose felicitating message and teaching the tired, erring [denizens of] earth [were] raised from the nadir of deficiency to the apex of perfection.

His being become being's very root
Muḥammad's largess ranges far from his tent¹

In the garden of the realm of taint and admixture grows the fruitful tree of felicity and perfection—this being the tree of gnosis (*ʿirfān*), the fruit of the integral and precious human form—, the cypress of the meadow of worship and work and root of the rosebush of knowledge and insight.

You—first in nature and last to appear:
take yourself not lightly²

The firstfruits of the presences of holiness and the garden of subsistence and intimacy—i.e., the letters in their spoken and written forms—are a product of the tree of its comprehensiveness (*jam'iyat*) and an outgrowth of its Pen (*sinān u qalam*). Were it not for the blessedly sweet odors emanating from that glorious fruit, earthly creatures of the material world would have no sign of divine majesty and oneness; were it not for its ensorcelling scent acting as waymark, those imprisoned in the subterranean depth of their dark natures could descry no trace of the purity of the cherubim among the heavenly host or the sanctified entities of the spiritual realm.

Had the wind not swept aside her tress
when would've the beloved's face appeared to her lover?

¹ I.e., seeking out its recipients and not having to be sought.

² Firdawsī, *Shāhnāma*, prologue.

Were it not for her scent, I wouldn't have found her tavern
were it not for her gorgeousness, fantasy couldn't have dreamt her³

Among the signs of the progress of the age (*taraq̃q̃-yi zamān*) and the [improved] ability of our contemporaries to grasp sciences dealing with [ultimate] realities is the fact that in our own blessed day (*vaqt-i dawlatmandī*) a variety of angelic principles (*malakāt-i malakī*) have been made the ornament of mighty works of dominion and a number of realities and varieties of mystical knowledge (*ma'ārif-i darvīshāna*) have been formulated in all their glory and magnificence—for the high purpose of his excellency (*janāb-ishān*)⁴ has not been seduced by the painted and perfumed harlot of the world, and the maiden of the madrasa and khanaqah, with all her coquetry of learning and sophistication, must remain forever exiled from the bazaar of his ravishment.

Let all look toward the walled garden of holiness
let all turn toward the enclosure of the Living

[His excellency] has emphatically requested that an offering worthy of his time [be presented to him] dealing with all the aspects of the science of letters (*jāmi'-i atvār-i 'ilm-i ḥurūf*), beginning with the basic premises and expanding upon this in a full discussion of the form and meaning of the letters; while time did not permit me to do justice to such an undertaking, which is in any case beyond the abilities of the present writer—

How can dust like myself attain that height?
Even when clouds reach it they rain, worthlessly⁵—

nevertheless, and according to the saying *The lords of nations are inspired men* (*arbāb al-duwal mulhamūn*), I had no choice but to comply with his inspired request. Thus to the extent that limited time has allowed the scribe of passion to inscribe on the codex of the senses, and that in hurried and broken form—

My beloved's tresses are disheveled—to work is impossible—

[this treatise] has been composed for the benefit of wayfarers in the clime of quest and travelers through the desert of determined exertion to serve as basic provision from the table of this age and firstfruit of the garden of time.

Two morsels for your table—my words
that no hand has ever touched⁶

³ Ibn al-Fāriḍ, qasida: *sharabnā 'alā dhikri l-ḥabībī mudāmat^{an}/ sakirnā bi-hā min qabli an yukhlaqa l-karamu*.

⁴ I.e., Iskandar Mīrzā (r. 812-17/1409-14)?

⁵ Niẓāmī, *Khusraw va Shīrīn*. The use of *āb rikhtan*, to rain, in the second hemistich is a play on words; the figurative meaning of the phrase is to become worthless.

⁶ Niẓāmī, *Makhzan al-Asrār*.

Inasmuch as the etiquette of composition dictates that one provide a list of contents after identifying a treatise's subject-matter, this treatise comprises an introduction touching on the meaning of the letter and a discussion of its [three] basic divisions, followed by three sections (*aṣl*) treating of these divisions [respectively] and the universal properties of each in more detail, and concluding with an addendum dwelling on the meaning of the Doubled Seven (*sabʿ al-mathānī*) as a test case on which to apply the principles laid out in the body of the treatise.

Introduction:

On the meaning of the letter and its basic divisions

The root meaning of *ḥarf* (letter) in Arabic is the edge or end of something. In the present context it connotes a form sent down from the heaven of holiness that reveals all things—indeed, it also reveals things which have not entered into the circuit of existence, describing the manner of their [nonbeing]. For this reason the [concept of] letter must be considered more encompassing than [such concepts as] existence (*vujūd*) or thing (*shayʿ*) or any other universal [category] that may be conceived.⁷ It therefore encompasses all things, comprehending each in precisely the same way without being more inclined to one than another; the letter thus remains standing straight [and unaffected] by virtue of its basic comprehensiveness. This is in contrast to everything else in existence, which [necessarily] inclines toward one of two opposing terms; thus existence is countered by nonexistence (*ʿadam*), and likewise with thing, [countered by ‘no-thing’ (*lā-shayʿ*)], or contingency (*imkān*), [countered by necessity (*vujūb*)], or anything else that can be conceived. [Referring to the letter's primordial straightness and singularity, says He:] *Praise belongs to God Who has sent down upon His servant the Book, and has not assigned unto it any crookedness* (Q 18:1).

Now three loci of self-manifestation (*maḥlā*) have been created for the letterform through which it manifests and reveals the end and the essence of every thing. The first is the faculty of sight (*baṣār*), to which the ‘ in the word ‘*abd* (servant) refers; the second is the heart (*qalb*), to which the *B* in ‘*abd* refers; the third is the faculty of hearing (*samʿ*), to which the *D* in ‘*abd* refers. By this measure, then, the letter may be divided into three categories (*qism*):

- 1) The written-textual (*raqamī kitābī*) form, which through the agency of fingers and hands is given form upon the open spread of white pages and reveals realities to both sight (*abṣār*) and insight (*baṣāyir*) as its proper loci; the exponents of this mode are *men of might and vision* (*ūlū l-aydī wa-l-abṣār*) (Q 38:45).⁸
- 2) The spoken-oral (*lafẓī kalāmī*) form, which through the agency of the tongue and the various points of articulation that modify the breath is embodied and expresses realities to the hearing (*asmāʿ*) and to reason (*ʿuqūl*) as its proper loci; its exponents are *the folk of remembrance*⁹ (*ahl al-dhikr*) (Q 16:43, 21:7).
- 3) The spiritual-mental (*maʿnavī lubābī*) form, which through the agency of the rational and imaginative faculties (*quvvat-i ʿāqila u mutakhayyila*) is analyzed within the broad

⁷ Ṣāʿ in al-Dīn emphasizes the same point in the introduction to his *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, translated in §7.3.1 above (section I.5), as well as in the first inquiry of section 1, paraphrased in §7.2.

⁸ Cf. the *R. Shaqq-i Qamar*, where this phrase refers to the Imams as repositories of all occult knowledge.

⁹ I.e., verbal remembrance, making mention.

realm of meaning with the heart as its proper locus; its exponents are *those possessed of minds* (ūlū l-albāb) (Q 2:179, etc.): *He gives wisdom to whomever He will, and whoso is given wisdom has been given much good; yet none remembers save those possessed of minds* (Q 2:269).

Each of these categories is specific to one of the three primary human faculties, to wit, the heart, the hearing, and sight. It is in this respect that quranic verses typically refer to all three together, usually giving precedence to either the heart (as in the verse *Surely in that there is a reminder to him who has a heart, or will give ear with a present mind* (Q 50:37), and the verse *There is nothing His like; He is the All-hearing, the All-seeing* (Q 42:11)) or to the hearing (as in the verse *And He appointed for you hearing, and sight, and hearts* (Q 16:78, 9:32, 67:23)). The first order reflects the fundamental and essential precedence of the heart with respect to the other members, and indeed with respect to all things in existence, whereas the second order reflects hearing's precedence at the moment of creation, inasmuch as it was the faculty singled out to receive the [spoken] command *Be! (kun)* from among the various members and faculties of perception. However, because accepted didactic usage involves giving precedence to that which is the most evident—as for example in the verse *How well He sees! How well He hears!* (Q 18:26)—, it is here more appropriate and useful to first treat of the written form of the letters. Indeed, the fact that the imperative form is used in the verse just cited suggests precisely the objective of instruction. Yet it must be noted that despite the fact that their written form is more manifest and their spiritual form more occult (*akhfā*), the first is not self-evident and must be learned, whereas knowledge of the second need not be; that is to say, knowledge of the numbers and their degrees is innate, in contrast to knowledge of the written form of the letters and their shapes, which cannot be understood until they are learned. This is so because of a basic principle of *tawhīd*, as those who have studied the subject know.

Each of them desired the quality
she had wrapped
in a form of loveliness shining forth
in a loveliness of form¹⁰

Her beauty, hidden, cannot manifest
yet is manifest through its hiddenness

A second preliminary point must be made here: Given that the science of letters is a universal science (*az 'ulūm-i kullīyya*) comprising numerous other sciences under its aegis, each of them important and worthy of purpose in its own right, the practitioners of this science naturally fall into various camps. Generally speaking, however, they may be divided into two overarching groups.

The first and best-known group consists of those who are concerned with the occult properties of the letters (*ahl-i khavāṣṣ*). These investigate into the occult properties of each letter according to each of its three forms [as described below], and hold that the utterance or contemplation of a letter in accordance with a specific description and its associated conditions activates its particular quality either with respect to the levels of the physical world (*marātib-i dunyāwī*) or to spiritual interactions at various levels (*mu'āmalāt-i ukhravī va madārīj-i ān*). The exponents of this first approach, including most prominently Abū l-'Abbās al-Būnī, have composed innumerable books and treatises on the subject, and make up the majority of those concerned with the science of letters.

¹⁰ Ibn al-Fāriḍ, *al-Tā'iyya al-Kubrā*, l. 244/246; trans. in Homerin, *'Umar Ibn al-Fāriḍ*, 143.

The second group consists of those who are concerned with the letters' underlying realities (*ahl-i ḥaqāyiq*). These investigate into the meanings (*ma'ānī*) behind the letters and the universal sciences (*'ulūm-i kullī*) they contain, and understand all types of knowledge and modes of knowing, whether with respect to the divine presences (*ḥazarāt-i ilāhiyya*) or the realms of contingency (*'avālim-i imkāniyya*) and all that comes to be in them, in terms of the heavenly Book (*kitāb-i āsmānī*) and the isolated quranic letters (*ḥurūf-i muqatta'a-yi qur'ānī*); they likewise apprehend the occult properties of everything that has ever manifested or will ever manifest in the universe, each communicating this according to the vigor and capacity of his understanding. My purpose in this treatise is to present a few of the guiding principles (*uṣūl*) of this latter group, this in order to familiarize seekers with this science and equip them to pursue it to perfection—God grant us all success to this end.¹¹

Principle One:

On the written form of the letters

For it is He Who sent down to you the Book well-differentiated (Q 6:114).¹² The written forms of the letters (*ruqūm-i kitābī*) possess a correspondence (*munāsabat*) with the mode of sanctified power (*valāyat*), which is primarily given to spiritual meanings and realities. For this reason many great mystics (*buzurgān-i valāyat-shī'ār*) characterized by this mode restrict the quest for these realities to this approach, and indeed, many powerful subtleties and worthy points are implicit within each written form. As suggested by the above verse and with respect to its [rank in] manifestation, the discussion of this principle must therefore come first.

The letter is the water of life and ink its deep darkness
whoso knows this will never die

This section comprises four subsections (*vaṣl*).

On the number of the written letters

The written letters are 28 (or 29) in number in their basic forms, with 22 derivative points (*nuqṭa*), totaling 50 in all; the latter number corresponds to the 50 prayers enjoined upon Muḥammad during his night ascent. They constitute the perfect form that Arabic, the perfect language (*tamām-i kalām*), would come to comprise as revealed to Muḥammad. Given that they are the perfect form, the totalizing words (*javāmi' al-kalim*)¹³ expressive of the essence and end

¹¹ Cf. a similar division in Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* between two types of magic, one being sorcery (*goeteia*) consisting "wholly in the operations and powers of demons ... an execrable and monstrous thing," the other being "nothing else but the highest realization of natural philosophy ... [The Greeks reserved] the term *mageia* to the second, and [understood] by it the highest and most perfect wisdom" (§32, trans. Forbes, 246-47).

¹² The verse in full: *What, shall I seek after any judge but God? For it is He Who sent down to you the Book well-differentiated; and those whom We have given the Book know it is sent down from your Lord with the truth—so be you not of the doubters.*

¹³ Referring to the Prophetic hadith, *I have been given the totalizing words*; see e.g. Muslim, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, *K. al-Masājid wa-Mawāḍi' al-Ṣalāt*, bab 1, no. 1199; Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal, *Musnad*, *Musnad Abī Hurayra*, nos. 7521, 8266.

of all things, it follows that the one to whom they were revealed would become the Seal of messengerhood (*khātim al-risāla*); for only the one who possesses the perfect form through revelation and communicates it to the nations can be the seal of prophethood and messengerhood.

Now before the coming of the Arab Muḥammad, in the time of the prophets who came before Abraham, the number of letters [was fewer, and] in the time of Abraham they reached 24. For Abraham realized the affirmative names (*asmā-yi thubūtī*) of the Real, and thereby laid the foundation for the realities to be vouchsafed the Seal, as the verse states: *And when Abraham raised up the foundations of the House* (Q 2:127). It is for this reason that [Abraham] is mentioned as having precedence in the formulas of blessing upon Muḥammad. (I have explained this point at length in my commentary on the *Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam*; I refer the interested reader there.) With the coming of the holy Messenger, however, four Arabic letters were added to make up the perfect number, becoming the Doubled Seven (*sab‘ al-masānī*), as will be explained below.

To this end was Adam’s clay mixed for forty days:
to complete the fortress of faith with the bricks of your being¹⁴

The shapes of these letters were then established by ‘Alī, Commander of the Faithful and conferrer of sanctified power (*valāyat-iqṭā‘*), constituting what became known as Kufic script. Ibn Muqla, the vizier of the ‘Abbasid caliph al-Qāhir bi-Llāh, then reformed the script, and from that point onward the Arabic script has undergone gradual and successive development from the simplicity of the angle (*zāviya*) to the perfection of the arc (*taqavvus*); I have discussed the reasons for this elsewhere.

On the order of the written letters

The written letters are ordered in two different sequences, the first being a dual (*izdivājī*) sequence based on the external form of the letters, as will be discussed below, and the second being a sequence of individual letters (*afrādī*) based on the spiritual, numerical values of each, as will be discussed under principle three below. There is no difference of opinion as to the first sequence, but differences do exist between the eastern and western versions of the second with respect to certain letters; these difference are not relevant to my purposes here and may be safely left aside. In any case, however, the basic forms of all the letters are 15 or 16 in total—A, B, J, D, R, S, Ṣ, ‘, F, K, L, M, N, H, L-A, Y; with the addition of the dot (*nuqṭa*) or the *hamza*, which also have distinct written forms (the reasons for their inclusion or exclusion cannot be discussed here), the total comes to 17, equivalent to the number of cycles (*raka‘āt*) in the ritual prayer. These represent the letters in their nondelimited form, i.e., when they were still in the transcendent realm of holiness and had not yet manifested in the world of admixture and taint as compound, engendered forms (*ṣūrat-i tarkīb-i kawnī*).

When the letters manifest in the world of admixture in compound form they must needs take on additional forms, i.e., nine forms corresponding to the nine accidents (*‘arāḍ*) upon which the visible world is founded, together with three vowels (*ḥarakat*) (or six if counted in both the dual and singular sequences) as well as the *sukūn*, *tashdīd* and *madda*. I have discussed the resulting correspondence between the two Books—that of manifestation and existence (*zuhūr*, *vujūd*) constituted by the universe, and that in written, making-manifest form (*raqamī*, *izhārī*) constituted by speech (*kalām*)—at length in another work, *Khaṣāyiṣ-i Kamālī*; space does not permit me to go into this here.

¹⁴ Kamāl al-Dīn Ismā‘īl, from a *tarkībband* in praise of the Prophet.

[On the meaning of revelation (inzāl)]

The meaning of [revelation, i.e.] ‘sending down,’ by which process the Book becomes manifest, connotes a descending movement from the height of essential and ontological oneness toward the lowness of the multiplicity of act and manifestation. Now it is clear that the first form to appear as a result of this process is the single line (*khaṭṭ*), i.e., the A as the first of the letters, after which the full reality of manifestation, the purpose of this process, follows ineluctably with further movements of expansion. Here the right and left sides trace arcs (*mutaqallib gardad*), eventually forming a full circle. What manifests at this point of convergence is the form of M. The mediating midpoint (*vāsiṭa, barzakh*) between these two extremes, possessing neither the simplicity of the A or the unifying property (*jam‘iyyat*) of the M, is L, as the letter’s name (*lām*) suggests. Thus do A-L-M encompass all written forms, as the intelligent are well apprised of.

A further instance of wisdom in support of this principle, one for which there exists a demonstrative proof, relates to the instructive nature of a physical body (*jism*), the mutable vehicle through which everything in the realm of sensation and imagination manifests—indeed, anything with a form at all necessarily has to do with a body. Bodies are defined by three principles [or dimensions]: line, i.e., extension in one dimension; plane, i.e., extension in two dimensions; and volume, i.e., extension in three dimensions. A, then, represents the first dimension, L the second dimension, and M the third dimension; this shows the degree of correspondence between the two Books, [i.e., the letter of revelation and the physical universe], as was indicated above.

[On the classes of letters]

Know that these letterforms, which are the source of their written manifestation, have both aspects in common that unify them and aspects that differentiate them from each other. In either case these aspects may be either complete—as in the case of H with respect to K (differentiating) or J with respect to Ḥ (showing similarity)—or incomplete—as in the case of H with respect to M (differentiating) or Ḥ with respect to ‘ (showing similarity). Each of these aspects comprises a variety of subtle realities, as I have discussed at length in my *Khaṣāyiṣ-i Kamālī*; space does not permit a reiteration of them here.

One such aspect that must be mentioned here, however, is the fact that the letters may be classed according to a threefold division: singular (*mufrad*), i.e., those letters dissimilar to any others, such as A, H and K; dual (*maṣānī*), i.e., those letters that have the same basic form as one other; and triple (*maṣālīs*), i.e., those letters that have the same basic form as two others. The dual letters stand in the middle of these as a *barzakh* that mediates their convergence, and thus due to the duality to be observed in their written forms they represent the heart. The dual letters are 14 in number, half of which have the same basic form as the other half, and include the letters from D to Q. They are preceded in the first place by A, which possesses fundamental primacy, followed by six triple letters; the latter precede the dual letters due to their representation of the property of multiplicity as controlled by true oneness (i.e., A). Seven singular letters then follow the dual letters. From this section the general principle behind this arrangement of the letters in a paired collection as seen in their written forms may be understood; for a more detailed discussion see the [*Khaṣāyiṣ-i Kamālī*].

Principle Two:

On the verbal form of the letters

The special virtue of the verbal form of the letters was touched upon above in the introduction. [Put briefly], it is clear that were it not for the beneficent light of the letters and the good things of speech (*kalām*) and remembrance (*dhikr*) everything would remain altogether enmired in the darkness of the evil of the engendered beings in the universe, as is expressed in the holy quranic dictum: *The good things drive away the evil things—that is a remembrance unto the mindful* (Q 11:114).

This section comprises four subsections.

On their order and some of their universal properties

The conventional order of the verbal form of the letters is the same as the order followed by their written form, according to the two aspects referred to above. It is however distinguished by the natural order imposed by the letters' points of articulation (*makhārij*), for the verbal form of the letters is constituted by sound waves that become perceptible as distinct sounds after being shaped by different points of articulation. Here again the A has precedence in that its sound originates from the first point of articulation [in the throat]. By this measure, then, the letters fall into three categories: faucal-glottal (*ḥalqī*), uvular to dental (*zabānī*), and labial (*labī*).

Now one of the established principles of this art is that a rule (*qā'ida*) that does not apply to or serve to explicate the unjoined luminous letters (*muqatta'āt-i ḥurūf-i nūrānī*) cannot be considered a rule nor should it be used to extract the meaning from quranic verses. Contrariwise, every universal property (*ḥukmī kullī*) and letter rule (*qānūnī ḥarfī*) that does apply to the unjoined letters enjoys full validity. Thus A-L-M possesses total comprehensiveness both with respect to its written form as discussed above and its verbal form, in that A is the first of the faucal letters, L [representative] of the uvular to dental letters and M [representative] of the labial letters. In short, these three letters comprise all the letters of the alphabet in their verbal form just as they do in their written form.

On the distinction between the names of the letters and their referents

The utterance that individually identifies each letter of the alphabet is called its name; this name invariably begins with the referent of that name, which in its written form is depicted as a single letter. Thus each letter's name comprises both the letter itself with an additional vocable that clarifies it. In some cases this produces a name of two letters, in other cases only one—i.e., *alif*. The former include *bā*, *tā* and *thā*, involving the inclusion of a long vowel (*madd*), unlike *alif*, whose name has no long vowel. The names of 'ayn and *ghayn* do contain a vowel that, while also long, is compound.

This manner of classifying the letters of the alphabet thus also produces three categories, the most comprehensive of which are ' and Gh; they therefore represent manifestation. The letters whose names add a long vowel are eight in number; these carry the throne of making-manifest (*izhār*) and the forms of their names: *And upon that day eight shall carry above them the Throne of your Lord* (Q 69:17) ...¹⁵ These eight are the universal principles of all the letters, whether those whose names end in a long vowel or those whose names end in a consonant.

¹⁵ I am unsure of the meaning of this phrase: *va tarkīb-i al-wadd munīf-jāmi'-i hama-st*.

[On the types of letter names]

As with the written forms of the letters, some of which have the form of a circle, such as *H*, and others of which have the form of a half-circle, such as *N*, so too do the verbal forms of the letters include some which have the form of a circle; the name *wāw*, for example, is articulated as a labial consonant that opens to an open faucal vowel then returns to its original point of articulation. Such letters are therefore described as tracing a circle [in verbal terms], and are also known as rounded or bent letters (*mun'atīf*). These are *nūn*, *wāw* and *mīm*, together forming the word *numuww* ('growth, increase'), with each name having one of the three long vowels, [i.e., *alif*, *wāw* and *yā*], which function as the substance (*mādda*) and interior (*bātin*) of each name. Because *wāw* includes an *A*, which has precedence over all other letters, it has precedence over the other two long vowels. When it is then conjoined with the letter whose written form is a circle, i.e. *H*, the two constitute the pronoun *huwa*, Him, the supreme name of God. Given that it is one of the elementary rational principles that the circle is the form of perfect comprehensiveness, these two letters in conjunction possess this comprehensiveness to a degree unmatched by any other letters, and therefore serve to connote the same.

[On their hidden and manifest aspects]

Each letter has a manifest and a nonmanifest aspect. Its manifest aspect is that which manifests upon the compounding (*tarkīb*) of that letter in the base world of admixture—in other words, its referent, as has been discussed. Its nonmanifest aspect is that which manifests in its name when it still remains in the realm of its nondelimitation and freedom (*istiqlāl*) before assuming its compounding in the world of admixture. Thus the name is the differentiated form of the referent, i.e., the elements within it that remain undifferentiated; that which understanding cannot encompass manifests to it through the differentiating effect of the name, which reveals the reality of the referent. The same holds true with respect to the rational definition (*ḥadd-i 'aqlī*) and the thing defined (*maḥdūd*) as used in logic (*ṣinā'at-i mizān*), the former serving to differentiate the latter. Thus, for example, *mīm* serves as the proof or outworking (*bayyināt*) and nonmanifest aspect of *lām*. According to this measure, then, the letters may be divided into two categories: manifest letters, i.e., letters which are referents, and nonmanifest letters, i.e., letters which are names. Now the former differ according to degree of manifestness, and no letter is more manifest than *ṣād*, which contains within it seven levels of nonmanifestness, as seen in this series: *Ṣ-D-L-M-Y-A-F*. Therefore wherever *ṣād* occurs it represents the manifest. The principle that the nonmanifest is the proof (*bayyināt*) of the manifest and serves to make it so was also discussed above in reference to [the principle of] *tawḥīd*.

Something so hidden such that it's almost not

For I only reach this bright morning by virtue of black night¹⁶

¹⁶ Sa'dī, ghazal: *man aḡar naẓar ḡarām ast basī ḡunāḥ dāram*.

Principle Three:

On the spiritual-mental forms of the letters

The spiritual-mental forms of the letters are constituted by their numerical values; that is, each letter is the form of a numerical degree as it manifests in the external world of the senses, these being arranged according to the order of the alphabet. It is this category of letterforms in particular that is the source of manifold wonders and subtle and strange realities, as testified to in the Prophetic hadith: *Learn the alphabet (abājād) and its exposition, for in it are contained all wonders. Woe to the scholar who knows not the alphabet and its exposition!*¹⁷

This principle likewise comprises four subsections.

On the supremacy of [the letters'] numerical form and the perfection of knowledge derived therefrom

It is well-known that the science of number (*‘ilm-i ‘adad*) is among the most glorious of the prophetic sciences and most exact of the revelations of the saintly elite. It is one of the marks of the Seal’s mission that this science became manifest during his truth-exposing tenure and the servants of his knowledge-replete threshold enabled to know it in its full perfection, for it is one of the most precious elements of the Prophetic teaching. Every science which has not been weighed and found worthy in its just scales and assayed for truth by means of its standard is [either] hopelessly imprecise or void of all benefit and purpose, being merely a senseless babbling or wholly corrupt and deceptive: *Therein they shall hear no idle talk, no cry of lies, as a recompense from your Lord, a gift, a reckoning* (Q 78:35-36). The validity of any particular science (*ṣinā’atī juz’ī*) and customary approach (*mu’āmalatī ‘urfī*) that has not been tried according to its touchstone cannot be vouched for so as to remove all doubt from the mind:

Good—let’s use the touchstone of experience:
the faces of the deceitful will turn up black!¹⁸

Now the outward aspect of number gives rise to certain properties that both common and elite are familiar with; but were they to inquire into the choice secrets and correspondences of this science they would hit upon the motherlode of all rare wonders—and it is impossible to articulate even a tenth of a tenth of these.

The enumeration of them is forever beyond articulation;
any attempt I might make would fall miserably short!¹⁹

For this reason the ancient philosophers held that the science of number is the alchemy in whose crucible all other sciences are produced and the elixir [of life] to all manner of rarities and marvels. Imam Ja’far [al-Ṣādiq] too vaunted this science and his disciples penned numerous works on the subject. The proper manner of its exposition is limited to the use of symbolism and subtle allusion, this being due to the scrupulous observance of etiquette with respect to this science in the writings of its great exponents, and so discussions of number are typically disguised as discussions of other topics. It is nevertheless possible to understand

¹⁷ Shīrawayh Daylamī, *Firdaws al-Akhhbār*, no. 2247.

¹⁸ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *naqd-i ṣūfī na hama ṣāfī bī ghashsh bāshad*.

¹⁹ Ibn al-Fāriḍ, *al-Tā’iyya al-Kubrā*, l. 35.

these cryptic treatments by virtue of the light emanating from the Seal, thereby installing the Prophetic era—*The day when the reckoning shall come to pass* (Q 14:41)—upon the bridal throne of manifestation and making-manifest (*zuhūr u izhār*) for all to see.

Let the down of her ear and the curl of her tress
take reason by the ear and drag it to school²⁰

Knowledge of this noble science having been all but erased a long time since, it has happily been and is currently being revived in our own day through the blessed efforts of the disciples of the Sayyidic Presence (*ḥaẓrat-i sayyidī*)²¹—God’s peace be upon him and his noble fathers.

[*On their manifest and nonmanifest aspects*]

The spiritual form (*ṣūrat-i ma’navī*) of the letters, as in their preceding levels, has both manifest and nonmanifest aspects. Its manifest aspect consists in the numbers associated with the *abjad* series [as such], while its nonmanifest aspect consists of numbers that may be associated with its *bayyināt*, [i.e., the letters in the names of each letter]. The latter are ranked according to their degree of nonmanifestness, for each of the *bayyināt* has its own number, which in turn has further *bayyināt* with its corresponding number, and so on in a receding series repeating as far as one’s thought can reach. It was stated above that the more deeply the nonmanifest becomes nonmanifest, the more it is capable of making clear the manifest.

Habit obstructs—but seek your desire; me,
I’ve attained peace of mind in her tangled tresses²²

The intelligent have many ways to extract meaning in this way, although for reasons of space and time these cannot be discussed here; nevertheless, those proficient in this science pursue this path by virtue of the blessed and enlightening guidance of the Seal: *That is God’s bounty; He gives it unto whomever He will* (Q 5:54, 57:21, 62:4).

The wayfarer of a pitchy night needs a sign:
led by the sweet fragrance of those black tresses
we have put to haven

[*On the superiority of their spiritual-mental form*]

It is clear that where the common run of people speak using the manifest aspect of the letters and are accustomed to pursue matters of common usage on the basis of conventional significations (*dalālāt-i vaẓ’ī-ji ja’lī*), the elite from among the ranks of human perfection base their speech on the nonmanifest aspect of the letters and communicate on the basis of real and essential significations and other universal ends, lifting the veil of confusion from off the meaning and reality of every thing in itself and showing the particular nature of all things. The

²⁰ Sa’dī, qasida: ‘*āshiqān-at sū-yi tū tuḥfa agar jān ārand*.

²¹ I.e., Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī.

²² Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *sāl-hā pay-ravī-yi mazhab-i rindān kardam*.

latter include the prophets and their heirs, the elite among the saints. Now each letter has the three forms discussed above, each of which has a manifest and nonmanifest aspect; and while such individuals are capable of bringing out the full meaning of each of these aspects, with respect to its degree of nonmanifestness the spiritual-mental form of the letters much be considered the highest and most perfect, and its properties, diligently assayed, the most comprehensive. Most people's natures, however, do not take easily to this level, and so remain incapable of grasping the realities associated with it. This verdict is supported by the Prophet hadith: *I am the first of those who speak using the dād*. If the discerning and intelligent calculate the *bayyināt* of all of the letters, they will perceive its meaning and realize that it fully supports what has been stated with respect to this level.

We need only mention one point from this book—it is this²³

[On the two categories of number]

Number intrinsically falls into two categories: those that exist and are real (*ḥaqīqī-yi vujūdī*), and those that do not exist and are subjective or perspectival (*i'tibārī-yi 'adamī*). The first category of numbers are those that subsist in themselves, not in respect (*i'tibār*) to another [number], and whose effect on another [number] is not intrinsic to its own existence; these include the numbers one to nine. The second category are those that are only formed with respect (*mulāḥaza*) to another [number]; those include all other numbers, which cannot exist except with respect to zero. Earlier philosophers, most of whom are the heirs of the prophets, employed geometrical figures to facilitate understanding of this division; the interested reader is advised to seek out these—[for as the saying has it,] *Many is the hoard hidden in a corner*. For whoever comes to understand this division through diligent and close study and meditates upon these lines, his inmost self will be flooded with realities and knowledge—this on the condition that he first cleanse it from all preoccupation with customary trappings and imitation in matters of belief.

Resist the calls of wrangling talk,
and save yourself
from false claims and their assaults,
which truly aim only to be heard²⁴

Heart—you've experienced the assembly of the elite—
speak not of the common gathering;
Soul—you've sat with the beloved—
speak not of messenger and message²⁵

These figures are as follows: *Ādam* = 45; from *A* to *Ṭ* = 45, and from *A* to *YD* = 99. Among the things that may be understood from the foregoing is the meaning of Adam/man and his ultimate perfection in the person of the Seal. But an understanding of this science can only be gained through figurative language (*zabān-i ishārat*), not through mere expository prose.

²³ Ḥāfīz, ghazal: *kay shī'r-i tar angīzad khāṭir ki ḥazīn bāshad*.

²⁴ Ibn al-Fāriḍ, *al-Tā'iyya al-Kubrā*, l. 189/190; trans. in Homerin, 'Umar Ibn al-Fāriḍ, 129.

²⁵ Awḥadī Marāgha'i, ghazal: *dil sarāy-i khāṣṣ shud az majlis-i 'āmm-ash ma-gū*.

These words that Sa'dī speaks are a message for those with hearts:
not everyone who listens can understand its meaning²⁶

Addendum:

On the meaning of the Doubled Seven

Know that each of the three aspects of the letters as described above possesses a meaning peculiar to it, but the clearest and most comprehensive of these [may be seen with respect to their occurrence in] doubled form (*masānī*). According to Arabic grammar *masānī* is the plural of *masnī*, which means doubled (*dū dū*); *masānī* therefore means quadrupled (*chahār chahār*). Now scholars hold that the lowest form of the plural is with respect to this case two, i.e., more than one. On this point Shaykh Muḥyī l-Dīn [Ibn 'Arabī] (God sanctify his secret) relates in his *al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya* that the Prophet (God's blessings and peace be upon him and his house) had a dream in which he was asked about the scholarly disagreement as to whether the lowest form of the plural is two or three. His answer, constituting the truth of the matter, was that if it is an even dual (*zawj*) it is accounted as two of each unit, and if an odd one (*fard*) its lowest plural is three. Thus as an even dual *masnī* involves two of its base unit, or two, and two times two is four.

In this sense, therefore, the meaning of the phrase *sab' al-masānī* is 28, i.e., the product of seven and four—[doubled doubled seven]; this refers to the 28 Arabic letterforms, constituting the perfect Speech and the perfect Book. None but the Seal had the capacity (*qābiliyyat*) to receive all of these forms; only one who possesses all of these forms is capable of being the seal of prophethood. It is clear that this meaning comprehends under its aegis the three aspects of the letters, with a specific meaning emerging with respect to each aspect.

With respect to the written forms treated as principle one above, [the Doubled Seven] refers to the 14 letters lying at the heart of that paired order (*tartīb-i izdivājī*), in which two letters have one form; given that they constitute the heart of this order, they serve to unify the letters, acting as the *barzakh* between oneness and multiplicity. With respect to the written order of the letters, then, the *sab' al-masānī* refers to these 14 letters, which find their correspondence in the book of human existence. These are the seven human faculties, which at the sensory level of the human body's [organs] occur in pairs: thus we have two eyes, two ears, two lips, two nostrils, two hands, two testicles, two feet. This form of the Doubled Seven as it occurs in the two Books, [the Quran and the cosmos], comprises sublime meanings that are, however, beyond the scope of the present treatise—God assist us in expounding them fully [elsewhere].

So far with respect to the written forms of the letters; with respect to their verbal forms, the manifest meaning of [the Doubled Seven] lies in the form of two *ṣāds*, which are situated at the furthest extremities of form; this is because each comprises seven ascending levels of nonmanifestness which serve as their *bayyināt*. No letter exceeds three or four, and therefore they constitute the heart of the paired verbal order. This point is supported by the hadith, *I am the first [of the prophets to be created, and the last of them to be sent]*.

Finally, with respect to the spiritual-mental forms of the letters through which the essence (*kunh*) of every thing manifests, as discussed under principle three above, it is evident that the number nine encompasses all the levels of existence, being the number of all the geometrical figures (*ruqūm-i handasa*), i.e., the furthest compass of intelligibles (*ma'qūlāt*). In this sense the number [nine] is represented by Ādam. It is self-evident that when the Adamic reality attained

²⁶ Sa'dī, ghazal: *kasī ki rū-yi tō dīda ast ḥāl-i man dānad*.

the perfection and fullness of its existence, such that what was contained within it in potentiality in terms of qualities of internal relations (*nisab*) and nonmanifest spiritual perfections, the source of the rare wonders of the [succeeding stages], became manifest in actuality, this transition was expressed by the number 99. Everything contained in potentiality in nine in terms of internal relations and its properties manifests in actuality in 99. The form of this realization is in the [numerical] knotting (*‘aqd*) 14, as those who are familiar with it know. It is thus clear that 14 represents the form of the Seal, the perfection of Adam. But I will not dwell on this mystery further; time does not allow mention of more than the brief suggestions as to the various meanings of the Doubled Seven given above.

In any event, the present author’s approach in penning this treatise has been to ignore the opinions of others and present only the firstfruits of our own time; accordingly I have declined to quote from books with their frequently stale and timeworn treatments of the subject.

Give ear to the bon-mots of Awḥadī
(assuming you can tell pearls from beads)²⁷

If after reading and digesting the foregoing the seeker craves further discussions on this subject, he is advised to consult my book *Qualities of Perfection* (*K. Khaṣāyis-i Kamālī*), where I have treated of it at somewhat greater length.²⁸

God grant us to realize our goal and place us in the path of the denizens of the abode of peace by virtue of the holiness of Muḥammad, the best of mankind, and his House and Companions, the blessings of God be upon them all. This treatise was completed on Saturday, 10 Ramaḍān 817 [23 November 1414] in Shiraz, God protect her from plague—all praise to God and blessings upon His noble Prophet.

²⁷ Awḥadī Marāghaī, ghazal: *pākbāzān-rā chi khārā va chi khaz*.

²⁸ This text, not otherwise extant, was presumably the first draft of the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*.

ب س م ال له ال ر ح م ال ر ح م

بعد از حمد بی حدّ خدایی را که در سر حدّ بدایت بحکم آفریدگاری هر ذره از ذرات کاینات را راهی جدا مقدر فرموده که (منه بدا) و در بارگاه نهایت بحکم پروردگاری همان ذره را طریقی معدّ داشته که (والیه یعود):

کفر و اسلام در رهش پویان وحده لا شریک له گویان

و تحیات بی کران نثار خاک پاک برگزیده ای که بی نشان بیانش یکدوزه قدم از کنه عدم در دایره وجود نهاده. اشارت دولت بشارت از صوب صواب چنین رسید که مقصود از علم تصوّف و علم حروف روشن می باید کرد، هر آینه بزبان ایجاز و اختصار این رساله در قلم آمد و چون امثال اشارت دولت بشارت وقت ناگزیر بود بیان غایت و غرض این دو علم شریف که نوباوه زمان و ترغیبه بوستان این اوانست بعبارتی که فهم همگان از ادراک آن عاجز نباید در رشته انتظام کشید تا بر صحایف اظهار و اشعار قوّت ادراک هر کس مضمون آنرا در یافته روشن و هویدا کرد.

حدیث با تو باندازه تو باید گفت که گر بلند کم اندکی گران شنوی

و این رساله مشتمل آمد بر مقدمه ای و دو وصل و خاتمه ای.

اما مقدمه بیاید دانست که آدمی از دیگر انواع جانوران بگوهر دانش و بینش گرامی گشته است و بواسطه عقل و دانایی از آفرینش بر سر آمده و همه را بفرمان خود در آورده چنانچه فرموده ﴿وَسَخَّرَ لَكُم مَّا فِي السَّمٰوٰتِ وَمَا فِي الْأَرْضِ جَمِیْعًا﴾ [۴۵:۱۳] بدان اشارت فرموده، و این گوهر دانش اگر چه انواع بسیار دارد ولیکن از میان همه برگزیده و گرامی دانش حکمتست آنکه در شأن او فرموده که ﴿مَنْ يُّؤْتَ الْحِكْمَةَ فَقَدْ أُوتِيَ خَيْرًا كَثِيرًا﴾ [۲:۲۶۹] چه از این علم حقیقت همه چیزها بر شخص هویدا میگردد، و بی دستیاری قوانین این علم آدمی را قوّت آن نیست که بخودی خود [مب ۱۵۴] ادراک چیزها چنانچه هست تواند کرد، و به تحقیق اصول محکم شناخت نفس خویشتن که سرمایه حقایق و معارف الاهیست حاصل توان کرد که از آنجا معرفت مبدا و معاد که جمیع پیغمبران از برای اخبار آن فرستاده شده و تحفه گرامی و جوهر نفیس خزانه این برگزیدگانست هم از آنجا ظاهر میشود.

سالها فکر من اینست و همه دم سخنم که چرا غافل از احوال دل خویشتم
ز کجا آمده ام و آمدنم بهر چه بود بکجا میروم و چیست مال شدنم

^۱ ما = مجلس ۱۰۱۹۶ ص ۱۵۷-۱۵۹؛ مب = مجلس ۱۰۰۰۴ ص ۱۵۳-۱۶۲.

و بایاد دانست که این علم در زمان پیشین از انفاس انبیای مرسل علیهم السلام زیرکان هر عصر فرا گرفته اند و بعالمیان رسانیده و از پرتو سخنان وحی نشان ایشان جهانیان راه بدین علم چنانچه اهل خبر از تواریخ فهم کرده باشند.

هر بوی که از مشک و قرنفل شنوی از دولت آن زلف چو سنبل شنوی

وصل اوّل

در بیان علم تصوّف و تحقیق غرض و غایت آن

چون این مقدمه روشن گشت بایاد دانست که در زمان پیغمبران پیشین این علم حکمت را ظهوری بیشتر بوده است بتخصیص در زمان سلیمان علیه السلام که از دامن تربیت او و ملازمانش علمای عالی قدر بر خاسته اند مثل انکساغورس و فیثاغورس و سقراط و غیرهم والحق حکمتهای ارجمند از ایشان زیور گوش و گردن روزگار شده چنانچه از تصانیف بلند پایه ایشان ظاهر میشود بر اهل بصیرت ولا غرور.

چو در² سنبل چرد آهوی تاتار نسیمش بوی مشک آرد بیازار³

ولیکن چون زمان دولت قران حضرت رسالت پناه محمد عربی صلوات الله وسلامه علیه نزدیک شد و صبح وجودش از افق اقبال سر زدن گرفت کواکب مواکب این علوم حکمی از سپهر هویدایی در حجاب تواری رفت و اندکی از آن بر مجالی اظهار و اشعار بماند و حکمت متعارف که در میان اهل مدرسه مشهور گشته و ارسطالیس آنرا معلّم اوّل بوده و بو علی سینا شیخ فنّ از آن زمان باز ظاهر شده و بعد از آن چون آفتاب حکمت پرتو حضرت رسالت پناه ختی که در غرب عرب تواری نموده بود از مشرق قریش طالع شد و زمین و زمانرا بانوار هدایت آثار روشن گردانید ریاض حکمت [مب ۱۵۵] از پرتو انوار ختی رونق و طراوتی دیگر پذیرفت و مزارع علم و معرفت از تابش پرتو آن انوار لطایف آثار نشو و نمایی تازه یافت از هر چمنش گلهای گوناگون شکفانیدن گرفت و بر هر شاخساری از درخت جمعیتش الوان بارها بر آورد فی الجمله بوستان علم و دانشوری منشای غرایب علوم و بدایع حکم آمد و گلستان حقایق و معانی منبع دقائق لطایف و جلال معارف گشت.

هر دم ازین باغ بری در رسید تازه تر از تازه تری در رسید⁴

هر آینه جمعی از زیرکان امت بزرگوارش که بر ذمت همت خویش [۱۱۵۸] التزام متابعت آنحضرت لازم داشته بودند و بوسیله اقتضای سنن گرامی آثارش ظاهر و باطن خویش را بمراقبت و مقاربت مزین و محلی گردانیده محلّ بدایع حکمت گشتند و از نفس مبارک هر یک غرایب علوم ظاهر شد چنانچه بر مبصران بازار زیرکی و دکان دانایی که از سرمایه تاجران دانش هر زمان باخبر باشند پوشیده نماند و چندانچه دور ظهور اطوار زمانی بنقطه ولایت نزدیکتر شد بنیان حقایق ارکان

² یا (بر).

³ نظامی، خسرو و شیرین.

⁴ یا (میرسد) بدل (در رسید).

این علوم بلندپایه تر گشت و کنگرهء رفعتش علوی دیگر گرفت چنانچه پوشیده نماند بر زیرکانی که در مقام هوشمندی ثابت قدم گشته و بر دیده همه دیده ایشان سبل رسوم و تقلیدات مانع مطالعهء تصانیف این بزرگان نباشد.

باز دانی که من چه میگویم گرت افتد گذر بعالم هوش⁵

هرگاه که این سخنان طراز خلعت اذهان گشت ظاهر شد که علم تصوّف عبارت از حکمتیست که السنهء سنت محمدی و شرایع ختمی علیه من الصلوات افضلها و من التّحیّات اتمها واکلها بدان ناطق گشته باشد از علوم شایسته و اعمال بایسته، همچنانچه حکمت متعارف عبارت از علمیت که السنهء ادلهء نظری و براهین عقلی بدان گویا باشد از علوم شایسته و اعمال بایسته. بدین طریق بین تفاوت ره کر کجاست تا بکجا.

مصطفی اندر جهان آنکه کسی گوید که عقل آفتابی بر فلک آنکه کسی جوید سُهی⁶

وامّا مقصود از علم تصوّف همچنین روشن گشت بر هوشمند که غایت علم تصوّف و غرض از تحصیل و اکتساب آن [مب ۱۵۶] همینست که شخص از مرتبهء حیوانیت و حیات عارضی بواسطهء آنکه متحقّق بعلم انبیا گردد و اعمال ایشان ترقّی نموده بمرتبهء کمال انسانی و حیات ابدی فایز گردد و در این ظلمات بشریت از سر چشمهء آب حیات بی بهره نماند.

آن چشمه که خضر خورد ازو آب حیات در منزل تست لیکن انباشته ای

وصل دوم

در بیان علم حروف و تحقیق غایت و غرض آن

بباید دانست که انبیای مرسل صلوات الله و سلامه علیهم اجمعین که هزار دستان این گلستان اعجوبه داستانند، ایشانرا با هر طایفه ای از طوایف ام زمان خود زبانی خاص هست و عرفی جداگانه دارند، چنانچه فحوائ فرموده ﴿وما أَرْسَلْنَا مِنْ رَّسُولٍ إِلَّا بِلِسَانٍ قَوْمِهِ﴾ [۱۴:۴] از آن معنی نشان میدهد چه کلام وحی انجام ایشان همچنانکه با محرمان مهانهء بُعد و محجوران بیابان بیگانگی بیان احکام شرایع میکند و ایشانرا راه قویم دار السلام هدایت مینماید بزبان دلالات وضعی و کنایات و استعارات عرفی، همچنین با محرمان پیشگاه قرب و آشنایان پرده سرای یگانگی و انس بیان حکم و حقایق میکند و ایشانرا بهر حرفی بر بسی اصول علوم و امّهات معارف واقف میگرداند و خزاین نقایس ارجمند و جواهر گرامی با ایشان در میان مینهد هم بزبان اشارات وضعی و رموز حرفی ولیکن نه وضع اعتباری جعلی که مبنای مقاصد متعارف عامه باشد بلکه وضع اصلی حقیقی که مُستند دلالات کلام آسمانی تواند شد و خلص خواص محرمان خلوتخانهء خصوص از آن باخبر توانند بود.

نهفته معنی نازک بسیست در خط یار تو فهم آن نکنی ای ادیب من دامن⁷

⁵ اوحدی کرمانی.

⁶ سنائی.

⁷ حافظ: (یاری اندر کس نمی بینم یارابرا چه شد).

و تمام تحقیق این سخن بواجبی نمودن بسطی و مجالی بیشترک در کار دارد همانا در کتاب مفاحص از ادای بعضی تفصّی نموده شده و بیاید دانست که این معنی بنسبت با کلام سایر انبیا و کمل متحقق است فکیف با کلام تمام انجام ابانت انتظام عربی قرآنی که حضرت رسالت پناه ختمی محمدی صلوات الله و سلامه علیه و علی آله بدان فرستاده شده بسوی کافّه ام چه در طی هر حرفی از حروف مقطعهء فرقانی و موصّلهء قرآنی که ذات مبارک حضرت [مب ۱۵۷] ختمی بدان مرسل شده فنون حکم جلیله ظاهر فرموده و اصول علوم عظیمه آشکارا کرده ولیکن اهالی شهرستان اهلیت که زبان نوحاستگان زمان داند از این معنی خبر یابند و معلوم کنند که چه تفاوتست میانهء حکمت تامّهء ختمی محمدی و میانهء حکمت انبیای پیشین و حکمای گذشته.

ای گل تو کجا و روی خویش او مشک و تو خار بار داری
نرگس تو کجا و چشم مستش او سر خوش و تو خار داری^۸

چون بر الواح تفضّل احوال این مقدّمه ثبت گشت معلوم شد که علم حروف عبارت از علم نیست محیط بر کلّ معلومات جزئی و کلی که مستنبط از اوضاع صور منزلهء سبّاهی و احوال هیأت آن جواهر مرسل بها شده که تحفهء گرامی انبیا و رسل از حضرت عزّت بسوی بندگانش همان آمده است، و تمام تحقیق این تعریف آنست که علوم حکمت دو قسمست بعضی آنست که کاشف از کلیات معلوماتست فحسب چنانچه حکمت متعارف از آن بحث کند و هر چه بادلّهء نظری اکتساب نموده شود از این قبیل خواهد بود و نوعی دیگر آنست که [ما ۱۵۸ب] کشف آن مخصوص بکلیات نیست بلکه جامعست میانهء کلیات و جزئیات و هر چه از ادلّهء صور منزلهء سبّاهی حاصل شود از این قبیل تواند بود چنانچه فحوای فرمودهء ﴿وَلَا رُطْبٌ وَلَا يَابِسٌ إِلَّا فِي كِتَابٍ مُبِينٍ﴾ [۶:۵۹] بدان دالّست چه این نوع حکمت از منطق الطیر سلیمانی اکتساب میتوان نمود و آن عبارت از علم نیست قانونی که مبادی آن مشتمل بر اولیات اشکال محسوسه و بیّنات اوضاع مبصره و مسموعه است که انبیای مرسل بدان فرستاده شده اند، و مسایل آن مشتمل بر اقترانات قضایای فطری و علوم اصل نیست که تقلّبات اطوار و ادوار در آن تغییر و تبدیل نتواند نمودن و بهبوب صرصر حدّثان گرد آرایش و آمیزش گردد کنگرهء رفعتش نتواند گشت و جزر بقدم قدم و کام یگانگی پیرامون حریم آن نتوان رسید متردّدان سر کوی نظر و فکر و معتکفان خلوتخانهء خیالات وجدانی از این راه دور افتاده اند.

غواصی کن گرت گهر می باید غواصانرا چند^۹ هنر می باید
سر رشته بدست یار و جان بر کف دست [مب ۱۵۸] دم نازدن و قدم ز سر می باید

وامّا بیان غرض از علم حروف و تحقیق غایت آن پوشیده نماند بر مبصران حلقهء هوشمندی و زیرکان کوی آفرینش که هر جوهر که سزاوار آن باشد که از قرارگاه قدم و شهرستان قدس قوافل انبیای مرسل سلام الله علیهم اجمعین حامل آن شده وفود ملأ اعلی و ملایکهء متقرّبین بجبال حفظ در بار ایشان بندند و بکارگاه حدّثان فرستند تا در تیز بازار ﴿رَجُلًا صَدَقُوا مَا عَاهَدُوا اللَّهَ﴾ [۳۳:۲۳] که آنجا بحکم فرمودهء ﴿بَلِّغْ مَا أُنْزِلَ إِلَيْكَ﴾ [۵:۶۷] بار ایشانرا بکشایند، هر یک از آن رجال که بر مرتبهء بلوغ انسانی رسیده باشند و قوّت آن پیدا کرده که (ما إليه البلاغ) شوند بقدر نقد استعدادی که در کیسهء همت و نیّت ایشان باشد در مقام خریداری در آیند و بواسطهء قبول و تملک آن جوهر گرانمایه از پایهء دوری و گمراهی ببساط

^۸ حافظ: (ای باد نسیم یار داری).

^۹ یا (چار).

قرب حضرت عزّت و سزاواری هدایت فایز کردند و بعد از آن بحسب قوت حمل و فهم نفایس آن بمدارج ایمان و اسلام و احسان ترقی نمایند و مغبوط و محسود ملأ اعلی و ملایکه گردند، بکدام عبارت سطری از اوصاف آن جواهر ادا توان کرد، یا کدام جارحه از جوارح مدارک بشری را قوت آن باشد که ورق از گلستان کمالش در جنگل ادراک آرد، مگر بزبان (لا اُحصی)¹⁰ شمه ای از شمایم بوستان آن جواهر و نسایم مدایحش بگوش هوش غافلان بوادی حیرت توان رسانید.

ما خود کیم تا ز ثنای تو دم زیم دم در کشیم تا تو بگوئی ثنای خویش¹¹

آنچه زبان اجمال از وجوه جلال آن مخدّرات خانواده قدس و حرم سرای قدم بیان توانست نمودن همینست فاما بیان آنچه السنه تفصیل از وجوه تحقیقشان مؤدّی میگرداند آنست که حکمت تامّه بالغه که از کلام اعراب انجام حضرت رسالت پناه ختمی محمدی عربی روشن گشته بزبان اشارات حرفی و اوضاع اصلی قدیمی ایشان مبین میگردد بر وجهی که براهین قاطعه و دلایل ساطعه همراهی نموده بسر حدّ ايقان و احسان رساند و بی شایبه تکلف. پوشیده نماند بر زیرکان کوی تیقظ و هوشمندی که هر علمی که معرفت هر چه هست از کلیات و جزئیات همه آثار افصاح آن تواند بود و سایر مراتب الاهی و کیانی از اکوان [مب ۱۵۹] و اعیان در طی مبادی و مسایل او روشن و هویدا گردد بوجهی که زیور برهان از مطاوی بیانش باهر و درفشان باشد، چنانچه بر طالبانی که مرتبه ادراک و همت ایشان از پایه قدر وارثان ختمی بسیار دور نیفتاده باشد و با خاکساران کوی خدمتش آشنایی داشته باشند اثبات توان نمود، بعزّت و نفاست آن هیچ علمی صورت نندد.

دل گفت مرا علم لدنی هوست تعلیم کن گرت بدان دسترست
گفتم که الف گفت دگر گفتم هیچ در خانه اگر کسست یک حرف بسست

و این نوع اشعار خاصّه کلام تامّ ختمیست و مخصوص زبان حقایق ترجمانش و بیاید دانست که تا غایت مخدّرات دودمان نبوّت و سر پوشیدگان سراپرده ختمی از حجاب نقاب بیرون نیامده و دیده ره روان مسالک طلب بر ایشان نیفتاده مگر در پس پرده امثله و اشباه.

روی تو کس ندید و هزارت رقیب هست در غنچه ای هنوز و صدت عندلیب هست¹²

در این چندگاه بمیامن ارقام اقطار انشقاق سیّدی از پرده های عزّتش بندی چند گشوده گشته، و از وجوه اعراب سپایش نشانی نموده شده تا که را توفیق آن باشد که پرتو سواد آن ارقام نور دیدگان ابصار و استبصار او را قوت آن بخشد که رنگی از این گونه در تواند یافتن تا در عداد آن در آید که زبان نوحاستگان زمان فهم نماید و بدان واسطه از عرایس حجله حروف و کلام قدیم [مب ۱۵۹] بهره ور تواند گشت و بمرتبه بلوغ خاص انسانی که ورای بلوغ عامّ حیوانیست که همان متعارف زبان جمهورست برسد. و تمام تحقیق این سخن آنست که همچنانچه بلوغ حیوانی عبارت از آنست که ذوق ادراک آن در شخص پیدا

¹⁰ مسلم، صحیح، کتاب الصلاة (۱۱۱۸): حَدَّثَنَا أَبُو بَكْرِ بْنُ أَبِي شَيْبَةَ حَدَّثَنَا أَبُو أُسَامَةَ حَدَّثَنَا عَبْدُ اللَّهِ بْنُ عُمَرَ عَنْ مُحَمَّدِ بْنِ بَحْجٍ بْنِ حَبَّانٍ عَنِ الْأَعْرَجِ عَنْ أَبِي هُرَيْرَةَ عَنْ عَائِشَةَ قَالَتْ فَقَدْ رَأَى رَسُولُ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ لَيْلَةً مِنَ الْفَرَاشِ فَالْتَمَسَتْهُ فَوَقَعَتْ يَدِي عَلَى بَطْنِ قَدَمَيْهِ وَهُوَ فِي الْمَسْجِدِ وَهِيَ مَنْصُوبَتَانِ وَهُوَ يَقُولُ «اللَّهُمَّ أَعُوذُ بِرِضَاكَ مِنْ سَخَطِكَ وَبِعَافَاتِكَ مِنْ عُقُوبَتِكَ وَأَعُوذُ بِكَ مِنْكَ لَا أُحْصِي ثَنَاءً عَلَيْكَ أَنْتَ كَمَا أَثْنَيْتَ عَلَى نَفْسِكَ».

¹¹ اوحی کرمانی.

¹² حافظ: (روی تو کس ندید و هزارت رقیب هست).

شود که از قابلی که مقابل او باشد در ماده حیوانیت که عبارت از جسم بالنده باحس و حرکت است حظ استمتاع واستلذاذ تواند یافت تا از آن ممر حیوانی دیگر از این نوع متولد گردد بحیات عرضی سریعه الزوال، همچنین بلوغ انسانی عبارت از آنست که ذوق ادراک آن در شخص پیدا شود که از قابلی که مقابل او باشد در صورت انسانیت که عبارت از [مب ۱۶۰] نطق و گویایی بحروف کلمات قدیمست فایز باستمتاع و استلذاذ تواند شد تا از آن ممر شخصی انسانی پیدا شود که حتی باشد بحیات ابدی، چنانچه بزرگی در این معنی گفته باشد که

گر بنیوشی زنده بمانی جاوید ور نه دم ماست هم بما باز آید

و همچنانچه آن بلوغ حیوانی را علامات و امارات هست و آن عبارت از شدت شوق و سبق بوصول قابل خودش باشد و فکر لذت استمتاع از او همچنین بلوغ انسانی نیز علامتش همینست که او را شوق اتصال بمقابل خاص خود پیدا شود و از فکر لذت استمتاع از او خالی نباشد.

و غرض از ایراد این سخن در اینجا دو چیز آمد یکی آنکه روشن میگردد بدین که هر نارسیده ای را قوت ادراک علم حروف نخواهد بودن چه نخواستی ای میباید که قوت مردی و رجولیت انسانیت که بزبان قوم آنرا فتوت خوانند در او پیدا شده باشد و لذت اتصال بمقابل خاص خود یافته تا از بازار دلربایی عروسان حمله خانه قدم یعنی حروف مقطعه فرقی نومیید باز نگردد.

اگر مردی قدم در نه وگر نه نه حد زاهد رعناست این راه

و دوم آنکه چون سیاق سخن بدین سر حد رسیده بود که بیان غرض علم حروف میبایست کرد و از این تعریف که گذشت بروشن تر و جمعی فهم میشود که درین بازار آمیزش و آلاش که بنقد حیات حیوانی داد و ستد میکنند حیات ابدی سود این سوداست هر که را سرمایه همت در بار ادراک و خواسته استعداد باشد.

جناب عشق بلندست همتی حافظ که عاشقان ره بی همتان بخود ندهند¹³

خاتمه

چند حکایت از آثار سلف و اخبار اخبار ختم رساله بدان میکنند تا مؤید سخنان گذشته شود چه ائمه اهل بیت و خادمان خانواده نبوت رضوان الله عليهم اجمعین که ایشان اساطین بنیان حکمت و معرفتند اثری چند بر صحایف روزگار گذاشته اند و هر یک نزد هوشمند آیتی از آیات اثبات این علم شریفست و نشانی از نشانهای حقیقت این غرض مذکور که عبارت از استطلاع سایر کلیات و جزئیات عالمست و ترتب آن بر علم مذکور هر آینه واجب آمد جهت [مب ۱۶۱] تنزل بمدارک مسترشدان چندی از آن آثار در این سلک کشیدن.

¹³ حافظ: (شراب بی غش و ساقی خوش دو دام رهند).

از آن جمله ثعالی آورده است که در آن وقت که آیت کریمه ﴿حَمَّ عَسَق﴾ [۲:۴۲-۱] نزول اجلال فرمود از بشره هدایت اسرّه حضرت رسالت آثار سامت و ملالت ظاهر شد جمعی از اصحاب که حاضران بساط مباسط بودند از حضرت امیر شهرستان ولایت علی بن ابو طالب که محرم سرپرده اسرار بود تفحص نمودند که کدام حادثه سبب سامت حضرت گشته و کدام واقعه موجب آثار ملال و کلال مزاج مبارک آمده؟ حضرت امیر بعد از تفحص و تحقیق فرمودند که آیتی که فرود آمده همانا دلالت بر آن میکند که اقامت معالی رتبت حضرت رسالت بعد از انقراض زمان هدایت نشانش بی ادبی با این خانواده جلال خواهند کرد.

دیگر در تواریخ اهل بیت آورده باشند که در آن وقت که مامون عباسی که واسطه عقد خلفای بنی عباس بود به پیشی گرفتن اسپ دولتش و سابقی جواد همتش بشرف پایوس امام همان ترغیبه روضه ارتضا و نوباوه بوستان اصطفا علی بن موسی الرضا فایز گشت و میامن نظر اکسیر آثارش از بیابان بعد و انکار بسوی شهرستان قرب و اقرار فرود آمد و در بساط ارادت و اعتقاد بار یافت، و همانا شمه ای از فوایح بوستان کالات امام از میامن ملازمت آن آستان بمشام جانش رسید هر آینه نشوه شوقش در حرکت آمد و عنان تمالک و اختیار (الملک عقیق) از [ما ۱۵۹ب] قبضه اقتدارش در ربود چنانچه فحوی گفته حافظ که:

ز جرعه تو سرم مست گشت نوشت باد خود از کدام خُست این که در سبو داری¹⁴

ترانه و قتش آمد. غرض که التماس از حضرت امام نمود که باقلام حقایق اعلام عهدنامه مرقوم رقم التفات فرمایند تا سبب اطمینان او گردد و تخت خلافت و پادشاهی بفرّ اقدام امامی سرافراز گردانیده بیای بندگی تواند ایستاد که کمر خدمت در میان بندد حضرت امام بحکم فرموده ﴿أَطِيعُوا اللَّهَ وَأَطِيعُوا الرَّسُولَ وَأُولِي الْأَمْرِ مِنْكُمْ﴾ [۴:۵۹] التماس او را مبذول داشته آن عهدنامه مرقوم رقم عاطفت و دلجوی گردانیدند ولیکن در زمان ملاقات و مناوالت چنین فرمودند که عهدنامه نبشته شد [مب ۱۶۲] ولیکن شکی نیست که این خلافت با تمام نخواهد رسید. مامون سوال کرد که از کجا تحقیق شده؟ فرمودند که جفر و جامع دلالت برین نمیکند. گویند که این عبارت بر صدر عهدنامه نبشته بوده اند: (کتبت هذا علی مقتضى حالک وأما الجفر والجامع فیدلان علی ضدّ ذلك).

دیگر ابو العالیه که از اساطین اهل تفسیرست نقل از ثقاة رواة کرده که مقطعات حروف نورانی که در اوایل سور قرآنی منزل گشته. جمعی سوال فرموده اند از ائمه رشد و هدایت معانی ایشانرا. جواب فرموده اند که اینها دلالت بر بسی حقایق و معانی میکنند از آن جمله بر زمان دولت جمعی و انقراض جمعی دیگر. غرض از نقل این حکایات آنکه تا هوشمند را فهم شود که اگر این علم بزبان رسم جویان مدرسه و خانقاه مذکور و مشهور نشده ولیکن در زبان بزرگان پیشین که خلع رسوم خلق و عادات خلق ایشان کرده معتبر و معظّم بوده و هست. فی الجمله این افسانهها جهت کویه بینان کوی هوس نبشته شد چه طالبان شاه راه دردمندی از یک نکته ذوق انگیز که در طی رساله بدان اشارت شده چندان لذّت و شادمانی بجانشان راه یابد که بمقیاس قیاس در نیاید.

گر شراب اینست کز جام تو مارا مست کرد باده مستانرا فریبی میدهد همچون سراب

¹⁴ یا (به).

¹⁵ حافظ: (صبا تو نکبت آن زلف مشک بو داری).

والسلام على من اتبع الهدى

تم في يوم الاحد ١٧ ذى القعدة

سنة ٨٢٨

م

R. ANJĀM

Conclusion; or, A Comparison of Sufism and Lettrism

In th NM of GD ALLMRCFUL EVRMRCFUL

Boundless praise be to God, Who at the beginning as Creator apportioned out singly each atom of every existent—*It began from Him*—and at the end as Sovereign will make tally of these same atoms—*and to Him it returns*—

Unbelief and belief chase after Him
chanting *To Him alone without partner*;

and boundless blessings be strewn upon the pure earth (*khāk-i pāk*) of the chosen one, in the absence of whose message not a single atom of eternity would have emerged from the womb of nothingness into the circuit of being.

There came a felicitating dispatch from the realm of truth (*ṣawb-i ṣavāb*) to the effect that I should treat of the respective objectives of the science of Sufism (*‘ilm-i taṣavvuf*) and the science of letters (*‘ilm-i ḥurūf*), albeit in abbreviated and summary form. In keeping with the dictates of this accession I have found it necessary to treat of the purpose of these two noble sciences, the firstfruits of the era and moist buds in the garden of this age, in such a manner that everyone will be capable of grasping it; the treatise has accordingly been written such that on the pages of manifestation and communication its contents will be comprehensible to all.

One must address you according to your measure
if I raise my discourse but slightly you will hear with difficulty¹

The work comprises a prologue, two sections and an epilogue.

Prologue

Know that the human being is superior to all other species of living beings by virtue of his knowledge and insight (*dānish u bīnash*), and through his rational faculty he crowns creation; all are subject to his command, as is indicated by His saying, *He has subjected to you all that is in the heavens and in the earth* (Q 45:13). Now there are many types of knowledge, but the choicest among these is wisdom (*ḥikmat*), of which He said, *Whoso is given wisdom has been given much good* (Q 2:269). For it is through this type of knowledge (*‘ilm*) that the reality (*ḥaqīqat*) of everything is made manifest to a person; a man deprived of the aid of its rules (*qavānīn*) and left to his own

¹ Awḥadī Kirmānī, qasida: *agar ḥaqāyiq-i ma’nā bi gūsh-i jān shīnuvī*.

devices is incapable of perceiving things as they truly are. It is through inquiry into wisdom's incontrovertible principles (*uṣūl*) that one is enabled to recognize one's self (*nafs*) as the principal stock-in-trade (*sarmāya*) of the divine realities and features (*ḥaqāyiq u ma'ārif*), for it is from the soul that one derives knowledge of origin and return (*mabda' u ma'ād*), the message that all prophets have been charged with bringing and the most prized jewel in the treasurehoard of these chosen ones.

For years my every thought has been the question:
 Why am I oblivious to my condition of my own heart?
 Where have I come from and why?
 Where am I going and how will this happen?

Know that this science was in former times extrapolated from the utterances of the prophets (upon whom be peace) by the learned of every age. The latter then communicated it to the world, giving people to understand with the radiance of their inspiration-bound words the path to this science, much in the way that historians (*ahl-i khabar*) do with their chronicles.

Every fragrance you think comes from musk and clove
 emanates rather from the province of that hyacinth tress²

Section One:

On the discipline of Sufism and its goals

If the foregoing is clear to you, know that this science of wisdom was more prevalent in the time of the previous prophets, and especially in the time of Solomon, on whose teaching and the teaching of his companions great thinkers such as Anaxagoras, Pythagoras, Socrates and others have drawn—truly, their noble philosophies (*ḥikmat-hā*) have beautified the lineaments of the age, as anyone with a modicum of insight may see from their magnificent writings.

When the Tatar roe grazes among the blossoms
 the breeze bears the scent of musk to market³

But by the time that the blessed advent of the Arab prophet Muḥammad drew near and the dawn of his being broke from behind the horizon of felicity, the starry ranks of these sciences of wisdom and philosophy (*'ulūm-i ḥikmī*) had departed the heaven of manifestness for the veil of occultation, with but a small fraction of them being communicated and discussed. The reemergence of the mainstream version of philosophy (*ḥikmat-i muta'āraf*) familiar to schoolmen (*ahl-i madrasa*), which derives from Aristotle, the First Teacher, and was reformulated by Ibn Sīnā, its latter-day master, received its impetus from the new revelation—that point at which the sun of wisdom gave forth the rays of prophecy's Seal who, long obscured behind the west of the Arabs, now rose from the east of the Quraysh, illuminating the world and time with the lights of guidance. Basking in this nourishing Seallight the gardens of wisdom-philosophy again grew fresh and verdant and under the warm radiance of its subtleties the fields of knowledge and gnosis (*'ilm u ma'rifat*) sprouted luxuriantly anew, each field blooming with innumerable flowers and each branch on its all-encompassing tree (*dirakht-i*

² 'Irāqī, *rubā'ī* 163.

³ Niẓāmī, *Khusraw u Shīrīn*.

jam'iyat-ash) groaning with every kind of fruit. In short, the garden of knowledge and learning saw the growth of the most rarefied sciences and choicest modes of wisdom and the flowerbed of realities and meaning bloomed with the subtleties and glories of gnosis (*ma'ārif*).

Each instant this garden produces fruits
each fresher than the last

Out of an elevated sense of purpose a group of the leading scholars of this community held it requisite to adhere to the example of the Prophet, and by dint of their emphasis on his holy custom beautified their inner and outer selves through tireless self-examination and effort; in so doing these exemplary individuals became hosts to wisdom and from the blessed breath of each proceeded diverse occult sciences (*gharāyib-i 'ulūm*)—this fact is obvious to those who are savvy traders in the market of acumen and the shop of knowledge, being well acquainted with the worth of the capital possessed by the merchants of knowledge in each era. The historical cycles (*dawr-i zuhūr-i aṭvār-i zamānī*) having thus drawn ever closer to their centerpoint of sanctified power (*valāyat/vilāyat*), the edifice constructed upon the foundational truths of these sciences became ever grander and its soaring turrets reached new heights. These developments are clear to the intelligent whose feet are firmly planted at the station of perspicacity and whose insight prompts them to the examination of the works of these great thinkers as not incompatible with the approach of organized and prescriptive religion (*subul-i rusūm u taqlīdāt*).

You know still what I'm saying;
if it happens to you pass beyond to the intellect's realm⁴

These words having embroidered your mind's robe of honor, then, the science of Sufism may thus be seen as constituting a mode of wisdom that is formulated in terms of Muḥammad's Sunna and the prescriptions (*sharāyī*) of his revelation, and has its place among the permitted sciences and required practices; mainstream philosophy constitutes a [complementary] science that is formulated in terms of inductive proofs and rational demonstrations (*adilla-yi naẓarī u barāhīn-i 'aqlī*), and likewise has its place among the permitted sciences and required practices. Consider the difference in their methods and compare the point of departure and end result of each.

The Chosen One is in this cosmos where one imagines Intellect to be,
a sun in that sphere where one strains to see Suhā⁵

The objective of the science of Sufism is likewise clear to the perspicacious: its program of education and training aims to elevate a person beyond the level of mere physicality (*ḥayavāniyyat*) and accidental being (*ḥayāt-i 'ārizī*) by means of the proven methods and practices contained in the prophetic teachings so as to attain to the level of human perfection and eternal life, thereby escaping entrapment in the darkness of the flesh where one is cut off from the fount of the water of life.

⁴ Awḥadī Kirmānī.

⁵ I.e., the faint star Alcor in Ursa Major; finding it in the night sky was regarded by the Arabs as a test of sight. The verse is by Sanā'ī.

That spring from which Kheẓr drank the water of life
is in your own home, but you've blocked it off!

Section Two:

On the discipline of lettrism and its goals

Know that the prophets sent by God (the blessings and peace of God be upon them all)—the nightingales of this marvelously storied garden—communicated their burden in the language of their people and in the idiom peculiar to each, as indicated by the divine saying: *We have sent no messenger except in the tongue of his people* (Q 14:4). The divinely inspired message that they convey makes known to those outcast and exiled in the desert of estrangement the dictates of divine law and guides them to the straight path to the Abode of Peace by means of conventional expressions, metaphors and customary tropes;⁶ at the same time it explicates truths and instances of wisdom to the initiates of the court of nearness and the companions of the harem of oneness and intimacy, with every letter thereof giving them to understand a myriad matrices and principles of knowledge and gnosis and pouring out before them priceless treasures and precious jewels, this likewise in the form of conventional allusions (*ishārāt-i vaẓ'ī*) and lettersigns (*rumūz-i ḥarfī*). This, however, is not to be understood as the typical conventionality of usage which is arbitrary and artificial (*vaẓ'-i i'tibārī-yi ja'li*) and used by the majority to express themselves, but is rather a conventionality or situationality that corresponds to that which is fundamental and real (*vaẓ'-i aṣlī-yi ḥaqīqī*), a suitable mode of expression for the heavenly Speech and capable of communicating its message to the elite of the elite from among the initiates of the seclusion chamber of the elect (*khuṣṣ*).

So many subtle meanings are hid in the down on his lip (*khaff-i yār*)
of which you are unaware, litterateur—but I know them⁷

(I have treated of this and related points with the appropriate depth in my *Book of Inquiries* (*K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*).) Know moreover that the above statement holds true for all other prophets and perfected individuals—how much more so then for the perfect Arabic Qur'ān with which the Seal Muḥammad (God's blessings and peace be upon him and upon his family) was sent to all peoples! For its every letter, including both its unjoined differentiating (*muqaṭṭa'a-yi furqānī*) and contiguous recitative (*muvaṣṣala-yi qur'ānī*) letters, discloses a wealth of glorious instances of wisdom and makes known the fundamentals of important sciences. Yet it is the denizens of the realm of skill and mastery, conversant as they are in the language of the new generation (*naw-khāstagān-i zamān*), that discover this fact and demonstrate the superiority of the perfect wisdom of the Muḥammadan revelation to the wisdom brought by previous prophets and sages.

Rose, what are you next to his pretty face?
He is musk and you—full of thorns
Narcissus, what are you next to his intoxicated eye?
He is charmingly tipsy and you—drooping drunk⁸

⁶ *Dalālāt-i vaẓ'ī u kināyāt u isti'ārāt-i 'urfī*.

⁷ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *yārī andar kas namī-bīnīm yārān-rā chi shud*.

⁸ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *ay bād-i nasīm yār dārī*.

If the thrust of this premise may be considered graven on the tablets of intelligence, it will be seen that the science of letters (*‘ilm-i ḥurūf*) is a science that encompasses all that can be known, whether particular or universal, by means of analysis of the state of the revealed heavenly forms and the nature of the shapes of those substances,⁹ the priceless gift prophets and messengers bear from the majestic Presence to His servants.

To clarify this definition we may divide the sciences of wisdom into two categories. The first comprises those that deal solely with universals as objects of knowledge, the approach of mainstream philosophy (*ḥikmat-i muta‘āraf*); any method that relies on inductive reasoning (*adilla-yi nazārī*) belongs to this type. The second comprises those that do not deal only with universals but encompass both universals and particulars; any method that relies on proofs (*adilla*) derived from the revealed heavenly forms belongs to this type, and takes as its proof-text the verse *There is nothing fresh nor withered but it is in a manifest Book* (Q 6:59). This latter category may be understood as having as its point of departure Solomon’s ability to understand the speech of the birds (*manṭiq al-ṭayr-i sulaymānī*). It is a science governed by rules (*qānūnī*) and predicated on the first principles of the sensible forms (*avvaliyyāt-i ashkāl-i maḥsūsa*) and the self-evident aspects of the visible and auditory elements (*bayyināt-i awzā‘-i muḥṣara u masmū‘a*) of that which has been revealed to the prophets; the set of problems with which it deals includes the associations that obtain between intuitively-known matters (*iqtirānāt-i qazāyā-yi fiṭrī*) and [the propositions of the] primordial (*aṣlī*) sciences. [Given such principles and concerns], this science cannot be affected or altered by the constant revolution of historical cycles, nor can the cold dustchoked winds of happenstance tatter to the summits of its exaltation. None may attain to its sanctuary save with a stride on the scale of eternity (*qadam-i qidam*) and a yearning for oneness (*kām-i yagānagī*)—those who haunt the alley of discursive thought (*nazar u fikr*) and who keep to the seclusion chamber of passion-induced fantasies (*khayālāt-i vijdānī*) remain far from this path.

Dive!—you might just find a pearl.
Now divers require several skills:
trusting a friend with the rope,
taking your life into your hands,
holding your breath,
turning head over heels

As for the objective of the science of letters, it is obvious to insightful members of the circle of perspicacity and inhabitants of the alley of native intelligence that every substance (*jawhar*) that is worthy to be carried by the caravans of the prophets (God’s peace be upon them all) from the abode of eternity (*qidam*) and the keep of holiness is strapped onto their loads by archangels delegated from among the ranks of the heavenly host and sent down to the workshop of temporal circumstance (*ḥidsān*) till that in the midst of the market bustle these *men faithful to their covenant with God* (Q 33:23) open their loads in accordance with His saying *Deliver what has been sent down to you* (Q 5:67). These men, having reached adult perfection (*bulūgh-i insānī*) and acquired virility so as to serve as models of emulation (*mā ilay-hi l-balāgh*), then become buyers according to the amount of currency of innate capacity (*naqd-i isti‘dādī*) each has in the purse of his high purpose and intent, and through their taking possession of that precious substance depart from the state of trackless exile and attain to the court of proximity to the majestic Presence, so becoming worthy of guidance. They then ascend

⁹ *Awzā‘-i ṣuvar-i munzala-yi samāwī u aḥvāl-i hay‘āt-i ān javāhir-i mursal bi-hā.*

through the degrees of faith, submission and virtue¹⁰ according to the ability of each to bear and fathom the treasures therein, so becoming envied and admired by the angelic host.

By what measure could one hope to pen a single line in description of those substances? What human faculty of perception possesses the ability to carry away a single leaf from the garden of that perfection into the forest of perception? For it is only by saying *I do not recount*¹¹ that a fragrance from the garden of those substances and a breeze bearing their praises may be wafted to the ear of comprehension for those wandering heedless in the valley of confusion.

Who are we that we should be silent from praising You?
But we pant for You to speak and praise Yourself!¹²

This, then, is what one may say in general terms as to the beautiful qualities of those veiled virgins dwelling the household of holiness and the harem of eternity. To speak in more specific terms, the perfect and mature wisdom propounded in the eloquent speech of Muḥammad, the Arab Seal of prophecy, was expressed through the medium of verbal allusions (*ishārāt-i ḥarfī*) and conventional expressions of long standing (*awzā'-i aṣlī-yi qadīmī*), its definitive proofs and clear arguments effortlessly productive of certitude and virtue. It is clear to the inhabitants of the alley of attentiveness and perspicacity that any science which can clearly formulate knowledge of all things, both universals and particulars, and whose principles and questions clarify the nature of every level of divine and engendered existence, from that of engendered beings (*akvān*) up to that of the [fixed] entities (*a'yān*), such that the ornament of proof (*burhān*) shines forth brilliantly from the folds of its expositions (as may be demonstrated to those seekers (*tālibān*) whose degree of perception and purpose is but slightly less than that of the Heirs of the Seal's legacy (*vārisān-i khatmī*) and who are acquainted with his devoted servants (*khāksārān-i kūy-i khidmat-ash*))—such a science surpasses all others in value.

My heart said, I long for mystical knowledge!
Teach me if you're able.
I replied, A. It said, Yes, and? I said, That's it:
if anyone's home a single letter will suffice.

Now this [allusive] mode of communication (*ish'ār*) is unique to the perfect reality-expounding speech of the Seal, for know that the veiled virgins of the prophetic house and harem can never leave their concealment nor can they be seen by questing travelers save by means of allegory and simile (*amsila u ashbāh*).

You have a thousand observers—yet none has seen your face
a hundred nightingales atrill—and you still in the bud¹³

¹⁰ *īmān u islām u iḥsān*.

¹¹ *Lā uḥṣī*, a reference to the famous hadith (recorded in e.g. *Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim*, K. *al-Ṣalāt* (5), bab 42, no. 1118) in which Muḥammad exclaims in a night prayer: “I do not recount Your praise—You are as You have praised yourself!”

¹² *Awḥadī Kirmānī*.

¹³ Ḥāfiz, ghazal: *rū-yi tū kas na-dīd u hizār-at raqīb hast*.

Recently a number of locks securing the veils that shroud the quranic grandeur have been opened and an exposition of its eloquent texture has been given through the good offices of the moon-splitting writings of Sayyid [Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī],¹⁴ such that the one to whom it is granted that the black radiance of those scrawls (*arqām*) give to the light of the scouts of his seeing and scrutiny the power to comprehend a color of this type may thereby join the ranks of those who understand the language of the new generation (*naw-khāstagān-i zamān*)¹⁵ and partake of the brides of the marriage chamber of the letters, the eternal Speech; in this process one attains to the type of maturity unique to human beings as distinct from the merely physical maturity of animals (*bulūgh-i āmm-i ḥayavānī*), which latter is all the common run of people know.

To understand this point, consider physical maturity, which is marked by the ability to experience sexual arousal (*zawq-i idrāk*); when confronted by a member of the opposite sex (*muqābil*) the physical apparatus (*mādda-yi ḥayavāniyyat*), i.e., the member, becomes engorged and sensitized so as to be capable of experiencing pleasure (*istimtāʿ, istilzāz*). By virtue of this process another animal of the same species (*nawʿ*) may be engendered, possessed of merely accidental life (*ḥayāt-i ʿarāṣī*) that cannot persist. Likewise, true human maturity is marked by the ability to experience a similar kind of arousal in which when confronted by a member of the *human* opposite sex—human here meaning the ability to speak and to reason using the letters that make up the eternal Words—an individual becomes capable of experiencing pleasure, by which process a true human being is born, possessed of eternal life (*ḥayāt-i abadī*). As a great man would say,

If you listen you will live forever
if not, my breath will return to me

Furthermore, just as [the onset of] physical maturity is accompanied by certain signs, e.g., a strong urge and sex drive with regard to one's mate (*muqābil*) and thinking constantly of the pleasure to be had with her, so too is [the onset of] true human maturity signaled by the urge to be conjoined (*ittiṣāl*) with one's human spouse and thinking constantly of the pleasure to be had with her.

Now my purpose in citing this example here is twofold: First, to demonstrate that an immature person is incapable of comprehending the science of letters; a prepubescent youth (*nā-rasīda*) must first acquire the human virtue of manliness (*mardī, rujūliyyat*), called chivalry (*futuvvat*) by the Sufis, so he may discover the pleasure to be had with a spouse and not remain barred from entering the showroom of beauties where the brides of the marriage chamber of eternity—that is, the unjoined differentiating letters (*ḥurūf-i muqaṭṭaʿāt furqānī*)—are paraded.

If you be a man, plant your foot firmly; if not,
abstainers (*zāhid*) aren't admired on this path

Second, the objective of the science of letters having been thusly defined, it is abundantly clear from the foregoing that in this polluted bazaar which operates with the currency of physical existence it is nevertheless possible to anyone whose capital of resolve is equal to the purchase to carry away from his transaction eternal life.

¹⁴ *Arqām-i aqmār inshiqāq-i sayyidī*.

¹⁵ Lit., the newrisen ones of the age.

The dignity of love is great—show some resolve, Hafez!
for lovers don't admit the irresolute to their ranks¹⁶

Epilogue

I close this treatise with mention of several reports from the righteous forebears (*salaf*) that support the points made above, for the Imams from the House of the Prophet (*a'imma-yi ahl-i bayt*) and the servants of the household of prophecy (*khādimān-i khānavāda-yi nubuvvat*) (God's good pleasure be upon them all), who constitute the pillars of the edifice of wisdom and gnosis, have left a number of traces upon the pages of time; each of these is considered by the intelligent to be a sign (*āya*) proving the validity of this noble science [of letters] and indicating the rightness of its abovementioned objective, to wit, investigation into everything in the cosmos, both universals and particulars, and their categorization (*tarattub*) by means of this science. However, to restate the foregoing in terms that beginners (*mustarshidān*) can understand it is necessary to reference several instances in this connection.

An instance is cited by al-Tha'ālibī who reports that when the holy verse ḤM 'SQ (Q 42:1-2) was revealed the Prophet appeared to be overcome by exhaustion. A group of Companions who were with him at the time asked 'Alī b. Abī Tālib, governor of the realm of sanctified power (*valāya/vilāya*) and intimate in the harem of mysteries, what untoward event had produced this exhaustion in the Prophet's blessed constitution. After looking into the matter 'Alī informed them that it was on account of the verse which had just been revealed, "for it indicates that the Prophet's noble community will after the expiration of the period of guidance treat his exalted family most improperly (*bī adabī*)."

A second instance is given in the chronicles of the House of the Prophet to the effect that during the reign of al-Ma'mūn, the crown jewel in the necklace of the 'Abbasid line, due to the advancement of the charge of his fortune and the superiority of the stallion of his resolve the caliph was honored to receive audience (*pāy-būs*) with Imam 'Alī b. Mūsā al-Rizā, that fresh bud in the garden of divine good pleasure (*irtizā*) and firstfruit of the orchard of election (*iṣṭifā*); through the boon of his elixir-like attention the caliph escaped from the desert of exile and rejection to the city of nearness and acceptance and pledged his devotion and belief in him. Thus did a fragrance emanating from the garden of perfections that was the Imam beguile the nostrils of the caliph's soul through the grace of his company till that the intoxicating force of his longing moved him to action and the reins of self-restraint and control as dictated by the maxim *Kingship is childless*¹⁷ were wrested from his capable hands, this in a manner described by Ḥāfiẓ:

From your draught I've become drunk—enjoy it;
where have you gotten what's in your jar?¹⁸

—indeed, this became his anthem. In short, he requested from the Imam that an official letter of compact (*'ahdnāma*) be prepared by truthful pens to provide for his security, and with the throne of the caliphate and kingship irradiated with the Imam's magnificent presence he would stand at attention to serve him. The Imam, acting in accordance with the divine saying, *Obey*

¹⁶ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *sharāb-i bī-ghashsh u sāqī-yi khōsh dō dām-i rah-and*.

¹⁷ *Al-mulk 'aqīm*.

¹⁸ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *ṣabā tō nakhat-i ān zulf-i mushk-bū dārī*.

God and obey the Messenger and those in authority among you (Q 4:59), acceded to the caliph's request, and the compact was duly drawn up in a spirit of great affection. However, in the course of a subsequent meeting the Imam said [to the caliph], "The compact has been written, but there is no doubt that this caliphate [you propose for me] will come to nothing." Al-Ma'mūn asked him how he knew this, and he replied, "It is counterindicated in the *Jafr* and *Jāmi'*." They also say that at the head of the letter of compact this line was written: "I have written this in accordance with your desire, but the *Jafr* and *Jāmi'* indicate the contrary."

A third instance concerns Abū l-Āliya, one of the foremost Quran commentators, who conveyed from reliable transmitters the following statement: The unjoined letters (*muqatta'āt*) are letters of light which have been revealed at the beginning of certain quranic suras. A group of people asked the scholars the meaning of these letters; they answered that they contain knowledge of many things, and the rise and fall of [political] groups in particular.

Now my purpose in citing these instances is to give intelligent people to understand that although this science may not be much discussed [today] by the hidebound scholars (*rasm-jūyān*) of madrasa and khanaqah, the luminaries of previous generations, who endeavored to divest people of their musty observances and habits,¹⁹ have always praised it and held it in high regard. In short, these episodes have been recorded here solely for the benefit of those shortsighted individuals who inhabit the alley of caprice (*havas*), for those a quest on the highway of affliction (*dardmandī*) experience myriad ineffable pleasures from each delectable point touched on in this treatise as are beyond all compare.

If it is really wine from your cup that has made me drunk
then wine dupes drunks like a mirage

Peace be upon those who follow guidance. [This treatise] was completed on Sunday, 17 Dhū l-Qa'da 828 [30 September 1425].

¹⁹ *Khal'-i rusūm-i khalq u 'ādāt-i khalaq-i īshān karda.*

بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم وبه أستعين

حمد بی نهایت حضرت باری را که عین بصیرت آدمی جهت در یافتن کمال خاتمی منور و روشن گردانید و صلاة بی غایت نثار خاک پاک آن برگزیده که نامش محمد عربیست و عالم و عالمیان برای ظهور و شعور مرتبه او هویدا و دانا آفرید. اما بعد چون اشارت سعادت بشارت از صوب بارگاه گیتی پناه براننده تخت سلطنت و بختیاری فرازنده تاج عظمت و جهانداری شهباز اوج نصرت و تایید الهی شاهین هوای جهانبانی و پادشاهی المؤید بتایید الملک الذی یحکم و یأمر معز الدولة و الدنيا و الدین امیرزاده بایسنغر خلد الله سبحانه ملکه و سلطانه چنان رسید که رساله ای در علم حروف میباید که بفهم همگنان نزدیک باشد و از ایجاز در لفظ و اشکال در معنی دور، هر آینه امثال فرموده جهانمقطع را این سخنان مرقوم رقم اخلاص و هواداری گردانید و چون این علم شریف دو قسم واقع شده عملی که آن عبارت از معرفت خواص حروف و اسما خواهد بود و نظری که عبارت از شناختن ذوات حروف و دلالات هر یک بر اعیان و مراتب کائناتست، پس واجب نمود که این رساله منقسم بر دو قسم شود، اولاً هر آینه صورت نظم این سخنان مشتمل آمد بر مقدمه ای و دو وصل و خاتمه ای.

اما مقدمه

در بیان معنی حرف و دلیل بر اثبات خواص و حقایق آن

پوشیده نماید بر زیرکان جهان آفرینش و هوشمندان عالم دانش و بینش که هر جوهری که همان تحفه انبیا و رسل تواند بود از جناب جلال جهت بندگانی که در بیابان حیرت و ضلال متوجه حریم قربت و وصالند سزاواری مرتبه قبول در تیز بازار تمیز و حلقه سودای مدارک و قلوب همو را خواهد بود.

گر بدی گوهری و رای سخن آن فرودآمدی بجای سخن²

و دلیل بزرگی مرتبه سخن و حشمت [مب ۱۷۴] بارگاه جلال حروف منزله قدسی هم از روی نقل و فنون آثار و هم از طریق عقل و صنوف انظارش فراوانست. اما اول چنانچه در صدر سورة بقره که سنام کلام منزلست آمده که ﴿وَالَّذِينَ يُؤْمِنُونَ﴾ [۵-۲:۴]، و همچنین در غیر

¹ ما = مجلس ۱۰۱۹۶ ص ۱۱۷۲-۱۱۷۸ ب؛ مب = مجلس ۱۰۰۰۴ ص ۱۷۳-۲۰۳.

² هلالی جغتائی، شاه و درویش، بخش ۷ (تعریف کلام فصیح و شعر).

این از آیات چنانچه قوله تعالی ﴿قَدْ جَاءَكُمْ بَصَائِرُ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ فَمَنْ أَبْصَرَ فَلِنَفْسِهِ وَمَنْ عَمِيَ فَعَلَيْهَا وَمَا أَنَا عَلَيْكُمْ بِحَفِظٍ﴾ [۶:۱۰۴]، وقوله تعالی ﴿اتَّبِعُوا مَا أُنْزِلَ إِلَيْكُمْ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ وَلَا تَتَّبِعُوا مِنْ دُونِهِ أَوْلِيَاءَ قَلِيلًا مَّا تَذَكَّرُونَ﴾ [۷:۳]. و هر که را چشم بصیرت از عمش تقلیدات عادی سلیمست داند که سایر سور قرآنی مشحون بدین معنیست و از احادیث نبوی نیز آنچه دلالت بدین میکند هم بسیارست و از آثار صحابه و تابعین و سلف همین سبیل. اولا آنجا که حضرت رسالت میفرماید (أنزل القرآن على سبعة أحرف كلها كافٍ شافٍ)، و همچنین آمده که (يا علي ويل للعالم لا يعرف تفسير أبي جاد؛ الألف من اسم الله الذي هو الله، الباء من اسم الله الذي هو الباري، والجيم من اسم الله الذي هو الجليل)، و قال ابن عباس (إن علياً رضي الله عنه يعرف الفتن من لحم عسق) [۱: ۴۲-۲]، و ذكر القشيري و الثعلبي في تفسيرهما أن (الني صلى الله عليه وسلم لما نزلت هذه الآية عُرف الكتابة في وجهه فقبل يا رسول الله ما أحزنك؟ قال أُخبرْتُ ببلايا تنزل بأمتي من خسف و قذف و نار يحشرهم إلى البر و ربح يقذفهم إلى البحر و رايات متتابعة عند نزول عيسى و خروج الدجال). و چون غرض از ایراد این کلمات آنست تا دلیل شود بر اهل جدال و عناد بهمان عبارت عربی انساب نمود آوردن تا میامن انفاس عیسوی مواد عناد از باطن ایشان دور گرداند.

بی سخنهای تو قلب دل زر نشود گیای سخن از درج دهان بیرون آر^۳

و همچنین آمده است که (سؤال کردند از حسین علی رضی الله عنهما که معنی ﴿کهیص﴾ [۱۹:۱] چیست؟ فرمود که اگر معنی این آیت بیان کنم از برای تو بر روی آب بروی). و همچنین سایر سلف از ائمه کبار و مجتهدان صاحب اقتدار بر این رفته اند که حروف قدیمیست و هر کس که بحدوث حروف قایل شده ایشان [مب ۱۷۵] تکفیر فرموده اند [ما ۱۷۲ب] و این از آنست که آثار حضرت رسالت را پاک از شوایب زمان و صافی از قاذورات حدثان دریافته اند چه سخنان قدسی نشانش بهمان طراوت ذاتی و نضارت ازلی خود بدیشان رسیده و آنها که بعد از ایشان بمذتهای مدید در رسیدند و آن سخنان را خالص از غبار آثار هر زمان و هر زبان نیافتند کمال آن صورت در نظر ادراک ایشان نیامد و متوجه طرفی دیگر گشتند.

صوفی اگر آن روی نبیند بگذارش کان مرغ ندانست که انجیر چه باشد؟^۴

چون زیرک از این کلمات فهم بزرگی حروف و کمال مرتبه کلام کرد هر آینه شروع در بیان قسمین این علم را وقت آمد. بایاد دانست که همچنانچه سنگها که در هر معدنی ظاهر میشود و گیاهها که در هر زمینی میروید از خاصیتی خالی نیست چنانچه در معالجات محسوس و مشاهد میگردد، همچنین این جوهر حروف که بعینها از جناب جلال و حضرت قدس که منبع قوت و تاثیرست بدین جهمان آمیزش و آرایش فرستاده شد باید که از مثل آن خواص خالی نباشد، و هوشمندان کوی بیداری و هوشیاری را درین سخن شکی نخواهد بود اگر چه سرگشتگان بیابان عادت و سودائیان بازار ریا و رعونت را توقفی شود چه ایشان داخل اهل خطاب نیستند.

سخن درست و تعلق بگوش شه دارد

^۳ اوحدی مراغه ای، ترکیب (در آرزوی کعبه و زیارت مرقد رسول).

^۴ اوحدی مراغه ای، غزل (با عارض و زلفت قمر و قیر چه باشد).

و قسم عملی این علم آنست که بحث از این خواص کند و قسمی دیگر علميست و بیانش آنست که علمی چند هست که بنیاد ایمان مؤمن بر آن میتواند بود چنانچه تصدیق یگانگی باری تعالی و باور داشتن رسول او بهر چه خبر داده بتخصیص روز آخر، و معرفت آن علمها را راهی چند هست راست ترین و نزدیک ترین همه این راهست که حروف منزله آسمانی بدان دلالت میکند چنانچه فحواى فرموده ﴿هُدًى لِّلْمُتَّقِينَ﴾ [۲:۲] از آن نشان داده.

رهروان را همین نشان کافيست

و قسم علمی این فن آنست که بحث از چگونگی دلالت حروف برین علمها کند و راههای آن و از نصوص آیات قرآنی آنچه بدین معنی دلالت میکند و بتحقیق قسمین مفصح و گویاست یکی آنجاست که میفرماید قوله تعالی ﴿وَنُزِّلُ مِنَ الْقُرْآنِ مَا هُوَ شِفَاءٌ وَرَحْمَةٌ لِّلْمُؤْمِنِينَ﴾ [۱۷:۸۲]، [مب۱۷۶] چه زبان ظاهر این آیه کریمه بروشن ترین عبارتی گویاست بدین که فرود آمده است از قرآن عظیم دو فایده کریمند که آن دو رکنست از ارکان بنیان کمال انسان و بی تمهید آن معنی کمال صورت تحقق نتواند^۵ پذیرفت یکی آنست که شفای بدن واقع گشته یعنی اگر مزاج که بمنزله مرکب این راهست که بسر حد کمال می رود از منبج اعتدال منحرف گردد و صورت جسمانی او یا بنیه روحانیش از کار باز ماند و هیکل قویمش از صلاحیت برداشتن بار و بریدن راه عاجز گردد این حروف قرآنی از شربتخانه لطایف رحمانی او را بنهج اعتدال باز آرد و قوت او را بقرار اصل خودش رسانند.

عیسی دمست یار مرا پیش او بکش و آن دم نگاه کن که دم او چه میکند^۶

پس باید که هر خاصیتی که در سایر اشربه و ادویه و معاجین یافت شود در طی این حروف قرآنی و جواهر قدیمه آسمانی باشد به بهتر و جهی و اگر کسی را در این معنی توقفی باشد میباید که داند که از ممر قصوربست که او را در باور داشتن معانی قرآنی و وصول بمدارج ایمانی شده.

بدست کوته از این شاخ بر نشاید چید قدم بلند نه و دست همت اندر یاز
چو حلقه بر در این آستانه سر میزن مگر که بار دهندت درون پرده راز^۷

و یکی دیگر از آن دو رکن بنیان کمالی که از حروف قرآنی فرود آمده و ظاهر گشته آنست که چون مزاج مستغنی از علاج باشد و قوای ظاهر و باطنش بقوایم اعتدال ثابت و راسخ فیض رحمت رحمانی در اکواب اسباب و آلات جسمانی زلالی افضال را بکام مرام او میرساند، اولاً تا از مهاوی نقصان و خذلان شیطانی ترقی نموده بمدارج معارج وجودی و کمال انسانی فیروز گردد و استعداد آن پیدا کند که از دست ساقی رحمت رحیمی رحيق تحقیق علمی و عوارف معارف الهی که در ظروف حروف ازلی و قصاع اوضاع اصلی میرسد تناول تواند نمود تا بمیامن تتالی و تداول آن تناول از درکات بعد و محامه تفرقه بدرجات قرب و حریم جمعیت راه یابد. پس روشن گشت بر طالب هوشمند که در این آیه کریم از هر دو قسم این علم بیانی شافی فرموده. [مب۱۷۷]

^۵ مب: تواند.

^۶ اوحدی مراغه ای، غزل (صبری کنیم تا ستم او چه میکند).

^۷ اوحدی مراغه ای، قصیده (میان کار فروبند و کار راه بساز).

بر گرفتست از این جمال نقاب هر که را چشم نور بین شد

وصل اوّل

در بیان خواصّ حروف و چگونگی انتفاع از جواهر کرمه آن

بباید دانست اوّلا که علو مرتبه حرف اقتضای آن میکند که انتفاع از او مخصوص بدفع آلام جسمانی نباشد و علاج مرضی که ظاهر مزاج را واقع شود بلکه همچنانچه [۱۱۷۳ا] امرجه جسمانی سالک را از عوایق عروج بر مراقی اعتدال انسانی حمایت میکند همچنین هیکل شخصی او را از موانع ترقی بر مدارج رتبی که قبله توجه او باشد نگاه میدارد خواه مراتب جاهی و مالی دنیوی و خواه مقامات و منازل اخروی چه جای این که صورت حقیقت او را مطلقا از ابتدای نشأت ازلیه تا انتهای وصول بمقاصد ابدیه از مصادمات اضداد و مقابلات انداد محافظت نموده هر لمحّه بتمهید اسباب امداد و تهیّه آلات اعداد که آن وقت را ضرورتست قیام مینماید و خواهد نمود.

گدائی در این خانه طرفه اکسیرست گر این عمل بکنی خاک زر توانی کرد

و اگر کسی طلب دلیل نماید بر هر یک از این مقاصد بسیاری از احادیث نبوی و آثار مبارک ایشان هست که مؤمن را بدان اطمینان حاصل گردد چنانچه از صفای فهم آن دلایل خاشاک شک و شوک شبهات مشوشه را مجال دخل در خاطر او نخواهد ماند هر آینه واجب نمود که از مؤدای آن احادیث مبارک انموذجی که مناسب این مختصر تواند بود نموده شود.

اوّلا آنست که در سنن ابی داود و ترمذی علیها الرحمه آورده اند باسناد ابو سعید خدری رضی الله عنه که حضرت رسالت صلی الله علیه و سلم چندی از اصحاب را بسفری روانه فرموده بودند. در اثنای آن بختی از احیای عرب که گذارشان بر آن افتاده نزول کرده بودند بزرگ ایشان را مارزده بوده است و بهر چیزی توسّل نموده بوده اند و مفید نیامده و سیاحت فکر و تدبیر ایشان در این باب بسر حدّ یاس و نا امیدی رسیده یکی از ایشان گفته است که اگر بنزدیک این جماعت رویم و استفسار نمایم شاید که نزد ایشان چیزی باشد که سبب خلاص گردد. چون آمدند و پرسیدند یکی از صحابه گفت که من رُقیّه خلاص او میدانم و لیکن بخت شما آمدیم و طلب [مب ۱۷۸] ضیافت کردیم و کسی از شما بقبول آن تلقی نمود تا مُردی و جُعلی معین کنی آن میسر شود. القصّه بقطیعی از گوسفند صلح کردند که سی سر باشد و این صحابی برفت و فاتحه الکتاب بخواند و بر او دمید در حال آن شخص مارزده بر خاست بسلامت و ایشان آن قطیع گوسفند تسلیم اصحاب کردند خواستند که در محلّ قسمت آرند صاحب رُقیّه گفت تا بحضرت رسم چون بر آن حضرت عرض کردند فرمود که شما از کجا معلوم گردید که این فاتحه رُقیّه است و بعد از تحسین و تصویب آن حرکت لب مبارک بتبسم گشوده اند و طلب سهم خاصّه فرموده. در طی این کلمات مبارک بسی حکم درجست، هر کس که اشتباهی فهم دقایق حقایق داشته باشد از اشارات و عبارات آن حدیث از کتب صحاح تصفّح نماید.

و ثانیاً در صحیح بخاری و مسلم بروایت عایشه و ابو سعید خدری رضی الله عنهما آورده اند که هر گاه که حضرت رسالت را خستگی طاری شدی جبرئیل پیامدی و گفتی (بسم الله یُبریک و من کلّ داء یشفیک و من شرّ کلّ حاسد اذا حسد و من شرّ کلّ عین). و پوشیده نماند که شرّ حاسد و شرّ عین مخصوص بمرتبه مزاج جسمانی نخواهد بود چه در این حدیث مبارک تصریح بخاصّیت حروف در هر دو مرتبه فرموده اند بوجهی که جمال مطلوب بحجاب احتمال غیر این پوشیده نگردد چه فاعل (یُبریک و یشفیک) بغیر از ضمیر بسم الله چیزی دیگر نمیتواند بود، مگر ظاهر ترکیب را از حلیّه خود

بگرداند و التزام تقدیری و تاویلی نمایند تا مطابق معتقد تقلیدی ایشان تواند بود ادب آنست که سخن بهان نشان که از لب تحقیق طلب آنحضرت بیرون آمده در یابند ولیکن این را همتی باید.

بر آن لبی که شکر با حلاوتش شورست هزار ملک سلیمان بهای یک مورست

و اما ثالثاً هر کس که در ظاهر باهر آیه کریمه ﴿إِنَّمَا أَمْرُهُ إِذَا أَرَادَ شَيْئًا أَنْ يَقُولَ لَهُ كُنْ فَيَكُونُ﴾ [۳۶:۸۲] بنظر بصیرت تأمل نماید فهم کند که اعانت حرف در وجود هر مرتبه از مراتب کلی و مدارج جزئی بهر حال که باشد از فنون احوال و صنوف افعال ثابت و متحقق است و امداد او در هر باب شافی و کافیت حاجت زیادتی بیان نیست [مب ۱۷۹].

باز دانی که من چه میگویم گرت افتد گذر بعالم هوش^۸

پس روشن و متبیین گشت که استعانت بخواص حرف نمودن در این مراتب سه گانه مفید و منجج بوده، پس ضرورت شد که از برای هر یک بابی از سخن گشوده گردد.

باب اول

در بیان استعمال مزاج جسمانی

و دفع انحرافات که او را در انتهای طریق اعتدال حسی روی نماید، و تحقیق آن موقوف مقدمه ایست که پیشتر طالب متذکر آن گردد. و بیانش آنست که مبنای معالجت و دفع امراض و اسقام [ما ۱۷۳ب] بر معرفت طبایع اشیا و تبیین مراتب آن خواهد بود و خواص هر یک دانستن چنانچه جزو قرآدین کتب طبی از آن بحث کند چه هرگاه که این معانی روشن شود و بعد از آن این اصل حکمی بدان منضم گردد که دفع هر چیزی بمقابله و ضد آن صورت بندد چنانچه ظهور و بقایش [بمقارنه] مثل متحقق گردد، هو آینه عالم بدان متمکن گردد هم از دفع امراض که طاری میشود مزاج را و هم از محافظت مرتبه اعتدالی که قوام صحت آن مزاج بدان خواهد بود. هرگاه که این مقدمه روشن گشت بایست که چنانچه کسی در تحقیق معرفت طبایع ماهرتر باشد و تفصیل مراتب هر یک پیش او روشن تر قدرت او برین دو نوع از تصرف که دفع مرضست و حفظ صحت بیشتر خواهد بود. و شک نیست که ائمه طب باستعانت قوت نظری از تفصیل مرتبه طبایع چهارگانه بیش از چهار مرتبه از هر یک نتوانسته اند استخراج نمودن چنانچه پوشیده نخواهد بود بر واقف علم طب. فاما آنانی که بوسیله حروف منزله و معرفت مطابقه اسمای هر چیزی هر مستیانش در این مسلک شروع نموده اند ایشان را همین مراتب روشن گشته با درجه هر یک و دقایق هر درجه و همچنین ثانیه آن دقایق تا بخامسه رابعه اش استخراج کرده اند چه ایشان بنشان هدایت نشان فرموده (ویل لعالم جهل ابی جاد) از پی تحقیق آن ترتیب رفته اند و بر ایشان روشن گشته است که هر مرتبه از مراتب چهارگانه طبایع را هفت طبقه در آن ترتیب میتنست چنانچه بر تحقیق آن مطلع خواهی گشت ان شاء الله تعالی.

ورقی باز کردم از سخنش زیر هر توی آن سخن توپیست^۹

^۸ اوحدی مراغه ای، ترجیع (در خرابات عاشقان کوپیست).

^۹ اوحدی مراغه ای، ترجیع (در خرابات عاشقان کوپیست).

[مب ۱۸۰] این سخنها همت معرفت طبایع بود ولیکن نباید دانست که تاثیر اشیا از دو گونه است عرضی تبعی و جوهری ذاتی و تاثیری که ادویه و اغذیه را از ممر طبایع ظاهر میشود از قسم اولست چه تاثیر جوهری ذاتی آنست که از ممر خواص آنها ظاهر گردد و ایمنه نظر بر ائیت این نوع واقف گشته ولیکن در معرفت لمیت آن و بیان مبداء متحیر مانده اند و معترف بعجز و قصور شده چنانچه شیخ مشائیان ابن سینا بقوت ذکائی داشته در بیان خاصیت مغناطیس که چگونه جذب آهن میکند و همی چند واهی گفته و در آخر عذر قصور خود نموده.

جایی که نشان بی نشانست آنجا انگشت عقول در دهانست آنجا¹⁰

غرض که معرفت این نوع تاثیر خود مخصوص واقفان وجوه حرفی و عارفان زبان اشارات ایشانست بقانون نظر حاصلی از آن صورت نمیندند چه تحقیق آن مبتنی بر علوم نیست که کاشف میبوده است از نسب مقداری و بیشتر آن علوم در این زمان مندرس گشته و اندکی که مانده هم ابنای زمان از تحصیل آن قاصرست، و بعد از آن نیز احتیاج باصولی چندست که وجوه ارتباطی که میان آن نسب کثیره و وحدت اصلی ذاتیست روشن گردد بتفصیلهای و این اصول در این زمانها اگر چه والهان کوی محبت و واصلان مقاصد معرفت از جلال اجمال آن وقوفی یافته اند، چنانچه شاعر را اتفاق افتاده:

گر چه در زلف تست جای دلم دایما در دل خرابت منی
تا بدانی که از لطافت خویش هم تو در بند زلف خویشتنی

ولیکن بر فیصل تفصیل آن که مثل این مقاصد مبتنی بر آن خواهد بود کمتر واقف شده اند و اگر شده اند ظاهر نکرده اند مگر جمعی از تلامذه امام صدق که در طی تصانیف برموز مغلق در ابواب مقفل تحقیق آن را متعرض گشته اند.

وَأَبْوَابُهَا عَنْ قَرْعٍ مِثْلَكَ سَدَّتِ¹¹

ولیکن امید واثقست که در این زمان سعادت قران بمیامن پرتو انوار حروف قرآنی و اقمار ارقامش که باشارت اصابع ختمی انشقاق پذیرفته بسی از آن علوم بیرون آید و بر همگنان بی زحمت استحصال این نوع مقدمات علمی روشن و متبیین گردد [مب ۱۸۱].

نهفته معنی نازک بسیست در خط یار تو فهم آن نکنی ای ادیب من دانم¹²

حاصل از تقریب این تشبیب آنکه حقیقت علم طب و کماهی احکام و مسایلش از این زبان فهم میتواند شد، چنانچه در وصل ثانی شمه ای از بیان آن بیاید آنچه در کتب منسوب بدین علم مزبور گشته رسوم و اطلال آن بیش نیست.

أَمَّا الْخِيَامُ فَإِنَّهَا كَخِيَامِهِمْ وَأَرَى نِسَاءَ الْحَيِّ غَيْرَ نِسَائِهَا¹³

¹⁰ کمال الدین اسماعیل اصفهانی.

¹¹ بیت ۹۱ از تائیه ابن فارض، اولش (أَتَيْتُ بُيُوتًا لَمْ تُنَلَّ مِنْ طُحُورِهَا).

¹² کمال خجندی.

¹³ بیت از ابو الحسن الفالی (د ۴۴۸).

این سخنان رابطه مناسب حکم کرده که در سلک بیان آید. آمدیم بر سر آنچه در مقاصد فتح این باب دخل دارد چون معلوم گشت که بنای معالجه امزجه جسمانی بر معرفت طبایع اشیاست تا استخراج اضرار امراض نمایند و بوسیله دخل آن در مزاج مریض دفع آن مرض کنند، بیاید دانست که طبایع حروف از این ترتیب مشار الیه که نشان داده شده فهم میشود بتفصیل درجاتها و دقایق احکامها، چنانچه هفت از این حروف سبع المثانی بطبیعت حرارت و ییوست مخصوصند و هفت بطبیعت برودت و ییوست [ما ۱۷۲] و هفت بحرارت و رطوبت و هفت ببرودت و رطوبت، و بیان تحقیق این ترتیب وضعی اشعاری و جهت تخلفی که او را با ترتیب طبیعی ظهوری هست در غیر این مجال صورت پذیرد و در طی ترتیب ای جاد این مراتب نموده شده، چنانچه هفت اول که عبارت از صاحب حرارت و ییوستست **ا ه ط م ف ش ذ** باشد، و از آن دوم که صاحب برودت و ییوست **ب و ی ن ص ت ض**، و از آن سوم که صاحب حرارت و رطوبتست **ج ز ک س ق ث ظ**، و از آن چهارم که صاحب برودت و رطوبتست **د ح ل ع ر خ غ**. پس هرگاه که مرض از غلبه برودت باشد بحروف **ح ا ژ** توسل جویند که البته تسکین آن ماده کرده شود، و اگر از غلبه حرارت بود بحروف **بارده**، و لهذا هرگاه که در امراض **ح ا ژ** هشت ^{۱۴} ح را بطریقی مخصوص مینهند و بدان توسل میجویند البته تسکین تمام میکند و هیجان آن ماده را دفعی بین میبشد. این وضع کیانی در سنه احدی عشر و ثمانیاه [۸۱۱ هـ] و بای عظیم در صوب عراق افتاده بود و هر که را توفیق توسل بدان صورت دست داد اتفاقا خلاص او مقدر بود [مب ۱۸۲] و بدان میسر گشت، چه جای آنکه در هر موضع که این وضع نهاده بود اثری ظاهر در سگان آنجا از تسکین آن ماده واقع شد و طریق توسل بحروف بسیارست اتم طرق در معالجه جسمانیات خواندن و دهندنست، چنانچه از السنه سته فهم گشت و آن در صورت کلامی حرف متحقق میتواند شد که مسلک انبیا بر آن صوب واقعست و تاثیر این صورت اگر چه بیشتر میباشد ولیکن بواسطه عدم استقرار و سرعت زوال در صدد تغیر و تبدل میباشد مگر بواسطه خاصیت اصل که انفاص کمل را تواند بود قرار آن تاثیر صورت تواند بست و از اینجاست که در صحاح آورده بروایت عائشه رضی الله عنها (کان رسول الله إذا مَرَضَ أَحَدٌ مِنْ أَهْلِهِ نَفَثَ عَلَيْهِ بِالْمَعُودَاتِ فَلَمَّا مَرَضَ الْمَرْضُ عَلَيْهِ جَعَلْتُ أَنْفَ عَلَيْهِ وَأَمْسَحُهُ بِيَدِي لِأَنَّهَا كَانَتْ أَعْظَمَ بَرَكَةً مِنْ يَدِي).^{۱۵}

و **طریق دیگر** توسل بصورت کتابی حرفست و این صورت مخصوص بقوام اوضاع و دوام آثارست، و نزدیکترین وجوه در توسل بدین صورت آنست که مشاعر و جوارح شخص متلبس باوضاع منزله آن حروف گردد، چنانچه خیال بتخیل ایشان مشغول باشد و بصر باحساس آن و دست بکتابت ارقامش، و این جمعیت قوی بسیار مفید میباشد در تاثیر حروف ولیکن وقتی که عقیده خالصه منظم بدن گردد و اگر عقیده مشوب باشد باحتالات وهمی و توهّمات عادی رسمی هیچ فایده بر آن صورت نبندد. بزرگی در این باب آورده که در زمانی که عیسی علیه السلام بواسطه مقابله اشرار و هجوم اضراد یهود متوجه طرف بحر گشت با جمعی از حواریان. یکی از ایشان متخلف شده بود و در وقتی رسید که کشتی روان گشته بود و از ساحل قدری دور شده. فریاد (خذ بی معک) بگوش باهوش آنحضرت رسانید، اشارت فرمود که (بیا). آن حواری بی توقّف و تعلل روان گشت و کامی چند بر روی آب بیامن استغراق که در اشارت روحی داشت بیآمد. ناگاه بخود آمد و خود را بجوارح و مشاعر جزئی خود مشاهده نمود و رقیقه آن جمعیت از دست حقیقت او برفت، در حال فرو رفت و باستعانت و استغاثت یاران بکشتی [مب ۱۸۳] در آمد، فرمودند که بدین مایه قوت چرا روان میشدی؟

^{۱۴} ما: حاذّه.

^{۱۵} صحیح مسلم، کتاب السلام، باب رقیه المریض بالمعوذات والنّفث (۵۸۴۳): حَدَّثَنِي شَرِيعُ بْنُ يُونُسَ وَيَحْيَى بْنُ أَيُّوبَ قَالَ حَدَّثَنَا عُبَادُ بْنُ عَبَّادٍ عَنْ هِشَامِ بْنِ غَزْوَةَ عَنْ أَبِيهِ عَنْ عَائِشَةَ قَالَتْ كَانَ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ إِذَا مَرَضَ أَحَدٌ مِنْ أَهْلِهِ نَفَثَ عَلَيْهِ بِالْمَعُودَاتِ فَلَمَّا مَرَضَ الْمَرْضُ عَلَيْهِ جَعَلْتُ أَنْفَ عَلَيْهِ وَأَمْسَحُهُ بِيَدِي نَفْسَهُ لِأَنَّهَا كَانَتْ أَعْظَمَ بَرَكَةً مِنْ يَدِي. وَفِي رِوَايَةٍ يَحْيَى بْنُ أَيُّوبَ بِمَعُودَاتٍ.

غرض از ایراد این حکایت آنست که توسل بمعالجات خصوصا این نوع که تاثیر آن منوط برقیقه روحانیتست بی آنکه عقیده مستحکم باشد و از شوایب وهن وهی و خلل خیالی محفوظ و محروس فایده ای بر آن مترتب نگردد.

کجا ینالّه زار تو گوش دارد شب که تا سحر زعم دیگری بفریادی
اگر بسان قلم سر نمینهی بر خط بهوش باش که خاطر هنوز نهادی

و جمعی بشُستنِ آن صورتها و آشامیدنِ توسل جسته اند ولیکن اصلی بر آن از دلایل سنت نیافت بلی بمجّرد قرب آن صورت شریقه آثار و میامن بسیار توقع میتوان داشت، و همین که در منزلی باشد تاثیر آن بنسبت با اهل اخلاص کافیت بشرط آنکه رقیقه اصلاص را برابطه حسن متابعت مستحکم و مستوثق گردانیده باشند.

گر تو در آبی ز پی کاروان زود باواز در آبی رسی
خواجه ترا چون ز غلامان شمرد گر نگریزی بیبایی رسی¹⁶

و طریقی دیگر در توسل بصور حرفی آنست که اوضاع نسب عددی را متوجه گردد و قوّت تاثیر این صورت از همه صور حرفی شهر و اظهارست، چنانچه وفق سه در سه جهت استخلاص از غوایل اجته و هر چه بدان ماند، و این طریق مسلک معهود قدماست و از ایشان در این باب رسایل و تصانیف بسیار باشد و بسی مردم بدان مشغول شوند ولیکن چون از شرایطی که خصوصیت این زمان حکم بدان کرده غافل و ذاهلند اثری کما ینبغی بر آن مترتب نمیگردد [ما ۱۷۴ب] و زیادتی بسط این سخن بعد از این میآید ان شاء الله وحده العزیز.

باب دوم در معالجت هیأت شخصی رتبی

و دفع انحرافی که از مقابله اضداد آن مرتبه بر آن طاری میگردد تا بمنتهای همت در مرتبه صورت و مراقب مال و جاه که همان صورت تمامی اعتدالیش خواهد بود برسد، و اکثر مردم که متوجه خواص حرفند طالب همین اثر میباشند و طریق توسل بصور سه گانه حرفی همانست که بیان کرده شد، ولیکن در جمع کردن نسب عددی لبابی با صورت کلامی و کتابی در این باب اثری بین دارد، چنانچه ارباب [مب ۱۸۴] تجربه آن را فهم کرده باشند. یکی از ائمه این فن آورده است که درویشی در بلاد غرب بگوشه مسجدی رفت و روی همت بقبله ای توجه کرد و زبان اخلاص بذکر (یا غنی) بگشود، و همین که نظم توجه و اخلاص او بی انحراف آن بدخلِ خاطری مشوّش بعقد هزار و هفتاد و یک رسید، گوشه ای از آن مسجد فرود آمد او از غایت دهشت و وحشت بدان طرف دوید صرّه هزار مثقال زر که در آن گوشه مکنون بوده بود در میان گلهای که فرود آمده بود بیافت این صورت در ترقی رتبی مالی و از آن جاهی بسیارست، چنانچه در آثار نبوی واردست که در آن باب استعانت بصور کلامی نموده اند چه در بعضی غزوات تلقین صحابه کرام فرموده اند که ﴿(ح)﴾ [۴۰:۱] لا ینصرون¹⁷ گویند،

¹⁶ اوحدی مراغه ای، غزل (محمد بکن تا که به جایی رسی).

¹⁷ سنن ابی داود، کتاب الجهاد «باب فی الرجل ینادی بالشعار (۲۵۹۹)؛ سنن ترمذی، کتاب الجهاد، باب ما جاء فی الشعار (۱۷۸۳): حَدَّثَنَا مُحَمَّدُ بْنُ غِيلَانَ حَدَّثَنَا وَكِيعٌ حَدَّثَنَا سُفْيَانُ عَنْ أَبِي إِسْحَاقَ عَنِ الْمُهَلَّبِ بْنِ أَبِي صَفْرَةَ عَنْ سَعْدِ بْنِ أَبِي هُرَيْرَةَ عَنْ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ يَقُولُ «إِنَّ بَيْنَكُمْ الْعَدُوَّ فَقُولُوا (ح) لَا يُبْصِرُونَ».

و همچنین در روز بدر که کواکب مواکب لشکر اسلام در آن روز از مطلع ظفر سر بر زد و منابر نبوت بتیغ ایالت و سلطنت بلند پایه گشت انہزام لشکر مخالف بتکرار لفظ (شاهت الوجوه)¹⁸ فرمود دادن و برمی سهام این صور کلامی که گشاد از کمان حرکت انقباضی و انبساطی نفس انسان یافته دشمن را دور کرده غالب آمد. و در زمان ملوک فرس که کاوہ آہنگر خروج کرد ہم باستعانت صور لبابی و ارقام آن بود، و حکایت این قصہ آنست کہ کاوہ را با یکی از حکمای زمان خود عقیدہ راسخ بود و در زمان فقد اولاد چون طمع در دیگری کردہ بودند از غایت تفجع و تضرع نزد آن حکیم رفت او از غلبہ حکم ترخم و رقت باطن بوضع اوضاع وفقی مشغول بود و تجربہ خواص آن را واقف گفت اگر ترا قوت آن باشد کہ این وضع را در انبان آہنگری خود نہی و بر جویی کنی و بر داری چندان مردم بر تو جمع شوند کہ دفع ضحاک را آمادہ و مستعد گردہ و او از تو رو گردان شود کاوہ از سر عقیدہ درست کہ داشت و توجہی کامل چنان کرد و آن کار بدو تمام شد و فریدون را بنشانند، و آن وضع را ملوک فرس درفش کاویانی نام کردند و بتعظیم و احترام آن مشغول شدند و ہر کس از ایشان کہ بر تخت سلطنت مینشست عقدی از نفایس جواهر ضمیمہ آن میساخت و قریب [مب ۱۸۵] دو ہزار سال کہ علم سلطنت در خانوادہ فرس افراشتہ بود این درفش بدست اولاد و اقربای کاوہ میبود. در تاریخ نصاری آورده اند کہ در زمان عمر خطاب رضی اللہ عنہ کہ لشکر اسلام را بصوب فتح مدائن روانہ کرد یزدجرد رستم ذو الحاجین را با لشکری کران از جہت مقابلہ و دفع آن پیش فرستاد و معہود از آثار و اوضاع آن درفش کاویانی چنان بودہ است کہ لشکر مخالف چنانچہ صورت آن را دیدندی منہزم گشتندی در این نوبت خلاف آن ظاہر گشت کہ لشکر عرب دلیر میآمدند و نزدیک میشد کہ درفش را باز ستانند بجانب یزدجرد باز نمودند کہ خللی بدین اوضاع درفش همانا راہ یافتہ کہ اثری کہ پیشتر از او ظاہر میشد. این زمان نیست جمعی از حکما کہ بدین اوضاع و علوم آن واقف بودند حکم شد کہ بروند و احتیاط آن ارقام و اوضاعش بکنند و اگر خللی پذیرفتہ باشد تدارک نمایند ایشان بعد از احتیاط بسیار خللی نیافتند یکی از آن حکیمان بقوت حدس گمان برد کہ مگر نزد عرب وضعی دیگر ہست کہ مقابلہ با این وضع میکند و سبب بطلان آثارش میشود. جمعی از اعراب کہ در حین مقابلہ بقید اسار گرفتار شدہ بودند حاضر کردند و از ایشان استفسار نمودند کہ این بزرگ شما هیچ صورتی از اعداد و اوضاع آن ہمراہ دارد. گفتند نہ در میان قوم ما ہفدہ رکعت نماز در پنج وقت از ساعت شبانروزی واجبست کہ کاینما من کان بہر حال کہ باشد این بجای؟؟ آرد و ہر کہ تخلف نماید البتہ بکشند و در هیچ حکمی این اہتمام نمینایند کہ در این حکما با ہم مطارحہ کردند در این معنی و بر ہمگان روشن شد بعد از قیاح زند فکر و لمعان نور نظر کہ درفش وضعی عددیست کہ حکما بقوت فکر خود ترتیب نمودہ اند و رقوم آن را بر سر این جوب کردہ چندین سال اثر او ظاہر شد این شخص نیز کہ بزرگ عربست وضعی عددی تعبیر نمودہ کہ صورت آن لا یزال ظاہر میشود در مرتبہ فعل انسانی کہ اجلای مراتبست از روی ظہور و اقوی از جہت سرعت تاثیر و آنگاہ بنسبت با ہر شخصی از این [ما ۱۱۷۵] جم غفیر کہ در ہر لحظہ بادای آن قیام نمایند، شک نیست کہ این وضع عددی متجدد متکثر ناسخ آن وضع عددی رقمی [مب ۱۸۶] خواہد بود کہ انقراض زمان کرد نقص و فتور بر صفحات احکام آن نشانندہ است.

تا بگلزار جہان قتر بلندت برخاست ہر نہالی کہ نشانند بہستان نشست

¹⁸ صحیح مسلم، کتاب الجہاد والسير، باب فی غزوہ حنین (۴۷۱۹): وَحَدَّثَنَا زَيْدُ بْنُ حَرْبٍ حَدَّثَنَا عُمَرُ بْنُ يُونُسَ الْحَضَنِيُّ حَدَّثَنَا عِكْرَمَةُ بْنُ عَمَّارٍ حَدَّثَنَا إِبْرَاهِيمُ بْنُ سَلَمَةَ حَدَّثَنَا أَبِي قَالَ قَالَ عَزْرَتَا مَعَ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ حَتَّى نَلَّحْنَا وَاجِهَتَا الْعَدُوَّ تَقَدَّمَتْ فَأَعْلَوْا نَبِيَّةً فَأَسْتَقْبَلَنِي رَجُلٌ مِنَ الْعَدُوِّ فَأَرْمَاهُ بِسَهْمٍ فَتَوَارَى عَنِّي فَمَا دَرَيْتُ مَا صَنَعَ وَتَنَزَّلْتُ إِلَى الْقَوْمِ فَإِذَا هُمْ قَدْ طَلَعُوا مِنْ نَبِيَّةٍ أُخْرَى فَالْتَقَوْا هُمْ وَصَحَابَةُ النَّبِيِّ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ فَقُلْتُ صَحَابَةُ النَّبِيِّ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ وَأَرْجِعْ مُنْزِمًا وَعَلَى بُرْدَتَانِ مُتَرَا بِإِخَائِهْمَا مُزْتَدِيًا بِالْأُخْرَى فَاسْتَطَلَقَ لِزَارِي فَجَمَعْتُهُمَا جَمِيعًا وَمَزَزْتُ عَلَى رَسُولِ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ مُنْزِمًا وَهُوَ عَلَى بَغْلِيَةِ الشَّهْبَاءِ فَقَالَ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ «لَقَدْ رَأَى ابْنُ الْأَكْوَعِ قَرَعًا». فَلَمَّا عَشَوْا رَسُولُ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ نَزَلَ عَنِ الْبَغْلَةِ ثُمَّ قَبَضَ قَبْضَةً مِنْ ثَرَابٍ مِنَ الْأَرْضِ ثُمَّ اسْتَقْبَلَ بِهِ وَجُوهَهُمْ فَقَالَ «شَاهَتِ الْوُجُوهَ». «فَمَا خَلَقَ اللَّهُ مِنْهُمْ إِنْسَانًا إِلَّا مَلَأَ عَيْنَيْهِ ثَرَابًا بِتِلْكَ الْقَبْضَةِ فَوَلَّوْا مُدْبِرِينَ فَهَرَمَهُمُ اللَّهُ عَزَّ وَجَلَّ وَقَسَمَ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ غَنَائِمَهُمْ بَيْنَ الْمُسْلِمِينَ.

پوشیده نماند که هرگاه که ارقام وفقی که از تحت قلم افهام بشری بر صحایف حدس و تجارب انسان نبشته شده بود این گونه اثر داشت در خانواده فرس اثر این ارقام الهی که از طی قلم ازل بر لوح وحی نگاشته شده در رفع رایات دولت عرب چه خواهد کرد.

جز با خط تو عشق نبازند عاشقان بر خط دیگران رقم عاشقانه نیست
دیوانه گشت خلق و بصحرا فتاد از آنکه در شهر بی حکایت تو هیچ خانه نیست

غرض از ایراد این حکایت آنکه طالب متیقظ را فهم شود که گاهی که این طایفه پیرتو نور علم چیزی از کمال حضرت رسالت که هنوز اشعه ظهورش عالم فرو نگرفته بود بمجرب آنکه نظر تفرس ایشان بر شیخ این بنیان وضع صلاة و اعداد رکعات و اوقاتش افتاد فهم کردند، اگر کسی را توفیق رفیق گردد که در مرافق این وضع الهی و بنیان شرعی دخل کند و بلطایف جواهر که در مخازن ارکان و ابعاض درجست از مفتوح تکبیر احرام تا مختتم تحیات و سلام تمتع یابد و بهره ور گردد از کمال حکمت محمدی صلوات الله و سلامه علیه شمه ای بمشام مشاعر و افهام او رسیده در سلک امت خاص او در آید و بمیامن این قرابت و سهام وراثت کمالش فایز گردد، زهار زین دین را بر اسب همت میباید نهاد و بتنگ و زرتنگ خلوص و اخلاص محکم کرد و پای سعی در رکاب آدایش ثابت و راسخ داشته متوجه صوب صواب این ابنیه ختمیه و اوضاع شرعیه شد و از این راه امید گشایش ابواب حکمت بست که درهای آن بر مشاعر ظاهر و باطن انسانی گشوده است اگر هر یکی را ای این جوارح حسی بخط خود مخصوص توانی داشت و این در قوت همت کم کسی باشد.

هزار جلوه اظهار میکند مقصود ولی چه سود که چشم امید ما کورست
فراز کنگره وصل کی توان رفتن که رشته کوتاه و بازوی بخت بی زورست

باب دوم در معالجه صورت حقیقی انسانی

و دفع انحرافی که این بنیه کمالی را طاری میگردد در طی مراتب استیداعی و استقراری [مب ۱۸۷] تا بمنتهای کمال اظهار و اشعاری خود رسد. بیاید دانست که غرض اصلی و غایت حقیقی حروف منزله همین خاصیت بوده آنها که پیشتر گذشت از این خواص بر سبیل تطفل و استطراد بود چه حکمت فرستادن حکیم علیم انبیا و رسل را و امری که باعث بر بعثت این قوم مبارکست همین هدایت بندگانش بود و شک نیست که این معنی وقتی صورت بندد که بر شارع شرعی که ایشان نموده اند ثابت و راسخ توانند بود و از آنجا انحراف نمایند و این شارع عبارت از طریق فعل و قول بنده است که بر چه نهج از او صادر گردد، چنانچه السنه کتاب و سنت و اجماع امت بدان ناطقست این زمان مقدمه دیگر ناگزیرست که تذکر نمایند تا فهم مقصود آسان گردد. افعال بنده از دو گونه است بعضی آنست که هم از ذات او چیزی هست که اقتضای صدور آن فعل میکند از او مانند افعال طبیعی و حیوانی و نفسانی چنانچه در جایش تحقیق تفصیل آن کرده شده، و بعضی دیگر آنست که سبب صدور آن نه اینهاست بلکه عقلست که صاحب حل و عقد در این بنیه انسانی اوست و او هر فعلی را که غایتی کمالی نیندیشد بصدور آن رخصت ندهد و این هر دو طرف متقابلند بهر طرفی که شخص میل نمود از طرفی دیگر دور شد. بعد از تذکر این مقدمه بیاید دانست که شارع شرعی محمدی در میان این طرفین واقعست و در هر طرف نوعی از مستلذات هست که میل شخص بدان میشود، تاره میل بطرف جسمانیات و استمتاع از انواع مطامع و مشارب و مناکح

میکند و تارۀ میل بروحانیات و اجتناب از استعمال جوارح و مشاعر و اشتغال بمسئلات انظار عقلی و ادواق حالی، و اول در مزاج این صورت حقیقی بمنزلۀ غذا میشود و ثانی بمنزلۀ شراب شارع ختمی که طیب حاذق اوست در تبیین شارع شرعی خود تمام نموده که از هر یک از این غذا و شراب چند میباید تناول نمود تا مزاج این صورت حنیفی انسانی از انحراف سالم ماند تا بمرتبه بلوغ حقیقی خود فایز تواند گشت و مستعدّ ابلاغ آن صور مرسلّ بها تواند شد که رسول مأمور بدان گشته چنانچه خفّای¹⁹ [مب ۱۸۸] فرموده امر ﴿بَلِّغْ﴾ [۵: ۶۷ و ...] و استفسار (هل بلغث)²⁰ در کتاب و سنت مفصح بدانست، غرض که صور شرعی که موضوع انبیاست بتخصیص اوضاع پسندیده خاتم الرسل [ما ۱۷۵ ب] صلوات الله و سلامه علیه امزجۀ اعیان عالم را سبب صحتست و موجب وصول بدرجۀ بلوغ و کمال، و با وجود این هر وضعی از آن رمز کنزی از جواهر معارف و حقایقست چنانچه در رسالۀ اسرار الصلاة شمه ای از آن نموده شده.

همچو گنجیست درین عالم ویران رخ دوست یاد آن گنج دوانید یویرانه مرا²¹

از صدای خفّای این کلمات مسترشد را معلوم گشت که صورت کلامی حروف و لبایش دخلی تمام در محافظت و تربیت صورت اصلی شخص دارد، و اما بیان دخل صورت کتابی در آن باب بر واقفان اشارات نبوی و حافظان اخبار و احادیث مصطفوی پوشیده نخواهد بود که اصول و قوانین کتاب و سنت چنان اقتضا میکند که اعیان کاینات بسایر افراد و اعداد از ابتدای نشأت و مراتب ابداع تا انتهای مقامات و مواطن معاد بی دستیاری حروف کتابی و اوضاع دعایی اجابت نشانش پای در دایره هیچ مرتبه از مراتب و مقامات نتواند نهاد، چنانچه از خفّای فرموده ختمی روشنست که در صحاح مثبت گشته از روایت ابی بن کعب و عبادۀ بن صامت که (أَوَّلُ مَا خَلَقَ اللَّهُ تَعَالَى الْقَلَمَ فَقَالَ لَهُ أَكْتُبْ مَا هُوَ كَائِنْ فَجَرَى بِمَا هُوَ كَائِنْ إِلَى الْأَبَدِ)، و اما روایت عبادۀ بن صامت بعد از (أَكْتُبْ) اینست که (مَا أَكْتُبُ؟ قَالَ أَكْتُبُ الْقَدْرَ، فَكُتِبَ بِمَا كَانَ وَمَا هُوَ كَائِنْ إِلَى الْأَبَدِ). پوشیده خواهد بود که در طی عبارتین تقدّم حروف کتابی بر سایر مراتب بدئی ابداعی و امداد او اعیان این مراتب را متبیین و روشن گشته، چنانچه از خفّای آیه کریمه قرآنی که فرموده ﴿وَلَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا اللَّهُ عَالِمُ الْغُيُوبِ﴾ [و لَانَّ عَلَیْكُمْ لِحَافِظِیْنَ کِرَامًا کَاتِبِیْنَ یَعْلَمُونَ مَا تَفْعَلُونَ] [۱۲-۸۲: ۱۰] روشن میگردد که سایر مواطن برزخی و عودی مسبوق بدان صور کریمه خواهد بود و احکام تقابل طایفتین یعنی اهل سعادت و محبوسان مطموره شقاوت نیز همه متفرّع بر این اوضاع تشخّص بنیان خواهد شد، چنانچه خفّای این آیه کریمه بدان افصاح مینماید که ﴿فَأَمَّا مَنْ أُوْتِيَ كِتَابَهُ بِیَمِیْنِهِ فَسَوْفَ یُحَاسِبُ حِسَابًا یَسِیرًا وَیَتَقَلَّبُ إِلَى أَهْلِهِ مَسْرُورًا وَأَمَّا مَنْ أُوْتِيَ [مب ۱۸۹] کِتَابَهُ وَرَاءَ ظَهْرِهِ فَسَوْفَ یَدْعُو ثُبُورًا وَیَصْلٰی سَعِیرًا﴾ [۱۲-۸۴: ۷]. غرض که از ظواهر این عبارات معرّیه ختمیه قوت تاثیر و تصرف صور کتابی در سایر احوال و اطوار شخص انسانی بل جمله افراد کاینات از اعیان الهی و کیانی فهم میشود و این که ارتباط مدارج بدئی از حدیث روشن تر مینماید و معارج عودی از آیات قرآنی تنبیه بدانست که فهم آن مدارج نزدیکترست بادرک عقول بشری و انظار افکار او ولیکن ادراک آن معارج دورست از آنکه بمساعی عقول و ترتیب مقدمات او چیزی فهم شود تحصیل علوم آن معارج در مدرسه اوضاع منزله کتابی و تصفّح تالیفات آن صورت بندد.

¹⁹ مب: (خفّای) ساقط شد.

²⁰ نک صحیح بخاری، کتاب العلم، باب لیبلغ العلم الشاهد الغائب (۱۰۵): حَدَّثَنَا عَبْدُ اللَّهِ بْنُ عَبْدِ الْوَهَّابِ قَالَ حَدَّثَنَا حَمَّادٌ عَنْ أَيُّوبَ عَنْ مُحَمَّدٍ عَنْ ابْنِ أَبِي بَكْرَةَ عَنْ أَبِي بَكْرَةَ ذَكَرَ النَّبِيُّ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ قَالَ « فَإِنَّ دِمَاءَكُمْ وَأَمْوَالَكُمْ - قَالَ مُحَمَّدٌ وَأَخْبِسُهُ قَالَ وَأَعْرَاضَكُمْ - عَلَیْكُمْ حَرَامٌ كَحُرْمَةِ يَوْمِكُمْ هَذَا فِي شَهْرِكُمْ هَذَا، أَلَا لِيُبَلِّغَ الشَّاهِدُ مِنْكُمُ الْغَائِبَ ». وَكَانَ مُحَمَّدٌ يَقُولُ صَدَقَ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ كَانَ ذَلِكَ « أَلَا هَلْ بَلَّغْتُ مَوْثِقِينَ.

²¹ اوحدی مراغه ای، غزل (به خرابات برید از در این خانه مرا).

آفتابی بیاید انجم سوز چراغ تو شب نگردد روز

و تمام تلخیص این سخنان آنست که سایر صور شرعیه که انبیا بوضع آن مبعوث گشته اند خواه صور فعلی کونی که عقلای عباد و عباد را حکم فرموده اند که بر آن ثابت و راسخ باشند و از آن تجاوز نمایند مثل افعال صلاة و زکاة و سایر ارکان اسلام و خواه صور قولی حرفی که بعینها از آسمان قدس بدیشان فرود آمده و بر مقتضای فرموده بهمان نشان بعباد رسانیده اند یکسر اسباب ترتیب عباد و آلات محافظت ایشانند از طریان خلل فساد در سایر منازل و موارد تا بسر حدّ معاد و دار السلام مراد برسند کونه نظران عالم فکر رسمی و علوم نظری پندارند که این اوضاع کریمه جهت محافظت همین هیأت اجتماعست که تمدّن طبیعی انسان محتاج بدان میباشد هیأت:

حفظت شیئاً و غابت عنک أشیاء

زهار از هوشمندان همان دانش و بینش که در این اوضاع بنظر احترام تمام نگرند بتخصیص این اوضاع شرعیه ختمیه و حروف منزله قرآنی که خاتم رسل بدان مبعوث شده اند و این امت گرامی بدان فایز و فیروز گشته، باید که هر چه شخص را پیش آید از اغراض و امراض جسمانی و روحانی و سایر حواجز و عوایق دینی و هیولانی دست توسّل در دامن امن و امان این اسباب زند و از سر ایمان کامل و اعتقاد خالص متوجه این اوضاع گرامی و حروف نامی شود و یقین داند که ماده نجات و فلاح او در همین صورت [مب ۱۹۰] درجست و اگر چه در زمانهای سابق نیز کسی که ادراک علاج هر غرضی و مرضی از این اوضاع و حروف تواند کرد نایافت و عزیز بوده اند ولیکن در این زمان امید واثقست که بیا من اشارات ختمیه که اقمار [ما ۱۷۶] ارقام حرفیه در طی آن صورت انشقاق پذیرفته ادراک این معنی و استعداد تحصیل آن جمعی را از اهالی بنیان اهلیت دست خواهد داد و قفنا الله و ایاکم له، اصل آنست که همه همت متوجه همین گردانند و بهر کمالی علمی و اگر چه ارجمند باشد باز نمانند که برسند.

راه ار دراز زخس ترا پی نکرده اند نخل ار بلند مرغ ترا پر نبسته اند

وصل دوم

در بیان قسم نظری علم حروف و تحقیق آنکه چگونه انواع علوم و معارف از آن ظاهر میگردد و فهم میشود

و سخن در آن محتاج تمهید مقدّم ایست یعنی ببايد دانست اولاً که هر کس که علمی از علوم دینی یا عقلی از مبدا فیاض بدو رسیده از ممر سخن رسیده و از راه کلام و حروف دلایل ظروف آن دریافته خواه که بطریق تعلیم و تعلّم که اسد طرق و اقومست فرا گرفته و خواه بطریق تفکر و تدبّر چه مقدّماتین ما دام که مشخص بصور حسّی یا خیالی در نظم ترتیبی نظری ظاهر نگردد هیچ اثر و نتیجه بر آن مترتب نخواهد شد، نه از مطالب فکری نظری و نه از مقاصد ذوق حدسی. پس معلوم شد که بهر حال گذار در مسلک تحصیل علوم در فضای حرف و صحرای با صفای سخن خواهد بود.

قسمت حوالتم بخرابات میکند چندان که آنچنان زدم و اینچنین شدم²²

²² حافظ، غزل (هر چند پیر و خسته دل و ناتوان شدم).

این زمان بیاید دانست که حکمت بالغه حکیم علیم چنان اقتضا کرد که واسطه میان ادراک معانی علمی و صور حرفی وضع باشد چه ما دام که شخص واقف بر وضع الفاظ و تخصیص آن بهر چیزی نیست از دلالت او بهره مند نتواند شد بلکه خط او بجز سماع لفظ مجزّد هیچ دیگر نباشد، و حال آنکه این وضع از دو گونه است یکی آنست که وسیله دریافتن عوامّ میشود که مقاصد و ما یحتاج خود را بدان وضع از الفاظ فهم میکنند و آن عبارت از نسبتیست خارج از ذات لفظ که بسبب فعل واضع و تخصیص او طاری شده این حروف مرتّب را و فعل عرضی باشد ناپایدار که قرار او صورت [مب ۱۹۱] [بنبند؟] چنانچه تواند بود که همان تخصیص از آن واضع یا از دیگری بر ضدّ آن معنی اوّل واقع شود و این در میان لغت عرب بسیار آمده چنانچه لفظ مولی و قرء و غیره و بیشتر مردم بدین راه از سوی لفظ و حروف کلامی بصوب معنی میرسند. و گونه دیگر از وضع آنست که تعلق بذات لفظ و حروف آن دارد و خارج را در آن دخلی نیست، و آن عبارت از نسبتی ثابتست که اجزای حروف و الفاظ بعضی با بعضی دارند و با نزدیکان مرتبه خود نیز دارند، و این نسبت اگر چه عرضست فاما در ذات حرف صورت بندد و از و منفک نگردد، و این وضعست که شاه راه ادراک حقایق حکمی بر آن واقعست و وسیله خواصّست در فهم معنی از الفاظ و حروف، و شک نیست که این وضع چون در ذات حروف و الفاظ ثابت و مقررست و تعلق بفعل شخصی ندارد تفاوت طوایف مردم در رسیدن صوب معنی بدان راه بمجزّد توجه و قوّت ذهن باشد و کمال تدبّر و تیقّظ در آن تواند بود نه بشنیدن از اقران زبان خود چنانچه در وضع اوّل، پس این راه لایق باشد که مخصوص بکلام خاتم الرسل بود که او مبعوث بر کافّه امست و کلام او باید که فهم آن مخصوص بجمعی معین نباشد. غرض که این دو راهست از سوی حروف بصوب معنی باید که مردم زیرک منحصر در یکی ندانند که از راهی دیگر محروم مانند، و حال آنکه آنچه از ظاهر آیات قرآنی فهم میشود سلوک این راهست چه تدبّر در او امر شده است و شک نیست که تدبّر در چیزی وقتی صورت تحقّق پذیرد که در ذات او و آنچه قریب بذات باشد سیر کنند نه در آنچه بخارج از او باشد. حاصل از این تطویل آنکه ورای این وضع متعارف و راه مشهور که عامّه مردم بدان راه از حروف بمعانی میروند راهی دیگر هست باید که هوشمندان عالم طلب از آن غافل نکردند تا از سخنان محمد صلوات الله و سلامه علیه و رموز ایشان که در طیّ احادیث و آنچه بدان فرستاده شده از قرآن بی بهره نمانند.

اوحدی تا کنون دری میزد چون خرابات ما دو در دارد
من و آن دلبر خراباتی فی طریق الهوی کما یأتی

پس میباید که بدانی اوّلاً این وضع که ذات حروف [مب ۱۹۲] بدان متحقّق و متّصف گشته و آنست راه خواصّ از جانب حروف بصوب معنی تا قوّت تدبّر در قرآن و کلام رسول که مامور بدانیم ترا حاصل گردد و آن وقتی توانی دانستن که صورت حروف معلوم کنی، همانا در صدر کتاب فهم شده باشد که صورت هیاکلّ سُورت حروف از سه گونه است و هر یک بمشعری از مشاعر کریمه انسان مخصوص چنانچه صورت رقیّ کتابی که بدستکاری قلم و تحریک بنان بر صحایف بیاض در سلک اعیان میناید و چشم آن را در میباید و صورت لفظی کلامی که بیامردی هوا [ما ۱۷۶ب] و حرکات تمّوّجی او بر صفای صوت دایما در جلوه است و گوش ادراک آن میکند و همچنین صورت معنوی عددی که بقوّت تنوّعات قلبی در فضای صحرای علم پذیرای تلّون و تحقّق میگردد و طرف ظاهر قلب که معبر بفؤادست آن را فهم میکند و از این همتست که در طیّ آیات قرآنی و تنزیل آسانی این سه مشعر را بسیار میباید که در یک سلک آمده و بتفخیم شأن و تعظیم مکان او اشارت شده چنانچه قوله تعالی ﴿وَهُوَ الَّذِي أَنشَأَ لَكُمُ السَّمْعَ وَالْأَبْصَارَ وَالْأَفْئِدَةَ قَلِيلًا مَّا تَشْكُرُونَ﴾ [۲۳:۷۸] و قوله تعالی ﴿وَجَعَلَ لَكُمُ السَّمْعَ وَالْأَبْصَارَ وَالْأَفْئِدَةَ قَلِيلًا مَّا تَشْكُرُونَ﴾ [۳۲:۹، ۲۳:۲۷] الی غیر ذلک من الآیات. هرگاه که این مقدمه بر صحایف اذهان صورت پذیرفت بیاید دانست که هر صورتی ای این صور سه گانه که هر حرفی را حاصلست اجزای متنوّعه دارند، مثلاً الف صورت کتابی او خطیست منتزّل که ابتدا از نقطه عالی کرده و تنزّل نموده تا بنهایت هفت یا ده رسیده، و هر یک

از این مبدا و منتهی بخاصه ای ممتاز گشته اول بزاید یمنی و آخر بیساری و اجزای این صورت عبارت از اینهاست و صورت کلامی او مدیست که از نفس انسانی طالع میشود و ابتدا از اول مخارج حلقی یعنی همزه نمود و بوسط لسانی که مخرج لام است خط کرد و از آنجا بنهایت شفوی فرود آورد، و اینها همه اجزای صور او شدند، و صورت معنوی او عبارت از حدیست که هیچ چیز در سلسله اعتبار بر او مقدم نتواند شد و در مرتبه او نیز مجال باشد که غیر او تواند بود و هر چه بعد از او در صدد ظهور آید همه صورت [مب ۱۹۳] تنوع و تنزل او باشد بلکه هر اسمی و لقبی که بر آنها افتد همه از سبای علو و قوت تاثیر آن حد خواهد بود و آن را واحد عددی خوانند. از طی این سخنان فهم شد که هر یک از این صور ثلاثه الف حقیقتیست مرکب از اجزای متنوع و بی شک اجزا را نسبتی بیکدیگر خواهد بود، هرگاه که مجموع این نسب را با نسبتی که بخارج دارد اعتبار کنند آن همه را وضع خوانند در زبان جمهور عقلا و اهل نظر، و این وضعست که واسطه دلالت الفاظ و حروف بصور سه گانه او میشود بر معنی ایشان، اگر کسی پرسد که چگونه این اوضاع دلالت بر معنی میتوانند کرد و بر تقدیر آنکه دلالت توانند کرد از کجاست که این دلالت معتبرست در شرع و بزرگان دین آن را اعتبار کرده اند؟ بیان هر دو سخن روشنست نزد آنکس که دیدۀ بصیرت او بعمش تقلید آبا مبتلا نگشته باشد و قوت پذیرائی سخن بهمان فطرت اصلی خود مانده باشد که در حدیث صحیح خُوای (کلّ مولود یولد علی الفطرة) از آن نشان داده، و عبارت ابواه بیودانه و یمنصرانه از آن صور تقلیدی آبا تحذیر فرموده. اما بیان آنکه این اوضاع را دلالت بر معنی صورت میندد در سه سخن روشن تواند شد.

سخن اول

در تحقیق آنکه وضع حسی که چشم در مییابد دلالت بر معنی میکند

و این نزد هوشمند بغایت روشنست چه دلالت وضع خفتن شخص بر ضعف و وضع نشستن و برخاستن بر مراتب قوت او همه کس در مییابد و جزم بدان میکند، چه جای اینکه در وضع بشره شخص که نگاه کند زیرک فهم میکند که باطن او متصف بمحببتست یا عداوت. پس هرگاه که این اوضاع محسوسه در این صورت شخصی حدثانی هیولانی مثل این دلالتها دراد و ما در مییابیم معنی از او همین اوضاع اگر در اشخاص حرفی قدیم آسمانی یابیم که همه مامور بتدبیر در آنیم باید که بی معنی ندانیم و بدیده اعتبار و تأمل در او نگریم تا امثال امر کرده باشیم و عصیان ننموده.

برک درختان سبز نزد خداوند هوش هر ورقی دفترست معرفت کردگار

و اما بیان آنکه این اوضاع در السنه کتاب و سنت بعبارت اعتبار وارد گشته و دلالت آنها بسمت سمو قدر موسوم [مب ۱۹۴] شده اگر کسی در خُوای آیه کریمه ﴿الَّذِينَ يَذْكُرُونَ اللَّهَ قِيَامًا وَقُعُودًا وَعَلَىٰ جُنُوبِهِمْ وَيَتَفَكَّرُونَ فِي خَلْقِ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ رَبَّنَا مَا خَلَقْتَ هَذَا بَاطِلًا سُبْحَانَكَ فَقِنَا عَذَابَ النَّارِ﴾ [۳:۱۹۱] تأمل نماید و اطوار جمل و تراکیب آن را بدیده تدبیر نگاه کند اولاً از عطف ﴿يَتَفَكَّرُونَ﴾ بر ﴿يَذْكُرُونَ﴾ مقرون باحوال و اوضاع مذکوره، و ثانياً الحاق خطاب ندائی ﴿رَبَّنَا مَا خَلَقْتَ هَذَا بَاطِلًا﴾ و ﴿سُبْحَانَكَ﴾ بدان ﴿يَتَفَكَّرُونَ﴾ و بعد از آن خطاب دعائی ﴿فَقِنَا عَذَابَ النَّارِ﴾ بدانها همه بسی از دلایل این سخن بر او روشن گردد و فهم تعظیم این اوضاع هم. ولیکن اگر تأمل در این کلام منزل بقوت تدبیر و تفکر در مفهوم آیه کند بی استعانت کتب که در آن باب ساخته شده،

تو خود بباغ رو و گوش کن که سهل بود اگر فضیلت بلبل ز باغبان شنوی²³

سخن دوم

در بیان آنکه وضع حسی کلامی که گوش در مییابد دلالت بر معنی میکند

و هر چه بیان این معنیست نزد علمای ظاهر روشن و مبرهنست چه اهل علم معانی بنای کلام ایشان بر این وضعست و دلالت او [ما ۱۷۷ا] و یکی از اصول قواعد ایشان اینست که تقدیم هر چه حق آن تاخیرست دلالت بر تخصیص میکند و افراد مقدم بحکم لاحق چنانچه میگویند ﴿إِيَّاكَ نَعْبُدُ وَإِيَّاكَ نَسْتَعِينُ﴾ [۱:۵] دلالت اختصاص مخاطب میکند بعبودت و استعانت، و این دلالت شک نیست که از قبیل آن نوع دلالت وضعیست نه وضعی متعارف ایشان چه نسبت کلماتست که در این ترکیب تغییر یافته و گشته و اگر نه اصل کلمات بحال خودست خواه که بگوئی (نَعْبُدُكَ) و خواه که بگوئی (إِيَّاكَ نَعْبُدُ) اصول کلمات نخویه بحسب وضع عرفی ایشان بر همان یک حالست و دلالت او متغیر نه و از اینجاست که بعضی از ائمه نحو که قوت فهم ایشان بمرتبه ذوق نرسیده و قاصر مانده منکر این نوع دلالتند مثل ابن حاجب و ابو حیّان و ابن هشام و غیره، و این طایفه از علمای ظاهر که بواسطه قرب مدارک ایشان بمرتبه ذوق عاثر بر این گونه دلالت گشته اند یک درجه از مراتب محبوسان پیفوله عادت ترقی نموده اند و لهذا بمیامن این خطوه که از محای تقلید آبا دور گشته اند بسی از حقایق تنزیل آسمانی و کلام نبوی [مب ۱۹۵] در حوصله ادراک ایشان فرود آمده و زخشری در کشف که بیت القصیده تفاسیر متداول آنست بنای سخنان بر مفهومات این گونه دلالت و معانی این وضع نهاده و بدین واسطه بنیان بیانش از سایر امثال و اقران خود بلندپایه تر گشته. و اما بیان اعتبار این نوع دلالات نزد پیشوایان دین در خبرست که از جاحظ که مؤسس قواعد این نوع دلالت در میان علمای ظاهر او بوده سؤال کردند که از کجا اخذ کرده ای این اصول را؟ گفت از کلمات امیر و ملازمت تلامذه او. غرض که این قدر از لطایف تنزیلی که در میان اهل ظاهر سبب امتیاز و سرفرازی ایشان گشته و شمه ای از گلستان رموز انبیا بمشام ذوق همگنان رسیده هم رشحه ای از بحر کمالات اهل بیت و خانواده ولایت و هدایت بوده لا شک.

هر بوی که از مشک و قرنفل شنوی از دولت آن زلف چو سنبل شنوی²⁴

سخن سوم

در بیان آنکه وضع معنوی عددی که دل در مییابد دلالت بر معنی میکند

بباید دانست که وجوه مدلولات عدد و مراتب آن بسیارست و لیکن آنچه بدیهه عقل بی استعانت قوت بصیرت و تحدیق نظر فکری در مییابد ضبط شتات کایناتست مطلقا چه متفرقات اشخاص کونی که بر صحاری ظهور و اظهار پیدا میشوند ما دام که بملا بس مراتب عددی مزین نمیگردند مستعد تحقق بکمال آن مرتبه نمیشوند چه جای این که شوارد مسایل علمی که بر

²³ اوحدی مراغه ای، قصیده (اگر حقایق معنی به گوش جان شنوی).

²⁴ عراقی، رباعی ۱۶۳ (... چون نغمه، بلبل ز پی گل شنوی اگل گفته بود هر چه ز بلبل شنوی).

مجالى شعور و اشعار در صدد ظهور میآیند تا جَلَع تقسیمات عددی و حُلل عقود آن نمپوشند صورت تحصیل علمی و تدوین تالیفی نمپزیرند.

بی نشان تو نیست یک ذره بجز این یک نشان نمیدانم

و از اینجاست که هیچ جمع از مجامع این عوالم خالی از عقود حالی عددی نمیبایم خواه مساجد و صوامع عباد و عباد و خواه مواضع و مواطن اهل تقابل و عناد یعنی مجامع دواوین ملوک که مشتمل بر ضابطان امور لشکر و رعیتند بی دستیاری این عقود عددی انگشت ایشان قلم ضبط بر نمیتواند گرفت و مواطن بازار که مشتمل بر عموم خلائقست هیچ حلقه بی گفت و گوی عدد منعقد نمیکرد و هیچ دکان بی صاحبی که همواره [مب ۱۹۶] باطن او مشغول بحساب اعیان آن دکان و ثمن هر یک باشد صورت رواج نمپذیرد. پس مبصران جهان هوشمندی را روشن و مبین گشت که این نوع ضبط که سایر آثار کمالی عالم ظهور و اظهار بدان مرتبطست امر دلالت مراتب عددست و افراد و ازواج او، چه شخص بی آنکه دست توسل بدامن عدد زند از این ضبطها عاجزست و امکان نیست که بی رهنمایی او و دلالت افراد اعدادش هیچ آفریده پای در دایره ضبط هیچ نوع از انواع عوالم ظهور و اظهار و شعور و اشعار تواند نهاد.

نشود کار عالمی بنظام که نه پای تو در میان باشد²⁵

و اما اول آنست که ثعالی و قاضی ناصر الدین بیضاوی در تفسیر خود آورده اند بروایت ابو العالیه که احبار یهود نزد حضرت رسالت آمدند و چون الف لام میم صدر البقره بر ایشان خوانده شد در اثنای دعوت ایشان بدین گفتند چگونه بدینی در آیم که مدت بقایش هفتاد و یکسال خواهد بود؟ لب و دندان همگی نمای را که صورت زبان و دهان واقع گشته و ینبوع علوم حکمی و کتابی همانجاست در آن حال بوضع تبسم و انبساط فرا نمودند بعد از آن سؤال کردند که از این مقوله سخن دیگر فرود آمده است فرمودند که المر و المص گفتند این زمان بر ما مشتبّه مختلط گشت. و پوشیده نمآند که یکی از صور سنت نبوی آنست که در آن حضرت قولی یا فعلی ظاهر گردد و مقرر دارند و نفی فرمایند و اینجا و رای تقریر انبساط نیز [ما ۱۷۷ب] فرموده اند که دلالت بر تعجب از ظهور این نوع علمست بر ایشان و تلقی باصغای سؤال دوم در این باب و اشتغال بجواب آن هم فرموده اند و اینها همه مؤیدات زیادتی تقریر و تمکینست نزد هوشمند این دلیل عبارت ظاهریست. و اما بیان دلیلی که بزبان رموز و اشارات خفی دلالت بدین مقصود میکند بسیارست ولیکن این زبان را کسی فهم کند که از عادات اهل رسوم قدمی پیش آمده [مب ۱۹۷] باشد و نظر در الفاظ و دلالات آن خالص از شوایب رسوم جعلی تواند کرد از آنجمله هر کس که در خوای فرموده ﴿إِنَّ عِدَّةَ الشُّهُورِ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ اثْنَا عَشَرَ شَهْرًا فِي كِتَابِ اللَّهِ يَوْمَ خَلَقَ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضَ مِنْهَا أَرْبَعَةٌ حُرْمٌ ذَلِكَ اللَّيْنُ الْقَيِّمُ﴾ [۹:۳۶] اندک تدبیری و تعمقی نماید چندانکه پای سیر و سعیش بقرار جای اطمینان رسد او را روشن گردد که این آیت دلیلی ینست بر اثبات صورت عددی حرف که کتاب الله از آن افصاح نموده و تمیز مراتب آن و اختصاص چهار مرتبه از آن بحرمت و احترام و مزید تعظیم و احتشام، چه بر محرمان پرده سرای ذکا و فطنت پوشیده نخواهد بود که عدّه مراتب مشهور عدد دوازده است از یکی تا ده و صد و هزار باقی همه صور تنوعات اشتقاقی و مدارج تطورات ترکیبی ایشانند این زمان باید دانست که چهار از آن مراتب را سمت اختصاص بوحده است که حرم سرای خاص واحدند و باقی تعلق بکثرت دارند و مجالی کثیرند و از آن چهار سه در یک سلک واقع شده اند که مستقر وحدت جمعی اند و واحد در طیّ مراتب کثیر بدیشان ظاهر گشته و یکی فرد واقع شده که وحدت فرقی را موطن استقرار

²⁵ انوری، قصیده (گر دل و دست بحر و کان باشد).

و ظهور شده چنانچه در احادیث وارد گشته که (ثلاثةُ سرد وواحد فرد)، و این واحد فردست که منبع اطوار و اسرار وحدتست از این رو اهتمام بشأن تحقیق احکام او بیشتر فرموده صاحب شرع هر کس که این معنی را متذکر گشت فهم تواند کرد که چرا حضرت رسالت صلی الله علیه و سلم در آن حدیث مبارک که میگوید (رَجَبُ مُضَرَ الَّذِي بَيْنَ جُمَادَى وَ شَعْبَانَ)،²⁶ این زمان مشهور معروف را تارةً باضافت و تارةً بوصف در صدد تحقیق و تبیین میآید و اهتمام بتفصیل احکام او میفرماید و هر کس که راه بدین مسلک برد از دقایق حکم انبیا و حلّ مرموزات ایشان بهره ور تواند گشت.

یک نکته از این دفتر گفتیم و همین باشد

غرض از ترتیب این سخنان آن بود که روشن گردد پیش مسترشد این معنی که اوضاع حروف را بصورت‌های سه گانه که دارند دلالت بر معنی میکنند و آن دلالت معتبرست پیش ائمه رشد و هدایت این زمان. بایاد دانست که این [مب ۱۹۸] نوع دلالتست که بدان استنباط حقایق اشیا و احوال کاینات از حروف منزله قرآنی میتوان کرد بغایتی که هیچ چیز از جزئیات عالم و کلیات آن نباشد الا آنکه مستفاد تواند شد از او چنانچه فحواى فرموده ﴿وَلَا زُطْبٍ وَلَا يَابِسٍ إِلَّا فِي كِتَابٍ مُبِينٍ﴾ [۶:۵۹] بدان مفصّحست و شک نیست که دلالت اوضاع بر معانی بواسطه مناسبت و قوت ارتباط آن اوضاع تواند بود بمعانی خودش، پس واقف شدن بر جهات مناسبت میانه اوضاع حروف و معانی از مقدمات دلالت او خواهد بود و اوضاع حروف معلوم شد که از سه مقوله است چندی محسوسست بحسّ بصر و چندی محسوس بحسّ سمع و چندی معقولست بقوت فکر و نظر، و هر یک از این اوضاع را فنون جهات ارتباطی بعالم معنی و طرق سعت فضای آن متبیین و روشنتست نزد هوشمند متیقّظ ولیکن جهت تنزّل مبدارک جمعی که ذهن خود را معوّذ گردانیده اند بدانکه حقایق علمی را در طّی اصول مقننه مؤلفه فرا گیرند چندی از اصول آن جهات ارتباطی و طرق مداخلش بصور تالیفی مقنّن و مبیین گشته در کتاب مفاحص تا مسترشدان راه نظر و ذوق را خدمتی باشد، ولیکن همان قدر کافی نیست در استنباط معانی از حروف مقطّعه و موصّله بلکه بسی از علوم دخل دارد اینجا بتخصیص در معانی موصّله و نسبت حروف بعضی ببعضی و تالیفی از خانواده ائمه اهل بیت مانده جعفر نام در تحقیق این وضع دخل بسیار دارد در استنباط مذکور اگر بضایم و لواحق اصولش مرتبط تواند شد، و تا غایت زمان مساعدت نموده و نظم آن مقدمات صورت نبسته مگر بنسبت جمعی از خلص اولیا که رقیقه مناسبت آن خانواده را بحسن متابعت با ادراک جوهر ذاتی جمع داشته باشد ﴿وَقَلِيلٌ مَّا هُمْ﴾ [۳۸:۲۴] در این اوان. امید هست که این مقدمات را صورت نظمی در عالم ظاهر گردد چنانچه زیرکان زمان از حقایق قرآنی کما ینبغی بهره ور توانند شد.

باش تا غنچه این روضه دهان بنماید باش تا سوسنش از لطف زبان بگشاید

²⁶ مثلاً يك صحيح بخاري لا كتاب بدء الخلق، باب ما جاء في سبع أرضين (۳۲۳۳): حَدَّثَنَا مُحَمَّدُ بْنُ الْمُثَنَّى حَدَّثَنَا عَبْدُ الْوَهَّابِ حَدَّثَنَا أَبُو ثَوْبٍ عَنْ مُحَمَّدِ بْنِ سِيرِينَ عَنْ ابْنِ أَبِي بَكْرَةَ عَنْ أَبِي بَكْرَةَ - رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ - عَنِ النَّبِيِّ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ قَالَ « الرِّمَانُ قَدْ اسْتَدَارَ كَهَيْئَتِهِ يَوْمَ خَلَقَ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضَ ، السَّنَةُ اثْنَا عَشَرَ شَهْرًا ، مِنْهَا أَرْبَعَةٌ حُرُمٌ ، ثَلَاثَةٌ مُمَوَّلِيَاتٌ ذُو الْقَعْدَةِ وَذُو الْحِجَّةِ وَالْمَحَرَّمِ ، وَرَجَبُ الْمُضَرِّ الَّذِي بَيْنَ جُمَادَى وَشَعْبَانَ ».

در بیان آنکه حقایق اشیا چگونه از حروف بیرون [مب ۱۹۹] میآید

و در آنکه بزرگان پیشین در این باب دخل فرموده اند و انموذجی از آن در طی اشارات شریفه خود ثبت گردانیده تا زیرکان جهان از آن انموذج متفطن گردند [ما ۱۷۸] و فهم دیگر معانی از جزئیات حروف را مستعد و آمده شوند. اولاً در استنباط کلیات حقایق چنانچه از ابن عباس رضی الله عنه مرویست که او سخنی چند فرمود در معنی ﴿الم﴾ [۲:۱، ۳۰:۱] و سه مرتبه در بیان معنی او روشن گردانید تا مستبصر را نشانی باشد در انتهای این طریق.

اول در استنباط حقایق قدسی و حضرات الهی که مبداست گفته اند که معنی او اینست که (أنا الله اعلم) یعنی الف دلالت بر آیت و لام بر الوهیت و میم بر علم میکند، و پوشیده نماند بر واقفان این مواقف شریفه که سایر حضرات و مراتب الهی در این مرتبه درجست با ظهور جهات مناسبت که سبب دلالت همانست.

و ثانی در استنباط مراتب وصفی و فعلی و مدارج آن که وسط امرست فرموده (الف آلاء الله و لام لطفه و میم ملکه) یعنی الف دلالت بر نعمتهای ظاهر میکند که خدای تعالی ارزانی داشته است بر بندگان خود مانند حیاة که اصل همه نعمتهاست و ظاهر ترین همه چنانچه الف در میان حروف که اصل همه حرفها اوست رقا و لفظاً و روشن ترین همه بر الواح مدارک هموست و لام دلالت بر لطف الهی منکند از روی سریان رحمت او در سایر مراتب استیداعی و استقراری بنده از ابتدای نقطه تا انتهای کمال و بلوغ مرتبه استقلال و احاطت رحمت همه این مراتب را در محافظت لطف خود چنانچه لام بنسبت با این حروف ثلاثه و میم اشارت بملک اوست از روی کمال جمعیت و تمام تنزل چنانچه نسخه کتابی میم هر دو جهت را مینماید. این معنی حروف از روی کلیات معانی و حضرات اسمائی بود که روشن گردانید.

و ثالث در بیان استنباط اعیان جامعه که نهایت و غایت کارست میفرماید که (الف من الله و لام من جبرئیل و میم من محمد ای القرآن منزل من الله بلسان جبرئیل الی محمد) یعنی الف اشارت بالله است که ابتدای امر از اوست و لام اشارت بجبرئیلست که واسطه انزال کلام اوست و لسان او ناقل [مب ۲۰۰] کلام از لوح اول برسول آخر شده و میم اشارت بمحمدست که تمام صورت را بتمام معنی مرتبط و متصل آشکارا فرموده. این زمان هوشمند متیقظ باید که چون این سه مرتبه سخن که آن بزرگ خانواده نبوت و ولایت در معنی ﴿الم﴾ گفته شنود بگوش هوش تلقی نماید و جهات مناسبات و وجوه تقسیات آن را فهم کند و در دل خود جا دهد و آن را مقرر گرداند و اصل سازد و مبنای سایر معانی حروف بر این نهد که شیمه کریمه بزرگان و رهنمایان شاه راه رشد و هدایت چنین میباشد که معانی بسیار در سخن اندک بیان فرمایند، چنانچه امیر فرموده که (خیر الکلام ما قلّ ودلّ وما ملّ فأخلّ). غرض که همین اصل در بیان علم حروف پیش مستبصران جهان دانش کافست و چون بر زبان رموز و اشارات که عرف خواص بر آنست آشنا گردد و فهم چیزی از آن زبان کردن گیرد سایر آیات قرآنی و کلام نبوی مفصح بدان اصول و حقایق یابد.

در خانه اگر کسست یک حرف بس است

چون ره نورد بیان زمام کلام را بدین سر حد کشید واجب شد که چیزی از معانی سایر مقطعات حروف که در اوایل سور قرآنی منزل گشته بیان کرده شود بر سبیل انموذج.

²⁷ مب: سخن چهارم.

الم ص ر
٧١
لفلم
٢٥١
٣٠٢

الم ص الم
٤٨٨
٦٩٨
٨٨٨

ط س م
تسعه ستين
٥٣٥
٥٢٥
٣٣٣
١٣٨٨

ن و الفم و ما يسطرون
خمسين
٧٤٥

تي س
٧٥
٤٥
اين
٦١
لفلاون
٣٥٨
١٤٧
عشره ستين
١٤٥٣
٥٧٥
٥٢٥
١٥٩٥

* * *

الم ص ر
لضام يم^٧
٢٠١
٢٧٢

الم ص
الم ر
لضام يم ا
٢٠٢

الم^٦
٢٢٤
٥٩١
١٥٨١
٢٥٨١

ي س
^٧
٦٠

ن
والعلم وبسطرون
٧٦٥

اين
لف اون^{٦١}
١٤٧
٣٥١

عشره
٥٧٥
١٠٩٥

سني
١٢٥٣
٥٢٠

طسم
شعة ستين
٥٣٥
٥٢٠
٣٣٣
١٣١١

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[مب ۲۰۳] چون امعان در این رقوم هندسی شاید که موجب سامت گردد این رساله را بنکنه روشن از این فن که هم مثبت اصول این علم باشد و هم مبین استدامت این دولت روزافزون ختم کردن بمنهج صواب اقرب دانست و بیانش آنست که بر مقتضای فحوای (الالقب تنزل من السماء) چنان فهم میشود که از لقب هر کس بلکه از نام هر چیز باید که سر انجام احوال او روشن گردد چون از آسمان قدس فرود آمده و حرف از برای نمایش هر چه هست فرود میآید. پس حرفی چند که بدان شخص مخصوص شده کنایست که کاشف احوال او خواهد بود، و از اینجاست که جمعی استخراج طالع از نام میکنند با وجود آنکه باصول علم حرف واقف نیستند بمجرب تجربه که ایشان را بحسب تخمین نه از روی یقین رو نموده است آری.

چو خورشید جهان آرا بر آید بهر سوراخ نوری اندر آید

هرگاه که این مقدمه بر لوح خاطر ثبت گشت بیاید دانست که از نام این پادشاه تقوی پناه روشن میگردد که او شاه این صد سالست که ثمانیایه بزبان عربی اعراب از آن نموده بفصیحترین عبارتی آن نام هایون سر انجام دلالت میکند که این دولت تا انقراض صد سال پاینده خواهد بود ان شاء الله تعالی چه را دویست [۲۰۰] است و خا ششصد [۶۰۰]، هر دو با هم هشتصد [۸۰۰] باشد. پس معنی شاه رخ برین تقدیر شاه هشتصد باشد و ظهور این معنی درین اسم مبارک بمیان آنست که موافق اسم ظاهر واقع شده که یکی از اسای کلیه چهارگانه است که هویت الهی بدان وصف فرموده محمد صلی الله علیه و سلم و بر همگان آشکارا گردانیده، و اگر کس بقراین عقل استدلال کند بداند که از ابتدای قرن هشتصد که در آمده روز بروز از چمن سعادت و بختیاری غنچه امیدی تازه میشکفت و از روضه اقبال و فرمان روائی دوحه مرادی نو در بر میآید. امید که تا آخر آن

هر دم از این باغ بری در رسد تازه تر از تازه تری در رسد

بحرمة محمد و آله الطیّین و صلی الله علیه و علی آله اجمعین و سلم تسلیما.
تمّ فی یوم الاربعاء ۷ رجب سنة ۱۲۹۰³⁰

م

³⁰ مب: تمّ الکتابه فی ذی الحجه سنه ۹۰۳ هجریه بمسعودیه یزد.

بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم

بعد حمد الله رب البرية وبارئ أخصائهم للتدبر في بينات آياته الجليلة والصلاة على من بدت بمشكاة نبوته الختمية وكمالاته الأتمية خفايا الحقائق العلية من خبايا الزوايا الحرفية وعلى آله وأصحابه هداة شوارع الايقان بالدلالات العقلية والإشارات الذوقية. رأيتُ بعض من برّء من تكلفات العوائد الرسمية وبلغ معارج همته إلى ما لا يغنيه المدلولات الوضعية ومحصورات أغذيتها الجعلية من جوع الطلب والفحص عن معاني التنزيلات السبوعية والصور الكاشفة الكتابية يسأل عن وجه تصدّر الباء في القرآن الكريم وبيان خصوصيته المنبئة لما تفرد به بين الحروف من جمات التقديم، وكنتُ متوقفا في إظهار ما عندي في ذلك لعزّ مرامه وقلة بضاعتي في سوق نظامه حتى وجدتُ من المتصوّفة من أتى في ذلك بما يشمّر عنه طباع المسترشدين من التكلّفات الواهية والتمخّلات التي عن أصول التوجيه خالية، فحتي قهرمان الوقت أن المظهر من يوانع ما أثمر الزمان على أفنائه مما لم يصل إليه يدُ المجتنبين بعدُ إلى أعالي أغصانه.

فلنقدّم في ذلك ما هو قريب الأنس بطباع المعوّدين بالمعهدات الرسمية من العلوم المتوّرة الكسبية تنزّلا إلى مدارك الطالبين من ذوي النفوس الزكية والأذهان الذكية، فإنّ علم الحروف على وضوح محجته ووثاقة حجته قد خفي أصوله على أكثر الناس وذلك لأن الحكيم العليم علّت حكمته قد أشغله عن احترام ما حريم عزّته ورعاية لعظم شأنه حتى يأتي الوقت برايات سلطنته.

من ذلك وجهٌ حكيم في نظم عربي:

اعلم أنّ الحروف لها تقسيمات كاشفة عن الجهات الاشتراكية والامتيازية التي بينها لا بدّ لدى الخوض في معانيها الحقيقية التي بدون توسّطٍ من الوضع وجعل من الواضع أو الناقل من الفحص عن تلك الجهات ضرورة أنّ استحصال تلك المعاني وفهمها من الحروف أنفسها إمّا يتوقّف على الإطلاع بوجوه المناسبات والخصائص اللازمة لكلّ حرفٍ بحسب صورها الثلاثة التي لها في مخارج الظهور ومجالي العلم والشعور على ما يبيّن تحقيق ذلك في مجال أوسع من هذا. ويبيّن أنّ ذلك لا يتمّ بدون استحضار الجهات المذكورة الاشتراكية المبينة لأصل الحقيقة والامتيازية الكاشفة عن الخصوصية الفاصلة على ما هو المستفاد من طي تلك التقسيمات بأعين طريق، فلذلك ألزمتنا قصد التفهيم وقادنا سوق الكلام نحو مسالك الإظهار والتعليم أن نصدّر أكثر الوجوه بالتقسيمات ونجعلها مبادئ لتحقيقها.

منها أنّ الحروف منها ما له دلالة مستقلة يستعمل فيها بين يدي العامة بالدلالات الوضعية كالسين والميم، ومنها ما لا يدلّ كذلك إلّا في طي تركبه مع الآخر في الكلمات كالعين والصاد (والأوّل منها ما له ذلك في أوّل الكلمة فقط كالباء والسين)، ومنها ما

¹ م = مجلس ١٠١٩٦ ص ١٢٢-١٢٣ ب.

له ذلك في آخرها فقط كالباء، ومنها ما له ذلك في طرفها فقط كالياء والتاء، ومنها ما له ذلك مطلقا سواء كان أولا أو آخر أو أوسطا كالألف. إذا تقرر لك هذا فاعلم أن كل ما له غاية كمالية تترتب عليه في بعض الأماكن التي أمكن وقوعه فيها فذلك المكان الذي بلغ فيه المتكهن إلى غايته الكمالية هو مقتضى حقيقته الأصلية ومستقر قابليته الذاتية كالباء والسين مثلا، فإن الغاية الكمالية منها هي الدالة على [م ١٢٢ب] المعاني وهي إما تترتب عليها ظاهرا عندما قُدم في الكلمات وصُدّر في التركيبات. فَعلم من ذلك أن مقتضى قابليتها الأصلية هو التقدم والتصدر على أن للباء دلالة أيضا على السبب الذي به بدء كل شيء، لذلك تفرد في المدون المتعاور بالتصدر.

ومن ذلك وجه حكيم في نظم نظري:

وهو أنه ما من مولود يولد في عوالم الإمكان أو يظهر على صحائف الألوان والأكوان إلا وقد تقدم عليه الأبوان أو المتقدمتان أو ما يجري مجراها من العبارات المتخالفة حسب تخالف الاعتبارات، وهذا هو المستوى في الاصطلاح بالنكاح الساري في جميع النراري. فظهر من هذا أن الثنوية لها التقدم على الكل طبعاً حيث لا يمكن ظهور شيء من الأشياء علماً وعيناً إلا بعد تقدمها عليه، وذلك هو الصورة المعنوية التي للباء فله التقدم بهذا الوجه.

ومن ذلك وجه كلامي في نظم ذوقي:

وهو أن من التقسيمات الكاشفة لوجوه خصوصيات الحروف أنها منقسمة إلى علوي نوراني وهي التي أنزلت بأسماها مستقلة في أوائل السور القرآنية الختمية، وسفلي ظلماني إنما أنزلت بمسمياتها في طي التراكيب والكلمات مطلقاً، وكلا القسمين متعادلان في كفتي التقابل. ويُن أن الألف هو صاحب الصدارة والتقدم في القسم الأول كذلك الباء في القسم الثاني، فله صلوح الصدارة في المدون المرتب عند الناس. فلئن قيل كيف يصلح الظلماني للصدارة من دون النوراني على اختصاصه بمزايا التقديس والشرف، قلنا إن في القرآن المدون الذي بين الدفتين عند الناس ترتيبين، أحدهما أصلي إنزالي قدسي وهو الترتيب الذي عليه عندما أنزل على عبده الخاتم صلوات الله وسلامه عليه وعلى آله، وصاحب القهرمان في هذا الترتيب هو الحروف النورانية على ما لا يخفى، فإنه صح عن رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم أنه قال أول ما أنزل عليه قوله تعالى ﴿اقْرَأْ بِاسْمِ رَبِّكَ الَّذِي خَلَقَ﴾ [٩٦:١]. والآخر جعلي وضعي امتزاجي وهو الذي اتفق عليه الصحابة في أيام عثمان رضي الله عنه، وصاحب القهرمان في هذا الترتيب هو الحروف السفلية، ويُن أن ترتيب المدون الذي عند الناس من قبيل الثاني فلا يليق بالصدارة هناك إلا الباء كما علم أيضاً مما صدر في الترتيب الأول فإنه هو المأمور بقراءته وبدايته.

ومن ذلك وجه كلامي في نظم تنبيهي:

وهو أن الحروف لها تقسيم آخر باعتبار اعتواره على الخارج، فإن منها ما هو شفوي إنما تقوم ظهوره عليها فقط، ومنها ما هو حلقي إنما تقوم ظهوره عليه، ومنها ما هو وُسْطاني إنما تقوم باللسان والأسنان. ثم إن الأظهر من بين هذه الأقسام إنما هو الشفوي لا سيما إذا تقوم ذلك بحرف المد كما هو المشاهد من الباء، ويُن أن ملاك الأمر في هذا المدون المرتب هو التبليغ والإظهار لا غير، وصاحب قصب السبق في مضار الإظهار بين سائر الحروف هو الباء لما عرفت فله التقدم فيه.

ومن ذلك وجه حسابي في نظم ذوقي:

وهو أنَّ الثاني من حيث أنَّه متَّصف بوصفه الخاصَّ به يدلُّ على الأوَّل الذي به صار ثانيًا، وإذا تقرَّر هذا ظهر أنَّ الباء مع ما له من الدلالة على المبدأ كسائر الحروف فإنَّ الكلام من حيث أنَّه كلام يدلُّ على المتكلم ضرورة بحسب صورته الخارجية السمعية، له دلالة أخرى على المبدأ بحسب صورته العقلية التي له بإزاء صورتيه الخارجية السمعية والبصرية، ففي الباء بابان للمقصود الأوَّل من دون سائر الحروف فله استحقاق التقدُّم في كلام الهادي، فإنَّ ﴿الله يقول الحقُّ وهو يهدي السبيل﴾ [٣٣:٤].

ومن ذلك وجه كتابي في نظم ذوقي:

وهو أنَّ من التقسيمات الشارحة لحقائق الحروف كلّها هو التقسيم الذي للحرف عند اعتبار النقطة معها بحسب الظهور والخفاء ثمَّ بحسب [م١٢٣] الفوق والتحت ثمَّ بحسب التوحد والتكثُر. والنقطة هي صورة التعيّن الامتيازي والوجه الكوفي فكلَّ حرف جمعها وظهر معها ووجدها وأحاط بها وجعلها تحت حقيقته الوجودية، فهو التامُّ في الدلالة على كنه المرام ضرورة ظهور جهات المناسبة بين الدالِّ والمدلول، ولا يخفى أنَّ الباء قد احتوى هذه الجهات وتفرَّد بما جعل النقطة تحته بما لها من الوحدة على ما أشير إليه ما قيل (أنا النقطة التي تحت الباء). ثمَّ إنَّ انخفاض أمر النقطة واختفاء أحكامها يفيد ظهور دلالة الحرف على الجمعية الإطلاقيه التي لا صورة لها في الخارج أتمَّ من التنزيل القرآني، ويبيِّن أنَّ كلّما هو أظهر دلالة من الحروف يجب في نظر التعليم والتفهم تقديمه، فوجب تقديم الباء.

ومن ذلك وجه آخر كتابي في نظم حكيم:

وهو أنَّ من التقسيمات الواردة للحرف ما له باعتبار الحركة الرقمية التي هي مبدأ ظهوره، فإنَّ منها ما استُحصل من حركة إنزالية خطية من العلوِّ إلى السفلى كالألف، ومنها ما استُحصل من حركة انبساطية من اليمين إلى الشمال وبالعكس، وهذا القدر يكفيننا من هذا التقسيم واستيفاء الكلام في فنون التقسيمات ووجوه دلالاتها يُطلَّب من المفاحص. وصاحب الهيمنة بين الحروف الانبساطية هو الباء. ثمَّ إنَّ التنزيل القرآني له من مطلع تبشير فخره إلى منتهى أظهار أمره وتبيين أرقام سطره مراتب، منها علمية إجمالية ومنها تفصيلية إنزالية، وتمَّ هذه المراتب بظهوره على عبده محمدٍ صلى الله عليه وسلم، وله مراتبٌ آخر انبساطية عند إظهاره وإبلاغه الأمم، وأتمَّ هذه المراتب وأظهرها بين ظهرائي القوم هو المدوّن الكلامي والرقمي الكتابي الذي عند الناس. والواجب أن يكون صاحب التصدير والتقديم في هذا المدوّن ما له الهيمنة في الانبساط تيسيرا لأمر الإبلاغ وإرشاد الطريق [و]التعليم، فالباء هو الذي يجب أن يصدر به المدوّن المذكور، فإنَّه أبسط الحروف الانبساطية.

ومن ذلك وجه كتابي في نظم لبائي:

وهو أنَّ الحركة الإنزالية التي بها ظهر الألف إذا امتزجت بالحركة الانبساطية التي بها ظهر الباء حصل من امتزاجهما اللام الذي هو تمام التنزيل، فإنَّه ﴿آلَمْ﴾ [٢:١] الذي هو صاحب الصدارة في المرتبة الإنزالية. ولَمَّا كان اللام هو إجمال هذه الصورة ومقام التدوين والترتيب التعليمي إنمَّا يقتضي التفصيل الامتيازي، صُدِّر الباء الذي هو صورة تفصيل اللام، فلذلك ترى صورته الكاملة قلب صورة اللام:

ب

ومن ذلك وجه لبائي في نظم تنبيهي:

وهو أنه قد ظهر من هذا الوجه أن الأب له تقدّم من حيث الظهور التفصيلي، واللام له تقدّم من حيث البطون الإجمالي على ما قيل:

وَلَدْتُ أُمِّي أَبَاهَا إِنَّ ذَا مِنْ أَعْجَابٍ²

وصاحب الخصوصية الأولى هو الباء كما أن صاحب الخصوصية الأخرى هو الميم، فكما أن الميم له رتبة الصدارة مع أخويه في مرتبة الإنزال الإجمالي فللباء أن يصدر في مرتبة التدوين التفصيلي وفاءً بمقتضى التقابل في كفتي التوازن والتعادل على ما لا يخفى لدى اللبيب.

ومن ذلك وجه آخر لبائي في نظم حسائي:

وهو أن الحقائق إما أن تتعلق بالكثرة الأسائية أو بالوحدة الذاتية ليس شيء سوى هذين الطرفين يدلّ عليها بدلالة أو يشار إليها بإشارة. ويبيّن أن نهاية الكثرة هي الألف كما أن صورة الوحدة هي الواحد، والباء له دلالة في بعض بطونه القريبة إلى ذينك الطرفين، فله استحقاق التصدر عند ما يُساق الكلام إلى صوب الإبلّاع والتعليم، فإنّ تصدير الدلالة الإجمالية على المراد مقتضى ذلك المسلك على ما لا يخفى. وأمّا وجه دلالته ذلك فإنّه يدلّ عليه أوّل ما حُوسب اسم عدده بالعربي المبين كما ظهر في هذه الرقوم:

ب
ثمان
١٥٥

ومن ذلك وجه آخر لبائي في نظم حسائي:

وهو أن الألف الذي له الصدارة في أيّ جمعية وترتيب كان له صورة إجمالية وهي صورة مستماه وصوراً آخر تفصيلية متفاوتة حسب تفاوت الوجوه في الظهور والاختفاء، ثمّ أنّ أوّل صورة من تلك الصور هو الألف الذي هو امسه المعرب عن مستماه ومن صوره الكاشفة عن حقيقته هو بسم. ولذلك ترى نسبة النصفية والضعفية الكاشفة عن المثلية التي هي أقرب النسب إلى تبين المنتسب متحقّق في سائر أجزائه، وذلك لأنّ النسبة المذكورة هي نسبة الشبيه والمثل الذي يكشف عن وجوه التباس المشبّه والممثل على ما لا يخفى. ومن أراد لبيان ذلك شاهداً يفصح عنه فليشاهد هذه الرقوم:

الف
بسم

وليكن هذا آخر ما أردنا إيراداً في هذه الرسالة من الوجوه الحرفية. زادنا الله تعالى الإطلاع على مطاوي بطون الآيات ورزقنا التوفيق إلى إبراز تلك الحفّيات بحرمة من ختم باسمه الشريف خزائن الكمالات محمّد صلى الله عليه وعلى آله أجمعين.

تمّ في ١٤ رمضان سنة ٨٢٨ والسلام

م

² البيت منسوب إلى علي بن أبي طالب.

BACK MATTER

P.1: Edition of translated passages from the *Mafāḥiṣ*

1. *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, Introduction (MS Majlis 10196 ff. 52b-57a [م], MS Esad Efendi 1731 ff. 1a-208b

[أس]:

بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم وبه نستعين وعليه نتوكل

الحمد لله الذي أعد عديد عبادته لفهم كمال مراده بإنزال أعداد بينات الكتاب وجعله الغدة المعتد بها لمعرفة معاده يوم الحساب وأبان بمعدودية أيامه ميعاد أعياد قربه ونفي بعباده على نهج الصواب وبيّن بها مدارج عبيده فيه بحسب ما لها من الإحساب والصلوة على محمد خير من أوتي الحكمة وفصل الخطاب وعلى آله وصحبه هداة شوارع الإيقان القائدين إلى مناهل أوراد أولي الألباب. **أما بعد:** فإن العلوم الإلهية على اختلاف طرقها وتباعد مذاهبها أجل ما بعثته الهمة واقصى ما يُساق إليه جياذ الطبائع اللهم¹ ولكن الذي تباينت فيه الرتب واستباقت في ميادين تناضله وتفاضله نجائب الركب ما لا يتطرق في طريقه وسواس الشبه المضلة ويهدي نحوه طوارق ثواقب النواميس المنزلة طالعة من أفق الإفصاح والبيان ساطعة من أثمار أرقافها أنوار الإيضاح والتبيان فائضة من ساء [أس ١٢] سموها وسناها سائر سائر السائرين بارزة من أرض دنوها ونماها خصائص جملة الصائرين.

رأيت سعودا من شعوب كثيرة ولم أر سعدا مثل سعد بن مالك²

فإن ذلك هو الذي بسط الله به في دار إسلامه سباط كلامه فأنعم على عبيده فنون ما نبئت به ورثته أراضي استعداداتهم في ولائم لوازمهم وغذاهم بما يقوّمهم ويُعدهم إلى بلوغ كمالهم من موحّات حوائج حواميمهم ثم رواهم بما يُحييهم حياةً سرمديّة في طاسات طواسينه من تسنيمه وكثيرا ما توجه نحو الإحتذاء به البارعون في الكمال من كلّ هُمام فحل من عطاء هذه الأمة ممن لا يسكنُ نهم همتهم بقدائد مخلفات الغابرين من كلّ أحد بل يسعى في طلب طرايا الحقائق اليانعة على أفنان أحياء كل زمان إلى الأبد. فمنهم من قصد نحو مشارق البسط والظهور وفاز باقتطاف يوانع الأثمار من أعالي شجرة ظهوره الكلامي³ قاصرا عليه مغتذاه حاصرا فيه غاية مبتغاه، ومنهم من انتحى صوب مغرب القبض والحفاء وسعدَ باكتناز يتائم الدرر عن أسافل زواجر بروزه الكتابي، ولعمري هم

¹ أس حاشية: اللهم مثل الخضم العظيم ورجل لهم كثير العطاء.

² البيت لطرفة بن العبد من قصيدة (قفي ودّعينا اليوم يا ابنه مالك): فلم تر عيني مثل سعد بن مالك.

³ أس حاشية: قوله الكلامي أراد به مقام الفرق لأنه من الكلم وهو الجرح والجرح فيه التفريق لهما؛ أراد بالكتاني مقام الجمع لأنه من كتبت البعلة جمعت بين شفرهما كما صرح به [المصنف] في شرح الفصوص.

الفائزون بوراثه خصائص الحضرة الختمية وما تركته للأقربين من تلائدها المتلوة التي ورثتها من آباءها الغر وأطرافها الكرام أعني الكلام القديم الذي ﴿علمه شديد القوى ذو مرة فاستوى﴾ [٥٣:٥-٦]، ومن طرائفها المستطرفة التي عندها من يوانع الجنان الختمية وهو الكتاب [أس٢ب] الحديث الذي قرأه من لوح ﴿أوحى إلى عبده ما أوحى﴾ [٥٣:١٠] جزاهم الله عتاً أحسن ما جُزي مفيد عن مستفيده.

ولكن لما قصرُوا سبيل الاستفاضة على هذين الطرفين اللذين من كرائم أموالها على قارعة الطريق ذهبوا عن الثالث الذي هو الأطراف^٥ المعززة^٦ الذي فيه فتح باب عين الصواب (٩٩)^٧ لما أتته في مخازن عزها وحجى قريبا من عقود [م١٥٣] فرائد الجواهر وسائر ما في عداد غدتها مما جمعه وعدده لولده الذي هو خاتم الولاية ورافع ألوية الدراية والهداية وتلك العقود هي العقود العددية التي هي الصورة المعنوية العقلية التي للكتاب المنزل من القلم الأعلى إلى اللوح الكريم فإن العدد هو الغدة العظمى في استحصال علوم جمّة كثيرة الجدوى عديد الحصى والثرى فإنه هو المعدن الأصلي للجواهر المخزونة من مُجهرات العلوم وجلالها المتلبسة في مدارك ذوي الرسوم والاصطلاحات بحجب الأوصاف الوضعية والأسماء الجعلية التي سَمَوْها هم وآباؤهم ﴿ما أنزل الله بها من سلطان﴾ [١٢:٤٠، ٥٣:٢٣]، وأمّا الآيات الدالة على جلالة أمر العدد وعظم شأنه فكثيرة متعددة عن حدِّ العدِّ بقسميها فإن منها آيات منزلة مساوية متلوة وآيات بارزة أرضية تالفة أما الأولى فما تراه من أنه هو الناعت المظهر للعطاء الإلهي بإطلاقه في قوله تعالى ﴿جزاء من رثك عطاء حسابا﴾ [٧٨:٣٦] كما أنه هو الذي إنما تفتح بإحصائه أبواب الجنان على ما ورد (إنَّ لله تسعةً وتسعين اسماً مائةً إلّا واحدةً من أحصاها دخل الجنة)^٨ [أس١٣] وتبته إليه حيث أكدّه بقوله (مائة إلّا واحدة) وذلك هو الذي على حوض وضوحه وكوثر كثراته المتكوثرة وقَفَ يفرّق الخاتم في الساعة بأكواب الفضة على يد علي من أهل بيته لذوي قربه ودتوه من كلِّ أهلٍ متعطّش الأكباد شائق الفؤاد ماء لا يظمأ أبداً من شرب منه شربةً أو اغترف غرفةً.

عطا اعداد
١٥ ١٥
علي لف
١٥ ١٥

تباعد ما بين السحاب وبينه فنائلها قَطُرٌ ونائله غَمَرٌ^٩

هذي^{١٠} المناقبُ لا قعبانٍ من لَبَنٍ^{١١}

وأمّا الثانية التالية منها فما تشاهده من أنه القرن^{١٢} الذي جُمع فيه سائر الصور ولأمر ما ترى الشعائر الشرعية المشعرة والأوضاع النبوية المنبئة قد ابثنيت قواعد ظهورها على معاهد عقودها وأنزلت صورها الكاشفة عن كنه الكلِّ مُفرغةً على قالب ضبطه

^٤ أس: اللذين هما من.

^٥ أس: الاطراف.

^٦ م أس حاشية: مقتبس من قوله تعالى ﴿فَعَزَّزْنَا بِثَالِثٍ﴾ [٣٦:١٤].

^٧ أس حاشية: الصواب ظاهره تسع وتسعون وكأنه إشارة إلى أسماء الإحصاء.

^٨ البخاري، صحيح، كتاب التوحيد، باب إنَّ لله مائة اسم إلا واحداً (١٢)، حديث ٧٣٩٢.

^٩ البيت للمنتبي، قصيدة (أريثك أم ماء الغمامة أم حَمَز).

^{١٠} م: هذا.

^{١١} البيت لأمية بن أبي الصلت الثقفي، فكله: تلك المكارم لا قعبان من لبن ١ شيبا بماء فعادا بعد أبوالا (= م أس حاشية). م حاشية: إشارة إلى التسمين.

وحودده فإنه لو غُطِّل الصلاة أو الزكاة أو غير ذلك من الشعائر المعظمة عن عقود العدد وجواهره المُجَهَّر بها للعامة لما حصل لها في مجالي العيان عين ولا أثر ولا زُويٍّ منها ذكر ولا خبر بل لو استقرئ سائر الصنائع الجزئية والحِرَف المدنية والمواضع الخطائية والمعاملات العرفية التي عليها مباني اتساق منازم الأسواق وبها مرابط جوامع الصوامع وسائر المجامع على الإطلاق لوجد الكلّ صور تنوّعاته ومواطن بسطه وفنون تقلّباته إذ لم توجد جمعيةٌ علمية خالية عن جليّ جمعه وتقسيمه ولا هيئةٌ عينية عارية عن ملابس نظمه [أس٣ب] وتفصيله. وأني من عنفوان الزمان وريعان الشباب مُشَوَّر عن ساق السعي في طلب الكمال الأصلي والعلوم الحقيقية شاكراً عليه لا متبجحاً به مفتش عنه في طيّ طروق البلاد ومطاوي قلوب العباد إلى أن لفظني لطائف التوفيقات الرثائية والتأييدات الصمدانية في رُفَقَةِ اخضهم أخي في الله شرف الدين علي اليزدي إلى مصر الولاية والهداية أعني السدة السنية السيّدية سلام الله على آبائه الكرام وعليه، ووقعْتُ منها في ظلّ نعمةٍ لم تكن من قبل للهادي ولا للرشيد،

كأنّا من بشاشتنا ظللنا بيوم ليس من هذا الزمان¹³

[م٥٣ب] إذ قد أُفيض عليّ في طيّ إشاراته الكريمة ما زادت رشتاً كماله سجال مسؤولي واستفدتُ من مُطِيفي سراق جلاله ما فاق أفابوق مأمولي جزاهم¹⁴ الله عتاً فوق كلّ جزاء يرجى للمقرّين من العبيد، وإذ قد كثُر في غالب الأحيان مفتشاً عن توالييف¹⁵ السالفين من أئمة أهل الحقّ والتوحيد متنقلاً عند انتظام مجالس الذوق بأطياب مكشفاتهم ولطائف مرموزاتهم على ما قيل:

إذا ما ظمئتُ إلى ريقه جعلت المدامة منه بديلاً
وأين المدامة من ريقه ولكن أُعلِّلُ قلباً عليلاً¹⁶

ما رأيْتُ فيما اشتهر بين الأنام مثل مؤلّفات الشيخين الحِصَمَيْنِ قدّس الله [أس٤أ] تعالى¹⁷ سرّها محيياً ناشراً لأصول الحكمة العلية بمباديها وغاياتها وسعداً طالعا عن أفق التحقيق كاشفاً عن آياته الكتابية وجوه رمزها وإشاراتها. ثمّ إذ صادفتُ رفقائي كلّما أُرزُّ لهم من ذخائر نفائس هذا العقد ونظمه أسُتُطِروا شوقاً إلى ثبته وضبطه حداني قهرمان الزمان وما هو عليه من إحكام بنیان الإظهار وإظهار أحكام البيان أن أشير إلى أصول جامعة تهدي إلى طرق الرشاد نحو مخازن إشارات الكتاب بفنون مذهبها وشُعابها حتّى يتفطن له اللبيب فيتمكّن منه أن يأتي البيوت من أبوابها ويتدرّج في معارج ذلك المنهج ومراقي بطونه وفتح أبوابها من لبها إلى لبابها تلميظاً للطالبين من موائد عقائق الوقت وطباخ خصائصه أتيا ببعض ما يجب عليّ من الشكر.

¹² أس حاشية: القرن هو الذي ينفخ فيه إسرافيل وهو هنا كناية عن العدد والصور هي مراتب الأعداد.

¹³ البيت لابن المعتز.

¹⁴ أس: أدام الله علينا فيضهم العتيد وجزاهم.

¹⁵ أس: تآليف.

¹⁶ البيت لابن المعتز.

¹⁷ أس: (تعالى) سقطت.

فعلهم أولاً تحليّة ذاتيّة إدراكهم عن مآلوفاتهم العادية ممّا نضجته نيران شوقهم في قدور الطنّ والتخمين متّوّلاً بمخدرات أباير تقليد الغابرين ثمّ التوجّه ثانياً إلى صوب صوابه وفتح عقوده وأبوابه بجوامع الهمة وخلوص النية وإمّا أريد من أولئك كلّ ذي دُرّة بأساليب الاستدلالات مرتاض النظر بترمّض طبّاء الذوق في مراعي الصدق واليقين ريّض النفس بين يدي الغالبين البالغين يقظان القريحة ذاك الملحّة وإن دقّ شأنها منتبّها على الرمزة وإن خفي مكانها ﴿وقليلٌ ما هم﴾ [٢٤:٣٨]، وبين أنّ [أس٤ب] ذهب طريق التعليم والسلوك نحو مسالك الضبط والتفهيم إمّا يوجب التزام ما تعاور بين المنتمين إلى طلب الكمال الإنساني المشتمرين عن ساق جدّم لدى الارتقاء عن خضيض تقاليدات العامة إلى أوج الشروع في الشعور العياني الإيقاني وأنهم وإن تكاثرت شعوبهم بين الأمم حسب تخالف درجاتهم وتفاوت همهم وتباينهم ولكن أجلاهم طريقاً وأقواهم نسبة إلى استئناس نفوس العامة هو طريق النظر العقلي والفكر الآلي ما لم تعتسف عن شارع جمعيته الذوقية إلى أطرافه التي هي مشتبك شوك الشكوك النظرية فحريّ بنا عندما جرّدنا لتفهيم شوارد الحقائق وتلميط المسترشدين من بدائع يوانع الزمان ما لم تستأنس ذاتيّة مدارك الأكثرين منهم بها أن نأخذ بطرف من مصطلحاتهم الناطمة وقواعدهم الضابطة.

(١) فحص حكيم في نظم نظري

لا يخفى أنّ النظم التأليفي إمّا تتكامل الصورة الجمعية منه إذا كان سوق الكلام فيه على نهج قويم تحكم بصحّته [م٥٢٢] قوائم الميزان وتدلّ على استقامته قوانين صحيح البرهان إذ بها تقوم على انتصاب قامتها قواعد الإيقان وعليها مباني تعليم العلوم وإظهارها لدى التبيان، وذلك أنّ المزاج الجعلي الذي به قوام بدن التدوين ومنه قيام نظامه إمّا يتحصّل من أصول أربعة هي بمنزلة الأركان الأربعة المكملة للكلّ الوجودي أولاً وللكمال العلمي الشهودي ثانياً وذلك التكميل هو المعدّل لذلك [أس١٥] الكمال أن يبرز عن كنه كونه بصورته المعقولة وكسوته الملفوظة والمكتوبة.

أولها الموضوع وهو الذي أسست¹⁹ عليه معالم بيان ذلك العلم ومنه تنشعب فروع أحكامه وفنون أبحاثه وذلك في علمنا هذا هو الواحد من حيث أنّه واحد بأيّ صورة ظهر بها من فنون دلالاته وصنوف إشاراته وإذ قد تبين وجه شموله وفضل اشتماله على الوجود ظهر علوّه المطلق بالنسبة إلى سائر العلوم.

وثانيها المسائل وهو الذي به ظهر وجه إثباته لدى التحصيل وعليه يقوم أمر إظهاره واستكشافه لدى الفحص والتفتيش وذلك فيما نحن بصددّه عبارة عن إظهار ما للواحد الحقيقي من الأساء الكاشفة عن وجوه تنزلاته الوجودية وتنزلاته الحكمية العقلية وإنزالاته الكتابية الذوقية.

وثالثها المبادي وهو الذي به تستحصل²⁰ تلك الصورة الجمعية المظهرة لتلك الوجوه من التصوّرات الموصلة إلى حقائق تنوّعات الواحد والتصديقات المؤيّدة لإثبات أحكامه وأقسامه الكاشفة عن خصائص الكلّ وآثاره وذلك في هذا الفنّ هو تحقيق معنى الواحد بأقسامه وتبيين صورها الكاشفة عنه بفنون أنواعه وأحكامها منها عقلية عديدة طالعة عن أرض الاستعدادات الأصلية ومنها حسّية كتابية هابطة نازلة من سماء القدس والوهاب وهاتان الصورتان ممّا اشتمل عليه بعض معاني (طه) ويشهد

¹⁸ المصراع للمتنبي من قصيدة (أجاب دمي وما التاعي سوى ظلّل)؛ البيت كلّ: أيّا المحبّين المشكّور من حمّي والشكر من قبل الإحسان لا قبلي.

¹⁹ م أس: أسس.

²⁰ أس: تستحصل.

على دلالة ذلك²¹ شهود المناسبات منها أنّ ط تمام مراتب الطالع [أس ٥ب] كما أنّ ه تمام مدارك الهابط وأتم مجالي ظهوره كما ستطلع على وجه تحقيقه.

ورابعها الغاية وهو الذي لأجله شرع السالك وخاض في مناهج طلب تلك الصورة الكمالية واليه تنتهي مراقي وجدانه وذلك ههنا عبارة عن النقطة التامة من الكلمة الكمالية²² التي إليها ينتهي مبلغ مراقي المراد الحقيقي في أمر إظهاره على كافة البلاد وعامة العباد بقدر ما حكم به الوقت ونقده الزمان على مشاعر الإيقان ومجالي العيان وذلك إتما يتصور بظهور تمام العلم وكمال القدرة فيما هو المراد من نظم سلسلة الظهور والإظهار و ربطه بعقود الشعور والإشعار أعني الخاتم العربي محمد صلى الله عليه وسلم ومما احتوت²³ عليه معاني (قل) هو الإشارة إلى تينك المرتبتين فإنّ قاف إشارة إلى القدرة ولام إلى العلم وستقف على وجوه تلك الإشارة وما أفصحت عنه بفنون ألسنتها بعد ضبط المبادي.

(٢) فخص منه

اعلم أنّ العلم الحاصل للعبد كائنا من كان لا يخلو أمر ظهوره لديه عن قسمين فإنّ اكتسابه واستحصله مقصور على طريقين إثنين. أحدهما هي الصور الكونية الحاجة والمدارك البشرية الحاصرة بما لها من القوى النظرية الاستعراضية وبما عندها [م ٥٤ب] من المقدمات اليقينية الشعرية والخطائية، ومالك أزمة هذا الطريق وصاحب الحلّ والعقد فيه هو العقل القدسي والمستحصل به من العلوم إتما هو العقود الاعتقادية والحدود المحصورة [أس ٦أ] الاعتيادية تحقيقاً للمناسبة التي للفروع إلى أصولها والمشابهة التي للولد بأبويه وطريق اكتساب العلوم الرسمية مطلقاً والمعارف النظرية مقصور على هذا وفي لفظي العقل والعقد ما يلوحك على سرّه وأصل هذا الطريق هو الذي سلك فيه الملاء الأعلى بأقدام التسييح والتقديس وبعض من يجري مجراهم من أولاد آدم. والثاني هي الصور الوجودية الكاشفة والمشاعر الإنسانية وشوارعها الواسعة بما لها من الأحدية الجمعية الإطلاقية وبما عندها من الصور المنزلة السماوية والعقود الأصلية الاستعدادية ومالك أزمة هذا الطريق هو القلب الإنساني الذي هو صورة الحقيقة الوجودية الآدمية التي بها صار الإنسان خليفة على الخليقة كلها ومنها فاق الملاء الأعلى جُلّها والحاصل به إتما هو انشراح علمي وانسباط وجودي كشمي تحقيقاً للمناسبة والمشابهة المذكورتين وهذا طريق أبناء آدم من الأنبياء والأولياء ثم أنّ تلك الصور الوجودية الكاشفة متفاوتة لدى الإفصاح عن المقصود والإعراب عن المراد حقّه وصاحب التمام في ذلك الأمر إتما هو الصور المنزلة المرسل بها الخاتم العربي محمد صلوات الله وسلامه عليه وعلى آله أجمعين، وكذلك العقود الأصلية الاستعدادية إتما تتبين بتلك الصور حقّ التبيين وإلّا فما كان للإنسان من حيث أنّه آدمي أن يكشف عن الأمر كنهه فإنّ الذي له من حيث هو كذلك هو الوجه العقدي العقلي [أس ٦ب] المستحصل من طريقه لا غير وذلك بمعزل عن أن يوصل به إلى مزارع التحقيق ومنابع الإيقان كما قال تعالى ﴿ما كنت تدري ما الكتاب ولا الإيمان﴾ [٤٢: ٥٢] الآية.

²¹ أس: دلالة على ذلك.

²² م أس حاشية: وتوضيح هذا الكلام أنّ الكلمة الكمالية عبارة عن الحروف المنزلة التي أرسل بها الأنبياء لإرشاد الأم وهدايتهم، وأنّ المراد من المراد الحقيقي هو الأنبياء، فإنّ سائر الموجودات وإن كانت مرادة ولكن بالبعية والاستطراد. ثم اعلم أنّ للمراد المذكور ترقياً في إنزال تلك الكلمة عليه وإبلاغه إلى الأم بحسب تفاوت استعداداتهم وأزمتهم إلى أن وصل إلى النقطة التامة من تلك الكلمة الكاشفة عن تمام العلم وكمال القدرة وهي المنزلة على الخاتم صلوات الله وسلامه عليه وعلى آله أجمعين.

²³ م أس: احتوى.

فلا بدّ لمن أراد فهم المراد من الدلالات والإشارات الحرفية من تخلية محلّ إدراكه عن سائر متعارفاته [أس٧ب] من العامية المأخوذة في طيّ مخاطباته مع بني نوعه مطلقاً²⁷ والخاصية المأخوذة في طيّ اكتساباته ومقاولاته مع من هو أعلى منه في ذلك ويندرج فيه سائر المصطلحات الرسمية والمقبولات الاعتقادية. فالمتعارفات الثلاث التي لا تُفهم المعاني من الصور المذكورة إلا بعد أن تحتفّ بها هو المشار إليه مع ما لها في مراتبها من القرب والبعد.

ثمّ اعلم أنّ هذا المعنى أنهى ما يتنزّل به إلى مدارك المسترشدين ممّا ساق النظم التأليفي إليه فإنّ في طيّ هذه الإشارة حكماً جمّة منها وجهٌ ظاهر إحصائي يفصح لسانه عن بيان ما ورد في الصحيح: (إنّ القرآن أنزل على سبعة أحرّف). وذلك لو تدبّر في هذه الإشارة الظاهرة من الأرقام الختمية التي انشقت بها أرقام الحقائق في سماء المعاني إلى غير ذلك من الحكم الجليلة فلا تغفل.

(٢) فحص إحصائي في نظم حكي

كأنّك لا تتوقّف بما عندك من الأصول الحكيمة في أنّ الصور التي ظهر الواحد بها عند تنزلاته الظهورية وتنزلاته الإظهارية كلّما اختفى فيها حكم التقابل الذي إنّما يتعاكس الحجب الكونية في العوالم الإمكانية من أشعة آثاره فهو الصالح لأمر إظهاره²⁸ والمتفرد بأن يكون مبدأ للشعور منه وإشعاره عند استيلاد معنى المراد له وأسراره. ولا يخفى على المتصفح صور تنوّعات الواحد جملة أنّه ليس بينها ما يصلح لذلك صلوح الثلاثة، ومن ثمة لا يتحقّق التوالد حيث ما كان²⁹ إلاّ بها فلذلك ترى الصور المرسل بها إنّما تظهر [أس٨و] عند تنزيلها من سماء علوّها وإطلاقها بها لا غير ثمّ إذا حوسبت³⁰ الشعورية منها مع الإشعارية صارت ستة على ما أفصح عنه لسان الإشارة المذكورة آنفاً. وأمّا وجه تحقيق الحصر في الثلاثة³¹ فإنّ لها صورة كلامية³² في الهواء عند تمّوجه في الخارج الواقعة بين البطن والظهر إنّما يدركها السمع، ولها صورة أخرى كتابية في الضياء عند تقلّبات ارتساماتها بين السواد والبياض [أس٥٥ب] إنّما يدركها البصر³³، ولها ضرب آخر من الصورة وهي العقلية³⁴ المعنوية الظاهرة في حقائق الأشياء أنفسها عند تنوّعات ظهورها بين الوجود والعدم إنّما يدركها القلب المعبر عنه في لسان الشريعة بالفؤاد³⁵، ومن ثمة ترى المشاعر الثلاثة

²⁷ أس حاشية: أن سواء كان المخاطب أعلى منه أو أدنى أو مساوياً كما تدلّ عليه المقابلة.

²⁸ م حاشية: كما ظهر في المواليد الثلاثة... كلّما كان تكثّر سورة التضاد واختفاء حكم تقابل العناصر في امتزاجها أكثر كان ظهوراً بواحد فيها أظهر فترقى من الكيفية المتشابهة المسماة بالمزاج إلى النفس النباتية ومنها إلى الحيوانية ومنها إلى الإنسانية التي هي مبدأ الشعور والإشعار.

²⁹ أس حاشية: قوله "حيث ما كان" أي سواء كان في الظهور كما في تثليث الفاعل من الذات والإرادة و﴿كن﴾، وكذا تثليث القابل من الماهية والسباع والامتنال، أو في الإظهار كما في الحدّ الأصغر والأوسط والأكبر للنتيجة وتماه في الفض الشيعي. [هذا غير صحيح - راجع فصوص الحكم، الفض الصالح، ص ١١٥ (عفيفي).]

³⁰ م أس: حوسب.

³¹ م حاشية: هي آلات التناسل أو الزوجان والولد (ع٥).

³² م حاشية: مظهر الصورة الكلامية اللسان في عالم الكون ومدرّكها السمع في عالم الوجدان (ع٥).

³³ م حاشية: مظهرها اليد في الكون وفي الوجدان والإدراك البصر (ع٥).

³⁴ م حاشية: مظهرها في الكون والوجدان واحد بخلاف صورتين الآخرين (ع٥).

³⁵ م حاشية: الله : الملك : والرسول :: القلب : واللسان : واليد :: فؤاد :: سمع : بصر.

في العبارة الحتمية القرآنية منخرطاً ذكرها في سلك منفضاً أمرها في طي ما أنعم على العباد من بين فنون نعمه العظام وآلائه الجسام حيث استقلّ الشكر في مقابلها وجعلها أعلى شأنًا من أن يكون فعلٌ من العبد بإزائها يؤدي واجب ثنائها، منها قوله تعالى ﴿وجعل لكم السمع والأبصار والأفئدة قليلاً ما تشكرون﴾ [٢٣: ٩، ٢٣: ٦٧] وقوله ﴿وهو الذي أنشأ لكم السمع والأبصار والأفئدة قليلاً ما تشكرون﴾ [٢٣: ٧٨]. فإنّ هذه المشاعر الشاعرة هي الكمال المترتب على نفخ الروح الإضافي في مستعدّه وذلك الكمال هو الذي أبرزه من مستجّن الغيب والبطون إلى مستجلى الشهادة والظهور كما ظهر من الآية الأولى لمن تدبّر فيها حيث قال تعالى ﴿ونفخ فيه من روحه﴾ [أس ٨ب] وجعل لكم السمع والأبصار والأفئدة قليلاً ما تشكرون﴾ [٩: ٣٢] وحيث جعلها بين النعم هي المسؤول عنه في قوله تعالى ﴿إنّ السمع والبصر والفؤاد كلّ أولئك كان عنه مسؤولاً﴾ [١٧: ٣٦]. فلذلك جعلنا الكلام في هذا الكتاب مقصوراً على ثلاث صحائف مصدراً بمقدّمة هي هذه ومختوماً بخاتمة هي الصحيفة الرابعة المعرّبة عن الوجوه الثلاثة بخصائص أحكام كلّ منها كما سيجيء الكلام فيها إن شاء الله تعالى.

٥) فحص حكيم منها في نظم نظري

اعلم أنّ موضوع العلم الأعلى المسمّى بالحكمة المطلقة والفلسفة الأولى عند المتأخّرين هو الموجود المطلق بما هو موجود، وذلك لأنّه ليس عندهم من المعاني المتعاطرة لديهم ما يجمع شتات المقولات جمعه. فإنّ الأعيان المبحوث عنها في الحكمة المطلقة بعضها جواهر وبعضها كمّيات وبعضها مقولات أخرى وليس يمكن أن يعمّها معنى محقق إلّا حقيقة معنى الوجود، فهو الذي يصلح لأن يوضع لمعاقد تلك الأبحاث موضوعاً مشتركاً تكون هي كلّها حالاته وعوارضه. ويبيّن أنّ الوجود وإن كان له ضرب من العموم والإحاطة ولكن ليس تماً يحيط بمقابله³⁶ إحاطةً جمعيةً وشمولاً بحيث تتساوي في ميزان جمعيته كقنّتا المتقابلين اللذين تحته، فإنّه لا يصدق على المعدومات والممتنعات³⁷ صدقه على الموجودات وله انحرافٌ عن استقامة طريق الجمعية واعوجاجٌ عن قويم سنّها. فلا يصلح لموضوعية الحكمة المطلقة التي قد جرّدنا في كتابنا هذا للبحث [أس ١٩] عنها صلوح ما له تلك الاستقامة وذلك هو الحرف بإطلاقه، فإنّه هو الذي قد أحاط بسائر المتقابلات من الموجودات والمعدومات والممتنعات إحاطةً جمعيةً واستوى على الكلّ استواء استقامة وجودية وعلمية بحيث لا يكون له ميلان إلى أحد المتقابلين بوجه ولا انحراف عن منهج الاعتدال أصلاً ولا اعوجاج على ما أفصح عنه قوله تعالى ﴿الحمد لله الذي أنزل على عبده الكتاب ولم يجعل له عوجاً﴾ [١٨: ١]. لا يقال كيف يتصوّر عموم الحرف وهو تحت مقولة الكيف طي أحد نوعيه فإنّ المراد بالحرف في كلامنا هذا هو الصورة المتزلة من ساء غيب الهوية الفاتحة لأبواب الوجود مطلقاً من مطلع ظهوره إلى استواء [م ١٥٦] إظهاره بكلمتها التامة المسماة في عرف ذوي الرسوم بالناقصة فهو المبدأ المستقرّ القائم بذاته المقوم للموجودات كلّها وفي نظرهم هو الفرع المستحيل الذي يتقوم بمستحيل آخر مثله مندرجاً تحت أحد من جزئيات المقولات التي هي في طي الموجود فلا ينبغي للمتيقّظ أن يلتفت إلى تلك المصطلحات الرسمية والعمليات الاعترافية التي ما أنزل الله بها من سلطان إلّا على طريق المخالفة ومسلك المجانبة.

فعاد دواعي القيل والقال وانح من عوادي دعاوي صدقها قصدُ سُمعة

³⁶ أس: مقابلة.

³⁷ م حاشية: وإن صدق عليها باعتبار وجودها في ذهن.

فنتبين أنه إذا نَرَهنا النظر عن الاختلافات الرسمية والمجملات الاعتيادية وقصدنا نحو [أس ٩ب] تحصيل ما يصلح لأن يكون موضوعاً للعلم الأعلى والحكمة المطلقة ما وجدنا لذلك ما له صلوح الحرف ومبدئه أعني النقطة وينبغي أن تعلم أنها ههنا ليست الأطراف المتوَهمة على ما هو المتعارف عند أهل الرسوم بل هي الأصل الفاتح والمبدأ للكل من حيث هو كذلك مقدّساً عن دلالة ما يدلّ عليه أو إشارة ما يشير إليه على ما أفصح عنه جواب الإمام عليه السلام لتكميل عندما سأل عن الحقيقة أنه (كشف سبحات الجلال من غير إشارة) وتام تلخيص هذا الكلام أنّ الواحد الحقيقي هو المرجع الأصلي لهذا البحث ولكن لم يتبين أحكام تنوعاته المعبر عنها بالسبع المثاني والقرآن العظيم [١٥: ٨٧] ولم يتمكّن من أن يكون عرضة للإبانة والإشعار وعُلقة للتدوين والتأليف الذي هو موطن البحث والاستفسار ما لم يتنزل الواحد هذا إلى الصور الثلاث ذوات الأوضاع والأشكال في هذه المشاعر الثلاثة التي هي للإنسان وذلك هو المستمى بالحرف الذي هو موضوع علمنا هذا.

وإذا تقرّر هذا ظهر لك أن العلم الباحث عن هذا الموضوع هو الحكمة التي هي أفضل علم بأفضل معلوم وذلك أيضاً هو الذي يفيد معرفة الأسباب القصوى للكل وله حدّ العلم الإلهي الذي عند الحكماء الرسمية وهو أنه علم بالأمر المفارقة للمادة في الحدّ والوجود فإنّ الحرف والنقطة وما يتبعهما من الأحكام واللوازم المتفرّعة³⁸ [أس ١٠أ] عنها ليس شيء منها كما اتضح إلّا متقدّم الوجود على المادة وغير متعلّق الوجود بوجودها وإن بُحث في هذا العلم عمّا لا يتقدّم المادة فإنّما يُبحث فيه عن ذلك المعنى من حيث أنه غير محتاج الوجود إلى المادة وذلك غير خفي على الواقف بما تمّدها آفاً والذي يؤيّد هذا ما حقّقه ربيب الإمام الصادق³⁹ في كتابه المستمى بالخمسين حيث قال (إن الخطّ والنقطة من طريق جوهر ومن طريق عرض فإنّها إن أخذت من طريق أنها موجودة للأطراف أو أخذت من حدّها معنى الإضافة كانت عرضاً وإن أخذت بأنّها في ذاتها غير ذات بُعد كانت جوهرًا وإن حملت من الجواهر على ما لا بعد له ولا حدّ كانت نفساً أو عقلاً [أو لاها ؟] أو غير ذلك) وأيضاً⁴⁰ قال فيه (إنّ الكلام الأول لا يشبه هذا الكلام لأن الكلام عند النفس أتمّ وأوضح وأبين وأنور وأشرق على حسب ما هناك من جِام التمييز ووفور أدوات العلوم لأنّه بالكلّ ولأنّ الذي ههنا بالجزء ولأنّ ذلك غير مشوب بشيء وهذا مشوب بالكون).

٦) فخص كتابي متم

كما أنّ الواحد عند الظهور في مرايا الحجب والنسب له وجهان، أحدهما أنّه مبدأ الكلّ⁴¹ أعني الحقيقة من حيث هي هي [٥٦م] وهو بهذا الاعتبار لا يصلح لأن يدلّ عليه بدلالة لا يشار إليه بإشارة كما عرفت وهو غاية البطون والخفاء، والآخر أنّه منتهى الكلّ أعني التعيّن الشخصي الذي به ظهر في الخارج ما ظهر وذلك هو النهاية في الظهور والجلاء [أس ١٠ب]. كذلك النقطة التي هي الدالة عليه لها هذان الوجهان في طرف الإظهار، أحدهما أنّها مبدأ الحرف والخطّ كلّ ففي هذا الاعتبار بمعزل عن الدلالة عليها أو الإشارة إليها كما أومي إليه، والآخر أنّه منتهى الكلّ أعني مبدأ التميّز الشخصي مفيد العلم بكلّ حرف وخصوصيته

³⁸ أس: المتنوعة.

³⁹ م حاشية: جابر الحيان. أس حاشية: ربيب الإمام جعفر الصادق هو جابر بن حيان [الأزدي] تلميذ لحري الجيني ثم للإمام الصادق، وله خمسة آلاف كتابة في الحكمة والصنعة كما نقله صلاح الدين الحلبي في كتابه المشتمل على معرفة النفس والصنعة.

⁴⁰ م: (حاشية) فوق وأيضاً.

⁴¹ م حاشية: اعلم أنّ المراد بالمبدئية ههنا أن يكون في تلك المرتبة قوّة ظهور الكلّ فلا بدّ وأن يكون معزّاة عن سائر النسب وأمّا التعبير عنها بالمبدأ فلضيق لسان العبارة ههنا فلذلك فسر بقوله أعني الحقيقة من حيث هي هي.

العينية الظاهر هو بها في الخارج كما هو المشاهد في الرقوم الكتائية وإلى ذينك الوجهين⁴² أشير بقوله (العلم نقطة كثرتها جمل الجاهلين).

٧) فخص ذوقي منه في نظم حكلي

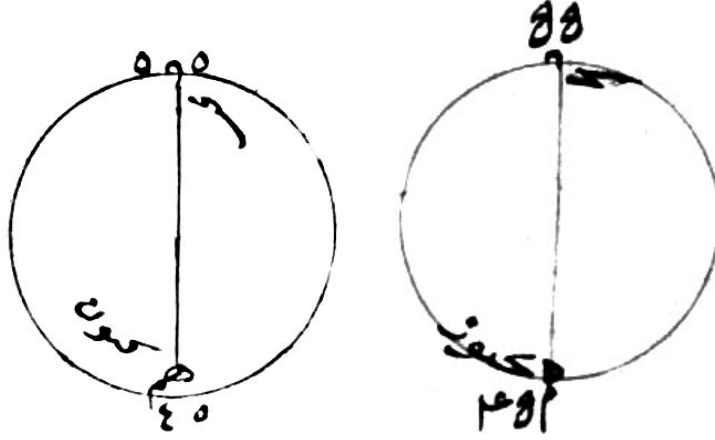
اعلم أنّ ذلك المبدأ الفاتح المذكور قد عبّر كلّ من أهل التحقيق بما يناسب مسلكه ويطابق مقصده ومدركه فإنّ المتأخرين منهم من جعله العشق الذي هو شدّة الحبّ بناءً على أنّ ميلان ذلك السرّ الفاتح نحو التنزّل إلى تنوّعات المراتب والعوالم إذا اشتدّ وخرج من مكامن القوة إلى مشاهد الفعل وتدرّج في الظهور بالجمالي والمنصّات صار به محلّ احتضاء السالكين صوب مسالك الكمال الإنساني فكان من حيثيته المذكورة موضوع إشاراتهم ومدلول عباراتهم ومن ههنا ترى أنّهم ما يصل إليه جياد أدواقهم عند طيّ المقامات الشهودية هو الحبّ فلهم في وضع ذلك الاصطلاح وإطلاقهم عليه إشارة إلى [أس ١١] تحقيق مبادئ المعاد وتبيين أمر المراد كما ستطالع عليه ثمّ أنّهم أيضاً في إطلاق ذلك اللفظ على طبقات متفاوتة حسب ما لهم من المراتب التي لأهل الذوق عند بلوغهم أقاصي ما قدر لهم في ذلك وتحقيق ذلك أنّ المبدأ الفاتح المذكور إذا ظهر بتنوّعاته المتباينة التي للمراتب والعوالم حصل له في كلّ منها طرفان أحدهما وهو الظاهر منها هو متعلّق الظهور والإظهار وعبر عنه عندهم بالمحبوبة والمعشوقة والآخر وهو الباطن منها هو متعلّق الشعور والإشعار وذلك هو المعبر عنه بالمحبّة والعاشقية ثمّ أنّ من الناس من عنده أنّ غاية المرتبة الأولى هي عالم الشهادة بما اشتملت عليه من الحسن والبهاء والبهجة والصفاء وغاية الثانية منها هو آدم بما له من الجوارح ذات الشعور لذلك والإشعار ومنهم من عنده أنّ غاية الأولى منها هي آدم بما له من الصور النائمة الوجودية المعبرة عن الحقائق الصادرة عنه عند وضعه إيّاه وهي المسماة بالنبوة وغاية الثانية منها هي ذلك بما له من المدارك الشاعرة الشهودية التي من شأنها أن تتحقّق عند بلوغها بالحقائق الوجودية الكاشفة عن كنه الكلّ بما هو عليه وذلك هو المستقّى بطرف الولاية وتام تحقيق هذا الكلام يحتاج إلى بيان مقدّمة أخرى كاشفة عن ذلك وهي أنّ حبّ الحبّ المذكور إذا تحرك من تحت أرض القابلية الأولى متوجّها نحو إظهار كنه المرام لا بدّ وأنّ تعلم أنّ لتلك الحركة الحثيّة مقصدين أحدهما [أس ١١ب] نحو غاية الإظهار وهو الذي ينتهي عند إتمام وضع الصورة والآخر نحو غاية الإشعار وهو الذي ينتهي عند تمام كشف المعنى الذي لتلك الصورة وذلك هو صورة ثمرة الحبّ المتحرّك في مكامن أراضي القوابل فهو عين ذلك الحبّ الظاهر [م ١٥٧] المستوي على عرش⁴³ الشعور على ما أفصح عنه إحصاء ظاهره فذلك هي النقطة التي بها اتّصل القوسان وكملت بها الدائرة وتمّت.

إذا تقرّر هذا فاعلم أنّه إذا تمّ قوس الظهور والإظهار من تلك الدائرة الكالية انعكس أمر المحبّة والمحبوبة على ما كشف عنه قوله تعالى ﴿يُحِبُّهُمْ وَيُحِبُّونَهُ﴾ [٥:٥٤] وذلك لأنّ الغاية المقصودة هي المحبوب المطلوب استحصاله كما أنّ القاصد إيّاه هو الطالب المحبّ استقباله ويبيّن أنّ الحركة التي في القوس الأولى من تلك الدائرة تمت عند ظهور الصورة النائمة وإظهارها لكنّه الكثرات الكامنة التي في عين الحبّ المذكور على ما أفصح عنه قوله تعالى ﴿يُحِبُّهُمْ﴾ فالمحبوب في هذه الحركة هي طرف الصورة النائمة الجامعة لسائر الكثرات التفصيلية ثمّ إذا تمت الصورة بكمالها وانختمت أبواب خزائن حليّتها وجمالها عادة الحركة القاصدة نحوها إلى طرف بطونها متوجّها صوب الشعور بكنه معانيها ومدارجها المشتمل عليها مطاوي كونها فينبذ تبدّلت سمة المحبّة بالمحبوبة وصار المحبوب طرف الوحدة الجمعية والمحبّ طرف الكثرة الإمكانية [أس ١١٢] على ما أفصح عنه قوله تعالى ﴿يُحِبُّونَهُ﴾ فعلم من هذا أنّ كمال المحبّة هو الذي لخاتم الرسالة صلوات الله وسلامه عليه وكمال المحبوبة هو الذي لخاتم الولاية وعلى هذا العرف بناء

⁴² باعتباراتهم.

⁴³ تحته ٥٧٠، وبالهامش: ١٠ عشر ٥٧٠.

كلام صاحب المحبوب وأكثر الفائتين في طريق التحقيق على ما ظهر من التلويحات القرآنية المعبر عن الدقائق فإنه جعل الحُب المدرجة فيه الحياة والبقاء صورة مفاتيح الغيب فلتمثل الدائرة بصورتها الحسية ليطلع بها المتفطن على بعض وجوه تلك التلويحات⁴⁴:



ومما عُلم من هذه الدائرة أنّ الوحدة الجمعية الإطلاقية التي صورتها الياء قد تنزّلت من إجمال جمعيتها إلى كمال تفصيلها فتام قوس المحببة إنما هو بظهور آدم مع غايته الكبالية على ما أفصح عنه (هـم) ثم أنّ قوس المحبوبة لها هذه التنوعات التي في تلك التنزلات مع تمام التفصيلات الوجهية الجامعة للكلّ مستويا على عرش العشر المُشعر بتلك التفصيلات التي في ضمن تلك الصورة الكبالية على ما أفصح عنه (نّه) فظهر أنّ غاية ما ينساق إليه أبحاث الكلّ وآخر ما ينحل إليه مقاصد الكلّ إنما هي الحكم العلية التي في طيّ الصور الحرفية سبيّا الإحصائية منها كما أفصح عنه التنزيل الختمي فهي التي يصلح لأن يكون موضوعا لمعاقد قواعد هذه العلوم.

2. K. al-Mafāhīṣ, §1.15 (on the Ṭahawī Circle) (MS Majlis 10196 ff. 63a-65a, MS Esad Efendi 1731 ff. 28a-32b):

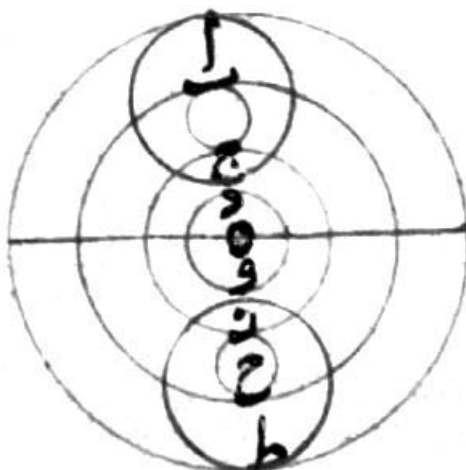
١٥.١) فحص إحصائي في نظم تعليمي

وهو أنّك قد عرفت [م٦٣ب] أنّ التنزل [أس٢٨ب] من علوّ المحيط وقُدس الوحدة الذاتية هو المسمّى بالحركة الإنزالية التي ظهرت بها الصور الإشعارية الحرفية على الصحف الكلامية والصفائح الكتابية، وذلك لأنّ المتحرّك ما لم يتنزل عن محيط الإطلاق الذي هو موطن الوحدة الذاتية التي لا تمايز فيها أصلا إلى مركز التقيّد ومنتهى البعد عن المحيط الذي هو مستقرّ الجمعية وموطن تعاكس الأشعة الإظهارية، لم يتمكّن من الظهور ولا يتصوّر له الإظهار الذي يترتب عليه الشعور؛ وكأنّك قد نبهت على أنّ الخامس من مراتب العقود العددية هو الذي له هذه المنزلة، فإنه هو غاية البعد عن محيط الوحدة الإطلاقية على ما لا يخفى. ثم اعلم أنّ تلك الحركة من مبدأ نهوضها عن الحضرات الأسماوية إلى منتهى استقرارها وظهورها في العوالم الكيانية لها أربع مراتب هي مدارج

⁴⁴ الدائرة على اليمين من م، الدائرة على اليسار من كيليج علي باشا ٦٢٦ ص ١٨.

تَنْزِلُهَا وَمَلَابِسَ كَتَمَهَا وَخَفَائِهَا إِلَى أَنْ بَلَغَ إِلَى الْخَامِسِ وَفِيهِ تَعَاكُسُ أَمْرُهَا وَبِهِ صَارَتْ مَدَارِجُ تَنْزِلِهَا مَرَاقِي عُرُوجِهَا وَمَلَابِسَ خَفَائِهَا مَظَاهِرَ كَشْفِهَا وَانْشِرَاحِهَا عَلَى مَا ظَهَرَ مِنْ هَذِهِ الدَّائِرَةِ الْخَاضِرَةِ لَجَمِيعِ الْمَرَاتِبِ مِنَ الْأَعْيَانِ الصَّائِرَةِ وَالْحَقَائِقِ السَّائِرَةِ وَالْأَمْلاَكِ الطَّائِرَةِ:

الدائرة الطَّهَوِيَّة



فلئن قيل أي أصل يدل على هذه الدائرة وبأي⁴⁵ قاعدة من القواعد يسند⁴⁶ إثبات نظمها وترتيبها، فإنه ما ذهب إليه أحد من المحققين [أس ١٢٩] وما أشار إلى قريب من ذلك سائر⁴⁷ السابقين في مضمار الكمال الفاتحين بمقائيد أذواقهم ومكشافاتهم عن أبواب التحقيق أقفال الإغلاق⁴⁸ إن هي إلا اختلاف، قلنا أما الدلائل العقلية والمؤيدات النوقية فقد أشير إلى شيء منها سابقا ولاحقا في صورة ينتبه إليها المتيقظ الفطن، وأما الآيات المنزلّة السامية والصور الأصلية القرآنية التي عليها مباني أمر هذه المكشفات وبها تمهد أصولها وتحقق موضوعات أبحاثها بجمل عمومها وتفصيل خصوصها على ما عرفت فالمفصح منها عن هذه الدائرة بتفصيلها والمشير إليها بمركزها ومحيطها وأصولها وفروعها هو قوله تعالى ﴿طه﴾ [٢٠: ١] فلذلك سميت بالدائرة الطهوية. فإنه لا يخفى على من له أدنى فطانة أن امتزاج هذين الحرفين وصورة تركبها لا بد وأن يكون منطوية على أمر بديع من جلائل الحكم الناصخة لما سواه وأصول المعارف الماسخة لما عداه كما ستطلع عليه. أما أمر السابقين وإشاراتهم المرموزة فلا يخفى على المؤمن الفطن أنها بالنسبة إلى الكلام المرسل به الخاتم وما انطوى [أس ٢٩ب] عليه من الحقائق كما قيل:

⁴⁵ أس: وإلى أيّ.

46 أس: يستند.

⁴⁷ أس: شاو.

48 م: تکتب (بسته) تحتها.

ومن ركب البحر استقلّ السواقيا⁴⁹

وذلك لأنّ في كلّ زمان خصائص من العلوم الحكّمية الخاصّة بتلك الحضرة ما لا يفيء⁵⁰ بإدراكه والفحص عن تحقيقه وإظهاره أذهان السابقين عليه ومما يؤيّد ذلك ما قد ورد عن الحضرة الختمية محمّد صلوات الله وسلامه عليه أنّه كثيرا ما يتمثّل بهذا البيت:

سنبدي لك الأيّام ما كنت جاهلا ويأتيك بالأخبار من لم تُرود⁵¹

والحرّ يكفيه⁵² الإشارة،⁵³ وأما تفصيل تلك الحكم والأصول المشار إليها فإنّ هذين الحرفين مشيران أوّلا إلى⁵⁴ القوسين الكمالين اللذين بهما تصوّرت الدائرة التامة وبوجودهما تحقّقت الحقيقة الآدمية وبشهود قربهما تمايزت كلّ الأنبياء والأولياء عن بني آدم وبمشاهدة أقربيّةهما فيضّل⁵⁵ الخاتم على الكلّ واختصّ بخصائصه الختمية وتلك الأقربيّة هي المعبر عنها في الكلام [م ١٦٤] المنزل به أو أدنى كما أنّ ذلك القرب هو المعبر عنه فيه به قوسين. وأما ثانيا فيشيران إلى خصوصية ما لهما من كليّات المراتب وإبانة خصوصية الشعورية منها⁵⁶ والظهورية وتحقيق مبدأ الكلّ ومعهاده أعني النهاية التي هي الختم، وذلك لأنّ القوسين المذكورين الكاشفين عن كليّات مراتب الكلّ من الظهورية والشعورية ما لم يبلغا [أس ١٣٠] إلى الدائرة الهائية تمايزا فلذلك تراهما مفصحين عن العشرة المشعّرة،⁵⁷ وأما الهائية فمندمجة فيها تلك العشرة مع كمال الظهور. ومن ههنا ظهر أنّ سائر الموجودات الكونية غير الثقلين لهم الشعور بالفعل من غير مزاوله اكتساب ومناولة فعل من حوادث الأعمال بخلافها، هذا ما دلّ عليه الصورة الإجمالية من هذه الدائرة بكليّتها.⁵⁸

⁴⁹ من قصيدة للمنتقي، والبيت الكامل يشير إلى كافور الإخشيدي (ت ٩٦٨/٣٥٧): قواصد كافور توارك غيره / ومن قصد البحر استقلّ السواقيا.

⁵⁰ أس: تفي.

⁵¹ من معلقة طرفة بن العبد.

⁵² أس: تكفيه.

⁵³ من مثل (العبد يقرع بالعصا والحرّ تكفيه الإشارة).

⁵⁴ أس: مشيران أما أوّلا فإلى.

⁵⁵ أس: فضّل.

⁵⁶ أس: وآيات خصوصيته الشعورية.

⁵⁷ أس حاشية: العشرة المشعّرة هي الحواش الظاهرة والباطنة وقوله (لهم الشعور) إشارة إلى أنّ عرفانهم بسيط كالحسوسات والوحدانيات للثقلين فلا ينافي نفي أهل الظاهر العلم عنهم.

⁵⁸ م حاشية: اعلم أنّ القوسين الأوّلين اللذين اشتمل عليها محيط هذه الدائرة لظهور أحكام الأصل فيها غير متلبس بما طرأ عليه في طي المنازل والمظاهر ولا متدنّس بإحداثه لها خصائص إشعارية فلذلك قدم حرف الطاء في الذكر. ولذلك ترى الألف في قوسيهما باقيا على كمال استقامتهما غير أنّ القوس التنزلي منها قد لبسه صورة جمعية إحاطية طاولية للكلّ بحيث لا يتغيّر بها قامة استقامة الألف، وأما بيان الخصائص التي تنفرد بها هذان القوسان فهو أنّ لهما مراتب عند بروزهما من مكامن الخفاء في كلّ من تلك المراتب كشفا عن ضرب من الحقائق، أوليا نفس ذات القوسين بدون ملاحظة خارج عنها فإنّ بهما تصوّرت الدائرة وظهر التمام المعبر عنه في عرف الاصطلاح بالذات الساذجة كما سيبيء بيانه، وثانيا اعتبار وجودهما مجزّدا عن ملاحظة وصف زائد عليهما، فإتّه ينكشف بهذا الوجه عن الحقيقة الآدمية التي تشترك فيها الكلّ أعني البرزخ الذي بين الوجوب والإمكان الجامع بحكميهما، وثالثها اعتبار النسبة المميّزة مع الوجود أعني قرب القوسين فإتّه بحسب تلك المقاربة يمتاز مراتب بين النوع الإنساني ويفوق بعضها على بعض بحسب الكمال الذي قدر لتلك الحقيقة من حيث هي وقد أشير إلى تفاصيل مراتب تلك المقاربة بقوله تعالى ﴿دنا فتدلى فكان قاب قوسين﴾ [٨:٥٣]- [٩]، ورابعها اعتبار تضعيف تلك النسبة المميّزة المعبر عنها بالمقاربة وهي الأقربيّة التي تنفرد بها الخاتم وورثته الكالية ويترتب عليها علوها وسائر خصائصها وقد أشير إليه بقوله

وأما بيان خصوصيات ما في هذه الدوائر على تفصيلها والفحص عمّا في مطاوي قوسي فرقها أولاً وجمعها وإحاطتها ثانياً فإنّها مشيرة إلى ما في المراتب الوجودية بخصائصها وأحكامها من أول ظهور الهوية والذات الساذجة إلى نهاية مرتبة الحسّ وعالم الشهادة وهو أنّ الألف منها هو المشير إلى الحضرة الأحدية التي هي أول التعينات الجامعة لأحكام اللاتينّ والتعينّ، والباء منه إلى الحضرة الواحدية التي بها البدء من سلسلة الموجودات وهي المسماة بالنفس الرحمانى المنبسط على الكلّ وبارئه، والجيم منه إلى أول التعينات الاستجلالية المسماة بعالم الأمر وهو العقل الأول الجامع لكلّ العاقد إياه بصور بروزه والقلم الأعلى الزاير إياه بمخازن كنوزه وذلك إنّما يتحقّق أيضاً باعتبار انعكاس صورة البسط الأول فيه مع التنزلات التي له في صورة القوس الجمعي إلى الانبساط [أس ٣٠] الأخير⁵⁹ المستقى عند المشائين بالعقل الفعّال، والبال منه هو الدالّ على عالم المثال الذي هو عكس القوس الجمعي الذي لعالم الأمر مع ما له من الميل إلى الكثافة التي يلزمها الانحراف عن الدور الجمعي إلى التزوّي بكثافة الزاوية وجسديتها المثالية، والهاء منه إشارة إلى عالم الشهادة ومرتبة الجسم وصورته هي الصورة الجمعية الكماله العرشية المشار إليها بقوله تعالى ﴿الرحمن على العرش استوى﴾ [٢٠:٥]، ثمّ الواو في القسي الطالعة منها يدلّ على الولد الأول من ازدواج الوالدين العلوي والسفلي أعني المعدن، والزاء يدلّ على الزائد في الاقطار بالذات يعني النبات، والحاء تدلّ على الحيّ الذي هو مؤسّس تمام البنين أي الحيوان، والطاء على نقطة ذلك التام وهو الإنسان الذي يختم بنطقه أبواب عقود ذلك النظام.

فلئن قيل هذا غير مطابق لما سلف في الكلام على الترتيب الأصلي والنظم الوجودي، قلّك إنّ تنوّع المدلولات التي تحت الدلالات الوضعية غير مستبعد في لسان أهل الظاهر على ما نهت إليه من تحقّق التعاقب الذي للأطراف والأضداد فيها ولا مضايقة لهم في ذلك مع توغّلهم في فنون المضايق الرسمية واقتحامهم صنوف عقبات العقود الحاصرة الاصطلاحية الجعلية، فإنّ لكلّ كلمة وحرف دلالات متنوّعة حسبها وقع طيّ [أس ٣١] التركيبات على المعاني التي تليق بكلّ جملة من القرائن المقترنة بتلك الكلمات في فنون الترتيبات، فلا يُستبعدن⁶⁰ ذلك في الإشارات الذوقية الشرحية التي للصور الأصلية المنزلّة من سماء القدس وفضاء إطلاقه، فإنّها هي ينبوع الحقائق والحكم بتفتّن شجونها وتشعب أغصانها. ومن ههنا ترى المتيقّظ الفطن كلّما أمعن النظر في هذه الدائرة زاد له من العلم ما لا يحيط به نطاق المنطوقات [م ٦٤ب] بدلالاتها المتعارفة.

ثمّ أنّ هذه الوجوه المنتظمة في دلالاتها المذكورة إنّما يجلو منها على منصّة الإشعار إذا وقع مسارح إدراك المستبصرين على صوب الوجود ومراتبه المتحقّقة في أنفسها، أمّا إذا كان مواقع إدراكهم طرف الكون ومراتبه الظاهرة على المظاهر وجدوا هذه الدائرة الكمالية بجامع كلمتها مطابقة إياه، فإنّ في هذه الدائرة بأرقاها إشارة إلى سائر المراتب الكونية الظهورية أيضاً بخصائصها الخاصّة بكلّ منها. فإنّ الألف في هذا المسلك هو المشير إلى البسيط المطلق الذي ليس له انحراف أصلاً إلى زوايا الكثافة من قدس الوحدة الخطيّة وصفائها، والباء فيه إلى المعدن الذي هو صورة بسط الجسم وإظهاره، والجيم إلى النبات الذي له ذلك البسط مع القوس الجمعي الإحاطي المفيد للتغذية والتنمية وتوليد المثل المنتهي إلى بسط آخر، [أس ٣١ب] والبال فيه إلى الحيوان الذي هو عكس ذلك القوس مع زيادة الظهور الذي له مع الشعور وهي الاستفادة من الزاوية ذات التقابل والتعادل، والهاء فيه إلى الإنسان الذي له تمام الجمعية وكمال الإحاطة. هذا ما قُسمها الهبوطية التنزلية، وأمّا ما في طيّ قسّمها الطلوعية فإنّ الواو حينئذ يدلّ على مرتبة الولاية التي هي كمال الإنسان، والزاء على زيادة ذلك الكمال وهي المسماة بالنبوة، والحاء على الحكم والخلافة، والطاء على طرف ذلك الكمال ونهايته وهو الختم.

تعالى ﴿أو أدنى﴾ [٩:٥٣]. فهذه أربعة مراتب للقوسين المشعّرين الكاشفين ... أنّه وإنّ يشتمل سائر الدوائر ... هذين القوسين بين الأولى والأخرى أعني المحيط والمركز قد اختصا بالإظهار والإشعار كما سيحيى تحقيق ذلك وإلى ذلك أشار بقوله (فإنّ هذين الحرفين مشيران أولاً) إلى آخره.

⁵⁹ أس: الآخر.

⁶⁰ أس: يستبعدون.

هذا كلّه بحسب المراتب الظهورية والوجودية فقط، وأمّا إذا وقع أشعة مدارك المتفطنين على المراتب الإظهارية الإشعاعية ففهي أيضاً إشارة إلى خصائصها وأحكامها بما لا مزيد عليه، فإنّ الكلام الذي هو مالك أزمنة الإظهار والإشعار أول مراتبه إنّما هو النزول من الحضرة الأسماوية وسواء إطلاقها الذاتي إلى مجالي العوالم الإمكانية ومحلّ انبساط القلم واللوح وتسطيره عليه والمشير إليها هو الالف والباء ثمّ له تنزّل آخر من ذلك الانبساط إلى صورة جمعية جبرئيل المشار إليها ههنا بالجيم لاحتياز وضعه الكتابي فنونا من المناسبة بما له من الصورة الانبساطية التي هي عكس الانبساط الأول المستفاد منه المطابق له والقوس التنزلي [أس ١٣٢] المبتي بالزاوية الحادة المجاوزة لحدّ إطلاقه الأصلي المجوّزة لامتزاجه واختلاطه بما تحته المنتهي إلى بسط آخر ثالث يحاذيه به يظهر للأنبياء عليهم السلام ويعلمهم ما في ذلك البسط الأول من الحقائق على ما هي عليه، ثمّ الدالّ الدالّ على ما أنزل على الأنبياء من الكلام الدالّ إلى دعوة الحقّ إلى دار سلامه، ثمّ الهاء الهادي إلى سبيل الصواب من أقرب الأبواب بقرانه الجمعي المنتهى إلى الكلّ من هامة⁶¹ علا الماهيات إلى هاوية ذنّة الهويات، ثمّ الواو الواصف طرف تمام ذلك الهادي بأوضاعه ومواقعه أعني وحداته الفرقانية التي هي أولى وسيلة عند استقامته وإبل الوجد والوجود من ساء الوهب والجود به يتولى ولاية الولاية ويتمكّن في ممالك العلم والدراية، ثمّ الزاء الزابر على صفائحه زاد السالكين الزائن زواجر بحره بزواهر الزيادة الكيالية التي للحجّ الختمي وورثته الفائزين، ثمّ الحاء الذي هو حديث الخاتم وما يستحدث في حدائق دولته من وضوح الحكم الحرفية التي فاحت نضجات تحقيقها بـ﴿روح وريحان﴾ [٥٦:٨٩] ولاحت تبشير أصباح منائحها ومدائحها بما لا يقدر⁶² عليه أيدي الحدّثان، ثمّ الطاء الذي هو طريقته الخاصة المنطوية على طرف الحكم والحقائق التي هي طريقة⁶³ لا تليده أعني بسط [أس ٣٢ب] الكثرة العددية التي هي الطامة⁶⁴ التي فوق كلّ طامة.

إذا تقرّر لك هذا ظهر عندك أنّ الهاء على جميع التقادير هو صاحب الجمعية الكيالية ومهبط فيضان الأنوار الوجودية ومنبع جريان المعارف الشهودية. ومن ثمّة جعل صاحب المحبوب دائرتها دائرة الدوائر المحدقة بالعلائن والسرائر، فالمتيقظ حينئذ له أن يتمكّن من الاستنباط عن بعض ما في طيّ إشارات الحضرة الختمية وورثته من قوله تعالى ﴿ليس كمثله شيء﴾ [٤٢:١١] وقوله صلى الله عليه وسلّم (إنّ الله خلق آدم على صورته) وقوله صلى الله عليه وسلّم (إنّ الزمان قد استدار كهيئته يوم خلق الله السماوات [١٦٥م] والأرض) وقولهم

أقول وروح القدس ينفث في النفس بأنّ وجود الحقّ في العدد الخمس⁶⁵

[ثمّ اعلم أنّ هذه الوجوه لمعة من لوامع أنوار الحروف وقطرة من تيّار⁶⁶ بحره الزاخر، إنّما أشير إليها تشويقاً للطالب وإيقاظاً له عن نومه الغالب لا تحقيقاً لما هو الأصل في هذه المأرب، فإنّ في طيّ كلّ حرف وكلمة وآية فنونا من الحكم التي لا يمتدّ إليها إلّا بعد ضبط القوانين التي تكفل ببيان شيء منها تمام أبواب هذا الكتاب، وفقنا الله لذلك].⁶⁷

⁶¹ م: هامة.

⁶² أس: تقدر.

⁶³ أس: طريقة.

⁶⁴ م: تكتب تحتها (فرا رسیده).

⁶⁵ أس حاشية: هذا البيت في الفتوحات.

⁶⁶ أس: تيان.

⁶⁷ م: الجملة بين المعقوفين تصحيح بخط المؤلف.

٢٢.١) فخص إحصائي في صفح كتابي ونظم لبائي⁶⁸

كأئتكَ قد وقفت بما مُهّد لك أنّ⁶⁹ الأفراد من العدد حيث أنّها هي الغالب في حقائقها أمر التنفرقة والتفاصيل هي التي تناسب مرتبة العلم والإشعار بما لها من الصورة الإحاطية بأجزاء المعلوم إحاطة الصورة الفردية [أس٣٦ب] المانعة لتلبس أجزائها بملايس الجمع الساترة لها بفنون الأستار⁷⁰ كما أنّ الأزواج منه لما فيها من غلبة أحكام الجمع وجمال الإجمال يطابق درجة الظهور والإظهار بما لها من القسمة الفارقة لأجزائها تفرقة أقسام الزوج الناعمة إيّاه المظهرة له بفنون الآثار. ثمّ إذا عرفت هذا ظهر لك أنّ الحروف النورية التي صدرت بها أبواب الكتاب الكريم وعنوت بها أمّهات سور ذلك النبأ العظيم وإن انسدت بها تلك السدّة السنية على وجوه أكثر المستفهمين وانغلقت بأقفال إعجامها ضبّت⁷¹ تلك الأبواب على عامّة الأمم من طوائف المقلّدين والمحقّقين، ولكن قد أعربت⁷² في أول وجوها الامتزاجية أعني الثنائية منها التي هي بجذاء الأوليات التي جُبِل عليها الإنسان ورُكّب منها البرهان على كلتا المرتبتين بأفصح لسان وأتمّ تبيان غير أنّه بعرف هذه اللغة الإحصائية التي عليها مباني أوضاع هذا اللسان. ألا ترى الدائرة الطهوية قد عبّرت عن المرتبة الأولى منها وافية شافية بفردين منفردين بالعلوّ من الطرفين، فانظر بعد ذلك إلى الدائرة الياسينية التي قد أعربت عن تمام المرتبة الثانية⁷³ منها حاوية⁷⁴ كافية⁷⁵:

⁶⁸ أس: سقط عنوان الفصل.

⁶⁹ أس: على أنّ.

⁷⁰ أس: الاشار.

⁷¹ أس: إعجامها [ضبطت].

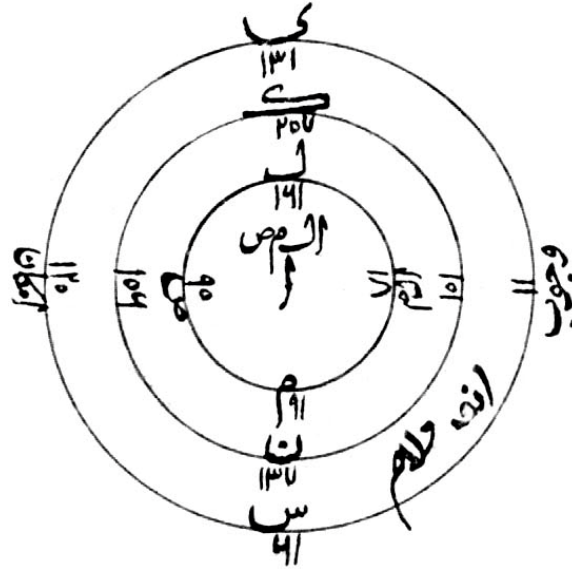
⁷² أس: عرفت.

⁷³ أس: الثنائية.

⁷⁴ أس: جاوية.

⁷⁵ م أس حاشية: اعلم أنّ من جلائل حكم هذه البائرة علم حقيقة العالم وأنّ الظاهر فيه من الصور الوجودية هي الحروف المقطّعة التي صدرت بها أمّهات السور القرآنية الحتمية لا غير سبّا ألف لام ميم، فإنّه يظهر بها لميّة أمر العالم وعالميته كما وقفت على شيء منها في طي حُكمه. ثمّ اعلم أنّ كلمة كلّ دائرة لها أربع نسخ وهي المثبتة على أطرافها الأربعة، الكبير وما يقربه والصغير وما يليه أمّا الكبير من كلّ منها فهو الدالّ على طرف ظهور تلك الكلمة وعمومها الكوني والصغير على طرف بطونها الوجودي وخصوصها والباقيان هما البرزخان المنتسبان إلى كلّ منهما كالسلام والساعة في الدائرة الأولى والوجوب والإمكان المنتسبين إليهما والعقول والقلوب في الثانية والساء والعلوّ المنتزعين عنها واللام والميم في الثالثة والصاد والعين المترتبان عليهما. وفي طي هذه الإشارات حكم كريمة لمن تدبّر فيها ووفق لها منها ما ظهر في الثانية أنّ العلوّ النسبي الذي للساء منزل عن العلوّ الحقيقي الذي للأرض إلى غير ذلك مما لا يحمله وسع الوقت.

الدائرة الياسينية



وذلك أنّ محيط هذه الدائرة هي السوية العدلية [أس ١٣٧] التي هي الميزان القويم عندما ثقلت موازين الأعيان والأكوان وانفصلت الأمائل منها عن الأراذل في كفتي النقص والرجحان على محيط الزمان الذي هو لسان ذلك الميزان. فإِنَّكَ لو تعمّقت فيها صادفتَ المحيط هذا هو الذي إذا تنزل عن تمام جمعية قوسيه⁷⁶ المشار إليه ﴿بقاب قوسين﴾ [٥٣:٩] مرتبة واحدة أفصح بالكلمة التامة التي ارتبط بامتزاج حرفها وانتظام طرفيها خروج ما في كن بطائن القوة من أجنّة بطون الإمكان، فإنّ في اتصال الكاف بالنون ظهر ملاء الأكوان ولم شعث التفرقة التي منعت تحقّق لون من الألوان على مجالي العيان، وتماثل تلخيص هذا الكلام أنّ لهذه الدائرة ثلاث مراتب على ما هو مقتضى أمر الإيجاد [أس ٣٧ب] والتكوين من العقد السائر والنكاح الساري، أولها هو المحيط الأقدم الذي صورته الياء صاحب الوحدة الجمعية [م ٦٦ب] ومادّته السين مالك تمام الكثرة أعني السوية العدلية وهذه هي المستمّة في عرف الصوفية بقاب قوسين، وأخرها هو المركز الذي صورته اللام الذي هو نهاية تنزل الصورة ومادّته الميم الذي هو تمام ترقّي الهيئة المعنوية المادّية كما قال صاحب المحبوب بلسانه الجمعي العجمي المعرب عن المعجم:

گر شکل بغایت برسد لام شود چون وسوسه نفس که الهام شود

ومن ههنا ترى المادّة والصورة فيه قد اتّصلتا اتّصالاً طبيعياً وامتزجتا امتزاجاً أصلياً وثيقاً يصلح لأن يكون مظهرها وافيها ولباساً ضافياً للألف كما سيبيء تحقيقه. وأمّا البرزخ الجامع بين كلّ مادّة من صنوف الموادّ التي من أزل أزال المبدأ بصورتها التي هي مدارج ترقّيها إلى أبد آباد المعاد، فهو الدائرة الوسطانية الجامعة بين لطائف المحيط وكثائف المركز بامتزاج كافها الكافي في تمام الإحاطة والدور بما له من الوجدتين الحاويتين على الطرفين مع نون⁷⁷ جنّة اليخّن وجنان بطنان المركز لما اختصّ به من الكثرة التامة الغالبة عليه، ولهذا قال صاحب المحبوب (إنّ الكاف الذي في الكلمة هذه كاف الملك [أس ٣٨و] ونونها نون الشيطان).

⁷⁶ أس: قوسه.

⁷⁷ م: تكتب تحت (نون) ١٠٤؛ أس: تفرد.

ثمّ اعلم أنّ بين هذه الدائرة والدائرة الطهوية وجوها من التقابل وقد أفصحت ألسنتها عن فنون من الحكم، منها أنّ أعيان هذه الدائرة قد تنزّلت عن علو وحدتها مرتبة واحدة وتلبّست بأحكام المرتبة نفسها دون أعيان تلك الدائرة فإنّها كلّها بصرافة علوها الذاتي ووحدتها الأصلية، ومنها أنّ صورة الأولى منها وهي الدائرة الأولى المحيطة على الكلّ فرد وصورة هذا زوج كما أنّ الأمر في صاحبيها بالعكس وذلك هو الظاهر في كلّ دائرة المختفي فيها، فإنّ صاحب الأولى عشرة وصاحب الثانية هذه سبعة عقدا.

فلنّ قيل فهذا ممّا تلجلج⁷⁸ به لسان المناسبة الذي هو المتكلّم بلغتنا هذه، وأيضا قد تقرّر أنّ مرتبة العشرات هي المناسبة للشعور والإشعار دون الآحاد، قلنا نعم كذلك ولكن في بادئ الرأي فإنّه لو أمعنت النظر الدقيق لرأيت أنّه ممّا استفصح به اللسان المذكور وبلغ به غاية البلاغة، وذلك عندما تدبّرت⁷⁹ في الصور الشعورية العلمية ووقفت على خصوصيتها الامتيازية التي بها تفارق الصور العينية الكائنة، وذلك أنّ الصور العلمية وإن كانت بالذات ذات تفصيلات فرقية بها يتمكّن المعلوم لأنّ يتجلّى على كلّ عالم بوجه من متنوعات وجوهه، فإنّ من [أس ٣٨ظ] شأن المعلوم أن يظهر للقريب بوجهه الذاتي الأصلي الذي هو كنه حقيقته وللبعيد منه بأوجه أخر عرضية، ولكن لها هيئة وحدانية بها يتحد العالم مع المعلوم بخلاف الصور العينية الكائنة فإنّ الذي لها بالذات إنّما هو الإجمال الجمعي الساتر لتلك الوجوه. ومن ههنا تسمع أنّمّة النظر يقولون إنّ الجنس بسائر أقرانه موجود مع النوع بوجود واحد، إنّما فصلت تلك الأقران الخمسة بعضها عن البعض في العقل فقط، ومع ذلك تراها مباينة لمدرک⁸⁰ مفارقة إياه واقعة منه على طرف من التباعد والتخالف. فإنّك إذا وقفت على هذه الجهات الامتيازية وتأملت في الجهة الفارقة التي للفرد بالنسبة إلى الزوج ههنا ما توقفت فيما نحن فيه من زيادة الإفصاح للسان المناسبة المذكورة عنه، على أنّ كلامنا في اختصاص إحدى الدائرتين بالعلم والأخرى بالعين مبتني على العبارة العربية القرآنية حيث أفصح عن الأولى بـ(طه) وعن الثانية منها بـ(يس)، فإذا نُظر إلى هذه الحيثية التي لها في العبارة المذكورة ظهر الاختصاص من هذه الجهة ولو نُظر إليهما بما لهما من الوجوه الأخر التي لها في ذاتها صودف لكلّ منها لسان يتكلّم عن الطرفين معاً بدون اختصاص أصلاً كما وقفت في طي الدائرة الطهوية على وجوهها المطابقة لفنون من الأعيان الكيانية والحقايق الإلهية وأصناف [أس ٣٩و] الموجودات والكائنات بأسرها.

ثمّ إذا تقرّر لديك هذا الكلام ظهر لك أنّ اختصاص مرتبة العشرات بالإشعار لا ينافي ما متمدناه من البيان فإنّ صور الحروف كلّها إشعارية ولكن دلالاتها إنّما تتبيّن بحسب القرائن المقترنة بها في جملة جملة فإنّ الحرف الواحد قد يدلّ على معنى في سياق وعلى ضدّه في آخر ولا تمنع بينها كما هو المشاهد في الوضع الجملي وأما الوضع الحقيقي الذي نحن بصدده فرحائب⁸¹ أفضيته قد وسعت أطرافا متباعدة الأقطار متباينة الأطوار فليكن المتفطن على تيقظ⁸² من ذلك غير ملتفت إلى العادات وما حكمت به من فنون المضايقات.

ومنها أنّ الأولى خُراسية بالطبع على وفق المشاعر [م ١٦٧] وأطراف الجوارح الشاعرة والثانية ثلاثية وهي التي عليها بنيان أركان التوليد والإيجاد. ومنها أنّ العالي الكثير الذي هو الحديث صار في الأولى عالياً ظاهراً علوّ الهيئة الإحاطية التي للمعلوم والقليل الذي هو القديم صار سافلاً محتفياً تحت اختفاء ذات المعلوم تحت الهيئة المذكورة، والأمر في الدائرة الثانية على عكس ذلك فإنّ القديم الذي بمنزلة الذات له المعلوّ هناك والحديث له الدقّ ودقائق هذه الحكمة ممّا لا يخفى على الفطن. ومنها أنّ الباطن

⁷⁸ م حاشية: اي تردّد.

⁷⁹ أس: ترث.

⁸⁰ أس: للمدرک.

⁸¹ م: = (سيعت).

⁸² أس: يقظة.

من الأولى وهو الذي يقال له المركز صاحب صورة وحدانية [أس ٣٩ب] قد اندمج فيها الصورة المثلية التي له متّحدة به اندماج المعلومات التي هي الصور المثليات في باطن العالم واتّحادها به، وأنّ الباطن من الثانية له صورة مركّبة من المختلفين متكثّرة به تركّب الكائنات من المتخالفات وتكثّرها به، ومن ههنا ترى الصورة الكائنة من العلم أيضا أعني الكلمة هذه الدالة عليه في الخارج قد ظهرت بها الدائرة بمركزها ومحيطها، وذلك لأنّ العلم هو صورة السبع المثاني في العشرة المشعّرة أعني تضعيف السبعة التي هي صاحب الدائرة هذه وصورة مثليته على الوجهين الإجمالي والتفصيلي كما هو المشاهد من مصدوق العلم وما له من ذينك الوجهين على ما هو المتين لدى الواقف بأساليب النظر وأهله، فإنّ ممّا وقع عليه أشعة مداركهم وأنظارهم أنّ العلم له هاتان صورتان أعني الإجمال الذي عبّر عنه عينه والتفصيل الذي لوح إليه لهُ⁸³ وهذا من الآيات الباهرة على تطابق الصور الكائنة الحرفية للحقائق الوجودية الأصلية حيث وقعت الصورة الكونية التي للعلم من بين فنون تلك الصور مطابقة لهذه الدائرة التي هي محيطٌ بجملة ما في العالمين بكلا الطرفين تطابق سائر الصور العلمية لما في العين. ومنها أنّ الظاهر من الدائرة الأولى في الكتاب القرآني والمفصح عنها فيه هو المحيط والمركز اللذان هما الظاهر والباطن ظهورهما في [أس ٤٠أ] الصور الشعورية العلمية، كما أنّ الظاهر من الثانية هذه فيه هو المحيط بطرفها أعني الظاهر منها مقتصرًا عليه اقتصار الصور الكائنة بعينها على ذلك الطرف.

٢٣.١) فخص إحصائي في صفح من حكم هذه الدائرة⁸⁴

أليس قد تبين لديك أنّ الواحد الحقيقي الذي لا مقابلة فيه كَلَمَ تنزّل مرتبة من علوّ عزّه الأصلي تلبّس بضرب من النسب ذات الكثرة مخفيا فيها وترقى القابل في تلك المرتبة بعينها من دناءة ذلّه العدمي متحلّيًا بنوع يقابل تلك النسبة من النسب الوحدانية ظاهرا به، فانظر في هذه الدائرة التي قد شافهتك بأفصح لسان عن تلك الحكاية بعينها مع الإبانة عن أحكام كلّ من تلك المراتب الجلالية الإطلاقية المسماة بالحضرات الإلهية إلى أن ينتهي إلى الاستجلائية المسماة بالعالم، وذلك لأنّ الياء الذي هو صورة ذلك الواحد الجمعي الذي لا يقابل⁸⁵ فيه بين الواحد والكثير وقع في الدائرة الأولى كما تراه في مقابلة السين الذي هو صورة تمام الكثرة المتجاوزة كما هو سمّه القابل وشيمته فإنّه هو الذي له تمام الكثرة لا غير، فلهذه الدائرة دلالة على التعيين الذي هناك تقابل القوسان الوحده والكثرة وظاهرهما عند العقل هو الوجوب والإمكان، ثمّ لمّا تنزّل إلى الدائرة الثانية تلبّس الواحد فيها بصورة أخرى متجدّدة من صورهِ الإطلاقيه وهي التي عرفت أنّها نهاية⁸⁶ الكثرة مخفيا فيها وتجلّى القابل في مقابله بما يناسبه ظاهرا به وهو الغاية العظمى التي ليست وراءها غاية، ومن ههنا [أس ٤٠ب] ترى التقابل في هذه الحضرة قد اختصّ بمزيد من الظهور وبه انفلق صبح يوم الوجود عن الليل البهيم⁸⁷ من العدم كما أفصح عن ذلك نُسخُها التي على أطراف الدائرة، ثمّ لمّا تنزّل إلى الثالثة من الدوائر اكتسى الواحد فيها كسوة تليق بجمعية تلك المرتبة وهو [م ٦٧ب] تمام الجمعية وأمر ذلك متبين في هذه الدائرة وذلك لأنّ ما اكتسى به القابل في هذا التعيين الثالث قد امتزج بما اكتسى به الواحد امتزاج اتحاد كسائر المراتب السابقة، ولكن هذا الامتزاج صاحب

⁸³ أس: لمّه.

⁸⁴ م حاشية: صفح الشيء ناحيته وصحف الإنسان جنبه وصفح الجبل مضجعته والجمع صفاح.

⁸⁵ أس: تقابل.

⁸⁶ أس: سقط الكلّ من (لمّا تنزّل) إلى (أنّها نهاية).

⁸⁷ م حاشية: أي المظلة.

الجمعية التامة التي لا فراغ في جوف تلك الجمعية لشيء أصلا بخلاف ما قبلها من الدوائر، فإن الامتزاج الواقع بين القوسين من كلٍّ منهما ذو فراغ خال كما لا يخفى على الناظر فيها، وبهذا الضرب من الامتزاج الذي بين القابل والواحد تحقق أمر المظهرية والظاهرية وصح إطلاق اسم العالمية والأدمية وصدق عليه العين حقيقة، فإن المرتبتين السابقتين هما التعتين كما لا يخفى وذلك لأن القابل في هذه المرتبة ترقى ودنى إلى أن وصل إلى ما تدلّى فيه الواحد وتنزل وصولا امتزاجيا اتحاديا بحيث لا يسع بينهما شيء من الوسائط أصلا، وبهذا التطابق صار المظهر كاملا وخليفة للظاهر مشاكلا إياه مشابها به كما قيل:

رق الزجاج ورقّت الخمر فتشابه وتشاكل الأمر
فكأنّا خمر ولا قدح [أس ١٤١] وكأنّا قدح ولا خمر

هذا ما دلّ عليه الأحرف الستة بـرّها فإنه لو استكشف عمّا دلّت عليه بيّاناتها ونسخها الكاملة كانت مجلّلات من الحكم، ثم إنه قد رُسمت على أطراف الدوائر رسوم هندسية تنبسط منها علوم غريبة فلا تغفل عنها.

٢٤.١) فخص من هذا الصنف

وهو أن الدائرة الثالثة التي هي مركز الدوائر صاحب المزاج العدلي الاتحادي الذي يقتضي الظهور بأحكام الواحد الساري في هذه المراتب وهذا الاعتبار يستوى بالعالم، ثم إن الواحد ههنا ظهر بصورة اللام⁸⁸ وإحصاؤه مفصح عن النصف الأول منه كما أن الدائرة مفصحة عن النصف الآخر، وأما القابل فظهر بصورة الميم ومجموعهما مفصح عمّا يقوم الإنسان فتبين أن هذا المزاج هو المزاج الإنساني لا غير، ثم إن هذه الهيئة التركيبية التي لهذين الحرفين لها صورتان إحداها هي التي حصلت لها عند فتح أبواب خصائص اللام وهو الطرف الظاهر من الكون ومقتضاه الإطلاق الصرف الذي هو مؤدّى النفي كما أنه إذا انكسر أحكام تلك الخصائص ينقلب أمرها إلى الطرف الباطن ويدلّ كلمتها على لميّة تلك الصور، فأحدى صورتين منها دالة على نهاية الظهور وأقصى مراتبه والأخرى منها دالة على نهاية البطون وأقصاه، ثم إن العين التي هي مؤدّى إحصاء طرف الواحد إذا ضُمت إلى هذه الهيئة لها [أس ٤١ب] هاتان الحالتان أيضا بعينها فإنها إذا افتتح أبواب خصوصياتها العينية تراه علما على صحارى الإظهار كما أنها إذا انكسرت انقلب أمره إلى البطون.

٢٥.١) فخص إحصائي في نظم كلامي

إذ قد عرفت أن الرابع أول ما يتلأأ منه أنوار الوحدة الجمعية الكليّة، والذي انتهى فيه أمر الكثرة وانختمت به أبواب ثوران حكمها إنما هو الثالث، اعلم أن الثالث له اعتباران أحدهما أن يكون ثالث الإثنين كما هو المشاهد من النسبة الجمعية بين الطرفين وهو وجه جمعيته الوجودية والآخر أن يكون ثالث الثلاثة وهو طرف كثرته ومحوضة إمكانه، وكذلك لكلّ عدد هذان الطرفان وجه وجودي جمعي وآخر عدي فرقي، فمما علم من هذا الفحص لميّة كفر القائلين بأن الله ثالث ثلاثة وتحقيق أنّه رابعها على ما أفصح عنه قوله تعالى ﴿لقد كفر الذين قالوا إنّ الله ثالث ثلاثة﴾ [٥:٧٣] وقوله تعالى ﴿ما يكون من نجوى ثلاثة إلاّ هو رابعهم

⁸⁸ م حاشية: ١٦١.

ولا خمسة إلا هو سادسهم ولا أدنى من ذلك ولا أكثر إلا هو معهم ﴿٥٨:٧﴾، ومنها وجه الجمعية الكمالية التي لللام⁸⁹ بين الصور الحرفية ودلالته على تعريف الواحد الحقيقي وإظهاره في سائر المعاني وعلى خصوصية إشعاره للكل كما سيجيء تحقيقه إن شاء الله تعالى.

5. *K. al-Mafāhīṣ*, §2.6 (approaches to the Light Verse) (MS Majlis 10196 ff. 75b-77a, MS Esad Efendi 1731 ff. 61b-65a):

٦.٢) فخص كتابي في حقائق حكمية قانونية

كأنك قد وقفت مما نهت عليه في طي الدائرة الطهوية⁹⁰ على أن التنزل بأي نحو كان وعلى أي صوب تصوّر ما لم يتدرّج خمس مدارج لم يتم أمره ولم يحصل له الغاية الباعثة على النهوض له من المتحرّك ولم يُصب سهام قصده من قُسي تلك الحركة مراعي المرام والبعية، كذلك الواحد بالوحدة الحقيقية الظاهر حكمه في الكثرات المتخالفة ما لم يتنزل بتلك المدارج المحدودة لم ينته له أمر تلك الوحدة [م١٧٦] ولم يبلغ إلى كمالها الخاص بها وبغيتها المأمولة منها. وتلخيص هذا الكلام أن الواحد المطلق إذا اقتضى الحركة الحبية وحصل له الطبع المحرّك تجوهر، ثم يكون له بعد تينك المرتبتين البعد واستعدّ لتحقيق الأبعاد الثلاثة المتقاطعة فيه وصار جسماً مُعدّاً لإظهار الآثار والخواص، ثم تكمل ذلك بالنمو. فانهى أمر تلك الحركة التي للوحدة الإطلاعية بالحيوان الذي هو خامس مدارج تنزلاته وأنهى هاوية هويّاته. ومن ههنا ترى الوحدة الجنسية به بلغت غايتها القصوى ورتبتها العليا [أس١٦٢] كما يبيّن تحقيق مجيئه في الرسالة المحمّدية، ومن ثمة صار مصدرا للصوت الاختياري الذي به ظهر ما في الباطن أولاً على مجالي الظاهر آخرًا وصار جمعا للطرفين ومعتنقا للمقابلين، أعني ﴿الأول والآخر والظاهر والباطن﴾ [٣:٥٧].

ثم إذا تذكّرت ما في هذه المقدمة، فاعلم أنّه وإن كان كلّ مرتبة من المراتب العيانية والعوالم الكيانية حتى الجمادات بما انطوى عليه من صنوف اللطائف وفنون الكائنات كتابا فيه آيات وحروف بصورتها الكونيتين، كما نهت عليه، ولكن لها مراتب متفاوتة النسب متباعدة الرتب لدى الإعراب عن المعاني والإفصاح بها، وذلك لأنّ الأحرف الظاهرة بصورتها على كتب الكائنات ومخارج الأعيان الخارجيات لها أربع مراتب عند اعتبار ارتباطها بالمعاني ووجه دلالاتها عليها. أولها هي التي على صفحات الأجرام ومخارج قرقع بعضها على البعض من الأصوات والأرقام وهذا القسم وإن عمّت صور أحرفها سائر ما في الخارج من الأعيان سواء كان من الجماد أو النبات أو الحيوان ولكن اختصّ فهم المعنى منها والعثور على وجه دلالاتها بنقاوة خلاصة خاصّة من كلّ نوع الإنسان. وأمّا الثانية منها فهي التي اختصّ بها بعض الأعيان من الصوت الاختياري الذي ينعق به الحيوان لدى الاضطرار إلى أن تنقّس عن كرب [أس٦٢ب] فقد ضروريات تعيّنه وطلب ما يحتاج إليه منها طبعاً إعراباً لما في باطنه من النزاع إلى معدّات تقوّمه عند مفارقتها لها ومعاوزته إيّاها، وهذا إنّما يفهم بنو نوعه الذين يقاربون له زماناً ومكاناً ورُتبةً. وأمّا الثالثة فهي التي تفرد بها نوع الإنسان وتقومت بها حقيقته من النطق المعرب عن تفاصيل ما يحتاج إليه بحسب تعيّنه وتمدّنه الطبيعيين أولاً وبالاضطرار

⁸⁹ أس: للام.

⁹⁰ م حاشية: اعلم أنّ الظاهر في الدائرة المذكورة من المراتب التنزلية إلى مركزها الهائي أربعة لما أنّ العدود هناك هي المراتب الوجودية التي أنزل بإزائها السبع المثاني، وإذا عدّت المراتب مطلقاً كان من حملتها ما هو الباعث للمتحرّك على النهوض نحو الحركة من النقطة إلى الألف وبه تحقّست، وفي قوله (ولم يحصل إلى آخره) إشارة إلى هذه النكتة فلا فتغل.

وعن خصائص ما عليه الأمر شهادة وغيبا عاجلا وأجلا، وذلك إنَّما يحتاج إليه الإنسان بحسب توجهه إلى الاستكمال العقلي الذي قدر لنوعه ثانيا وبالاختيار.

ثم إنَّ أفراد الإنسان منهم من ليس له الخطّ من الحرف إلّا الفائدة الأولى وليس لهم فضل امتياز في ذلك عن غيره من أنواع الحيوان سوى أنَّهم بذلوا جواهر الأحرف القديمة الساموية لتحصيل المآرب الحسيسة الدنيوية وابتدلوا نفائس ما أرسل به الرسل وأنزل عليه الكتب بتداوله بين أيديهم عند طلب جزئيات الأمور المتضعة حيث استعملوه في الأكاذيب وجعلوه وسيلة للسخرية في مستهزئات الأقاويل ومستقبحات التائيل. ومن ههنا ورد فيهم قوله تعالى ﴿وَلَنْتَكْ كَالْأَنْعَامِ بَلْ أَضَلُّ﴾ [١٧٩:٧]. ومنهم من جمع بين الفائدتين واستحصل من الحروف ما هو مقوم حقيقته الأصلية غير مقتنع في ذلك باستغذاء بدنه الجسائي واستبقاء قوته الطبيعية والحيوانية فقط بل [أس ١٦٣] سعى بها في طلب أقواته الروحانية وابتغى منها تقوية قواه المجردة مطلقا فيها على حقائق مشاهدات الملك ومغيبات الملكوت نائلا بها مراتب الملاء المقربين الذين لهم الطهارة عن حدث الحوادث وندس الناسوت. ثم إنَّ لهذه الطائفة مراتب متفاوتة ومسالك متباينة متباعدة، فإنَّ منهم من قصر طريق استحصال ذلك المطلب على ما عتبه أصل اللغة بوضعها الشخصي غير مجاوز عن ذلك أصلا حيث ما اعتبر في استعمال الألفاظ إلّا مدلولاتها اللغوية التي تدلّ عليها بحسب الحقيقة فقط، ومنهم من ترقى عن تلك المرتبة وجعل ما يتفرّع عن ذلك الأصل ويناسبه داخلا في مفهوم تلك الألفاظ حيث أدخل فنون المجازات والكنائيات وما هو المستفاد من صور العبارات وخواص [م ٧٦ب] التركيبات وبدائع الاستعارات تحت مدلولات تلك الألفاظ، فإنَّهم وإنَّ عبّروا عن الوضع الشخصي ووصلوا إلى النوعي منه وعثروا عليه ولكن لما حصروا وجوه تلك المناسبة فيما وصل إليهم من استعمالات العرب وأعيان بلغاتهم حيث جعلوا تتبع تراكيهم هو العمدة في تحصيل تلك الوجوه وقعوا ثما عليه الأمر في طرف بما قلّد كل خلف منهم لمن اعتقد فيه من السلف.⁹¹

وأما الرابعة فهي التي اختصّ به الكمال من أفراد الأنبياء وخُصّ الأولياء، وذلك أيضا له مراتب: فإنَّ منها [أس ٦٣ب] ما للدلالة اللغوية الوضعية فيها دخل، ومنها ما ليس للخارج فيها دخل أصلا. فإنَّ مباني أمر الدلالة عندهم إنَّما هو الإشارات الرقمية أو اللفظية أو النسب العددية، فإنَّها هي الأوضاع اللازمة للحروف عندما أنزلت على الأنبياء صلوات الله عليهم أجمعين، وما دون ذلك من الأوضاع الخارجية التي هي مراهص الدلالة التي تداولت عند العامة فتنزل في درجة الاعتبار عن ذلك كما ستطّلع على بيانه. ثم إنَّ هذه الدلالة المبنية على الإشارات الثلاث اللازمة للحرف هي الدلالة الأصلية التي للحروف بذواتها بدون توسط جعل ولا وسيلة وضع وهي التي تفرّد بها الحقي الختمي وانفقت على استعمالها كلمتهم.

وأما القسم الأوّل منها وهو الذي للوضع اللغوي فيها دخل ما، فقد اشترك فيها غيرهم من محققي الصوفية والحكماء الذين لهم شرب من عين الكمال الإنساني على اختلاف درجاتهم وتفاوت مهمهم ونياتهم،⁹² وذلك كما فهموا مثلا من المشكاة الواردة في آية النور [٣٥:٢٤] الروح الحساس. فإنَّ بعضهم فهموا منها ذلك من حيث أنّ نوره يخرج من ثقب عدّة كالعينين والأذنين والمنخرين، كما عثر عليه الغزالي. وبعضهم فهموا منها القوة الاستعدادية التي للنفس نحو المعقولات المسماة عندهم بالعقل الهولاني تشبها بإثاها بالهولي الأولى الخالية في نفسها عن جميع الصور المستعدّة لقبولها لا على التساوي لاختلاف السطوح والثقب فيها كما وقف عليه ابن سينا. وبعضهم فهموا منها هيئة البدن الإنساني الذي تحيط بالقلب من سائر الجوانب ويكون ذا ثقب ومنافذ ومجاري معيّنة تجري منها الروح الحيواني ويستنير به الأعضاء الباطنة [أس ١٦٢] الشريفة، أو لا بنوره كسطوحها الباطنة ويستنير به الأعضاء الظاهرة والأجرام البعيدة، ثانيا كسطوحها الظاهرة، كما تحقق به جدّي⁹³ وحققه في رسالته النورية. ومنهم من فهم

⁹¹ م: (بما ... السلف) صح.

⁹² م: (على اختلاف .. ونياتهم) صح.

⁹³ أي صدر الدين تركه، مؤلف قواعد التوحيد.

الغشاء الغليظ والقحف وسائر الأعضاء المحيطة بالدماغ والروح النفساني المتكون هناك، فإنَّ هيئتها بالنسبة إليه كهيئة كرة مجوفة بالنسبة إلى جرم أطف منه نير تحفظه في جوفها وهي ذات المنافذ والثقب تجري فيها ذلك النير ويتعكس ضوءه منها إلى الخارج كما هو حال النور الذي في المشكاة، فإنَّ الروح النفساني المتكون في تلك الكرة يجري في المنافذ أولاً ثمَّ يتعكس ضوءه إلى الأعضاء فحصل لها به الحس والحركة الإرادية كما انكشف على أخي وأستاذي وبين في رسالته. ومنهم من فهم منها عالم الشهادة حيث ظلمته في ذاته وقبوله لنور الوجود غير متساوي الأجزاء بل متخالفها في مظهره لذلك النور الواحد بالذات المتكثّر بحسب تكثّر أفراد المظاهر المشتل عليها العالم تكثّر النور الناري المحسوس الواحد بالذات حسب تكثّر الثقب التي في الشبكة المشكائية، كما ذهب إليه السالكون مسالك الحَيِّ الختِي الواقفون على حكّمهم العربية التي أفصحت عنها اللغة الاعرابية. ومنهم من فهم منها آدم وحواء والأولاد، كما فهم [أس ٤٦٢] من المصباح الحرف والنقطة والإعراب ومن الزجاجية النبوة والرسالة والولاية، كما أوماً إليه صاحب المحبوب. فهذا ما فهموا أعيان الأزمنة السابقة من هذه الآية نور الله ضريحهم بالرحمة والرضوان.

ويمكن أن يفهم منها المقادير الرقمية أو الصوتية التي يتقدّر بها النقط والنطق أولاً حيث أنّها أعراض كونية مظلمة بالذات، ثمَّ إذا أمّدها المادّة الوجودية في إحدى تبنك الصورتين وأشرق على سطوحها المتأثّلة القابلة أنوارها وتقومت المادّة بمقاديرها تكونت الصور الحرفية التي هي كالزجاجة لمصباح المعاني المنيرة المشعرة، والزجاجة هذه هي الكوكب الدرّي الموقد من الشجرة المباركة الآدمية التي لا اختصاص لها بشرق الوجوب ولا بغرب الإمكان. [م ١٧٧] وتكرّر الزجاج في الآية إشعار بما للحرف من الصورتين، كما أنّ قرب زيتا التي هي مادّة النور من الإضاءة مشعر بما له من المعنى العددي البين بذاته بدون الاحتياج إلى ميساس نار الصور المنيرة له.

وإنّما بسط الكلام في هذا القسم بحكاية وجوه الدلالات التي بها يناط فهم كلّ أحد من الذين يستنبطون الحكم الأصلية من الصور المنزلة السماوية ليكون أنموذجاً للمتيقّظ الفطن عندما أراد أن يستفهم الحقائق العلية من العبارات الكاشفة الختمية ويستنبط ما في بطنان الكتاب بدلالة المستبغات العددية، ومعيّاراً للناظر المستبصر عندما حاول انتقاد القرائح الصافية بما قدر لها من الترقّي [أس ١٦٥] إلى مدارج كمال الإنسان حسب تقارب الزمان، وسلماً للمسترشد الطالب عندما قصد الاستشراق إلى مراقبي بطون الآية⁹⁴ وبها استعدّ للعروج على مدارج حدودها ومطلّعها. وذلك لأنّ هذه الوجوه كلّها إنّما أفصحت عنها ألسنة المناسبات التي للأوضاع اللغوية فيها دخل، وأما الوجوه التي أفصحت عنها الحروف بحسب دلالاتها الأصلية التي لا دخل للخارج عنها أصلاً فيها وهذا اللسان يتيسّر بيان أكثر الحدود والمطلّع، فإنّما يتمكّن من الكشف عنها بعد تحقيق الأصول التي هي له كالمراهص، وقد قدّم لتمهيد بيان شطرٍ منها هذه المفاحص وفقنا الله تعالى لإتمام المرام فإنّه هو الهادي سواء السبيل بنور الختم الذي هو سراج مجامع التمام.

6. K. al-Mafāhīṣ, §4.74 (on the ontological status of prosody) (MS Majlis 10196 ff. 118b-19a, MS Esad Efendi 1731 ff. 206a-8a):

٧٢.٢) فخص حكي في صفح عروضي

وهو أنّ للاعتدال بهيئته المذكورة وظلاله الظاهرة المشهورة صورة يتبيّن بها في كلّ مرتبة من المراتب وجودية كانت أو ظهورية إشعارية منها أو شعورية. ثمَّ اعلم أنّ تلك الصورة من حيث أنّها ذات دلالة على مراتب ذلك الاعتدال ومبدأ تمييز للعالي منه

⁹⁴ م: (الآية) صح.

عن السافل يقال لها الميزان،⁹⁵ ويُنَّ أن دلالة الموازين كلّها على ما يقصد منها أعني التمييز والإبانة عن خصائص الأشياء ومراتب تحقّقها إنّما بحسب الوضع الحقيقي الذي قد أسّس بنیان بيانه في مباحث هذا الكتاب وشيّد مراهص تبيانه في هذا المفاحص والأبواب. وقد عرفت من قبل أن الدلالة التي للحروف أنفسها إلى المعاني إنّما هي بحسب ذلك الوضع، ثمّ أنّه ممّا ظهر ههنا⁹⁶ أنّ دلالات الموازين على مراتب الموزونات وخصائص كلّ منها عند امتحانها على محكّ الاستبصار من [أس ٢٠٦ب] الآيات الباهرة الدالّة على اعتبار هذا الوضع بين يدي عموم الناس واعتداد دلالتهم عند العقل إذا حاول استعمال المجهولات خالصة عن شوائب الشبهات. فتبيّن أنّ الدلالة التي للحروف أنفسها لها هذه المنزلة بين فنون ما لها من الدلالات.⁹⁷

ثمّ إذا تذكّرت هذا فاعلم أنّ الميزان على تنوّع أفنانه يرجع إلى أصول ثلاثة وفق ما ظهر لك في هذا الكتاب أنّها هي صورة المجالي الكلية التي للحروف المؤصّلة والصور المنزلة التي هي معيار الموازين كلّها. فإنّ لكلّ من تلك المجالي ميزانا بحسبها، وذلك أنّ ميزان العامة الذي هو بأيدي الناس يستخرجون مقادير الأشياء في فنون معاملاتهم وصنوف مقابلاتهم ومماثلاتهم هو الهيئة الميزانية المبصرة⁹⁸ التي هي بمنزلة الصورة الكتابية للحرف كما أنّ الأشعار التي تعاوت على ألسنتهم عند محاوراتهم ومقاولاتهم هي الهيئة الميزانية المسموعة⁹⁹ التي للصورة الكلامية. وأمّا الهيئة التي لها في الصورة العددية اللبائية فالظاهر منها لدى المدارك هي الصورة الانتظامية التي للغات الموسيقية والمزاج الفاضل المستحصل من اثتلاف تلك النسب ذات التقابل والتأثّل. واعلم أنّ بهذا المزاج ونسبها هذه صارت النغمت مؤثّرة في النفوس الفارغة الواعية إيّاها ضرورة أنّ ارتباط النسب القوية حاكم بسرّية سرّ أحد المنتسبين [أس ١٢٠٧] إلى الآخر.¹⁰⁰

ثمّ ههنا دقيقة أخرى تنطوي على أصول لا بدّ للفظن من الاطلاع عليها، وهي أنّك قد عرفت أنّ الصور الحرفية لها ضربان من الدلالة بحسب الوضعين المتخالفين اللذين طرأ لأفرادها، أحدهما الجعلي الصناعي الذي هو متعمّل الناس ومختلقهم، والآخر الحقيقي الطبيعي الذي لا دخل للتعمّل فيها أصلاً وهو المنزل من السماء على قلوب الأنبياء. فكذلك لكلّ من هذه الهيئات الميزانية الثلاث التي يازاء تلك الصور لها ذاك النوعان من الوضع بعينها: أمّا الهيئة الصورية الكتابية فالذي لها يازاء الوضع الجعلي هو الميزان المتعارف الذي بأيدي العامة يستعلمون به الكمّيات من الأشياء فقط، والذي لها يازاء الوضع الحقيقي هو التناسب الأصلي الفاضل المسقى بالحسن وهو الذي يستعلم منه المقادير التي للكيفيات والكمّيات والهيئات المركّبة منها. وأمّا الهيئة الصورية الكلامية فالذي لها يازاء الوضع الجعلي هو البحور العروضية التي يستعلم منها مقادير الكلمات وأوزانها التي هي من مقولة الكمّيات المتصلة منها، والذي لها يازاء الحقيقي من الوضعين هو الهيئة الفاضلة للكلام المستمّة في صناعة الأدب بحدّ الإعجاز، وإليه أشار

⁹⁵ م حاشية: وبيان ذلك أنّ من شأن الاعتدال النوعي المذكور تماثل أفرادها وتخالّف حقائق أعيانه ومعروضاته فهو صاحب التقابل والتأثّل فلذلك ترى له مراتب متباينة النسب في أمر تلك الحياطة التي ظهرت آثارها في أشخاص كلّ من تلك الأعيان. ثمّ إذا تفقّرت لك هذه المقدّمة فاعلم أنّ الصورة الشخصية منها كليات وهي التي احتوت الصورة الكونية التي لها على ضروب من المراتب التي للوجود بآثارها سواء كانت مراتب نوعه الذي هو تحته أو غيرها من المراتب، فإنّ إبانة الأمر من الشخص في هذا الموطن ما ظهر في طي التقابل والتأثّل وهذا كلام يحتاج إلى مقدّمات طويلة الأذنان قد ألف فيها الكتب ثمّ إنّ هذا الشخص باعتبار إباتته للمرتبتين المتقابلتين وتقيؤه العالي منها عن السافل يقال له الميزان وفي لفظه إشعار بلسان الإحصاء العقدي إلى الجمعية والتمييز: ا ل م ي ز ا ن = ١ ٧ ١٠ ٧ ٥١.

⁹⁶ م: (مما ظهر ههنا) صح.

⁹⁷ م: (إذا حاول ... الدلالات) صح.

⁹⁸ م: (المبصرة) صح.

⁹⁹ م: (المسموعة) صح.

¹⁰⁰ م: (والمزاج ... الآخر) صح.

قوله صلى الله عليه وسلم (إنّ من البيان لسحرا)،¹⁰¹ وذلك جامع بين سائر المقادير التي للكلمات والكيفيات والأوضاع. فإنّ [أس ٢٠٧ب] غاية البلاغة للكلام [م ١١٩م] وحدها المعجز هو النسبة الفاضلة الجامعة بين هذه المراتب في المسموع جمعية الحسن لها في المبصر بعينه. وأمّا الهيئة المعنوية اللبائية فالذي لها إزاء الوضع الجعلي هي الأقوال الموسيقية والأعمال ذات النغمات المنتظمة الموزونة بالإيقاعات الصناعية الظاهرة بين يدي ممترني تلك الصناعة وأرباب ملكاتها إتقان أصولها وإحكام آلتها، وأمّا الذي لتلك الهيئة إزاء الوضع الحقيقي فهي ذات النسبة الشريفة المكّلة التي يصحّ بها كلّ سقيم ويتمّ بها كلّ ناقص لنيم، وذلك هي النسبة التي من فاز بها وعلم طريق استحصالها نال المراتب السنية والمقامات العلية، وقد نبّهت على ذلك مرارا. ثمّ إنّ لهذا العلم أصولا وقواعد عند أهلها من الحكماء الذين هم تلامذة الأنبياء والأولياء، ولكن ما وقف عليها إلّا كلّ مبصّر بأساليب ألسنتهم ولغاتهم. فإنّ في كلام هؤلاء الكمل المقتدين بالأنبياء موارد عليّة قد صادف كلّ متأمل فيها منهله وقد علم منها كلّ أناس مشربه [٦٠:٢، ٦٠:٧].

هذا كلّ كلام وقع في البين، فلنرجع إلى ما كتنا بصدده بيانه هنا وذلك هو الحكم الختية التي في طي القواعد والأصول العروضية وسرّ سرّاتها هناك، وذلك أنّ الصورة الكلامية كما عرفت هي الذروة لهيكل الحروف وسنماحها وبها تيسر أمر الدعوة من الأنبياء وتحقق تمامها. فلذلك ترى الهيئة الميزانية التي اختصّت [أس ٢٠٨م] بهذه الصورة بين الهيئات التي لغيرها أعني البحور العروضية مدركة للعامة بطباعها حيث أنّ سائر الأفهام من الخواصّ والعوامّ قد ميّزت بين الصحيح منها والسقيم بدون أن يتوسّل في ذلك إلى آلة أو تتوقّف استنباطه على فكرة أو حالة. ومن ههنا ترى أمّهات تلك البحور إمّا تتقوّم أجزاؤها وتتأصّل أركانها على بنیان السبع المثاني كالذي يقال له الهزج والرمل والرجز، فإنّ هذه الأبحر إذ كانت سالمة عن العلل ترى حروفها هي السبع المثاني مصوّرة بهذه الصور الموزونة والأشكال الكلامية المطبوعة، وكذلك غيرها من البحور إذا أمعنت في تفصيل أجزائها متّزنة بالميزان المعدّ العددي وجدت لها مطابقا من تنوّعات صورها النورانية التي في صدور السور القرآنية. ثمّ إنّ من بدائع وجوه التطابق ههنا ما بين الموصلات¹⁰² التي تصوّر بها السبع المثاني وبين الصور الحقيقية التي لها، أعني الحروف المرسل بها الخاتم العربي صلوات الله وسلامه عليه وعلى آله أجمعين، حيث أنّ أعداد الساكن الذي سكن عن التحرك تحت حمل النقط وأعباء تعيّناتها إمّا هي إثنا عشر في صورتين هاتين. فإنّ الصورة الجمعية التي للموصلات بمنزلة الألف للكلّ في الحروف،¹⁰³ ثمّ إنّ تحت هذه الدقيقة لطيفة غير خفية.

¹⁰¹ م: (واليه ... لسحرا) صح.

¹⁰² م: (وكذلك ... الوصلات) صح.

¹⁰³ م: (فان الصورة ... الحروف) صح.

P.2: Edition of letters referenced

1. Munsha'āt-i Turka, letters from Ibn Turka:¹⁰⁴

(۱) به شرف الدین علی یزدی¹⁰⁵

بشرف مطالعه اعلی جناب اخوی حقایق قبایی فضایل ایابی عظم الله شانۀ شرفا رسانند بالخیر و العافیة.

هو

متعنی الله تعالی بیامن لقائه شرفا و رزقی عاجلا من لطایف محاوراته طرفا بدعوات اشتیاق¹⁰⁶ آیات که منبعث از صفای طویات¹⁰⁷ باشد خود را فرا خاطر جناب اخوی حقایق قبایی فضایل مآبی میآرد¹⁰⁸ رقی که بر صحایف محبت و دلنوازی کشیده بودند در اعز اوقات رسید و سبب بهجت و شادمانی آمد و هم در آن اثنا ناگاه از ممکن تقلبات معتنق الاطراف خطابی طرفه رسید و بسی مشاغل عادی و شواغل اعتیادی از صحایف اعتبار محو کرد، چنانچه تفصیل احوالش از تقریر دارنده حمید مستفاد تواند شد. فی القصة ساعت تحریر که در طی لیلۀ السبت سادس عشر اولی الجمادین واقعست عازم صوب حجاز گشت از طرف اصفهان یسره الله تعالی و چند روزی در هر جا تعللی خواهد بود. اگر تسکین نایره شوق بخطوات اقدام دست ندهد و میسر نشود، متوقع که از خطابات اقلام¹⁰⁹ بهره ور فرمایند مشاعر حسّی را که موج تطورات زمان¹¹⁰ چهره گشائی غریب بنیاد کرده.

تا سخر چشم یار چه بازی کند که باز بنیاد بر کرشمۀ جادو نهاده شد¹¹¹

اسباب جمع شمل علی احسن الوضع و اقرب الحمل متّسق و منتظم باد بمحمّد و آله صلوات الله و سلامه علیه و علیهم اجمعین.

کمترین فقرا، صابین ترکه

¹⁰⁴ م = مجلس ۱۰۱۹۶ (TMN/M)، مس = مجلس سنا ۳۱۶ (TMN/MS)، د = دانشگاه ۲۵۷۶ (TMN/D).

¹⁰⁵ م ۱۶۰، مس ۱.

¹⁰⁶ مس: استجابت.

¹⁰⁷ مس: طویت.

¹⁰⁸ مس: میآورد.

¹⁰⁹ مس: خدمات خطابات.

¹¹⁰ مس: قطرات زمانی.

¹¹¹ مس: نهاده ایم.

حاشیه: زمره اصحاب را بجمع¹¹² سلام میرساند خصوص وقفه الله لقضوی الکالات یعقوبا¹¹³ را ممتع بادند.

(۱۳) به درویش احمد [سمرقندی]¹¹⁴

بشرف مطالعة نور حقیقه ملک و دین برسانند بالخیر و العافیه.

هو

اللهم کیا وقفته علی مواقف الکمال فوقته [للاحتطاء به] فی احسن الاحوال. بعد از رفع دعائی که از رسوم رعونت و ریا عاری باشد و بشیوه صدق و صفا مزین و حالی ... ممالک [سرای] میکند که هر چند دیده جسمانی از مشاهدۀ [محبتا ...] بخش حظی ندیده ولیکن تلاقی روحانی که از ... سماع اوصاف جبلّی و احوال حقیقی بحکم (ربّ ... الی قلب من الاذن) رو نموده ز حرمسرای تواصل جانی که اهل تحقیق آن را اجتماع عیانی خوانند کمال ... و صفای توجّهی پذیرفته که در خلوت [ایشان] اتفاق [شمع] و کشف الغطاء بر افروخته:

هر چه از دیده [دید می زین بیش] آوازه گوشم ... [خویش]

لا شک دقیقه [نسبتی] که [بوثیقه] ﴿او القی السمع وهو شهید﴾ [۳۷:۵۰] مستحکم گردد تاثیر آن گردانید و نتیجه آن ارجمند خواهد بود.

با جانب تبریز رو وز شمس الدین محظوظ شو یا از زبان صادقان از صدق بنا باوری

از این رو ترجمان وقت را شرح قصیده نظم الدرر که چندی از اطوار محبت در آنجا مبین گشته در صحبت درویش احمد سلمه الله بشرف مطالعه فرستاد تا مذکر این معنی تواند شد. اسباب عروج بر مراقی کمال متسق و منتظم باد بمحمد و آله صلوات الله و سلامه علیه و علیهم اجمعین.

کمترین فقرا، صابین ترکه

¹¹² مس: (بجم) ساقط.

¹¹³ مس: یعقوب.

¹¹⁴ مس ۸-۹.

۱۶) به استدعای سید نعمة الله از زبان ایشان در جواب به شاهرخ¹¹⁵

حضرت علیه سلام الله علیه باستدعاء سید نعمة الله، از زبان ایشان این جواب مکتوب در جهت استدعاء حضور سید از اصفهان بیزد نوشته بودند در زمان گرفتن امیرزاده اسکندر بامیرزاده شاهرخ نوشته.¹¹⁶

هو

أَرْجُ النسيمَ سَرى عن الزوراء سحرًا فأحيا ميّت الأحياء

منشور میسور آمال و امانی و طغرای [ظفرزای/ظفررای] دولت و کامرانی یعنی لمعان برق عنایتی که از وادی ایمن الطاف الهی و بقعه مبارکه عوارف و اعطاف پادشاهی درخشیدن گرفته، مقتضای فحوی ﴿آئی﴾¹¹⁷ آنست از شجره مراحم ثمره آن معاین گشت.

برق از منزل جانان بدرخشید سحر وه که با خرمن عُشاق دلفکار¹¹⁸ چه کرد

و هدهد تفقدی که از سباء مکرمت حاء مظهر رحمت رحانی وارث ایهت و حشمت سلیمانی لازالت رایات دولته مقرونه بالتائید الرثائی¹¹⁹ و آیات سعادت و اقباله متلوّة بالسنّة التوفیق الصمدانی وارد شد. از نوازش آب حیات آیاتش فحوی¹²⁰ ﴿آئی﴾ آلتی إلى کتاب کریم ﴿[۲۷:۲۹] صورت حال آمد.

أتانی کتاب سَرنی طیب نشره ینادمنی منه¹²¹ الخطاب واطربا
وبشّر بالیوم الذي فيه يلتقي إلاّ أنّه یوم یكون له بنا

بعد از تقدیم مراسم استکانت نقاوه دل و جان که خلاصه شهرستان پیکر انسانی ایشانند برسم استقبال مورد همایونش بر یکدیگر¹²² مسابقت و پیشگیری نمودند در منزل اکرام و افضال نزول اجلال فرموده.

کناجّه قد قُض عنها ختامها¹²³

¹¹⁵ م ۱۴۸، مس ۱۱-۱۲، د ۱۷۰-۱۷۳.

¹¹⁶ مخ د ۱۷۰: باستدعای حضرت مقدّسه از زبان ایشان در جواب امیرزاده شاهرخ نویسد.

¹¹⁷ نک م ۱۲۲.

¹¹⁸ مس د: دل افکار.

¹¹⁹ د: الرحانی.

¹²⁰ مس د: (فحوی) ساقط.

¹²¹ د: من.

¹²² م: یکدیگر.

همچو بدری که برآید شهب¹²⁴ و [بحور] فراق

و چون فحوی عواطف مطاوی آن محتوی بر صنوف نوازش پادشاهانه و مشتمل بر فنون مرام خسروانه یافت، هر آینه مؤدای¹²⁵ آیه کریمه ﴿اذکروا نعمة الله علیکم﴾ [۳:۱۰۳ و...] از خلال سطور سحر آفرینش مشاهده افتاد و فحوی فرموده ﴿وان تعدّوا نعمة الله لا تحصوها﴾ [۱۴:۳۴، ۱۶:۱۸]، از لطایف عبارات و بدایع استعارات عنایت غایات آن معاین شد، هر آینه آنرا بقوافل دعوات استجابت آیات مقابل گردانید، چنانچه آثار میامن آن بر صفحات روزگار همایون دولت ابد پیوند ظاهرست و خواهد شد.

شهباز دولت تو که پرواز میکند خود صبر کن که چشم کنون باز میکند

و حقیقت آنکه دعای دولت چنین پادشاهی که از مبادی ایام¹²⁶ طفولیت باز هرگز دامن دژآه اعمالش بشایه گرد عصیان آلوده نشده، هر جا که در ربع مسکون الحاله هذه [سره] امنی دمیده یا شکوفه عدالتی شکفته از آبیاری تیغ ستم سوز او شده، و در هر گوشه¹²⁷ که شمع جمعیتی افروخته با قندیل عبادت خانه در گرفته از فروغ رای عالم آرای اوست بر ذمت همت اهل اسلام مطلقا بل ملت جبلت نوع انسان جملتا، واجب و لازم آید.

برین باشد آنکس که او آدمیست

و از جمله دلایل کمال¹²⁸ ذات شریف و عنصر لطیف آن سلطان ممالک صورت و معنی آنست که با وجود اشتغال اوقات همایونش بنشر آیات معدلت و بسط آثار رأفت از حال گوشه نشینان خانقاه معنی غافل نشده بسط بساط مباسطت و مخاطبت نمودند¹²⁹ و بساط عوارف و مرام خسروانه دعوت فرمودند.

آری آری از چنانکس اینچنین آید همی

و بی تکلف آنکه هوای استلام بساط سعادت انبساط دیرهاست که آتش شوق و نیازمندی در نهاد این فقیر نهاده و درین¹³⁰ وقت که التفات آفتاب اشراق پرتو دژه پروری بر صوب این ممالک انداخت لواح ثوران¹³¹ آن تضاعف پذیرفت¹³² و باز چون بگوشه ابروی¹³³ قلم اشارت وصال بشارت ارزانی فرموده عنان اختیار از قبضه اختیار در ربوده.¹³⁴

¹²³ علی بن محمد التهامی (م ۱۰۲۵/۴۱۶)، قصیده (هل الوجد الا أن تلوح خیالها).

¹²⁴ مس د: شب.

¹²⁵ م د: مودی.

¹²⁶ مس د: (ایام) ساقط.

¹²⁷ م: و هر گوشه.

¹²⁸ مس د: کالات.

¹²⁹ مس: خطاب نمودند؛ د: خطاب نمودن.

[ما یوهی/ما یوئی؟] مست و ساقی پر دهد پیمانه را

و هر چند که درین وقت که قهرمان طبیعت تیغ حرارت آفتاب را مغیلان وار در راه انداخته و قوای طبیعی که مراکب و مطایای¹³⁵ طی این راهست روی در سستی نهاده ولیکن سلطان عشق بر فحوی

بادر فما کلّ وقت ینجح الطلب

دم بدم تشحید¹³⁶ حدود عزیمت میفرماید کردن و هر آینه حکم او بر مملکت ظهور و اظهار روانست و روان خواهد بود ازین جهت واجب دید که پیشترک از وصول قدم زبان قلم به بندگی و ثناخوانی و عذرخواهی قیام نماید.

هر چند پر و خسته دل و ناتوان شدم لیکن چو عزم وصل تو کردم جوان شدم

سایه چتر معدلت گستر بر عالم و عالمیان مبسوط باد بمحمد و آله صلوات الله و سلامه علیه و علیهم اجمعین.

(۱۷) به امیرزاده بایسنغر¹³⁷

حجّاب بارگاه گیتی پناه خلد الله تعالی فی مرضیه مآثر سلطنته و رأفته معرّ الممالک والدین امیرزاده بایسنغر فتح نموده، بعزّ عرض رسانید بالخیر والعافیه.

هو

اللهم كما تورت سریر السلطنه بظلال جلاله فاحرس عن عین الکمال جمال اقباله [کمترین] دعاگویان دولت روزافزون و [کهنترین] هو[ا]داران خاک آشیان است حیوان نشان همواره بتقدیم وظایف دعوات استجابت آیات خود را در سلک غلامان و مقبولان درگاه گیتی پناه میکشد و زبان حالش بمؤدای آن گفته مترنم.

¹³⁰ مس د: و این.

¹³¹ د: سوران.

¹³² د: پذیرفته.

¹³³ د: ابرو.

¹³⁴ مس د: درر بود.

¹³⁵ مس د: مطاوی.

¹³⁶ د: تشخید.

¹³⁷ م ۱۷۲، مس ۱۲-۱۳، د ۱۷۳-۱۷۵.

ای باد صبحدم چو بر آن سوی بگدزی از ما سگان آن سرکو را سلام کن
در دل خیال آن رخ و آنکه حدیث شوق اندازۀ تو نیست زبان را بکام کن

حرفی که پیشتر از این منشیان براعت شعار بر صحایف تربیت و دژه پروری کشیده بودند درین وقتها بدین فقیر رسید و آنرا تاج تارک بهجت و افتخار ساخت.

سر بگذرانم از سر گردون بگردنی گر بگذرد بخاطر تو یاد چون منی¹³⁸

اشارتی که در باب رساله و ایراد شخصی بر آن فرموده بودند حال آنکه سخنانی که در آن رساله ثبت گشته همه بر قواعد و اساس دلایل نقلی و عقلی مبتنی گشته. اگر ایراد از مسلک طالب علمی کرده همانا از خاطر فضلا که در پایه سرپرند جواب آن غایب نخواهد بود بعد از تأمل و اگر از مسلک طامات و مرمت دگان شیخیت آن نیز بر زیرکان کوی فطانت و هوشمندی پوشیده نباشد. غرض که چون آن سخن بعینه ذکر نرفته بود بغیر از این جهات اجمالی در جواب صورت توجیه ندارد. جهانپناها این نوع سخن نو عروس عالم غیبت دست هر نارسیده بدامن ادراک آن نخواهد رسید و بجز مردانِ مرد محرم آن نیستند چون امر عالی پادشاه بود نبشته شد که (المأمور معذور) اگر چه بسیار مردم خود را در صورت اهل کمال مینمایند ولیکن این طایفه بغایت غایت عزیزند.

روز صید آن سوار از این نخجیر پر بیفکند لیک کم بر داشت¹³⁹

بیش ازین اوقات لطیف را مکدر ساختن ادب نیست. سایه چتر معدلت آثار بر عالم و عالمیان مبسوط باد بمحمد و آله صلوات الله و سلامه علیه و علیهم اجمعین.

کمترین فقرا، صابین ترکه

(۲۰) به امیرزاده شاهرخ¹⁴⁰

اللهم یا ظاهر کما جعلت خلدۀ مظهر الرأفة فخلّد ملکه و سلطانه محروسا عن کل آفة. بعد از اقامت وظایف دعا که همواره در اوقات شریفه که مقتضای فرموده (ادعونی استجب لکم) در آن هنگام امیدوار باشد و آن زمان [بنود در ره دعا پرده]¹⁴¹ مواظبت نموده و خواهد نمود. بعزّ عرض پایه سریر معدلت صریر میرساند که خدا آگاهست که نیت این فقیر در استادگی¹⁴²

¹³⁸ اوحدی، غزل (سر بگذرانم از سر گردون به گردنی).

¹³⁹ اوحدی، ترجیع (در خرابات عاشقان کویت).

¹⁴⁰ مس ۱۷، د ۸۲-۸۳.

¹⁴¹ مس: عاپرده.

¹⁴² مس: استاگی.

نمودن بخدمت شریعت دو چیزست. اولاً رو سپیدی در نزد حضرت رسالت صلوات الله و سلامه علیه،¹⁴³ و دوم آنکه چون در زمان دولت چنین پادشاهی دین پرور واقع شده بخدمتی که از دست این فقیر بر میآید خود را داخل دیگر خدمتکاران کرده باشد چه این دولت بزرگتر از آنست که هر کس خود را قوت ادراک جلال¹⁴⁴ آن باشد:

باش تا سر آن شود پیدا باش تا کار آن رسد بظهور

حاليا درویشی فرستاده و چند مهم ضروری جهت رواج آن خدمت بعرض رسانیده که ثواب را بفرمایند جوابهای آن را بر وجهی کردن که آثار مرحمت بر آن ظاهر گردد از معدلت گستری و شریعت پروری دور خواهد بودن. دیگر آنکه چون در باب خواص اشیا و علوم است غریب چیزی چند یافته بود که مناسب مزاج مبارک آید، هر آینه از روی خدمتکاری واجب نمود فرستادن - انشاءالله مقبول افتد. سایه چتر معدلت پرتو بر عالمیان مبسوط باد بمحمد و آله صلوات الله علیه و علیهم اجمعین.

کینه خاکساران، صاین ترکه

(۳۶) به خواجه تاج الدین حسن عطار¹⁴⁵

اللهم كما ضوّعت البلاد بعطر انفاسه الکرمة و نورتها بظلال جلاله العمیة فلا تضيّع عبادک و متّعهم بالاستفاضة عن تلک الحضرة العظیمة. همواره بوسیله رفع دعوات اخلاص آیات و عرض خدمات اختصاص غایات خود را عرضه تذکر اوقات قدسی ساعات و خلوات معارف برکات میکند و بمیامن فرموده (و لکل وجهة هو مولیها) امیدوارست که آثار التفات فیض بخش و انوار باطن غیب نقش بر صفحات احوال طالبان دردمند ظاهر گردد و متعظشان بادی شوق را بزال کمال خاص که از سر چشمه ﴿قَدْ عَلِمَ كُلُّ اُنَاسٍ مَّشْرِیْهِمْ﴾¹⁴⁶ زاینده شده سیراب گرداند:

[الاقول] لسگان وادی¹⁴⁷ الحیب هنیئا لک بالجنان الخلود
افیضوا علینا من الماء فیضا فنحن عطاش و اتم ورود

و چون گاه گاهی برشحات افلام ارشاد اقالیم ریاض محبت مخلصان و مریدان جانی را تازگی و طراوت میبخشند سر رشته امیدواری را استحکامی هر چه تمامتر میشود و دست امل در¹⁴⁸ عروه وقتی عنایت اصلی و محبت ازلی میزند و ظاهرا و

¹⁴³ مس: علیه و علیهم.

¹⁴⁴ مس: قوت جلال ادراک.

¹⁴⁵ م ۵۱، مس ۲۹، د ۲۰۶-۲۰۷.

¹⁴⁶ ۲:۶۰، ۷:۱۶۰.

¹⁴⁷ مس د: واد.

¹⁴⁸ د: به.

باطنا استمداد همت میناید انشاءالله اعته التفات شریفه بسوی مخلصان قدیم منعطف فرمایند چنانچه آثار آن همگنان مشاهده نمایند. بیش از این مبالغه نمودن ادب ندانست.¹⁴⁹

ز اهل کرم حاجت سؤال نباشد

سایه ارشاد پناهی بر مفارق عالمیان از طالبان و دردمندان گسترده باد بمحمد و آله صلوات الله و سلامه علیه و علیهم اجمعین.

کمترین فقرا، صاین ترکه¹⁵⁰

ملحق: مریدن حلقه ارادت و معتکفان آستان افاضت را بسلام مخصوص گردانیده فحوی (یا لیتنی کنت معهم) تذکار میکند، متوقع که از گوشه خاطر عاطرشان فراموش نباشد، ممتع بادند.

(۳۷) به سید قاسم انوار¹⁵¹

اللهم كما تورت مواطن البلاد و بواطن العباد بظلال اجلال ارشاده سیدا قاسما لحظوظ الطالبین فاصرف عین الکمال عن فیضان عیون کماله برحمتک یا ارحم الراحمین. اوقات قدسی ساعات اعلی مواقف نقابت قبای ارشاد مآبی که پرتو انوار (قی) مع الله ظلمات) رسوم عادی را دور گردانیده باشد عرضه عرض دعوات اخلاص آیات که زلال صفایش از غبار رعونت مبرا باشد و نسیم قبولش از رواج رسوم عادی مقدس و معزا میگردد، و حقا که لحظه دیگر که در لحاظ التفات ارشاد آیات بفنون اشارات حقایق عبارات فایز و مستعد گشته همان را سر دفتر ایام شادمانی¹⁵² و عنوان روزنامه آمال و امانی دانست

مواطن آمالی و مربی ماری و اطوار اوطاری¹⁵³ و مأمن [خیفی]
بجرعه تو سرم مست گشت نوشت یاد خود از کدام خمست اینکه در سبوداری

چون از ژنده هزار منحنی نجیه ملامت که پوشش پیشین دل خرجه خونین در وقت نزول [نیر] طراز طرزی روی نمود که صورت آن را بعزّ عرض پایه سریر اعلی رسانیدن واجب شد درویشان را که احرام آن حرم کرم دیربست که بسته بودند فرصت دانسته متوجه [استسعاد] بدان عرفات عرفان گردانید و¹⁵⁴ یقین که لحاظ التفات معهود که سرمایه مطالب و

¹⁴⁹ مس د: نیست.

¹⁵⁰ مس د: (کمترین فقرا صاین ترکه) ساقط.

¹⁵¹ مس ۲۹-۳۰، د ۲۰۷-۲۰۹.

¹⁵² د: ایام و شادمانی.

¹⁵³ مس: و اطوار اوطاری.

¹⁵⁴ مس: (و) ساقط.

مآرست دریغ نخواهند فرمود و اگر گاهی قلم حقایق ترجمان را فرمایند که سری صحایف اخلاص هواداران قدیم جنباند و احوال مزاج مبارک که دایما پیش نهاد خاطر میباشد اعلام بخشد از مکارم جبلّی بعید و بدیع نخواهد بودن. بیش از این اوقات گرانمایه را مشغول داشتن ادب ندانست، سایه سجّاده ارشاد پرتو بر طالبان ممدود و مبسوط باد.

ملحق: ملازمان آستان ارشاد آشیان را بدعوات اشتیاق آیات مخصوص داشته دایما استمداد از همم عالیّه ایشان میکنند بزرگانی که ایشان را در سباط انبساط درویشان نصیبی و نوالی میباشد و همه را خدمات میرساند سیمّا اعلیٰ جناب سعادت مآب تقویٰ قباب فتویٰ آیات لازال بعلوّ شانه عزیزا فی مصر الفضایل علی مسند الافادة بین الامثال جلالا للفضيلة و المکارم و الشریعة و الدین یوسفّا که بی شایه تکلف واسطه عقد فضلی دهرند و نادره کاملان عصر ممتّع بادند.

(۳۸) به سیّد قاسم انوار¹⁵⁵

مطیفان¹⁵⁶ آستانه ارشاد آشیانه اعلیٰ موقف سیادت قبابی ارشاد مآبی لازال بظلال جلاله سیّدا فی العالمین قاسما بحظوظ الطالبین و المسترشدين فتح نموده بعزّ عرض رسانند بالخیر و العافیه.

هو

اللهم كما تورت العالم بظلال جلاله فمتّع العالمین بطول بقائه و کسب کماله اوقات قدسی ساعات اعلیٰ مواقف ولایت پناهی ارشاد ملاذی سیادت قبابی حقایق مآبی عرفان ایابی را لازال ظلال جلاله موطن استرشاد الطالبین و جمال کماله مستتر قلوب العاشقین و العارفين. عرضه عرض دعوات اخلاص آیات و خدمات اختصاص غایات میگردد، و حقّا که در آن چند روز که قران دولت و اقبال اقتضای انخراط در سلک مستفیضان و مقتبسان انوار هدایت از مشکوة ولایت کرد آن را بیت القصیده¹⁵⁷ عمر و زندگانی دانست:

جعلناهن تاریخ الیالی و عنوان المسرة و الامانی

عذر اصناف الطاف که مطیفان آستانه هدایت آشیان فرموده اند چون از آن نیست که السنه تقریر و تحریر بیان سطری از آن وفا تواند نیز حواله بکرم عمیم درویشان کردن بمنهج صواب اقرب دانست.

نفس می نیارم ز [داز] لطف دوست که شکری ندانم که درخورد اوست

¹⁵⁵ مس ۳۰-۳۱، د ۲۰۹-۲۱۰.

¹⁵⁶ د: مطیعان.

¹⁵⁷ د: (و) ساقط.

چون دارنده را احرام حرم کرم بسته دید نخواست که صحبت او خالی از عرض نیازمندی¹⁵⁸ باشد. اسباب مراقی کمال متشوق
باد بمحمد و آله صلوات الله و سلامه علیه وعلیهم اجمعین.

¹⁵⁸ د: نیازی.

2. Munsha'āt-i Turka, letters to Ibn Turka:

(١) مكتوب شريف حضرت سيدي سلام الله عليه [از سيّد حسين اخلاطى]¹⁵⁹

الحمد لله الذي بالتقوى تقوى عن الهبوط إلى مهاوي اللغات وبالنجوى تنجو لأن تنحو نحو النحويات وبتصرف باريك تنصرف لأن تتصرف بتصرف التصريفات. ب س م الله الرحمن الرحيم. ربّ اشرح لي صدري ويسّر لي أمري وأحلل عقدة من لساني يفقهوا قولي. خليلي إني باذر في دياركم ﴿بذراً يضلّ الإسم والوصف والرسا﴾ فإن شئتُما أن تخصدا ما بذرتُما ﴿فقوموا لتعديل الصفات بلا عذرا﴾ ﴿إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَذِكْرَ لِمَن كَانَ لَهُ قَلْبٌ أَوْ أَلْقَى السَّمْعَ﴾ وهو شهيد ﴿[٥٠:٣٧]﴾. ف الحمد لله الذي أدار مراده¹⁶⁰ [بمّره] ف عدل مراده بمزيد فتوحاته فأعناه بالعادات عن تطواف العبادات ﴿ذلك فضل الله يؤتيه من يشاء﴾¹⁶¹ من أهل الدرايات¹⁶² المتخلّصين من مطامير الدركات.

بعد تبليغ النحية والإكرام والتبجيل والاحترام إلى جناب الأمير الخطير والبدر المنير والبحر الغزير واسطة عقد إخوانه والمتخصّص بخواص [إليه] من أهل زمانه، جعله الله للمتقين إماماً وأنزل به عليهم سكينته وعصاماً. فالمرجو من فضله تأليف مقدّمات وتشكيل اقتراعات يكون ناتجة جمع الشمل بأحسن الرّي وأطرى الزين ناثرة لكلّ وحشة وبين. أيّما الناظر في هذا النوال ومسالكها كنت من كنت ما لك منها إلا ما للأئمة من الألوان فالأولى إسراحه في بقعة الإمكان وعدم التعرّض له بكان وكان، فإنّ (للحروب رجال وللثريد رجال) وكلّ ميسّر لما خُلق له. وهذا الأسلوب كان كامناً في قعورة مكامنه وإتما أبرزه خصوصية الزمان، فإن الزمان قد استدار كهينته يوم خلق الله السماوات والأرض فلهذا المناسبات نتج ما نتج. فبعد أن صرّت أيّما الأمير أضيافنا ببذل محبوبك وحسن اعتقادك صرّت ضيفنا، فلو لم نصفك بعد أنّا كُنا متّصفين (بشّر الناس من أكل وحده)، لكن لا بدّ من مشكلة بين الغذاء والمغتذي وإلا السكوت في بعض المواطن غاية البلاغة. لكن الرزق بالذات طالب للمرزوق على أي قدر وصفه كان:

اف اف ١٦٢	٤٤٥	لف اون اون ٢٢٤	ام الف اوون لف اوون ٣٨٨	لف اين ١٧٣
طعام	الواحد	يكني الإثنين	وطعام الإثنين	الأربعة وطعام الثانية ¹⁶³
١٢٠	١٩	٦١١	٦١١	٢٧٨ ٦٠٦
واحد	ثمانين	أربعائة		لف اين ١
١٩	٦٥١	٣٢٩		٧٨٣ ١٧٣
				٣٢ ١٧٣

¹⁵⁹ م - ٣.ب.

¹⁶⁰ حاشية: اقبال.

¹⁶¹ ق ٥٤:٥، ٥٧:٢١، ٦٢:٤.

¹⁶² حاشية: العلوم.

¹⁶³ مسلم، صحيح، كتاب الأشربة، باب ٣٣، حديث ٥٤٨٩؛ الترمذي، سنن، كتاب الأطعمة عن رسول الله (ص)، باب ٢١، حديث ١٩٣٤؛ إلى آخره.

این لف یم

۲۲۱

لف اون ام ایم ۲۶۰

ی ه ۱۲۸۵
۷۰۰
۵۷۰
۱۲۷۰

فاجمع الأعداد رحمة وشفقة وتنزلاً ترى الحاصل
ترى أمر الوجود يقوم. وإن أضيف الأسماء إلى المستميات تنبع سبعة عشر وفيه ما فيه. فهذا هز¹⁶⁴ لجذع النخل وإزالة لغلط
الوسن¹⁶⁵ لمن كان له قلب، فالمرجو أن المؤمن لا بد^{۱۳۷ ۵۷۰} أن يستطعم ما عند الله فإنهم أضيافه وعلى بساطه
وردوا، فهم ثلاثة أيام في ضيافته فيؤول إلى ستة^{۷۰۷} والسابع نهايته، فالمرجو فيه انقشاع¹⁶⁶ الظلمة التي
خلقوا فيها فالبشارة لمن وافى هذه المدة ويكون مؤمناً فينادى:

ستبدي لك الأيام ما كنت جاهلاً ويأتيك بالأخبار من لم تزود¹⁶⁷

اللهم رقق الحجب وكثر النصب¹⁶⁸ والعناء¹⁶⁹ بدل الفناء بسر ما في ب س م الله الرحمن الرحيم
۶۹۹ ۱۱۷ ۲۸۳ ۷۸۶

(۲) از قاضی زاده رومی در سمرقند به حضرت علیه صاینته¹⁷⁰

این مکتوب از سمرقند قاضی زاده رومی بحضرت علیه صاینته خلد الله تعالی ظلال جلاله و جماله و کماله الى يوم الدين نوشته
در صحبت کاتب.

هو

¹⁶⁴ حاشیه: حرکت.

¹⁶⁵ حاشیه: قدر.

¹⁶⁶ حاشیه: انکشاف.

¹⁶⁷ البيت من معلقة طرفه بن العبد.

¹⁶⁸ حاشیه: بت.

¹⁶⁹ حاشیه: مشقت.

¹⁷⁰ م ۱۵۳ ب.

بعزّ عرض عتبه عليه و سده سنیه حضرت شریعت شعاری طریقت دثاری حقیقت آثاری خواجه صابن الدین صان الله تعالى حوزة الکلام ببركة ذاته العظمی و میامن آیاته الکبری رسد بالخیر ان شاء الله وحده.

یناجیکم سري و ان کنت نائبا ويلزم روجي دون جسمي ذراکم

پیوسته تا منهل اهل شریعت و مشرب عذب ارباب حقیقت مورد ورود عطاء دین و محلّ وفود امناء یقینست صفحات الواح شرع برشحات اقلام معاهد گشای و صحایف مواقف آثار حق برکات ارقام حقایق نمای خدام عتبه علیه حضرت ولایت شعاری وراثت دثاری ختمی اتی، اسبغ الله علی العالمین سجال نوال افاضته و ابد علیهم ظلال جلال افادته صونا للدين و عوناً للیقین مزین و محلی باد. تضرّع و ابتهاج و خاکساری و نیازمندی بخاکبوس آستان عالیشان که کیمیای حیوة ابدی و توتیای بینائی سرمديست متعالی و متجاوز از آنست که بنان بیان بتحریر و تقریر آن شروع تواند نمود.

مرادي من النطق ذكري لکم مراي من الطرف لقیام
فلو لاک ما عرفنا الهوی ولولا الهوی ما عرفناکم

امید که ستاره سعادت که متکفل شرف این امنیت آیهت باشد از افق غیب بر ساحت شهادت طالع و تابان گردد.

ازین پس گر سعادت دست گیرد سر آرم در حضورت عمر باقی

از آن وقت که حضرت بارفعت سلطنت پناهی خلد ملکه در هراة [بهجت] ملاقات مسرور و بین استفاده و استفاضه مستعد گشتند و بوعده توجه بدین جانب موعود شدند پیوسته مترصد و مترقب میامن مقدم میمون و همواره متفحص اخبار و احوال همایون میباشند ان شاء الله تعالى که این وعده پر سرور با حبور عن قریب باحسن وجوه صورت انجام پذیرد. الحق که ﴿شجرة مبارکه﴾ طبع لطیف که ﴿یکاد زيتها يضيء ولو لم تمسه نار﴾ از آثار انوار آن صحبت سمت ﴿نور علی نور﴾ پذیرفته سوی آنجناب انجذاب یافته، ﴿یهدی الله لنوره من یشاء﴾ [۲۴:۳۵]. رساله بسمله¹⁷¹ که سر دفتر اسرار نامتناهی الهی و مقصوده ابکار افکار ﴿لم یطمئن انس قبلهم ولا جان﴾ [۵۵:۵۶، ۷۴] همانا که همان خواهد بود بعزّ عرض رسید و در موقع قبول تاء و احترام تمام واقع گشت، خدمت اخوی اعزّی اکرمی را لازال ظهیرا للدين و نصیرا للیقین که حامل آن یتیمه روزگار و یتیمه اهل اعتبار بود بانظار الطاف التفات بسیار نمودند و بتعظیم و توقیر استفسار احوال ذات بی همال فرمودند و تحیت و درود فرستادند. و چون آن برادر عزیمت عود (یا لیتی کنت معه) فرمود بنده کینه بدین ضراعت عبودیت انبساط نمود ذیل عفو مبسوط خواهد بود.

وان لم اقر حقًا الیک بنسبة لعزتها حسبی افتخاری بهمتی

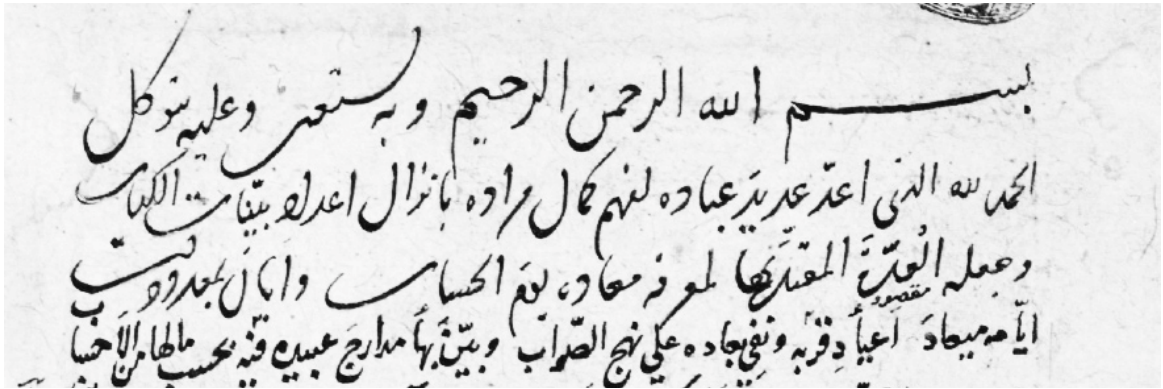
ظلّ ظلیل ممدود و مواید فواید نا معدود الی الیوم الموعود گسترده باد.

عبده موسی

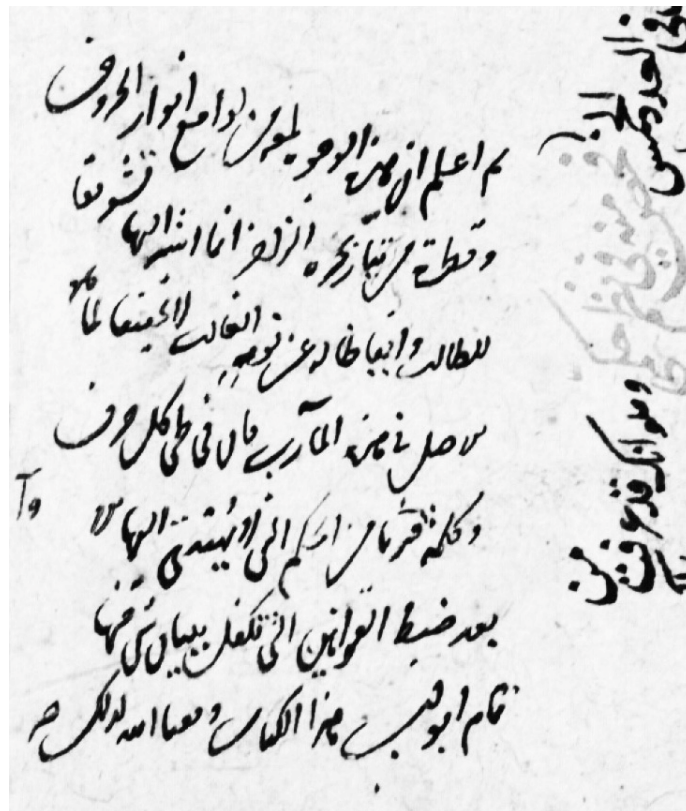
¹⁷¹ رساله بسمله یا شرح بسمله: مجلس ۱۰۱۹۶ ص ۳۳۲-۳۵۱ (۲۸ شعبان ۸۲۹).

P.3: Ibn Turka's handwriting

1. MS Majlis 10196 f. 29b, K. al-Mafāḥiṣ:



2. MS Majlis 10196 f. 57a, K. al-Mafāḥiṣ:



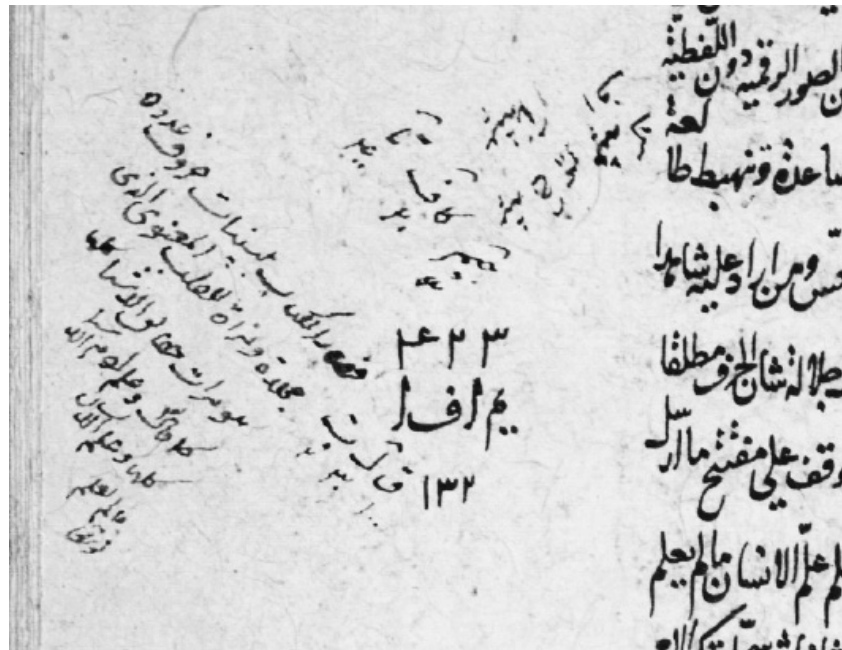
3. MS Majlis 10196 f. 119a, K. *al-Mafāḥiṣ*:

من الناس اطلع هذا الكتاب طبعه على ما لم يفرغ سمع م بيايم سبعة ليني الما على ما ج الدبره ولا قطار فيه ليايا
 الى الخوض في مسائل الشناعة له الاستنكار عليه فان الحروب لاو للثريد رجال وكل عيسى لما خلق له على ابي غير آمن عفو القام
 وكبو القدم عصما الله تعالى عن دكن حرمة الفاتح الابواب هذا الطريق وانما تم انا
 بنحتم التمام محمد عليه وعلى اله الصلو. والسلام ومع الوارث نعم الله عليهم العظم
 سنة ٨٢٣ والسلم على راسع الهدي كنهه معروف بالهاك صاحب مسعى الله يشاء طهره
 حرر ٢٩ رمضان الواحد ٨٢٧
 وقد تفتق المراجعة اليه واستلجا
 وما لم فائدة والتقاة شرفا في
 وآياهم للبلوغ الي افاض المرام محمد و
 وقد شرف الكتاب هذا
 خلد له حاله
 عليه السلام

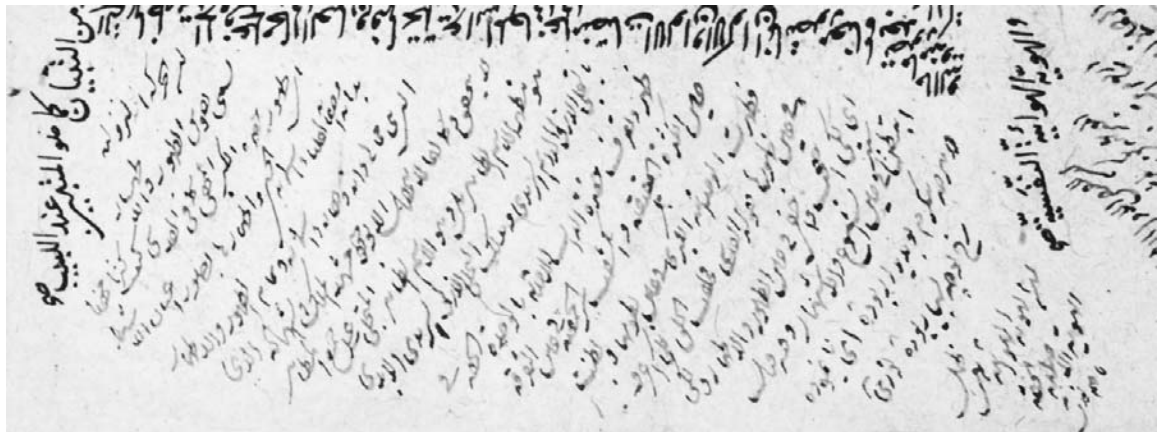
4. MS Majlis 10196 f. 330a, *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-Ḥikam* (note the author's signature in the second line, *aqall al-fuqarā* 'Alī b. Muḥammad b. Muḥammad Turka):

سنة ٨٣١ والسلم
 اقول مخبرني بوزة الكاتب وقد تفتق المراجعة اليه واستلجا
 من اقل الفم اعلى
 حامدا وصلياً
 عيسى في قوله صوم ثم والعلم له السلام
 ٩٢٢ م

2. MS Majlis 10196 f. 74a, K. *al-Mafāḥiṣ*, section 2 preface (note Nūrī's numerological calculations):



3. MS Majlis 10196 f. 78a, K. *al-Mafāḥiṣ*, section 2.10:



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¹ NB: For the sake of regularity, surnames with particles are alphabetized by their first part; “van Ess,” for example, falls under V. The Arabic definite article is dispensed with in all transliterated surnames; e.g. “Biṣṭāmī,” not “al-Biṣṭāmī,” but “al-Oraibi.”

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